

Jared Humphreys Log

2025-01-06

Tested Keyence laser height gauge to measure flatness of a flat-top PXL single unit base before and after grinding with 800 grit sandpaper. The Keyence software can generate a data set of height values recorded over a period of time, so you can start recording data, move the part around underneath the laser, and stop recording the data, then export it into a CSV file that can be analyzed in Excel, but the software doesn't provide an easy way to do a flatness measurement without external analysis.

Conducted REDRESS (reverse investment casting) test. Printed a mold from Aquasys GP water-soluble FDM filament, filled it with 17-4 powder that had been coated with PMMA, cooked it in a heat treat furnace to 275F, impregnated the green part with paraffin, then washed it in warm water to remove the mold.

2025-01-07

Bagel Tuesday

Tried to clean discoloration from the bottom of the fully-soldered PXL plate using Lysol toilet bowl cleaner that contains 9% HCL, per Al's suggestion. It did not seem to affect the discoloration, however, the concept is worth trying on a production plate that may have a less durable discolored coating.

Two green parts were created following the previously documented REDRESS process. One was heated in the toaster oven to remove the paraffin but collapsed during this process, while the other was heated in the heat treat furnace and sagged but mostly kept its shape.

Designed and started printing casting molds to make silicone molds that can be used to make standard 3 point bend testing coupons. These were printed on the Formlabs printer using Clear Cast SLA material (this is an SLA material that can be used to make ceramic molds; it can be burned off cleanly in an air furnace). This material was used because it was originally purchased for the REDRESS process but is no longer necessary for that project. It prints similarly to the clear SLA material that I generally use for nonfunctional prototypes, so it is a good material to use for this application. I also added a demo part to the print that Sean asked for to show the geometry they are considering for the Epson UV ink heat exchanger.

Received a PXL assembly back from AEM whose leaks had previously been epoxied. It was sent back to have the tabs machined off, but this opened up two leaks: one in a new position on

one of the pentagonal units that is adjacent to one of the removed tabs, and one that is at a previously epoxied joint. To attempt to repair these leaks, I used a Dremel tool with a carbide burr to excavate a groove where the leak is present, and filled it with 3M DP420 epoxy.

Meeting discussing PXL project.

2025-01-08

An issue was seen with one of the Ultimaker S5s (Optimus Prime). It did not seem to be extruding filament properly and the print being attempted failed to start repeatedly (an Outer Bearing Ring Clamp - Lower for a rotary spray head). I first heated the print nozzle manually, made sure it was unclogged with a needle, then tried to pull out the filament. It was stuck and took some force to pull it out with pliers. Upon inspection of the filament, the section of the filament that was present in the print head had expanded beyond its nominal diameter, causing it to jam in the print head. This can be seen when the print head cooling fan fails, causing the region of the print head above the nozzle to heat above the melting point of the filament, but the fan seemed operational. After cutting off the expanded portion of the filament and reinserting the filament into the print head, the print was restarted and completed successfully.

The 3D printed molds that were started yesterday were finished and post-processed this morning. They were coated with a dry film release agent and Smooth-On Mold Start 15 Slow silicone was mixed and poured into the 3 molds. This silicone mold making material was several years old and had to be mixed extensively; a white material had settled out of the silicone and fused to the bottom of both buckets. Even after mixing the silicone seemed slightly lumpy, but after mixing the two components together it looked OK. After mixing, the silicone was degassed in the vacuum chamber and poured into the molds.

Started a print of 4X X AXIS CABLE CARRIER TOWER HOSE FITTING V4s on the Formlabs with Tough 1500 material. The material currently being used (I believe Durable?) has broken at least once. Hopefully the Tough 1500 material will hold up better over time to the cyclical loading (NOTE 2025-11-04: it failed at least once more. Recommend remanufacturing from metal). The part is bent every time the spindle is raised or lowered.

A batch of pre-coated powder was retrieved after being sieved in the powder room. This batch is (I believe) coated with PVP-VA polymer backbone.

The current process being used to coat the powder is:

Dissolve a polymer backbone in an appropriate solvent. For PVP-VA, PVA, or PVP, this is water, and for PMMA, it is acetone. Pour an appropriate amount of solvent in a beaker (~200

mL/9g PVP-VA seems to be too much liquid). Use the mixing/heating plate in the Materials lab to dissolve it completely. PVA and PMMA seem to take about a day to dissolve at 80C and 1000 RPM, PVP-VA takes about an hour.

Pour this liquid binder into a mixing cup, then add the appropriate amount of powder (the ratio I have been using is ~3% binder by weight, so 3g of binder per 97g of powder). Mix the powder and binder until they are uniform.

Coat a pie tin with the same dry film release agent used for the 3D printed molds above. Fill it with the powder/liquid binder mix.

Place this pie tin on a hot plate at 120C (if the binder is water based) or place it outside (if the binder is acetone based). Wait until the mixture has solidified completely (overnight).

Remove the block of bound powder from the pie tin.

Break the block into pieces, then grind the pieces in a motorized spice grinder or equivalent. Be careful not to run the grinder for more than 30s or so; if the mixture heats up it will fuse to the sides of the grinder.

Sift the ground powder using the powered sieve in the powder room. This should return the powder to an acceptable particle size distribution (PSD)

To fill the mold, a 3D printed funnel is attached to the top of the mold, then the mold is filled a little at a tap, and tapped repeatedly after adding powder each time to densify the powder. Once the mold has been filled completely, it may be difficult to densify the powder that is closer to the bottom of the mold because of the restriction at the nozzle throat. The mold is overfilled slightly, then the funnel is removed and the excess powder is pressed into the mold to densify the powder in the mold further. As much excess powder on the outside of the mold is removed as possible using a small paintbrush.

Blue Photon demo. This is a system used to glue parts to a cylinder with a sapphire window at the top. A thick UV-curable acrylic adhesive is applied to the sapphire window, the part is applied maintaining a gap of 0.040-0.060" from the window (one customer has gone with a larger gap of 0.090 but it requires that the cure time be increased from 60s to 120s) then a UV light is shone through the bottom of the cylinder, passing through the sapphire window and curing the adhesive. To remove the part after machining is complete, the joint can be broken mechanically using a quarter-turn ejection mechanism build into the cylindrical "gripper," or the joint can be weakened using heat or cold and the part removed. The acrylic adhesive is largely chemically inert after UV curing, but residual adhesive on the part can be burned off in a furnace at 900C. Adhesive left on the gripper is removed using a steam gun or similar.

A mold was filled with the latest batch of PVP-VA coated 17-4 powder, heated to 275F, impregnated with paraffin, and is currently being washed. The mold was damaged during filling; when the funnel was removed it snapped the inner shell at the throat of the rocket nozzle. Because the powder generally holds its shape after being tapped into the mold, the inner shell could be reinserted without needing to completely refill the upper part of the mold. Due to this and damage done to the green part while attempting to remove the bottom layer of the mold to make impregnating with paraffin easier, the green part exposed after washing likely will not be functional, but it is still a useful test of the overall process.

Another batch of PVP-VA powder was mixed up (300g) and is currently being dried on the hot plate.

2025-01-09

PXL meeting with AEM - 2X increase in heat transfer performance after flattening plate ($\sim 60 - \sim 120 \text{ W/cm}^2$). Increasing interest from chip manufacturers in AEM's testing system for testing wafers after semiconductor fabrication but before dicing. Craig raised concerns about the structural integrity of the brazed joints currently, pointing out that they are not reliably sealing at the horizontal flange surface and may only have marginal seals at the vertical surface. He is worried that the assemblies may fail under the compressive force applied by probes to the wafer (several hundred pounds). He recommended that some process and design changes be made to yield a more robust product that also seals properly after one braze cycle with no rework. After the call I again brought up the concept of epoxying the joints instead of brazing them. If switching to epoxy provides the necessary seal and thermal and chemical resistance (based on existing knowledge and documentation, it should, but this still needs to be tested) then this would have multiple benefits: elimination of the costs of braze cycles (\$2500 each, assuming 1 round of rework total is \$5000), elimination of braze stop, paste, and wire application (~ 1 day of operator time, \$800), loosened part tolerance requirements and thus QC time (unknown), elimination of assembly distortion caused by high temperature brazing (saves ~ 3 days machinist time, \$2400)

B-Jetting Call - Presentation from Dan at B-Jetting on hopper and spreader systems for binder jet printers, covering their doser and shaker systems as well as dual roller spreading systems. This is in preparation to design, fabrication, and testing of an in-house developed hopper and spreader system intended to achieve various goals, including the reduction of overflow powder, the ability to use less flowable powders, improvement in density uniformity of green parts, the ability to print with thinner layers, and the elimination of the powder tank.

PXL internal meeting - Parts need to go to plating next Monday to meet the current schedule, which may not allow enough time for QC of the machined copper parts and any necessary rework.

PXL copper part machining fixturing meeting - discussed various options for fixturing copper parts for machining for the PXL assembly, including mechanical clamping, gluing with Blue Photon's system or cyanoacrylate, and vacuum chucks. Mechanical clamping and gluing are to be tested in the near future.

Metrology equipment meeting - discussed process of testing possible options for a metrology system. General plan is to select several representative parts and test measuring them on each system, then ranking the systems based on various parameters (ease of use, cost, accuracy, flexibility, fixturing required, etc.)

Re-epoxied PXL unit - PXL unit still had leaks at two epoxied joints after the latest round of epoxying, some of which seemed to be coming from the vacuum channel, so I removed the epoxy at the leaks with a brass wire wheel in the Dremel tool and re epoxied them, also filling in the vacuum channel where it seemed to be leaking. I also applied a vacuum to the plate while the epoxy was wet to hopefully pull it into the joints.

2025-01-10

Hopper meeting - discussed hopper project. Immediate goal of the hopper project is to make a prototype hopper derived from Dan's design (B-Jetting) by Q1. Nominal design right now is a shaker-type hopper that has small channels on the bottom and two eccentric mass vibrator motors. When shaken, powder will flow through small channels at the bottom of the hopper, and when vibration is turned off, the powder will not be fluid enough to flow through the channels.

PXL repair - cleared out the partially occluded vacuum port on the PXL unit that AEM sent us after it had been lapped at Sealap. Process used was to drill out the channels by hand using a 2.5mm straight flute carbide drill bit designed for drilling hardened materials. It was possible to blow air through all of the vacuum channel ports before any rework, but the customer spec is that the holes be visually clear and a toothpick can be inserted into the vertical and horizontal holes and seen at the intersection of the two (I approximated a toothpick with a 2mm drill bit shank). In one of the vertical holes that was occluded, it seemed that there were fragments of a broken drill bit, but in the other partially occluded holes it seemed to be metal chips that had been lodged in the holes at some point. There are two leaks in the unit that appeared after lapping; one is at a previously grooved and brazed joint, while the other is at a joint that had not leaked previously. To repair these, 3M DP420 epoxy will be applied to the leak points and a

vacuum will be applied to the unit, hopefully pulling epoxy into the leaking opening to seal it without any epoxy left on the surface.

REDRESS - A water-soluble mold that had been filled and heat-crosslinked yesterday was completely immersed in melted paraffin and placed in a vacuum chamber to completely impregnate the green part with paraffin, then that part was placed in a water wash system to dissolve the mold. It was noted that in trying to remove the mold more quickly by washing it in a sink with more water, the paraffin waterproofing the green part was softened and it was possible to distort the green part. In the future, the paraffin impregnated green part should only be washed in cold water, or a wax with a higher melting point should be used, or a different hydrophobic treatment of the green part should be used, or a non-water-soluble binder that is stronger than the PMMA tried previously should be used. Mahmood noted that Kymera is experimenting with pre-coating powder with PVA, which suggests that that is a binder I should potentially explore more. When I tried PVA recently I was unable to get it to crosslink at a low temperature, but this is likely a solvable problem. Gave two 17-4 green parts that had previously been impregnated with paraffin to Chris Fontaine to sinter over the weekend. One was made with the REDRESS process and one is a standard 3DEO printed green part. Both had the paraffin melted out in the toaster oven. Mixing up a new batch of powder that has 3% 350K molecular weight PMMA dissolved in acetone mixed with 17-4PH powder.

2025-01-13

Reamed the locating holes in a Saffron spreader bar to 6mm. These holes tend to be undersize when received, so the round locating pins tend to jam in the holes.

REDRESS - Filled a water soluble mold with PVP-VA powder and cooked it over the weekend. Today I impregnated the green part in the mold with PMMA dissolved in acetone. The goal is to hold the green part together initially with PVP-VA, then impregnate it with PMMA to waterproof it for the mold removal cycle. Interestingly, the powder within the mold seemed to densify significantly while impregnating it with the acetone/PMMA mixture; the level of powder that was initially near the top of the mold lowered ~10mm during the impregnation process. This may be a useful effect of impregnation; a denser green part is generally better since it gives less shrinkage during sintering. However, a denser green part means there is less space for vaporized binder to flow through the part while the part is debinding, which can lead to a longer debinding cycle being required, or the part may crack or collapse during the debinding cycle from internal pressures.

The first sintered REDRESS part came out of the sintering furnace this morning. It appears not to have held its shape during the sintering process.

AEM PXL design change meeting - 2 hour meeting on proposed design changes to the AEM PXL assembly to improve reliability of sealing. Design is based on a brazing consultant's suggestion to focus on sealing at the horizontal flange sealing surface, extend the sealing surface length from 1 to 3mm, and pre place BFM wire in a groove in the lower sealing surface (in this case the stainless steel cavity plate). This design still requires the 50 micron flatness spec on the contacting surfaces, as has been recommended by the previous 5 brazing consultants. Any design changes will likely not be implemented until unit 8 since the copper parts are already printed up to unit 7. Before investing significant engineering time into the project, a proposal will be sent to AEM for them to pay for 3DEO's work.

HOPPER - began putting together a SolidWorks assembly of the PILOT printer's Y-axis gantry to figure out how much space there is to fit a hopper. As expected there is not much space; it looks like ~1.5" along the Y direction of travel, however, there is more space to extend the design in Y above the spreader bar.

2025-01-14

REDRESS: Removed mold packed with PMMA powder from heat treat furnace after curing. Green part seems somewhat bound by testing with pressing a screw into the top of the part, but I am concerned that it may break apart in the mold removal stage. Instead of directly washing the mold and green part as is, I will soak it in liquid paraffin to waterproof it by impregnating it with paraffin. To maintain a controlled liquid paraffin bath, I have a beaker filled with paraffin placed on top of a hot plate that is set to 100C. The bottom of the beaker broke off when I was lifting it, spilling the liquid paraffin over the hot plate and the surrounding area, so I instead filled a paper coffee cup with liquid paraffin heated in a wax melter, placed the filled mold in the paraffin, and used a vacuum chamber to degass the green part and impregnate it with paraffin.

Hopper Meeting - [Hopper Project Notes](#) Generating want/need requirements and timeline for project.

Wax Dispensing Project - Brainstorming session discussing the wax dispensing project with Payman and Pourya. The goal is to eliminate the need for depowdering green parts after printing by filling in cuts with wax during a print. To test the concept, ARM V2.0 (AUTOMATED REAMING MACHINE V2.0) will be retrofitted to have a cutting spindle and a heated wax dispensing syringe.

2025-01-15

Set up print on Ultimaker S5 (Megatron) for an SVP bypass valve. The CAD is available in the 3DEO SolidWorks PDM Vault "Asm - minimalist svp bypass in-house print.SLDASM"

Set up print on Ultimaker S5 (Optimus Prime) for some rotary sprayer parts - a rotating plate seal and 12 bearing clamps of the ROTSPRAY V6 design

REDRESS - Completed removal of the water soluble mold from the green part that had been made yesterday by curing PMMA-coated powder in the heat treat furnace at 275F then impregnating the green part with paraffin to waterproof it. Cold water was used to dissolve the mold because the paraffin softens at higher temperatures. The green part seems to have come out well, the question at this point is whether it is possible to melt out the paraffin and still have a sufficiently strong green part. If the paraffin impregnation process broke the PMMA bonds then there will be nothing binding the metal particles together once the paraffin is melted out. I am running that green part through the PMMA crosslinking thermal cycle in the lower Keith heat treat furnace to melt out any paraffin. At the same time, I have filled a new water-soluble mold with PMMA-coated powder and am curing it in the same heat treat furnace cycle. In theory PMMA binder should be waterproof, so it should be possible to skip the paraffin impregnation step. It occurs to me that the melting point of paraffin is above the crosslinking temperature of PMMA, so even though PMMA is theoretically non-soluble in liquid paraffin, the impregnation process is still likely to break the PMMA bonds formed when curing the PMMA-coated powder. Perhaps impregnating the part with a waterproofing agent with a melting point lower than room temperature would waterproof the part without breaking the crosslinked bonds, or the PMMA part could be washed to remove the mold without any impregnation. This was the original intent of switching from PVP-VA/PVA/PVP to PMMA; it should create a waterproof green part but I have historically had issues with the green part breaking apart when washed in water. I am currently making a new batch of powder with 5% PMMA, increased from the current 3% PMMA. This should create stronger green parts that may hold up better to washing. The part that had paraffin melted out of it seemed to hold its shape, so it should be able to go through the sintering process. The other part that was cured at the same time was impregnated with paraffin by soaking it in a beaker of liquid paraffin that was placed in a vacuum chamber. It is currently being washed. Another water soluble mold has been filled with PMMA-coated powder and is currently being cured in the Keith furnace. I have reduced the temperature ramp rate to minimize distortion of the mold while it is being heated; it was previously 120 F/hr and is now 90 F/hr (to 275F). If distortion continues to be an issue then I will add reinforcement to the printed part so it holds its shape better during the thermal crosslinking process, but I would prefer to avoid that for the sake of print time and material usage.

HOPPER - Received vibrator motors and installed them in Dan's sample shaker-type hopper design. Benchtop testing shows that it can dispense stock 3DEO 17-4 powder with flowability additive (fumed silica) when vibrating and stop dispensing when vibration is stopped. The flow rate seems to be non-uniform across the line of dispensing. It is able to dispense non-flowable Atmix powder, but the dispense rate is much lower and dispensing is even less uniform. The flow rate also appears to be highly dependent on vibration frequency and level of powder in the hopper. Dan noted in the meeting we had with him that he prefers to use doser-type hoppers when possible; they don't tend to work well with flowable powders because the powder can flow around the dosing roller, but they work better with non-flowable powders than a shaker-type hopper. Next step in the project is for Pourya and Mohsen to build an experimental setup to test the flow rate of the hopper by weighing the powder it dispenses onto a scale. Began working on a new hopper design that is based on Dan's design; the channels have similar dimensions but are now adjustable because they are in a SolidWorks CAD model instead of an STL. I have also extended the length of the dispensing line to match the width of the PILOT printer's build plate. It will also have provisions for being mounted to a vibration isolating mount. I have designed and am printing several cases to enclose the vibrating motors; these will make it easy to swap out motors if necessary and will seal the motors from powder ingress. The disadvantage is that without air flow the motors may overheat and fail, but if that becomes a significant issue then the system can be redesigned with motors that are already sealed and so are safe to use in open air or the case can be redesigned so that it conducts heat away from the motors.

2025-01-16

PXL Meeting with AEM: AEM noted that there was epoxy blocking one of the vacuum ports on the plate they have currently. Epoxy was initially applied to the area next to the area in question; a groove was machined from the copper and filled with 3M DP420 epoxy, but that failed to seal the leak. Epoxy was later applied to the location in question in the vacuum groove to seal a leak through the vacuum groove itself where the groove may have been machined too close to the edge of the stainless steel cavity plate. Some of the epoxy wound up sealing the vacuum port hole and I failed to clean it out later. The plate is being brought back to 3DEO to remove epoxy from the vacuum port and make a groove in the epoxy that is in the vacuum groove. AEM recommended that we have an inspection procedure and generate an inspection report before shipping a PXL unit to them. AEM is currently working with Electrolurgy to have a unit plated. We also discussed some of the possible changes to the braze joint to ensure that the joint is formed properly on the horizontal sealing surface of the heat exchanger flange. The Japanese brazing vendor MTC suggested that we have a design that is 3mm wide, with a 1mm wide and 1mm

deep groove in the middle of the flange surface that will have a wire preform installed in it before the brazing cycle. Whether to place BFM outside of a joint and have it flow in or to place it inside the joint seems to be a matter of personal preference with brazing consultants. Extending the joint, however, is a common rule of thumb; the rule of thumb is to have the overlap between two brazed surfaces be 3X the thickness. Since the flange thickness during brazing is 1.5mm, we technically should have an overlap of 4.5mm. Since the final flange thickness is 1mm, you could make a tortured argument that the overlap should be 3mm. Currently, the overlap is close to 1mm. To increase the flange overlap would require significant design changes to the copper parts and cavity plate, so we are trying to get AEM to pay us for the NRE.

HOPPER - Finished printing of the vibrating motor cases, which did not fit the motors properly and curled up from the print bed. I have redesigned the case based on these results and applied Magigoo adhesive to the glass plate to improve adhesion. I am currently running a print of the new case design on OG, one of the Ultimaker S3 printers.

Designed and printing plate with same opening size and threaded insert spacing as the PILOT printer gantry to enable benchtop testing of hoppers that are designed to be installed in the PILOT printers.

After switching the Prusa printer from Aquasys GP to TPU, running a test print, and switching back to Aquasys GP, the printer is having issues. It seems not to be dispensing continuously, leaving large gaps in the line it is trying to lay down. I am drying the Aquasys GP filament overnight in the dehydrator at 65C, and will work on the issue further tomorrow.

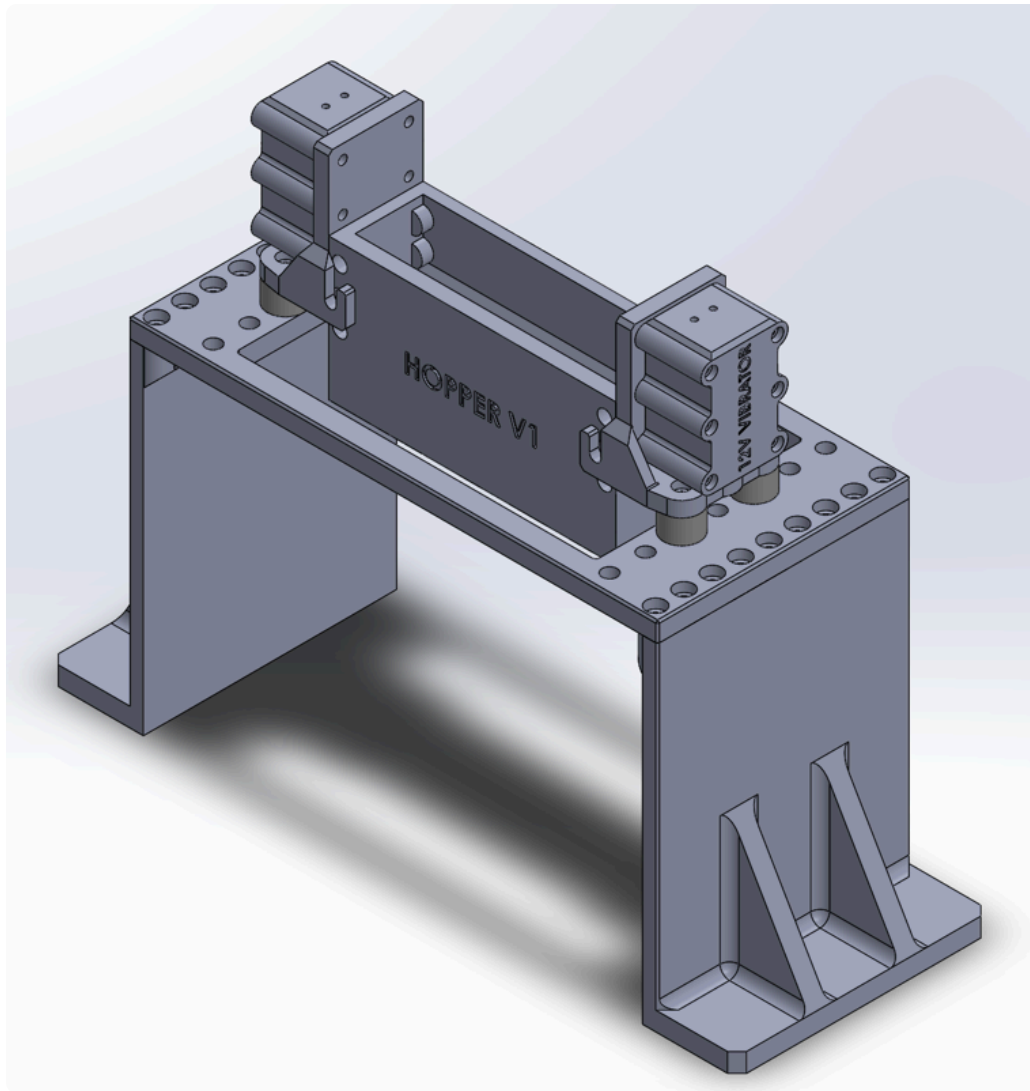
2025-01-17

The issue with the Prusa seemed to be that the filament was not sufficiently dry; after drying the Aquasys GP filament overnight at 65C in the dehydrator and starting the same print as yesterday, it seemed to adhere to the build plate properly and did not have the same gaps in the lines being laid down as seen previously.

Cleaned out the vacuum port hole that had been sealed on the plate that was brought back from AEM this morning. The vacuum port hole had been blocked by braze filler material so I drilled that out using an uncoated HSS 2mm drill bit and checked the vacuum port hole using a light shone in from the side as well as a toothpick inserted into the hole. I also cut a small groove into the epoxy with a scalpel, trying to keep away from the side of the vacuum channel that had leaked previously. This operation seems to have opened up a new leak that had previously been sealed by epoxy, but the leak is small enough that it may be acceptable to AEM.

Mixed up a new batch of pre-coated powder. This one is 3DEO's treated 17-4 powder coated with 5% PVP. I am trying PVP instead of PVA or PVP-VA in an attempt to increase the strength of green parts. I also removed the two green parts from the heat treating oven where they were heated to a temperature of 275F at a rate of 90F/hr. The green part that had the mold dissolved off of it seemed to crack and several pieces of it broke off. The other green part was one that was still in a water soluble mold. It had been made from 3% PMMA pre-coated powder that was poured into the mold, the mold was tapped to densify it, and it was immersed in melted paraffin in an attempt to cure it without needing to send it through an initial curing cycle. While immersed in paraffin, it was placed in a vacuum chamber to completely impregnate the green part with paraffin. It is currently being washed in the water wash chamber. If the mold can be dissolved completely and the paraffin removed by heating it then it will go into tonight's 17-4 sintering run, but it is unlikely that that process will be completed in time. 2 parts are going into the sintering run tonight. They are both made with 3% PMMA coated powder. A test was also conducted with powder pre-coated with 5% pure PVP. The powder did not thermally crosslink and so stayed unbound after the curing cycle.

The updated version of the vibrator motor case has completed printing and seems to fit properly. I completed a design of side mounts that are attached to vibration isolating mounts as well as a central hopper. The vibrator motor cases are mounted to the side mounts, and the central hopper mounts to the side mounts with M5 thumb screws to make it easy to remove and replace the hopper without needing to switch the vibrator motors. The hopper has small channels to let out powder on the bottom, so it is being printed on one of the Ultimaker S3s with a 0.25mm nozzle, which enables very small features to be reproduced accurately but lengthens the print duration to ~2 1/2 days. I completely assembled one of the vibrator motor cases. The motor is glued into one side, wires are fed through the holes, and the other side of the case is glued on after a bead of Loctite Professional cyanoacrylate glue is applied to ensure that the case is sealed. The same glue is also applied around the holes where the wires pass through the case to seal them against powder ingress. After gluing, the case is sprayed with super glue hardener to cure all of the super glue.



2025-01-20

Ordering parts for a pellet extruder style FDM print head for next-gen technologies. This print head can be used to extrude pure paraffin for filling in cut areas to eliminate depowdering, or it can be used to print parts directly using a kind of feedstock that is derived from MIM powder. I don't have an exact recipe for the feedstock yet, but it should be similar to that used for metal powder-bearing filament, with metal powder blended with a polymer backbone that is thermally activated as it is passing through the hotend, as well as whatever flow additives are necessary. I am hoping that by using an extruder screw instead of a standard filament feed mechanism, it will be possible to minimize the flow additive content to provide green parts with a higher metal powder load.

All the Hopper V1 parts are printed, so I will assemble those and review the design at today's hopper meeting. Since the McMaster purchase request placed on Friday has not been completed by morning today, the order will, at best, arrive tomorrow morning. Since I will be out tomorrow, I will not be able to assemble the system until Wednesday.

The various wax melting experiments done so far have sometimes resulted in paraffin being heated beyond its smoke point and producing smoke that travels throughout the R&D lab and attached office rooms. I have stopped using the toaster oven and I am hoping to eliminate the solder pot that I've been using because it tends to overheat the wax. I have put in a purchase request for a purpose-built wax melter that will melt wax quickly but regulate the temperature so it does not go beyond the smoke point of paraffin.

Filled a REDRESS mold that was printed from PolyMaker PolyCast with 3% PMMA 17-4 powder. I then put it in the lower Keith heat treat furnace and started it cooking with a cycle ramping to 500F at 120F/hr. The goal here is to eliminate the need to impregnate the green part with paraffin and dissolve the mold. In theory, during this cycle the coating on the powder will first crosslink, creating a green part, then the mold will soften and eventually vaporize as the temperature is ramped. This would simplify the workflow considerably: a mold would be printed, filled with powder, and first run through a cycle in an air furnace to vaporize the mold and partially debind the part, then the part would be sintered as normal. If the PolyMaker PolyCast material could be removed in an inert atmosphere, then the workflow is even simpler: after filling the mold, it would be placed in the sintering furnace, and after an appropriate cycle a completed part would come out.

Received the two parts that had been sintered over the weekend. They seemed to hold their shape and did not develop more cracks (one of the parts had several cracks in the green state, but they did not seem to get much worse. Sliced a sample off of the cracked part to have Adriana embed it in resin and polish it to get an idea of the quality of the sintered part.

I have an idea for a change to the process I have been using. Polyethylene would be dissolved in liquid paraffin at elevated temperature, the binder would be blended with metal powder, and the powder slurry would be poured into a water soluble mold. This mold would then be dissolved with water, and the green part would either be thermally or chemically debound and sintered. I am in the process of dissolving Poly(ethylene-co-vinyl acetate) into liquid paraffin. PE is only semi-soluble in paraffin, so I have had to dilute it to a ratio of 85:10 paraffin to PE and mix it at a temperature of 150C. I mixed 500g of 17-4 powder into the paraffin/PE-CVA binder, heated it until the mixture was liquid, then poured some into a water soluble mold. It did not completely flow into the mold; particularly in the reinforcing ribs there were bubbles left behind that are visible from the outside of the mold. I am currently reheating the mold along with the beaker of powder/binder mix in the toaster oven with the temperature dial pointed straight left (9:00 position) which correlates to a temperature below 250F. The intent is to heat the mold until the powder mixture is liquid, then vibrate it to remove any bubbles, then top it off with the mixture that has been kept liquid in the beaker. I increased the temperature to 250 because having the

temperature set below 250 (in a region of the dial labeled “warm”) did not seem to be heating the mixture above its melting point. I was mistaken; the power strip the toaster oven is connected to kept tripping and turning off the toaster oven. I connected the toaster oven to the wall (bad practice) and it seemed to keep running without blowing a circuit breaker, but the water soluble mold began to distort and I was not able to vibrate out the bubbles. I filled up the mold as much as I could with the powder/binder mix in the beaker, but the ribs aren’t going to be formed when I demold the green part.

HOPPER meeting: Marcus populated the Hopper Jira page [Hopper | Board](#) with the current progress on the Hopper project. The 3D printed parts for the HOPPER V1 prototype and base are done printing, I am just waiting on hardware to arrive from McMaster to complete it.

AEM PXL Design Changes Meeting: Discussed the process of testing possible changes to the design of the AEM PXL assembly with the intent of improving sealing of the brazing process. There are various options regarding how to approach the experimental protocol; one proposal is to do a series of single-unit tests first then scale up to quarter units then scale up to full units. Another proposal, the one that was ultimately preferred, is to test with quarter units. My preference is to pick one approach that is feasible to integrate into the final product (various changes to the sealing design have impacts on other aspects of the assembly design, and these impacts can be determined without having run any experiments) and braze one full plate with the experimental design and one plate with the current design in the same brazing run. This approach lets us eliminate untenable sealing concepts before investing in detailed design and fabrication, and also increases confidence that the results of the experiment (albeit only one data point) are more valid because we have previously seen that results with single unit tests don’t necessarily correlate with results seen when brazing the full plate. Also, since we are going to braze full plates with the current design anyway as part of our current manufacturing schedule, this eliminates the need to make separate samples just for the purpose of acting as a control.

2025-01-22

HOPPER - Assembling HOPPER V1 prototype. Hopper V1 and benchtop test rig are assembled. The vibrator motors need to be wired to a DC power supply for testing. Eventually the vibrator motors will need to be controlled through software.

REDRESS - Dissolving water-soluble mold off of the green part that was formed by pouring a mixture of 17-4 powder with Poly(ethylene-co-vinyl acetate) dissolve in paraffin into a water soluble mold. The pour left a number of large bubbles in the mold so it will not be a usable part,

but for testing mold removal and dissolving the paraffin with N-Heptane and debinding and sintering the part it is a useful sample. **Mahmood inspected a sectioned sample from one of the sintered PMMA parts, and noted that the porosity was comparable to 17-4 parts printed with 3DEO's process, although he did note two voids that were likely caused by a void present in the process of packing the powder into the mold. This all suggests that in terms of part density and porosity at least, this is a viable process for making good quality parts.** Ground and sifted a batch of 5% coated PVP-VA powder.

Abandoning approach: Method is to dissolve a formulation of polyethylene in paraffin, combine this with metal powder, and pour it into a water soluble mold when hot enough to pour well. (ratio used: 85g paraffin, 10g PE-CVA granules, 500g pre-treated 17-4 powder). Note that the binder to powder ratio is ~16% by weight, which would need to be reduced to 5% at most to have acceptable green part density. The mold is then dissolved off with water, then the green part is solvent debound in N-Heptane to remove the paraffin component, then sintered. **Reason for abandoning:** difficulty of dissolving PE-CVA in paraffin, difficulty with bubbles/voids forming in mold when pouring because the liquid cools below the melting point of paraffin and solidifies, need for a hazardous solvent debind step, open questions about strength of green part after solvent debind.. I have greater confidence that a dry powder can be packed into a mold uniformly than pouring in a liquid, particularly when the binder content percentage is reduced to the necessary level. That said, there are advantages to this process (ease of working with a slurry compared with a powder, elimination of grinding/sieving step, protection from oxidation, solvent debind of paraffin opens up a network of pores for gas to escape from the part). The issues are potentially solvable, but I think it is a better use of time to pursue the dry powder approach instead.

PXL Meeting - Philip at meeting. Discussing the measurement protocol for measuring the copper parts after machining. Copper drawings need to be updated with critical dimensions and measurement protocol needs to be formalized for transfer to QC. Including visual inspection criteria (could be automated with Keyence VR-6000). Machining fixture (for OP 2) in progress.

2025-01-23

REDRESS - Impregnated the mold filled with 5% PVP-VA coated powder with paraffin by placing the mold in a coffee cup, filling the cup to near the rim of the mold but not over it, placing the cup in the toaster oven set to a temperature that is slightly above the melt temperature of paraffin for 30 minutes, then filling the cup to 1cm above the top of the mold, placing the cup in a vacuum chamber and slowly ramping the vacuum level to remove any air, holding the vacuum at 25 inHg for 10 minutes, releasing the vacuum level, removing the mold from the paraffin cup,

placing the mold on a paper towel in the toaster oven for 10 mins to allow paraffin on the outside of the mold to flow away, removing the mold from the toaster oven and allowing it to cool, then placing it in the water wash station to dissolve the mold.

Dissolving PE-CVA into paraffin at a 1:1 ratio in a beaker placed on the stirring hot plate set to 110C. I have decided to try the PE-CVA/paraffin bound melted slurry pouring technique again; if I can make it work with a binder content of 5% with a binder that has a higher concentration of PE than previously tried, I think it may be a viable technique.

Mixed up a batch of powder slurry using 10% binder that is 20g PE-CVA : 60g paraffin

Printing a new water-soluble mold to try with the poured slurry technique. Tried it with the previous batch of PE-CVA/paraffin bound powder heated and poured into the mold a little at a time, with the mold stored in the toaster oven in between every pour to give the slurry a chance to fill the mold. This heat was apparently too much for the mold to withstand and also hold its shape; it distorted significantly and began to leak during this process.

AEM PXL Mtg - Discussed chamfering the parts for rework and initial brazing to target the BFM at the joint, have a filled groove that seals the joint if BFM does not flow into the joint, and providing a way of locating BFM wire. Discussed possibility of DFM changes to the plate to increase reliability of the brazing process. My opinion is that this is not necessary; our current process should work as long as our parts are sufficiently flat, but we will find out if this is the case with the next full plate we are brazing. AEM has installed the sealed PXL they have right now into a wafer prober. They are also receiving a plated assembly from their plating vendor Electrolurgy.

HOPPER - Decision was made yesterday to make HOPPER V2 a doser-style hopper instead of another shaker-style hopper. Working on design of a prototype. I have advanced the design to the point that I am going to print out a test hopper and roller to test fit the components. The design is roughly based on the geometry of the example hopper that Dan from B-Jetting provided us with an STL for.

PERPLEX - working on the hardware design of a screw-driven pellet-fed print head for melting and depositing paraffin wax.

2025-01-24

HOPPER - Test fit the roller into the hopper printed yesterday. The roller did not fit despite the roller being printed at a diameter of 16mm and the hopper opening being printed at a diameter of 16.5mm. Continuing to develop design of doser-style hopper.

REDRESS - Experimenting with pouring a slurry of PE-CVA/paraffin and 17-4 PH powder into several different styles of mold. Tried to dissolve SLA Formlabs Clear Cast in Dichloromethane and an acetone/xylene solution, neither of which it was soluble in. PolyCast material was found to be soluble in dichloromethane. Melting paraffin out of a green part made using 5% PVP-VA powder cured and impregnated with paraffin in preparation for a sintering run today. The part did not seem to retain much strength as the paraffin was being melted out. In the same heat treat furnace cycle, I am testing heat curing 3% and 5% PVP-VA powder in ceramic crucibles. My current theory is that either the coated powder is degraded by exposure to oxygen or atmospheric moisture and is therefore not binding well during the curing process, or having 5% binder works less well than 3% binder.

PERPLEX - Received NEMA 17 motor with 27:1 gearbox, which seems too large to be used for the hopper or PERPLEX projects. I have put in an order request for a NEMA 11 and a NEMA 8 geared stepper motor.

Meeting discussing this week's progress on R&D projects and next week's projected work. Goal is to get HOPPER V2 designed, built, and start testing, select parts to try with the NEXTGEN wax filling system, and have some sort of demo of the NEXTGEN process.

2025-01-27

REDRESS - Over the weekend I made some more test parts using 5% 350K PMMA powder. The green parts produced that way seem to be weak, so I am exploring some alternatives, such as using 15K PMMA as a binder, as well as using PE-CVA dissolved in paraffin. When I tried to melt the paraffin out of a part made this way it completely liquified, so I am going to try dissolving out the paraffin with heptane

HOPPER - As expected, the current ordering system tends to delay McMaster and Amazon orders by 1-2 days as compared with the previous ordering process. Continuing design of HOPPER V2. Moved bearings from the body to the side mounts so they won't need to be replaced every time the body is switched out.

NEXTGEN - Pellet extruder hot end needs to be powered up right now so I am setting up a Duet 2 board for this purpose. Pellet extruder heat break was tested by energizing the ceramic heater with a Duet 2 board and controlling the temperature with the installed thermistor. It was possible to control extrusion of wax by rotating the screw using a cordless power drill. When the temperature was set low enough (~50 degrees) it was seen that there was solid wax on the screw after the screw was removed, which suggests that the extruder is functioning as desired. The amount of drag seen on the screw increased as the temperature dropped and was

noticeable by the amount of torque applied to the heat break. It is unclear how much torque may be required in operation, so a geared stepper motor is likely to be the best drive system to use for initial testing.

AEM Design Changes Meeting: Rajan talked with Christina about the design changes and the PXL project in general, and it sounds like she doesn't have confidence that the design can be manufactured at all, much less cost-effectively. Rajan asked us to answer a few questions about the design: design intent (assuming he means brazing joint the answer is the drawings), what precision is necessary (assuming he means accuracy and not precision the answer is whatever is necessary to meet the drawing tolerances) and the confidence of the team that this is achievable (100% confidence that we can make parts that demonstrably meet the drawing tolerances, assuming that we change our process and get the necessary equipment) and 70-90% confidence that if we make parts that meet those tolerances then the assembly will seal on the first braze.

2025-01-28

HOPPER - Finished initial design and printing body, roller, and side mounts for initial testing.

REDRESS - Dissolving mold off of paraffin-impregnated PVP-VA part. Melted out 2nd paraffin-impregnated PMMA part. It held its shape, but two of the ribs were damaged by an edge of paper towel being blown against the part by the furnace's internal blower.

NEXTGEN - Continuing design work on the pellet style extrusion head.

AEM PXL Meeting - internal meeting discussing the AEM PXL project design changes. They are looking for a proposal for the proposed brazing joint design changes, including a timeline, worker hours spent, and material costs.

2025-01-29

HOPPER: The body, side mounts, and one roller are printing on one of the Ultimaker S5s, and another roller is printing on the Bambu printer. The various parts necessary have been ordered, so final assembly should be possible in a few days. Parts showed up from McMaster, so I should be able to put it together with the NEMA 17 geared stepper motor tomorrow. The smaller stepper motors won't show up until later, so I will have to wait to switch to using those.

REDRESS: I have had issues with making green parts using the thermal crosslink - paraffin impregnation - mold dissolve - paraffin melt out process, so I am currently pursuing two alternative processes: one is to fill a soluble mold with feedstock that is a blend of 17-4 powder

with PE-CVA dissolved in paraffin. I am heating the mold and a syringe of feedstock in the toaster oven with the dial pointed straight left; this keeps the temperature low enough that the mold doesn't soften from the heat but the feedstock is also liquid enough to inject into the mold. At the same time, I am reexploring an older process; this process entails filling a PolyCast mold with coated powder, thermally crosslinking the powder, then burning out the mold. I had previously had some issues with the green part not keeping its shape, but I believe I can address that with newer formulations of powder coating.

PERPLEX - PERPLEX is the name of the pellet-style extruder I am developing for the NEXTGEN project. I am still working on designing the mounting and structural components for the extruder. Completed initial design of mount and printed from CF PLA on the Bambu printer.

2025-01-30

HOPPER: Printed a PLA-CF roller. Cross drilled and tapped a hole in the shaft for a pin that will rotationally lock the shaft to the roller while still being easy to remove and replace by disassembling and sliding out the shaft. Received a NEMA 8 geared stepper motor. Installed threaded inserts for mounting vibrator and side mounts to the hopper body. I wired up connectors to the NEMA 8 stepper motor and the two NEMA 17 stepper motors. I also fabricated two cables to connect the stepper motors to a Duet board (I used the standard Molex Micro-Fit 3.0 4-pin connectors we use on stepper motors around the company for the steppers, and the cables adapt that to a standard Duet connector).

REDRESS: Green part that was soaked in N-Heptane overnight was cracked extensively and weakened, but it held up to heat that would reduce the unsoaked green part to a puddle. It seems that there is still some paraffin in the middle ~1mm of the wall of the part that can be seen to liquify when a broken piece of the green part is heated, but the outer 1mm of the wall seems to be unaffected by the heat (the wall thickness is ~3mm). I am making a new batch of PVP-VA 3% coated powder; that seems to produce the strongest green parts when thermally crosslinking so that is the kind of powder I want to fill a PolyCast mold with and test heating to 500F tonight. I am also pursuing a new technique, using a slurry made with the same PVP-VA binder: I poured the slurry into an AquaCast GP water-soluble mold. Historically I have had trouble with slurries shrinking inside the mold as well as difficulties with removing the solvent from the slurry before removing the mold, but in this case the water in the PVP-VA slurry should be absorbed into the mold and soften it, while at the same time drying out the slurry to form a solidified green part. At that point, I could either impregnate the green part with a non-water-soluble material (i.e. paraffin or mineral oil) or burn off the mold, although vaporizing AquaCast GP is an as-yet-untested technique.

PERPLEX: Main structure was printed yesterday, hopper and base mount was designed and printed today.

AEM PXL: The lapped PXL plate was returned from AEM by Karl, and was found to be leaking from three unit cells, at points which had previously been repaired by rebrazing. We received authorization to epoxy the joints to seal them, and I worked on my technique digging out trenches to epoxy the joint. The goal is to get a deep groove at the joint between the copper and stainless steel, but this is more difficult than it sounds because there is a small distance of stainless steel to cut into before breaching the vacuum channels. I used a carbide bit in a Dremel tool to cut a groove, while observing the joint under a microscope to cut as close to the vacuum channel as possible without cutting into it. I applied 3M DP420 epoxy to the joint using a mixing nozzle with a needle on the end (the mixing nozzles are conveniently designed with a Luer taper tip) and used a razor blade to scrape off as much excess epoxy as possible.

2025-01-31

PXL: Epoxied plate sealed when pressure tested in the morning, and Marcus is bringing it to AEM today.

HOPPER: Finished assembling HOPPER V2. Had to drill and ream one of the timing belt pulleys to fit the 8mm roller shaft. Tested stepper motor using a DUET 2 board, but it will eventually be powered using a DUET 3 board. I had to modify the benchtop test rig to get the new HOPPER design to fit: I had to cut a section out of the back of the test stand to provide clearance for the vibrator motor and cut a section out of the side (where one of the M5 threaded inserts is) to provide clearance for the timing belt pulley. There are Viton o-rings sealing the sides around the shaft support bearings, and the shaft support bearings are a solid polymer-filled type so it should take a while for powder to make its way through them, but the fit between the shaft and the bearings is not as tight as I would like so I suspect some powder may make its way through there. For the next HOPPER, I will use felt or packing seals inboard of the bearings to act as a primary seal (the bearings will be retained to support the shaft against the bending moment applied by the timing belt).

PERPLEX: I assembled the pellet-style extruder setup and tested it by running it with a DUET 2 board. Initially there was some leakage between the ceramic heater and the heat break, as well as between the ceramic heater and the nozzle. I suspect that the pressure in the hotend is high enough that it leads to leaks at areas that are not pressure-tight. The heat break also started spinning after a minute of operation; the torque applied to it by the driving stepper motor was too high for the 3D-printed clamping feature to hold.

REDRESS: I have a new process that I think may work.

- Coat powder with PVP-VA at a concentration of 3%
- Grind and sift powder
- Fill a water-soluble mold with powder and tap to maximize density
- Heat mold and powder to 250F at 60F/hour
- Remove bottom of mold
- Place mold in a cup of liquid paraffin where the level of paraffin is slightly below the top of the mold
- Place in oven at 220F for 30 minutes
- Add paraffin to the cup to a level of 1cm above the top of the mold
- Return to oven for 30 minutes
- Remove the mold from the oven and place it on a paper towel that is on top of a ceramic plate
- Increase the oven temperature to 250F and place the mold back into the oven for 1 hour
 - This will remove as much paraffin as possible from the green part while leaving enough residue to waterproof the green part. It will also serve to enhance crosslinking of the part.
- Remove the mold and allow it to cool to room temperature
- Place the mold in a water wash tank until the mold has been completely dissolved from the green part
- Air debind the part to 500F at a rate of 60F/hour
- Sinter the part as usual

Note that the specific process variables here are estimated and err on the conservative side; if the process works as written here there is extensive room for optimization.

2025-02-03

HOPPER: Assembled and wired HOPPER V2 to the Duet 3 board in the hopper testing area and ran a quick test by pouring powder into the hopper, running the vibrator at 7V, and rotating the roller at 10 RPM. It seemed to dispense powder well, although the spiral hopper caused the point of highest powder flow to sweep along the line of dispensing. I am printing a new roller that has a larger number of straight grooves that are also somewhat shallower than the spiral grooves used on the current roller.

REDRESS: The sintered parts came out this morning; the two PMMA parts collapsed while the PVP-VA part mostly held its shape, although there is evidence of bubbling and the cracks that were present in the green part are still present in the sintered part. I am making a new batch of

coated powder using 9g PVP-VA and .5g Stearic Acid dissolved in 99% isopropyl alcohol mixed with 300g of treated Sandvik 17-4 PH powder. Stearic acid is commonly used in MIM binder formulations as a lubricant; it may help here to get the powder particles to flow better when filling the mold. I also filled two molds with the PVP-VA powder dried over the weekend and ground and sieved today; one was cured rapidly in the toaster oven at 250F for 10 minutes, the bottom of the mold was removed to allow paraffin to flow into the and impregnated with paraffin by placing it in a coffee cup filled with paraffin to slightly below the rim of the mold, leaving it in the toaster oven for 10 minutes, filling the cup above the rim of the mold, leaving it in the toaster oven for 10 minutes, and leaving it in a vacuum chamber at 25 inHg for 10 minutes to draw out any air. The other mold was placed in the heat treat furnace with air circulation running a cycle to heat it to 275F at 120F/hr (I think) with a dwell of 1 hour (I think). This more conservative heating approach is less likely to cause green part cracking, but takes more time. Tomorrow I will impregnate the part with paraffin using a more gentle procedure (using a vacuum chamber is fast and effective but I worry that it is aggressive enough that it may cause green part cracking).

NEXTGEN:

I am currently working on an improved version of the pellet extruder-style wax dispenser. Some of the changes are a hopper that clamps to the top of the heat break instead of screwing onto the mount, the heat break is clamped by a shaft collar with side tapped holes that the mount is screwed to to provide greater resistance to spinning than the previous version, the hopper width is reduced in preparation for designing it to fit within the PILOT printer, and I have eliminated the need for heat set inserts.

2025-02-04

HOPPER: Replaced the helical roller with one with straight grooves. It does not have the same issue with sweeping dispensing but it is still pulsing more than I would like.

REDRESS: Melting out wax from the green part formed yesterday. The part seems to soften considerably where the wax is liquid, but solidifies once the wax is removed (even at high temperatures). I began impregnating the second PVP-VA green part in pure paraffin, but I decided to pull it out and mix up a custom formulation of wax: 100g paraffin, 10g PE-CVA, 3g stearic acid. My hope is that this will flow into the part more easily and strengthen it while melting out the wax and during the debind process if any of the PE-CVA is left in the part after the wax is melted out.

NEXTGEN: I have assembled the V2 pellet style extruder. The ceramic heater I had cracked so I had to replace it with a standard aluminum block-style heater. The mount snapped during testing; the torque being applied to the heat break was sufficient to break the 3D printed part. I had printed it in a weaker orientation to simplify the print, but now I will add some reinforcement to the part and print it in a stronger orientation. I will also add mounting features for the fan; the heat sink on the heat break was warming up enough that I am concerned it may cause issues with the hopper interface (which is a PLA part clamped directly to the top of the heat break, yes, I know, but the temperatures here are much lower than are usually used in FDM hot ends (<100C vs. 200-300C)). Put in an order request for a replacement ceramic heater.

2025-02-05

HOPPER:

REDRESS:

NEXTGEN: Latest iteration of pellet extruder is operational. It seems to be able to dispense liquid wax when the feed screw is rotating and not dispense it when the feed screw is not rotating. The feedstock being used is "sand wax," which appears to be paraffin formed into small (~.5mm) balls so it flows well in the hopper. Also, the stepper motor vibrates while operating, which aids in flow of the feedstock.

2025-02-06

HOPPER: Testing is continuing. Mohsen plans to get the data collected together in preparation for a discussion of the design tomorrow or Monday.

REDRESS: Melting wax out of two green parts that had been crosslinked with 5% PVP-VA and demolded. I am still seeing issues with part cracking. I mixed up a batch of 3% PVP-VA that I am testing today as well as a batch with 3% PVP-VA and 2% Epsom Salts. The theory is that the Epsom Salts (magnesium sulfate) will act as a metal binder that holds the particles in the green part together after the polymer has been melted or vaporized but before sintering has started.

NEXTGEN: Replaced the aluminum hot end with a ceramic one that heats and cools faster and takes up much less space, improving the packaging of the design. Tested the system with paraffin granules that we have around; it does not dispense as reliably but it does not have the unmelted white particles that were visible in the melted wax droplets with the previously used sand wax. I showed the system to Payman and Pourya and Payman's suggestion was to

improve the consistency of dispensing and increase the flow rate to the point that it can dispense a steady stream instead of drops.

2025-02-07

HOPPER: Meeting to go over results and discuss next design iteration. Hopper needs to be functional in machine at end of March (end of Q1). Functionality here is not officially defined; it may be dispensing only, dispensing and spreading, or dispensing, spreading, and printing.

- Clear hopper to see powder behavior in real time
- Connect vibrator motor to Duet board

REDRESS: Dissolving the mold from one of the paraffin-impregnated (soaked overnight) green parts made with 3% PVP-VA coated powder. There appear to be cracks in the green part; I believe this is due to the shrinkage of the impregnating paraffin as the part cools after impregnation. I am working on testing shrinkage of the machinable wax we have as well as a custom-mixed wax comprising 80% paraffin, 10% stearic acid, and 10% petrolatum.

NEXTGEN: Replaced the geared NEMA 17 stepper motor with a direct drive NEMA 23 motor that can run considerably faster. It is actually able to extrude paraffin through the heat break with the hot end removed and no heat, but the pressure generated when trying to force non-liquid paraffin through the hot end is high enough that it leaks at the interface between the hot end and the heat break and between the hot end and the nozzle. This can be resolved by epoxying the hot end to the heat break and the nozzle to the hot end and heat break, although this would make the assembly permanent.

- To do: figure out how to dispense continuous streams of wax at different temperatures

Slurry definition:  solid particles suspended in a liquid

2025-02-10

REDRESS: Had success over the weekend with making extremely strong green parts by adding Triethylene Glycol Dimethacrylate (MEHQ stabilized) to PMMA-coated powder and heating it to 300F. It turns out that PMMA is unnecessary; the TEG-DMA on its own will crosslink powder when heated above its thermal crosslinking temperature (~130-140C). The issue is with the water soluble molds; they weaken and sag before the powder slurry hits its crosslinking temperature. I am working on making higher-temperature molds, including reexploring using molds made with Formlabs Clear Cast resin and PolyMaker PolyCast filament. There are also higher-temperature water soluble FDM filaments made by Aquasys, but they require a printer

with a heated build volume. It's possible the current Bambu printer would be able to print with it; it does not have a heated build chamber but the build chamber is enclosed. Filled 2 Aquasys GP molds with slurry made by mixing 200g of pre-treated Sandvik 17-4 powder with 20g of TEG-DMA (I had to go with a 10% binder load to get the mixture flowable enough). To fill the molds without bubbles forming, I first filled a syringe with the slurry and injected it into the mold while the mold was being vibrated vertically with a pneumatic linear vibrator.

HOPPER: Reprinting the current roller in FormLabs Tough 1500 Resin material to compare the performance of a resin roller with an FDM printed roller.

NEXTGEN: Epoxied the heat break, ceramic heater, and 1.25mm nozzle together to hopefully withstand the pressure applied when extruding non-liquid paraffin. I am also printing a new mount that is designed to use a NEMA 23 ungeared stepper motor instead of the previously used NEMA 17 geared stepper motor. This new motor is much larger but can run at a much higher speed so it is more suited to dispensing wax the way we need for this project. It may need to be reconsidered when packaging the extruder to install in the PILOT printer, but for benchtop testing it is valuable.

Moved the tools and several tables out of the R&D lab, including the AEM assembly and testing tables.

2025-02-11

Bagel Tuesday meeting. Key takeaways are that Rajan visited Epson and Atmix in Japan last week, and they are interested in integrating 3DEO's technology into their prototype printers, receiving a PILOT printer, and integrating their powder business with our process. There is a board meeting next Wednesday that needs to be prepared for. IHI wants to accelerate their Inconel thruster project. There are IHI and Epson meetings on either side of next Wednesday's board meeting, and some representatives from Epson will be present at the board meeting.

Continuing to move the R&D lab over to the warehouse and organizing and setting up the new R&D lab.

REDRESS: Removed two molds from the Keith furnace that had been filled with TEG-DMA/17-4 PH slurry and cured with a cycle of 60 F/hr to 200F, dwell 1 hour, 30 F/hr to 300F, dwell 3 hours, cool naturally. One part seems to have distorted slightly and the other look good. The top of the green part is ~3mm below the top of the mold, suggesting that either the slurry shrank while curing or the mold expanded outward slightly while the slurry was still liquid. Dissolved the mold off of the two green parts, and currently I am running the lower quality of the 2 through the "GENBURNOUT" cycle in the upper Keith furnace. This is a cycle to 1000F at a ramp rate of 120

F/hr to pre-debind and pre-sinter the part before final debind and sinter. I am also running two molds printed from FormLabs Clear Cast resin through the PMMACrosslink cycle in the lower Keith furnace. One of them was filled with a slurry made using 200g of treated 17-4 PH Sandvik powder mixed with 20g of TEG-DMA and 1g of stearic acid as a flow aid. The other was half-filled with the same slurry and half-filled with the slurry from yesterday (it turns out that 200g of powder and 21g of binder makes enough slurry to fill 1 1/2 SLA molds).

2025-02-12

REDRESS: The burned-out mold retained its shape but built up a rust-red crust on the outside, and when the crust was removed the part was cratered with indentations ~1mm in diameter. I am currently curing two parts with a lower binder load in water-soluble molds and burning out a part in a FormLabs Clear Cast mold as well as one that had been cured and had the water soluble mold dissolved off. I have set the ramp rate to 60F/hr in an attempt to reduce cratering of the part. Making a new batch of PVP-VA 3% coated powder for a test Payman suggested. Filled 1 1/2 water-soluble molds with slurry made using a new recipe: 5g PVP-VA, 20g water, 5g TEG-DMA, 1g stearic acid, 5 drops T80. I will leave the molds overnight to see if the water is absorbed into the mold, then cure one of them using the standard cycle.

HOPPER: Designing a new roller with rounded grooves. Mohsen is testing the SLA roller printed to match the geometry of the roller previously tested.

PXL: Meeting about fixtures for machining the copper parts. The earlier design did not have sufficient throw to clamp parts that are as variable as our printed parts, so Kai altered the design to use a different style of clamping component to give more throw.

Continuing to organize and set up new R&D area.

2025-02-13

PXL: Sean and Kai began test-fitting parts in PXL unit 4. The cavity plate pockets are undersize, so the copper parts don't fit as is. The decision was made to modify the copper parts to fit the current cavity plate rather than wait for the next cavity plate to be completed (Next plate could be plated by next Wednesday, so it would be a delay of 3 working days). Worked on sanding the edges of the square copper parts with a Dremel tool to make them fit in the plate. This may or may not effect the braze joint. It also means that we are not making the assembly with any in-spec parts; the cavity plate was machined out of spec and the previously in-spec copper parts have now been modified so that they are no longer in spec.

REDRESS: Mixed up a batch of paraffin/PE-CVA/SA binder and filled a mold with that binder blended with powder. Also made a batch of slurry with PVP-VA, TEG-DMA, SA, and TWEEN 80.

HOPPER: In process of post-processing a new roller with rounded geometry that Payman suggested. Also sanded down the previous SLA roller because it did not rotate freely in the current hopper. Issues are being seen with the stepper motor getting hot and skipping steps; I was able to get it working temporarily by reducing the current and reducing the microstepping, but long-term it would be a good idea to increase the motor size or gear ratio.

2025-02-14

PXL: Continued sanding parts. Began assembly of 4th full unit.

REDRESS: Sent 2 brown parts to sintering (one debound to 600F, one debound to 1000F). Cured IN625 part in soluble mold, 8% TEG-DMA. Continuing issues with molds warping in heat; I ordered a higher-temperature water soluble 3D printing filament that should hold up better but is harder to print with and dissolve. I also think it is possible to heat-treat the molds to survive better.

HOPPER: New roller with curved and filleted indentations is cured and needs to be post-processed and tested.

2025-02-17

PXL: Completed assembly, including: applied BAg-8 braze paste to copper parts and installed them in the locations specified by Kai's chart, applied NicroBraz Green braze stop around the perimeter of the cavity plate and on each copper part to prevent BFM from flowing along the surface outside of the desired joint, applied braze paste to each corner of each copper part and placed BAg-8 BFM wires at each desired braze joint, with the braze paste holding the wires in place, and placed the assembly on top of a hot plate set to 60C. A paper towel was placed between the hot plate and the PXL assembly to keep the bottom of the assembly clean, which unfortunately also insulated the PXL assembly from the desired applied heat. After noting that the braze paste had not dried within an hour or so, I increased the hot plate temperature to 80C. The hot plate will need to be turned off at 1:00 PM so that it has one hour to cool before Manju takes it over to Bodycote.

For the cavity plate for unit 5, there were metal hanging chads left in the holes drilled for the valve seats and the primary liquid feed/return channels for the copper heat exchangers. These

need to be removed, and I also need to try to fillet the valve seat holes using some new radius forming end mills received today from Harvey Tool.

REDRESS: Received 2 sintered 17-4 parts that were sintered over the weekend, both bound with TEG-DMA, but one had been debound and pre-sintered to 600F while the other had been debound and pre-sintered to 1000F. The one that had been heated to 600F came out shinier, while the one that had been heated to 1000F came out more matte and with numerous cracks. There is also an interesting separation of a layer of the material within the combustion chamber internal side of the part, which is not present on the part that was debound to 600F. I suspect that this is due to oxidation or other damage done to the powder by heating it to such a high temperature in air.

NEXTGEN: Downloaded CAD file of Prusa I3 to design a pellet-feed print head for it. Took apart printhead to determine best way to retrofit printer to pellet extrusion.

2025-02-18

NEXTGEN: Continued work on designing new Prusa-compatible pellet-feed printhead.

Spent 1 hour on Bambu printer maintenance due to filament grinding when trying to print with an exotic high-temperature water-soluble filament.

REDRESS: Green part made using recent batch of PEG/PMMA powder was very weak and partly fell apart during the mold dissolving process, but I think this is due to a weak bond in general and not the water dissolving the binder used. I am making another batch of powder using a similar ratio of PEG to PMMA to powder but with Stearic Acid added and mixed more thoroughly. I am also doing a 600F burnout of the TEG-DMA CuCrZr part, a crucible filled with PMMA/PEG powder, and the partially broken green part. I am also curing another PMMA/PEG water soluble mold green part to a temperature of 300F instead of 275F.

PXL: Tested unit 4 and found several leaks. Marked leaks, took pictures, then applied nickel powder to all gaps and lift pin holes in the plate, then applied wire to the corners of the parts and lift pin holes with paste tacking it in place. Because we ran out of BAg-8 BFM wire, I had to use braze paste instead at some joints, but all leaking joints had wire applied.

2025-02-19

PXL: Leaks found after rebrazing. Plate was then machined, leak tested, and leaks were marked in preparation for cutting grooves and sealing. Decision was made to epoxy grooves instead of attempting more braze repairs.

REDRESS: Tested new powder with PEG/PMMA/SA coating in a small ceramic crucible (20g powder) in the toaster oven to 300F. Filled a soluble mold with powder combined with TEG-DMA and EGME and cured in lower Keith heat treat furnace. The green part from the ceramic crucible is still very weak; the PEG/PMMA binder is waterproof but too weak.

HOPPER: Ordered piezo ultrasonic stack vibrator:

<https://www.piezodrive.com/product/200v-7x7x40mm-piezo-stack-actuator-sb070740/>

and piezo driver:

[BD200 Dual-Channel 200V Amplifier - PiezoDrive](#)

<https://www.piezodrive.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/01/BD300-V5-Datasheet-R6.pdf>

and arbitrary waveform generator:

https://www.amazon.com/Koolertron-Generator-Precision-Dual-channel-Arbitrary/dp/B07211YWMK/ref=sxin_16_pa_sp_search_thematic_ssapa?content-id=amzn1.sym.f365033e-b793-4e66-b7ff-67f86c886ec7%3Aamzn1.sym.f365033e-b793-4e66-b7ff-67f86c886ec7&crid=3IBS21O7H6KCU&cv_ct_cx=waveform%2Bgenerator&keywords=waveform%2Bgenerator&pd_rd_i=B07211YWMK&pd_rd_r=b81565d4-38a1-4605-b437-a5189e81a22b&pd_rd_w=oD2Ng&pd_rd_wg=SUFbR&pf_rd_p=f365033e-b793-4e66-b7ff-67f86c886ec7&pf_rd_r=WYKQY7VMFCG7H0R3ENN&qid=1739908620&sbo=RZvfv%2F%2FHxDF%2BO5021pAnSA%3D%3D&srefix=waveform%2Bgenerator%2Caps%2C162&sr=1-3-7efdef4d-9875-47e1-927f-8c2c1c47ed49-spons&sp_csd=d2lkZ2V0TmFtZT1zcF9zZWFiY2hfdGhlbWFOaWM&th=1

NEXTGEN: Printhead design for Prusa completed and mount was printed, but direction of project was changed by Payman to mount the pellet-style extruder to the former reaming machine gantry that Pourya is using instead of mounting it to the Prusa. A mount needs to be designed that can hold the pellet-style extruder, the spindle, and Pourya's syringe-type extruder.

2025-02-20

NEXTGEN: Removed supports on Prusa pellet extruder mount.

REDRESS: I remembered last night that PEG is water-soluble, so the binder I have been using that is a mix of PEG and PMMA shows that it is possible to make waterproof green parts using a binder with a water-soluble component. Mixing new binder recipe that is 1% stearic acid (flow and wetting aid), 10% PEG 8000 (plasticizer), 20% PMMA 350K (polymer binder that is waterproof but weak), 70% PVP-VA (polymer binder that is strong but water-soluble), and 1%

Aerosil R 972 if it is available (hydrophobic fumed silica nanoparticles). Loaded a water soluble mold and a ceramic crucible with tapped powder and am running them through the TEG-DMA cycle on the lower Keith furnace.

PXL: Cutting grooves into plate and applying epoxy to seal leaks. Cut grooves and applied epoxy. Left excess on surface to be removed during machining.

2025-02-21

NEXTGEN: Assembled pellet-style extruder printhead and installed to Prusa. Looking for granulated paraffin to test it.

REDRESS: The mold filled with yesterday's batch of powder expanded and cracked in several places, but the powder cured in a ceramic crucible seemed fairly strong and waterproof.

PXL: Unit 4 leaked after the epoxy repairs. It will be machined to the upper end of the final height spec and have the vacuum grooves machined in, then it will be epoxy repaired again. Received several new carbide burrs to use, including two 60 degree conical burrs that should make it easier to machine a groove exposing the leaking joint while minimizing damage to the vacuum grooves.

HOPPER: Received piezo vibrator and driver board from PiezoDrives. Connected waveform generator to driver, power to driver, and driver to piezo stack. By running the piezo stack at audible frequencies and touching it to the table or various objects, it was possible to hear a tone, but the motion of the stack was not visible.

2025-02-24

NEXTGEN: Mixed up a formulation of low-shrinkage wax over the weekend per a suggestion from Claude: 80% paraffin, 10% PE-CVA, 10% Stearic Acid. I filled a small crucible with this formulation of wax to compare its shrinkage with the shrinkage of pure paraffin poured into a crucible of the same size.

REDRESS: After testing a sample made by curing an earlier formulation of powder in a ceramic crucible (5% binder load, 70% PEG 8K, 30% PMMA 350K), I found that a green part made with that formulation is fairly hard and also quite waterproof. I mixed up a new batch of powder by dissolving 17.5g of PEG 8K and 7.5g PMMA 15K in dichloromethane and combining that binder with 500g of treated Sandvik 17-4 PH powder.

PXL: Had a meeting investigating the root cause of leaks seen in unit 4, particularly focused on the differences between unit 3 and unit 4. Intro call with Vitesse Systems, a company that

makes various waveguides and heat exchangers with whom we are talking about brazing. The cavity plate for unit 5 needs to have various hanging chads removed at the 4 small holes and the 1 large hole in each valve seat.

Vitesse Systems said that having two horizontal joints at the same time tends to fail.

2025-02-25

PXL: After unit 4 was machined, I pressure tested it and found only one leak. I then cleaned the braze stop from the inside by injecting muriatic acid into all unit cells, then flushed out all the acid, then blew compressed air through all the openings to remove as much water as possible. After doing this, I found several more leaks (~8 in total) that I then marked, grooved, and epoxied.

HOPPER:

REDRESS: I made a green part in one of the new high-temperature molds with the latest batch of powder (70% PEG 8K 30% PMMA 15K) and it was not very flowable, after curing there were multiple cracks visible through the translucent mold, and the green part was not waterproof; while trying to dissolve off the mold the part dissolved the same way PVP-VA bound parts tend to.

NEXTGEN: All the pellet extruder components are now spliced into the Prusa 3D printer. Since it is not possible to directly control the Prusa functions with a laptop, I am setting up OctoPrint on a Raspberry Pi to control the Prusa. This is necessary because I need to print with the nozzle at a lower temperature than the Prusa will allow (my target paraffin printing temp is ~45C, and the Prusa won't extrude below 180C).

2025-02-26

PXL: The unit was pressure tested and was found to have three leaks. I ground out the leak points (using a 60 degree conical burr to try and form an undercut in the stainless steel) and filled the grooves with epoxy.

REDRESS: Worked on printing more high-temperature water soluble molds. I am also going through and retrying some earlier formulas that I had abandoned for what I now think are insufficient reasons. I am testing the PVP-VA/PMMA/PEG/SA/AS formula I made a while back in one of the high-temperature molds. I believe I abandoned the formula because the parts were somewhat soft at elevated temperature, but I now think this is less important and this recipe

yielded powder that is highly flowable and produces green parts that are both waterproof and stronger than the PMMA/PEG parts.

HOPPER: Made a new roller using Payman's polygonal design suggestion. It was printed on the Bambu from CF PLA as the Formlabs printer takes longer and its parts take more post-processing, and previous experiments suggested that there is no functional difference between FDM and SLA printed parts.

NEXTGEN: Got the wax pellet extruder operating on the Prusa and started to run a few test prints. So far I have had minimal success with getting a good print, but it does follow a tool path and extrude wax.

2025-02-27

HOPPER: Discussing next week's meeting with Dan at B-jetting next week. Goal is to figure out how to present our current designs and results to get his advice on how to move forward with the project.

PXL: There is still one leak in unit 4, so Steve did the final machining on unit 4 (adding vacuum grooves, drilling vertical holes for the vacuum inlets, and removing plate mounting tabs). Next I will grind out the leaking joint and epoxy it again. Received a new rotary tool to use for rework that has a remote motor and a pedal for turning the tool on and off and controlling its speed. It also has a three jaw chuck for holding burrs with different shank diameters and a more solid bearing setup than the cordless Dremel tool to reduce chattering while using the tool. Also need to print a jig for aligning the flattening punches that will be used to flatten and expand the parts after they are installed in the plate.

NEXTGEN: Continued work on printing with the paraffin printing Prusa. I have received the heat break, extruder screw, and heater for the next pellet extruder printhead. I have not received the stepper motor yet. I still need to design and print a mount to interface with Pourya's gantry.

REDRESS: The part made yesterday with the elaborate formula powder was not completely; it didn't completely dissolve but it broke apart into several pieces during the mold dissolving process. I tested the sample cured in a ceramic cup and it was also not highly waterproof. The heat curing process only went to 250F; I think the PMMA needed to be heated more to melt and join the particles. I have filled up a high temperature water soluble mold with the same powder and I am curing it to 300F. I have also made a green part by filling a ceramic cup with a slurry made from PMMA/PEG coated powder, some PVP-VA coated powder, and a wax mixture made with paraffin, stearic acid, and microcrystalline wax. Technically, based on how MIM works traditionally, it should fall apart once heated above the melt point of paraffin, but if it is possible

to use paraffin as a binder in this way then it makes slurries more feasible. I also tried to fill a low temperature water-soluble mold with the paraffin/powder slurry, but the slurry can only be poured when it is above the melt point of paraffin, and pouring in a slurry at that temperature causes the mold to soften and warp. It may be possible to fill one of the high-temperature water-soluble molds with the slurry, but that material doesn't print reliably so I try to avoid using those molds whenever possible.

2025-02-28

NEXTGEN: Continued testing of paraffin pellet extruder on Prusa. Able to fill a channel in a green part with wax. Pellet extruder needs priming to build up pressure to extrude and continues to extrude after the screw has stopped due to residual pressure. This effect seems to be fairly reliable so it can in theory be compensated for in software, but it is something to keep in mind. Received two different geared NEMA 17 stepper motors for the printhead to be installed on the test gantry. I still need to design and print components for the gantry mounted printhead and assemble it. Pourya suggested using super glue to seal the nozzle threads; this apparently works well to seal them and is also more removable than epoxy.

REDRESS: The green part formed yesterday was not completely waterproof and fell apart during mold dissolving. I also noted cracks on the top of the part after curing and before attempting to dissolve the mold. I am currently dissolving some Poly(ethylene-co-vinyl acetate)

[https://www.sigmaaldrich.com/US/en/product/aldrich/340502?](https://www.sigmaaldrich.com/US/en/product/aldrich/340502?srsId=AfmBOogpVP9ohAhJUe3CDdMzNdzFPgNhwrILnoty5IBl6z1NaKljKG_x)

[srsId=AfmBOogpVP9ohAhJUe3CDdMzNdzFPgNhwrILnoty5IBl6z1NaKljKG_x](https://www.sigmaaldrich.com/US/en/product/aldrich/340502?srsId=AfmBOogpVP9ohAhJUe3CDdMzNdzFPgNhwrILnoty5IBl6z1NaKljKG_x) in

dichloromethane to use as a waterproof powder coating binder. I have historically been only able to dissolve P(ECVA) in paraffin, but it seems to be at least somewhat soluble in dichloromethane, although it is taking a long time to dissolve. I have ordered some toluene that may be a more effective solvent.

PXL: The plate was found to leak at one point where it had not previously been epoxied. I will grind out the leak point and epoxy it.

2025-03-03

NEXTGEN: Working on mount to install pellet extruder and filament extruder (Creality Sprite) on Pourya's gantry.

HOPPER: Meeting with Dan at B-Jetting to go over the results of our testing and the hopper designs we've tried so far.

PXL: A leak was found at one point that had been previously epoxied. The plate had to be pressurized for several hours before the leak appeared. Also ran a dye penetrant test on the plate that showed several disbondments at the vertical seal that did not leak, suggesting that we are getting some successful seals at the horizontal joint. I also reamed out the 5mm holes, but I am currently waiting on the 4.5mm reamers to arrive to be able to ream those holes.

REDRESS: Ground and sieved a powder that was made with 500g of 17-4 powder, 15g of PVP-VA, 2g of PEG 8K, and 1g of Stearic Acid. I also tried coating a mold with the custom wax I made (blend of paraffin, stearic acid, and P(ECVA)) and coating one with a PMMA/PEG blend. The idea is to waterproof the inside of the mold to protect the green part during mold dissolving and to improve flow of impregnating wax along the mold between the green part and the mold. I am also dissolving the mold off of a PVP-VA part that had been impregnated with my custom wax.

2025-03-04

PXL: A test of the plate did not show any leaks, so the plate is going to Steve to have the tabs machined off. If the plate passes another leak test after machining and cleaning, it should be ready to go to the customer. Discovered one leak after cleaning that expanded to two after several hours under pressure. Ground out the leaking area and epoxied it. AEM has issued an order to stop work on units 5, 6, and 7 and instead have use work on the changed design. I believe unit 5 had a good shot at working if we used the punches to press the copper parts into place with sufficient force. Alternatively, I believe the current design could work if epoxy was used instead of brazing.

REDRESS: I have the green part made with my custom PVP-VA/PEG/SA powder in a waxed mold and one made using PMMA/PEG/SA powder in a PMMA/PEG coated mold. The PVP-VA green part will be impregnated with my custom low-shrinkage high-flow wax to waterproof it, while the PMMA part will have some PMMA binder added to the top to enhance waterproofing and have the mold dissolved off without wax impregnation. Currently trying to dissolve the mold off of the PMMA/PEG part. I sanded the bottom off of the mold and the green part seemed to be broken into pieces at the bottom, possibly because of the sanding process or possibly because it was like that during the curing process.

HOPPER: Brainstorming meeting. Vibration applied to roller directly. Set up linear stage to move hopper along one axis. Quantify the uniformity required and develop a system for measuring it. System is currently being run with a Duet board so it should be easy to set it up to run a stepper

motor with linear stage. **Adapt current doser design to PILOT printer. Try printing rollers from PP. Look for air knives.**

2025-03-05

NEXTGEN: Designed mount for Ender Sprite extruder. Will print to test fit and reprint if necessary.

PXL:

REDRESS: Made a batch of PVP-VA (3%) coated powder. Made 1 kg of powder with 15g of PVP-VA dissolved in ~150 mL of water. It is important that the powder slurry be well mixed and as thick as possible before drying on a hot plate to prevent settling. I also added .1g of stearic acid as a flow aid. Also experimenting with dissolving paraffin in N-Heptane and soaking a green part with it to waterproof it and enable the mold to be washed off without destroying the green part.

2025-03-06

REDRESS: Left the 1kg batch of PVP-VA powder on the hot plate at 110F overnight. Ground it and sifted it, then filled 3X high-temperature water-soluble molds and 2 ceramic cups with 20g each and put in the lower Keith furnace to cure with a cycle heating from 70-275F at 30F/hour, with a 2 hour hold at peak.

PXL: Began assembling Unit 5 in preparation for brazing tomorrow, including: test-fitting parts to select a set that fits as well as possible, applying braze stop to the cavity plate and all copper parts, installing flow spreaders and copper parts, and pressing each copper part with a punch made from pre-hardened 4140 steel in a hydraulic press.

2025-03-07

PXL: The heights of the copper parts in Unit 5 are currently being measured. NicroBraz green needs to be applied to each copper part and also around the edge of the plate to prevent braze filler material from flowing down the edges of the plate or flowing into the vacuum port holes. Wire preforms also need to be cut to the correct length, bent if necessary, and held in place with braze paste.

NEXTGEN: Meeting with IVEK to discuss precision wax dispensing systems.

HOPPER: Continuing to work on design of HOPPER V3 for installation into the PILOT printers. One design goal is to make it compatible with doser-style dispensing or Payman's powder

valving system. Meeting discussing progress on hopper project.

2025-03-10

PXL: Received Unit 5 and was leak tested by Sean. Multiple leaks were found. Next steps are TBD; Marcus has contacted Rajan to ask for permission to rebraze the assembly but as yet I have heard no reply.

HOPPER: Continuing to work on design of HOPPER V3 to be installed in the PILOT printer. I have designed the endcaps with the motor mounted on one side, but I am having difficulty designing the overall system mounting; for vibration isolation it is best that the assembly be resting on springs on top of the PILOT Y axis plate, but the HOPPER assembly must be installed from underneath due to the protruding motors.

NEXTGEN: Working on assembling the pellet extruder for Pourya's gantry. I have designed a new hopper for it and printed one out from ESD-safe PETG, but the print did not come out as well as I'd like so I am going to print it again, along with a test roller to see how powder sticks to it.

REDRESS: Removed a green part from the lower Keith furnace that had been filled and cured over the weekend, then impregnated it with wax that is a blend of paraffin, PE-CVA, stearic acid, and mineral oil, to make a theoretically soft, low-shrinkage wax. I first soaked it in melted wax on the large hot plate set to 150C for 2 hours, then put it in a vacuum chamber to completely impregnate the part. I then dissolved off the mold. The surface finish of the part looked good but there were several longitudinal cracks that seemed to originate at the castellation notches on the top of the part. The part did seem quite waterproof. I also mixed up a batch of TEG-DMA/17-4 PH slurry and filled 2 molds with it, then put them in the lower Keith furnace to cure. The ratio I used is 500g metal powder to 50g TEG-DMA, which is a high binder load but I am trying to get some aesthetically good green parts even if it partially compromises debindability. I also mixed up a batch of coated powder that is currently drying made with 17-4PH powder and a binder liquid that comprises PMMA, PEG 8K, and stearic acid dissolved in acetone. I used the same ratio as I did TEG-DMA, although the actual binder load of the powder once it is dried should be considerably lower because the PMMA/PEG/SA binder components are a small percentage of the binder liquid. With both of these batches I made an effort to ensure that they were well-mixed with an electric hand mixer to ensure that the powder is completely coated with binder; I think that this is an important variable that I have so far been neglecting.

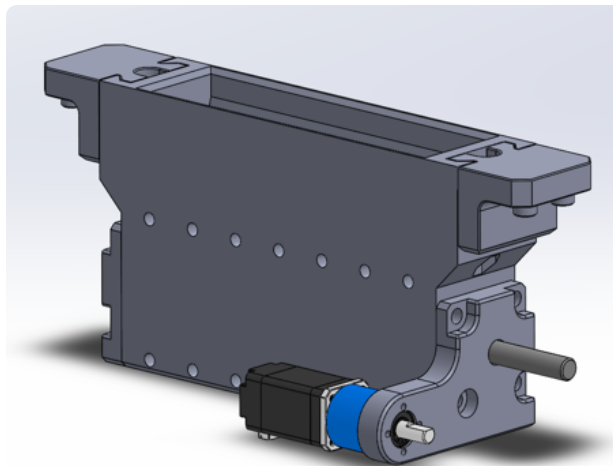
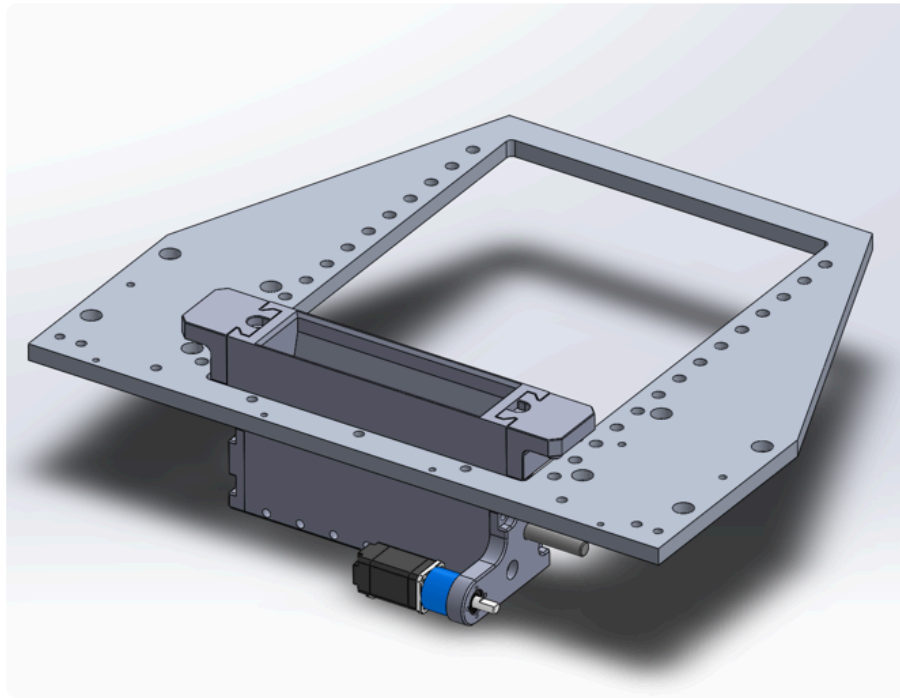
2025-03-11

Bagel Tuesday Company Meeting - 2X PILOT printers to Epson and 2X to IHI; undecided whether they will be made here or at Rajan's machinery manufacturer. Discussed the redesign of the PXL heat exchanger.

Company Cleanup: Same as last time, I spent the hour cleaning up the fabrication R&D lab.

PXL: PXL meeting was scheduled but not canceled and not held.

HOPPER: Completed preliminary design of hopper body, side mounts, and upper mounts.



NEXTGEN: Assembled the pellet-based extruder for Pourya's gantry.

REDRESS: Did a test heating the PMMA/PEG/SA powder made yesterday in a ceramic crucible to 250F. The green part held its shape when overturned out of the ceramic crucible but was not hard enough to prevent indentation from a toothpick. When I mixed up that batch of powder the

components of the liquid binder had not completely dissolved, so I mixed up a new batch of powder with the now-fully-mixed binder liquid, with a 10% liquid binder load.

2025-03-12

REDRESS: Generated a new pre-coated powder binder with assistance from Claude:

**Metal Powder Binding Formulation for 17-4 PH
Stainless Steel**

Ingredients

Component	Amount (wt%)	Function
PMMA 15K	85.0%	Primary binder polymer
TEG-DMA (Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate)	10.0%	Crosslinking agent
Benzoyl peroxide	2.5%	Thermal initiator
Dibutyl phthalate	1.5%	Plasticizer
3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate	1.0%	Adhesion promoter

This recipe will, in theory, be triggered to thermally crosslink when heated sufficiently, yielding strong, waterproof green parts that can have their sacrificial molds dissolved without damage but will be easier to debind than a green part bound purely with TEG-DMA.

HOPPER: Connected an audio amplifier to the signal generator to drive the bare voice coil speaker element and the PS5 controller vibrator. I was able to liquify the powder using either element; the voice coil was able to transmit more energy into the powder but is considerably larger and noisier than the PS5 controller vibrator. The most effective frequency seemed to be around 144 Hz, much lower than I had expected but in line with Claude’s suggestions. I also connected one of the ultrasonic horns we have around to the 200V driver I got previously, and was able to generate a tone but not a significant amplitude of vibration. This may be due to the power capability of the driver I have or a limitation of the horn itself.

2025-03-13

PXL: Assemble PXL unit 5 for first cycle of BAg-8 rebraze. Cleaned all joints with a stainless steel wire wheel in a small rotary tool, the cleaned with acetone and air. Applied NicroBraz green braze stop around the edge of the plate and inside the perimeter of each copper part. Applied braze stop to each corner (I used less braze stop than usual to conserve it; the only tube we have on hand is running low). I straightened BAg-8 .032” wire then cut it to the appropriate

lengths. I upgraded my wire cutting tool with a glass bottle that screws onto the end; this catches cut wires so it isn't necessary to move the tool over a cup to drop the cut wires every time a wire is cut. I applied nickel powder to the lift pins and left a fillet-shaped pile of nickel powder around the joint. Normally I try to confine the nickel powder to the joint to be sealed, but this time I left a pile of powder to potentially generate a brazed fillet that may provide better sealing. This technique may be applied to the chamfered joints as well.

HOPPER: I printed out some of the smaller components required for HOPPER V3 from 3DXTECH ESD-PETG. In theory this material is slightly conductive so it should prevent static buildup and reduce the likelihood of powder sticking to it, but this remains to be tested.

NEXTGEN: I finished wiring up the pellet extruder for Pourya's gantry. The only step remaining is to test it before it can be mounted.

I reassembled the Prusa and got it printing again; I think it is important to have at least two printers running 1.75mm filament because the Bambu printer may be booked in the near future for HOPPER parts. I want to be able to print water-soluble molds while the Bambu printer is being used for more critical projects.

2025-03-14

HOPPER: I test-fit the dovetail joints printed (I printed 2 of the actual side mounts and a small section of HOPPER V3 that contains the dovetail negative) and they seem to fit well; there is some drag on them but that is unlikely to be a critical problem and will go away over time as the joints wear by being assembled and disassembled.

REDRESS: Working on getting the Prusa to reliably print Aquasys 120 molds. I first had issues with stringing that I resolved by adjusting the scarf joint settings; now I have issues with the print cracking. This material is meant to be printed in an enclosed and heated build chamber, so it is unsurprising that it has issue with being printed in the open, particularly because the light R&D lab is colder than usual today.

NEXTGEN: Order for a 36" fume hood for the heavy R&D area was approved. This will be used to chemical mixing for binders and for wax melting experiments that may burn wax and release toxic fumes. I have the pellet extruder working well on the benchtop; at 50C it is able to extrude through a 0.4mm nozzle. Per Pourya's suggestion I super glued the nozzle to the heater and the nozzle/heater assembly to the heat break. This seems to provide an effective seal,

2025-03-17

HOPPER: I have the body, side mounts, and prototype dovetail vibration isolation supports printed. I redesigned the dovetail mounts to have a screw passing through them so they will be held in place on the PILOT printer's Y axis gantry where before they were just resting on springs. I have also designed the body and roller for Payman's hopper design; it recycles the side mounts from the primary hopper design but flips them upside down so the roller is slightly closer to the bottom of the hopper. Drilled 1X 3mm hole in each of 2X 8mm shafts and installed a 3mm X 12mm L spring pin in each hole to rotationally couple the shaft to the roller. I assembled HOPPER V3.0 without a roller and the components seem to fit properly.

NEXTGEN: The pellet-style extruder head is complete and tested and ready to be installed on Pourya's gantry when the system is ready for it.

REDRESS: I made a new formulation of powder over the weekend that has 15g of TEG-DMA and 5g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate (adhesion promoter) dissolved in acetone and mixed with 1 kg of 17-4 PH treated powder. After drying it over the weekend it still seemed damp and clumpy, and did not sift well through the sieve in the powder room. I have filled a water-soluble mold and a ceramic crucible with it as best I could and am passing it through the TEG-DMA cycle on the lower Keith furnace (ramp to 200F, hold 1 hour, ramp to 275F, cool). I mixed up a new batch of coated powder with 10g PVP-VA and 20g TEG-DMA with the intent of making a reasonably strong "cake" of powder that can be ground and sieved cleanly (PVP-VA) while also being waterproof once it has been fully cured in a mold (TEG-DMA). Since this batch is already looking like it is going to be damp once fully dry, I am mixing up another batch. This new batch has 10g PVP-VA with 3g TEG-DMA and 420g of 17-4 PH powder, yielding a coated powder with a 3% binder load with binder that is 3:1 PVP-VA to TEG-DMA. This will hopefully yield a crispier powder that is easier to grind, sieve, and pour, while still giving the benefits of TEG-DMA binder.

PXL: No word yet on the success or failure of Unit 5 post rebraze, but I overheard that AEM is considering having us solder the unit so presumably it leaked. This may give us the opportunity to try furnace soldering instead of manual soldering. Manual soldering had mixed success in the past, so I personally would like to explore furnace soldering further. By soldering in a controlled atmosphere with controlled thermal parameters, we can gain improved process control that may yield a more reliable soldered joint.

2025-03-18

PXL: Unit 5 has 5 leaks after rebrazing and machining, which is considerably better than after the first braze, but next steps are still to be determined. At the PXL meeting we discussed

various approaches for repair, including furnace soldering. I think the best option is flux soldering in the nitrogen furnace.

HOPPER: Redesigned hopper body to use square drop-in nuts instead of heat-set inserts and also have a bolt-on dovetail receiver instead of printing the dovetail as part of the body (it was difficult to print the hopper body sideways with the dovetail attached; since there is only a small part of the body attached directly to the build plate it had a tendency to pull off of the build plate).

REDRESS: The green parts made with the 15g of TEG-DMA and 5g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate (adhesion promoter) powder came out strong and waterproof, but it was not possible to make a cohesive green part in the soluble mold because the coated powder was damp and clumpy and did not flow well. Where I was able to pack the powder into the ceramic crucible by hand the green part came out waterproof and nearly indestructible (I couldn't get it out of the crucible so I smashed apart the crucible as much as I could, but where it is glued to the green part I couldn't affect it by hammering it without applying a lot more impact than I was willing to). I am currently drying a new batch of powdering using 3% binder load (12g PMMA (8g 15K 4g 350K), 2.25g TEG-DMA, .75g Stearic Acid). The TEG-DMA content should be small enough that the powder cake can still be ground and sieved and the powder will flow reasonably well, but hopefully the TEG-DMA will act as a crosslinking initiator to cause the PMMA to crosslink when being cured. I also tested the powder made using a 3:1 ratio of PVP-VA to TEG-DMA; the dried cake was flexible and seemed damp after grinding, so I added about a tablespoon of fumed silica as a flow aid, which did allow it to flow well but the green part produced was weak and not waterproof. This may be due to the PVP-VA content or the high flow aid content.

2025-03-19

PXL: Meeting with Rajan, Sean, Marcus, Manju, Payman, and me about design changes to the PXL. Specifically the near-term goal is to use a roughed plate that we have around and machine some copper parts as best we can to create a lap joint with more overlap. We are also going to do a brazing run to try and repair the last leaks on Unit 5; I grooved the 4 side leaks and used a counterboring bit to machine down the 2 leaking lift pin bosses. I then placed BAg-8 wire preforms in all 4 grooves and the 2 lift pin bosses, tacked them in place with BAg-8 paste, and applied NicroBraz Green braze stop around all 6 repair points. The grooving operation is intended to increase BFM access to the leak points, create a chamfer that if filled with BFM may act to seal the leak point even after machining, and provide a clean material surface for the BFM to bond to.

HOPPER: The HOPPER body V3.2 print last night was not successful and the two dovetail adapter parts were warped because of poor bed adhesion, so I am currently reprinting the dovetail adapters and will reprint the body tonight. I am also going to change the design of the body; I am rethinking the square nuts because heat-set inserts will provide a more reliable and reusable attachment point and a cleaner design, and since we are likely not going to print very many HOPPER iterations the cost of using heat-set inserts is not a huge factor.

REDRESS: When mixing the powder batch yesterday I forgot to add the TEG-DMA after dissolving the PMMA and Stearic Acid so I had to add 3.3g of TEG-DMA to 150 mL of acetone (I accidentally added too much TEG-DMA, so the recipe is going to have 3.3g of TEG-DMA instead of 2.25g), then break up the dried cake and dissolve it in the TEG-DMA/acetone solution. I mixed it in a cup first and poured it into a metal pie tin, but since there were still visible clumps I added more acetone and mixed it further in the pie tin to uniformly coat the powder.

2025-03-20

HOPPER: Post-processed hopper bodies for Payman's design (HOPPER V3.1) and the latest HOPPER V3 design (HOPPER V3.4). Will install M3 and M5 heat set inserts and assemble. In process of printing rollers for HOPPER V3.4 and 4X different roller's for Mohsen's hopper design.

PXL: Meeting with AEM discussing the PXL. They plan to do a brazing experiment with machined copper heat exchangers and a thick machined 304 SS base, without plating either. They also are increasing the thickness of the flange to increase the length of the vertical joint.

R&D Meeting w/ Michele: 1.5hr meeting with me, Michele, Marcus, Mahmood, and Midhun discussing R&D projects in progress and the org structure of the R&D department.

REDRESS: Filled and cured a mold and a ceramic crucible with the TEG-DMA/PMMA/SA powder, and the results were generally positive: the green part seemed reasonably strong and highly waterproof (although it did have cracks when the mold was dissolved, possibly from heating it too rapidly in the curing cycle or more likely from poor packing density). I am making a new batch tonight, with a 3% binder load comprising 66% PMMA 15K, 15% TEG-DMA, 10% Dibutyl Phthalate (plasticizer)

2025-03-21

HOPPER: Assembled HOPPER V3.1 (Payman's idea) and HOPPER V3.4 (current design for installation in PILOT). Still struggling with printing rollers from PETG on the Prusa and Bambu printers. Issues generally revolve around base layer adhesion.

PXL: PXL Unit 5 has some leaks after the 2nd rebraze. There are some leaking brazed seams as well as leaking from the bottom of 3 lift pin bosses. I removed the plate from the pressure test fixture and noted that one of the o-ring grooves seemed to be filled with ash; I would guess that an o-ring was left inside that groove during brazing and the o-ring carbonized. I blew out the o-ring groove, then noted that there was some dust or debris that came out of one of the nearby heat exchanger element holes, so I went though and blew them all out. There was noticeable dust, debris, or liquid that was blown out of each one. I suspect that this is residue of the NicroBraz Red braze stop that was used previously and not removed with acid.

REDRESS: The green part whose mold I started dissolving yesterday was fully exposed today. There are some noticeable cracks, but the part seems to have duplicated the surface finish of the 3D printed mold well and seems to be uniformly porous (as desired) without macroscopic voids. I ground and sieved the powder made using the advanced binder recipe

2025-03-24

HOPPER: Installed doser roller in HOPPER V3.4 prototype and installed on HOPPER test station for Sean to use to test vibrators of different styles.

REDRESS: Trying new advanced recipe with both 1% and 3% binder load.

Metal Powder Binder Formulation

Composition (for 1000g metal powder, 3% binder load)

Compone nt	Chemical	Amount (g)	Percentag e	Supplier Specificati ons	
PMMA	Poly(meth yl methacryl ate)	20.1	67%	Molecular Weight: 25-30K	
TEG-DMA	Triethylen e glycol dimethacr ylate	4.5	15%	Purity: >99%	

	3-(trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate	Silane coupling agent	2.1	7%	Purity: >98%
DBP	Dibutyl phthalate	2.4	8%	Reagent grade	
Stearic acid	Fatty acid	0.9	3%	Purity: >98.5%	
Polyester resin catalyst	MEKP-based catalyst	1.2	4%	15-40% MEKP content	
Acetone	Solvent	90	(will evaporate)	HPLC grade	

Preparation Procedure

Equipment Required

- Precision analytical balance
- Glass mixing vessel
- Magnetic stirrer
- Fume hood
- Personal protective equipment (gloves, safety glasses)

Detailed Mixing Instructions

1. Preparation Setup

- Ensure clean, dry working environment
- Use calibrated precision balance
- Work in well-ventilated area or fume hood

2. Solvent Preparation

- Measure 90g of acetone into clean glass vessel
- Begin gentle magnetic stirring at 200-300 RPM

3. Polymer Dissolution

- Slowly add 20.1g PMMA to acetone
- Stir until completely dissolved (15-20 minutes)
- Ensure no visible undissolved particles

4. **Additive Incorporation**

- Add 2.4g DBP, mix for 5 minutes
- Add 2.1g 3-(trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate, mix thoroughly
- Add 0.9g stearic acid, ensure complete dispersion

5. **Crosslinker Addition**

- Add 4.5g TEG-DMA
- Mix for 3-5 minutes

6. **Catalyst Incorporation**

- Add 1.2g polyester resin catalyst
- Mix quickly and thoroughly (30-45 seconds)
- Avoid prolonged mixing to prevent premature activation

Powder Coating Process

- Immediately mix with metal powder
- Spread in thin, uniform layers (max 5mm thickness)
- Dry at room temperature (20-25°C)
- Drying time: 18-24 hours
- Avoid direct sunlight or heat sources

Curing Parameters

- Heating Rate: 2-3°C/minute
- Peak Temperature: 90°C
- Hold Time: 60-75 minutes
- Cooling: Slow, natural cooling to room temperature

Safety and Storage

- Store components in cool, dry place
- Keep away from heat and direct sunlight
- Catalyst is light and heat sensitive
- Use within 3 months of preparation

Quality Control Notes

- Check viscosity before use
- Ensure homogeneous mixture
- Verify no visible particulate separation

Caution: Contains volatile and potentially harmful chemicals. Use appropriate personal protective equipment.

PXL: Emergency meeting about delivering a functional plate by 4/11. Evidently Samer at AEM is pushing Scott to deliver a plate by 4/11, so the purpose of this meeting was to determine the feasibility of making a plate with the 2.5mm horizontal flange lap joint by then. The general conclusion of the meeting was that it is probably feasible to make Unit 6 by 4/11 exactly the same as Unit 5, but changing the horizontal flange lap joint to 2.5mm is essentially the scope of the 6 month redesign project we were trying to get AEM to pay us for, and thus is unlikely to be done within 3 weeks.

2025-03-25

PXL: Setting up Unit 5 for rebraze 3 today. Recommended max number of rebraze attempts is 2, but that is more of a rule of thumb than a hard spec. AEM wants to ship a functional unit on 4/11, which means we would need to deliver it by 4/4, the Friday of next week. We are discussing possible design changes to Unit 6 to improve probability of sealing, including eliminating capillary gap to buy .010” per side of flange overlap, skipping plating and blister testing of copper parts to help reduce distortion and brazing the parts without having plated the copper, etc. Had 3 Troy Ounces of BAg-8 wire delivered from McMaster via courier. Completed wiring plate in preparation for rebraze.

Cleanup. Assembled 36” fume hood for wax/chemical experiments in heavy R&D lab, but it arrived without a filter so that will need to be purchased separately.

REDRESS:Metal Powder Binder Formulation

Composition (for 1000g metal powder, 3% binder load)

Component	Chemical	Amount (g)	Percentage	Functional Role
PMMA	Poly(methyl methacrylate)	18.0	60%	Primary binding matrix

TEG-DMA	Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate	4.5	15%	Crosslinking agent
3-(trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate	Silane coupling agent	2.1	7%	Improve particle adhesion
PVP-VA Copolymer	Vinyl Pyrrolidone-Vinyl Acetate	1.2	4%	Flow aid and secondary binder
Polyester resin catalyst	MEKP-based catalyst	1.2	4%	Curing initiator
Stearic acid	Fatty acid	1.5	5%	Surface modification
Acetone	Solvent	75g	•	Primary solvent
Isopropyl alcohol	Co-solvent	15g	•	Dissolution aid

Rationale for 4% PVP-VA

1. Increased Flow Characteristics
 - More pronounced powder dispersibility
 - Enhanced initial mixing properties
 - Potential improvement in green body uniformity
2. Balanced Composition
 - Reduced PMMA to accommodate increased PVP-VA
 - Slight increase in stearic acid for surface modification
 - Maintained critical binder components

PVP-VA Selection Criteria

- Low molecular weight variant (K-15 to K-30)
- Vinyl acetate content: 10-20%

- Optimized for organic solvent dissolution
- Controlled water interaction

Processing Modifications

- Adjust mixing protocol for higher PVP-VA content
- Ensure thorough, uniform dispersion
- Monitor initial powder coating characteristics
- Potential slight adjustment of drying parameters

Performance Considerations

- Enhanced initial flowability
- Careful monitoring of water resistance
- Potential subtle changes in green body properties
- Thermal debinding performance

Caution: Contains reactive chemicals. Use appropriate personal protective equipment.

2025-03-26

PXL: Received Unit 5 back from Bodycote. It only leaks in one spot, but more leaks may be opened after machining.

HOPPER: Working on installing HOPPER V3.4 in PILOT 2. Ben removed the mist box and heater to clear up some space for installing the hopper without being space constrained.

2025-03-27

PXL:

Electron beam welding meeting w/ Matt Wade at Electron Beam Engineering. The combination of braze filler material and electroless nickel plating is likely to cause cracking. Even welding it without BFM would be unlikely to succeed. Starting and stopping a weld can cause cracking so it is beneficial to weld around the entire cell in one shot and do a power taper off as ending the weld. They regularly weld assemblies that are then brazed later. The corners of parts butting together should be as sharp as possible, burrs can even be beneficial as they act like filler material.

Meeting with AEM. Craig is interested in EBW. They tried soldering stainless steel to copper and had difficulty getting the solder to wet to the stainless. They did some research that suggests

that solder joints between stainless steel tend to be weak.

HOPPER: Assembled and installed in PILOT 2.

2025-03-31

HOPPER: Working on design of benchtop testbed for HOPPER/spreader technologies that would enable motion in one axis with total access to the HOPPER and spreader from the top, bottom, and sides. Working on integrating a sealed solenoid into the HOPPER 3.4 design to act as a tapping mechanism.

PXL: Meeting on next steps for the various PXL assemblies. Removed as much epoxy as possible from Unit 3 in preparation for a debind cycle that is being run tonight in one of the CM (hydrogen) furnaces. The nominal plan is to BAg-7 braze the leak points and install a new copper part in the pocket whose copper part Craig removed.

REDRESS: The powder formulation tried over the weekend made brittle green parts that were not waterproof. I made a new batch of 500g of powder with the last of the PMMA and added back the plasticizer. I am also trying to make a batch of binder using amorphous polypropylene by dissolving stearic acid and amorphous polypropylene granules in ethyl acetate. N-heptane would work better, but we are currently out of it. The polypropylene granules are very slow to dissolve in ethyl acetate, so I have increased the mixing plate temperature to 50C.

2025-04-01

HOPPER: I am working on modifying the HOPPER V3 design to fit through the opening in the PILOT base plate and to have a larger dispense line of 140mm (5.512", I went with 140mm for the sake of clean metric dimensions). This entails a redesign of all components, so technically I should've increased the version to V4. The hopper version has been incremented to V3.5 to mark the new design as being distinct.

PXL: Removed Unit 3 from F2. The cleaned grooves seemed similar to the way they had appeared before the cycle. The only noticeable change to the plate was that the copper appeared to be less oxidized. Whoever removed the plate from the pressure test fixture last failed to remove the o-rings, so they were decomposed and some pieces of the large o-ring fell off at several locations around the furnace heat bricks as I was removing the plate. The o-rings held their shape but had turned gray and broke apart into dust when force was applied. I used compressed air to remove the remaining o-rings and o-ring fragments before preparing the top surface for brazing. I cleaned out the two grooves and the empty pocket with acetone and a

stainless steel wire wheel in the rotary tool in the heavy R&D lab. I applied BAg-7 paste to one groove immediately after cleaning it to protect it from oxidation before the brazing cycle begins, and the other groove has BAg-7 wire tacked in place at the ends with BAg-7 paste. Sean gave me a chamfered bare copper FG2 heat exchanger to install in the empty pocket. It seemed to fit well. I applied BAg-7 BFM paste to the corners and BAg-7 wire to the sides (1/32" diameter, the same as we use when brazing with BAg-8). I worked with Mahmood to generate a brazing cycle for the plate based on BAg-7 experiments I had run previously. The cycle goes to a peak temperature of 730C with a hold time of 30 minutes.

REDRESS: I am having some difficult dissolving amorphous polypropylene in ethyl acetate, so I am trying to

2025-04-02

PXL: Meetings, assembly, repair

2025-04-03

PXL: Meeting w/ AEM. Prepared Unit 6 for BAg-8 rebraze. Soldered Unit 5 on hot plate. Prepared Unit 3 for 2nd BAg-7 braze and started cycle in F2 with a peak temperature of 710C (previous peak temperature for 1st BAg-7 braze was 730C).

2025-04-04

PXL: 5 and 6 leak, 3 is sealed before machining. 3 leaked after machining, so I grooved the leaking joints and filled the grooves with BAg-7 paste, trying to keep the level of the paste flush with the level of the plate.

To Do Next Week: Install and wire HOPPER V3.5, redesign for tapper, add vibrator, spreader bar for V3.1. Try fly cutting with Stepcraft.

NOTE: Goal is to have some hopper in PILOT 2 to run prints to be able to show the board, explicitly not to create an optimized hopper before starting to print with it. Optimal process would be to determine the quantifiable specs of the function and performance required from the hopper, then design and test prototypes to meet those requirements, then integrate that into the machine.

2025-04-07

PXL: Came in on Saturday and removed plate 3 from F2 and leak checked it. It was sealed, so I cleaned it up a bit with a diamond stone and it stayed sealed. Today Unit 6 was minimum cleanup machined, leaks were marked, and I cleaned the leak points with acetone and a wire wheel, and applied BAg-7 BFM paste, left it on the hot plate at 40C for a few hours, then loaded it into F2 and started cycle 13, which is the BAg-7 braze cycle currently set with a peak temperature of 710C.

REDRESS: Having difficulty with making a PMMA-based binder that produces strong green parts after curing. I am experimenting with: Poly(methyl methacrylate-co-ethyl acrylate) <https://www.sigmaaldrich.com/US/en/product/aldrich/182249> which forms the strongest powder cake I've ever seen when dissolved in acetone and mixed with powder, but doesn't bind back together well after grinding, sieving, and curing. Although to be fair, I was only able to get ~1/3 of the cake to grind into powder because the remaining chunks were too strong to grind.

2025-04-08

PXL: No word back from AEM on Unit 3. After removing Unit 6 from last night's BAg-7 brazing run in F2, it only leaked on one side of one unit (2 points) before and after machining. Some porosity is visible where the BAg-7 BFM was melted into the grooves.. I grooved out the leaking joint, then grooved it deeper per Marcus' request at the exact location of the leak to get a better view of the leak point.

HOPPER: Working on a new motor mount for the stepper motor that drives the dosing roller; mounting it to the end cap doesn't provide reliable belt tension. I am also working on mounting a stepper motor to act as the impact doser roller cleaner; a solenoid is difficult to integrate given the dimensional limitations and has limitations on the frequency and amplitude control. I am printing a new hopper that has mounting holes on the front and back to enable mounting of the roller and tapper motors on one side of the hopper and the vibrator on the other side.

2025-04-09

PXL: Cleaned groove on Unit 6 and applied BAg-7 braze paste using the final Unit 3 method: I injected paste into the groove to fill it as well as possible, then scraped off the excess with a razor blade held at an angle to hopefully push the braze paste into the groove as much as possible and reduce the excess paste left above the surface.

REDRESS: I have a batch of 1 kg of powder coated with 28g PMMA EA and 2g silane coupling agent. I am working on a batch that will have 1g of 3-(trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate

dissolved in 100g IPA, allowed to hydrolyze for 1 hour, then mixed with powder and dried to pre-treat it, then it will be blended with 36g of PMMA-EA dissolved in acetone combined with 1 g of dibutyl phthalate. I have also been omitting TEG-DMA in recent formulations, which may be a mistake because TEG-DMA is apparently acting as the crosslinking initiator. Here is a possible recipe: 1000 g powder to 20g binder, 17g PMMA, 1g AIBN, 1g TEG-DMA, 1g Silane

HOPPER: Assembled a HOPPER V3.6 for PILOT 2 with a shorter belt that moves the stepper motor closer to the shaft and a new stepper-tapper design that has a brass bolt on the end of a carbon-fiber reinforced plastic arm to tap the shaft without damaging it. This would enable precision control of the frequency (by setting number of stepper moves per second) and the amplitude (by controlling rotational velocity) of the tap impulse. I also began working on using an Arduino to control HOPPER functions (doser roller rotation, vibration of doser roller with stepper motor, stepper-tapper, and vibration motor). Controlling these functions with an Arduino would enable more advanced control of functions independently of simple gantry motion. Per Payman's request, I removed the stepper-tapper and replaced it with a traditional solenoid, and abandoned the advanced control system in favor of simple Duet control through the PILOT printer.

2025-04-10

PXL: Weekly meeting with Craig at AEM. Shipping the unit to TSMC has been delayed, so they didn't actually need it on Friday. They pressure tested Unit 3 to 80 psi for several hours and it remained sealed. They have been simulating the performance of fully machined copper heat exchangers that have solid outer walls and are therefore brazed with a full-height vertical braze joint. Their simulation results suggested that the performance of machined heat exchangers would be lower than 3D printed lattice heat exchangers, but may be acceptable for their application. They are also looking into reducing the total height of the PXL assembly by 1-1.5mm to compensate for changes that need to be made elsewhere in their hardware stack. We are not attempting any further repairs of the plates that we have in our possession. The BAg-7 leak repair completed last night on Unit 6 was not successful; one key difference between the repair protocol used on Unit 3 and that used on Unit 6 was that Unit 3 was initially BAg-7 brazed with a peak temperature of 730C, which Unit 6 was always brazed to a peak temperature of 710, the temperature profile that was used for rebraze attempts on Unit 3.

HOPPER: HOPPER V3.6 is assembled and installed in PILOT 2, waiting for Pourya to finish wiring and programming. I am working on printing a new body for HOPPER V3.1 that has spreader bars attached. I am also working on HERMES, a simple testbed for testing the hopper outside of the

printer that can also be upgraded to be a full printer when used with pre-coated powder with the addition of a laser or projector to cure the layers.

REDRESS:

AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Water-Soluble Mold Metal Forming (Adjusted)

Materials

For 1280g Final Metal Powder Mixture (98% Metal, 2% Binder)

Metal Powder

- 1254.4g of metal powder (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)

Binder Components (25.6g total)

- 22.5g Poly(methyl methacrylate-co-ethyl acrylate) (88% of binder)
- 1.54g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (6% of binder)
- 1.02g 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate (4% of binder)
- 0.51g 2,2'-Azobis(2-methylpropionitrile) (AIBN) (2% of binder)

Solvent

- 230-256g Acetone (9-10:1 ratio with binder solids)

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with tight-fitting lids
- Mechanical mixer or high-shear mixer
- Drying trays
- Controlled temperature oven
- Grinding equipment (ball mill or attritor mill)
- Sieves (appropriate mesh size for your application)
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)

Procedure

A. Binder Preparation

1. In a well-ventilated area, weigh 230g of acetone into a glass container.

2. While stirring, slowly add 22.5g of PMMA-co-EA to the acetone. Stir until completely dissolved (approximately 30-60 minutes).
3. Add 1.02g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate to the solution and stir for 15 minutes.
4. Add 1.54g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.
5. Finally, add 0.51g of AIBN and stir gently until completely dissolved (approximately 10 minutes).
6. Cover the container with a tight-fitting lid to prevent acetone evaporation. The binder solution is now ready.

B. Slurry Preparation

1. Place 1254.4g of metal powder in a mixing vessel.
2. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the prepared binder solution to the metal powder.
3. Continue mixing for 30-45 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder.
4. If the slurry appears too thick, add small amounts of additional acetone (up to 26g) to achieve proper consistency.

C. Drying

1. Spread the slurry evenly in drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
2. Initial drying: Allow to dry at room temperature in a well-ventilated area for 12-24 hours.
3. Secondary drying: Place in an oven at 50°C for 4-6 hours.
4. Final drying: Increase temperature to 60°C for 2 hours to ensure complete solvent removal.
5. Allow to cool to room temperature. The material should form a solid cake.

D. Grinding and Sieving

1. Break the dried cake into smaller pieces.
2. Grind using a ball mill or attritor mill under controlled temperature conditions (below 40°C to prevent premature crosslinking).
3. Sieve the ground powder to obtain the desired particle size distribution (typically 45-150µm for application).
4. If necessary, add 0.06-0.13g of fumed silica (0.005-0.01% of total weight) to improve flowability if the powder still appears damp.

E. The AquaMold™ Process

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology (PVA, specialized PLA, or other water-soluble polymer).

2. Pack the prepared flowable powder into the 3D printed water-soluble molds, ensuring uniform density.
3. Heat the packed molds to 80°C and maintain this temperature for 1.5 hours to activate the AIBN and crosslink the binder.
4. Cool gradually to room temperature (approximately 1-2 hours).

F. Dissolution and Green Part Recovery

1. Submerge the entire assembly in warm water (40-50°C) to dissolve the water-soluble mold.
2. Monitor dissolution and refresh water as needed until mold is completely removed.
3. Carefully extract the green part from the water bath and allow to dry completely.
4. The green part is now ready for debinding and sintering according to your standard protocol for the specific metal alloy.

Notes

- Store the AIBN in a cool, dark place to prevent premature decomposition.
- All mixing containers should be clean and free of contaminants.
- Perform all solvent handling steps in a well-ventilated area away from ignition sources.
- The binder formulation can be adjusted slightly based on the specific metal powder characteristics and desired final properties.
- The water-soluble mold geometry will determine the final shape of your metal part - ensure proper mold design for complex features.

2025-04-14

REDRESS: I came in over the weekend to grind and sieve the latest batch of powder (the recipe above, but with the powder pre-treated with the silane coupling agent before being blended with the binder). I loaded it into a mold and tried to run the PMMA crosslinking cycle in the lower Keith furnace, but the powder seems completely unbound this morning so I suspect that the furnace did not actually heat up. I have been seeing it have some issues lately with not heating at all, so hopefully that is what happened and it wasn't an issue with the powder not curing at all. I am trying the same powder batch in a new mold tonight with a different thermal cycle. I have historically been heating the molds to 250F, but Claude suggested that a temperature that high could cause issues with particle binding because it would cause the AIBN to decompose too rapidly and PMMA can degrade at temperatures above 100C. Looking at the PMMA-EA I have been using <https://www.sigmaaldrich.com/US/en/product/aldrich/182249> it says in the information that the glass transition temperature is 104C (219.2F). I had previously assumed that

heating the PMMA above its glass transition point would be necessary to bind the particles, but I may have been wrong about that. The cycle I am using right now is 70F-160F ramp at 120F/hour, 30 min dwell, 160-180F ramp at 120F/hour, 90 min dwell, cycle end.

HOPPER: Working on designing a HOPPER V4.0 that uses an aluminum doser roller modified from a piece of timing pulley stock.

HERMES: Designed belt drive system and just need to print various components and assemble them. I also need to cut the 4040 stock to the right lengths to put together the core frame.

2025-04-15

REDRESS: The mold I cooked last night was no better, so I ran the same mold through a fast ramp cycle set to 300F (it probably overshot that by a bit because of the ramp speed) and the part came out better. Still not strong enough, and it seems to be still breaking apart when I am dissolving off the mold, but my sense is that it is significantly stronger. I believe Claude may have been wrong about staying below the glass transition point of PMMA, and when I confronted it it changed its mind and said that heating above the glass transition point would be beneficial for green part strength.

HOPPER: I made an aluminum roller for HOPPER V4.0 by turning down the ends of a piece of timing belt pulley stock. I also designed and generated a drawing for a mount to mount Payman's HOPPER V3.1 to the blue and silver gantry.

HERMES: I mounted the main carrier mount to the two linear guide bearings and installed the motor, idler pulley, and belt. I still need to cut down a piece of 4040 extrusion to fit the front of the frame so the frame has not been aligned and the screws tightened, but the bulk of the structure and functionality is ready. It does not have a good cable management solution yet, which I may need to work on or possibly ignore for the time being.

2025-04-16

REDRESS: I put two molds in the new higher temperature curing cycle (peak 300F), one filled with the latest batch of powder and one filled with the same powder that had been mixed with fumed silica, and the one that had been mixed with fumed silica came out stronger and held up to mold dissolving much better. Some bits of it still broke off, but it mostly held its shape. I think the issues with structural weakness at some points are due to uneven fumed silica coating. I am currently drying a new batch of powder that has some dibutyl phthalate added to give it a bit of flexibility:

AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Water-Soluble Mold Metal Forming (Optimized Version)

Materials

For 1000g Final Metal Powder Mixture (97% Metal, 3% Binder)

Metal Powder

- 970g of metal powder (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)

Binder Components (30g total)

- 25.2g Poly(methyl methacrylate-co-ethyl acrylate) (84% of binder)
- 1.8g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (6% of binder)
- 1.2g 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate (4% of binder)
- 0.6g 2,2'-Azobis(2-methylpropionitrile) (AIBN) (2% of binder)
- 1.2g Dibutyl phthalate (4% of binder) - *new plasticizer component*

Solvent

- 270-300g Acetone (9-10:1 ratio with binder solids)

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with tight-fitting lids
- Mechanical mixer or high-shear mixer
- Drying trays
- Controlled temperature oven
- Grinding equipment (ball mill or attritor mill)
- Sieves (appropriate mesh size for your application)
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)

Procedure

A. Binder Preparation

1. In a well-ventilated area, weigh 270g of acetone into a glass container.
2. While stirring, slowly add 25.2g of PMMA-co-EA to the acetone. Stir until completely dissolved (approximately 30-60 minutes).
3. Add 1.2g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate to the solution and stir for 15 minutes.

4. Add 1.8g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.
5. Add 1.2g of dibutyl phthalate and stir for 15 minutes to ensure complete incorporation of the plasticizer.
6. Finally, add 0.6g of AIBN and stir gently until completely dissolved (approximately 10 minutes).
7. Cover the container with a tight-fitting lid to prevent acetone evaporation. The binder solution is now ready.

B. Slurry Preparation

1. Place 970g of metal powder in a mixing vessel.
2. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the prepared binder solution to the metal powder.
3. Continue mixing for 30-45 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder.
4. If the slurry appears too thick, add small amounts of additional acetone (up to 30g) to achieve proper consistency. *Note: The plasticizer should improve flowability, but monitor consistency carefully.*

C. Drying

1. Spread the slurry evenly in drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
2. Initial drying: Allow to dry at room temperature in a well-ventilated area for 12-24 hours.
3. Secondary drying: Place in an oven at 50°C for 4-6 hours.
4. Final drying: Increase temperature to 60°C for 2 hours to ensure complete solvent removal.
5. Allow to cool to room temperature. The material should form a solid cake.

D. Grinding and Sieving

1. Break the dried cake into smaller pieces.
2. Grind using a ball mill or attritor mill under controlled temperature conditions (below 40°C to prevent premature crosslinking).
3. Sieve the ground powder to obtain the desired particle size distribution (typically 45-150µm for application).
4. If necessary, add 0.05-0.1g of fumed silica (0.005-0.01% of total weight) to improve flowability, though this may be less necessary with the added plasticizer.

E. The AquaMold™ Process

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology (PVA, specialized PLA, or other water-soluble polymer).

2. Pack the prepared flowable powder into the 3D printed water-soluble molds, ensuring uniform density.
3. Heat the packed molds to 80°C and maintain this temperature for 1.5 hours to activate the AIBN and crosslink the binder.
4. Cool gradually to room temperature (approximately 1-2 hours).

F. Dissolution and Green Part Recovery

1. Submerge the entire assembly in warm water (40-50°C) to dissolve the water-soluble mold.
2. Monitor dissolution and refresh water as needed until mold is completely removed.
3. Carefully extract the green part from the water bath and allow to dry completely.
4. The green part is now ready for debinding and sintering according to your standard protocol for the specific metal alloy.

Notes

- The addition of dibutyl phthalate as a plasticizer should improve the flexibility of the green parts and potentially improve packing density during molding.
- You may need to adjust the debinding cycle due to the increased binder content (3% vs 2%) and the addition of the plasticizer.
- The plasticizer may slightly lower the temperature at which the binder softens, which could be beneficial for molding but requires attention during handling.
- Monitor the first few production runs closely to ensure the modified binder system maintains structural integrity during the molding and dissolution steps.
- Store the AIBN in a cool, dark place to prevent premature decomposition.
- All mixing containers should be clean and free of contaminants.
- Perform all solvent handling steps in a well-ventilated area away from ignition sources.

I deviated slightly from the recipe by pre-treating the powder with the silane coupling agent instead of mixing it with the binder. I also tossed the pieces of the last three batches of powder, some of which had not been ground and sieved, into the v mixer with a bunch of fumed silica. Hopefully this will mix the powder with the fumed silica while also breaking apart the unground chunks so that it is easy to sieve the final mixture.

HOPPER: The HOPPER V3.6 is installed in PILOT 2 and is wired up and running. There is an issue with the solenoid sticking to the roller shaft and therefore not tapping, which per Pourya and Mohsen is due to the solenoid being too close to the shaft. I will reprint the solenoid mount with greater spacing to (potentially) alleviate this issue. Worked with Payman to support his

continued development of HOPPER V3.1 on the silver and blue gantry. I am printing a new HOPPER V4.0 body that hopefully will fit the aluminum doser roller better; the one I printed today was still a little too tight to be useable. The one printed today was printed with PETG-CF while the one I am printing tonight is PETG Basic, which is the material I printed it with initially when I tweaked the dimensions to get the doser roller to fit.

HERMES: I installed the hopper mount, which because of the hexagonal cutouts I designed it with is too flexible to be useful in final testing, but it should be fine for initial motion testing. I got a DUET 2 board connected to it and got the main axis homing sensorlessly.

2025-04-17

PXL: Meeting with AEM. They still haven't mounted Unit 3 to their test setup, so apparently they didn't need it when they said they did. They haven't abandoned working with us yet, but they do seem to be exploring the possibility of brazing in billet machined parts. They have a monolithic plate that has a single piece of machined copper on the top with a single part stainless steel base that have been brazed together. Apparently there are concerns with crosstalk between the cells, but it is unclear if that has been tested and whether it matters. They are also having a brazing company in Finland conduct brazing experiments; they first brazed 9 machined copper heat exchangers into an unplated 304SS base and were successful. Next they are going to try the same with 3DEO printed parts. The company won't disclose the exact process and alloys they're using, so presumably they have some secret sauce, although we have also had success with brazing machined copper before.

HOPPER: Assembled a V4.0 hopper with an aluminum roller and a stepper tapper. I still need to make a new mount for the solenoid for the V3.6 hopper in PILOT 2, but other than that it should be ready to begin testing. I want to make some vibration damping mounts by printing them from FormLabs elastic material instead of using springs; the springs isolate the hopper vibrations from the mount well, but do a poor job of locating the hopper.

REDRESS: Mixed up a batch of PVP-VA powder to try to form layers with heat application. Ground and sieved a batch of powder with the advanced blend with no plasticizer, and ran yesterday's batch of advanced binder powder with plasticizer in the v mixer for 6 hours. I then filled a mold with the non-plasticizer powder and one with the plasticizer powder. The mold with non-plasticizer powder is the V8 mold design, which has thicker reinforcing gussets. I am running both molds through the PMMATEGDMAIBN cycle on the upper Keith furnace.

ULTRA: Printed a mist box for Payman's ULTRA setup that is derived from the standard HOPPER design but has straight sides and no opening for a doser roller.

2025-04-21

To Do this Week:

- New solenoid mount for V3.6 - DONE
- Stepper tapper testing - DONE
- New V3.1 hopper with larger width aperture and roller lowered to minimize uncontrolled powder capacity - DONE
- Micro Drop mount - Mount complete for Pourya's gantry, not ready for installation on PILOT yet
 - Mount on reaming gantry first then move to PILOT by end of week

Weekly R&D Meeting

PILOT: Designed and ordered sheet metal panels for laser protection on PILOT 3.

REDRESS: Ordered 10 kgs of MIM feedstock from [Ryer, Inc. | Metal Injection Molding Feedstock | Powder Injection Molding Feedstocks](#) (5kgs 1740-9016AA, \$53.00 per kg, 5kgs CUMI-9016OS, \$75.00 per kg)

2025-04-22

REDRESS: Mixed up a batch of powder using a new recipe that eliminates the plasticizer and increases the TEG-DMA content:

AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Water-Soluble Mold Metal Forming (Optimized Version)

Materials

For 1000g Final Metal Powder Mixture (97% Metal, 3% Binder)

Metal Powder

- 970g of metal powder (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)

Binder Components (30g total)

- 25.2g Poly(methyl methacrylate-co-ethyl acrylate) (84% of binder)
- 3.0g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (10% of binder)
- 1.2g 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate (4% of binder)

- 0.6g 2,2'-Azobis(2-methylpropionitrile) (AIBN) (2% of binder)

Solvent

- 270-300g Acetone (9-10:1 ratio with binder solids)

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with tight-fitting lids
- Mechanical mixer or high-shear mixer
- Drying trays
- Controlled temperature oven
- Grinding equipment (ball mill or attritor mill)
- Sieves (appropriate mesh size for your application)
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)

Procedure

A. Binder Preparation

1. In a well-ventilated area, weigh 270g of acetone into a glass container.
2. While stirring, slowly add 25.2g of PMMA-co-EA to the acetone. Stir until completely dissolved (approximately 30-60 minutes).
3. Add 1.2g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate to the solution and stir for 15 minutes.
4. Add 3.0g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.
5. Finally, add 0.6g of AIBN and stir gently until completely dissolved (approximately 10 minutes).
6. Cover the container with a tight-fitting lid to prevent acetone evaporation. The binder solution is now ready.

B. Slurry Preparation

1. Place 970g of metal powder in a mixing vessel.
2. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the prepared binder solution to the metal powder.
3. Continue mixing for 30-45 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder.
4. If the slurry appears too thick, add small amounts of additional acetone (up to 30g) to achieve proper consistency.

C. Drying

1. Spread the slurry evenly in drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
2. Initial drying: Allow to dry at room temperature in a well-ventilated area for 12-24 hours.
3. Secondary drying: Place in an oven at 50°C for 4-6 hours.
4. Final drying: Increase temperature to 60°C for 2 hours to ensure complete solvent removal.
5. Allow to cool to room temperature. The material should form a solid cake.

D. Grinding and Sieving

1. Break the dried cake into smaller pieces.
2. Grind using a ball mill or attritor mill under controlled temperature conditions (below 40°C to prevent premature crosslinking).
3. Sieve the ground powder to obtain the desired particle size distribution (typically 45-150µm for application).
4. If necessary, add 0.05-0.1g of Aerosil (0.005-0.01% of total weight) to improve flowability.

E. The AquaMold™ Process

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology (PVA, specialized PLA, or other water-soluble polymer).
2. Pack the prepared flowable powder into the 3D printed water-soluble molds, ensuring uniform density.
3. Heat the packed molds to 80°C and maintain this temperature for 1.5 hours to activate the AIBN and crosslink the binder.
4. Cool gradually to room temperature (approximately 1-2 hours).

F. Dissolution and Green Part Recovery

1. Submerge the entire assembly in warm water (40-50°C) to dissolve the water-soluble mold.
2. Monitor dissolution and refresh water as needed until mold is completely removed.
3. Carefully extract the green part from the water bath and allow to dry completely.
4. The green part is now ready for debinding and sintering according to your standard protocol for the specific metal alloy.

Notes

- The increased TEG-DMA content (10% of binder vs previous 6%) will create a more highly crosslinked polymer network, which may:
 - Increase green part strength
 - Reduce flexibility compared to the plasticized version

- Potentially increase resistance to deformation during handling
- Result in slightly different debinding characteristics
- Maintaining the full 4% of silane coupling agent ensures good adhesion between the metal particles and polymer binder
- The removal of the plasticizer and increased crosslinking agent will likely create a more rigid green part
- You may need to adjust packing parameters to ensure uniform density with this more rigid binder system
- The higher crosslink density may affect the debinding profile - consider a more gradual temperature ramp during initial debinding stages
- Store the AIBN in a cool, dark place to prevent premature decomposition
- All mixing containers should be clean and free of contaminants
- Perform all solvent handling steps in a well-ventilated area away from ignition sources

I am also continuing to experiment with the batch that I made 2kg of (I think it might be a combination of several previous batches that I had made? I'm not 100% certain of the additive composition, but it is definitely PMMA-EA based). Last night I mixed some hydrophobic aerosil with the powder in the v mixer and had Nick resieve the powder this morning, then filled a water-soluble mold and a ceramic crucible with it. I am currently running the PMMA cycle in the upper Keith furnace, but I reduced the peak temperature from 300F to 275F to minimize mold distortion. The powder flowed really well when I was filling the two receptacles, so I think adding Aerosil and in particular mixing the powder well makes a big difference.

I am also drying the 2kg cake I made with PVP-VA in the oven in the materials lab. I want to try it in PILOT 3 using the laser to cure the desired part outline. PVP-VA coated powder did very well in producing strong heat cured green parts, but it was not compatible with my Aquamold process because it is water soluble. However, it should work well with the laser curing process because the parts do not need to be waterproof. The laser curing process should eliminate the need for spraying or cutting and will not produce debris that would need to be vacuumed up like laser cutting the outlines of a part. It would also eliminate the need to cure the entire layer (although this could be done using the standard heater if necessary).

HOPPER: I have printed the parts for the update version of Payman's hopper design. There are some McMaster parts I need to order tonight to be able to assemble it, and I am still waiting on more stepper motors from StepperOnline, but I can install the heat set inserts today. The heat set inserts have been installed, so I should be able to reassemble

NEXTGEN: I have designed and printed the gantry mount for holding the spindle and Micro Drop wax dispenser, although Sean and Pourya are encountering issues with getting the Micro Drop system to dispense drops of paraffin, so it is unclear when the mount will become necessary.

2025-04-23

HOPPER: Assembling Payman's hopper. I have the bushings installed (I am switching from bearings to bushings on the hopper to reduce cost and volume of the rotating component support element. I am also switching to larger timing belt pulleys to increase the number of teeth engaged at any given time and hopefully reduce belt slippage. Since we don't have enough geared NEMA 8 stepper motors around I am going to scavenge one from Payman's current hopper, but I am holding off until Payman demos the hopper for Scott.

I am continuing to develop the stepper tapper system. I have it working with one of the 19:1 geared NEMA 8 stepper motors, but it is limited in the speed it can move the impact arm and I am concerned about tearing up the gear box since the stepper tapping cycle involves stalling the motor to home the arm and every time it impacts the shaft; the way the cycle works it drives the motor slightly past where it contacts the shaft. I found a NEMA 11 motor around that seems to be functional so I have designed a mount for it and a new stepper tapper arm to use with it. Hopefully this new system will enable a higher frequency of impacts and greater impact force with less likelihood of damage to the stepper system because there is no gearbox. Assembled the new motor and stepper tapper arm on HOPPER V4.0. The NEMA 11 motor seems to work as expected. It does protrude farther from the hopper than the NEMA 8 motor does.

REDRESS: I have tasked Mohsen with trying out a batch of PVP-VA coated powder in the laser-enabled PILOT printer (PILOT 3). He is trying various laser parameters to try and selectively cure the powder where we would want a part to be if we were printing a part.

The batch of PMMA powder I mixed up yesterday dried on the hot plate overnight, and after running it in the v-mixer for a while I am drying it in the oven in the materials lab. The reason it had be dried initially on the hot plate is because it uses acetone as a solvent, which would be unsafe to vaporize in the materials lab oven. Once it has dried sufficiently (likely this afternoon) I will grind and sieve it. Since it has twice the TEG-DMA that the previous batch did, I am hopeful that it will produce stronger green parts (I dissolved off the mold I filled yesterday and the green part mostly fell apart). I put 30g of this powder into a ceramic crucible and tapped it, then crash heated it to 275F (it usually overshoots with crash heating so it may have gone over, on the other hand I only gave it 30 minutes to get to 275 so it may have undershot the temperature). The green part produced was still not as strong as I'd like, but it is considerably stronger than the

previous batch while still being fairly flowable. I have a suspicion that at least some of the “sticky” powder I have seen in the past was simply not sufficiently dried and/or did not have sufficient flow aid added.

2025-04-24

AEM PXL: Meeting with AEM. There wasn't anything they wanted us to do on the project, so at the moment we're trying to move forward with some low-cost IR&D projects, including initial in-house brazing with BAg-7 braze alloy (which is in theory compatible with bare copper and bare stainless steel), electron beam welding of bare copper coupons to stainless steel (we may need to do a shrink-fit of the copper parts to get the zero gap that electron beam welders prefer), and also experiments to confirm that the vacuum impregnation resin is compatible with the HFE coolant that AEM wants to use.

HOPPER: Continued testing of stepper tapper with NEMA 11 motor.

2025-04-25

HOPPER: HOPPER V3.5 running on PILOT 2. Dispensed a layer of powder. The stepper tapper is not running yet pending Pourya wiring a new expansion board, but even without it the powder was flowable enough to dispense reasonably well.

2025-04-28

R&D Meeting

- HOPPER: HOPPER V3.6 running in PILOT 2. Stepper tapper is installed but not tested with integrated control system.
- NEXTGEN: Ordered laser safety windows for Ultimaker hopper. Micro Drop wax dispenser received and Pourya is in process of testing it on the old reaming gantry. Mohsen is continuing experiments with the xTool F1 Ultra laser in PILOT 3.
- PILOT Ultra: System running on old reaming gantry (blue and silver, rollers on frame. Sean is working on building the same system

TO DO:

- Assemble HOPPER V4.0 and install in PILOT 2 replacing V3.6.
 - Installed in PILOT 2, but the dispense rate is too high with the machined timing belt pulley roller so I am printing a new roller that should dispense at a lower rate.

- Roller dispense rate is high and uneven due to discretization of dispensing regions (
- New mount for laser on PILOT 3.
- Once sheet metal has been received, paint and install.
- Make new HOPPER V3.1.1 with smaller valve - DONE
- 2 new mist boxes with a smaller length of mist deposition to match the spreader bar on the HOPPER - DONE
- New stepper motor mount that provides adjustable belt tension

ULTRA: Designing 2X new mist boxes for the blue gantry ULTRA system: one has the mist chamber length reduced from 130 to 125mm to match the spreader bar on HOPPER V3.1.1 (the line of dispense on HOPPER V3.1.1 is 130mm but the spreader bar is 125mm long, I don't recall a good reason for that being the case so I plan to modify that in the future). The other mist box has the same dimensions but the width of the mist chamber is increased from 35mm to 75mm.

Need a picture of various HOPPER iterations for the board meeting.

REDRESS: Making a new batch of powder by pre-treating 1 kg of 17-4 powder with 2g of silane coupling agent, drying it, then mixing it with 15g PVP-VA dissolved in 200 ml of water. I am also seeing some promising initial results from the latest advanced binder batch; this one used 26.4 g PMMA-EA, 4g TEG-DMA, and 1g AIBN. It seems to form the strongest green parts of the PMMA batches so far, although the powder is stickier and less flowable with the higher TEG-DMA content.

2025-04-29

ULTRA: Completed post-processing of 2X mist boxes (V2 and V2.1) and installed heat set inserts, then gave them to Payman.

- Make duplicate HOPPER V3.1.1 for the Ultimaker ULTRA printer
 - Body
 - Valve
 - End Caps
 - Motor mount
 - Order timing pulleys and belt

HOPPER: Installed new PETG-CF printed roller in HOPPER V4.0 and reinstalled the roller drive motor and stepper tapper. Since I do not believe the tapper system to be necessary or even beneficial, I am adding a vibrator motor per the suggestions of Dan, my experience of controlling powder flow for the robotic cleaning station, and the design of every commercially

available hopper on the market (to the best of my knowledge; I will admit that I don't know the detailed design of every hopper that is commercially available). Reinstalled HOPPER V4.0 and loaded it with powder after mounting the vibrator motor. The vibration is strong enough and the powder flowable enough that it will flow around the doser roller even when the roller is stationary; this effect could be useful or detrimental. Either way, it is likely caused by too large of a gap between the roller and the body.

REDRESS: I demolded the part cured last night using the latest formula, and it only lost a bit of material on the top and bottom. I have also cured another part with the same powder after it had been dried overnight in the oven in the materials lab and had .1g more Aerosil R 812 S added to it. Either or both of those made it much more flowable when filling the mold, and the part being demolded looks promising so far. I also used a slightly different procedure to demold the second part; I clamped it so that it was immersed in water up to ~2mm below the top of the part until the mold had mostly dissolved into strings, instead of immediately dunking it in water. I believe this may reduce stress on the top surface of the part by allowing the porous part to fill up with water more slowly as the mold dissolves.

2025-04-30

HOPPER: Tested HOPPER V4.0 with new doser roller. This is an octagonal faceted design; it dispensed less than the aluminum doser roller but dispensed in pulses when the facets were aligned with the output region. I am printing a new doser roller that has a large number of very shallow grooves (5mm dia, .3mm depth cut into roller).

2025-05-01

HOPPER: Removed faceted roller and installed grooved roller, then reinstalled HOPPER V4.0 in PILOT 2. I also showed the system to Mohsen and described the macros that show how to trigger the roller (A axis), stepper tapper (B axis), and vibrator (M42 to trigger GPIO pin 14, I think). I also renamed some of the macros to be less confusing, because I am using the output that Pourya had previously wired up for the solenoid tapper.

PILOT 3: Painting 4X sheet metal panels and plastic panel to cover the end of the machine that is not shielded by the control cabinet. All 5 panels are painted, although the finish is not completely uniform; you can see lines between paint passes and the paint on one of the panels was damaged when it fell onto asphalt because it was resting up against a box at an angle to dry both sides and it was a windy day. Once the panels have dried, I will smooth out that side with some steel wool and add another coat of paint.

REDRESS: A part came out of sintering this morning, and looks pretty good. There are regions on the top and bottom that are missing, but that occurred when dissolving off the water soluble mold, not during debinding or sintering. The part did not collapse or crack, however, there was some distortion of the base, which may have been due to the fact that it was not resting level on the ZTE setter.

AEM PXL Meeting w/Craig: They haven't officially severed the relationship with 3DEO, but they are pursuing making another monolithic machined unit (1 SS part, 1 Cu part) and a P52 with 52 machined units. These may perform worse than PXLs made with 3DEO printed copper parts, but they may be willing to take the performance hit if brazing works more reliably. Also, the thermal conductivity of billet machined pure copper parts will be slightly higher than 3DEO's parts, which will help to offset the loss of performance due to sub-optimal geometry.

2025-05-02

PILOT: 5 panels are printed and ready to be installed on PILOT 3. In process of printing the laser shielding window frames.

HOPPER: HOPPER V4.0 is running on PILOT 2. The dispense is uneven along the dispense line, so I am going to print a new hopper body and roller that should dispense more evenly. The body that is currently installed was printed in two stages because it ran out filament halfway through the print, and the second half of the print seems slightly shifted from the first.

2025-05-05

PILOT: New HOPPER body (v4.0) printed to install on PILOT 2 along with a new roller that is small enough to spin freely. Designing mount for extra Z stage for the Micro Drop head on PILOT 1. Mount is currently printing on the Bambu printer from PAHT-CF (CF nylon). There is a modified version of the cable carrier tower that the 2nd Z stage mounts to, and a 3D printed part that mounts to that stage and to which the Micro Drop head is mounted.

ULTRA: Painted clear panels on Ultimaker S5 cover black to block laser light during operation of the Ultimaker-derived ULTRA printer.

REDRESS: Dissolved the mold off of a green part over the weekend; the mold is the older style with the thinner fins but it seemed to come out pretty well regardless. The top partially dissolved off; I think this may have to do with oxygen exposure during thermal curing so I am going to try placing a ceramic sheet on top of the mold the next time I cure one to protect it from the atmosphere. I am also working on grinding MIM feedstock pellets into a finer powder than my

extruder can handle using a coffee burr grinder. The pellet extruder mount I am using melted from the heat of the hotend, so I am going to design and print a new one from a higher temperature resistance SLA material. I am currently printing it from PAHT-CF as part of the same print as the two Micro Drop mounts; this should have a higher temperature resistance than the CF PLA I used previously. I also intend to attach the cooling fan to the heat break, which I failed to do previously (intentionally; I wanted to heat up the entire heat break to help soften the MIM feedstock, but this meant the heat break got hotter than it would otherwise, and when the heat was conducted through the shaft collar it softened the PLA mount to the point that the force of the feedscrew pushed the two bolts holding the shaft collar through the PLA part). I have redesigned the mount to be stronger around the two mounting screws, and printing it from a higher temperature material should help. I also have two new coated powder formulations I want to try. One is similar to the previous one, but the powder is pre-treated with silane and the binder load is reduced to 1% and the AIBN is replaced with a UV-activated photoinitiator:

Silane-Enhanced UV-Curable AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Water-Soluble Mold Metal Forming

Materials

For Metal Powder Pre-Treatment

- 990g of metal powder (choose one: 17-4 PH stainless steel, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)
- 1g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate (γ-MPS)
- 100mL of Isopropyl Alcohol (IPA)

For 1000g Final Metal Powder Mixture (99% Metal, 1% Binder)

Pre-treated Metal Powder

- 990g of silane-treated metal powder

Binder Components (10g total - 1% of final mixture)

- 8.2g Poly(methyl methacrylate) (PMMA) (82% of binder)
- 1.5g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (TEG-DMA) (15% of binder)
- 0.3g Phenylbis(2,4,6-trimethylbenzoyl)phosphine oxide (TPO) (3% of binder)
- 0.2g Aerosil R 812 S (to be added after grinding and sieving)

Solvent

- 90-100g Acetone (9-10:1 ratio with binder solids)

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with amber/dark tinting or aluminum foil covering
- Mechanical mixer or high-shear mixer
- Drying trays
- Controlled temperature oven
- Grinding equipment (ball mill or attritor mill)
- Sieves (appropriate mesh size for your application)
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- UV light source (365-405nm wavelength)
- UV safety equipment (UV-blocking eyewear, gloves, covered skin)
- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)

Procedure

A. Metal Powder Silane Pre-Treatment

1. In a well-ventilated area, add 1g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate to 100mL of isopropyl alcohol in a suitable container.
2. Stir the solution gently for 5 minutes, then let it stand for 30 minutes to allow hydrolysis of the silane coupling agent.
3. Place 990g of metal powder in a large mixing vessel.
4. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the hydrolyzed silane solution to the metal powder.
5. Continue mixing for 15-20 minutes to ensure even distribution of the silane solution over all metal particles.
6. Spread the treated powder on drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
7. Dry at 60°C for 2-3 hours to remove the isopropyl alcohol.
8. Allow the treated powder to cool to room temperature. The silane-treated metal powder is now ready for the binder application.

B. Binder Preparation

IMPORTANT: Perform this step in subdued lighting or yellow lighting to prevent premature activation of the photoinitiator

1. In a well-ventilated area, weigh 90g of acetone into an amber glass container or a container wrapped in aluminum foil.

2. While stirring, slowly add 8.2g of PMMA to the acetone. Stir until completely dissolved (approximately 30-60 minutes).
3. Add 1.5g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.
4. Finally, add 0.3g of Phenylbis(2,4,6-trimethylbenzoyl)phosphine oxide (TPO) and stir gently until completely dissolved (approximately 10 minutes).
5. Cover the container with a tight-fitting lid to prevent acetone evaporation and protect from light exposure. The binder solution is now ready.

C. Slurry Preparation

Continue working in subdued lighting

1. Place the 990g of pre-treated metal powder in a mixing vessel.
2. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the prepared binder solution to the pre-treated metal powder.
3. Continue mixing for 30-45 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder throughout the metal powder.
4. If the slurry appears too thick, add small amounts of additional acetone (up to 10g) to achieve proper consistency.

D. Drying

Protect from direct UV light exposure

1. Spread the slurry evenly in drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
2. Initial drying: Allow to dry at room temperature in a well-ventilated area with subdued lighting for 12-24 hours.
3. Secondary drying: Place in an oven at 50°C for 4-6 hours (ensure oven does not emit UV light).
4. Final drying: Increase temperature to 60°C for 2 hours to ensure complete solvent removal.
5. Allow to cool to room temperature. The material should form a solid cake.

E. Grinding and Sieving

Continue working in subdued lighting

1. Break the dried cake into smaller pieces.
2. Grind using a ball mill or attritor mill (ensure equipment doesn't generate significant heat or light).
3. Sieve the ground powder to obtain the desired particle size distribution (typically 45-150µm for metal powder applications).

4. Add 0.2g of Aerosil R 812 S to the ground and sieved metal-binder powder mixture. Mix thoroughly to ensure even distribution and improved flowability.
5. Store the powder in light-proof containers until ready for use.

F. UV Crosslinking Process

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology (PVA, specialized PLA, or other water-soluble polymer).
2. Pack the prepared flowable powder into the 3D printed water-soluble molds, ensuring uniform density.
3. Expose the packed mold to UV light (365-405nm wavelength) for crosslinking:
 - For thin sections (< 5mm): Expose for 2-5 minutes at appropriate intensity
 - For thicker sections: Increase exposure time accordingly or expose from multiple angles to ensure complete curing
 - Consider using a UV light with penetration appropriate for your part thickness
4. Allow the part to cool if any heat was generated during the UV exposure.

G. Dissolution and Green Part Recovery

1. Submerge the entire assembly in warm water (40-50°C) to dissolve the water-soluble mold.
2. Monitor dissolution and refresh water as needed until mold is completely removed.
3. Carefully extract the green part from the water bath and allow to dry completely.
4. The green part is now ready for debinding and sintering according to the standard protocol for your specific metal alloy (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr).

Notes

• Benefits of Silane Pre-Treatment:

- Creates covalent bonds between metal surface and polymer binder
- Significantly improves metal-polymer adhesion
- Enhances green part strength and handling durability
- Improves dispersion of metal particles in the binder
- Potentially allows for even lower binder content while maintaining adequate strength
- Reduces the risk of delamination or cracking during handling

• Silane Coupling Mechanism:

- The methoxy groups on the silane hydrolyze in the IPA solution forming silanol groups
- Silanol groups react with hydroxyl groups on the metal surface

- The methacrylate functional group on the silane remains available to copolymerize with TEG-DMA during UV curing
- This creates a chemical bridge between the metal surface and polymer network

- **UV Curing Advantages:**

- Room temperature processing (no thermal activation required)
- Rapid curing (seconds to minutes vs. hours)
- On-demand curing only when exposed to UV light
- Potential for selective curing of specific areas

- **TPO Photoinitiator Characteristics:**

- Absorbs light in the 365-405nm UV range
- Generates free radicals when exposed to UV light
- More effective for thicker sections than many other photoinitiators
- Yellow color may affect aesthetic appearance of green parts

- **Important Precautions:**

- Protect the binder solution and mixed powder from UV light/sunlight until ready for curing
- Use amber containers or aluminum foil wrapping for storage
- Work in subdued lighting conditions when handling the material
- Wear appropriate UV protection when operating UV light sources
- This formulation uses a reduced binder content (1% vs typical 3%) which will:
 - Result in higher green density
 - Lead to lower shrinkage during sintering
 - Potentially limit complexity of possible geometries
 - These limitations are partially offset by the silane coupling enhancement
- The increased TEG-DMA content (15% of binder vs traditional 10%) will:
 - Create a more highly crosslinked polymer network
 - Provide reactive sites for the UV-initiated polymerization
 - React with the methacrylate groups on the silane-treated metal surface
- Depth of cure will be limited by:
 - Metal powder shadowing effect (metal particles block UV penetration)
 - TPO concentration and efficiency
 - UV light source intensity and wavelength
 - Part thickness and geometry
- For thicker sections, consider:

- Staged packing and curing of layers
- Using multiple UV light sources from different angles
- Longer exposure times
- Higher TPO content (up to 5% of binder) for deeper penetration
- Store all components in cool, dark places to prevent premature activation
- All mixing containers should be clean and free of contaminants
- Perform all solvent handling steps in a well-ventilated area away from ignition sources

I am also working on a recipe that is similarly photoinitiated, but has both water soluble and non-water-soluble binder components so that it can be poured into the mold as a slurry, UV cured, and the mold can be dissolved off while at the same time debinding the water-soluble components to yield a porous green part that is only loaded with the non-water-soluble components. The binder load is also increased to 3% for this formulation:

UV-Curable Pourable Metal Slurry with Water-Soluble Component

Materials

For Metal Powder Pre-Treatment

- 970g of metal powder (choose one: 17-4 PH stainless steel, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)
- 1g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate (γ -MPS)
- 100mL of Isopropyl Alcohol (IPA)

For 1000g Final Metal Slurry (97% Metal, 3% Total Binder)

Pre-treated Metal Powder

- 970g of silane-treated metal powder

Binder Components (30g total - 3% of final mixture)

- 9g Polyethylene glycol diacrylate (PEGDA, Mn ~575) (30% of binder) - *water-soluble component*
- 6g Poly(vinyl alcohol) (PVA, hydrolysis 87-90%, Mw ~30,000) (20% of binder) - *water-soluble component*
- 6g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (TEG-DMA) (20% of binder) - *non-water-soluble component*
- 7.5g Polymethyl methacrylate (PMMA) (25% of binder) - *non-water-soluble component*
- 1.5g Phenylbis(2,4,6-trimethylbenzoyl)phosphine oxide (TPO) (5% of binder) - *photoinitiator*

Solvents/Diluents

- 30g Deionized water
- 30g Ethanol (or Isopropanol)
- 0.6g Dispersant (e.g., Darvan C or Dolapix CE64) (2% of binder weight)

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with amber/dark tinting or aluminum foil covering
- High-shear mixer or ultrasonic homogenizer
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- UV light source (365-405nm wavelength)
- UV safety equipment (UV-blocking eyewear, gloves, covered skin)
- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)
- Viscometer (optional but recommended)

Procedure

A. Metal Powder Silane Pre-Treatment

1. In a well-ventilated area, add 1g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate to 100mL of isopropyl alcohol in a suitable container.
2. Stir the solution gently for 5 minutes, then let it stand for 30 minutes to allow hydrolysis of the silane coupling agent.
3. Place 970g of metal powder in a large mixing vessel.
4. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the hydrolyzed silane solution to the metal powder.
5. Continue mixing for 15-20 minutes to ensure even distribution of the silane solution over all metal particles.
6. Spread the treated powder on drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
7. Dry at 60°C for 2-3 hours to remove the isopropyl alcohol.
8. Allow the treated powder to cool to room temperature. The silane-treated metal powder is now ready for slurry preparation.

B. Water-Soluble Component Preparation

Work in subdued lighting

1. In a suitable container, add 30g of deionized water.
2. Heat the water to 80°C and slowly add 6g of PVA while stirring.
3. Continue stirring until the PVA is completely dissolved (approximately 30-45 minutes).

4. Allow the PVA solution to cool to room temperature.

C. UV-Curable Component Preparation

Work in subdued lighting

1. In a separate amber glass container, mix 30g of ethanol with 0.6g of dispersant.
2. Add 7.5g of PMMA and stir until completely dissolved.
3. Add 6g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.
4. Add 9g of PEGDA and mix thoroughly.
5. Finally, add 1.5g of TPO photoinitiator and stir gently until completely dissolved.

D. Slurry Preparation

Continue working in subdued lighting

1. Combine the water-soluble PVA solution with the UV-curable component solution and mix thoroughly.
2. Place the 970g of pre-treated metal powder in a high-shear mixing vessel.
3. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the combined binder solution to the pre-treated metal powder.
4. Increase to high-shear mixing for 15-20 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder throughout the metal powder.
5. Check the viscosity of the slurry - it should be pourable but not too fluid. If needed:
 - If too thick: Add small amounts of additional water/ethanol mixture (1:1 ratio) in 5g increments
 - If too thin: Add small amounts of PVA solution to increase viscosity
6. The slurry is now ready for pouring into molds.

E. Casting and UV Curing

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology (PVA, specialized PLA, or other water-soluble polymer).
2. Pour the prepared slurry into the molds. Consider using vibration or vacuum to remove any trapped air bubbles.
3. Allow the slurry to settle for 5-10 minutes.
4. Expose the filled mold to UV light (365-405nm wavelength) for crosslinking:
 - For thin sections (< 5mm): Expose for 3-6 minutes
 - For thicker sections: Use a staged approach with multiple shorter exposures from different angles

- Allow 30-60 seconds between exposures to prevent excessive heat buildup
5. Allow the part to cool completely after UV curing.

F. Primary Debinding (Water-Soluble Component Removal)

1. Submerge the entire assembly in warm water (50-60°C) to dissolve the water-soluble mold.
2. After the mold is completely dissolved, continue soaking the part to begin dissolving the water-soluble components of the binder (PVA and PEGDA).
3. Change the water every 2-3 hours to facilitate faster dissolution.
4. Total immersion time will depend on part thickness but typically requires 12-24 hours.
5. Once the primary water-soluble components are dissolved, carefully remove the part and dry it at room temperature for 12 hours, followed by gentle heating at 40°C for 2 hours.
6. The part is now partially debound but still held together by the non-water-soluble components (PMMA and TEG-DMA).

G. Secondary Debinding and Sintering

1. Follow standard thermal debinding protocols to remove the remaining organic components:
 - Slow heating rate (1-2°C/min) to 300°C with appropriate hold times
 - Continue to final debinding temperature based on the specific binder components
2. Proceed with standard sintering protocol for the specific metal alloy (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr).

Notes

• Dual-Component Binder System Benefits:

- Water-soluble components (PVA and PEGDA) allow for primary debinding via water immersion
- PMMA and TEG-DMA provide structural integrity during the water debinding step
- The combination allows for lower total organic content during thermal debinding
- Reduced risk of defects from rapid gas evolution during thermal debinding

• Slurry Properties:

- The ethanol and water create a homogeneous system that will evaporate slowly, giving good working time
- PVA acts as both a binder and a rheology modifier
- PEGDA provides both water solubility and UV-curability through its acrylate groups
- The dispersant is crucial for preventing metal particle agglomeration in the slurry

• Key Process Controls:

- Viscosity is critical - too thin and particles may settle before curing; too thick and pouring becomes difficult
- UV exposure time must be sufficient to cure throughout the volume, not just the surface
- Water temperature during primary debinding affects dissolution rate and potential distortion
- **Metal Loading Optimization:**
 - This formulation uses 97% metal loading, which is high for a pourable slurry
 - The silane treatment is essential for maintaining flowability at this high metal content
 - If pouring issues occur, metal content can be reduced to 95-96% by adjusting the formulation
- **Potential Challenges and Solutions:**
 - **Sedimentation:** If metal particles settle too quickly before UV curing, consider adding 0.1-0.2% xanthan gum to the water component
 - **Incomplete Curing:** For thicker sections, consider adding a secondary thermal curing step at 80°C for 30 minutes after UV exposure
 - **Poor Surface Finish:** If surface definition is insufficient, increase the PVA content slightly
 - **Cracking During Drying:** Slow the drying rate after water debinding by using a humidity-controlled environment
- **Storage Considerations:**
 - The prepared slurry has limited working time (4-8 hours) and should be used promptly
 - Store any unused slurry in light-proof, sealed containers in a refrigerator (4-8°C) to extend working time
 - Allow refrigerated slurry to return to room temperature before use and check viscosity
- Perform all steps involving solvents in a well-ventilated area away from ignition sources
- The water-soluble components also make this process more environmentally friendly

Bambu Printer: I removed the updated roller from the printer this morning, and I am going to try printing a Benchy test part using PAHT-CF, a material that I am completely unfamiliar with. Okay, apparently PAHT refers to a polyamide, which in this case is likely some formulation of nylon. I printed the Benchy and it came out pretty well; the surface is a bit rough but other than that it looks good with no stringing or sagging.

2025-05-06

PILOT: Printed opaque guards for PILOT 3 windows. Iterating on Micro Drop mount to mount the Micro Drop head to a linear stage of the same type used for the spindle Z axis on the PILOT printers and the BETA printers.

PILOT ULTRA: Repainted and installed the 5X acrylic windows on the printer cover and painted the clear doors. Installed 1X laser guard window on the left hand door.

Ultimaker issue: One of the Ultimakers kept being unable to extrude filament about 10 minutes into a print; I believe this is due to the hot end heat break cooling fan not functioning correctly and allowing the filament in the heat break to soften and expand, jamming it in place. I blew out the fan and it seems to be working now, but it should be replaced before too long.

PERPLEX: I am working on setting up the Prusa to print with MIM feedstock by installing an updated version of the pellet extruder.

REDRESS: I mixed up a batch of powder with a binder with a photoinitiator added. In theory, once the powder is fully prepped and loaded into a mold, it should be possible to cure it with UV light instead of heat. I also ground and sieved the batch of powder I made with a 1% binder load, and it is currently curing in the upper Keith furnace. It did not seem quite as flowable as I'd like; I would like to run it in one of the tumbling mixers for a while to see if that helps to break up agglomerations and coat the powder more evenly with Aerosil. When I pulled the ceramic crucible out of the oven while it was still at 275F, the powder did not seem well bound. This may be an artifact of the reduced binder load, but I also believe that this batch was made with silane pre-treated powder, which may have inhibited the bond between particles. Fortunately I have another batch made with 3% binder load that is also silane coated; if it has similar issues with binding then that would suggest that the silane coupling agent is detrimental to my process.

2025-05-07

HOPPER: Designed and printing a new mount for the stepper tapper. The previous mount broke because of the print orientation and design of the mount; it was essentially an L bracket with the stepper mounted mounted to one side of the L, and it was printed so that the bending stress is applied to a joint held together by Z axis layer adhesion.

REDRESS: Attempted to print using MIM feedstock (17-4 PH Aquamim from Ryer Inc) in the pellet extruder that was previously used for paraffin printing. I was unable to get it to print well; there seems to be a narrow band of volumetric flow rate where the feedstock will extrude and adhere well (to the build plate as well as to other layers) and I was unable to force the Prusa to extrude at a constant volumetric flow rate. The extruder stepper seemed to slow and stop at the same point when printing certain perimeters; this may be due to the slicing or because the Prusa

control system is not rated to provide enough current to drive the extruder stepper while it is completing that section, possibly because other axes are drawing current instead. It also seemed that the hot end was struggling to maintain sufficient temperature to get a good extrusion; the first few layers would come out well but the extrusion got more and more spotty as it build up layers.

I loaded a ceramic crucible with UV photoinitiator sensitized powder, and first cured it in the Elegoo curing chamber for 30 minutes, then in the Formlabs curing chamber for 60 minutes with no heat, and I am now curing it in the Formlabs curing chamber for 60 minutes at 60C. The two UV-only curing cycles had minimal effect, however, the batch was not very well mixed (a skin of dried binder was left on the surface) and ground (most of the cake was not rendered into powder and was also used with silane pre-treated powder, any of which may have contributed to poor particle adhesion.

To test the theory of silane pre-treatment causing poor adhesion, I have filled a water-soluble mold with the latest batch of powder with a 3% binder load. I also had that batch of powder mixed for 15 minutes after grinding and sieving with a small amount of Aerosil R 812 S added, but the final powder was still not as flowable as I'd like. I dried out the powder in the oven in the materials lab before grinding and sieving it, but I then left it out for 24 hours, which may have allowed it to pick up atmospheric moisture.

I dissolved off the mold that I cured last night filled with 1% binder load powder and it fell apart during the process.

HOPPER: I tried out the new stepper tapper mount, and the clamping feature I modeled in did not fit the NEMA 17 motor well. I

ROTSPRAY: I ordered 6X new pulleys (McM #6495K745) and 4X new belts (McM #6484K241) for the rotary sprayer assemblies.

2025-05-08

PILOT: Assembled the new mount for the stepper tapper. This mount has an added clamping feature that was printed in an orientation to make it as strong as possible, so it should be more resistant to breaking as compared with the older mount. The stepper tapper is ready to be installed, but because the hopper is currently installed in the printer and the stepper tapper is hopefully not necessary, it will not be mounted until the hopper is next removed from the printer.

Working on a new mount for the Micro Drop for PILOT 1. This mount needs to have a limit switch rigidly installed, as well as being compatible with the limit switch currently used elsewhere in the

PILOT printers, which is backordered for a month so the mount also needs to be compatible with the standard inexpensive limit switches that are used on the rotary spray heads.

REDRESS: Attempting to print with 17-4 AquaMIM feedstock still. I believe that if I can get the print file to maintain a constant flow rate and match that flow rate to the print speed in X and Y as well as the maximum continuous flow rate capability of the extrusion system, it may be able to make good parts.

I have mixed up a new batch of powder following this recipe:

Thermal-Curable AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Water-Soluble Mold Metal Forming

Materials

For 1000g Final Metal Powder Mixture (98% Metal, 2% Binder)

Metal Powder

- 980g of metal powder (choose one: 17-4 PH stainless steel, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)

Binder Components (20g total - 2% of final mixture)

- 15.4g Poly(methyl methacrylate) (PMMA) (77% of binder)
- 3.0g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (TEG-DMA) (15% of binder)
- 0.6g Azobisisobutyronitrile (AIBN) (3% of binder)
- 0.6g Dibutyl phthalate (DBP) (3% of binder)
- 0.4g Aerosil R 812 S (fumed silica) (to be added after grinding and sieving)

Solvent

- 180-200g Acetone (9-10:1 ratio with binder solids)

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with amber/dark tinting or aluminum foil covering
- Mechanical mixer or high-shear mixer
- Drying trays
- Controlled temperature oven
- Grinding equipment (ball mill or attritor mill)
- Sieves (appropriate mesh size for your application)
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- Thermal curing oven (capable of 80-90°C)

- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)

Procedure

A. Binder Preparation

1. In a well-ventilated area, weigh 180g of acetone into a suitable container.
2. While stirring, slowly add 15.4g of PMMA to the acetone. Stir until completely dissolved (approximately 30-60 minutes).
3. Add 3.0g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.
4. Add 0.6g of dibutyl phthalate (DBP) and stir thoroughly for 5 minutes.
5. Add 0.6g of AIBN and stir gently until completely dissolved (approximately 10 minutes).
6. Cover the container with a tight-fitting lid to prevent acetone evaporation. The binder solution is now ready.

B. Slurry Preparation

Maintain temperature below 30°C

1. Place the 980g of metal powder in a mixing vessel.
2. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the prepared binder solution to the metal powder.
3. Continue mixing for 30-45 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder throughout the metal powder.
4. If the slurry appears too thick, add small amounts of additional acetone (up to 20g) to achieve proper consistency.
5. Keep the temperature below 30°C during mixing to prevent premature activation of the AIBN thermal initiator.

C. Drying

Maintain moderate temperature

1. Spread the slurry evenly in drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
2. Initial drying: Allow to dry at room temperature (20-25°C) in a well-ventilated area for 12-24 hours.
3. Secondary drying: Place in an oven at 40°C for 4-6 hours (temperature must remain below AIBN activation temperature).
4. Final drying: Increase temperature to 50°C for 2 hours to ensure complete solvent removal without activating the AIBN.
5. Allow to cool to room temperature. The material should form a solid cake.

D. Grinding and Sieving

Maintain cool conditions

1. Break the dried cake into smaller pieces.
2. Grind using a ball mill or attritor mill.
3. Monitor temperature during grinding to stay below 60°C to prevent premature AIBN activation.
4. Sieve the ground powder to obtain the desired particle size distribution (typically 45-150µm for metal powder applications).
5. Add 0.4g of Aerosil R 812 S to the ground and sieved metal-binder powder mixture. Mix thoroughly to ensure even distribution and improved flowability.
6. Store the powder in containers at room temperature or below until ready for use.

E. Thermal Crosslinking Process

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology (PVA, specialized PLA, or other water-soluble polymer that can withstand 90°C).
2. Pack the prepared flowable powder into the 3D printed water-soluble molds, ensuring uniform density.
3. **Thermal Curing Step:**
 - Place the packed mold in a thermal oven
 - Heat to 85-90°C for 60-90 minutes to activate the AIBN
 - For thicker sections (>10mm), extend curing time to 90-120 minutes
 - This ensures complete crosslinking throughout the entire part volume
4. Allow the part to cool gradually to room temperature before proceeding.

F. Dissolution and Green Part Recovery

1. Submerge the entire assembly in warm water (40-50°C) to dissolve the water-soluble mold.
2. Monitor dissolution and refresh water as needed until mold is completely removed.
3. Carefully extract the green part from the water bath and allow to dry completely.
4. The green part is now ready for debinding and sintering according to the standard protocol for your specific metal alloy (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr).

Technical Notes

Thermal Initiation System

1. **AIBN (Thermal Initiator):**

- Activates throughout the entire part volume during thermal curing

- Ensures uniform crosslinking in all sections regardless of thickness
- Activation temperature: begins ~65°C, optimal at 80-90°C
- Half-life at 85°C: approximately 1 hour
- Generates nitrogen gas upon decomposition (ensure adequate ventilation)

2. **Dibutyl Phthalate (DBP) Benefits:**

- Functions as a plasticizer for the PMMA polymer
- Improves flexibility and toughness of the green part
- Reduces brittleness and improves handling characteristics
- Enhances polymer chain mobility during crosslinking
- Typically improves defect tolerance in green parts

Processing Considerations

• **Temperature Control:**

- Keep all processing steps below 60°C before intended thermal curing
- Store materials in cool environments (AIBN below 5°C for extended shelf life)
- Monitor grinding temperature to prevent premature AIBN activation

• **Thermal Curing Parameters:**

- Water-soluble mold material must withstand 90°C
- Thicker parts require extended thermal curing (up to 2 hours)
- Allow gradual cooling to minimize thermal stress
- Ensure adequate ventilation for nitrogen gas release during AIBN decomposition

• **Formulation Adjustments:**

- For very thick sections (>15mm): Consider increasing AIBN to 4% of binder
- For higher green strength: Consider increasing total binder content to 2.5%
- For more flexibility: DBP content can be increased to 5% (reducing PMMA accordingly)
- For better flowability: Aerosil content can be increased to 0.6g

• **Advantages of Thermal-Only Curing:**

- Uniform crosslinking throughout the entire part regardless of geometry
- No limitations from shadowing or penetration depth
- Simpler processing without need for specialized UV equipment
- More consistent results across varying part thicknesses
- Higher crosslinking density in thicker sections compared to UV curing

• **Safety Precautions:**

- AIBN is thermally sensitive - store in refrigerated containers

- Dibutyl phthalate should be handled with appropriate PPE (gloves, goggles)
- Ensure adequate ventilation during thermal curing
- Handle all chemicals with proper PPE in well-ventilated areas

I also deviated from my standard mixing procedure. After preparing the binder, I mixed it with the powder a little at a time using a handheld power mixer with a single whisk as usual, then I left the slurry in a cup for an hour, then I mixed it again before pouring it through a filter into an aluminum pie tin to dry.

2025-05-09

REDRESS: The cake made with a 2% binder load is fully dried after being on the hot plate at 40C for 12 hours. Based on hand-grinding some of the residue of this batch from the mixing cup, it seems to be more flowable and less damp/sticky than previous batches without the dibutyl phthalate.

I broke the cake into pieces, added 0.1g of Aerosil R 812 S, ground them, ground up any remaining large chunks in a mortar and pestle, then ran them through the sieve to get a good PSD. The powder wasn't super flowable even with the 0.1g of Aerosil. I am also concerned about the heating that occurs during the grinding process.

In case it is not recorded elsewhere, here is the initial version of the recipe for a UV-curable metal slurry with a water soluble binder component and a non-water-soluble binder component:

UV-Curable Pourable Metal Slurry with Water-Soluble Component

Materials

For Metal Powder Pre-Treatment

- 970g of metal powder (choose one: 17-4 PH stainless steel, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)
- 1g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate (γ -MPS)
- 100mL of Isopropyl Alcohol (IPA)

For 1000g Final Metal Slurry (97% Metal, 3% Total Binder)

Pre-treated Metal Powder

- 970g of silane-treated metal powder

Binder Components (30g total - 3% of final mixture)

- 9g Polyethylene glycol diacrylate (PEGDA, Mn ~575) (30% of binder) - *water-soluble component*
- 6g Poly(vinyl alcohol) (PVA, hydrolysis 87-90%, Mw ~30,000) (20% of binder) - *water-soluble component*
- 6g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (TEG-DMA) (20% of binder) - *non-water-soluble component*
- 7.5g Polymethyl methacrylate (PMMA) (25% of binder) - *non-water-soluble component*
- 1.5g Phenylbis(2,4,6-trimethylbenzoyl)phosphine oxide (TPO) (5% of binder) - *photoinitiator*

Solvents/Diluents

- 30g Deionized water
- 30g Ethanol (or Isopropanol)
- 0.6g Dispersant (e.g., Darvan C or Dolapix CE64) (2% of binder weight)

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with amber/dark tinting or aluminum foil covering
- High-shear mixer or ultrasonic homogenizer
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- UV light source (365-405nm wavelength)
- UV safety equipment (UV-blocking eyewear, gloves, covered skin)
- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)
- Viscometer (optional but recommended)

Procedure

A. Metal Powder Silane Pre-Treatment

1. In a well-ventilated area, add 1g of 3-(Trimethoxysilyl)propyl methacrylate to 100mL of isopropyl alcohol in a suitable container.
2. Stir the solution gently for 5 minutes, then let it stand for 30 minutes to allow hydrolysis of the silane coupling agent.
3. Place 970g of metal powder in a large mixing vessel.
4. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the hydrolyzed silane solution to the metal powder.
5. Continue mixing for 15-20 minutes to ensure even distribution of the silane solution over all metal particles.

6. Spread the treated powder on drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
7. Dry at 60°C for 2-3 hours to remove the isopropyl alcohol.
8. Allow the treated powder to cool to room temperature. The silane-treated metal powder is now ready for slurry preparation.

B. Water-Soluble Component Preparation

Work in subdued lighting

1. In a suitable container, add 30g of deionized water.
2. Heat the water to 80°C and slowly add 6g of PVA while stirring.
3. Continue stirring until the PVA is completely dissolved (approximately 30-45 minutes).
4. Allow the PVA solution to cool to room temperature.

C. UV-Curable Component Preparation

Work in subdued lighting

1. In a separate amber glass container, mix 30g of ethanol with 0.6g of dispersant.
2. Add 7.5g of PMMA and stir until completely dissolved.
3. Add 6g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.
4. Add 9g of PEGDA and mix thoroughly.
5. Finally, add 1.5g of TPO photoinitiator and stir gently until completely dissolved.

D. Slurry Preparation

Continue working in subdued lighting

1. Combine the water-soluble PVA solution with the UV-curable component solution and mix thoroughly.
2. Place the 970g of pre-treated metal powder in a high-shear mixing vessel.
3. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the combined binder solution to the pre-treated metal powder.
4. Increase to high-shear mixing for 15-20 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder throughout the metal powder.
5. Check the viscosity of the slurry - it should be pourable but not too fluid. If needed:
 - If too thick: Add small amounts of additional water/ethanol mixture (1:1 ratio) in 5g increments
 - If too thin: Add small amounts of PVA solution to increase viscosity
6. The slurry is now ready for pouring into molds.

E. Casting and UV Curing

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology (PVA, specialized PLA, or other water-soluble polymer).
2. Pour the prepared slurry into the molds. Consider using vibration or vacuum to remove any trapped air bubbles.
3. Allow the slurry to settle for 5-10 minutes.
4. Expose the filled mold to UV light (365-405nm wavelength) for crosslinking:
 - For thin sections (< 5mm): Expose for 3-6 minutes
 - For thicker sections: Use a staged approach with multiple shorter exposures from different angles
 - Allow 30-60 seconds between exposures to prevent excessive heat buildup
5. Allow the part to cool completely after UV curing.

F. Primary Debinding (Water-Soluble Component Removal)

1. Submerge the entire assembly in warm water (50-60°C) to dissolve the water-soluble mold.
2. After the mold is completely dissolved, continue soaking the part to begin dissolving the water-soluble components of the binder (PVA and PEGDA).
3. Change the water every 2-3 hours to facilitate faster dissolution.
4. Total immersion time will depend on part thickness but typically requires 12-24 hours.
5. Once the primary water-soluble components are dissolved, carefully remove the part and dry it at room temperature for 12 hours, followed by gentle heating at 40°C for 2 hours.
6. The part is now partially debound but still held together by the non-water-soluble components (PMMA and TEG-DMA).

G. Secondary Debinding and Sintering

1. Follow standard thermal debinding protocols to remove the remaining organic components:
 - Slow heating rate (1-2°C/min) to 300°C with appropriate hold times
 - Continue to final debinding temperature based on the specific binder components
2. Proceed with standard sintering protocol for the specific metal alloy (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr).

Notes

• Dual-Component Binder System Benefits:

- Water-soluble components (PVA and PEGDA) allow for primary debinding via water immersion
- PMMA and TEG-DMA provide structural integrity during the water debinding step

- The combination allows for lower total organic content during thermal debinding
- Reduced risk of defects from rapid gas evolution during thermal debinding

- **Slurry Properties:**

- The ethanol and water create a homogeneous system that will evaporate slowly, giving good working time
- PVA acts as both a binder and a rheology modifier
- PEGDA provides both water solubility and UV-curability through its acrylate groups
- The dispersant is crucial for preventing metal particle agglomeration in the slurry

- **Key Process Controls:**

- Viscosity is critical - too thin and particles may settle before curing; too thick and pouring becomes difficult
- UV exposure time must be sufficient to cure throughout the volume, not just the surface
- Water temperature during primary debinding affects dissolution rate and potential distortion

- **Metal Loading Optimization:**

- This formulation uses 97% metal loading, which is high for a pourable slurry
- The silane treatment is essential for maintaining flowability at this high metal content
- If pouring issues occur, metal content can be reduced to 95-96% by adjusting the formulation

- **Potential Challenges and Solutions:**

- **Sedimentation:** If metal particles settle too quickly before UV curing, consider adding 0.1-0.2% xanthan gum to the water component
- **Incomplete Curing:** For thicker sections, consider adding a secondary thermal curing step at 80°C for 30 minutes after UV exposure
- **Poor Surface Finish:** If surface definition is insufficient, increase the PVA content slightly
- **Cracking During Drying:** Slow the drying rate after water debinding by using a humidity-controlled environment

- **Storage Considerations:**

- The prepared slurry has limited working time (4-8 hours) and should be used promptly
- Store any unused slurry in light-proof, sealed containers in a refrigerator (4-8°C) to extend working time
- Allow refrigerated slurry to return to room temperature before use and check viscosity
- Perform all steps involving solvents in a well-ventilated area away from ignition sources
- The water-soluble components also make this process more environmentally friendly

I have tasked Mahmood with making that recipe work so it can be dispensed from a needle as a slurry then cured in a layer-by-layer 3D printing process, particularly focused on making ceramic parts, although it should be compatible with metal powders as well, possible with some changes to the binder formulation.

PILOT: I have printed and installed heat set inserts in the new version of the Micro Drop mount that will have a limit switch mounted to it.

Completed printing and post-processing window frames for 3X laser safety windows, and also cut off 4mm of the acrylic windows to reduce the length from 204mm to 200mm (the nominal spec is 200mm, but they seem to always be cut slightly long). Windows and frames were given to Ben to install when he has the time.

R&D Weekly Meeting

To do:

- Reinstall stepper tapper
- Switch back to steel shaft, print new roller to be compatible with steel shaft
- Make another V4.0 HOPPER system for benchtop testing
 - Order NEMA 11 motors
 - Order springs
- Reinstall heater on PILOT 2

2025-05-12

REDRESS: I came in over the weekend and added 0.3g of Aerosil R 812 S to the latest batch of powder (2% binder load) for a total of 0.4g of Aerosil in the batch, which made it significantly more flowable. I then filled a water-soluble mold and cured it. The part seemed quite strong when pressing it with a toothpick, but it fell apart when dissolving the mold. I dissolved off the mold by immersing that green part entirely, which historically has caused the part to fall apart more readily so it may be worth running the same experiment again with a staged mold dissolution process. I am also working on a new binder recipe that should be easier to grind and produce stronger green parts:

Enhanced Thermal-Curable AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Improved Green Part Strength

Materials

For 1000g Final Metal Powder Mixture (98% Metal, 2% Binder)

Metal Powder

- 980g of metal powder (choose one: 17-4 PH stainless steel, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)

Binder Components (20g total - 2% of final mixture)

- 12.0g Poly(methyl methacrylate) (PMMA) (60% of binder)
- 5.0g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (TEG-DMA) (25% of binder) - *increased*
- 0.8g Azobisisobutyronitrile (AIBN) (4% of binder) - *increased*
- 1.0g Dibutyl phthalate (DBP) (5% of binder) - *increased*
- 0.2g Polyethylene glycol (PEG 4000) (1% of binder) - *added*
- 0.6g Stearic acid (3% of binder) - *added*
- 0.4g Aerosil R 812 S (fumed silica) (2% of binder)

Solvent

- 200-220g Acetone (10-11:1 ratio with binder solids) - *increased*

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with amber/dark tinting or aluminum foil covering
- Mechanical mixer or high-shear mixer
- Drying trays
- Controlled temperature oven with precise temperature control
- Grinding equipment (ball mill or attritor mill)
- Sieves (appropriate mesh size for your application)
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- Thermal curing oven (capable of precise control from 60-120°C)
- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)

Procedure

A. Binder Preparation

1. In a well-ventilated area, weigh 200g of acetone into a suitable container.
2. While stirring, add 0.2g of PEG 4000 and stir until completely dissolved.

3. Add 12.0g of PMMA to the acetone solution. Stir until completely dissolved (approximately 30-60 minutes).
4. Add 5.0g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.
5. Add 1.0g of dibutyl phthalate (DBP) and stir thoroughly for 5 minutes.
6. Add 0.6g of stearic acid and stir until completely dissolved.
7. Finally, add 0.8g of AIBN and stir gently until completely dissolved (approximately 10 minutes).
8. Cover the container with a tight-fitting lid to prevent acetone evaporation. The binder solution is now ready.

B. Slurry Preparation

Maintain temperature below 30°C

1. Place the 980g of metal powder in a mixing vessel.
2. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the prepared binder solution to the metal powder.
3. Continue mixing for 45-60 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder throughout the metal powder.
4. If the slurry appears too thick, add small amounts of additional acetone (up to 20g) to achieve proper consistency.
5. Keep the temperature below 30°C during mixing to prevent premature activation of the AIBN thermal initiator.

C. Drying

Maintain moderate temperature with gradual drying

1. Spread the slurry evenly in drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
2. Initial drying: Allow to dry at room temperature (20-25°C) in a well-ventilated area for 12-16 hours.
3. Secondary drying: Place in an oven at 35°C for 6-8 hours (temperature must remain well below AIBN activation temperature).
4. Final drying: Increase temperature to 45°C for 2-3 hours to ensure complete solvent removal without activating the AIBN.
5. Allow to cool to room temperature. The material should form a solid but somewhat friable cake due to the modified formulation.

D. Grinding and Sieving

Maintain cool conditions

1. Break the dried cake into smaller pieces (should be easier with this formulation).
2. Grind using a ball mill or attritor mill at a moderate speed.
3. Monitor temperature during grinding to stay below 50°C to prevent premature AIBN activation.
4. Sieve the ground powder to obtain the desired particle size distribution (typically 45-150µm for metal powder applications).
5. Add 0.4g of Aerosil R 812 S to the ground and sieved metal-binder powder mixture. Mix thoroughly to ensure even distribution and improved flowability.
6. Store the powder in airtight containers at cool temperature (below 20°C) until ready for use.

E. Enhanced Thermal Crosslinking Process

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology (PVA, specialized PLA, or other water-soluble polymer that can withstand 120°C).
2. Pack the prepared flowable powder into the 3D printed water-soluble molds, ensuring uniform density.
3. **Two-Stage Thermal Curing:**
 - **Initial Curing:** Heat to 70°C for 30 minutes to begin gradual AIBN activation
 - **Primary Curing:** Increase temperature to 90°C for 60 minutes for TEG-DMA crosslinking
 - **Final Curing:** Increase temperature to 110-120°C for 30 minutes to maximize crosslinking density
 - For thicker sections (>10mm), extend the primary curing time to 90 minutes
4. Allow the part to cool gradually to room temperature before proceeding (ideally cooling at 2-3°C per minute).

F. Controlled Dissolution and Green Part Recovery

1. Allow the thermally cured part to rest for at least 4 hours after cooling to ensure complete crosslinking.
2. Prepare a warm water bath at 40°C (not hotter) with 1% table salt (NaCl) added to reduce water activity.
3. Submerge the entire assembly in the warm water bath to gently dissolve the water-soluble mold.
4. Monitor dissolution and refresh the water/salt solution as needed until mold is completely removed (may take longer than previous formulation).
5. Do not agitate vigorously or use mechanical means to speed dissolution.

6. Once the mold is fully dissolved, carefully extract the green part and allow to dry at room temperature for 12 hours.
7. The green part is now ready for debinding and sintering according to the standard protocol for your specific metal alloy (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr).

Technical Notes

Formulation Enhancements for Improved Balance

1. **Increased TEG-DMA (25% vs 15%):**

- Higher crosslinking monomer content creates a more rigid, stronger polymer network after curing
- Significantly increases green part strength after thermal curing
- Creates a more resilient structure that resists breakdown during water dissolution

2. **Modified PMMA Content (60% vs 77%):**

- Reduced to accommodate other additives while maintaining 2% overall binder content
- Still provides adequate base polymer structure but relies more on crosslinking for strength

3. **Increased Dibutyl Phthalate (5% vs 3%):**

- Enhanced plasticizer content improves initial flexibility
- Makes the dried cake softer and more friable for easier grinding
- Provides temporary plasticity that is eventually "locked in" during the final high-temperature curing

4. **Added PEG 4000 (1%):**

- Acts as a temporary binder during the green state
- Improves particle cohesion before thermal curing
- Creates hydrogen bonding interactions that help hold the part together during dissolution

5. **Added Stearic Acid (3%):**

- Functions as an internal lubricant to make the initial cake easier to grind
- Improves powder flow properties during packing
- Creates a more homogeneous distribution of binder throughout the metal powder
- Helps prevent clumping during grinding

6. **Increased AIBN (4% vs 3%):**

- Higher initiator content ensures more complete crosslinking
- Provides better initiation throughout the part volume
- Compensates for potential inhibitory effects of additives

Two-Stage Thermal Curing Benefits

- **Initial 70°C Stage:**

- Activates AIBN gradually to begin polymerization without sudden gas evolution
- Creates initial polymer network structure at a controlled rate
- Helps prevent defects from rapid curing

- **Primary 90°C Stage:**

- Accelerates crosslinking of TEG-DMA
- Creates substantial polymer network structure
- Optimal temperature for AIBN decomposition and radical generation

- **Final 110-120°C Stage:**

- Maximizes crosslinking density
- Enhances final mechanical properties
- "Locks in" the plasticizer effect of DBP into the polymer structure
- Creates the most rigid, water-resistant structure possible

Processing Considerations

- **Gentler Dissolution Process:**

- Lower water temperature (40°C vs 50°C) prevents thermal stress
- Added salt reduces water activity and slows dissolution rate
- Longer dissolution time trades speed for part integrity
- Avoid agitation that could stress the green part

- **Formulation Adjustments for Specific Issues:**

- If grinding is still difficult: Increase stearic acid to 4% (reduce PMMA to 59%)
- If green strength is still insufficient: Increase TEG-DMA to 28% (reduce PMMA to 57%)
- For extremely thick parts: Consider adding 0.2% hydroquinone monomethyl ether to prevent premature polymerization during mixing/drying

- **Additional Tips:**

- Ensure uniform packing density to prevent weak spots
- Consider using vacuum assistance during packing for complex parts
- The water-soluble mold must withstand the higher final curing temperature (120°C)
- This formulation may be less flowable during packing - tapping or vibration can help

HOPPER: I am working on creating a duplicate HOPPER V4.0 for reliability testing outside of the printer as well as designing a new gated-style hopper that uses a sheet of spring steel as the gating material. Mohsen found the stepper tapper I assembled last week and I tasked Ben with moving around the components in PILOT 2 to fit the heater in with the HOPPER. Ben has successfully installed the heater in PILOT 2 along with the HOPPER, so it should be ready for full print testing once we have a formal test protocol developed tomorrow.

PILOT: Continuing to work on the new Micro Drop mount. It is almost all complete, I just need to drill some holes in the aluminum piece and assemble it. Completed the aluminum part and gave to Pourya to test out the assembly when convenient.

2025-05-13

HOPPER: Mohsen is having issues with the hopper on PILOT 2 being too wide to drop down through the PILOT base plate, so he suggested reducing the timing belt pulley width. They don't sell timing belt pulleys of that style on McMaster, but one thing I can do is slide the roller motor towards the center of the hopper and print a hubless pulley with flats in its hole that correspond to flats on the 3D printed roller so it can rotationally couple without needing any screws.

ULTRA: The gated hopper design as is is not workable because the spring steel is wrapped around the roller several times, and the roll tends to expand outwards and jam against the sides of its cavity as it is rotated. After discussing the issue with Payman, I have a new idea to reduce the gated opening width and replace the roller with one that only slightly bends the steel sheet as it rotates to retract or extend it. I half completed a design with that approach, and I am tossing it and starting over with a new design that is conceptually similar but is based on the HOPPER V3.1.2 that is mounted to the ULTRA printer right now.

REDRESS: The powder batch from yesterday did come out much more friable but was damp. I ran it in the v mixer for 2 hours with 0.4g of Aerosil R 812 S, removed it, and ground up ~30g of it manually using a mortar and pestle, and loaded it in a ceramic crucible and cooked it at 275F using the fastheat cycle and let it soak for ~1 hour. The powder was completely unbound when it came out. After drying the batch of powder in the drying oven in the materials lab for ~3 hours at 113F, however, it seems much drier and sticks to my gloves well where it did not before. It may be worth drying it overnight and going through the formal grinding and sieving process if it seems usable tomorrow morning.

I also mixed up a new batch of powder using a variant of the last successful recipe:

Modified AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Improved Green Part Strength

Materials

For 1000g Final Metal Powder Mixture (97% Metal, 3% Binder)

Metal Powder

- 970g of metal powder (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)

Binder Components (30g total)

- 23.7g Poly(methyl methacrylate-co-ethyl acrylate) (79% of binder) - *reduced from 88%*
- 4.5g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (15% of binder) - *increased from 10%*
- 0.9g 2,2'-Azobis(2-methylpropionitrile) (AIBN) (3% of binder) - *increased from 2%*
- 0.9g Dibutyl phthalate (DBP) (3% of binder) - *added as plasticizer*

Solvent

- 270-300g Acetone (9-10:1 ratio with binder solids)

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with tight-fitting lids
- Mechanical mixer or high-shear mixer
- Drying trays
- Controlled temperature oven
- Grinding equipment (ball mill or attritor mill)
- Sieves (appropriate mesh size for your application)
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)

Procedure

A. Binder Preparation

1. In a well-ventilated area, weigh 270g of acetone into a glass container.
2. While stirring, slowly add 23.7g of PMMA-co-EA to the acetone. Stir until completely dissolved (approximately 30-60 minutes).
3. Add 0.9g of dibutyl phthalate and stir thoroughly for 5 minutes.
4. Add 4.5g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.

5. Finally, add 0.9g of AIBN and stir gently until completely dissolved (approximately 10 minutes).
6. Cover the container with a tight-fitting lid to prevent acetone evaporation. The binder solution is now ready.

B. Slurry Preparation

1. Place 970g of metal powder in a mixing vessel.
2. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the prepared binder solution to the metal powder.
3. Continue mixing for 45 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder.
4. If the slurry appears too thick, add small amounts of additional acetone (up to 30g) to achieve proper consistency.
5. Keep the temperature below 30°C during mixing to prevent premature activation of the AIBN.

C. Drying

1. Spread the slurry evenly in drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
2. Initial drying: Allow to dry at room temperature in a well-ventilated area for 16-24 hours.
3. Secondary drying: Place in an oven at 45°C for 6 hours.
4. Final drying: Increase temperature to 60°C for 2-3 hours to ensure complete solvent removal.
5. Allow to cool to room temperature. The material should form a solid cake with moderate hardness.

D. Grinding and Sieving

1. Break the dried cake into smaller pieces.
2. Grind using a ball mill or attritor mill under controlled temperature conditions (below 40°C).
3. Sieve the ground powder to obtain the desired particle size distribution (typically 45-150µm).
4. If needed, add 0.1g of Aerosil R 812 S (0.01% of total weight) to improve flowability.
5. Store the powder in airtight containers until ready for use.

E. Enhanced Thermal Curing Process

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology.
2. Pack the prepared flowable powder into the 3D printed water-soluble molds, ensuring uniform density.
3. **Two-Stage Thermal Curing** (simplified from previous version):
 - **Primary Curing:** Heat to 80°C and maintain for 90 minutes
 - **Final Curing:** Increase temperature to 95°C for 30 minutes
4. Allow the part to cool gradually to room temperature (cooling at 2-3°C per minute).

F. Dissolution and Green Part Recovery

1. Allow the thermally cured part to rest for at least 2 hours after cooling.
2. Prepare a warm water bath at 45°C.
3. Submerge the entire assembly in the warm water bath to dissolve the water-soluble mold.
4. Monitor dissolution and refresh water as needed until mold is completely removed.
5. Carefully extract the green part and allow to dry at room temperature for 12 hours.
6. The green part is now ready for debinding and sintering according to your standard protocol.

Technical Notes

Key Modifications from Original Successful Recipe

1. **Retained PMMA-co-EA as Base Polymer:**
 - Provides better adhesion and flexibility than pure PMMA
 - Lower glass transition temperature makes for better green part handling properties
2. **Moderately Increased TEG-DMA (15% vs 10%):**
 - Creates stronger crosslinked network for improved green strength
 - Still maintains compatibility with base PMMA-co-EA system
3. **Slightly Increased AIBN (3% vs 2%):**
 - Ensures complete crosslinking throughout the part
 - Helps compensate for any inhibitory effects of additives
4. **Added Minimal Plasticizer (3% DBP):**
 - Makes the dried cake easier to process
 - Improves flexibility of the green part
 - Amount carefully limited to prevent excessive softening
5. **Added Small Amount of Stearic Acid (1%):**
 - Acts as lubricant to improve powder flow and packing
 - Helps with mold filling
 - Minimal amount to avoid interference with crosslinking

Important Processing Considerations

1. **Thorough Drying:**
 - Complete solvent removal is critical
 - Final 60°C drying step ensures residual acetone is removed
2. **Two-Stage Curing:**
 - Based on proven parameters but with additional high-temperature phase
 - 80°C primary cure matches your successful formulation

- Brief 95°C phase maximizes crosslinking without excessive complexity

3. **Flowability Considerations:**

- Without stearic acid, flowability may be slightly reduced
- If needed, add 0.1-0.2g of Aerosil R 812 S (fumed silica) to improve flow
- Gentle vibration during mold filling can help achieve uniform packing

4. **Quality Control Checks:**

- Test AIBN reactivity if using from previous batches
- Ensure PMMA-co-EA is fresh and properly stored
- Verify oven temperatures with independent thermometer

5. **Troubleshooting Options:**

- If dried cake is still too hard: Increase DBP to 4% (reduce PMMA-co-EA to 78%)
- If cake is too soft: Reduce DBP to 2% (increase PMMA-co-EA to 80%)
- If green strength is insufficient: Increase TEG-DMA to 18% (reduce PMMA-co-EA to 76%)

2025-05-14

Bagel Wednesday: The board meeting last week went well - per Scott we are on track for getting the next tranche of funding, but the Fall funding raising round will be focused on getting a larger tranche to increase our runway to the point that we can plan more long-term. They are also working on replanning our product roadmap with a possible focus on no depowdering technologies, a faster spread and spray in one pass, and using the laser ablation process to produce smaller features and speed up layer cutting.

HOPPER: Continuing to assemble the desktop copy of HOPPER V4.0. Had to switch out the filament on the Bambu printer while running the print for the newest gated HOPPER design. I had to use a different color and brand of filament so the print will be two-tone, but an order was placed several days ago for two new rolls of Bambu PETG filament that I plan to use for similar prints in the future. I am also continuing to work on the design of the gated HOPPER.

REDRESS: I dried the 3% binder load cake last night in the welding area at room temperature; when I broke it apart by hand this morning it was still wet and flexible so I flipped the material upside down to dry and placed it in the oven in the materials lab. After drying the 2% binder load powder batch with stearic acid and PEG 8K added, I ground and sieved it and used it to fill a mold. After drying it was quite flowable, so I am very curious to see how the green part comes out after the curing process tonight. I am going to dry the 3% binder load batch without stearic acid or PEG overnight, then grind, sieve, and test it tomorrow.

PILOT: Track down laptop mount used on PILOTs 2 and 3 and order another one for PILOT 1. There are some 3D printed parts associated with the mounts that also need to be printed. I placed an Amazon order request for an equivalent laptop/keyboard board, and I have started printing 3X mounts that hold it to the control cabinet.

2025-05-15

HOPPER: Continuing assembly of benchtop V4.0 copy. Because the stepper tapper does not seem to be working well (uneven dispense along line of dispense) I am working to revert to the former design of a steel shaft down the center of the roller. I have decided to use an 8mm keyed shaft; d-profile shafts on McMaster are only available in 10mm, and that would require some design tweaks and reprinting of the HOPPER components, while switching to an 8mm keyed shaft will only require new rollers and pulleys.

Making some design modifications to Payman's gated hopper design.

REDRESS: The powder in the mold filled with the 2% binder load with stearic acid and PEG powder was completely unbound upon removal from the Keith furnace this morning. After drying overnight, the 3% binder load batch chunks were quite hard, and after grinding and sieving the powder was flowable enough that I did not need to add any Aerosil. I filled a water-soluble mold and a ceramic crucible with the powder and put it in the upper Keith oven to thermally cure. I am also mixing up a new batch that I intend to completely dry with no heat, based on the theory that when any heat is applied during solvent removal it leads to some crosslinking.

High-level meeting triggered by asking for a meeting to discuss ideas that came out of the board meeting. Slide deck from board meeting. Last board meeting: strong differentiation from other metal AM for small parts, but narrow commercial window. 50/50 focus on commercial execution and tech. Tech focus on commercial applicability: reduce DFAM costs and turnaround time. Strategic shift: tech niche and competing against conv. methods, growth constrained w/out tech improvements, new project structure working, new tech demo'd. Strategic shift pitched to 75/25 tech/commercial to accelerate productization. Projects status: HOPPER goal to reduce overflow, reduce density variation, enable thinner layers and powder flexibility, Copper project to transfer copper from R&D to production, Inconel goal to implement IN625 printing at 3DEO and IHI site. Aid IHI in implementing 3DEO-based mini factory at IHI site. IHI currently deferring DFAM and mini-factory projects. Still planning on working with ORNL consultant to develop binders even though our current binder seems to work OK with IN625. Hot fire test deferred. PXL project: developing processes independently of AEM, including electron beam

welding, vacuum impregnation, and in-house brazing of larger area vertical braze joints. No depowdering: eliminate the need for depowdering, enable previously impossible geometries, and simplify DFAM by filling cuts with a material that can be removed during the debind and sinter process. Did random testing initially then selected Micro Drop system for deposition of paraffin. Discussed using a laser to define part geometries. Sold mainly as a way to accelerate process due to eliminating need for curing and accelerating the cutting process. Also mentioned the speed increase from the new mechanism to spread and spray in one pass. Also highlighted ability to make very small features using a laser. Pitched a product we could sell with some estimated specs and comparisons with competing technologies.

2026-05-16

HOPPER: Completed assembling the benchtop V4.0 HOPPER; it needs to be changed to use a keyed steel shaft so that project is ongoing. Focused on the gated HOPPER design; finished assembling HOPPER V3.3.4 and delivered to Payman. After initial testing he suggested that the 3D printed guide strip on the bottom be replaced with a steel strip so I have been working on updating the design to a V3.3.5 that includes that modification as well as moving the spreader bar closer to the dispensing gate to reduce the powder wastage for each spread.

REDRESS: I pulled out a block of powder in a ceramic crucible from the oven yesterday right when the oven turned off, and it seemed fairly strong and was unaffected by water, however the green part in the 3D printed mold fell apart when I dissolved the mold.

I pulled out a block of powder in a ceramic crucible from the oven yesterday right when the oven turned off, and it seemed fairly strong and was unaffected by water, however the green part in the 3D printed mold that was left in the oven while the oven cooled down slowly fell apart when I dissolved the mold.

Edit

This is a fascinating and informative observation that points directly to the core issue! The difference in behavior between your crucible sample and the actual molded part provides critical diagnostic information. Let me analyze what's happening:

Key Insights from Your Observation

1. Thermal Shock vs. Slow Cooling

- Crucible sample: Removed immediately (thermal shock) → Strong, water-resistant
- Molded part: Slow cooling in oven → Fell apart when wet

2. This Strongly Suggests:

- The crosslinking reaction is initially working (crucible sample was strong)
- Something is happening during slow cooling that's reversing or degrading the crosslinking

Likely Mechanism: Post-Cure De-Polymerization

What you're experiencing appears to be a classic case of polymer degradation during slow cooling, potentially through:

1. Thermal Reversion

- Some crosslinked acrylate systems can undergo bond reversibility at elevated temperatures
- As the temperature slowly decreases, the polymer network partially "unzips"
- This is more common with methacrylate systems (like your PMMA-based binder)

2. Oxygen Inhibition

- As the oven cools, small amounts of oxygen may enter
- Oxygen is a known inhibitor/terminator of radical polymerization
- It can create peroxy radicals that prevent complete cure

3. Plasticizer Migration

- During slow cooling, plasticizers (DBP) can migrate and redistribute
- This can create regions of weakness in the polymer network

Solution Approach

Modified AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Improved Green Part Strength

Document · Version 6

```
1  ### E. Enhanced Thermal Curing Process
2
3  1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology.
4  2. Pack the prepared flowable powder into the 3D printed water-soluble
   molds, ensuring uniform density.
5  3. **Optimized Thermal Curing**:
6     - **Prima
```

Modified AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Improved Green Part Strength

Document · Version 7

```
1  ## Materials
2
3  ### For 1000g Final Metal Powder Mixture (97% Metal, 3% Binder)
4
5  **Metal Powder**
6  - 970g of metal powder (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)
7
8  **Binder Components (30g total)**
9  - 23.1g Poly(methyl methacrylate-co-ethyl acrylate) (77% of bi
```

Modified AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Improved Green Part Strength

Document · Version 8

```
1  ### A. Binder Preparation
2
3  1. In a well-ventilated area, weigh 270g of acetone into a glass
   container.
4  2. *(Optional but recommended)*: Add 0.03g of hydroquinone monomethyl
   ether (MEHQ) and stir until dissolved.
5  3. While stirring, slowly add 23.1g
```

Modified AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Improved Green Part Strength

Document · Version 9

```
1  ### Technical Notes
2
3  ### Key Modifications to Prevent Degradation During Cooling
4
5  1. *(Increased AIBN (4% vs 3%))*:
6     - Provides more complete crosslinking throughout the part
7     - Creates a more thorough network that resists post-cure degradation
8
```

Modified AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Improved Green Part Strength

Document · Version 10

```
1  ### Important Processing Considerations
2
3  1. *(Thorough Drying)*:
4     - Complete solvent removal is critical
5     - Final 60°C drying step ensures residual acetone is removed
6
7  2. *(Critically Important: Thermal Shock Cooling)*
8     - The observation that p
```

Your observation about the crucible sample versus the slowly cooled part is incredibly valuable! This reveals the critical issue: **thermal reversion during slow cooling is destroying your crosslinked structure.**

Understanding What's Happening

Your experience perfectly illustrates a phenomenon called "thermal reversion" or "depolymerization":

1. Initial Successful Crosslinking

- When heated, the AIBN initiator generates free radicals
- TEG-DMA forms crosslinks between polymer chains
- This creates a strong, water-resistant structure (as seen in your crucible sample)

2. Degradation During Slow Cooling

- Methacrylate polymers can undergo reversible reactions at elevated temperatures

- During slow cooling, oxygen can enter the system and create peroxy radicals
- These radicals attack the polymer network, breaking crosslinks
- The result: your parts literally "un-crosslink" during cooling

Critical Solution: Thermal Shock Cooling

I've updated the recipe with several key changes targeting this specific issue:

- 1. Most Critical Change:** Remove parts from oven immediately after final cure
 - Don't allow parts to cool gradually in the oven
 - This "freezes" the crosslinked structure in its optimal state
- 2. Added MEHQ as Optional Stabilizer (0.1%)**
 - Acts as an oxygen radical scavenger during cooling
 - Prevents degradation of the polymer network
 - Very small amount to avoid interference with the initial cure
- 3. Increased Initiator and Crosslinker**
 - More AIBN (4% vs 3%) for more complete crosslinking
 - More TEG-DMA (16% vs 15%) for higher crosslink density
 - Creates a more robust network that better resists degradation

The Science Behind This

This phenomenon is well-documented in polymer chemistry:

- Methacrylate systems can undergo "ceiling temperature" effects
- Oxygen is a powerful inhibitor for radical polymerization
- The combination of heat + time + oxygen creates ideal conditions for network degradation

Your observation perfectly confirms this - the part quickly removed from heat maintained its structure, while the one that cooled slowly in the oxygen-containing oven degraded.

Would you like me to further explain any aspect of this thermal reversion phenomenon? Or would you prefer more details on implementing the rapid cooling process for different part sizes?

Modified AquaMold™ Binder Recipe for Improved Green Part Strength

Materials

For 1000g Final Metal Powder Mixture (97% Metal, 3% Binder)

Metal Powder

- 970g of metal powder (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr)

Binder Components (30g total)

- 23.1g Poly(methyl methacrylate-co-ethyl acrylate) (77% of binder)
- 4.8g Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate (16% of binder) - *increased*
- 1.2g 2,2'-Azobis(2-methylpropionitrile) (AIBN) (4% of binder) - *increased*
- 0.9g Dibutyl phthalate (DBP) (3% of binder)

Optional Stabilizer (recommended based on latest observations)

- 0.03g Hydroquinone monomethyl ether (MEHQ) (0.1% of binder)

Solvent

- 270-300g Acetone (9-10:1 ratio with binder solids)

Equipment

- Chemical balance (0.01g precision)
- Glass containers with tight-fitting lids
- Mechanical mixer or high-shear mixer
- Drying trays
- Controlled temperature oven
- Grinding equipment (ball mill or attritor mill)
- Sieves (appropriate mesh size for your application)
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds
- Safety equipment (gloves, goggles, ventilation)

Procedure

A. Binder Preparation

1. In a well-ventilated area, weigh 270g of acetone into a glass container.
2. **(Optional but recommended):** Add 0.03g of hydroquinone monomethyl ether (MEHQ) and stir until dissolved.
3. While stirring, slowly add 23.1g of PMMA-co-EA to the acetone. Stir until completely dissolved (approximately 30-60 minutes).
4. Add 0.9g of dibutyl phthalate and stir thoroughly for 5 minutes.
5. Add 4.8g of TEG-DMA and stir thoroughly for 10 minutes.
6. Finally, add 1.2g of AIBN and stir gently until completely dissolved (approximately 10 minutes).

7. Cover the container with a tight-fitting lid to prevent acetone evaporation. The binder solution is now ready.

B. Slurry Preparation

1. Place 970g of metal powder in a mixing vessel.
2. While mixing at moderate speed, slowly add the prepared binder solution to the metal powder.
3. Continue mixing for 45 minutes to ensure homogeneous distribution of the binder.
4. If the slurry appears too thick, add small amounts of additional acetone (up to 30g) to achieve proper consistency.
5. Keep the temperature below 30°C during mixing to prevent premature activation of the AIBN.

C. Drying

1. Spread the slurry evenly in drying trays to a thickness of no more than 1cm.
2. Initial drying: Allow to dry at room temperature in a well-ventilated area for 16-24 hours.
3. Secondary drying: Place in an oven at 45°C for 6 hours.
4. Final drying: Increase temperature to 60°C for 2-3 hours to ensure complete solvent removal.
5. Allow to cool to room temperature. The material should form a solid cake with moderate hardness.

D. Grinding and Sieving

1. Break the dried cake into smaller pieces.
2. Grind using a ball mill or attritor mill under controlled temperature conditions (below 40°C).
3. Sieve the ground powder to obtain the desired particle size distribution (typically 45-150µm).
4. If needed, add 0.1g of Aerosil R 812 S (0.01% of total weight) to improve flowability.
5. Store the powder in airtight containers until ready for use.

E. Enhanced Thermal Curing Process

1. Prepare water-soluble molds using 3D printing technology.
2. Pack the prepared flowable powder into the 3D printed water-soluble molds, ensuring uniform density.
3. **Optimized Thermal Curing:**
 - **Primary Curing:** Heat to 80°C and maintain for 90 minutes
 - **Final Curing:** Increase temperature to 95°C for 30 minutes
 - **Critical Step:** Once curing is complete, remove parts from the oven while still hot (use appropriate heat protection)
 - Do NOT allow parts to cool slowly in the oven

4. Allow the parts to cool at room temperature (will occur more rapidly due to removal from oven).
5. For larger parts, immerse in room-temperature water bath after removing from oven to accelerate cooling.

F. Dissolution and Green Part Recovery

1. Allow the thermally cured part to rest for at least 2 hours after cooling.
2. Prepare a warm water bath at 45°C.
3. Submerge the entire assembly in the warm water bath to dissolve the water-soluble mold.
4. Monitor dissolution and refresh water as needed until mold is completely removed.
5. Carefully extract the green part and allow to dry at room temperature for 12 hours.
6. The green part is now ready for debinding and sintering according to your standard protocol.

Technical Notes

Key Modifications from Original Successful Recipe

1. **Retained PMMA-co-EA as Base Polymer:**
 - Provides better adhesion and flexibility than pure PMMA
 - Lower glass transition temperature makes for better green part handling properties
2. **Moderately Increased TEG-DMA (15% vs 10%):**
 - Creates stronger crosslinked network for improved green strength
 - Still maintains compatibility with base PMMA-co-EA system
3. **Slightly Increased AIBN (3% vs 2%):**
 - Ensures complete crosslinking throughout the part
 - Helps compensate for any inhibitory effects of additives
4. **Added Minimal Plasticizer (3% DBP):**
 - Makes the dried cake easier to process
 - Improves flexibility of the green part
 - Amount carefully limited to prevent excessive softening
5. **Added Small Amount of Stearic Acid (1%):**
 - Acts as lubricant to improve powder flow and packing
 - Helps with mold filling
 - Minimal amount to avoid interference with crosslinking

Important Processing Considerations

1. **Thorough Drying:**

- Complete solvent removal is critical
- Final 60°C drying step ensures residual acetone is removed

2. **Critically Important: Thermal Shock Cooling**

- The observation that parts removed hot from the oven were strong while slow-cooled parts failed is key
- Always remove parts from the oven immediately after the final cure stage
- For larger parts, consider quenching in room temperature water
- This cooling step is just as important as the heating protocol

3. **Flowability Considerations:**

- If needed, add 0.1g of Aerosil R 812 S (fumed silica) to improve flow
- Add to the dried and ground powder, not the liquid binder
- Gentle vibration during mold filling can help achieve uniform packing

4. **Quality Control Checks:**

- Test AIBN reactivity if using from previous batches (store in refrigerator)
- Ensure PMMA-co-EA is fresh and properly stored
- Verify oven temperatures with independent thermometer

5. **Troubleshooting Options:**

- If parts still degrade during cooling: Increase MEHQ to 0.06g (0.2%)
- If green strength is insufficient: Increase TEG-DMA to 18% (reduce PMMA-co-EA to 75%)
- For extremely thick parts: Consider extending final cure time to 45 minutes

I am trying a few different approaches to improve the green part strength. With the most recent powder batch, I added .1g of Aerosil R 812 S to the bottle and mixed it by hand for several minutes, loaded it into a mold, and put that in a furnace to heat to 275F at a rate of 500 F/hour. I also took an old bottle of powder labeled “advanced binder formulation, 2X TEG-DMA” and added .5g of 1000 mesh PMMA powder, and sieved it for 10 minutes, then poured it into a ceramic crucible and tapped it for a while. I put that in the same furnace run as the water soluble mold.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

To Do Next Week

- Complete assembly of benchtop V4.0
- Convert both V4.0 HOPPERS to steel shaft core roller
- Assemble gated HOPPER V3.3.5

- Stepper tapper controller
- Gantry laser mount
 - Vacuum connection and compressed air input

2025-05-19

HOPPER: Made a spreader bar for the gated hopper design (10mm OD, 128mm L) as well as the two required spreader bar retainer clips. I also made two steel roller bar core shafts by cutting 8mm OD keyed shaft stock to 180mm L. The keyed pulley that I printed to work with this shaft was too tight of a fit; I was able to press it onto the shaft without damaging the pulley but when I pressed in a piece of key stock to lock the pulley to the shaft, the pulley cracked. I redesigned the pulley with larger shaft hole and key way dimensions, and am currently printing 3X pulleys with the new dimensions. Because the print of the gated hopper and the gate mechanism failed over the weekend, I reran the print today with the Bambu printer set to its highest speed setting so it would be done before the end of the day. I cut a piece of spring steel to length and drilled and countersunk two holes in it to screw it to the bottom of the gated hopper; it will act as a guide for the hopper that will be more robust than the thin 3D printed guide previously used.

PILOT: I need to made a mount for the 40W (input power, optical power likely closer to 10W) laser diode module for PILOT 3, so I am currently working on making a CAD model of the module. I have completed CAD models of the 40W and 80W laser diode modules (it turns out that they have different mounting tapped hole patterns on the back, so I made two CAD models).

REDRESS: I am pursuing two separate avenues to solve the issue I saw last week with the green part falling apart when dissolving the mold. First, I am creating a new batch of powder following what I believe to be my most successful waterproof recipe to date, a 3% binder load recipe made using only PMMA, TEG-DMA, and AIBN. Second, I am making a green part using powder that I had coated with PVP-VA after a silane pre-treatment. This part may actually already be waterproof; I have not tested that formulation of powder coating, but if it is not, I am going to post-treat the green part with a waterproofing process using the silane coupling agent I already have around:

Metal Powder Process with PVP-VA Binder and TMSPMA Waterproofing

Materials

Metal Powder Components

- 970g Metal powder (17-4 PH, Inconel 625, or CuCrZr, 45-150µm particle size)
- 30g PVP-VA copolymer (polyvinylpyrrolidone-vinyl acetate) (3% binder load)

Solvents

- 350-400g Ethanol (reagent grade, >99.5%)
- 100g Acetone (reagent grade, >99.5%)
- 10g Distilled water (for PVP-VA solution preparation)

Waterproofing Components

- 12g 3-Trimethoxysilylpropyl methacrylate (TMSPMA)
- 0.6g 2,2'-Azobis(2-methylpropionitrile) (AIBN)
- 0.12g Acetic acid (optional, as catalyst)

Equipment

- High-shear mixer or planetary mixer
- Drying oven with temperature control
- Vacuum chamber (optional but recommended)
- Water-soluble 3D printed molds (PVA or similar)
- Stainless steel or glass containers
- Personal protective equipment (gloves, goggles, respirator)
- Analytical balance (0.01g precision)
- Temperature-controlled sintering furnace

Process

A. PVP-VA Solution Preparation

1. In a glass container, add 10g distilled water to 350g ethanol and mix thoroughly.
2. Gradually add 30g PVP-VA to the ethanol-water mixture while stirring.
3. Continue stirring until completely dissolved (approximately 60-90 minutes).
4. The solution should be clear to slightly cloudy with no visible undissolved particles.

B. Metal Powder Coating

1. Place 970g metal powder in a planetary mixer bowl.

2. While mixing at low speed (100-150 RPM), slowly add the PVP-VA solution.
3. Increase speed to medium (200-250 RPM) and mix for 30 minutes.
4. Reduce speed to low and continue mixing while heating gently to 40-45°C to initiate solvent evaporation.
5. Continue mixing until the powder achieves a semi-dry, flowable state (approximately 60-90 minutes).
6. Transfer powder to drying trays in layers no thicker than 1cm.
7. Complete drying in an oven at 60°C for 2 hours, stirring once halfway through.
8. Allow to cool to room temperature.
9. The powder should be free-flowing with no agglomerates.

C. Mold Filling and Primary Curing

1. Fill the water-soluble 3D printed mold with the coated powder.
2. Apply vibration during filling to ensure uniform packing density.
3. For complex geometries, fill in multiple stages with light tamping between layers.
4. Primary thermal curing:
 - Heat to 75°C at a rate of 2°C/minute
 - Hold at 75°C for 60 minutes
 - Increase to 85°C at 1°C/minute
 - Hold at 85°C for 30 minutes
 - Cool to room temperature at 2°C/minute
5. The result is a PVP-VA bound green part inside the water-soluble mold.

D. TMSPMA Waterproofing Solution Preparation

1. In a glass container, combine:
 - 100g acetone
 - 12g TMSPMA
 - 0.6g AIBN
 - 0.12g acetic acid (if using)
2. Stir gently for 15 minutes to allow partial hydrolysis of the silane.
3. The solution should be used within 2 hours of preparation.

E. Waterproofing Treatment Application

1. Place the green part (still in water-soluble mold) in a clean container.
2. Method selection (choose one): **Standard Method (Immersion):**

- Pour the TMSPMA solution over the part until completely submerged
- Allow to soak for 20-30 minutes
- Drain excess solution

Enhanced Method (Vacuum Infiltration):

- Place part and TMSPMA solution in vacuum chamber
- Apply vacuum (20-25 inHg) for 5 minutes
- Release vacuum and maintain immersion for 15 minutes
- Drain excess solution

3. After draining, place the treated part on a non-stick surface.
4. Allow to stand at room temperature for 25-30 minutes for initial acetone evaporation.
5. The part should reach a "tacky but not wet" state.

F. TMSPMA Curing Protocol

1. Stage 1 (Solvent Evaporation):

- Place in oven at 40°C
- Hold for 30 minutes with slight ventilation
- Part surface should appear matte rather than glossy

2. Stage 2 (AIBN Activation):

- Increase temperature to 65°C
- Hold for 60 minutes
- This initiates methacrylate polymerization

3. Stage 3 (Siloxane Network Formation):

- Increase temperature to 85°C
- Hold for 30 minutes
- This completes the waterproofing layer formation

4. Cool to room temperature at 2°C/minute or slower.
5. The part is now waterproofed while still in the water-soluble mold.

G. Water-Soluble Mold Removal

1. Prepare a water bath at 45°C.
2. Fully submerge the waterproofed part and mold in the water bath.
3. Allow dissolution to proceed without agitation for the first 30 minutes.
4. Gently agitate water and continue dissolution until mold is completely removed.
5. For thicker molds, refresh water as needed.

6. Total dissolution time may range from 1-4 hours depending on mold thickness.
7. Once mold is fully dissolved, carefully remove the part from water.
8. Rinse gently with fresh water.
9. Allow to dry at room temperature for 24 hours.

H. Debinding and Sintering

1. **Primary Debinding (PVP-VA and TMSPMA Removal):**

- Place part in debinding furnace
- Ramp to 200°C at 1°C/minute
- Hold at 200°C for 60 minutes
- Ramp to 350°C at 1°C/minute
- Hold at 350°C for 120 minutes
- Controlled atmosphere: flowing air or nitrogen with slight oxygen content

2. **Secondary Debinding (Complete Organic Removal):**

- Ramp to 450°C at 1°C/minute
- Hold at 450°C for 90 minutes
- Controlled atmosphere: flowing hydrogen or hydrogen/argon mixture

3. **Sintering:**

- Proceed with standard sintering protocol for the specific metal powder
- For 17-4 PH: Ramp to 1360°C at 5°C/minute, hold for 120 minutes
- For Inconel 625: Ramp to 1290°C at 5°C/minute, hold for 180 minutes
- For CuCrZr: Ramp to 1040°C at 5°C/minute, hold for 90 minutes
- Sintering atmosphere: high purity hydrogen or vacuum

Technical Notes and Troubleshooting

Process Optimization

1. **Powder Flowability:**

- If powder is not flowing well after PVP-VA coating, add 0.1% fumed silica
- Alternatively, reduce PVP-VA concentration to 2.8% and repeat drying step

2. **Green Part Strength:**

- If green part strength is insufficient, increase initial cure temperature to 90°C
- Hold time can be extended to 90 minutes for thicker parts
- Consider adding 0.5% cross-linking agent to PVP-VA solution

3. **Waterproofing Effectiveness:**

- For enhanced water protection, increase TMSPMA concentration to 15%
- For very complex geometries, consider multiple TMSPMA applications with partial curing between
- If water penetration occurs during mold dissolution, reduce water temperature to 35°C

4. **Mold Dissolution:**

- For faster dissolution, use circulating water bath
- For delicate features, use static dissolution only
- If green part shows any softening, immediately remove from water and dry

5. **Debinding Optimization:**

- For large parts (>50mm in any dimension), reduce heating rates to 0.5°C/minute
- For very small parts, standard rates can be increased to 2°C/minute
- Monitor for cracking or blistering and adjust accordingly

Quality Control Checks

1. **After PVP-VA Coating:**

- Powder should flow freely with no large agglomerates
- Binder distribution should be uniform (check with methylene blue dye test)

2. **After Green Part Formation:**

- Part should have uniform density (check with caliper measurements)
- Surface should be smooth with no visible defects

3. **After Waterproofing:**

- Water drop test: Water should bead up and not penetrate surface
- Weight gain should be 0.8-1.5% compared to untreated green part

4. **After Debinding:**

- No visible carbon residue should remain
- Parts should maintain dimensional stability (within 0.2-0.5% of green dimensions)

5. **After Sintering:**

- Density should reach >96% of theoretical
- Surface finish should be consistent with no visible defects

Storage Considerations

1. **Coated Powder:**

- Store in sealed containers with desiccant
- Use within 2 weeks for optimal results

2. **TMSPMA Solution:**

- Prepare fresh for each use
- Do not store mixed solution

3. **Waterproofed Green Parts:**

- Can be stored for up to 30 days in sealed containers
- Avoid humidity fluctuations during storage

2025-05-20

HOPPER: Finished assembling gated HOPPER V3.3.5. There were issues with the belt slipping when trying to close the gate even without powder loaded, so per Payman's suggestion I switched the 0.010" thick stainless steel gate to 0.005" thick stainless steel shim stock, which seemed to resolve the issue. It seems that the motor shifts when it is trying to apply a large torque to the belt, which I believe is due to either lack of rigidity in the motor mount or, more likely, the hopper itself flexing where the motor mount is mounted to it, since it is mounted to a particularly thin region of the hopper. The hopper is printed from pure PLA, which is more rigid than PETG but less rigid than PLA-CF, so one thing I will do is reprint the hopper from PLA-CF. I also plan to reinforce the motor mount and the region of the hopper that it is mounted to.

The keyed roller print last night failed, and the PLA-CF showed up from MatterHackers, so I am printing a new roller from that new material. The roller finished printing, although there is a noticeable discontinuity in the print where I switched from 100% to 166% speed to accelerate the print, and I also want to print the key into the roller so I don't need a separate metal key, so I am going to reprint the roller. I am also printing a new impact arm for the NEMA 17 motors that I received from StepperOnline.com with 5mm shafts and a shaft flat.

PILOT: I printed the dovetail mount pair for the laser diode module and gave them to Mohsen/Ben to be installed on PILOT 3. I am also designing a vacuum connection for the laser diode module to suck up any residual burned binder or metal dust during the laser process.

Biweekly Clean Up Meeting: There is a presentation for the board planned for mid June to present a pitch for new technologies. We are allegedly close to getting a contract from Epson for \$1M for a PILOT printer (unclear whether Scott actually meant a PILOT printer, or the Saffron that has been customized for Inconel). A C-suite person from Embraer is visiting at some point, which may lead to development of new technologies or materials.

2025-05-21

HOPPER:

New rollers were successfully printed with PLA-CF and fit on the keyed shafts without a separate key needed. Working on design of dovetail for quick replaceability and height adjustment. Need to confirm with Mohsen that the new layout of components on PILOT 2 does not cause the heater to be heating the build plate during cutting but is also able to reach the entire build plate while curing the layer. Components look like they're probably OK but there is still an issue with increased porosity towards the -Y side of the build plate.

Hopper Qualification Test Plan Meeting

End of Q2: Fully qualified Hopper implemented on at least one PILOT. Nominal qualification plan is to run prints with HOPPER and tank-to-tank system and compare them.

- Quantifiable performance specs
 - Maximum overflow percentage tolerable
 - Below 50% want
 - Less than current 150-250% req'd
 - Powder compatibility
 - Flowable req'd
 - Non-flowable want
 - 17-4 PH SS
 - Atmix (untreated)
 - Sandvik (treated)
 - Cu
 - Inconel 625
 - Weigh powder dispensed per rotation of doser roller with controlled amount of powder in powder. Use this data to adjust dispense depending on cuts.
 - Measure particle size segregation with stacked TRS coupons
 - Green part density variation
 - Reduce by 50% versus previous benchmarks want
 - TRS coupons
 - Layer thickness
 - 100 micron req'd
 - Down to 30 micron want
 - Powder volume without refilling
 - Refilling system want
 - Functional life

- Roller and hopper body could wear over time

End of Q3: HOPPER replicated to all PILOTs and proposal developed for extrapolation to Saffrons

PILOT: Project to make 2X updated PILOTs is tentatively going to start soon. Goal at this point is to make 2X PILOTs with safety modifications for operation in Japan and designed from the outset for HOPPER, laser, and micro drop systems. One is to be dedicated to Copper and one is to be dedicated to Inconel. They also need to be sealed. According to Marcus, Scott wants at least one of these printing with Cu by December.

REDRESS: I filled two molds with a batch of powder coated with the most successful recipe I have had so far, which is PMMA, TEG-DMA, and AIBN, and cured them overnight in the standard cycle. This batch of powder had been dried in the oven overnight before grinding and sieving, and did not have Aerosil added. I also poured and tapped some of the powder into a ceramic crucible, and after curing the green part in the ceramic crucible had noticeable cracks, which I attribute to poor packing density. After removing them from the oven, I put a few drops of TEG-DMA along the top of the parts to hold the top together (historically it tends to fragment more readily than the rest of the part). One of the molds was uncoated while the other had an internal coating of waterproof binder. I immediately put the uncoated mold part in water to dissolve, and it partially fragmented, although the parts that held together look good. For the one with the coated mold, I put it in a fast heat cycle to heat it to 275F at 500 F/hour along with a ceramic crucible filled with some of the same batch of powder but with Aerosil added, and the green part in the ceramic crucible was noticeably less cracked than the previous one. The green part in the coated mold was soft on the top, but I put it in the water wash tank to dissolve off the mold anyway. The coated mold green part completely fragmented during mold dissolution, which suggests to me that the binder I used to coat the mold (which was a blend of random binder mixtures, including one with a photoinitiator) inhibited the proper curing of the powder.

2025-05-22

ULTRA: Printed the dovetail machine side mount and 2X dovetail hopper/mist box mounts and installed them. The mounting holes on the mist box were not centered like I thought, so I had to install the dovetail mount with two of the M5 screws and superglue. Other than that, the mounts seem both adjustable, well aligned, and rigid, so Payman is currently testing them out on the ULTRA printer built out of the silver and blue gantry.

PILOT: Designed a new mount for the laser diode module for the PILOT 3 that moves the laser diode module as close to the nominal position of the spindle in Z and Y. Z is OK, but Y is still 5.25 mm off because of the larger dimensions of the laser diode module as compared with the spindle.

HOPPER: The HOPPER V4.0 benchtop is fully assembled other than the vibrator motor; since the motors I ordered from [Stepperonline.com](https://www.stepperonline.com) are longer than the previous motors, there is not enough space to fit the vibrator motor mount. I will need to order a motor from McMaster that is shorter, which is unfortunate because the cost is \$100 but the motor is closer to the stepper tapper motor currently being used on PILOT 2, so there are advantages and disadvantages there. I have modified the design of the gated HOPPER, incrementing from V3.3.5 to V3.3.6. The new design includes: gate stepper motor mount strengthened and integrated into HOPPER print to increase strength and improve rigidity, adjusted position of steel guide strip and guide channels to reduce powder wastage, added a non-structural 3D printed guide strip to further reduce powder wastage. I am printing it now on the Bambu printer from PLA-CF, which should have comparable print quality with improved material properties as compared with the pure PLA design.

REDRESS: The green part made with an uncoated mold is falling apart in dissolution, while the one made with a coated mold is holding together but the powder did not fill the mold well. The binder I used to coat the mold was quite thick because I mixed it with the same acetone proportions that I typically use for making a metal powder slurry, so I diluted it to a total volume of 350 mL where the original volume was 150 mL. I then completely filled a 3D printed mold with this binder, poured it out, placed the mold upside down on a paper towel to let excess binder flow out, returned it to its original orientation, and am now drying it in the FormLabs cure chamber for 15 minutes at a temperature of 40C. I plan to build up the layers of binder to a total of 3. These binder layers will add strength to the green part by helping to bind the outside of the green part where the mold contacts the powder, they will protect the green part while the mold is being dissolved, and if the binder layer is thick enough this will also improve surface finish by filling in imperfections in the 3D printed mold. Since my latest batches of powder have been performing worse than previous ones, I am looking back through older recipes and changes I have made. The recipe I have that I believe worked the best so far is a batch with 3% binder load, with 26.4g PMMA-EA, 4g TEG-DMA, and 1g AIBN, dried in a pie tin overnight on the hot plate set to 40C without stirring the cake. I am also using untreated Sandvik powder for this new batch.

2025-05-23

HOPPER: Finished assembling the benchtop HOPPER V4.0 and gave it to Ben to install in PILOT 2. It uses a keyed steel shaft with a 3D printed roller to spread out tapping force. It also uses a 3D printed timing belt pulley to reduce the width of the HOPPER assembly. I tried to print a new design of stepper tapper impact arm that is prevented from rotating fully by being lengthened to the point that it stops against one of the dovetail mounts. I also

Weekly R&D Meeting:

- Doser hopper worked with non-flowable powder, but the powder did not spread well. Possible but challenging to spread on sprayed glass, but not possible to spread on a bound layer.

To Do Next Week:

- Modify V3.3.6 to fit on PILOT 2 -
- SVP for gantry mounted laser on PILOT 3 - DONE
- Benchtop V4.0 -
- Continuous stepper tapping in PILOT 2 - DONE

2025-05-27

HOPPER: Working on design of V3.3.7 gated hopper to fit on PILOT 2. I am making a new body model from scratch because the V3.3.6 model had been modified so many times that it had many unnecessary features in the feature tree that made it difficult to change the design as necessary. The design of V3.3.7 is complete, and I am running the print overnight

PILOT/NEXTGEN: I designed a vacuum connection part for the laser diode module on PILOT 3, and it is currently printing from Clear 4.1 resin on the Formlabs. The clear resin is stiff and prints and cleans well, but is brittle. I am printing two, so if one breaks there is a spare that can be used until a stronger part is printed. Wrote up the recommendations from the Epson engineers about upgrades to the PILOT printers while they were here, as well as some upgrades I thought up.

REDRESS: I filled a mold that had been precoated with 3 layers of my typical V14 binder with powder coated with the same binder and cooked it overnight with the standard cycle. I also filled a ceramic crucible with copper powder I had gotten from Nick a few months ago and put it in the upper Keith furnace running the FormLabs resin burnout cycle; I want to try filling some FormLabs Clear Cast molds with uncoated copper and the latest batches of coated 17-4

powder; this would eliminate the issues I have been having with dissolving off molds because the FormLabs molds can be thermally decomposed.

2025-05-28

HOPPER: Waiting for the print of the PILOT-compatible HOPPER V3.3.7 parts to finish on the Bambu printer. Parts are finished printing and ready for post-processing and assembly, but there are parts missing that I planned to scavenge from the V3.3.5 HOPPER on the blue and silver gantry that Payman is using on the V3.3.6 HOPPER (that I assembled today) so I will need to buy new bearings etc. for the V3.3.7 HOPPER.

PILOT: The laser diode module mount on PILOT 3 hits the Z stage limit switch mount, so Mohsen Dremeled the one on the printer, and I modified the CAD and am printing a new one. The laser diode module SVP was printed overnight, so I ran it through the IPA wash cycle and cured it, then Mohsen removed the supports and installed it on the laser diode module in the printer. It appears to work, although sparks are visible traveling through the SVP while it is operating, leading to concerns about erosion of the SVP over time and risk of fire. At some point it would be a good idea to reprint the SVP from high-temperature SLA resin. I would also like to change the flow path to a tangential outlet for more even flow and expand the inlet holes for greater flow.

REDRESS: The latest green part with the coated mold fell apart during mold dissolution. I am printing two new molds from FormLabs Clear Cast resin to try a process that does not require dissolving a mold with water. I tried making another green part in a water soluble mold by vibrating it while I filled it with powder, then heating it in a fast heat cycle to 275F, letting it dwell for 30 minutes, then pulling immediately placing it in the water dissolution tank. It also fell apart.

2025-05-29

PILOT:

Meeting about Epson PILOTs

- 2X for Epson and 2X or 4X for internal use (1X laser 17-4, 1X wax 17-4, 1X laser Cu, 1X wax Cu)
- Compatible with laser, no depowdering,
- MRD: Market Requirements Document
 - Not really done for PILOT
- PRD: Product Requirements Document
 - Contains some high level requirements for market

- Operated by technicians and engineers
- Qualified for certain materials and sample parts
- Rajan's company is too busy to work on printer
- Current intent is to go with Trak employees as consultants
- Want them to be more aesthetically advanced to be used as a marketing tool by Epson
- TBD who will be building it, possibly Trak will do manufacturing and detail design with high-level direction from 3DEO employees
- Enable profitable prototyping
 - 1 hr NRE setup per part
 - High success rate producing minimally acceptable parts, aesthetically good but dimensions may not be exact
 - 1 week turnaround time for prototypes (1 week from customer's perspective)
 - Prototypes produced "as-is" without dimensional refinements
- Machine needs to be able to be upgraded to use wax deposition and laser hardware, but will not be necessary to be installed/tested for machine to ship to Epson
- Retain general design of PILOT 2 and 3
 - Tank-to-tank, fixed recoater, spindle, SVP, mist box, heater
 - Retain general gantry layout?
 - May use cantilevered structure from back wall
 - Aluminum extrusion frame
 - Base plate - Al or granite?
 - Increase Y and X travel
 - Same build plate size
 - Retain current control system - Raspberry Pi and Duet
 - Machine fully sealed for inerting
 - Redesign of build plate

PILOT: Continuous tapping works on PILOT 2. It seems that the roller axis was moving in the negative direction, and the negative limit of the roller axis was set to -100 mm, so once it hit that limit it would stop rotating.

HOPPER: Finished assembling gated HOPPER V3.3.7. I asked Mohsen to try and run a test print with the doser-style hopper tonight now that continuous dispense is working, but he may not have time to do that because he also has to document some of his laser experiments from this week. Payman has been pushing to switch from the doser-style hopper to the gated hopper in

PILOT 2, so my plan is to switch them out tomorrow morning, but once that has been done I suspect that we will not be reverting to the doser-style hopper anytime soon.

REDRESS: I post-processed some FormLabs Clear Cast resin molds and filled one with V14 coated 17-4 and one with copper (I think Ultrafine, but I'm not sure). I also did some research on AIBN, and it's possible that I have been overheating the powder when I thermally cure it; the typical decomposition temperature of AIBN is 80C or so. It has a half life of ~80 hours at 50C, 7 hours at 70C, and 9 minutes at 100C, while I have been curing the molds up to 135C (275F). I filled up a regular water-soluble mold with V14 17-4 powder and cured it to 80C (176 F) with a dwell of 1 hour; immediately after the dwell I pulled it out and the powder was somewhat cured but still quite soft and powdery. Claude's suggestion was 2-3 hours at 80C, and looking back at the numbers now I think a more appropriate time would indeed be ~3 hours at 80C.

2025-05-30

HOPPER: Mohsen ran a TRS coupon print last night with the doser-style hopper V4.0 on PILOT 2, and is going to try running it with non-flowable powder this morning. The gated HOPPER V3.3.7 is ready to be installed as soon as testing of the V4.0 HOPPER has been tested.

REDRESS: The green part water-soluble mold that was run at a lower temperature in the lower Keith furnace was still not bound completely, so I am running it through another cycle with a 1 hour dwell at 200F (93C, ~20 min half life) to try and complete crosslinking without burning off the AIBN. I am also experimenting with using TEG-DMA as a single-component binder. Historically I had good results with using a 10% binder load of pure liquid TEG-DMA with no added solvent to make a slurry; the green parts were completely waterproof and extremely strong, but also completely solid and so would be difficult to debind. I am trying something different today where I use a 3% TEG-DMA binder load but with 150 mL of added acetone blended with the TEG-DMA before making the powder slurry cake. There are two approaches I am trying with this slurry: one is to pour it directly into a water soluble mold, while the other is to dry the slurry and try to use the cake to make pourable powder. One thing of note is that the powder is not held in suspension with TEG-DMA blended with acetone; the powder particles settle out in the water-soluble mold. This has the disadvantage of the top of the green part being lower than the top of the mold, but it may prevent the issue I have seen previously of part shrinkage causing the green part to fracture as the solvent vaporizes.

R&D Meeting:

- Abandoning doser-style hopper for time being in favor of gated-style hopper
- Ignoring overflow for time being

To do next week:

- Install gated-style HOPPER V3.3.7 in PILOT 2
- Work on reducing powder wastage further with V3.3.8
 - Linear driven wedge
 - Will need linear guides and sufficient force to lift all powder in HOPPER
-

2025-06-02

HOPPER: Redesigned mounts for HOPPER V3.3.7.2 (gated HOPPER designed to be smaller than previous version so that it fits in the PILOT printer better). The new mounts enable the HOPPER to be adjusted using the Edmund Optics X axis lead screw drives that we have a bunch of around, previously used for manual adjustment of spindles in the Beta machines:

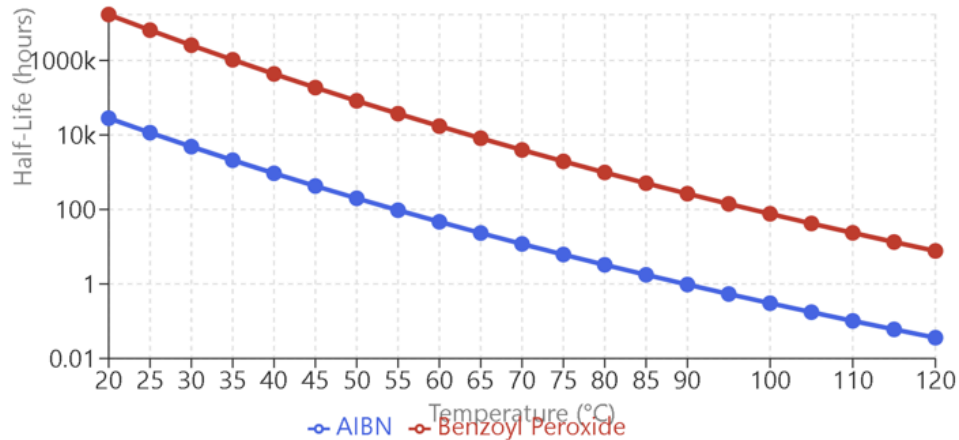
<https://www.edmundoptics.com/p/small-x-axis-lead-screw-drive/11767/?srsltid=AfmBOoryJPdkpyVvvN1iGDV3bU26lyMMbUz7qOLgMmHSB7j4N8H3ThIU> .

Designed and printed a new machine-side dovetail mount plate with a dovetail added 90mm to the left of the current mist box dovetail

Beginning design of HOPPER V3.4.0, the latest version of the gated HOPPER, that in theory will have near-zero waste.

REDRESS: I am working on a new binder formulation that uses Benzoyl Peroxide as the thermal initiator instead of AIBN. AIBN has a much shorter half life, leading to faster decomposition at curing temperatures, but possibly more critically it may decompose over time at room temperature. It really should be stored in a refrigerator, but I have kept it stored at room temperature, which may have lead to my inability to recreate earlier results. It also has a very short half life at the curing temperatures I have been using, which could mean that it decomposes before it has a chance to fully crosslink the binder. My instinct, though, is that it has been degrading in storage over the several months that I have had it and that is at least one of the factors leading to my recent poor green part quality.

Half-Life vs Temperature: AIBN vs Benzoyl Peroxide



2025-06-03

New dovetail mount for Payman's setup is printed, so I just need to install 9X M5 heat-set inserts for it to be ready for use.

HOPPER: HOPPER V3.3.7.2 body is printed and ready for post-processing and installation of heat-set inserts. This is not the zero-waste HOPPER design, but is the latest spring steel gated style HOPPER adapted for use in PILOT 2. It has now been fully assembled and installed in PILOT 2, and is ready for leveling and testing. I am continuing to work on the design of HOPPER V3.4.0, the first zero-waste gated hopper design. My design concept at the moment is to use a horizontally-moving steel blade at the bottom of the hopper that is moved and guided by a pair of the Edmunds optics adjustment stages.

Laser IP Meeting:

[Sign in to access Google Drive Document](#)

- Localized curing of binder
 - Powder pre-coated with binder (photosensitive or thermally cured)
 - Photosensitive sprayed binder
- Pre-sintering of part to increase green strength, dimensional accuracy, and control warpage during sintering
- Selective oxidation of regions of parts
- Controlled porosity at different regions of parts
- Laser sintering or melting combined with binder jetting

Biweekly cleanup

REDRESS: I finished drying and ground and sieved a batch of V15 coated powder and loaded some into a low-temperature water-soluble 3D printed mold, then put it in a thermal curing cycle that heats it to 250F and dwells there for 7 hours. This is based on Claude's graph, which suggests that at 120C the half life of Benzoyl Peroxide is 7.7 hours. Considering the time to ramp up to peak and time to cool back down to room temperature, a dwell of 7 hours at that temperature should roughly decompose all the Benzoyl Peroxide. However, the chart from Sigma Aldrich suggests that the decomposition half life of Benzoyl Peroxide is ~30 minutes at 100C, and so is presumably shorter at higher temperatures, so a dwell that long would be inappropriate if that chart is correct.

2025-06-04

HOPPER: The gated HOPPER V3.3.7.2 is functional and installed in PILOT 2. The pulley printed from FormLabs clear resin on the keyed shaft shattered, so I replaced it with an aluminum pulley. I also wrote some macros to open and close the gate, although there is no mechanical feature preventing the gate from opening too far, which is a pain because the stainless steel sheet needs to be carefully threaded back into its guides. The hopper is not operating on PILOT 2, and seems to be able to successfully spread layers.

REDRESS: The most recent test was unsuccessful; the part broke apart during mold dissolution. I am considering moving back to using PVP-VA coated powder and adding a chemical to waterproof it before dissolving off the mold.

PILOT:

Meeting with Manjun to discuss PILOT BOM.

- Quote for extrusion lengths from Vention
- List of 3D printed parts
- STEP file to Manjun

2025-06-05

HOPPER: Gated hopper being tested in PILOT 2 by Mohsen. Continuing work on design of zero-waste gated hopper.

Slicer Meeting: 1 hour 40 minute meeting on features for the slicer ZZ is currently developing. The meeting was mostly very low-level focused on specific instances and part features that have caused issues in the past. From a high level, the slicer ZZ is developing is not based on a commercial 3DP slicer.

PILOT:

PRD Meeting

- Sold as 6 month project
- PO for \$850K
- Priority order: schedule, then scope, then cost
- ~\$100K each
- Largely identical to PILOTs 2 and 3, with some industrial design upgrades and safety/electrical upgrades per Epson engineer recommendations

To Do:

- **Estimate space requirements for all hardware by 6/13 (assume same build plate size, add hopper and vulcan jet dispenser and second spindle)**

2025-06-06

Next Gen Tech Review Meeting:

- Rajan created a document of risks and concerns
 - Looking for a plan for testing of each subsystem (laser, wax, hopper, spread/spray) and testing of subsystem integration
 - Also wants energy req'd to heat binder in 1 cc of bound powder
- Includes laser-assisted Intelligent Layering process, Epson Pilot, spread and spray system, IPP (Internal Production Pilot), no depowdering system (wax), wax/laser interaction
- Asked about physical effects underlying what we are seeing
 - Laser energy absorbed by metal powder
 - Heats and vaporizes binder, producing gases that blow out powder
 - Effect may work differently when wax is involved
 - Sensitive to binder composition and load
- More melting/burning from NIR, clean cut from blue laser
 - May be caused by increased blue laser absorption by water <?>
- NIR and mid-IR often used for ceramics, visible absorbed better into metal <?>
- There is precedent for melting metal powder with low power blue lasers
- Initial objectives:
 - Confirm hypothesis of physical mechanism underlying observed effect
 - Determine different variables/process parameters that impact effect

- Laser power, wavelength, cut speed, dot size
- Process limitations
 - Material compatibility
 - Binder compatibility
- Extensive precedent for laser ablation machining of green bodies using metal and ceramic powders, with and without binder

To Do:

- **Summarize laser technologies**

- Q-switched lasers
- Fiber lasers
 - MOPA laser
- CO2 lasers
- Diode lasers

R&D Weekly Meeting

Free flow hopper design is currently highest priority; doser style testing is deferred to some time in the future. Density testing is the priority; since preliminary tests with the doser-style hopper did not yield good density, it has been essentially abandoned for now.

Per Payman, goal of laser is to increase cutting speed and enable manufacturing of fine features.

To Do:

- **Add limit switch to free flow hopper on Monday - done**
- **Mix up some paraffin with PE-CVA to increase viscosity**
- **Mount Vulcan Jet on PILOT 1 - done**
- **Design new LVP**

2025-06-09

Epson Pilot Space Requirements

- Assuming a tank-to-tank system where all components on the gantry need to be able to access both build and powder feed tanks (worst case scenario)

- Build plate and tank size 5.5"X5.5"
- 3/8" bridge between powder and build tanks
- $5.5 \times 2 + .375 = 11.375$, round up to 12" for powder/build module
- Nordson Asymtek (largest component protruding from X axis): 4.5"
- X axis length in Y direction with mount:

PILOT: Working on estimating the Y axis gantry travel required for the worst case of the Epson PILOT printer.

HOPPER: Installed a limit switch on the hopper on PILOT 2, but I don't like how the design came out. Because the gate holder is able to shift along the keyed shaft, and because of how I oriented the limit switch, it would be possible for it to trip at different points depending on how the shaft shifts. I will redesign it so that it reliably trips in the same gate holder position and print a new mount tonight.

REDRESS: I am dissolving some ParaPlast paraffin in some N-Heptane to test whether they are compatible for cleaning the MicroDrop unit that Pourya is working on that has become clogged, and also to use as a possible waterproofing agent for green parts produced using the REDRESS process. I received a new roll of AquaSys 120 filament (the higher temperature water-soluble filament) and filled it with some V15 powder that I am now cooking in the upper Keith furnace with a 30 minute dwell at a peak temperature of 275F.

NEXTGEN: I made an aluminum plate with holes drilled in it to be used as a mount for the Nordson Asymtek head on PILOT 1. I have concerns about the extra torque being applied to the X axis stage because the Nordson Asymtek head is about a 1 K, which is applied cantilevered about 75mm away from the stage, but it remains to be tested whether that is indeed an issue. I am also working on a document summarizing various available laser types: [Laser Technologie](#)

[S](#) .

2025-06-10

NEXTGEN/PILOT: The aluminum mount I made yesterday works, but because the Nordson Asymtek dispensing head is mounted to the side of the spindle it takes up enough space that the spindle and dispensing head cannot address the same area of the bed. I am pursuing two approaches to resolve this: one is printing a new spindle mount that is mirrored from the original and so has the vacuum line attachment point on the side of the spindle mount opposite from the

dispensing head, and the other is to make a longer aluminum mount that places the dispensing head in front of the spindle.

I am working to dissolve 15g of PE-CVA in 100g of ParaPlast paraffin. I have them on the heated mixer plate set to 80C and 800 RPM mixing speed. The paraffin melted in a few hours, but the PE-CVA is taking a while to dissolve. Historically I have seen that it first swells as it absorbs the paraffin and eventually dissolves, but the process will likely take overnight.

HOPPER: Test fit the various limit switch mounts printed last night. It seemed that the limit switch would be triggered before the gate is fully open, so I printed 3 more limit switch mounts with the limit switches mounted at different distances from the gate holder in 1mm increments. The middle one seemed like it would work OK, so I installed it and placed the hopper on the blue and silver gantry that Payman has been using for testing gated hoppers.

REDRESS: I treated a green part with paraffin dissolved in N-Heptane and let it dry overnight, then tried to dissolve off the mold and it completely fell apart. When I put several drops of the N-Heptane/paraffin solution on a surface and let it dry out for a few minutes, the solution did not seem to reconstitute into pure paraffin. It is possible that a thin layer of paraffin is formed on the surface of the drops when the surface solvent evaporates, and this thin layer prevents further evaporation of the solvent.

2025-06-11

NEXTGEN: The PE-CVA pellets have swollen more overnight, but they have not dissolved completely, so I increased the temperature to 90C. The extended aluminum mount I made yesterday for the Nordson Asymtek head on PILOT 1 seems to be usable, but I am still working on a print of a mirrored spindle holder. It printed last night mostly successfully, although there are cured resin fragments in the tank that suggest it is not printing perfectly. I have seen this happen before when the slide and leadscrew of the Formlabs printer are not properly greased, so at some point I will grease those components and clean out the Tough 1500 tank.

HOPPER: The print of the HOPPER V3.4.0 (zero waste gated style) body failed last night, but the miscellaneous greebles did print successfully. HOPPER V3.3.7.2 is currently being tested on PILOT 2 by Payman.

REDRESS: The water-soluble mold filled with TEG-DMA slurry bulged outward during the curing cycle last night, despite the peak temperature being set to 250F. I filled a water-soluble mold and a ceramic crucible with powder coated with PMMA and TEG-DMA without a free radical initiator, and the green part formed in the crucible seems fairly waterproof. When the green part is first immersed in water you can see that bubbles come out of the green part all over it, so

clearly water is able to flow into the interstitial spaces between bound particles, but the part still holds its shape. I have a theory that one of the causes of the part formed in a water-soluble mold breaking apart is that it absorbs water and swells, but because the water-soluble mold prevents it from swelling outward, the swelling force causes the part to fragment. I cut the bottom off the water-soluble mold that I made last night with powder coated in PMMA/TEG-DMA and soaked the bottom with PVP-VA binder and the part started to break apart. I also soaked the top 1 cm of the part with paraffin with PE-CVA

PILOT PRD Meeting:

- Options are to replicate current PILOTs with minimal electrical upgrades, or to take longer and do the same changes with additional upgrades for beautifying and enabling future upgrades (laser, wax, etc.).
- Still waiting on response from Trak; seems unlikely that they are interested in this project
- **To Do: Spec out and price a stage for Y axis 48" stroke and X axis 18" stroke**
 - https://www.tolomatic.com/wp-content/uploads/2022/05/3600-4222_08_TRS_cat-1.pdf

2025-06-12

NEXTGEN: Gave a mist box catch for the ULTRA Mist Box V2 to Payman, and redesigned and reprinted it based on his experience with it. Gave a hopper side dovetail mount printed last night to Payman. Entered an order for two types of polymer for increasing wax viscosity:

<https://www.sigmaaldrich.com/US/en/product/ambeedinc/ambh9a9ac98a?context=bbe>

(Ethylene-vinyl acetate copolymer) and

<https://www.sigmaaldrich.com/US/en/product/aldrich/437247> (Poly(ethylene-co-vinyl acetate)).

The second polymer is one that I have dissolved in paraffin previously in order to reduce shrinkage and act as a binder when the wax is melted out for the REDRESS process.

HOPPER: Printed out the body of the zero-waste free-flow hopper, but I noticed that the motor mounts will interfere with the Y axis stages so I will need to redesign and reprint the body.

2025-06-13

HOPPER: In process of redesigning zero-waste hopper body to enable it to fit within the PILOT printer.

REDRESS: In process of melting paraffin/PE-CVA wax out of a vacuum-impregnated green part. Vacuum impregnated another green part (binder V15) with hard microcrystalline wax.

NEXTGEN: In process of mixing a wax formulation that is 95% hard microcrystalline wax and 5% PE-CVA to make a higher viscosity wax for the Nordson Asymtek dispensing head. The wax formulation completed mixing and I poured it into a pie tin to cool.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

To Do Next Week:

- **Integrate tank-to-tank spreader bar into free flow hopper and increase opening**
 - **Print another SVP**
 - **New LVP**
-
- Free flow hopper gave better density uniformity of TRS bars as compared with line dispense of doser-style hopper, but lower density than the tank-to-tank system (~57 vs ~51).

2025-06-16

NEXTGEN: Mixing up a new batch of 95% hard microcrystalline wax / 5% PE-CVA in a (loosely) closed jar for Pourya to test. The batch I made previously seemed to have some visible FOD in it, so this one will hopefully have less contamination because it is sealed. At the same time, Pourya is trying to filter out the contaminated batch using some 5 micron syringe filters from McMaster.

REDRESS: I have a total of 5 green parts I am running through a modified furnace cycle to melt out the wax; there are four nozzles with one partial nozzle tip. The new furnace cycle goes to a peak temperature of 300F in several stages with 2 hour dwells at each stage. I believe the three temperatures are 198, 250, 300. They were made using various binders and different waxes, but look fairly equivalent. I am also making a new batch of V15 coated powder to compare with the V15 batch I have been using.

HOPPER: Mainly working on the new hopper design (V3.5.0) that uses the same spreader bar as the PILOT printers. The design intent is to have a hopper that is as similar to V3.3.7.2 as possible, with the only difference being the larger spreader bar. Also continuing to work on the zero-waste free flow hopper (V3.4.0).

PXL: In the process of thermal interference fitting copper parts to stainless steel bases in preparation for electron beam welding tomorrow. There are three geometries, so I assembled one of each geometry without processing the parts other than the acetone cleaning last week, and I plan to assemble one of each geometry with copper parts that have been acid descaled. Supposedly surface oxides inhibit electron beam welding, so I will quickly assemble the parts

and vacuum seal them in nitrogen with a desiccant packet to preserve them for testing tomorrow.

2025-06-17

PXL: Went to Electron Beam Engineering in Anaheim with Marcus to run test EBW welds on some PXL thermal interference fit parts. There were chronic issues with weld cracking. The cracks were small enough that they were not visible to the naked eye or on pictures taken up close with a phone, but they were detectable with the helium leak test used at EBE. The cracks were also highly localized, generally no more than 5mm in length along a weld that is a total of ~80mm. There was one unit that was completely sealed, so the process can work, but it may take some part modifications to make the process more robust. The welds completed on the lift pin holes where the copper was ~1mm higher than the level of the stainless steel, however, came out well. This suggests that it may be possible to make copper parts that are 1mm higher than the stainless steel and form welds robustly. Because copper is so much more thermally conductive than stainless steel, it is necessary to direct most of the heat into the copper, but because of the thin copper flange there is a tendency for the weld to melt through the flange. With a thicker copper part, it is possible to melt the copper and roll down the edge to the stainless steel, where the heat from the copper is conducted into the stainless steel, melting it, and joining the two parts.

REDRESS: Filled a mold with V15 powder and cured it overnight.

2025-06-18

HOPPER: Worked on assembling hoppers V3.4.0 and V3.5.0. Noted that the side mounts are shallow enough that the M3 screws protrude too far into the carriage of the Edmund Optics adjusting stages, causing them to lock up. I redesigned the mounts and will print new ones.

REDRESS: Impregnated green part made last night with 85% ParaPlast paraffin / 15% PE-CVA solution and in process of dissolving off mold. Began mixing up binder in preparation for making a 1kg batch of Inconel 625 coated powder using Inconel powder waste. Printing a new water soluble mold that has internal channels.

Call with Techcon, a company based in Cypress, CA that makes wax dispensing heads similar to the Nordson Asymtek system. They offer free applications testing, are open to us visiting their facility to test our paraffin in their system, offer nozzles in sizes from 50-400 micron, and have a

dispense rate of up to 1500 Hz but recommend keeping it around 150 Hz for production applications because the piezo actuator tends to heat at higher frequencies.

PILOT: Based on discussions with Will, I looked back at the PILOT CAD and found that the stroke of the Y stages is actually closer to 615mm and the stroke of the Saffron stages is close to 670mm, so a 48" stage would be WAY oversized for what we need.

2025-06-19

HOPPER: Mohsen removed the hopper from PILOT 2 because it had been having issues with not closing completely. This seems to be due to a buildup of powder on top of the metal gate strip, likely as a result of powder leakage out of the hopper. I am working on scavenging parts from it for the new hopper I am working on that uses the standard PILOT spreader bar. In the meantime, Mohsen is going to run baseline tests with the tank-to-tank setup.

PILOT: 2.5 hour meeting to discuss Epson PILOT program. Sounds like the goal of the program right now is to make 2 PILOTs to send to Epson that are as similar to PILOTs 2 and 3 as possible, with several safety upgrades and a larger chamber volume to enable use of the full stroke of the current X and Y stages. The plan is to have these complete by October, with some number of similar PILOTs ready for internal use by December.

2025-06-20

HOPPER: Continuing to work on larger roller and zero-waste free flow hopper.

PILOT: Talked with Manju for ~1 hour to help him with inventory.

R&D Weekly Meeting:

Green density generally indicates distribution of powder, green strength generally indicates distribution of binder.

To Do:

- **Complete and install updated free flow hopper with larger spreader bar**
- **Add vibrator to free flow hopper with larger spreader bar**
- **Look into metal safe compact vacuums**

Epson Project Update Meeting:

- October 15 date is critical, not sure if that means machine completion, machine testing completion, or ship date

2025-06-23

HOPPER: Finished assembling gated hopper with two limit switches to detect open and closed state. I had redesigned the side mounts to work with 6mm long M3 screws, but in redesigning it I made the side mounts 1mm thicker which meant the hopper would not fit within the Y gantry cutout, so I reverted to the older side mount design and gave the hopper to Ben to install in PILOT 2.

Continuing to work on zero-waste hopper design. Figuring out how to integrate limit switches into the design to ensure that the gate opens or closes when commanded to do so.

PILOT: Working on modifying design of PILOT base plate and frame for the Epson PILOT printers.

2025-06-24

PILOT: Continued work on design modifications of PILOT printer for Epson.

 [Sign in](#) to access [Google Drive Spreadsheet](#)

HOPPER: Completed gated hopper with larger diameter spreader bar. It seems to be having issues with incomplete spreading after several layers, so Mohsen is adding a vibrator motor to it. It also has two limit switches now, one that detects opening and one that detects when it is closed, so operation should be more robust.

2025-06-25

PILOT: Continuing to refine the design of the PILOT-E. Discussed machined parts with Manjun to confirm which parts are needed and which are obsolete.

HOPPER: I accidentally started the print last night with the red PLA-CF instead of the brown, so the print did not complete because it ran out of filament and was the wrong material anyway (Payman wanted to try the brown PLA-CF because it seemed to work better on past free flow hoppers).

2025-06-26

PILOT: Continuing to work on CAD and design details (vacuum etc.).

HOPPER: Installed heat set inserts in new hopper V3. The zero-waste hopper is assembled and able to open and close with a 3D printed blade. It is very slow with the stepper motor controller I use for testing, but should be able to run faster in the pilot printers with the Duet board running

it. I have the two motors just wired in parallel so that they can be run with a single stepper driver; it seems to be working so far.

2025-06-27

PILOT: Refining CAD for design review on Monday (finishing sizing of frame and doors so that the side extrusion of the doors does not go higher than the top of the enclosure, added in new larger cable carrier, etc.)

Weekly R&D Meeting:

HOPPER: Working on updated version of zero-waste bladed-gate hopper based on learnings from the testing Mohsen ran this week (larger diameter spreader bar, in-powder vibration).

2025-06-30

HOPPER: Ben and Mohsen assembled the brown PLA hopper V3.5.0 and are currently testing it in PILOT 2. I am working on designing a way to apply vibration to the powder directly with some sort of structure that is inserted into the powder. This will hopefully replicate and automate the manual stirring process that Mohsen used to get good density results in testing last week. Mohsen and Ben are pursuing an alternative design that vibrates a thin sheet of spring steel (~0.010") inserted vertically into the hopper aligned with the X axis. I drilled several holes in the sheet they selected to mount a vibrator motor and to install screws to act as stops to prevent the sheet from falling into the hopper. I am printing the part that holds the 4X pointed rods that insert into the powder in the hopper. The part will be vibration isolated from the hopper by silicone rubber strips.

PILOT: CAD update meeting. I raised concerns about decreased rigidity and increased vibration with the larger base plate and frame. Since the Y stages are farther apart, the Y gantry needed to be widened, which will result in less rigidity and possible sagging of components. I also have concerns about whether Epson will be happy with a printer that is considerably larger than the first 3 pilots, but that is ultimately more a business decision than a technical decision. We also discussed the design of the new mist box; Sean is working on a design that is made from machined aluminum instead of the current 3D printed PLA.

2025-07-01

HOPPER: AI finished machining the blade for the zero-waste hopper, and I installed it for Payman to conduct benchtop testing. The bladed gate is able to open and close, but it appears

to have difficulty spreading a flat layer without being mounted to a rigid gantry, so it needs to be tested on one of the pilot printers. Continued working on the vibrating rod insert. I have cut rods to roughly the right length and ground a small chamfer on them; machining them to a point was deemed too difficult with the available equipment. The orientation I used for printing the vibrating rod insert plate was correct for the motor mount but incorrect for the rod mount, so I have separated it into two parts that I will print tonight.

PILOT: Spent a few hours going over the current pilot printers with Rajan and Manjun to finalize the current components list. Discussed which parts will be 3D printed vs machined (all parts that are currently being printed will continue being printed, other than the mist box). Had a meeting with Will, Rajan, and Manjun to discuss CAD, drawings, and timelines. Per Rajan's request I am going to reduce the width of the cutout in the Y axis gantry to the original width in pilots 1-3. I repeated the point 3 times that this limits space to install wider components and also limits access to components from the top.

2025-07-02

3DEO Technical Team Sync: Current & Upcoming Tech Improvements

1.5 hour meeting with Scott, Rajan, Payman, Marcus, and all of the technical staff at 3DEO. It entailed Scott and Rajan discussing their various philosophies of business and product development and their view of the future of 3DEO and the technologies we are currently pursuing. At two points Scott asked if anyone had any questions; there were none.

Part Benchmarking Meeting

Four different geometries were printed by Xometry and Protolabs using DMLS and binder jetting and compared with 3DEO's parts and pricing structure. 3DEO has a lower per-part cost and higher quality parts, but also has a significant minimum order quantity based on the build plate size (51 for the parts benchmarked).

PILOT Printer Discussion W/ Payman, Marcus, Rajan, Mahmood (informal):

It sounds like the plan as it is right now is to make 2 pilot printers to send to Epson by mid october then make 2 identical printers for in-house use by mid december. I was pushing to purchase off-the-shelf glove boxes and recirculating gas management systems for the two in-house printers, such as systems available from <https://lctechinc.com/> . This would give us precise environmental control, a completely inert internal environment, and complete operator safety without investing significant internal resources. My pitch was ultimately rejected; inerting the pilot printers is not a requirement for the foreseeable future, it is thought that it is not

possible to develop a workflow where the printers can be operated without regularly opening large doors to access the mechanical systems, thinks it would be easy to make the pilot printers airtight as they are right now, and inhalation of stainless steel powder is deemed an acceptable risk for machine operators.

R&D Weekly Meeting NEXTGEN:

To Do:

Burnout test of different waxes - done

Order/test 2 flute end mill - Mason testing various end mills, trying to get a single flute .020" cut diameter end mill

Filter custom wax blend - done

Increase hopper size - hopper extension printed

Add limit switches to zero-waste hopper - 1 limit switch added for closing, hard stop present for opening

2025-07-03

PILOT: Discussed power supply requirements with Manjun. One issue that I had forgotten about is that the heater needs to be converted to DC power; this will necessitate a >500W 12VDC power supply to be added that is dedicated to the heater. Also, I need to spec out some lights for the printers. Per Pourya's request, I will select lights that are external to the primary machine chamber to minimize heat input to the chamber.

HOPPER: Ben is in the process of installing the zero-waste gated hopper into Pilot 3. I accidentally printed two of the same modified side mount brackets, but there are different versions for each side, so I am in the process of printing 1 of the correct brackets that are needed.

I am also in the process of assembling the vibrating rod - based powder vibration system.

2025-07-07

PILOT: Working with Manju and Pourya to spec out wires and cables for the Epson pilot printers. The color code I used on PILOTs 1-3 is compatible with the Japanese color code:

 [Sign in](#) to access [Google Drive Spreadsheet](#)

. In Japan, it is optional to use either red or black for single

phase line voltage, but it would be better for use to use black because the cables sold by McMaster use the black-white-green American color code.

HOPPER: Printed new Edmunds stage to Y axis mounts for the bladed hopper V3.4.0 because the older ones did not allow the hopper to be raised high enough that the spreader bar was clear of the base plate. Continuing to work on installing a limit switch to detect whether the gate has completely opened or closed. It is challenging because of the space limitations, mainly the fact that the opening in the Y axis gantry is so small, and the hopper needs to fit within that space to be able to be dropped in from above.

NEXTGEN: Played with some different end mill options to see if changing geometry or wax formulation can reduce wax buildup. I tried a stock end mill (.020" cutting diameter, .060" LOC, 4 flute, coated but exact coating formulation is unknown), an end mill from McMaster that has 2 flutes but has a 1/8" shank diameter and so it incompatible with the .09375" diameter collets in the spindles currently being used in the Pilot printers,

2025-07-08

Bagel Tuesday: Emily discussed hiring for various positions, including several high-level positions for developing next-generation printers. There were several anonymous questions asked. One was asking why the pay scales for the recent job postings were much higher than what current engineers are getting, and their response was that the pay scales match what people are getting paid right now. Since the job postings are for positions that are level V and VI, so this suggests that at least Midhun and I are essentially junior-level engineers, since our pay is below the lowest pay of the pay scale. Another question asked was about 3DEO's 1 year and 5 year plans. The 1 year plan is to stabilize the company, sell parts made with the laser and wax deposition technologies, sell parts made with inconel, prototype parts profitably, reduce our cash burn by 1/2 by adding commercial revenue. In roughly 2 years we expect to be selling next-generation printers. Within 5 years, the plan is to sell the company. The third question asked was what exactly Epson expects for their investment in 3DEO; the answer was that they expect to be first in line for acquiring us if and when that makes sense.

HOPPER: Gave overview of hopper history and purpose to Mason Gunn, a new R&D ME intern who started today. Modified design of bladed hopper as a result of some issues encountered with the blade riding up the hopper edge and motor mount breaking.

PILOT: Meeting reviewing machined part drawings. I raised a concern about bowing of the plate due to weight of the powder and build tank and suggested we increase the base plate from 1/2" to 3/4", but the decision was ultimately made to keep it the same.

NEXTGEN: Placed wax filtering setup in lower Keith furnace set to dwell for 2 hours at 220F.

2025-07-08

NEXTGEN: Experimenting with reaming the collets in the dental spindles we are using to fit end mills with a standard 1/8" shank. It is difficult to find end mills with the smaller stock shank size that the spindles use; I have so far had two different tool makers no-quote my request for a tool bit with a .09375" shank because they can't grind something that small. Reaming the collet will cause some loss of precision and increased runout, but that may be acceptable for basic proof-of-concept testing. I have ordered several end mill options to try from McMaster and placed an order request to order an end mill from Harvey Tool for a single-flute end mill option.

PILOT: Meeting with Manjun to discuss the updated electrical BOM with components that are specified by Novo. Steve agreed with me that the base plate should be made thicker. We are both concerned about distortion from weight, distortion from installation, and distortion during machining from the original ground state. There also is no real disadvantage to a thicker plate; it would cost slightly more and would be slightly heavier if we bumped the thickness up to 3/4" (20 Kg to 30 Kg), but those are largely irrelevant concerns within the scope of this project.

Meeting with Will and Sean to go over the part machining drawings for the Epson Pilot printers.

HOPPER: Printed a new V3.4.0 bladed hopper with some strength upgrades and mounting points for hard stops/limit switches to prevent overtravel of the blade. It also has mounting points for a funnel to expand the capacity of the hopper.

2025-07-10

NEXTGEN: Bored out the collet on a Beta dental spindle to fit a 1/8" end mill. I bored it out in the closed state so that if I bore it out to slightly less than the end mill shank diameter (in theory) it will fit the end mill when open. I first reamed it to .122", which was too small to fit the end mill even when the collet was open. I then drilled it to .125", which was still too small. I then drilled it to .1285" (#30 drill bit) and the end mill could fit when the collet was open but was loose even when the collet was closed. For now I super glued the most promising end mill (1/16" diameter, 1 flute, ceramic coated carbide) into the collet, which means the spindle will be essentially scrap once the end mill testing is complete, but it is the fastest way to test a single flute end mill. I will order a .126" reamer and try that, which hopefully will be the sweet spot where the end mill will fit when the collet is open but be held in place when the collet is closed.

Made a new formulation of wax that is 90% paraffin and 10% stearic acid, with the intent of making a harder formulation of wax that is still possible to debind cleanly.

The paraffin burnout test done last night heating a ceramic crucible with .5g of paraplax paraffin to 1000F yielded the expected result: it burned out completely, with a few particles left in the crucible that I believe are ceramic fragments that fell from the top of the furnace.

HOPPER: Designed and printing limit switch mounts/hardstops for zero-waste hopper V3.4.0. Designed hopper extension that will increase hopper powder capacity by 150% of what it is right now.

2025-07-11

HOPPER: Completed assembling latest iteration of zero-waste hopper. It now has a limit switch to detect when it is fully closed, which should prevent overdriving the gate, which can cause the gate to bow outwards and, at best, cause a poor layer, and at worst, cause the gate to crash into the machine or build plate. The hopper is ready to be installed into the machine, but the machine needs to be wired to detect a limit switch input. I asked Pourya to do this whenever he has a chance and I asked Ben to install the hopper in Pilot 3.

Designing a new blade for the zero-waste hopper with a much sharper angle (20 degrees vs the current 45 degrees).

NEXTGEN: I removed the two ceramic crucibles from the upper Keith furnace that had gone through a burnout cycle last night, testing the burnout properties of hard microcrystalline wax and the 85% paraffin/15% PE-CVA blend. The results were promising; the microcrystalline wax showed very minimal residue and the blend showed a slight amount of residue.

I also learned about a different kind of wax that may be useful: it is called Synthetic Fischer-Tropsch (FT) Wax and is a synthesized wax that in theory has a more standardized chemical structure than paraffin, since there are so many variations of paraffin available.

PILOT: Meeting with Manju and Will about frame design for Epson Pilot.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

HOPPER: Mohsen encountered mechanical issues with Hopper V3.4.0, so

TO DO:

Ben was seeing issues with the zero-waste hopper on Pilot 3, check with him for details.

Hopper cannot be raised sufficiently even with adjuster stages at maximum position, need to redesign and reprint. - done

Make new blade with sharper angle

- **Design and print new hopper body to match angle - done**
- **Design and print new blade mounts to match hole spacing - done**
- **Have new blade made**

Design sheet metal based powder vibration system - mount to somewhere on the Y gantry

Modify a spindle collet to hold a 1/8" shank diameter end mill and measure the runout

Filter more custom wax - Filtered a bottle of Paraffin/PE-CVA wax and a bottle of Paraffin/Stearic Acid wax - done

Design new PILOT heater based around 12V bulbs - done

Set up and test StoneVac AM vacuum cleaner

2025-07-14

HOPPER: Printed two new Y gantry mount brackets for the zero-waste hopper in pilot 3 and gave them to Ben to install.

PILOT: Worked on design of heater for Epson pilots. This version has 12V bulbs instead of the current 120 VAC bulbs to ensure that there are no high-voltage wires running into the machine enclosure, it has a heat shield to protect operators from touching hot metal, it has two fans for active cooling of the inner reflector, and a copper heat sink to provide threads for mounting the bulb holders and to enable a thermostatic switch to be mounted to detect if the system is overheating and cut power to it if necessary.

Worked with Manju to add items to the BOM.

NEXTGEN: Filtering more of the 85% ParaPlast Paraffin / 15% PE-CVA wax for Pourya to use with the VulcanJet wax drop dispensing head.

2025-07-15

NEXTGEN: Did a burnout test of 1g of the 90/10 paraffin/stearic acid wax. There was a very small amount of black particles left behind, which is worse than any of the other burnout tests (other than the first one, which left a large amount of black sludge-like residue).

Working on modifying a Beta spindle to accept 1/8" shank diameter end mills. My procedure is to remove the spindle and collet assembly, which is naturally closed when removed. I chuck it in the lathe and align it, then use a reamer to expand the hole. I started with a .122" reamer, which did not allow the end mill to be fully inserted when the collet was open (after the collet/spindle assembly was reinstalled in the tool). I then tried a .1285" diameter #30 drill bit, which allowed the tool to slip even when the collet was closed. I then used a .1245" reamer, which did not allow the end mill to be inserted fully, much like the .122" end mill. I suspect that there is a diameter between .1245" and .1285" that would work, but for the moment the runout with a tool inserted in the collet reamed out to .1245" seems to not have visible runout, so I deemed it good enough for Mason to start testing with it.

HOPPER: Removed limit switch from the zero-waste gated hopper in pilot 3 so Pourya could rewire it; I wired it to be normally closed originally, which is generally preferred because if the wire is cut it reads as the switch being pressed, but apparently the rest of the limit switches on

the pilot printers are wired to be normally open. I believe I standardized that originally because only normally open Metrol limit switches were available from Automation Direct when I was first ordering parts for pilot 1, and it became a de facto standard from then on. This is an interesting case of how an engineering decision can be propagated through design iterations even though the original motivation is not there, even when the engineering decision is sub-optimal for the application. Anyway, I removed the limit switch, Pourya rewired it, and I installed it. It is possible to remove and reinstall the limit switch while the hopper is installed, but it is unergonomic enough that I would not want anyone else to do it that way.

Biweekly cleanup in preparation for IHI/FusionX/someone tour on Thursday.

2025-07-16

HOPPER: Post-processed and populated with heat set inserts the hopper Payman asked me to print that is a modified version of V3.3.5 (spring steel gated, extended shaft supported by two bearings). He modified it so that it uses a feature on the 3D printed body as the spreader bar instead of a metal part and reduced the outlet gap width, both presumably to reduce waste. I also populated a new version of the linear-motion zero-waste hopper with threaded inserts. This is a version modified to accept a sharper blade (20° angle instead of the previous 45° angle blade). There are also some minor dimensional changes I made to increase strength and improve rigidity and alignment of the linear adjustment stages.

Payman gave Al the drawing and stock for making the sharper blade, since Philip has not responded to my email or Slack message. Al will need to order a chamfering bit to be able to make it

Keyence Demo:

Keyence LM-X system was demoed with sample parts and with a copper heatsink that we had printed. It is a metrology system similar to the IM, except it has a standard touch probe (the physical probes they buy from Renishaw) and confocal laser height gage along with the optical system the IM has. It also has greater edge distinguishing ability with its optical system because it uses higher magnification than the IM as well as an “open aperture” (meaning large aperture) camera, yielding a smaller depth of field that enables any features other than the target feature to be out of focus. It can measure up to 1000 parts at a time, can conduct 5000 measurements in one cycle, and has a total system cost of ~\$94K. This includes a PC and a calibration target. It can generate a heat map from multiple discrete height measurements, and the probe enables it to measure vertical or angled surfaces. It is billed as being a system somewhere between a CMM and a pure optical system like the IM. Apparently the IM has a “light probe,” an illuminated

ball that is touched off of parts being measured. I have heard anecdotal evidence from coworkers that it is not accurate, but I have not verified that independently.

PILOT: The StoneVac AM vacuum cleaner from Vaniman showed up and I have begun assembling it in preparation for testing with powder. It is a simple design but it seems fairly robust, and is surprisingly quiet in operation (other than its vibrating filter cleaner, which is quite loud). It came with an ESD-safe cyclone separator that is screwed to the side of the vacuum unit.

2025-07-17

PILOT: Started work on CAD design of electrical subpanel for Epson Pilot printers.

NEXTGEN: Working on making a wax that is 75% hard microcrystalline wax and 25% PE-CVA. It is difficult to keep the mixture liquid because of the high melting point of hard microcrystalline wax; I currently have the hot plate in the wax testing fume hood set to 160°C to keep the mixture liquid for mixing with a PTFE magnetic stirrer, but I have not checked whether that is sufficient to keep the whole batch liquid (it tends to stay liquid towards the bottom but solidifies towards the top). The batch is a total of 100g. I had to bump the temperature up to 180°C, I'll see if that is sufficient.

2025-07-18

PILOT: Working on the design of the electrical subpanel for the Epson pilots.

2025-07-21

PILOT: Continuing to work on the CAD design of the electrical subpanel. Received a new electrical schematic, which is improved but still incomplete.

R&D Meeting:

To Do:

- **Assemble zero-waste hopper with sharper blade - done**
- **Design zero-waste hopper with machined arc-segment spreader bar and a double-thickness blade**

HOPPER: Changed layer target temperature in an attempt to reduce layer time. Baseline temperature is 24.5C pre-spread, 25.5 pre-cut. Changed to 27/28 for one test and 30/29 ? on glass plate and 27/28 for two experiments on an aluminum base plate. Print time was >12 hours for the baseline test, ~7.5 hrs for the glass plate, ~6.5 hrs for the aluminum base plate. Layer time was generally shorter with the aluminum build plate. Measured density of parts seemed good, generally 57.5-58.5%. This improvement as compared with previous results is likely due to the addition of vibration directly applied to the powder in the hopper by a vibrated steel sheet.

After the spread, there was powder dropped on the build surface by the hopper going back over the build surface. These had to be manually removed and resulted in defects in the parts.

Vibrating plate added to zero-waste hopper. A screw came loose from one of the side mounts, causing the side mount to break.

NEXTGEN: Mason worked on the issue of wax buildup on the end mill. He tested various end mills and cutting parameters (feed rates, vacuum timing) to machine slots in cast blocks of pure paraffin. Microcrystalline wax machined worse than pure paraffin, leaving longer strings of wax on the end mill. The wax seems to stick to the end mill on pilot 1 when machining cuts filled with wax more than it does on the open air gantry machining cast blocks of wax. It is possible that this is due to wax temperature when cutting; the wax on the pilot printer will be at a higher temperature during the print.

Pourya ran more experiments with filling cut channels with wax and machining the top. Order was placed for MEST wax dispensing unit.

Mahmood raised concerns about the CTE mismatch between metal powder and waxes; pure paraffin wax expands at a rate ~30X that of green parts.

2025-07-22

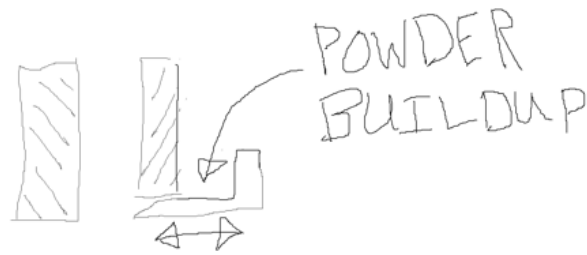
PILOT: Working on CAD for electrical control cabinet for pilot printers to send to Epson. Meeting with Manjun and Will to go over panels to have laser cut and bent sheet metal parts for the new heater design. Marked up the latest electrical schematic from the EE at Novo. I would like to start making the subpanels, but Rajan wants to hold off on that until the CAD is 100% complete, and he doesn't want that to be done until the schematic is 100% complete, which is dependent on the Novo EE.

HOPPER: Printed two new Y gantry mounts to replace the ones that had been broken for the zero-waste hopper on Pilot 3. Showed Mason how to put together the zero-waste hopper with the new, sharper, 20° blade.

2025-07-23

HOPPER: Working on a redesign of the zero-waste linear gated hopper. The spreader bar is changed to a larger diameter bar stock that has been machined down to be 10mm thick between flats and has holes added for mounting to the hopper. This will let us use a larger diameter spreader bar surface while also letting the gate close as close to the spreading surface as possible. The concept of the new blade is to start with a thicker bar of material with a section of it machined down into a thin blade. This should both increase the strength of the blade while decreasing the force required to close the blade. The difficulty with the design, other than

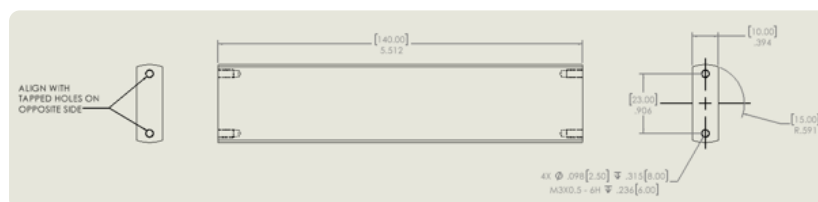
machining the part, is designing it such that it can close without powder building up in front of the thicker portion of the blade blocking it from closing.



PILOT: Continuing to work on the Epson pilot electrical system and CAD. I am still on hold for starting fabrication of the electrical control cabinets until the schematic is complete. I sent Manjun several items that needed to be added to the BOM and the schematic. Pourya is going to do some benchtop life cycle testing on the TEC power supply (Mean Well UHP-1000-48) because the current rating is slightly lower than the startup current of the 48V TECs. I have ordered a replacement power supply so that one can be dedicated to life cycle testing while there are two for the two pilot printers. Apparently the Delta TEC has an integrated control system that turns it on and off depending on the resistance of a thermistor; since we want to be able to control it directly, Pourya is going to try replacing the thermistor with a fixed resistor to tell the TEC to be on continuously.

2025-07-24

HOPPER: Gave drawing of new spreader bar design to AI along with some case hardened 1055 steel shaft stock to machine. It would be better to machine it from the Igus hard anodized shaft stock, but since that has a long lead time I want one made from a readily available material for initial testing. I am also working on the design of the blade



PILOT: The smaller Vention parts showed up (~1m extrusion sticks, angle brackets, etc.). Manjun is looking into where the longer extrusion parts are currently. Continuing to work on the design of the electrical control cabinet. I opened up one of the door lock solenoids, and am in the

process of figuring out how to wire it. I am in the process of printing the Duet and Raspberry Pi board mounts, and am also working on designing the Arduino Mega mount. I printed out 2 RPi mounts and installed Pis to them, but I realized that the ribbon cable connecting the Pi to the Duet board needs to wrap underneath the Pi, so I am reprinting the Pi mount with increased height to give enough clearance for the ribbon cable underneath the board. I sent the latest CAD of the electrical control cabinet to Manjun. It is largely complete, but it is missing some of the breakers and terminal blocks (depending on the final electrical schematic) and the cabinet is missing some cutouts for electrical cord plugs and the buttons/switches on the operator side of the cabinet.

Performance review with Marcus. It went pretty well, I think. I got a bunch of 3's, but Marcus seems to view those as reasonably positive scores.

2025-07-25

PILOT: Working on the design modifications to the new heater design. Got formal quote for, and added to the purchasing request Jira page, an order from SendCutSend for the heater sheet metal components and acrylic windows for the machined mist box.

NEXTGEN: Meeting to go over results of and issues with recent no depowdering wax filling experiments and discuss solutions.

2025-07-28

PILOT: Showed the CAD of the latest version of the Pilot printer and the current control cabinet electrical CAD to two Epson visitors (no idea who they are, nobody tells me anything).

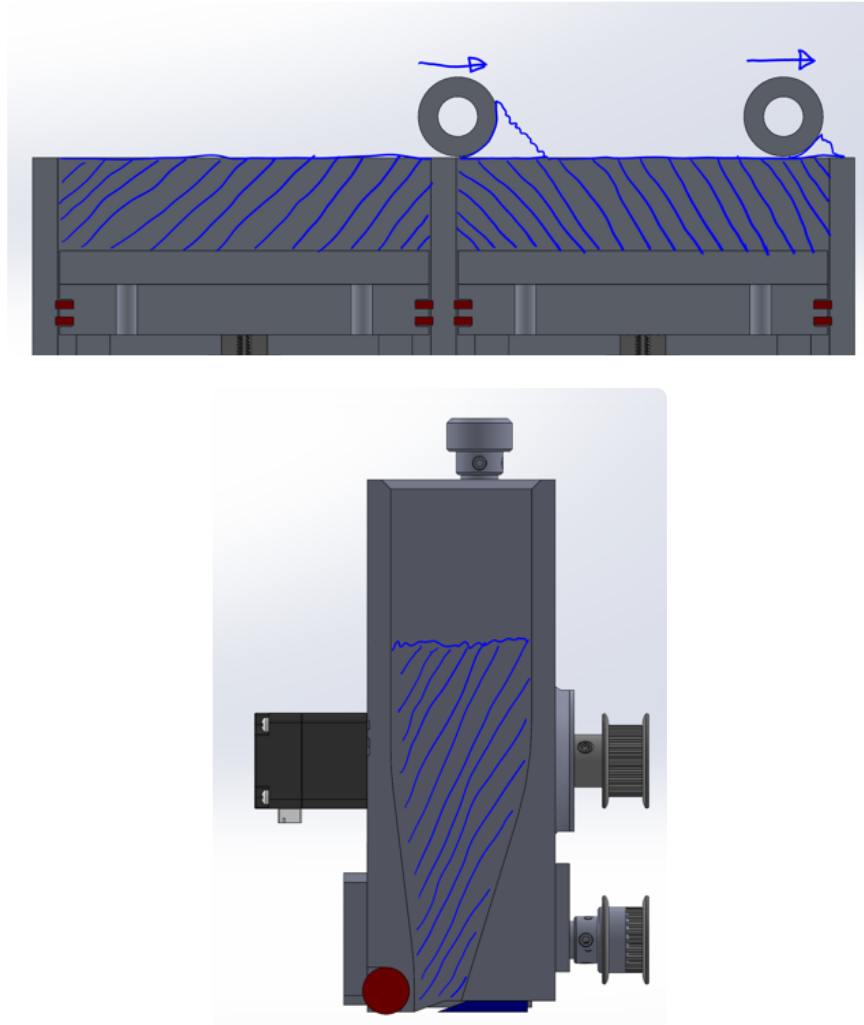
HOPPER: Continuing to work on the blade for HOPPER V3.4.2, the latest iteration of the linear gate zero-waste hopper design. The design direction I am going in right now is to use a thin, flat blade (2mm thick, 15 degree angle blade) with machined side mounts to give it structure. I am also considering a reinforcing strip along the back of the blade, which would give it increased rigidity but could cause issues with powder buildup jamming the gate from closing fully.

R&D Weekly Meeting: Held on Monday because Payman was out last Friday.

To Do:

- **New zero-waste hopper**
- **Find connecting hose for refilling hopper without opening doors**
- **Order polyethylene wax**
- **There will be a demo of setting up the Pilot printers for Epson engineers who will be here on Friday**

Generated two images for Payman: one was a section view of one of the hopper versions (V3.4.0 zero-waste) with components color coded and powder hand-sketched in, the other was a section view of spreader bars spreading powder from the powder feed tank to the build tank of a PILOT powder/build tank module, with the level of powder in front of the spreader bar shown as decreasing as it spreads across the build.



2025-07-29

PILOT: Showed Fernando how to assemble the Vention frames and got him started with putting together the two frames. Finally got permission to start work on the electrical subpanel.

Completed layout, completed cutouts, drilled holes for and installed 16X rivet nuts for large PSU sheet metal mounts, riveted in the DIN rails on one of the panels.

HOPPER: Working on design of side mounts for the 15 degree blade for HOPPER V3.4.2. Printed body of HOPPER V3.4.2.

2025-07-30

HOPPER: Gave hopper body to Mason to assemble. Received machined flat spreader bar from Al and gave him the drawing and stock for the new thin blade. I forgot to design the mount for the limit switch for HOPPER V3.4.2, and there are no heat set insert holes in the hopper for the limit switch mount, so I will need to add that in later.

PILOT: Finished attaching DIN rail and wire duct for the electrical subpanel for PILOT 4.

2025-07-31

HOPPER: Printing new Edmund Stage Y Plate Mount brackets for the hopper in Pilot 2 because the previous ones broke. The previous ones were made from PLA-CF with an infill of less than 100% so I have added reinforcing material to the design and I am printing replacements from PETG-CF with 100% infill. Beginning to work on the external hopper refill system. The current approach I am taking is to route a hose from the top of the print chamber to a connection point on the hopper. This hose will remain attached throughout the print, and powder will be added to the hopper as necessary.

PILOT: Began populating the electrical subpanel for PILOT 4. In process of attaching the wire duct and DIN rail to the PILOT 5 subpanel. Fernando is still working on the frames; he also looked up the torque spec for Vention aluminum extrusion mounts, which is 13 Nm. This sounds a little low to me, but apparently Fernando initially tightened them to a lower torque so possibly it is higher than I might have tightened them initially. He said that there is a possibility of distortion of the extrusion if the screws are tightened too much, so he is using a torque wrench to install them.

2025-08-01

HOPPER: I reprinted the blade side brackets for hopper V3.4.2 because the older ones were too thick to be able to slide the hopper through the opening on the Y gantry. Al finished the new steel blade, and Mason is currently installing it on hopper V3.4.2.

PILOT: Connected AC wires to the 12VDC power supply to be able to mount it to the subpanel; the connection points are inaccessible once the sheet metal mount has been screwed to the subpanel. Fernando is continuing to work on the frame for PILOT 5; he had put two of the cross members in the wrong location so I showed him where they should be and gave him the drawing of the frame that I generated. Working on a redesign of the heater for the Epson pilots. Due to limitations with SendCutSend's bending capabilities, I need to redesign the sheet metal parts so that they are manufacturable. I finished a new design and uploaded it to have them look it over to see if it is more manufacturable than the previous design.

2025-08-04

HOPPER: Mason has assembled and installed hopper V3.4.2 on pilot 3. Ben cut himself on the blade on Friday, that new blade may be a serious safety issue that needs to be addressed. Working on a part to interface to the hose to be able to fill the hopper from a hose connected to the top of the pilot printer. Designed and printing a limit switch mount for hopper V3.4.2. Printing a funnel to connect to the hopper refilling hose through the top acrylic panel of the pilot printer. I need to redesign and print a hopper-side interface because the current design is incompatible with the vibrating sheet metal plate.

PILOT: Talked with Will about some of the 3D printed parts required. Went over 3D printed parts with Manju again. We also have a meeting tomorrow to go over the 3D printed parts again.

Weekly R&D Meeting

2025-08-05

HOPPER: Printed a new limit switch mount and it was installed on the V3.4.2 hopper on pilot 3 by Mason. Printed a funnel for the flexible fill hose that looks good, although I need to redesign and print a new low-profile adapter that will feed powder into the hopper with the vibrating sheet metal in place.

PILOT: Working on wiring and installation of final electrical components on 2X electrical subpanels.

2025-08-06

HOPPER: Asked Mason to help out with the design of hopper hose filling adapter.

PILOT: Installing Duet boards and Raspberry Pi boards with 3D printed DIN rail mounts. Duet boards and Raspberry Pi's are installed and connected with a ribbon cable. I am currently working on installing the Arduino Mega's for environmental control. I asked Pourya, and the only two boards that need to be installed on the electrical subpanel are the Arduino Mega and Adafruit I2C multiplexer board (PCA9548). Soldered the screw terminal shields for the two Arduino Megs.

2025-08-07

PILOT: Arduino Mega mounts are printed and ready to be installed. The low voltage rail is getting crowded so I am considering moving the USB hub to an alternate location. The Arduino Mega has been installed. I have moved the USB hub to the lowest rail (safety controller, USB hub, motor cutoff relays). Three power supplies are connected to AC power, although the primary 24VDC power supply is connected through the safety relay so it will need to be bypassed for initial testing. The two acrylic windows that are sandwiched between the control cabinet and the Vention frame arrived. Assuming that they have been cut correctly, I can use

them as a template for marking out the M8 clearance holes for bolting the cabinet to the frame. I still need to finish the CAD for the cutouts on the control cabinet. It is also confirmed that we will be making 2 more carbon copy PILOTs for internal production use, and there is interest in making a PILOT for printing with copper so there may be a third (these would be PILOTs 6, 7, and 8. The PILOTs in progress are 4 and 5, and the ones already build are 1, 2, and 3.) Wired up all 5 DC PSUs and energized them on subpanel 4, resulting in green lights across the board. Subpanel 5 will be tested tomorrow. Once the PSUs are tested successfully, I will proceed to connect the remaining components to power.

2025-08-08

Weekly R&D Meeting

PILOT: The subpanel is fully populated and the control boards are powered.

2025-08-11

PILOT: Showed Fernando how to do the wiring and how to read the electrical schematic, so I hopefully have time to complete the CAD of the cutouts required on the control cabinet and start cutting it either today or tomorrow. Here is a company I believe I have used in the past for making custom enclosures:

<https://www.nemaenclosures.com/rfq.html>

Drawings of the cutouts to be made in the control cabinet are complete. Engineering printer is not printing well so I had to order some more toner cartridges; it turns out that the front office printer uses 054 toner cartridges while the engineering printer uses 045 cartridges

2025-08-12

Bagel Tuesday. Switching to Clockify for time tracking. Hired a new Director of Sales, Steven Rizzo.

PILOT: Reviewed safety system options with Rajan. The decision was made to include the safety system as designed but add a safety system defeating keyswitch on the front of the control cabinet which will override the safety system when active and allow the doors to be opened for machine setup. Completed cutouts on top, left, and bottom of control cabinet. Rear cutouts and final cleaning are pending, after which the control cabinet can be installed on the frames.

NEXTGEN: Payman brought up an interesting concept for me to work on: making a pourable substance that, when sintered, will act as a porous material that liquid can be pumped through for transferring heat.

2025-08-13

PILOT: Completed cutouts, cleaned cabinets, mounted cabinets and cabinet-side acrylic panels to Pilots 4 and 5 with the assistance of Fernando, installed both Roxtec block cable glands on each cabinet, and installed 3X power outlets on each cabinet, as well as the NEMA power input socket.

2025-08-14

PILOT: Added tapped holes to mount the 3D printed parts that clamp onto the keyboard and monitor mount. Pushed for us to buy a dedicated Bambu printer to just go ahead and print the non-resin 3D printed parts in-house; the process of getting them quoted and ordered from an outside vendor is taking up more time than we would spend just printing them here. The main advantage of having them printed outside is saving our time, but the process of ordering them is taking too long. Installed the electrical subpanels in the control cabinets. Installed the stack lights, power disconnects, and cabinet cooling fans. Installed one E-stop; we only have one currently available but more are being ordered. 2X anodized base plates were received. Installed threaded inserts in base plates and began installing one base plate in a pilot printer. The base plates seem flat but they are definitely quite flimsy.

2025-08-15

PILOT: Fernando developed a test protocol for testing the flatness of the base plate by mounting a dial indicator to one of the Y stages and moving it along the direction of travel. When the plate is in the machine (without being bolted down to anything) or resting on a bowed table, it is up to .015" out of flat, and can be warped by .005" by pressing on it, but it is flat within .001" when it is fully supported by a granite surface plate, so the base plate was machined flat, it just needs to be supported well in the flat position. I laser engraved labels for the switches and the Raspberry Pi USB bulkhead fitting and installed them on the control cabinet. I realized that I had forgotten to install the pneumatic system components, so I am working on adding them to the control cabinet CAD and will drill two holes today for installing the bulkhead fitting. Received Bambu printer for printing PILOT printer parts and began setting it up.

Weekly R&D Meeting

2025-08-18

PILOT: Working on printing with the new Bambu X1E by loading the sliced print file onto a microsd card and installing that in the printer. I have been having issues with connecting to the printer over wi-fi. Using an SD card is a little slower than wi-fi, but it has the advantage that it is possible to rerun prints from the printer touchscreen directly without needing to send them from a laptop every time. Working on installing the keyboards and monitors today. The mounts are printed, but I think it will be necessary to order a new pipe because the mounting rod is likely

too short for the height of the new cabinet. The Bambu X1E is up and printing; I ran a Benchy with CF nylon and now am running two overflow blanking inserts. Assembled 2X pneumatic system regulating assemblies. These each have a 1/4" quick disconnect, a pressure regulator, and a flow regulator. The pressure regulator used is no longer available, so the system will need to be redesigned at some point to accommodate an available regulator. I successfully powered up one of the machines (I need to number them individually so that I can keep track of which is which). Drilled hole, and installed pneumatic pressure/flow regulator stack, in one of the pilot printers. Set up the FormLabs printer for printing parts with ESD safe resin and started two spindle cleaning troughs printing. Running a print of overflow chutes for the 2X pilot printers on the Bambu X1E.

2025-08-19

PILOT: Drilled hole and installed pneumatic regulator stack in the other Pilot printer. Tested powering on the printer and it seemed OK. The prints on the Bambu X1E last night failed because they came unstuck from the print bed, so I am running some smaller prints now after applying Magigoo to the print bed. There is still some print warpage going on and the parts are pretty rough so I am considering switching from PAHT-CF to PETG-CF to get a better surface finish and make printing easier. The Y stages and Y plate are installed and aligned on one of the Pilots. I have a print running on the FormLabs for all components that hold an endstop or an endstop mount and a print running on the X1E for new monitor mounts from PLA-CF that was included with the X1E (I have some PAHT-CF and PETG-CF coming from Bambu, but they likely won't be here for a day or two.)

2025-08-20

PILOT: Printed and post-processing all resin endstop components. New monitor/keyboard mounts printed with PLA-CF are good to go. Populated 2nd Y plate with keenserts and installed the X stage mount. Main focus today is working on the electrical schematic; apparently that is super critical right now for some nebulous reason. I have gotten the Duet board and Raspberry Pi connections to add to the schematic, and I am working on cleaning up some of the notes I made during the wiring process. Learning how to use KiCAD for electrical schematic design. Split the CAD of the bottle holder into two parts to print on the X1E because it would not fit in one part. Printing it in gray PLA-CF because the PETG-CF and PAHT-CF have not come in yet. Tried installing one of the safety reset pushbutton boxes, but it was difficult to get the DIN rail clips to engage and the counterbore on the bottom of the box cracked when I tightened the screws down, so I plan to reprint it in a stronger material with some strengthening modifications.

2025-08-21

PILOT: Installed carbon fiber keyboard and monitor mount tubes with PLA-CF gray cabinet mounts. Printing parts for UV tank module. Printing a new safety reset button case and face plate from indigo PETG-CF. Focusing on creating a complete electrical schematic in KiCAD based on the Altium generated one from Novo.

2025-08-22

PILOT: Parts are still being machined for the UV tank modules. Mainly working on the Pilot-E electrical schematic.

2025-08-25

PILOT: Completed the initial draft full electrical schematic for Pilots 4 and 5.

Meeting regarding systems that are not currently being used in the Pilot printers

- Spindle cleaning trough
- End mill touch probe
 - Recess below machine surface to clear spreader bar
- Pilots are going to be sent with gold mesh nebulizers

2025-08-26

PILOT: Designed bracket for mounting the large Y-axis cable carrier to the frame. Attempting to print from PAHT-CF on the R&D Bambu printer, will also print from PETG-CF on the X1E. Started assembling the powder tank module. There was an issue encountered when screwing the center plate to the middle of one of the front/back plates; the threaded mounting hole pattern was dimensioned from the centerline of the part and made symmetrical when it is supposed to be slightly off center. This was a poor design on my part, and while the information was technically captured in the drawing, it was not made very clear. Will updated the drawing to make it clearer that the holes are not positioned exactly symmetrically. Other than that issue, the assembly is going together very well. I plan to redesign the carriage bellows mount to be a single piece that is not bolted to the carriage to increase reliability and so that holes do not need to be tapped in the carriage.

2025-08-27

PILOT: Installed Z axis stage mount, Z axis end stop, Y axis end stop. Continued assembling first powder tank module. Measured cable length for Y1, Y2, and X axis, and had Fernando add connectors to the ends of those cables.

2025-08-28

PILOT: Meeting about electrical schematic. Made updates per ZZ's suggestions, including a modification to the water sensor wiring and the addition of a DC-DC 12V power supply for powering the water sensor. Entered order for DC-DC converter in Jira ordering page, but Will will not be back until next Tuesday to process orders. Attached connectors to 4X lead screw stepper motors and attached them to their corresponding mounts. Attached 1/4-20 threaded shaft collars to lead screws. Completed assembling the powder tank module for PILOT 4.

2025-08-29

PILOT: Cables made, installed, and routed for X, Y1, Y2, U, and V axes, along with endstop cables for Y, U, and V axes. Installed Z axis stage on PILOT 4.

2025-09-02

PILOT: Continued cable routing. Installed monitors, keyboard, and mice on PILOTs 4 and 5. Modified electrical schematic so that the third 110 VAC outlet is dedicated to the monitor power cord. Rewired all three outlets so that they use 14 AWG free wires instead of the rubber-coated cables to improve heat dissipation and packing efficiency. Began wiring one of the safety door interlocks. Printed a new batch of zip tie mounts and am printing the parts for the overflow chute assembly for PILOT 4. Ordered the steel wire reinforced vacuum hosing. Printing the hose adapter to mount on top of the X axis cable carrier tower. Designed a custom symbol for the heater and integrated it into the schematic. Added the 50A circuit breaker to the electrical schematic; previously it was installed in the machine but it had not been documented in the schematic.

2025-09-03

PILOT: Redesigned and ordered felts from Ponoko where each side is reduced by .75mm. Finished wiring up one of the solenoid lockout switches and showed Cisco how to wire them up so he can get started on the other 3. Reworked 4X resin spindle mounts that had not been printed accurately and installed one on Pilot 4 so that I can finalize the length of cables and hoses routed to the spindle. Attached 6" lengths of cable to the Marathon dental spindle style 2 pin connector and attached Molex Micro-Fit 3.0 connectors to the other side to interface to the continuous-flex cable that runs to the control cabinet. Cisco wired up the other two door solenoid interlock switches, for a total of 3 wired. We only have 4 onsite at the moment, and one is being used by ZZ.

2025-09-04

PILOT: Printing mist box vacuum hose adapters. Routed keyboard and mouse USB cables and power and HDMI cables for the monitor through the Roxtec block in the bottom of the control cabinet. Powered up Pilot 4; ZZ is now working on setting up the Raspberry Pi and Duet board.

Will was terminated shortly after raising concerns about Manju with Rajan. Technically he was a month-by-month contractor and per his contract he was given 5 days written notice that his contract would not be renewed for the next month. The ordering tasks in Jira which were assigned to Will are now being assigned to Manju, but Manju has also reassigned some of them to Jasmine so I am not sure if she will be doing the ordering in the future instead.

2025-09-05

PILOT: Wiring on Pilot 5. Discussion about wiring labels; it sounds like Epson wants the wires to be individually labeled but that is not needed for their upcoming visit next week.

Weekly R&D meeting

2025-09-08

PILOT: Epson visit for dry test is scheduled to begin tomorrow. Recorded video showing how to chill the locating pins and receptacles in liquid nitrogen to install them in the build plates. Also recorded a video while showing Fernando and Cisco how to assemble the build plate assembly; to complete the powder and build tank module there are some 3D printed parts required that I am currently printing. Worked on cleaning up some of the cable routing on Pilot 4 and initial cable and hose routing and wiring on Pilot 5. Cleaning up the CAD of the powder and build tank modules in preparation for showing the CAD to Epson. Cleaned and curing 4X 3D printed resin mist box vacuum interfaces.

2025-09-09

PILOT: First day of Epson visit. Reviewed electrical schematic of pilot printers and went over hardware and wiring in machine to solicit advice for changes to be made to the printers before shipping. Among the changes are adding labels to some of the wires, adding corner guards to the vacuum tray, enclose the bottom of the machine with sheet metal panels and doors in the front, add power on/off labels to main power disconnect, add a safety system reset button to the front of the machine

2025-09-10

Bagel Wednesday: Emily acknowledged that many people are leaving at the same time. There are many positions they're hiring for, mostly high-level engineering and R&D positions, as well as one R&D technician and one cross-trained technician. Most interestingly, Scott was surprised that many people are concerned that the company may shut down soon. To the best of my knowledge, we have operating capital for 3 months and are dependent on another funding round to stay open beyond that. Two people have been fired and four have chosen to leave within the past month. Epson seems to be pushing to get access to all of our IP and technology

before the end of the year (PILOT printers, slicer, their engineers are going through training to transfer knowledge from 3DEO to Epson). The job listings have been posted several times over the past few months, with only one hire so far. Scott was recently in Japan and said that Epson seems excited about integrating our technology into their portfolio, although it occurs to me that once they have the PILOT printers in hand, have been trained on their use, our approach to DFAM, and software, they have much less need for 3DEO at all.

PILOT: Modifications to printers per Epson recommendations. Pushbuttons added to outside of control cabinet to reset safety system, bumpers added to vacuum tray, labels added to main power disconnect, schematic modified with markings for wire labels. Designed sheet metal panels for sides of lower chamber.

2025-09-11

PILOT: Continued training of Fernando and Cisco on assembling the powder tank module. Added label markingS to the schematic (ground wires need both ends to be labeled with "E"). Began labeling the wires; I am experimenting with several approaches, including adhesive letters that wrap around the wire that then need to have heat shrink tubing or tape applied around them, or using the heat shrink tubing label printer, which seems easier, as long as you need to use heat shrink either way. Meeting about documentation. Mostly completed design of vacuum chamber enclosure panels.

2025-09-12

PILOT: Finished design of vacuum chamber enclosure panels and earthquake brackets, generated a quote for ordering them from OSHCut powder coated, and entered the order in the Jira purchasing request form. Completed the mounting bracket for the BME280 sensor/LTC4311 I2C extender boards and am printing out 1X in indigo PETG-CF and 9X in black PETG-CF.

2025-09-16

PILOT: Installed 6X DC fans on 3X heater shields. Continued working on installing helicoils in the copper heat spreader bars. Installed the cord grips for the two vacuum hoses on PILOT 4. Designed a mount for the IR camera. Designed a mount for holding the air filter. Confirmed with the Epson engineers that they want the front door panels to be made from black powder coated sheet metal instead of acrylic as I had originally designed it. Fortunately, I had already ordered black sheet metal panels for the front doors along with the other panels that were already known to be made from sheet metal, just in case they did not want the front door panels to be made from acrylic.

HOPPER: Helped Mohsen with the rotary gate hopper. The set screws on the pulley attached to the rotary gate hopper hinge shaft had fallen out and the threads had partially stripped, so I

chased the threads on the hole that is aligned with the keyway and installed an M3X6 screw.

2025-09-17

PILOT: Designed and printing new door latch mounts. Designed new pull handles for vacuum support plates that do not interfere with the new lower front doors. Added M8 lifting eyes to design of vacuum support plate, modified the drawing per the new design, and ordered 4X straps for holding the vacuums in place. These straps are added per Epson's request. Tested and redesigned door latch mount and printing the new version to test before mass producing them. ZZ seems to have added several terminal blocks to the control cabinet so I asked him for the connection points so I can update the schematic. Updated the schematic with a new power supply for the nebulizer driver; I am using a 12V boost converter powered by the USB hub. It may be possible to power the nebulizer driver with the 12V power supply that powers the water detection sensor, but because the output of that power supply is not connected to any terminal blocks but is instead connected directly to the water detection sensor, I would have to add in terminal blocks and rewire the sensor to those terminal blocks. In the future it might be better to have a boost converter attached to every device that uses a nonstandard voltage, or start out with non-dedicated DC power supplies. Went through several iterations of Vention zip tie mounts to get a design that was possible to print with no supports, minimized material usage, and was self-aligning with the Vention extrusion. I am now printing 10 of those on the Bambu X1E and trying to print 4X latch mount sets and 1X vacuum support panel pull handle on the Bambu X1C. I am also printing 3X nebulizer top caps because those were not machined as part of the mist box assembly.

2025-09-18

PILOT: Drilled and tapped holes in the inner/lower sheet metal part in the heaters for Pilots 4 and 5 for M5 screws. I tried to install the M3 sheet metal panel inserts, but when I tried to use an M3 screw to pull it into the sheet metal, the screw head kept snapping off. For the next design I think the right approach would be to get one of those sheet metal forming tools that let you bulge out a section of sheet metal to give more threads when you tap it. Currently printing a set of latch mounts to test out the latest design.

HOPPER: Started a part printing on the X1C for Payman for his hopper design.

2025-09-19

Fernando's last day; we have a company-sponsored lunch coming from Blue Salt Fish Grill.

PILOT: One heater is mostly assembled, only needing the metal screen and a connector attached to the 24VDC cooling fan wires. Printing more Vention zip tie mounts. Assembled the visible light and IR camera mounts so both are ready to install.

2025-09-22

PILOT: Informed by Manju that Epson (or someone else?) wants the printers to be called Epson 1 and 2 instead of PILOT 4 and 5, so I removed the laser cut placards labeling the printers. The first printer needs to be moved to the R&D printing pod by tomorrow morning to start the wet test. I resolved the issue with the spindle Z stage on the first printer not being able to move all the way to the top to hit the end stop switch; it appears that there was some interference the heads of the M3 socket head cap screws that I had used to mount the stage to the aluminum X axis mounting plate.

2025-09-23

PILOT: Wired up the heater power supply and cables and the new 12V power supply that will power the lights and the water sensor. Powered up machine. Adjusted U and V tank home positions and installed 4X felt seals. Wired up 2X cables with barrel connectors to connect to the lights. Printing 4X blank door handles. Printed 7X door latch mount sets, with one a new design that should require less adjustment to install. Drilled a hole in the top panel of Epson1 for the lights.

2025-09-24

PILOT: Finished the N1/N2/L1/L2/E labeling of the first Epson printer, then moved it to the R&D lab. It was too large to fit through the standard door, so we had to roll it through the double doors to the R&D printing pod. The vacuum cleaner support plate was grinding on the drawer slides that it is riding on, partly because the plate was flexing from the force of the clamping straps and partly because the vacuums were shifted too far back and were causing the plate to tilt backwards. The solution is to design a new sheet metal plate with folded sides for increased strength along with mounting holes for the center lifting eyes, cutouts for the strap carabiners to grab so lifting eyes will only be necessary in the center, and holes premade for bolting on the slides. Started printing the left side of the powder tank catch box.

2025-09-25

PILOT: The spindle vacuum on Epson 1 is not turning on when the relay is energized, so I need to figure that out. Apparently it is an issue with the Festool vacuum; when the Bosch vacuum is plugged into the spindle vacuum port it works fine, and when the Festool is plugged into the mist vacuum port it still does not work. There has been flex noted in the X endstop mount, which really needs to be machined from aluminum so I am planning on redesigning that for machinability today. I also need to update the model of the control cabinet with changes that need to be made based on lessons learned from Epson 1 and 2, including the safety reset button cutout and new cable pass-through connections. The Roxtec block used currently does not

have enough openings for all the cables used, so it needs to be redesigned. An issue was encountered with the Festool vacuums; they are a newer version than the ones used on Pilots 1-3 that does not turn on automatically when power is connected. The short term workaround was to connect a dummy load to the power tool power outlet on the vacuum (in this case we used a solid-state Sprite refrigerator). The vacuum is designed so that it can only be switched on by either pressing the "MAN" membrane button on the front or when it detects current draw through a 120 VAC outlet on the vacuum. I am working on installing a cooling fan in the vacuum cleaner chamber that will be plugged in to the Festool; this will both act as a load that triggers the vacuum and will recirculate air in the vacuum cleaner chamber while the Festool vacuum is running to prevent heat buildup. It was noted in testing Epson 1 that the heater exceeded 100C when it was run without the cooling fans, which caused the safety system to trip and shut down the Duet. Talking with ZZ the setpoint is currently set at 100C. Made new laser engraved plaques for EPSON 1 and EPSON 2 that will need to be covered with protective film until the printers have been delivered.

2025-09-26

PILOT: Printing more Vention zip tie mounts. Redesigned and printing new overflow chute parts; I modified the design of the chute and blanking plates to fit the machine main plate more tightly. I eliminated the mounting area for the brush. I also matched the bolted thickness of the overflow chute to the blanking plate so they will use the same screws. I updated the schematic with new lengths of cables and corrected the board side connector callouts. I designed and generated a drawing for a new machined X axis endstop mount. I sent the part number for M3X10 screws to Manju to order.

NEXTGEN: Weekly R&D meeting discussing the wax dispensing no-depowdering project. I feel like the project has not really advanced in the last few months, and I am unsure that the approach being taken is correct. Dispensing wax using the various wax dispensing heads does not seem to be controllable enough for our purposes and there are many unknowns around how dewaxing and sintering the dewaxed part will result, and how the internal surface finish will be in fully enclosed parts. If the goal is to make it easier to depowder internal channels that have a connection to the outside of the part, I would focus on increasing green part strength and transitioning to using a binder jetting head to enable the use of stronger binders and more selective binder application. A layer-by-layer hybrid LPBF/machining process also would make internal features easier to depowder while maintaining the surface finish advantages of 3DEO's printing process, although this carries with it increased risk. If the goal is to make fully enclosed features, I would first question why that is necessary. Filling channels with wax (or preferably a water-soluble polymer such as PVP-VA) is not necessarily a bad approach, but it is clearly more

difficult to implement in a production process than we anticipated. Either the timeline to production implementation should be extended, or resources should be added to the project (this would necessitate hiring more engineers, I think). A hybrid DED process might make fully enclosed features possible, as would a paste-based or FDM-based sinter-based system, such as Mantle's process or running metal-powder-bearing filament in an FDM printer.

2025-09-29

PILOT: Installed solenoid valve on Epson 2 and connected it to the air line that runs to the muffler in the printing chamber. Working on a mount for the vacuum chamber air recirculation fan. Printing another handle for the vacuum plate. Filled the "PULL" letter debossing with gray SLA resin and currently curing it in the Formlabs curing chamber with the same settings as ESD resin. An increased layer time has been noted on Epson 1; this may be due to a lower cooling rate because the layer cooling fan is mounted higher on Epson 1 and 2 than it is on PILOT 1-3. The easiest approach to try improving this is to print a duct to make the fan flow more laminar and provide more targeted flow at the build plate, so I have designed such a duct and it is printing now on the X1E. Printed the duct and gave it to Ben to install on Epson 1 once it is not busy with printing. I have also designed a mounting scheme for the vacuum cleaner chamber air recirculation fan. It will be bolted directly to the left rear louver (on the side of the Festool dust collector) on the inside of the vacuum cleaner chamber, blowing air outwards. Holes will need to be drilled through the louver and the sheet metal panel to mount the fan. In the future, the sheet metal will have its holes laser cut (I have already modified the sheet metal design accordingly) but the louvers will likely need to be modified, unless we are able to form the louvers into the side sheet metal panels in the future. Drilled holes through 2X louvers matching the mounting holes of the fans being used, then riveted them to the sheet metal panels, then used the drilled louver holes to drill holes through the sheet metal panels. Received the sheet metal panels and earthquake mounting brackets.

2025-09-30

PILOT: TS3. Need to design a printed fan guard for the vacuum cleaner chamber cooling fan. The light mounting clips are printed but not installed. The left side panel with louvers riveted and fan installed has been mounted to Epson 1. The cooling fan for Epson 2 needs to be wired and installed. Selecting new terminal blocks for the next machines that are screwless (spring loaded), have the wires coming out the top so it is easier to install/remove wires out of order, and hopefully have labels that clip in better than the current screw-based terminal blocks. Designed and printed the fan guards and installed them on Epson 2 along with the fan.

Changes / To Do:

- Zip tie protection sleeves - spiral wrap approved
- Tighten empty terminal blocks - DONE
- Electrical hazard warning label on control cabinet door
- High temperature warning label on heater
- Mount water leakage sensor
- Reduce vacuum noise
 - Vacuum chamber walls should help with this
 - Add sound deadening panels to walls to further reduce sound
 - The StoneVac is much quieter, but it has also not been tested with the integrated system

2025-10-01

PILOT: Installed vacuum chamber fan guard on Epson 1. Installed spiral wrap on some of the hoses and wires on Epson 1 to show others the general approach. The Epson engineers signed off on the use of spiral wrap instead of teflon sheets. Installed light mounts on Epson 1 and switched to a different type of barrel electrical splitter instead of having the lights wired in series; since the maximum run of the lights we're using is 2, having 3 in series either causes them to be dimmer or causes a risk of fire. With me and Manju present, the Epson engineers approved putting the doors on the front of the machine instead of the back and were informed by Manju that the rear panel would need to be removed to access the vacuum hoses, the control panels of the vacuums, and the vacuum chamber exhaust fan. They also confirmed that we will be adding the same door latches to the lower doors as are present on the upper doors. I am currently printing the door latch mounts on the Bambu X1E. I am currently printing a layer fan duct and layer fan guard on the X1C. The layer fan duct and guard are printed and ready for installation. I need to print another fan guard for Epson 2. Received a batch of 5000K LED light bars (the ones I have been using are 4000K, because the 5000K were out of stock at some point). I tried wiring up 2X 5000K and 2X 4000K light bars on Epson 2, because I think the combination of lights with two color temperatures is cool and because it lets us use up the 4000K light bars. Decision was made to standardize to 5000K LED lights across the machines.

2025-10-02

PILOT: Went over wiring in Epson 2 with Cisco. Some of the wires are connected to points that do not match the schematic, the circuit breaker for the 48V TEC power supply was unconnected, and the safety system wiring is undocumented because it is wiring done by ZZ, but electrically the system is functional. Combined the two overflow chute components that are currently super glued together into one component, and modified the dimensions so that it will provide a better powder seal to prevent the powder from leaking through the plate. Currently

printing one on the X1E. Since the Festool on Epson 1 is still loud even after reducing the flow, I am working on adding an intake filter to further muffle the sound.

2025-10-03

PILOT: Attached 3X Caution Hot labels to the heater on Epson 1. I ran the heater until the heatsink temperature hit 75C, and the labels seemed to still be adhering, but it will definitely take more testing to confirm that it is a reliable solution. I was informed by Marcus at the end of the day yesterday that we have hired a new EE, and he has set up a meeting with him, me, Pourya, and ZZ next week to transfer knowledge of the pilot printers so that he can design the electrical systems for the next generation pilot printers, which makes me very sad because I had hoped to be working on that at some point. It is also interesting to note that the whole interview process was conducted entirely by senior management, with no involvement of any engineers or people who would be working with this new guy. I am having difficulty spinning that in a positive way; the best I have come up with so far is that maybe they were trying to minimize our extra workload because we are busy with the printers to be sent to Epson, but there are many possible negative interpretations of it. I entered the situation into Claude to get its analysis, and it was uncharacteristically negative about the situation. Usually it puts a positive spin on almost everything it says, but in this case it found the events worrisome. I learned at 2:00 that they want the lower doors installed on the printers today so that they can show them to some higher-up at Epson on Monday, so I cut 8X 720mm Vention extrusion pieces so that Cisco can get the doors put together and installed today. Since the X axis cable carrier tower hose fitting on Epson 1 broke during printing, I am doing a complete redesign to make it more robust. The general design concept is to use a brass barbed elbow fitting that is clamped between two 3D printed blocks to hold it in the right orientation and hold the hose onto the barbed fitting.

2025-10-06

PILOT: I confirmed with Manju twice and Marcus once that the plan is to not test Epson 1 printing any further, and move it back to the assembly area for wiring of the light stack and cleaning in preparation for shipping. I have concerns about this; I would rather benchmark it as much as possible and run it to see if any other issues show up, such as the X axis cable carrier tower hose fitting breaking. I am working on a comparable part made from all metal pipe and hose fittings.

2025-10-07

PILOT: The printed box parts don't really make sense; the crenellated should be on the rear door instead of the body so I will redesign it today and reprint it tonight. I am also working on updating the electrical schematic with the updates given to me by ZZ; this will be done by the

end of the day so that Cisco and/or Ning can double check the panels to see if the actual wiring matches the schematic. The sheet metal vacuum plate has still not been ordered, despite Manju saying in this morning's meeting that Philip had confirmed that it had been ordered last Friday. After Jasmine got authorization from Marcus and completed the PO, I entered the link to place the order in the Jira page yesterday. I have completed the latest revision of the electrical schematic and sent it out to the team. I need to update the design of the X axis cable carrier tower hose fitting.

2025-10-08

PILOT: Spoke with Marcus about the plan for the next two Pilot printers. It sounds like we're putting them on the back burner for now because we don't have any technicians to dedicate to assembling them. Presumably Cisco will return to mainly working on inconel development once the two Epson printers have shipped, and the implication is that I will return to R&D efforts. Meeting about spare parts to send to Epson; I need to print a set of all the 3D printed parts that are used one printer, as well as a tool for measuring the static pressure of the Festool vacuum applied at the tip of the spindle mount.

2025-10-09

PILOT: Rajan spoke to Ning yesterday and the plan as it is right now is to move forward with building the next two Pilot printers and have Ning make the next two electrical subpanels matched to the updated Epson schematic design. I will be moved back to R&D process development (no depowdering, hopper). This makes me very sad for several reasons: first, I had hoped to create a new electrical panel design that had some significant improvements from the current one, including cleaning up the location of circuit breakers and power supplies, reducing the number of power supplies, switching to spring-loaded terminal blocks, cleaning up the arduino to sensor wiring, etc. I also was not involved in the hiring process, and the work I was doing that I had really enjoyed (particularly learning KiCAD) will be taken over by someone who I was not involved in selecting. I also was interested in learning about SolidWorks electrical, which now will no longer be necessary. I was also not consulted about what projects I would like to work on; I would prefer to focus on manufacturing of the current PILOT design and development of the next industrialized version. This lack of transparency and collaboration in company direction and roles is frustrating. I also have concerns about the viability and necessity of the no-depowdering, laser, and hopper processes. I would be more interested in developing a machine that uses the traditional 3DEO hardware stack with tighter environmental and motion controls as well as in-printer measurement to achieve tighter process controls, as well as developing more controlled processes around printing itself, such as pre-processing the powder and recycling overflow powder to reduce waste in a way that is more easily industrialized than a

hopper design. Pilot documentation meeting. Designed and printed new angled part for holding the all-metal X axis cable carrier tower hose adapter. Working on post-processing the first batch of resin 3DP parts and preparing the second batch for printing; it seems that I can print all the parts required for one printer in two Form 3 prints.

2025-10-10

Went over the schematic modifications that Ning found were necessary to match the schematic to Epson 1. The TEC circuit was wired in a nonsense gibberish way which doesn't match the schematic or Epson 2, but since Epson 1 needs to have final software testing done today, I updated the schematic to match the wiring in Epson 1. Once Epson 1 is signed off on and locked down, Epson 2 will need to be rewired to match the schematic. Marcus sent out an email about resource allocation for the next 2 Pilots:

\Hi, all,

As you all probably know, we have two more pilots of the same design as the Epson units to build for our own use. My understanding is that we have most, maybe all of the parts needed to do so.

At the same time, we need to dial back the amount of resource we put into making those units - we had a hard shipping deadline and a lot of newness for the first two, these don't have a hard deadline and should just be replicates of what we ended up with on the first ones. (with maybe one caveat, I'd like to use the metal-safe vacuums we bought, partly since we already bought them, but I'd also like to get some experience with them).

We also need to get more of Cisco's time back on Inconel, and also get him free to cover for Alex during some scheduled class times.

So, here's what I'm proposing:

- all this starts after Cisco is done with the Epson pilots. Supposedly that should wrap up for him this coming Monday (Manju, please correct me if I'm wrong).
- Cisco will generally be available before lunch to work on building Pilots, and generally go to inconel afterward.
- Cisco will also be unavailable the following dates before 9:30, to cover for Alex. I certainly hope it won't take this long to build two Pilots, but sharing them all for completeness sake.

- 10/16

- 10/23

- 10/27-31

- 11/13

12/1-5

12/11

- We should have Abe available to shadow Cisco the days (pre-lunch) that he's there. I recommend that Abe work with Cisco on the next unit (I guess we're calling that Pilot 6? 1-3 are existing lab units, 4-5 are the Epson ones?), and then independently try to replicate on the one after that (Pilot 7). We want to end up where Abe can basically build independently except for when we literally need more than two hands.
- Jared is available for consultation only, with the one exception of leveling the stages/plates (and training Manju, Abe, and Cisco to do it in the process). I had originally thought to do this with what I call "office hours" (a scheduled window where he can be asked stuff), but I think instead I want to do what I call the "15 minute rule"
 - if you have a question that should take 15 minutes or less, you can just talk to him informally. Jared is empowered to ask you to come back later if he's not at a good break point of whatever he's doing.
 - For more than that, it should be arranged through me (and we'll schedule a time).
- IN parallel to all this, Ning owns building the electrical cabinets, with Abe's help as needed. (we also potentially can bring in an intern Philipp knows if that would be helpful).
- Any other resources (Sean, Mason, Senai etc) should only be tapped through me, with my explicit approval.

This is intentionally not the fastest possible way of getting these units built, but should be reasonable. We're going for minimally intrusive, so we can get back to some things that got back-burnered during the Epson sprint.

Questions, comments, concerns? Let me know! Otherwise, we'll officially kick this off next week when Cisco's help is no longer needed on the Epson units.

Thanks,

Marcus

Sounds like I'm off the pilots for the foreseeable future. There are also no immediate plans to begin work on the industrialized version of the pilot printers. I asked Marcus about it, and he said that the plans are contingent on decisions by the board and decisions driven by future funding received (or not).

2025-10-13

PILOT: The latest design of the powder catch was printed over the weekend and fits well; now I need to print 3 more. The powder tank module box parts were also printed, so I joined those

together with VHB tape in preparation for installing them into Epson 2. The design of the custom electrical control cabinet from NEMA Enclosures Mfg. is complete, and I signed off on the design for ordering. Manju talked about the need to customize the COTS electrical cabinets we have in stock to match the custom design we ordered. I also pointed out that we will need a custom subpanel designed and fabricated, which will require Ning to complete the schematic, create the SolidWorks assembly of the full electrical panel, design the sheet metal part, and have it fabricated. I would prefer to create an improved schematic with various upgrades (fewer power supplies, spring loaded terminal blocks instead of screw terminal, better organized circuit breakers, terminal blocks, and power supplies, more organized wiring (possibly using SolidWorks Electrical), etc., but that is out of my hands now). Sometimes you can't do what you want to do, or even what you're best at. Sometimes you have to do what only you can do. This is infuriating, obviously, but I understand the motivation. It is important to have redundancy in employee skills, and it would be unwise for the company to only have me who can do electrical design and mechanical design for the PILOT printers as well as certain R&D activities. On the other hand, what I would prefer in this situation is to be heavily involved in the selection of new employees to develop new electrical and mechanical systems, as well as have a say in how my time will be split between developing next-generation printers vs. experimental subsystems. Also, I would like clarity in whether we will even be developing new printers or just duplicating the current PILOT printers. I feel like the party line with the PILOT printers (for years) has been that we need to crank out something quickly to show board members, get funding, and run some experiments, then for the next generation we will take our time to design something right. That wasn't true when going from PILOT 1 to 2 and 3, it wasn't true when going from PILOTs 1-3 to Epson 1 and 2, and it wasn't true when going from Epson 1 and 2 to PILOTs 6 and 7. For some reason we were always rushed when moving from generation to generation.

R&D To Do This Week:

- Spindle bit cleaning
- New wax recipe
- Burnout comparison between paraffin and microcrystalline

Learning how to set up an ESP32-based touchscreen to apply to an upgraded version of the THC. Working on developing a cleaner version of the electrical system for the PILOT printers.

2025-10-14

PILOT: Preparing printers for shipping. Designing and printing a plate to replace the Roptec block on the bottom of the control cabinet with three bulkhead electrical pass-throughs (2X USB, 1X HDMI).

NEXTGEN: Ordered some polyurethane elastomer material from McMaster in three different hardnesses. The goal is to clean wax residue off of the spindle bit by inserting the spindle bit into the rubber, either with the the spindle motor on or off, depending on what seems to work better. I will design and print an insert for the non-overflow chute side slot with three rectangles of rubber inserted (40A, 60A, and 80A durometer). I did a crude benchtop test where I dipped a spindle bit into some pure paraffin and jabbed it into the different hardnesses of rubber, and it wiped off most of the wax, although the bit had to be rotated to clear out the flutes completely. I am unsure if it will be adequate to clean off the outside of the end mill cutting length without clearing out the flutes entirely.

2025-10-15

PILOT: Printed the first Roxtec block blanking plate with bulkhead electrical pass-throughs and installed the pass-throughs. There were connectivity issues with the cable going through the HDMI bulkhead connection point.

NEXTGEN: I have been steadily ramping up the temperature of a paraffin/EVA (ethylene vinyl acetate copolymer) mix on the hot plate in the R&D fume hood. The EVA seems very difficult to dissolve; I am up to 180C now and the EVA has softened into a floating mass but it is not completely dissolved yet. I am continuing to work on the design of a rubber block holder for cleaning end mills on one of the Pilots. Finally completed the design and it is printing right now.

2025-10-16

PILOT: Completed the second Roxblock blanking plate. There were some more connectivity issues that seemed to be alleviated by replacing the micro HDMI to HDMI cable with a higher quality one, then when Epson 2 was moved from the R&D lab to the warehouse the RPi power supply breaker was tripped for some reason. I switched it back on and the system seems OK so far, but that is a worrisome failure mode because I am not sure why the Pi breaker might trip, unless there was a short in the system or the Pi was overloading its power supply for some reason (it is a 4A power supply so it should be good, but it is still a possibility). Printed TEC terminal covers on the Bambu using Senai's design. Tapped holes for, and installed, the powder and build tank module lower cover, and slid the two powder catches into place. Completed the design of the custom electrical subpanel and made the order request in Jira. I designed the plate out of 1/8" thick aluminum instead of the original .09375" thick mild steel to reduce cost and eliminate the need for powder coating.

NEXTGEN: I cut out blocks of rubber of the three hardnesses being tested and glued them into the appropriate slots, then gave the assembly to Pourya to test whenever he has a chance.

2025-10-17

NEXTGEN: I ran across a very interesting solvent that machinablewax.com sells for dewaxing:

https://machinablewax.com/sp-28-wax-remover/?searchid=7965&search_query=F-99+%28Arctic%29+Machinable+Wax%3A

It is reputed to be able to dissolve both paraffinic and microcrystalline waxes, and is also allegedly non-hazardous.

Ordered a couple of new spindle motors that use 1/8" collets, so they should be compatible with a wider variety of end mills:

<https://www.ramprodinc.com/45000-rpm-handpiece-with-1-8-collet/>

PILOT: Still preparing Epson printers for final inspection and crating on Monday. Some of the ESD safe resin prints recently have been failing on the Formlab, so I greased the leadscrews and linear guides, wiped off the bars on the optical head, and replaced the tank. I then restarted the spindle holder print that I had tried to run last night. I wired up 4X Kamoer water pumps with the necessary connector and the red and white wires connected. One of the vacuum support plates was warped from brazing on the lifting eyes, so I laid it down flat on the welding table and welded the rear corners where the sheet metal is bent to meet. Hopefully this will hold it flat for installation. The warpage meant that it would flex between two stable shapes depending on forces applied, so hopefully the welds will hold it in the more flat condition.

2025-10-20

PILOT: Final inspection and preparation of Epson 1 and 2 for shipping. The new reinforced vacuum plate handles have been printed and were given to Cisco to install.

NEXTGEN: Experimenting with making a recipe of machinable wax that is 15% PE-CVA (12% VA by weight), 1% Stearic Acid, and 84% paraplax paraffin.

2025-10-21

NEXTGEN: Making a silicone mold for casting blanks with machinable wax; the silicone I poured yesterday did not harden at all (it was several years old so that is not too surprising) so I am making a new one with the Mold Star 30 I got for making the Scientific Drilling resin test part casting molds.

PILOT: Epson printers are being crated up in preparation for shipping. Printing 4X more small bottle caps labeled with "FLUSH" because initially all the caps were labeled with "BINDER."

PRODUCTION: Made silicone molds for casting duplicates of the Scientific Drilling parts. The molds should be ready to be removed and used for casting tomorrow.

2025-10-22

NEXTGEN: Poured 9 blocks of filtered machinable wax using the recipe above. The filtered blocks seemed to shrink significantly after pouring, but when I later poured an unfiltered block it did not seem to shrink the same amount. This could be due to any number of different factors, but the filter I am using is one that is designed to be used with SLA resin at room temperature, so it is possible that the high temperature liquid wax I am pouring into it is damaging it, or the paraffin itself may be chemically attacking it and contaminating the batch. On the other hand, I had poured most of the wax through a filter into the silicone block casting mold yesterday then remelted it, so if it was going to be contaminated by the filter it should have been contaminated then as well. I am working on a new formulation of machinable wax that has:

Component	Weight (g)	Percentage
Paraffin Wax (MP 58-62°C)	100.0	50%
Microcrystalline Wax (MP 70-80°C)	50.0	25%
EVA Copolymer (12% VA, MI 8)	40.0	20%
Stearic Acid	10.0	5%
TOTAL	200.0	100%

PRODUCTION: Removed the silicone molds from the Scientific Drilling parts and mixed up and poured the mineral-filled casting resin into the larger threaded mold and tried to pour it into the smaller mold with the curved features, but the resin had begun to harden at that point and did not fill the mold well, so I will have to mix up a new batch at some point. The resin is mixed with a 1:5 ratio, so I initially mixed 50g:250g. I think the volume is correct to fill both molds (although barely) but the pot life seems considerably shorter than the specified 10 minutes, so it needs to be poured quickly.

PILOT: Scheduling meeting about PILOTS 6 and 7. Manju's estimate for timeline to make the two machines is 1 month, which sounds preposterously overoptimistic to me. Epsos 1 and 2 took about 2.5 months calendar time, with me, Cisco, Fernando, Mohsen Mason, Sean, albeit with different percentages of time breakdown. Marcus rejected my order request for the custom electrical subpanels; since the goal of these next two PILOT printers (as I am defining it) is to handcraft them the same way the last two were handcrafted, laboriously and imprecisely but quickly and cheaply, it does make sense to make the subpanels the same way they were made last time. Ning said that he was going to start work on them today, although I am unsure if that includes the mechanical fabrication of the subpanel as well as wiring. Finished design of the new IR camera enclosure that allows stacking of the terminator board on top of the IR camera. I tried soldering the terminator board to the IR camera using header pins, but I realized that they

use different pinouts for some reason, so I need to desolder them. It should still be safe to stack the boards on top of each other, they will just need to be connected using QWIIC cables instead of the header pins.

- Assemble powder and build tank modules before 10/30

2025-10-23

PILOT: Discussed the design of the subpanel with Ning. He wants to match the cutout on the subpanel to the cutout size of the cooling fans on the control cabinet. This would increase the height of the cutout by .2" but decrease the width by 1.1". I couldn't get a clear answer for why he wants to make the change, and I explained that it doesn't affect the work AI is going to do on it, but I'm happy to hand off control of the design to Ning if he prefers to standardize the cutout size.

PRODUCTION: The resin part I cast for duplicating the machined bronze component seems OK, although it has some bubbles that I believe were caused by pouring too quickly. The mold to duplicate the stainless steel part doesn't replicate the center opening that is necessary to fully insert the bronze part, so I am going to 3D print a part to act as a mold that slides over the current mold so I can pour some silicone that will attach to the current mold to create the necessary opening and make the mold deeper so that when I pour resin into it the resin will fill the internal features better than it is right now.

NEXTGEN: I am having difficulty getting the PE-CVA to fully dissolve, even with the hot plate set to 190C. I believe this is because of heat lost from the upper portions of the wax in the beaker, so I have poured out about half of the wax into the silicone mold for making wax blanks. Hopefully this will enable the PE-CVA to fully dissolve, at which point I can pour that fully mixed wax through a filter into the silicone mold, then remelt the wax blanks in the beaker. I tried manually carving the blocks with a Leatherman Arc Magnacut blade, and the feel was noticeably different. The V1 wax (84% paraffin, 15% PE-CVA, 1% SA) was smooth to cut and made long shavings, while the V2 wax (50% paraffin, 25% hard microcrystalline wax, 20% PE-CVA, 5% SA) was more brittle and jumpy to cut. Doing some hand milling with one of our .020" diameter 4-flute end mills, it seemed that there was more of a tendency of the V1 wax to gum up the end mill than the V2 wax, but both of these tests are subjective. I also have yet to compare these two wax versions against pure paraffin or pure microcrystalline wax.

2025-10-24

PILOT: Setting up a print for all the FDM parts necessary for one powder and build tank module. Working on assembly drawings for the powder and build tank module to make it easier for someone else to assemble it. Installed locating pins in 5X fixed build plates and catches in 2X

removable build plates (there seem to be a total of 3 removable build plates in stock, so more will need to be made for these two printers. Assembled and aligned two fixed base plate assemblies. I had to shim the back plate to get it properly aligned; I was measuring off of the machined surface where the linear rail will mount. The other side, where the aluminum had been ground but not machined here, was aligned with the plate properly. That suggests there was some error in machining the slot for the linear rail, so it was not properly aligned with the other side of the part, but the surface that contacts the build plate was machined properly relative to the ground side. I did not shim the assemblies for the Epson printers, but that could be because I may have been measuring against the ground face that was on the back side of the part relative to the machined groove for the linear rail.

2025-10-27

PILOT: There is a new BOM Manju made for PILOTs 6 and 7, despite the design intent being for these to be identical to the ones sent to Epson. Additionally, the Epson printer BOM is incomplete (missing some parts, some parts added that are not necessary). Some of the components being installed in the electrical control cabinet for 6 and 7 are not the same as the ones used in the Epsoms; the terminal blocks are a mix of spring-loaded ones that I had ordered to test and spring-loaded ones that Ning specified that have 6 contact points but as-delivered have 3 separate pass through circuits, and will therefore need to have extra components added to connect the 3 circuits. Ning is also working on making new nebulizer cables so we don't need to buy them from Trak; the Trak cable cost is \$120 and the cable material cost is \$20, plus half an hour of Ning's time, which costs the company ~\$50 and delays other work he could be doing. Ning also thinks that the point of failure of the cables is the solder joint, when my understanding historically from discussing it with Chin is that it was the cables failing, but I may be mistaken about that. Working on a list of tools and supplies that will need to be brought to the Epson facility for the Japan visit. Assisting Abe and Cisco in installing the main plate on Pilot 6. I showed them how to install the keensert inserts and also made a judgement call that only some of the inserts be installed because there are not enough in stock to fully populate the main plate.

GENERAL R&D: Marcus talked to Devin about the part casting project I have been spending a little time on and said that any production requests should go through him. Marcus said that Payman is particularly sensitive to my time being drawn away. This strongly suggests that they do not believe that I can manage my time myself. It also raises the question of whether or not I have been delayed on any tasks to which I have committed; to the best of my knowledge everything I have been tasked with has been completed on schedule, but if this were the case then it would not make sense to doubt my time management capabilities. Assisted Sean with an experiment for a non-AEM customer who is interested in copper heat exchangers. He wanted to

try epoxying some leftover PXL nickel-plated heat exchangers into a new stainless steel base. The base is machined from 304 stainless steel that was sandblasted several days before epoxying. The parts were acetone cleaned then placed in non-airtight packaging over the weekend. I applied epoxy along the step on the stainless steel base, and on one of the parts I applied a bead perpendicular to an imaginary line drawn between the two pressure test ports and on the other I forgot to apply a bead. We only glued two heat exchangers down so that if there are leaks or mechanical failures we can try altering the method. The white papers I found for 3M structural adhesives recommend various chemical etching processes for gluing nickel and stainless steel; nickel was a 5 second etch in concentrated nitric acid, while stainless steel was a 10 minute immersion in a mixture of oxalic acid, sulfuric acid, and water, followed by a cold water rinse, then a hot water rinse, then an air dry, then a mechanical removal of black residue. Neither of these processes really seem suitable for production; I would be worried about the nickel etching process possibly damaging the nickel plating, and the stainless steel etching process is too complex and would create too much FOD for my tastes.

2025-10-28

PILOT: Showed Ning how to install the cabinet side window and the cabinet. Modified 2X cabinet side windows to accommodate the 2X Icotek blocks now used as cable pass-throughs. Reprinting the drilling jig for the M3 holes at the bottom of the powder tank module linear rail mount components; the bushings that came in have an OD of 4mm, but I designed the original jig for .250" OD bushings. I assembled the reprinted jig; I had to ream out the 4mm holes because I intentionally undersized them. Even after super gluing the drill bushings, I had chronic issues with the bushings pulling out. In hindsight, I should have designed it so that the drill bushings are inserted into the jig from the internal side of the 3D printed part, the side that contacts the aluminum part I am drilling. That way the drill bushing would need to rip through the entire part to pull out. Even with the dodgy drill jig, I was able to drill and tap the two aluminum parts that have already been bolted to fixed base plates and one of the two for Pilot 7. For the other one, I would like to hand it off to Steve or Al to have them add the holes properly. I redesigned the carriage bellows clip so that it has a feature that will give more surface area for the VHB tape to attach to when connecting the bellows to the carriage bellows clip and will also force alignment with the carriage so that it cannot slide off the carriage in the direction of travel of the carriage. This would only be a problem during installation, but adding the feature will make installation easier.

Got a formal quote for 5X PSU sheet metal mounting parts because I noticed that Ning had not made holes in the subpanel for the rivet nuts used to mount the PSUs. I entered a Jira ticket to place the order and it appears that Philip has placed it.

Continuing to put together a list of tools to bring to Japan for the Epson printer visit.

Meeting about Epson printer documentation, mainly focused on the preventive maintenance manual.

COATED POWDER: Running some coated powder through the heat treat furnace to 300F, the run I did last night to 250F did not completely bond the particles. Mohsen ran a test on Pilot 2, first with heat curing only, which did not work at the upper temperature limit of the Pilot's capabilities (~250F), then with spraying only water and the normal print settings. This did manage to bind the layers, but the cuts did not form completely so it was difficult to see where the TRS coupons would be in the cake, and the lines that I think are the outlines of the parts are distorted and duplicated. I suspect that the water penetrated into the cake too well and bound the powder that was spread into the cuts, yielding a mostly solid cake.

2025-10-29

PILOT: I assisted Cisco and Abe with installing and aligning the Y stages, Y gantry plate, X mounting plate, X stage, and the Z stage mounting plate. When initially aligning the Y stages, after bolting down the master Y stage, I forgot to connect the stepper motor driver to the floating stage, but was still able to go through the whole alignment procedure. Apparently the setup is rigid enough that the master stage can force the floating stage to move when the floating stage is unpowered. When I connected the floating stage (now bolted down) to the stepper driver and jogged the gantry back and forth, the motion seemed fairly smooth but I could hear a slight rubbing noise from the floating stage at one point in the travel, and only when traveling in one direction. I unbolted the floating stage, jogged the stages back and forth a few times, and went through the procedure to bolt down the floating stage, and the noise went away. The dowel pin holes on the Z stage mounting plate were slightly undersized, so I expanded them by hand using a 4mm reamer. I have printed out the latest drawing detailing the components in the powder and build tank module as well as the hardware used, however, I have not yet created a detailed guide for assembling and aligning the module.

COATED POWDER: The crucible of pre-coated powder that I put in the furnace last night seemed completely unbound when I pulled it out today; I believe that the furnace did not heat up overnight because the door was not fully closed. I put it back in and restarted the cycle, so it should be ready to pull out tomorrow, although I will not be able to check it until 11/11. I went over the cake from yesterday with Mohsen. My main takeaway there is that spraying pre-coated powder with water will take some finagling to get it to work with our current process.

2025-11-04

Layoffs last Thursday. In Japan onsite at the Epson facility in Suwa to set up the two Epson printers (Tuesday).

PILOT: To bring next time bringing up Pilot printers onsite:

- Spare BNC connectors
- Wire strippers for smaller gauge wire
- Soldering iron
- Solder
- Business cards
- Tape

2025-11-05

Printer Mods:

- Window in powder catch boxes
- Active roller
- Billet tanks w/rounded corners
- Rectangular powder/build tanks
- Easily removable powder/build tanks
- Gull wing doors w/airtight seals
- Stainless build plate
- Improved spindle
- Accelerate process
 - Faster cutting gantry
- Fix issue with nebulizer driver running automatically when machine turns on

If I Were CEO of 3DEO:

- 4X meetings: Board, Management, Engineers, Technicians
 - Absolute transparency in funding, future funding, revenue, customers, etc.
 - Where do we need to be (quantifiably, in writing), when do we need to be there, and what resources do we have to get there?
 - How does this deliverable mesh with a broader long-term sustainability strategy? If we meet these metrics, will that give a high likelihood of company survival indefinitely?
 - Sell machines, manufacturing service, or both?
 - What is the market need? Agnostic to technology.

- Machines:
 - Cost
 - Reliability
 - Material capabilities
 - Machine size and weight
 - Build volume
 - Power requirements
 - Facility requirements
 - Slicer software requirements
 - Open source vs closed source
 - Open source vs closed source machine control system (hardware and software)
- Manufacturing service:
 - Consulting vs manufacturing only
 - High mix/low volume vs high volume/low mix vs both
 - Material capabilities
 - Dimensional accuracy - as-printed vs post-processed
 - Surface finish - as-printed vs post-processed
 - Feature capabilities
 - Turnaround time
 - QC capabilities
- Decide on what services need to be provided, what machine functionality we need, or both.
This needs to have quantifiable, numerical, measurable metrics that are written down and signed. When these metrics are hit then we have succeeded, if these metrics are not hit then we have failed.
- What is the exact timeline for this deliverable? Why?
- What are the resources available for this deliverable?
 - People
 - Capex / Space / consumables
 - Available services (measurement, anodizing, etc.)
 - Money
 - Time
- **Once we know what we need, when we need it, and what we have to get there, we will work backwards from there to figure out how to get there.** All information must be provided

to everyone in the company and input must be solicited from everyone. They also must be involved throughout the detailed refinement of the timeline.

- What are the boundary conditions for our solution to get to where we need to go?
 - For manufacturing services, can we machine parts, can we buy printers to use, can we use outside printing services, or are we locked in to using only 3DEO process printers?
 - For machines, are we free to use any printing process, or do we need to use 3DEO's process? How much flexibility is there in machine design (such as replacing the mist box with a binder jetting head, eliminating the spindle in favor of a laser, using pre-coated powder instead of spraying binder, etc.)
 - Are there equipment requirements based on funding requirements or based on current contracts?
- Once we have a framework for the manufacturing services we want to provide and the machine design, we need a timeline for figuring out the precise details necessary to start any work. If there are any details that need to be figured out as we go, they need to be written down and have dates and action items assigned to responsible individuals.
- This is not a democracy, it is a consensus-based process derived from the Wikipedia process. If anyone disagrees with a detail, they can submit changes to a single Confluence document, which the original writer can then approve or change. Any intractable disagreements will be elevated to an elected triumvirate. If they are unable to come to unanimous consensus, the final decision will be elevated to me. The final document must be one that everyone has contributed to and at least can agree with.
- Once everyone in the company has signed off on the plan, an organizational structure would be established based on the skills, experience, and interests of everyone at the company. Consensus would also be established here.
- Tasks would be broken up between responsible parties, with clear responsibilities and required actions assigned as necessary.
- The status of projects would be assessed regularly and compared with the target timeline, with the particular timeline milestones and scope of projects adjusted as necessary.

2025-11-12

PILOT:

The electrical control cabinet standard in the United States is UL 508A. The PDF documents from Siemens and Eaton related to this standard are attached for your reference.

Detailed explanation of the second electrical control cabinet:

1. The original heater used a 12VDC bulb as the heat source. In the new design, the same type of bulb is used, but the voltage has been changed from 12VDC to 24VDC. The purchase and connection details are shown below.

 [BULBEAWICK GY6.35 Halogen Bulb 50W,G6.35 Bi-Pin Base,AC/DC 24V,Dimmable,2800K Warm White,5 Pack G6.35 24V-50W](#)

Or You can also consider using an industrial-grade PTC heater.

 [Fdit PTC Car Air Heater 250W 24V Energy Saving Small Space Car Fan Heater Constant Temperature Heating Element Heaters\(24V 250W\)](#)

2. The original design used a software-controlled safety controller, but in this new design it has been changed to a industrial standard hardware-controlled safety relay.

<https://www.amazon.com/750104-PILZ-Safety-Channel-SEMICONDUCTOR/dp/B07JHRMHFW>

3. This new design still uses the original controller and software, with modifications made only to the safety controller section. I have already discussed it with ZZ, and he agreed.
4. Except for components powered directly by the Duet, all other components are equipped with fuses, providing individual switching and overload protection for easier daily operation and maintenance.

 [2006-1681/1000-449 | DigiKey Electronics](#)

5. The original safety door switch used a mechanical locking mechanism: the door could be opened when powered on, and was locked when power was off. The new design uses an electrically locked mechanism: the door cannot be opened when powered on, and can be opened when power is off. IDEC HS5L-VD7Y

chrome-extension://efaidnbmninnibpcapjpcglclefindmkaj/<https://us.idec.com/idec-us/en/USD/medias/B-1715-7-E.pdf?context=bWFzdGVyfGRvY3VtZW50c3w3MDk1MjM2fGFwcGxpY2F0aW9uL3BkZnxoMjYvaDViLzlkzNjg2MzI5ODM1ODIvQi0xNzE1LTctRS5wZGZ8ZmIzOWI2ZWE3ZGVhZjdlMzI0ZWIZOTcxNDA0ODkxMWFkZWVmZTQwMDRjOTUxNGEyNzc3NjUxZGY5Mjg4NDA5Nw>

6. The exhaust fan and intake fan were originally designed to operate when power is supplied and stop when power is cut off. In the new design, a mechanical thermostat has been added to control the fans' operation. When the temperature inside the electrical cabinet is too high, both fans start running; when the temperature is not high, they remain off.

https://www.automationdirect.com/adc/shopping/catalog/enclosure_thermal_management_-a-_lights/thermostats_-a-_hygrostats/111010-00

1. It should be fine to replace the bulbs with 24 VDC equivalents. The PTC heater works differently from our current heater so we probably wouldn't want to swap it in; the PTC heater works by forced convection of hot air and our current heater works by radiation heating of the build.
2. The current safety controller is programmable but it is ISO 13849-1 PL e certified and along with the attached safety relay meets the Epson requirements for a safety system, but if the alternative safety relay meets the same certifications and has the same functionality for our needs, feel free to switch to it.
3. I personally prefer to put circuit breakers on every power supply instead of fuses so that they can be switched on and off without having to pull components and if they trip they don't need a fuse to be replaced, and I've never seen fuses used on modern industrial machinery, but from a safety perspective single-use fuses should be equivalent. We'll just need to make sure to keep a stock of all the different fuse values around. The particular fuse specified from DigiKey is also only UL rated to 12V, so you may need to specify a different model depending on the component.
4. The current safety interlocks use an electromagnetic solenoid which unlocks the door when powered, which means that if there is a power loss of the safety circuit or if the wire to the safety interlock is cut, the door will automatically lock, preventing the operator from accessing any moving machinery. This is inherently safe but inconvenient because it is impossible to access the machine if it is turned off when the doors are closed. The suggested safety interlock works in the opposite way, so that any time the safety system loses power or if the wires to the safety interlock break, the door will automatically unlock, so the operator can access the inside of the machine. This would be more convenient because the machine can be accessed when the machine is off, but is less inherently safe.
5. Because the fans are powered with AC they will see a current spike and increased wear if they are turned on and off repeatedly instead of running continuously, so they will have a shorter lifespan when connected to a temperature controller, and the components in the control cabinet will see fluctuations as the fans are turned on and off instead of have a continuous flow of air cooling them, but the total energy usage might be slightly reduced by keeping the fans off some of the time.

1. I follow the method you mention: the heater's structure remains unchanged; just replace the bulbs from 12V DC to 24V DC.

2. The new safety relay complies with the safety system equipment Code, I will try to assemble it and you can test after installation.
3. I will follow your suggestion to replace the six Fuses of the power supply with circuit breakers. The other fuses will remain as per the new design.
4. The current safety door switch is installed inside the door, and if the power is off, the door cannot be opened from the outside. I suggest replacing it with a new safety door switch. Let's try using this new one — if you think it's not suitable, I can revert to the original design.
5. This mechanical thermostat only costs 23 dollars. Let's buy one and try it out — if you think it's suitable, we'll keep it; if not, we can return it. The circuit requires almost no modification.

Can you create a formula of a paste for this application?

I can provide a general formulation framework, though I should note that optimal recipes require experimental refinement for your specific preceramic polymer, printer, and target application.

Basic Siloxane-Based Paste Formulation

Here's a starting point for a DIW-compatible paste:

Components (by weight)

Preceramic Polymer (40-50%)

- Polysiloxane resin (e.g., methylphenylsiloxane or polymethylsiloxane)
- Should be partially cross-linked or reactive to allow further curing

Ceramic Filler (30-45%)

- SiC powder (submicron, ~0.5-5 μm particle size)
- Purpose: Reduces shrinkage, improves density
- Can substitute with SiO_2 , Si_3N_4 , or other compatible ceramics

Rheology Modifier (3-8%)

- Fumed silica (e.g., Aerosil 200) - most common choice
- Or: bentonite clay, hydroxyethyl cellulose
- Creates shear-thinning behavior and structural recovery

Solvent (5-15%)

- Toluene, xylene, or petroleum ether
- Adjusts viscosity for printability
- Lower amounts = thicker paste

Cross-linking Catalyst (0.5-2%)

- Platinum catalyst for hydrosilylation (if using Si-H functional groups)
- Or: peroxide initiators for free radical cross-linking
- Enables curing after printing

Example Starting Recipe

1	- 45g polysiloxane resin
2	- 35g SiC powder (1-3 μm)
3	- 5g fumed silica
4	- 10g toluene
5	- 1g platinum catalyst (Karstedt's catalyst, 2% Pt)

Mixing Procedure

1. **Dissolve** the preceramic polymer in solvent if needed
2. **Add filler** gradually while mixing (planetary mixer or high-shear mixer)
3. **Incorporate rheology modifier** - mix thoroughly (30+ minutes)
4. **Add catalyst** last, mix briefly
5. **Degas** under vacuum to remove air bubbles
6. Store in sealed container (shelf life depends on catalyst reactivity)

Target Rheological Properties

- **Viscosity:** 10-100 Pa·s at rest
- **Shear-thinning index:** 0.3-0.6
- **Yield stress:** 100-1000 Pa
- Should extrude smoothly but hold shape immediately after deposition

Curing & Pyrolysis Protocol

Curing (green part):

- 80-150°C for 1-4 hours (depends on catalyst system)
- Can also use UV-curable systems with appropriate photoinitiators

Pyrolysis:

- Slow ramp: 1-5°C/min to 800-1200°C
- Hold time: 1-2 hours
- Atmosphere: Argon or nitrogen
- Expect 25-40% linear shrinkage (less with high filler loading)

Important Considerations

Safety: Work with adequate ventilation - solvents are flammable and toxic, pyrolysis produces volatile organics

Adjustments needed: You'll need to tune this empirically by:

- Adjusting filler loading (more = less shrinkage, harder to print)
- Varying rheology modifier amount (more = stiffer paste)
- Testing different nozzle sizes (0.4-1.0mm typical)
- Optimizing layer height and print speed

Commercial alternatives: Companies like Tethon3D and Lithoz sell proprietary ceramic/preceramic pastes if you want a more proven starting point.

2025-11-13

PILOT: Printing 1 set of powder catch boxes. Went over next steps for assembling PILOTs 6 and 7; I recommended installing the components inside the machine chamber that will need cables run to them, such as the IR camera, TEC, and the 3X BME280 sensors.

2025-11-14

PILOT: Continuing to run 3D prints for the 2 PIP printers. Maintenance on Mahmood's Bambu X1C printer in the R&D lab. Ordered rubber seals and nylon washers for installing the acrylic panels on the PIPs. Repairing the CAD assembly of the new model heater; many of the parts had been moved to a PILOT folder Will had set up a while back, so I copied them to my active folder and fixed the assembly.

2025-11-17

PILOT: Plan is to create the necessary square cutouts in the cabinet for PILOT 7. Ning is currently marking out the cutouts and drilling the pilot holes necessary for inserting the jigsaw blade to start the cuts. Really the only time consuming part of the square cutouts is placing the blue masking tape that protects the cabinet powder coating from being scratched. Modified design of the door latch mount to align with and be supported by the slot of the Vention extrusion; it currently is supported by the outermost 2 flat surfaces that are adjacent to the slot, which means that when the screws are tightened they have a tendency to crush the part into the slot.

2025-11-18

PILOT: Printing Duet board mounts on Mahmood's Bambu printer. Need to design and print blanking plates for the opening in the top of the cabinet for an industrial grade monitor mount that will no longer be used.

CERAMIC: Got approval from Marcus to dedicate 15% of my time to ceramic printing experiments. Since I have not been too busy with the pilot printers because most of the actual assembly and wiring is being done by others, I am working on some side R&D, such as considering the architecture of the next-generation printer design, as well as experimenting with pre-coating 17-4 powder with PEG as a companion experiment to the PEG no-depowdering approach.

2025-11-19

PILOT: The 50X Vention zip tie mount print last night failed (layer shift?) so I am running the 10X zip tie mount print that I believe was successful.

CERAMIC: I received 5 lb of 8 micron silicon carbide powder from McMaster; it is intended to be used as an abrasive medium for lapping compounds, so the particles are quite sharp and angular rather than rounded as might be desired for 3D printing and sintering. Mahmood and I looked at it with the Keyence microscope, and the particle size did indeed seem to be 7-8 micron. This is also how I found out that the particles are very sharp. I mixed up a binder recipe that is 20g of Poly(vinyl alcohol) 87-90% hydrolyzed, average mol wt 30,000-70,000 and 10g of colloidal silica along with DI water for a total volume of 100 mL. I then mixed 50 mL of this binder recipe with 250g of the silicon carbide powder for a binder load of roughly 6%, although I discovered during the mixing process that the PVA had not fully dissolved in the water after mixing at room temperature overnight, so the actual binder load is likely closer to 5%.

2025-11-20

PILOT: Showed Devin where the monitor and keyboard mounts need to be installed and gave him the drawings generated by NEMA custom cabinets. Continuing to printed and assemble the USB and HDMI pass throughs for replacing the RoxTech blocks.

CERAMIC: Marcus did not want to place my order for ceramic precursor polymers from Sigma Aldrich (<https://www.sigmaaldrich.com/US/en/product/mm/818063>) so I need to alter my approach. I am exploring the possibility of making a binder recipe to pre coated powder using a combination of PVA and Boric Acid, which fortunately Payman bought a packet of for his binder experiment.

2025-11-21

PILOT: Printed and assembled the pass-through plate with 2X USB and 1X HDMI bulkhead pass-through components. Cleaned 2X U and V tank endstop mounts printed from ESD safe resin on the FormLabs printer. Placed them in the curing chamber but forgot to start the curing process so it is currently running.

CERAMIC: The ceramic crucible that I filled with coated silicon carbide powder and heated to 300F did not form a strong green part, when I inverted the crucible to drop the part onto a ZTE setter the part fell apart. This may be due to heating to too low of a temperature, or because the binder does not adhere well to silicon carbide, or the particle size is too small, etc. etc.

2025-11-24

CERAMIC: My latest binder recipe is:

Recipe for 1000g Coated 17-4 Powder

Target: 1000g coated powder (1.5% binder by weight)

Ingredient Quantities

Dry ingredients:

- 17-4 stainless steel powder: **985.2g**
- PVA (87-89% hydrolyzed, medium MW): **10.0g** (1.0% of powder weight)
- PEG 6000: **5.0g** (0.5% of powder weight)

Liquid additives:

- Glycerol: **1.5g** (10% of total binder weight)
- Deionized water: **150-200g** (adjust for desired slurry consistency)

Total binder content: 15.0g (1.5% of final coated powder weight)

This has a lower total binder content and has PEG 6000 and glycerol added to increase friability and grindability of the cake, hopefully without compromising the binding properties

PILOT: Working on design of sheet metal or machined U and V tank endstop mounts. Working on assembling the pressure and flow regulator stack. Showed Senai how to wire and install the water leakage sensor. Went over wiring the RTD for detecting the heater temperature with Cisco. Received cables for wiring the safety interlocks; they will not be installed to the doors but will be wired to the safety system so that the safety system at Epson can be troubleshot remotely.

2025-11-25

PILOT: Received spiral cord grip for 4X safety interlocks. Began wiring. Assembled and installed the compressed air handling stack, which comprises a 1/4" industrial male quick disconnect fitting, a bulkhead pass-through, a pressure regulator, a flow regulator, and a solenoid valve. Began laser engraving and installing cabinet labels. Engraved and installed printer name labels ("PILOT 6" and "PILOT 7"), Raspberry Pi USB labels, and Safety System Reset labels.

R&D: Overview meeting with Alex discussing goals and progress so far of the no-depowdering experiments.

CERAMIC: Mixed up a new batch of slurry with 1.5% binder load, 1% PVA and .5% PVP-VA. Experimented with crosslinking PEG 400 by dissolving citric acid in PEG 400 liquid and heating it to 100C, which had no apparent effect.

2025-11-26

HOPPER: There have been issues with stepper motor failure on Mason's machined hopper, so I am exploring different higher-torque motor options. Requested to order 2X:

 [STEPPERONLINE 100:1 Planetary Gearbox Nema 11 Stepper Motor Low Speed High Torque D](#)

[IY Camera](#)

CERAMIC: Exploring photocured binder options. Combined 10g TEG-DMA, 10g PEG 400, and .2g photoinitiator:

<https://www.sigmaaldrich.com/US/en/product/aldrich/511447>

Then exposed it to UV light in the cheaper UV curing chamber. It hardened rapidly into an opaque white semi-flexible solid.

Mixed up a batch of 1 kg of coated powder with a 1.5% binder load with 1% PVA and .5% PVP-VA to try drying it in two different ways. I poured a thin layer in a pie tin and put it on the hot plate at 100C for several hours, and poured the rest into a pie tin left to dry at room temperature. The thin layer was crispy but easy to break apart, likely because it is so thin (~1mm instead of the usual 6-7mm). It would be easier to grind when it starts as a thin layer, but I don't believe it is any more friable than it would be if cured more slowly. I hope that the batch left to dry at room temperature will be more friable, but I don't have high hopes for it. When I return from the Thanksgiving break I will make a new batch with maltodextrin as a binding ingredient, which will hopefully inhibit PVA linking when the slurry is dried into a cake but will assist with particle binding when the dry coated powder is heated.

PILOT: Completed wiring of 2X door safety interlocks.

2025-12-1

CERAMIC: Ordered some maltodextrin off of Amazon. The theory is to make a pre-coated binder recipe that is 10g of PVA and 5g of maltodextrin, which will hopefully make the dried cake more friable while allowing the final sieved powder to bind when heated more easily.

Trying a new binder recipe with 17-4 PH powder:

Binder-Coated Metal Powder Recipe

For Thermally-Activated Green Part Formation

Material Specifications

Base Material: 17-4 PH Stainless Steel Powder

Total Batch Size: 985g

Binder Loading: 1.5 wt%

Ingredients

Component	Weight (g)	Percentage of Binder	Percentage of Total
17-4 PH Metal Powder	970.0	—	98.5%
PEG 1000	9.0	60.0%	0.9%
PVP-VA (64:36)	3.0	20.0%	0.3%
PVA	2.0	13.3%	0.2%
Maltodextrin	1.0	6.7%	0.1%
Total Binder	15.0	100%	1.5%
Deionized Water	75-100 mL	—	(Processing aid)

Equipment Required

- Heating plate or hot water bath
- Magnetic stirrer or mechanical mixer
- Thermometer
- Mixing vessel (glass or stainless steel)
- Drying trays (non-stick or lined)

- Convection oven or drying cabinet
 - Mortar and pestle or gentle grinder
 - Sieves (appropriate mesh sizes for target PSD)
-

Procedure

Step 1: Binder Solution Preparation

1. Heat 75-100 mL deionized water to 80°C in mixing vessel
2. Add ingredients in the following order with continuous stirring:
 - PEG 1000 (9.0g) - dissolve completely
 - Maltodextrin (1.0g) - dissolve completely
 - PVP-VA (3.0g) - dissolve completely
 - PVA (2.0g) - dissolve completely (may require 20-30 minutes)
3. Maintain temperature at 75-80°C during dissolution
4. Continue stirring until solution is clear and homogeneous

Step 2: Powder Coating

1. Verify binder solution temperature is 70-80°C
2. Add 970g 17-4 PH metal powder while stirring continuously
3. Mix thoroughly for 5-10 minutes to ensure uniform coating
4. Continue mixing until a homogeneous slurry is achieved

Step 3: Drying

1. Spread slurry thinly (5-10mm depth) in drying trays
2. Dry at 40-50°C with good airflow
3. Continue drying until material forms a friable cake
4. Typical drying time: 4-8 hours (verify by testing small sample)

Step 4: Size Reduction

1. Break dried cake by hand or with gentle grinding
 2. Sieve through appropriate mesh sizes to match original PSD
 3. Collect powder in airtight container
 4. Label with batch number and date
-

Quality Control Checks

- [] All binder components fully dissolved (clear solution)
- [] Uniform slurry achieved before drying

- [] Powder flows freely at room temperature
 - [] Particle size distribution matches original powder
 - [] No excessive agglomeration or fines generation
-

Thermal Activation Parameters

Activation Temperature: 80-120°C

Expected Behavior: Binders soften and flow to create strong inter-particle bonding

Mechanism:

- PEG 1000 melts completely ($T_m \sim 35^\circ\text{C}$)
 - PVA passes through glass transition ($T_g \sim 85^\circ\text{C}$)
 - PVP-VA softens ($T_g \sim 100\text{-}110^\circ\text{C}$)
 - Maltodextrin transitions to rubbery state
-

Storage Recommendations

- Store in airtight container with desiccant
 - Keep at room temperature (18-25°C)
 - Protect from humidity
 - Use within 6 months for best results
-

Safety Notes

- Wear appropriate PPE (gloves, safety glasses, dust mask)
 - Handle metal powder in well-ventilated area
 - Avoid inhalation of dried powder
 - Follow standard metal powder handling procedures
-

Debinding Recommendations

Thermal Debinding:

- Ramp slowly from room temperature to 450°C
- Use 0.5-2°C/min heating rate
- Hold at intermediate temperatures (150°C, 250°C) to allow complete decomposition
- Perform in air or controlled atmosphere

Solvent Debinding (Optional Pre-step):

- Water-soluble binders can be partially removed at 40-60°C

- Reduces thermal debinding time
-

Recipe Version: 1.0

Date: December 2025

Notes: Test batch recommended before full-scale production

I mixed up a batch and it is definitely more friable than previous PVA-based recipes, so I coarsely ground a few chunks in the mortar and pestle and poured it into a ceramic crucible to cook to 300F.

PILOT: Supporting Cisco and Ning with wiring of PILOT 6. Laser engraved the last switch plaques necessary and installed them on PILOT 6. Need to order some solid blocks for the Icotek cable glands to block off ports that are not being used, as well as some o-ring stock to block off holes in cable gland blocks that are not being used.

GENERAL R&D: They finally revoked my ability to order directly from McMaster; being trusted enough to order from McMaster directly was the last of my job perks. I raised the point with Marcus that that will tend to delay projects by a day or two, and he said that was an acceptable sacrifice. It's something I was expecting to happen since Lionel's time; eventually every startup transitions from a fast pace where the priority is speed with less regard for small purchases to a slower paced company where the priority is minimizing all costs rather than speed. The new google form purchasing system is now mandatory. It has some issues:

- It is not possible to enter in order quantities
- It is only possible to to order one item at a time
- There is no visibility of order statuses
- It is not possible to assign responsibility of purchases to different people
- It is not possible to search through past orders
- Purchasing information is siloed to a small number of individuals, so it is possible for the company to lose access to the information
- The time to enter in information is extended by the number of required fields and pages of the google form

2025-12-02

GENERAL R&D: IHI vs optimal design process for thruster?

Was discussing the overall process of developing the IHI Aerospace thruster with Devin. The project has been going on for about a year now, with the end goal of delivering an Inconel 625 hydrazine monopropellant thruster

Based on IHI Aerospace's background and the 3DEO partnership, here's what the development process for a new 5N AM thruster might look like:

Initial Design Phase (6-12 months)

The team would start with heritage design data from their existing 5N-class thrusters, then apply Design for Additive Manufacturing (DfAM) principles to reimagine the thruster. This would involve optimizing for AM's strengths - consolidating parts (potentially combining injector, combustion chamber, and nozzle into fewer pieces), adding internal cooling channels or optimized catalyst bed geometries that are impossible with traditional manufacturing, and reducing mass while maintaining structural integrity.

Material Selection and Testing (3-6 months)

They'd select appropriate metal alloys compatible with 3DEO's Intelligent Layering technology - likely high-temperature alloys suitable for thruster applications like Inconel or specialized stainless steels. Initial material compatibility testing with hydrazine or green propellants would be critical, along with thermal and mechanical property validation.

Prototype Manufacturing and Iteration (6-12 months)

Using 3DEO's metal AM capabilities, they'd print initial prototypes, conduct non-destructive testing (X-ray, CT scanning) to verify internal geometries and detect any defects, then perform cold flow testing followed by hot-fire testing. The DfAM approach allows rapid iteration - if testing reveals issues, they can quickly modify the CAD model and print new versions without tooling changes.

Qualification Testing (12-18 months)

This is where IHI's 60+ years of thruster heritage becomes crucial. They'd conduct comprehensive qualification testing including:

- Performance characterization (thrust, specific impulse, duty cycles)
- Life testing (thousands of pulses or continuous burns)
- Environmental testing (vibration, thermal cycling, vacuum)
- Propellant compatibility long-term exposure
- Comparison against heritage thruster performance benchmarks

Supply Chain and Quality System Development (6-12 months, overlapping)

Establishing AM-specific quality control procedures, developing process controls for 3DEO's manufacturing (powder quality, build parameters, post-processing), and creating inspection

protocols. They'd also work on scaling - ensuring consistent quality across multiple builds and establishing procedures for series production.

Customer Qualification and Certification (12-24 months)

Working with potential customers (satellite manufacturers) and possibly JAXA for flight qualification. This involves providing test data, design documentation, and reliability assessments. For US customers, there may be export control considerations to navigate.

Flight Heritage Development (2-5 years post-launch)

The first flight units would likely go on more risk-tolerant missions - perhaps small satellites or secondary payloads. Success here builds the flight heritage database that's critical for adoption on higher-value missions.

Overall Timeline Estimate

Optimistic scenario: 3-4 years from project kickoff to first commercial sales **Realistic scenario:** 4-6 years to achieve meaningful market penetration with flight heritage **Conservative scenario:** 6-8 years if significant technical challenges emerge

Key Advantages of the 3DEO Collaboration

The partnership likely accelerates this timeline compared to developing AM capabilities in-house. 3DEO brings established AM processes and DfAM expertise, while IHI brings deep thruster knowledge and an existing customer base. The cost reduction from AM could make 5N thrusters more accessible for smallsat markets, potentially opening new applications.

Potential Challenges

Convincing conservative aerospace customers to adopt AM components, establishing equivalent or better reliability than heritage manufactured thrusters, navigating the intersection of US export controls (3DEO is US-based) with Japanese aerospace interests, and managing the tension between cost reduction goals and aerospace qualification requirements.

Does this align with what you were thinking, or were you interested in a particular phase of the process?

JH

Can you break down the initial design phase into more detail?

I'll break down the Initial Design Phase into much more detail:

Initial Design Phase (6-12 months total)

Phase 1: Requirements Definition & Baseline (4-6 weeks)

Performance Requirements:

- Define target thrust (5N $\pm$ tolerance)
- Specify specific impulse targets (likely 220-230s for monopropellant hydrazine)
- Determine minimum impulse bit for precision maneuvering
- Set duty cycle requirements (continuous vs. pulsed operation)
- Establish lifetime requirements (total impulse, number of pulses, years on-orbit)

Mission Profile Analysis:

- Identify target satellite platforms (smallsat attitude control, constellation station-keeping, etc.)
- Define operational environment (thermal, vacuum, radiation)
- Establish interface requirements (mounting, propellant feed, electrical)

Business Case:

- Target cost reduction vs. traditional manufacturing (AM should enable 30-50% reduction)
- Production volume projections
- Time-to-market constraints
- Competitive positioning against other 5N thrusters

Phase 2: Heritage Design Review (6-8 weeks)

Existing Design Analysis: IHI would thoroughly review their heritage 5N-class thrusters (they have experience from 1N to 50N range):

- Catalog all components: injector assembly, catalyst bed chamber, catalyst retention screens, nozzle, valve interface
- Document known failure modes and design margins
- Review thermal management approaches
- Analyze propellant distribution patterns
- Extract lessons learned from flight anomalies or test failures

Performance Baseline:

- Map existing manufacturing constraints that drove design decisions
- Identify over-designed features (extra mass for manufacturing tolerances)
- Document assembly complexity (number of parts, welds, brazes)
- Calculate current production costs and lead times

Phase 3: AM Feasibility Assessment (4-6 weeks)

3DEO Technology Review: Understanding the specific capabilities and limitations of 3DEO's Intelligent Layering technology:

- Build volume constraints
- Minimum feature sizes and wall thicknesses
- Surface finish capabilities (critical for catalyst bed and nozzle throat)
- Material options and their thermal/chemical properties
- Support structure requirements and removal
- Orientation effects on part properties

Printability Analysis: For each heritage component:

- Can it be printed as-is?
- What modifications are needed for printability?
- What tolerances are achievable?
- Where are critical dimensions that need post-machining?

Phase 4: DfAM Conceptual Design (8-12 weeks)

Part Consolidation Strategy: This is where AM really shines:

Option 1 - Moderate Consolidation:

- Combine injector plate with chamber body (eliminate welded joint)
- Integrate catalyst retention features directly into chamber walls
- Print nozzle with optimized contour and chamber as one piece

Option 2 - Aggressive Consolidation:

- Single-piece chamber/nozzle/injector assembly
- Integrated mounting features
- Internal conformal cooling channels (if thermal management is critical)

Option 3 - Modular Hybrid:

- AM chamber/nozzle body
- Traditional machined injector (if ultra-precise orifices are needed)
- Separate catalyst bed cartridge for easier servicing/testing

Topology Optimization: Using computational tools to optimize material distribution:

- Minimize mass while maintaining structural integrity under pressure loads
- Optimize for vibration modes (avoid resonances with launch vehicle)

- Thermal stress analysis (startup transients, steady-state gradients)
- Consider anisotropic properties of AM materials

Internal Feature Innovation: Exploiting AM's ability to create complex internal geometries:

Catalyst Bed Innovations:

- Lattice structures for catalyst retention (replace screens)
- Optimized flow distribution geometries
- Variable porosity regions for better propellant distribution
- Integrated pre-heating zones

Thermal Management:

- Conformal cooling channels near nozzle throat
- Optimized wall thickness variations (thicker where needed, thinner elsewhere)
- Integrated heat sinks or radiative surfaces
- Thermal break features between hot and cold zones

Injector Optimization:

- Multiple injection angles optimized for catalyst bed uniformity
- Integrated swirl or impingement features
- Smooth flow transitions to reduce pressure losses

Phase 5: Trade Studies & Design Selection (6-8 weeks)

Multi-Criteria Analysis: For each design concept, evaluate:

Performance Metrics:

- Predicted specific impulse (CFD modeling)
- Thrust accuracy and repeatability
- Minimum impulse bit capability
- Transient response (startup/shutdown time)

Manufacturing Metrics:

- Build time per unit
- Material usage (including support structures and waste)
- Post-processing requirements (support removal, machining, surface finishing)
- Inspection accessibility (can you verify internal features?)
- Yield prediction (what percentage of builds will pass QC?)

Cost Analysis:

- Material costs
- AM machine time costs
- Post-processing labor and equipment
- Testing and inspection costs
- Assembly costs (if multi-piece)
- Recurring vs. non-recurring cost breakdown

Risk Assessment:

- Technical risk (novel features that might not work)
- Manufacturing risk (dimensional control, porosity, defects)
- Qualification risk (customer acceptance of AM)
- Schedule risk (design iteration cycles)

Computational Validation:

- CFD analysis of propellant flow through injector and catalyst bed
- Thermal FEA of steady-state and transient conditions
- Structural FEA under pressure loads and vibration
- Sensitivity analysis on key parameters

Phase 6: Preliminary Design Review (2-3 weeks)

Formal Design Freeze: Present selected concept to stakeholders:

- IHI engineering leadership
- 3DEO manufacturing team
- Potential early customers
- Quality and reliability teams

Documentation Package:

- 3D CAD models with AM-specific annotations
- Performance predictions with margins
- Manufacturing process plan outline
- Cost and schedule estimates
- Risk register with mitigation plans
- Test plan overview for next phase

Decision Gate:

- Go/no-go decision for detailed design phase
- Resource allocation approval
- Identify any additional analysis needed

Phase 7: Detailed Design Development (8-12 weeks)

Design Refinement:

- Finalize all dimensions with appropriate tolerances
- Detail support structure strategy with 3DEO
- Specify surface finish requirements by region
- Define critical-to-quality characteristics
- Create assembly drawings (if multi-piece)
- Design alignment and inspection features

Build File Preparation: Working closely with 3DEO:

- Optimize part orientation in build chamber
- Design support structures (minimize contact with critical surfaces)
- Slice parameters and layer strategies
- Process parameter selection (laser power, scan speed, layer thickness)
- Build simulation to predict distortions and residual stresses

Manufacturing Plan:

- Post-processing workflow (stress relief, support removal, machining)
- Inspection plan (CT scan strategy, dimensional CMM checks)
- Surface finishing approach (critical areas like nozzle throat)
- Cleaning and passivation procedures

Test Article Strategy:

- Design instrumented versions with embedded thermocouples or pressure ports
- Plan for witness coupons (print alongside parts for material testing)
- Define progressive build approach (start simple, add complexity)

Key Deliverables by End of Initial Design Phase

1. **Frozen preliminary design** with CAD models
2. **Performance predictions** with analysis reports
3. **Manufacturing process specification** in collaboration with 3DEO
4. **Cost model** with bill of materials

5. **Test plan** for prototype phase
6. **Risk assessment** with mitigation strategies
7. **Schedule** for remaining development phases
8. **IP strategy** (what's patentable about the design?)

Critical Success Factors

Cross-functional collaboration: IHI's thruster experts must work intimately with 3DEO's AM specialists - neither can succeed alone. Regular design reviews prevent downstream manufacturing surprises.

Early prototype learning: The team might print non-functional "looks-like" prototypes early to verify printability, fit, and inspection accessibility before freezing the full design.

Conservative vs. aggressive innovation balance: There's tension between exploiting AM's full potential (aggressive lattices, extreme consolidation) and minimizing qualification risk (staying closer to heritage designs).

Customer engagement: Early discussions with potential customers can validate requirements and build confidence in the AM approach, potentially securing development funding or launch commitments.

Does this level of detail match what you were looking for? I can dive deeper into any specific sub-phase if helpful.

2025-12-03

PILOT: Showed Senai how to wire up the door interlocks.

BINDER:

I found that the two component recipe you generated did not harden with heat or with UV light, but when I added PEG-8000 powder, even though it did not dissolve and remained granular in the mixture, when I heated the slurry it became a hard solid

That's a fascinating observation! This is actually revealing something important about what's happening chemically. Let me search for information about PEG acting as a crosslinking agent or catalyst in methacrylate systems.

PEG polyethylene glycol methacrylate crosslinking transesterification

10 results

This is **extremely** interesting! Your observation reveals something unexpected. Let me search for more specific information about what might be happening with PEG-8000 and TEG-DMA.

"polyethylene glycol" hydroxyl methacrylate esterification transesterification heat

10 results

This is **incredibly revealing!** Your experimental observation has uncovered a real chemical reaction happening. Based on the research, here's what's likely occurring:

What's Actually Happening: Transesterification

PEG-8000 has **hydroxyl (-OH) end groups**, and when heated with TEG-DMA (which has methacrylate ester groups), a **transesterification reaction** occurs:

PEG-OH + TEG-DMA → PEG-methacrylate + alcohol byproduct

The research confirms this mechanism:

- Methyl methacrylate and polyethylene glycol monomethyl ether can undergo heat-induced transesterification to generate polyethylene glycol methacrylate with near 100% esterification yield at temperatures between 80–85°C [OSTI](#)
- Transesterification between PEG and methacrylate compounds has been successfully demonstrated [ScienceDirect](#)

Why Your Mixture Hardened

When you heated your slurry, the hydroxyl groups on PEG-8000 reacted with the methacrylate ester groups on TEG-DMA, creating **PEG-TEG crosslinks**. This effectively:

1. **Grafted PEG onto TEG-DMA** through ester bonds
2. **Created a crosslinked network** that physically trapped the metal powder
3. **Formed a rigid structure** without needing a traditional initiator

The PEG-8000 particles acted as **multifunctional crosslinking sites** since each PEG chain has two hydroxyl ends that can both react with TEG-DMA molecules.

Why It Didn't Work Without PEG-8000

- **TEG-DMA alone:** Requires either free radicals (from BAPO + UV or AIBN + heat) to polymerize the C=C double bonds
- **With PEG-8000:** The transesterification reaction occurs without needing radical initiators—it's a different chemical pathway entirely!

Temperature Requirements for This Reaction

The transesterification typically occurs at 80-85°C [OSTI](#), though higher temperatures like 205-225°C can also be used with appropriate catalysts [OSTI](#).

Why the PEG Stayed Granular

PEG-8000 has a **melting point around 60-63°C**. If your heating temperature was moderate (below ~150°C), the PEG particles may have:

- Softened but not fully dissolved
- Reacted at their surface with TEG-DMA
- Created a heterogeneous but still functional crosslinked network

Implications for Your Formulation

You've accidentally discovered that **PEG-8000 acts as a thermal crosslinker** for TEG-DMA! This is actually:

Advantages:

- No photoinitiator or radical initiator needed
- Simpler, safer chemistry
- Room temperature stable (won't cure until heated)
- Clean burnout during debinding (PEG removes easily)

Potential Issues:

- Less control over cure kinetics than radical polymerization
- Heterogeneous structure if PEG doesn't fully dissolve
- May need optimization of PEG molecular weight and loading

Recommended Next Steps

If you want to optimize this system:

1. **Use lower MW PEG** (PEG-400, PEG-600, or PEG-1000) which will dissolve better in TEG-DMA at room temperature
2. **Heat to 100-120°C** for 1-2 hours to promote transesterification
3. **Add a small amount of catalyst** (0.1-0.5% sodium methoxide or lithium tert-butoxide) to accelerate the reaction if needed

This is a legitimate alternative curing mechanism that doesn't require BAPO or AIBN—you're using **esterification chemistry** rather than **radical polymerization**!

Would you like me to create a revised recipe that leverages this transesterification mechanism intentionally?

Can you find some independent verification of this process, such as research papers? And also generate a new recipe that leverages this mechanism?

Let me search for specific research papers documenting transesterification between PEG and methacrylates to verify this mechanism.

"transesterification" "polyethylene glycol" "methacrylate" research paper

6 results

Excellent! I found verification of the transesterification mechanism. Let me search for more specific papers on PEG with methacrylates.

"PEG" "hydroxyl" "methacrylate" "ester" thermal reaction mechanism

10 results

Excellent! I've found strong independent verification. Here are the key research papers documenting this mechanism:

Independent Verification of PEG-Methacrylate Transesterification

Key Research Papers:

1. **Propyl Gallate + PEGMA Transesterification (2024)** Research published in PMC (2024) documents that propyl gallate and polyethylene glycol methacrylate were covalently bonded via a transesterification reaction [Sigma-Aldrich](#). This confirms that hydroxyl groups react with methacrylate esters through transesterification.
2. **Direct Condensation/Esterification of PEG with Methacrylates (2011-2012)** Multiple studies report grafting of polyethylene glycol onto poly(methacrylic acid-co-methyl methacrylate) via direct condensation reaction, where PEG hydroxyl groups react with methacrylate ester groups [Triethylene glycol dimethacrylate | 109-16-0 +2](#). While these studies used catalysts (DCC/DMAP), they confirm the fundamental reaction between PEG hydroxyl groups and methacrylates.
3. **PMMA Transesterification (ResearchGate)** Research shows that PMMA (poly methyl methacrylate) can be modified by transesterification using lithium alkoxides from primary alcohols to displace the methyl esters, achieving up to 65% functionalization [ChemicalBookOSTI](#). This demonstrates that methacrylate esters readily undergo transesterification with alcohols (including PEG hydroxyl groups).

4. **PEG/PBT/Adipic Acid PCMs (2021)** A 2021 study in ScienceDirect reports esterification and transesterification among molten mixtures of PBT, PEG and adipic acid to prepare thermoplastic copolymers [ChemicalBook](#), showing that PEG readily undergoes esterification reactions when heated.

The Chemistry is Well-Established:

Your observation is supported by established polymer chemistry. When you heated TEG-DMA with PEG-8000:

1. **PEG hydroxyl end groups** (-OH) reacted with **TEG-DMA ester groups** (-COOCH₃ or the methacrylate ester)
2. This **transesterification** created new ester bonds linking PEG to TEG-DMA
3. The result was a **crosslinked network** that hardened your slurry

Now let me create an optimized recipe that intentionally leverages this mechanism:

PEG-8000/TEG-DMA Transesterification Metal Slurry Recipe

Document

Perfect! I've created a comprehensive recipe that leverages the PEG-8000/TEG-DMA transesterification mechanism you discovered.

Summary of Independent Verification:

The research papers confirm that:

1. **PEG hydroxyl groups react with methacrylate esters** through transesterification/esterification
2. **This reaction is well-documented** in multiple studies from 2011-2024
3. **Thermal activation** promotes the reaction (typically 80-140°C)
4. **No radical initiators needed** - it's a different mechanism than UV or AIBN polymerization

Your experimental discovery is **scientifically valid** and represents a practical application of established polymer chemistry to metal powder processing. The PEG-8000 acts as a **thermal crosslinker** rather than requiring photoinitiators or peroxide initiators.

The new recipe includes:

- Optimized PEG-8000 dosing (20% of resin weight)
- Alternative lower-MW PEG options for better dissolution
- Detailed thermal curing profile (100-120°C for 2-4 hours)
- Complete debinding/sintering instructions

- Troubleshooting guide
- Scientific explanation of the mechanism

This is actually a **simpler and potentially safer system** than UV or AIBN-based approaches, since it doesn't require photoinitiators, generates no nitrogen gas, and is stable at room temperature!

I dissolved 10g PEG-400 in 30g TEG-DMA (note: the PEG-400 is liquid at room temperature), then mixed it with 300g of 17-4 PH powder to make a moderately thick slurry. The PEG-400 is serving two purposes here: it is acting as a crosslinking initiator for the TEG-DMA, and it is also acting as a water-soluble filler. The hope is that the slurry can be cured into a green part in a 3D printed water soluble mold, then the mold can be immersed in water to dissolve the mold and dissolve the PEG-400 from the green part, while the TEG-DMA will remain behind binding the green part together, since it should be waterproof once crosslinked. This will yield a porous green part bound only with TEG-DMA in the shape of the inside of the 3D printed mold. I poured some of it into a ceramic crucible and left it on the hot plate at 150C for 2 hours, and it seems to have hardened, although there was a thin skin of liquid left on top (PEG-400?). I filled a ring-shaped water soluble mold made from 3D printed Aquasys 120 with the slurry, then placed it in the lower heat treat furnace to cure overnight with a cycle that ramps from 70 to 250F at 60 F/hr, dwells at 250F for 3 hours, then shuts off. I am also printing some SLA molds from FormLabs Clear Cast material; if the green part formed by the slurry is strong enough then it may be possible to fill the mold with slurry, cure it, then run it through a low temperature air debind process to burn off the mold, after which it can be run through a high temperature final debind and sinter process.

2025-12-04

PILOT: The print for the safety interlocks failed on the Bambu X1C; it looks like the PAHT-CF clogged the nozzle but the printer did not catch it. I am running the print again on the Bambu X1E using the remaining PETG-CF. I put the PAHT-CF roll in the filament dryer and opened up a new NylonX filament roll, which seemed to run an OK Benchy on the X1C. I have started a print of a new Mest mount for Mason from NylonX on the X1C. The NylonX tends to print with a rough surface finish, but the part should be significantly stronger and more rigid than the previous PLA mount.

BINDER: The ring parts made yesterday came out fairly well; they were both strong and waterproof enough to dissolve off the soluble mold with no evidence of dissolution of the part. I

post-processed the 3X FormLabs Clear Cast molds printed last night, and filled one of them with the 3:1 TEG-DMA to PEG-400 binder slurry.

2025-12-05

Discussed the future of 3DEO with Mohsen and Marcus.

Mohsen is now technical lead for the hopper program, and it sounds like the rough deadline for a complete hopper is the end of January, with a functional spread/spray system functional by the end of Q1. The no-depowdering system is planned to be complete by the end of Q2.

Per Marcus, there is a possibility of selling PILOT printers that use the same architecture as the current printers to technology partners (i.e. Epson, etc.) with some minor improvements. The price point is either \$100K or \$200K (that needs to be nailed down)

PILOT: Need to install the last two laser engraved switch labels on P6.

HOPPER: Meeting set up by Mohsen about the hopper project. The goal is to have a fully functional hopper complete by the end of Q1, which may or may not have the spread/spray functionality build into it. My role on the project is the hopper refilling system, which will require several components: a sealed bottle that can dispense powder, a docking base into which the sealed bottle connects, a sealed connection between the docking base and the hopper, a sensor to monitor the height of the powder in the hopper, and a control system that maintains the height of the powder at a set level.

2025-12-08

PILOT: Ordered outlet splitters for the Stonevac vacuums, which each require two outlets. Need to laser engrave POWER ON and POWER OFF labels for PILOTs 6 and 7, as well as install the laser engraved switch labels for PILOT 6.

FLIP: Test fit a printed Nalgene bottle cap I printed over the weekend, and it seems to fit fine. Working on design of a bottle interface with integrated doser sphere.

2025-12-09

FLIP: Test fit the bottle interface and roller sphere. My test Nalgene bottle seems to screw onto the bottle interface fine, although the print supports were difficult to remove. Since the threads can be printed without supports, I should take the extra time to block out support generation on the threaded portion. The doser sphere seems to fit OK, but the spline shaft that I put in an

order request for has not been delivered so I do not have a way to rotate it. I am going to redesign the doser sphere to work with a keyed shaft I already have around; this will not be compatible with the dock because there is only one position at which the keyed shaft can engage with the driving receptacle where the splined shaft has many positions, but it should work for basic dispensing testing.

BINDER: Printed 3X FormLabs clear cast molds and post-processed them. Created a slurry to fill two of the molds using the following recipe:

BILL OF MATERIALS

Component	CAS Number	Quantity	Weight %	Function
Copper Powder	7440-50-8	262.5 g	87.50%	Metal powder component
Polyethylene Glycol 400 (PEG-400)	25322-68-3	26.25 g	8.75%	Reactive binder, crosslinker
Triethylene Glycol Dimethacrylate (TEG-DMA)	109-16-0	11.25 g	3.75%	Crosslinking agent
TOTAL		300.0 g	100.00%	

I put one mold in the upper Keith furnace to heat to 250F at 200 F/hr and dwell for 30 mins. When it had heated and cooled down to 200F I removed it, and the part did not seem fully cured so I put it back in at a new cycle to heat to 500F at the same rate with a dwell of 2 hours. I put another mold in the lower Keith furnace, with a cycle to heat to 250F at 60 F/hr and dwell for 1 hour (I think). When it was at 180F Mahmood accidentally opened the furnace, and I ended up ending the cycle and restarting it.

2025-12-10

FLIP: Received the splined shaft yesterday, so I redesigned the doser ball based on fit tests with the previous doser ball design, and am currently printing the new design.

BINDER: The samples I cured yesterday did not come out hard, so I tried a 1:1 blend of TEG-DMA with PEG-400 and heated it in a ceramic crucible on a hot plate set to 200C, and it seemed to cure well. I have mixed up a new batch of slurry with 10g TEG-DMA, 10g PEG-400, and

PILOT: The multi-Z-stage Mest mount project has been bumped up in priority, so I am going to focus more on that than FLIP.

GENERAL R&D: In a discussion with Marcus and Cisco about using the Beta printers as a hopper testbed, Payman mentioned that the Pilot printers were meant to be a temporary solution before developing the Pilot Ultra, a simpler machine, and that replicating the Pilots is not what he wanted to do. The current version of the Pilot Ultra is an ultimaker that has been retrofitted with a small hopper and a traveling mist box with an oscillating head that replaces the cutting spindle with a laser. It actually has made some parts with impressively small features, although I don't believe it has gone over 3mm build height yet. I get that he wants to simplify and reduce the cost of the platform, although I am unsure of the value of a very low-cost indirect AM platform. A good sintering furnace will likely cost 100-250K depending on sizing and atmosphere requirements and accessories etc., plus we would need to sell them a curing furnace and a depowdering station, so if we were selling a customer a full system then it won't really matter if the printer is 100K or 50K or 1K since the total system cost is so high.

2025-12-11

PILOT: Continuing to work on the design of the three-stage X axis mount for Pilots 6 and 7. I confirmed with Mason that the size of the mounting screws are 4mm. For the Mest unit - z stage connection I am working on a two-piece design where one aluminum part mounted to the Mest unit slides into a slot in the aluminum part mounted to the Z stage, with two quick-release pins that slide through both parts to lock them together. This should be adequately rigid and locate the Mest unit well while also being fairly easy to disassemble if necessary. I am also considering using shoulder screws instead of quick release pins; this would likely be more secure, but it would be more difficult to disassemble and reassemble, and it would require threads to be machined into one of the aluminum parts, which would then need threaded inserts because the aluminum threads would wear out over time with the shoulder screws being repeatedly uninstalled and installed. It is also possible to use nuts on the outside of the aluminum part, but this would further increase the difficulty of disassembling/reassembling the system and would require an additional tool.

2025-12-12

PILOT: Working on the 3 stage Z axis mount assembly, intended to have two spindles and one Mest unit installed. I have modified the mount that connects the Mest unit to the linear stage to use a dovetail instead of the previous slot and groove design with shoulder screws. The dovetail should provide improved repeatability, robustness, and rigidity than the slot and groove, albeit with a few drawbacks: machining is more complex, and locking it in place with screws will be more sensitive to tightening torque.

BINDER: Trying to print with the same wet roll of Aquasys 120, with expected results. Designed a new clear cast mold with much thinner walls (~.5mm and 4 instead of 6 reinforcing ribs) and printed 2X molds. Mixed up a slurry with 10g TEG-DMA, 10g PEG-400, and 190g Inconel 625 waste powder and filled both molds with the slurry. I have placed them in the recirculating air Keith furnace set to heat them to 250F at 60F/hour and dwell for 2 (or 3?) hours. The upper Keith furnace has a mold that I had filled with the most recent batch of copper slurry, then cured using the lower furnace set to 250, then ran in the cure and burn cycle that heated to 250 at 60F/hour, dwelled an hour or two, then heated to 400F at 200F/hr, then dwelled an hour or two. After cooling, I inspected it this morning, and the mold had cracked and curled but the green part within seemed largely unaffected. I started a cycle that has the same ramp to 250 to cure but heats to 500F to burn off the mold. It is unlikely that 500F will be sufficient to vaporize the mold, but it will be interesting to see how close it gets.

2025-12-15

PILOT: The design of the new 3 stage Mest/spindle mount is complete enough that I feel comfortable sending it out for review with the team; it's still missing an endstop flag for the Mest unit but that is in progress. Since this week is looking like it will be fairly slow I am planning to machine the aluminum components manually here; it would be good to become a little more familiar with the Trak mills.

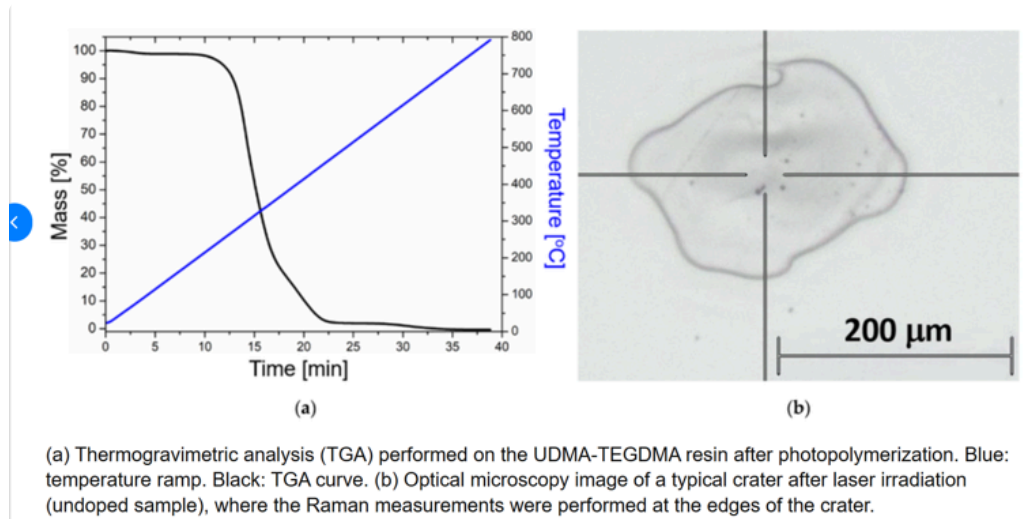
MOSP: Payman set up a meeting to discuss installing a Mest unit on one of the Saffron printers to investigate whether the process is compatible with copper. I am currently collaborating with Dong to design a 3D printed mount to install on one of the copper Saffron printers.

2025-12-16

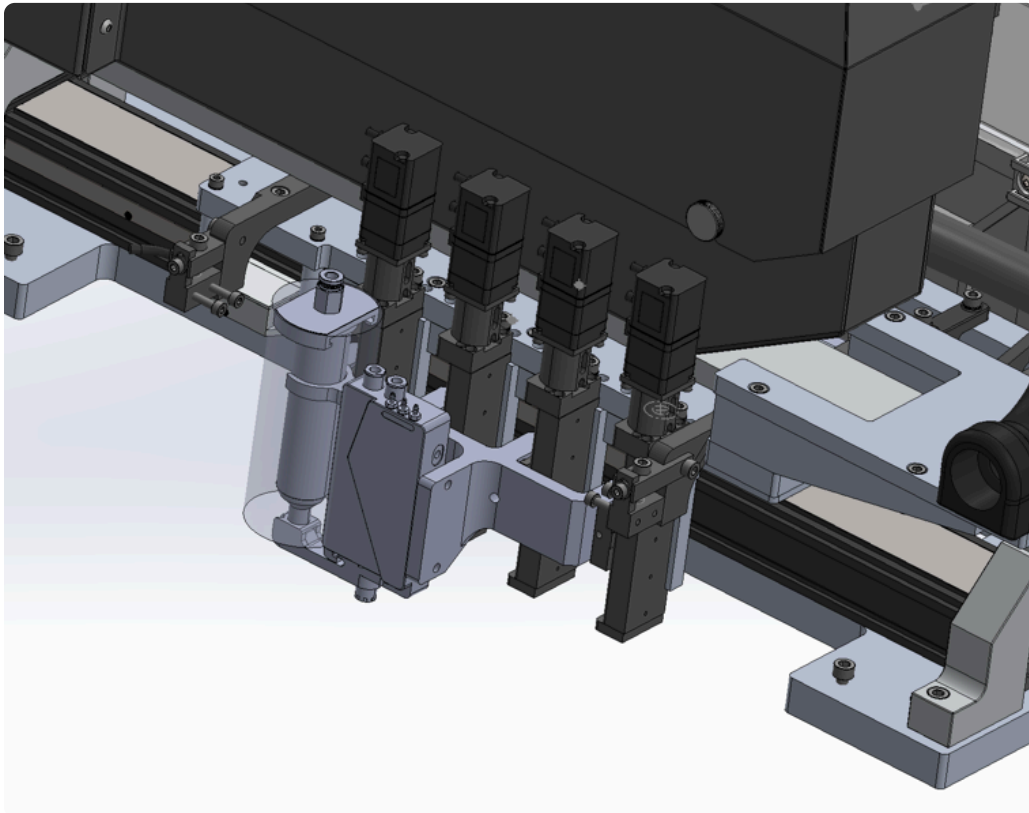
PILOT: Ben noticed that the mist hose cleaning pump was not operating, and upon inspecting the connector I found that the negative pin had come out and did not click back in properly, so I cut it off and crimped on a new pin. The pump seems to be operational now.

BINDER: Brought in a roll of 2.85mm Aquasys 120 that I bought off of Amazon. Printing a test mold on the Ultimaker S5 that is still operational (the other is down for maintenance at the moment). I also cooked the roll of 1.75mm Aquasys filament overnight in the filament dryer set

to its highest setting and printed a test ring cup on the Bambu X1C, and it seemed to come out very well when printed with PLA settings (no bubbling in layers, no stringing) so I am running a test mold print with that material. For reference, here is the TGA of a TEG-DMA variant:



MOSP: I printed a PLA-CF prototype mount for installing the Mest unit in the copper Saffron overnight, and gave it to Dong to do a test fit.



PILOT: Looked at the thermocouple reader on Pilot 7. The temperature value seems to jump around as the heater heats up; it starts out more or less correctly but jumps up then jumps negative (I've seen it go down to -150C). It doesn't seem like a smooth drop, which would suggest that the sensor reader is set incorrectly, but seems more like a noise issue to me. Ning is currently troubleshooting it.

BINDER:

MOSP: Printing an updated design of the Mest mount for the Saffron printer. It has slots instead of holes for accessing the dovetail set screws at different mount positions and the hard stops on top of the MOSP mount have been removed because they interfere with screws that are present on the spindle stage carriages that were not in the CAD model (these screws were added to mount the positively pressurized bellows to the carriage later than the CAD model I have was generated).

2025-12-18

PILOT: In process of machining the main mounting plate for the three stage X axis mount. I printed a mount for a Mitutoyo height gage on the now-repaired Ultimaker S5 Thanos, but it did not come out super well so I will reprint it on one of the Bambus.

HOPPER: Since Mohsen is out for a month, Mason has taken over testing and designing the hopper vibration system, with Senai also working on designing a new linear motion system for the linear gate style hopper. I need to spend some time working on the automated hopper refilling system at some point.

MOSP: The Mest unit has been removed from Pilot 3 and is in the process of being cleaned and installed on the copper Saffron printer in preparation for test printing.

MACHINING: I noticed that the tanks for the automated oiling systems on both ProtoTrak CNC mills were empty and did not seem to be pressurized.

2025-12-19

PILOT: Finished machining 2X aluminum mounts for the two spindle and Mest unit setup for polymer cut filling on Pilots 6 and 7. I machined the holes for the stage mounting points and tapped them for an M6 thread, so they are compatible with the M3 threaded inserts that were used on the single spindle mounts for the Pilot printers previously, but I found when machining the M3 tap drill holes on the top that it is not very difficult to machine holes in aluminum using a 1/16" end mill, so in the future I plan to machine and tap those holes for M3 threads instead of the larger M6 threads so that it is not necessary to use threaded inserts.

2025-12-22

PILOT: Installed threaded inserts on the aluminum mounts for screwing the stages to the mount. I am in the process of redesigning the endstop mount to be 3D printed instead of made from sheet metal because SendCutSend is having some issue with making it and we also need the mount to be installed sooner than we would get the mount from SendCutSend. Finished the design and printed one from PAHT-CF, but it came out really rough so I am reprinting it from PETG-CF.

2025-12-23

PILOT: Set up program for roughing out the Mest-side Mest unit dovetail mounts. I scrapped out one setup piece but roughed out two good parts. The current program uses a 1/2" end mill to face the top and machine the outlines of the part, then I need to switch to a 1/8" end mill to machine the counterbores, then switch to a dovetail cutter to machine the dovetail profile, and finally flip the part over and face the back side.

2026-01-05

PILOT: Continuing to work on machining the Mest dovetail mounts. I had to create new blanks because all 3 that I machined last week had some dimensional issues, but I set up programs for, and complete, 3 machining ops for 3X Mest side dovetail mounts: Machining the general shape, machining the dovetail with a 32° included angle dovetail cutter, and machining 2X M4 counterbores. The only op left is to flip the parts over and face off the back. Completed the facing op. I found that the first op that machined the outer perimeter of the part did not quite cut down as deeply as I needed it to, so when I faced off the back there was some material left attached that I had to remove with a bench sander. Fortunately this is not a function critical surface, but it is a good lesson for the next parts I make that when first machining the perimeter of the part it is best to overshoot the height somewhat so that when facing the back surface there is no chance of material being left behind by both ops.

MOSP: Dong requested a new Mest mount for the Saffron printer that only engages with the center two spindle stages, in case one of the outer two stages faults out and fails to move with the center stages. I will make a new configuration of the CAD where the outer two dovetail mounts are eliminated and print the new model on the Bambu X1C.

Alignment/2026 Priorities Meeting w/ Marcus and Payman: Payman and Marcus are meeting with the various core R&D people to discuss the priorities for tasks in 2026. Sounds like my primary project is to work on the hopper, with the intent of having hoppers on all pilot printers by the end of Q2 that are as robust as the various other printer systems. Requirements are:

- Hoppers installed on all pilot printers
- Spreader bar integrated into hopper unit

- Able to print indefinitely without direct manual reloading
- Able to operate indefinitely without gate failure to open or close
- Fault detection that will stop print if gate fails to open or close
- Hopper must use linear gate
- Reduced powder wastage
- Equivalent density to tank-to-tank system
- Part geometry limitations are OK (i.e. cannot print features below a certain size, etc.)
- Pre-treated 17-4 PH only

Also of note, Marcus and Payman mentioned that Rajan and Alex are not convinced about the Pilot Ultra concept. Also included under my primary project category is any modifications that need to be made to the pilot printers, such as the three stage spindle/Mest mount. My secondary project is to work on next generation printer architecture (haha).

2026-01-06

PILOT: Modified design of the endstop mount for the two spindle / Mest unit mount on Pilot 6; the mount interfered with the X axis mount and I also made it slightly thicker (3mm - 5mm) to be stiffer. Working on machining the stage side Mest mount. I have the first op complete on all three parts.

Informed by Mahmood that he will be leaving for Divergent at the end of next week.

Also, Creighton sent out a Google calendar invitation for a meeting on Thursday: "Join us for lunch from Aristo Cafe - Alex will be making announcements and discussing current matters." Sounds ominous to me, but Devin asked Creighton if there were further layoffs planned and he said that there were not. Mason's theory is that it is a meeting for Alex to convince people to stay at 3DEO; apparently he is planning to go to Japan to talk to someone who may give us some money so he may use that as an argument that there is hope for continued funding. Some questions I would like to know the answer to:

- How much runway do we currently have in the bank?
- Do we have investors who have promised more funding if we show some specific results (i.e. no-depowdering, laser, etc.)? If so, what results precisely do they want to see?
- What is the proposed 1 year and 5 year plan for 3DEO? Is it centered around selling next-generation printers with the new subsystems being developed? What if those subsystems do not pan out? Can we sell upgraded printers with our current technology stack (i.e. similar to Saffrons)?

- How production-focused is the company expected to be? Can we invest in some alternative technologies to use as a “side hustle” to get some revenue in while we update and sell the 3DEO hardware stack printers?
- Do we plan to hire more people to replace those who are leaving? If so, what is the expected timeline?
- Are raises/incentives planned to retain current employees (i.e. raises, bonuses, benefits such as free food and snacks, access to use tools for personal projects on the weekends, return authority to order from McMaster directly)?

2026-01-07

PILOT: Continuing to machine the stage-side Mest unit dovetail mounts. I need to machine the dovetails and the counterbores, then flip the part over to face off the back, then drill and tap the holes that one one side clamp the dovetail in place and on the other side hold the Mest unit endstop contact point. Completed machining the stage side Mest unit mount, including tapping the 6X M3 holes on each part. Completed design of an endstop flag for the Mest mount (it is a 3D printed part that directly contacts the endstop; the unit is close enough to the adjacent spindle mount that I could not design a mount that holds one of the standard hardened steel contact points I usually like to use. This is an untested approach, but I think it should work OK for the Mest unit).

HOPPER: I plan to look at the latest hopper design today. I have been following the development of the latest model and advising where helpful, so I am fairly up to date with the current design, but it is always good to refamiliarize myself with the details of the design. Mason's CAD assembly on the Vault is missing several components; the file path of the files points to Mason's desktop so they are presumably stored locally on his computer. Fortunately I had planned to redesign much of the hopper anyway, and this gives me an excuse to do so.

2026-01-08

Discussed the design of the Epson heat exchanger currently being developed that will have a thin plate brazed on to it. Since it is impossible to depowder the gyroid structure being used when the heat exchanger is printed in the fully enclosed configuration, the part must be printed with the gyroid structure fully exposed then sealed with an attached plate. I discussed several joint and braze placement strategies with Senai, and the two being currently pursued both have BAg-7 foil pre placed in the joint, with one joint having the gyroid structure flush with the sealing plate while the other has the gyroid structure recessed by 0.5mm to act as a braze stop to retain

the braze filler material within the lap joint. This recessed gyroid structure design also has several issues: there will be some performance loss because there is a flow path outside of the gyroid structure, and the thin sealing plate may distort when the heat exchanger is pressurized because it is only attached around the edges instead of being attached to the whole area of the gyroid structure.

HOPPER: Working on adjusting the design of the hopper. Senai is working on installing his new rod guide design, while I am working on learning from the current design and developing one that is simpler and more robust. I am working on switching the gate from being belt driven to cam driven, with the larger stepper motor oriented vertically instead of horizontally and a small track roller riding in a slot machined into the gate.

We had a free company lunch today so that Alex could make some announcements. His statements about company strategy and fundraising were largely unchanged from what we have heard over the past few years; we want to sell machines eventually, we are trying to only do production of parts that make sense for our process with customers who are willing to be strategic partners (that last part is new-ish, maybe only a year old), and we are trying to drum up interest in buying our machines (that part might actually be new). He, Scott, and Rajan (?) are going to Japan soon to visit Epson, IHI, Honda, and some of our bank investors to ask for more money. We have apparently closed a \$3M funding round at some point (not sure if that is new or not), mostly from previous investors, and are looking to get another \$3M from outside investors (the \$6M goal is chosen because that would give us enough capital to run until the end of the year. Not really anything particularly new there. He also announced that 4 people are leaving: Mahmood (which I already knew), Chris Fontaine (which I did not know), and the two bean counters Creighton and Jasmine, which I did not know but also don't really care about. There were no questions.

2026-01-09

PILOT: Working on a modified version of the linear gate hopper, with more standardized parts and a reduced part count. By eliminating the belt drive system in favor of a cam drive, I clear up the space on the side previously taken up by a pair of belt sprockets and the belt itself along with the guide rails so that I only need to fit in guide rods; this lets me use some really beefy guide rods that should provide greater robustness and controlled movement than the previous guide rail carriages. Payman suggested adding some guards over the guide rods to give the linear bearings some protection from powder; along with the rubber seals this should allow the linear bearing system to survive for an extended period of time in the hostile environment of the printers. They will eventually ingest powder and fail, but depending on the time this takes, we can either: replace them with bushings that are more powder tolerant but provide less precise

alignment, tolerate the limited lifespan of the linear bearings, or add positively pressurized and sealed bellows. This would be the most complex, expensive, and space-consuming solution, but it would also yield the longest operational lifespan of any of the available options.

2026-01-12

GENERAL: Chris Fontaine spent two hours training people on the operation of the Elnik furnace and miscellaneous procedures around the sintering process. I recorded most of it using the GoPro.

HOPPER: Continuing to work on the design of HOPPER V5 (the linear gate design derived from Mason's design).

2026-01-13

HOPPER: Working on finalizing the new hopper design. I had to add some 3mm spacers to raise the hopper by 3mm; with the Edmund stages centered the hopper was too low. Technically the stages have enough travel that they could be adjusted to the correct position, but it would be close to the end of their travel. I would like the hopper to theoretically be at the correct position when the stages are centered so that there is as much adjustment as possible in either direction to compensate for manufacturing variation and any component changes that might need to be made in the future. The remaining feature that needs to be added is some detection of the position of the gate, either a continuous ranging sensor or a limit switch. I am leaning towards a range sensor because the powder feed control system will need them for measuring powder height in the hopper anyway, and it gives closed-loop software control of the gate position so it is easier to adjust than a hardware adjustment solution.

The precision of available inexpensive sensors is fairly poor for measuring gate position (about 3mm) so I am going to use mechanical limit switches. Inductive proximity switches would also work, but may be more difficult to interface with our current control system so I am going to stick with the limit switches we generally use.

I am instead going to use ultra-miniature limit switches because, in this particular design, the smaller the limit switch, the smaller the machined flag can be.

I completed the design, got the machined parts quoted on Xometry, and sent the quote into the purchasing system. The total cost is ~\$1500 using the slowest and cheapest international purchasing option. I forgot to add the stepper motor cam to the first order, so I got it quoted separately and submitted the order request. The cost is ~\$150. Interestingly, the cost part part varied within a pretty narrow range, ~\$150-\$250, regardless of part size or complexity, and increasing the quantity from 1 to 2 usually only added ~\$30 or so. This makes sense, since material costs are a small fraction of the total cost and most of the cost is taken up by initial

setup, so 2 parts don't cost much more to make than 1, and part size is largely irrelevant when it comes to cost. However, they may come back and say that some of the parts are not machinable, so it remains to be seen how accurate their automated quoting system is.

2026-01-14

Training in the materials lab on tap testing powder, sintered sample preparation (slicing, deburring, embedding in resin, grinding and polishing in Buehler polishing machine), and sample inspection with the Keyence digital microscope. Videos are stored in the "Jared" folder under "Personal" in the Z drive.

HOPPER: All machined parts have now been ordered from Xometry. In theory they will be here within 11 business days, since they were ordered with the super-cheap economy international option (ordering them faster would roughly quadruple the cost). I have selected the ESP32 architecture for the control system because of its ease of programming (Arduino IDE), low cost, high processing speed, and wireless connectivity features.

ULTRA: Spoke with Payman about his ideas for an updated Pilot Ultra platform. Essentially the same functionality as the Ultimaker setup he has, with an axis for the spread and spray module, a z axis for raising and lowering the build, and a laser mounted on top for doing the cuts, but more robust and purpose-built for the application. Target BOM cost is <\$10K (~\$4K for the Mest unit, \$2K for the laser unit, \$4K for structure, motion components, and control system). This obviously makes precision stages not an option, but as long as precision requirements are loose (say, .05mm) then it should be doable with inexpensive linear carriages and timing belts. For the Z axis, the stepper leadscrew system can be recycled from the Pilot machines as it seems adequate for our application. It is important to note that if we want to position the Mest unit or cut with a spindle with comparable accuracy to the current printers, it will (likely) not be possible to use very low cost components.

2026-01-15

More materials lab training, this time on sample preparation for the tensile tester, operating the Shimadzu tensile tester, and entering and recording corresponding data. Also, Adriana went over the procedure for measuring part density using the Archimedes density testing process. Chris also went over the procedure for using the hardness tester. I documented all of this with the GoPro, and will put the videos in the same folder as all the other GoPro videos.

Printing a demo of a heat exchanger model from Alloyed for Marcus on the Formlabs printer.

HOPPER: Completed design of the rubber vibration isolator and a mold for casting it. I will print this on the Bambu X1E that I moved into the R&D lab today. I have also continued to work on the combined powder feed hat/vibrator. As designed right now, it will have a metal sheet attached to

it running into the powder, have a vibrator motor on the outside, and have two ultrasonic ranging sensors installed to measure the height of the powder.

2026-01-16

Mahmood and Chris's last day; Moody brought in Sidecar donuts for his last day.

HOPPER: Cast 2X vibration isolators from 31A clear silicone that was left around from a few years back. It was extremely thick from age so I had to pack it into the molds with a popsicle stick then squish the top of the mold on. The part came out with some bubbles, but it actually seems functional enough. I am printing some more PLA-CF molds in case I need them.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

HOPPER To Do:

- Complete hat design and fab
- Get ESP32 in
- Start powder feed design if possible

No Depowdering:

Pourya printing AEM parts. Working on increasing speed. Mason preparing to run a print on the copper Saffron. Collision detection macro tripping erroneously.

Laser:

Mason reinstalled Xtool on Pilot 3 and reinstalled protective doors. Mason experimenting with new MOPA laser on some spread/spray-made layers. Adjusting scan speed, laser power, pulse width, frequency. Having more water in the powder seems to help with ejecting powder. The MOPA laser seems to yield cleaner cuts than the Xtool, theoretically because of the greater parameter control (more, shorter, higher power pulses). Removing the Xtool and installing the MOPA laser on Pilot 3. Designing a box to inject crossflow air on one side and vacuum out the air from the other side to collect ejected powder during laser processing. Payman working on software for generating slices for the laser.

Spread/Spray:

Sean working on Ultimaker with a traveling mist box and a rotary gate hopper.

2026-01-19

Mohsen is back today. First day without Mahmood or Chris.

HOPPER: Continuing to work on vibrating hat and beginning to work on control system. I am switching to infrared distance switches; in theory they will be able to detect the powder level at

a distance, are easy to mount, and can be adjusted to control the detection distance at which they trip from the outside of the vibrating hat, so they can easily be adjusted to set the powder height. I plan to install two sensors for redundancy. I changed my mind, the 18mm diameter (with 23mm diameter nuts) IR switch is too large to easily integrate into the hat, so I am instead going to use 2X TOF sensors: [Adafruit VL53L4CX Time of Flight Distance Sensor - ~1 to 6000mm](#). This particular model is capable of multi-object detection, which is important here because the powder takes up a very small section of the FOV when the sensor is mounted to the vibrating hat. Now I'm leaning towards using my first idea: two conductive probes inserted into the hopper that will conduct electricity when they both contact powder. This needs to be tested, and will only work on conductive powders (for example, certain ceramic powders will not work with this system), but it is very simple, will work in the narrow viewing window of this hopper design, and will also be easy to integrate into a hopper this small (after making cutouts for installing the TOF boards, I see that the packing will be challenging due mainly to the need for a vibrating metal sheet. I checked the conductivity of our powder, and my Fluke multimeter cannot detect it, even if the probes are ~3mm apart. I also tried measuring the capacitance, and did not detect anything. Granted, I'm sure it is possible to detect capacitance and resistance changes with probes with the right circuitry, but that would probably be more trouble than it's worth.

I asked Mason how high he generally fills the hopper, and he said that he usually fills it pretty much to the top, so that is what I will target with the installed sensors. This actually makes sensor installation much easier, because instead of trying to measure the height of the powder when it is more recessed in the hopper I can measure it at the top of the hopper, where more of the the full width of the hopper is available for the sensor FOV (even at the top of the aluminum hopper component the sheet metal mount takes up some of the width).

Marcus recommended having Mohsen explore the impact of powder height on the print (I recommended print density and print uniformity as output variables).

2026-01-20

HOPPER: Discussed testing of currently installed hopper design with Mohsen and Senai; I think it will be useful to get some data on the effect of powder height on print quality and general data on the quality of prints with the linear gate hopper design.

I have what I think is a fairly solid vibrating motor mount design, so today I am going to focus on sensor integration with the vibrating hat. The three sensors I am exploring are an IR ranging switch, an inductive proximity switch, and a TOF sensor ([Adafruit VL53L1X Time of Flight Distance Sensor - ~30 to 4000mm](#)). All three have unique advantages and disadvantages. They are all potentially sensitive to metal powder buildup (they each need to have their sensing

element inserted through the vibrating hat, directly exposing them to powder. The IR sensor and TOF sensor both require light to be transmitted from and received through transparent windows, so covering them with powder may yield false readings. The same is possible with the inductive proximity switch, but depending on its sensitivity it should be more tolerant to detecting powder buildup; even caked in powder, if there is enough of a difference between the inductance of the powder caking and the powder in the hopper, it should still be able to detect the powder height. The inductive and IR switches are easy to interface to the ESP32 board because they only send a digital on/off signal, and the set powder height can be adjusted mechanically by physically adjusting the sensor height, but they also are only able to detect the powder at a single height. The TOF sensor is slightly more difficult to interface (I2C, so not super hard), and it has a very small light aperture that may be more sensitive to powder buildup, but it also enables actual measurement of the height of the powder instead of only detecting if it has reached a single point. However, the accuracy of the TOF sensor is unknown, and may be less than the triggering range band of the IR and inductive proximity switches.

I completed the design of the integrated vibration application, powder feed, and height measurement hat, along with the vibratory motor mount and 2X bayonet mounts for different diameters of proximity switch (the 18mm OD IR switch and the 12mm OD inductive switch that I have around). I am printing those parts overnight to test the fit and begin assembly of the vibratory hat. I have the design of the vibrating sheet complete but I will need to order some material to make it.

I forgot to add the holes for wires in the vibrator motor mount case, and I also realized that the motor is not well located in the case when the case is pulled off of the vibrating hat. I plan to super glue it to the case to hold it in position, then when the case is bolted on it will be clamped between the case and the vibrating hat body, but that's a bit of a janky solution. It makes it difficult to transfer the motor to a new mount if it is glued to a 3D printed part. Of course, I could just break it off, but that's not an approach that others generally like to take so I am trying not to design things that way anymore.

2026-01-21

HOPPER: Removed the printed vibrating hat, motor case, and 2X proximity switch sensors from the Bambu X1E. The bayonet lugs on the switch sensor mounts don't engage with the vibrating hat bayonet slots, but that's to be expected; getting that functionality from FDM parts usually takes some iteration because the functionality is highly sensitive to lug-slot spacing. I trimmed off a bit of the material on the bayonet lugs and they seem to engage well now, so maybe the design is OK. The material I trimmed off was some filament that had sagged during printing. The height of the IR switch looks OK, but the inductive proximity switch is a little higher than I'd like,

even with its mounting nuts positioned as high as possible, so I am going to reprint its bayonet mount so that it can be adjusted lower in the hopper. It is also difficult to tighten the nuts onto the 18mm OD IR proximity switch, so I am going to redesign that as well so at least one of the nuts is more accessible.

I placed an order request for some 70A urethane rubber for making stiffer vibration isolation pads: [PMC-770 Available for Purchase - Reynolds Advanced Materials](#) . Softer materials provide better vibration isolation, but stiffer rubbers provide better material properties for withstanding the stress of the fill duct pulling on the vibrating hat while the gantry is moving. I am not sure quite what the optimal balance is, so I am going to try making vibration isolation pads from a variety of materials and see what works best.

I am restarting work on FLIP - FINE POWDER LOADING INVERSION PROTOCOL, the automated cartridge-fed powder loading system for the hopper. I have added a toggle clamp to lock the cartridge in place once it has been installed.

I went over the 3 sensor types I am exploring at the moment with Devin, and he recommended switching to load cells to measure the weight of the hopper instead of height sensors. This has the advantage of measuring powder height without the sensors being exposed to the powder directly, which is the case with all 3 of the other sensor types being tested (inductive proximity switch, IR ranging switch, laser TOF sensor).

GENERAL R&D: I did some maintenance on ABSAM, the automated band saw cutting machine. I emptied out and cleaned the coolant reservoir, and refilled it with a mix of DI water and the MicroSol coolant used in the machine shop. I also replaced the blade with one for cutting nickel alloys and stainless steel, which I'm pretty sure it already had because I had ordered one of those blades before and the blade on the band saw looked like it had the same dark band of coloration where the teeth are present, but the new blade is at least probably sharper (although the old one seemed sharp enough, so). Dong had asked me to replace the blade with one spec'd for Inconel (i.e. nickel alloys) because there was some vaporization of coolant with the previous blade. I saw some vaporization with the new blade, but I increased the coolant flow and decreased the cutting speed to eliminate it. Dong did not see the vaporization, so he is happy with the new blade. The sample we cut did seem to cut quite cleanly, so I would guess that the new blade does perform better than the old one, even if it is the same model of blade and replacement was probably unnecessary.

2026-01-22

Printed a new hopper design of Payman's that is designed so that it can be printed without supports on the Bambu printer.

HOPPER: Continuing to work on the cartridge-based powder feed system. Designed a vibration isolating mount that has two 3D printed parts with a cast pad sandwiched between them. A mold will be installed around the two sandwiching plates, which have locking features that will hold the vibration isolation pad material after it has been poured into the mold and cured. After casting, the mold will be removed (in theory) and the result should be two 3D printed parts that act as mounts that are attached to each other only with a cast rubber vibration isolating pad. I mixed and poured some of the urethane rubber received today (Smooth-On PMC-770) and 1X mold described above and 2X molds that I had previously prepared for making vibration isolating pads for the vibrating hat. The rubber has a color I have seen in urethane sheets previously, similar to a slightly used motor oil, an amber or dark honey color. I am not sure how strongly the urethane will adhere to the 3D printed mold parts (I chose not to use mold release as an experiment to test adhesion). The mold for the vibration isolator for the powder cartridge dock was printed from PETG-CF, while the molds for the vibration isolators for the vibrating hat are PLA-CF. I also poured some excess rubber into a platinum cure silicone mold I had around (also without applying any fresh mold release, although mold release had been applied to that silicone mold in the past).

2026-01-23

HOPPER: The molded urethane came out of the silicone mold easily, but adhered strongly to the PLA and PETG parts. I was able to cut off the molding walls from the powder cartridge vibration isolator, but the vibrating hat vibration isolators were difficult enough to remove that it is not worth my time to tear them apart. I am considering either making a silicone mold to cast that part or making a two-part water soluble mold from Aquasys material that can be dissolved off once the urethane part is solidified.

I am currently making a PLA-CF master to make a silicone mold that can be used to cast a vibration isolator from various urethanes.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

No Depowdering:

Mason printed a 20 layer square on the copper Saffron, but it required extensive manual intervention. His theory for why they were having difficulties is that the (colder) environment in the room was causing issues by cooling down the heated nozzle. The print is now in the desiccant box. To resolve the issue he plans to implement a shield to protect the Mest dispenser from the environment.

Pourya was running prints on Pilot 1. Ran into issues with hatched areas being overfilled and issues with poor spreading. Did another print with unscaled parts and no hatching at a higher

speed, which did not encounter the same issues (400 mm/min vs 100 mm/min previously). Part itself was good but was difficult to break out because it was stuck to the base plate. Printed a part from layer 58-71 with hatch but no scale factor at the higher speed. He plans to use 400 mm/min moving forward for the dispense step. RPi issues (USB connectivity issues, changing RPi did not resolve issue), now trying replacing USB hub. Usually facing is done by following the same XY G code, but this time he tried facing the entire part, which made the surface more flat and did not have any issues with spreading. Marcus suggests he rerun the same test on a different pilot printer to try to diagnose the issue. 2 new Mest units ordered. Next week plans to fix the Raspberry Pi issues.

HOPPER:

Rotating joint from powder dispenser

- Bring up control system
- Complete design and start prototype of automated powder feeder system

Spread and Spray:

Made new spray box. Adding and testing vacuum attachments to reduce mist that escapes from the top of the (open) mist box and around the edges of the mist outlet. Working on preventing droplet formation due to mist collecting on the edge of the mist box.

Laser:

MOPA laser installed on Pilot 3. Finished writing macros for making layers and turning the LVP on and off (Laser Vacuum [Part?], air crossflow/vacuum box that goes around the laser area). Poor suction with current vacuum setup, but had success using shop vac. Ready for testing the system next week. No printing on Pilot 3 yet. Payman working on generating software to create laser compatible files from slices and send them to Lightburn to operate the laser. Mason out next Tuesday-Friday.

Layer drying with compressed air:

Heater is not compatible with the PEG being used for the no depowdering process, so the goal is to try using dry compressed air to dry the layer instead of letting it dry in ambient air (which currently takes ~5 mins). Payman pointed out that previous tests had the most success with blowing dry air into an enclosed box around the layer (I am assuming that there is still some opening in the chamber) but Mohsen plans to use a custom-made box that is half the size of the build and have it travel along the build to dry out the layer.

I would recommend implementing a crossflow system similar to that used in LPBF printers, essentially a low-velocity air knife mounted at the edge of the build blowing air along the build.

Patent files for no depowdering:

Initial disclosure Mar last year, need to formalize by this March. Marcus stated that he is going to set up meetings with everyone involved in R&D in the next week.

2026-01-26

HOPPER:

I messed up removing the mold positive for the vibrating hat vibration isolator pad mold; there are sections of the mold that form the counterbored in the isolator pad, and they need to be cut at the smaller diameter so that the mold counterbore positive can be removed when demolding the part, but the first two I cut at the larger diameter counterbore end, which makes it impossible to demold the part. I am going to print another mold positive and pour silicone into it at the same time as I am filling a mold positive for making a silicone mold to cast the powder dispenser vibration isolation pad.

Completed the pour of the mold for making the powder dispensing dock vibration isolator, but was only able to half finish the pour of the mold for the vibrating hat vibration isolator, even with mixing up the last of the Mold Star 15 Slow and the Mold Star 31 that we had around. I have been using up older silicones as much as possible, so there is more Mold Star 30 that is fairly fresh that I did not use, so I can finish the pour tomorrow and the various layers should fuse together chemically (as long as the older silicones cure OK).

I have begun working on the system that will enable the duct hose to rotate freely as the gantry moves while minimizing exposure of the bearing to powder. It will eventually ingest powder and seize, but between its rubber seals and the 3D printed guards/labyrinth seal I am making it should last for quite a while.

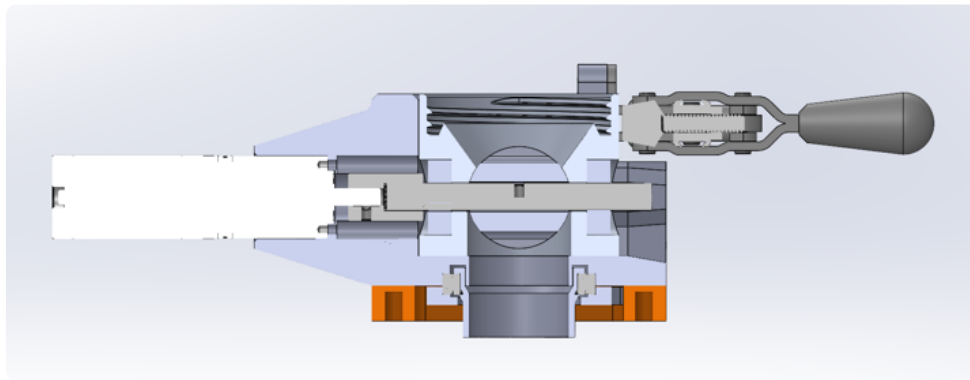
2026-01-27

HOPPER/FLIP:

I printed a Nalgene bottle interface for FLIP last night, but the opening for the splined shaft clamps is a little too small so I am going to expand that and reprint the part. The sides of the opening do not seal to the splined shaft clamp, it is the contacting face that seals with some wool, so it is not critical that the counterbore in the Nalgene bottle holder be very close to the OD of the splined shaft clamp. I have modified the model by expanding the counterbore from 25mm to 26mm.

The mold for the powder dispenser vibration isolator is fully cured so I am going to try breaking that out. The mold for the vibrating hat vibration isolator needs a third silicone pour to fill the mold to the top, so I will do that as long as I am mixing up various casting compounds.

I removed the silicone mold for the FLIP vibration isolator and installed 8X M4 screws holding 8X M4 threaded inserts in place. I then mixed up some of the industrial grade urethane and started a pour, but it reached a point where the urethane stopped flowing through the funnel feature, so I filled up a syringe with urethane and injected it under pressure, which worked for a while until the urethane began leaking out the sides of the mold. I plan to let the urethane cure then cut some more funnel features into the mold and try to finish the pour that way. Since there was some urethane left over at that point, I poured it into the first mold I had made for the vibrating hat vibration isolator as a test. Since that mold is missing two of its counterbore features it will not be possible to use the part that is cast unless I freeze it in liquid nitrogen and post-machine the counterbores, but it will give me a better sense of how to do a successful cast with this urethane. I have the design of FLIP reasonably complete:



Note the shielded but freely rotating hose duct joint on the bottom.

I removed the new three-pour mold for making the vibrating hat vibration isolator and added a large number of pour holes; because the urethane rubber is quite viscous it does not tend to flow well through the narrow channels I am trying to fill, so I have added pour holes with a scalpel and did a urethane pour by pouring into every other pour hole so the others can act as air outlets. That way the urethane only needs to flow ~1" along the inside of the mold instead of ~6".

I have started a print on the Bambu printer for all the remaining parts necessary for a FLIP prototype.

I am printing two parts for Mohsen, a muffler clamp that I added to my Bambu PETG-CF print and a larger box print that I am running on the Ultimaker S5 Thanos because it's not worth using up a bunch of the PETG-CF filament.

I am continuing to work on the design of the rotating hose duct interface. I think the FLIP-side interface is pretty solid, so I have moved to the vibrating hat-side interface.

2026-01-28

Alloyed Meeting:

Joined a meeting between various people from the company Alloyed and 3DEO.

HOPPER/FLIP:

Demolded the vibration isolator for the vibrating hat. It has some voids at the top of the part, but for the most part it came out pretty well. I think the voids are small and localized enough that it should seal sufficiently.

I have redesigned the rotating duct mounts so that they use a spiral retaining ring instead of printed teeth; this should be a more durable method for locking the rotating duct to the bearings.

2026-01-29

HOPPER/FLIP:

Completed print of the new vibrating hat design. Machined 2X splined shafts for the powder cartridge. Machined a short piece of splined shaft and glued it into a splined bushing to make a custom stepper motor-splined shaft coupler. Drilled and reamed a 6mm hole for the stepper motor shaft through the splined shaft that had been glued into the bushing. Tomorrow I will drill and tap two holes at right angles to install set screws to lock the coupler onto the stepper motor shaft. Installed heat set inserts in the vibrating hat and the cartridge dock. I test assembled the two rotating duct hose adapters and two bearing clamps, and modified the design of the cartridge dock rotating duct hose adapter and both bearing clamps based on fit testing of the original design.

Joined Alex's debrief on events in Japan with Sean, Senai, Payman, and Marcus. He visited Epson and the facility where they are running the two pilot printers as well as some other companies and the two banks Mizuho and DBJ. He said that the visits were generally positive but we did not get any new funding.

2026-01-30

HOPPER/FLIP:

The new parts printed last night seem good; they hold the bearings in place and shield them while not interfering with their rotation.

I am starting to work on the sensors. I am concerned about the TOF sensors building up powder, and since they claim to be able to detect distances through windows I am designing a new bayonet style prox switch holder that the board can be mounted to and will have a window that the sensor beam passes through. This will make it easy to remove the board and clean the window before each print or whenever readings become faulty.

R&D Weekly Meeting:

To Do:

- Bring up microcontroller and sensors
- Continue prototyping of assembly and start cycle testing of hopper gate
- Find large end mill/fly cutter for facing cake after meltable filler has been applied

2026-02-02

HOPPER:

Need to generate an image of the hopper/dispenser CAD to send to Marcus for the board meeting slide deck.

HOPPER:

Prepared the new mold for making a vibration isolator for the vibrating hat and did a pour of the Urethane 744 (shore 40A). I forgot to cut out some of the pour holes so the pour did not go as well as I had hoped; even after poking through the pour hole (there was just a thin membrane of silicone where there had been a slight gap between the positive and the posts printed as part of the mold shell) I was still not able to get air to evacuate passively as I had hoped. I used a syringe to inject urethane under slight pressure, which seemed to push out lots of air through the holes that were fully open, but that is not a super elegant solution and may or may not have cleared the air and is more difficult to demold because there is a lot of urethane that overflowed the mold.

Continuing to work on interfacing the ranging sensors with an ESP32; I was unable to get the Waveshare relay ESP32 to send Serial.println commands back to the Arduino IDE, so I gave up on it and am switching to one of the basic ESP32 boards I have around.

I got the new ESP32 board to connect to the VL53L4CX TOF ranging sensor. One difficulty I ran into is that one of the ground screw terminals was not directly connected to ground; for some reason I read a voltage of 1.6V when measuring from that ground to the 5V line, so I had to switch to a different ground terminal to power the board. I also had to add a wire to connect to the XSHUT pin; technically you can use the board with only 2 power connections and an SCL and SDA connection, but the board cannot be reset with software without the XSHUT line. Where that is useful is when loading new code onto the ESP32; without the XSHUT line you have to power cycle the board (in my case by unplugging the ESP32 board from the USB connection) to get the board to connect properly.

The machined parts finally showed up from Xometry (for reference, they shipped Thursday 1/29 and were received Monday 2/2). I am going to pivot to working on assembling the machined

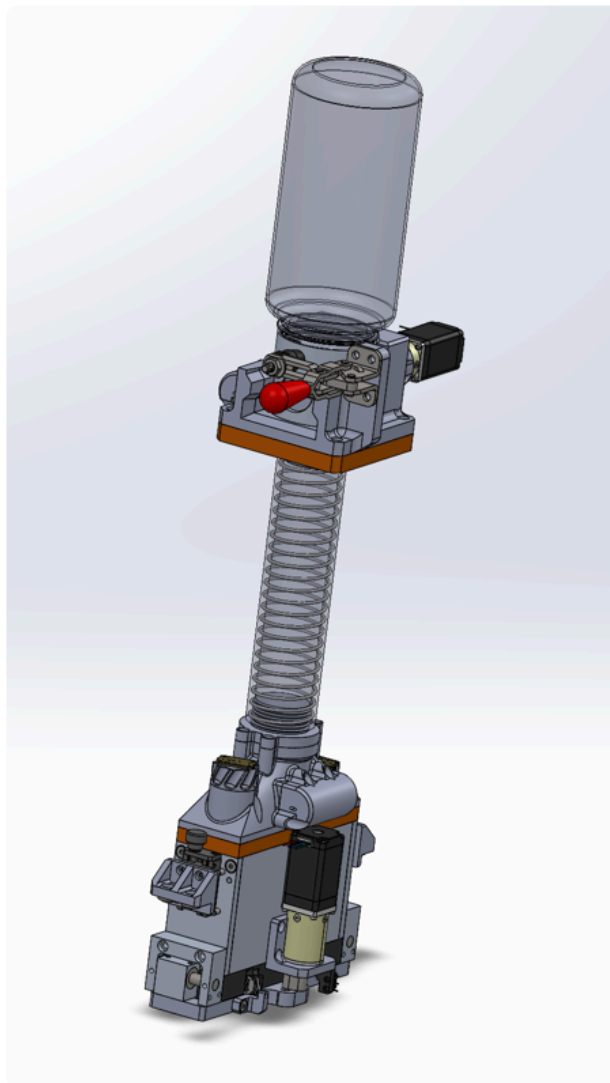
parts so I can start a cycle life test of the new motion system while I pivot back to the control system and powder dispenser.

The aluminum machined parts were fairly clean and free of burrs, but the stainless steel parts were dirty with cutting fluid and chips, so I cleaned all of them off with Citrusafe BBQ grill cleaner, washed them in the far left-hand sink, and dried them off with air. The side panels are missing two M4 threaded holes each, and all of the dowel pin holes are too tight of a press fit so I will need to ream them all out.

GENERAL R&D:

I am working on printing a new V block for Dong to measure the IHI thruster combustion chamber/nozzle. I have removed the endcap and lowered the outer wall height, and it will be printed from clear resin instead of PETG-CF to improve the ability of the Keyence IM to detect the edges of the part visually.

2026-02-03



Began working on assembling the machined components of the hopper. I had to ream out the dowel pin holes by hand, grind down the aluminum side plates where they were interfering with the gate closing fully, add in the screws to act as hard stops for the side bushings, start alignment work and shimming of the gate and bushing mounts to get the gate to move freely. I tried installing the cam holder on a stepper motor and wound up destroying the stepper gear box shaft. The opening in the cam holder is too small, so I ground it out a bit, heated it up with an acetylene torch, and tried to press it on to the shaft using a vise. I think the cam holder cooled down as I was pressing it on, and I applied enough force with the vise that the gear box shaft ended up buckling.

2026-02-04

At the morning standup Marcus announced that at the long meeting yesterday that he had with Payman, Rahjan, and Alex, they decided, among other things, that they want 2 more pilots built, at least one of which will be dedicated to copper printing. I discussed with Senai what kinds of resources will be necessary to build these printers, and the rough estimate we came up with is that it will take about 4 people 3 months to build them after the design is complete (Marcus also wants some design upgrades). Between Ning (full time Pilot), Cisco, Ben, me, Sean, and Senai, we can probably scrape together 1 1/2 to 2 people equivalent without too much disruption to other projects, so optimistically it would take 6 months. I think a realistic estimate is that without additional resources it would take about 9 months to complete the design upgrades, order all the parts, and build and commission the printers. To cut down that time we would either need to hire some additional people (which may or may not accelerate the project because they would have to be trained and I have failed to document the printers well), or stop work on most R&D efforts and production projects (I suspect Accretech and other customer projects will take up all of Sean's time and some or all of Senai's time), or we could contract the machine building to an external machine manufacturer (which would have the added advantage of familiarizing them with our process so we could then contract them to make a productized pilot).

Senai and I also have questions about the necessity of this project. Having two more pilots would certainly be nice, but we don't have resources to dedicate to it at moment and it is also an open question what exactly we are trying to accomplish as a company. Here are some company objectives I can imagine:

- Make and sell more pilot printers more or less of the current design
- Complete the R&D projects and integrate a refined version of them with the pilots
- Complete the R&D projects and create a new printer platform with them designed into it
- Design and make a productized printer and slicer that we can sell to any customer
- Make printers to operate in-house to work as a part and assembly manufacturer

- Focus fully on providing part and assembly services using any technology that is most appropriate to the design; we would purchase printers using other processes and continue to operate and refine our printers. This would open up new market opportunities (such as printing larger parts or printing in materials such as ceramics and aluminum or titanium that we cannot currently print on our platform) which would provide a more reliable revenue stream to help support the development of our printers.

HOPPER/FLIP:

I plan to try to remove the cam holder from the shaft and grind down its opening to enable it to fit on the second motor I have, but since I have destroyed one of the motors I need to either order a new one or borrow one from Senai (I think I ordered the same model for this hopper design that I had previously ordered for Mason's that Senai installed, and I think I ordered him two motors).

I finished post-processing the 3D printed wedge, glued some wool to the bottom to act as a seal/wiper for the blade, and tried clamping the blade back on, but the gap for the wool seal is too small. When I tried clamping the blade back on, it was not possible to move it because the friction against the wool was too high. I have redesigned the 3D printed wedge and will print the new version now.

The newly printed version will probably work but may be a little too tight, so just in case I am printing a new version that is .3mm looser. I have also wired both stepper motors to TMC2209 stepper motor driver boards. I also modified a stepper motor shaft and the stainless steel cam holder to fit each other. This should enable me to begin cycle testing tomorrow as soon as I wire up the ESP32 board to the stepper motor drivers and the two endstop switches that detect whether the gate is fully open or closed.

2026-02-05

Troubleshoot the binder making machine with Ben and Ning. The lower limit switch that the linear stage to which the mixer is mounted uses to detect when the mixer has reached the binder pitcher was not tripping correctly. We first tested the limit switch function directly and it seemed fine, so we then inspected the Tango board that the machine is using as its control system and ben found that connector for that limit switch had come loose. Ben reconnected it, and the machine seems functional now.

HOPPER/FLIP:

Wired up the TMC2209 stepper driver boards to the ESP32 and the two stepper motors and got them to work with the AccelStepper library. The motors are both spinning now, although they are

fairly speed limited. Part of that is that the AccelStepper library itself is speed limited, but it is also because the motors are geared down with a 100:1 gearbox.

Got some sample code working reading both limit switches with the ezButton library. This has a built in debouncing function that I think may be necessary for the limit switches I am using.

2026-02-06

HOPPER/FLIP:

I finally have code opening and closing the hopper, so I can start a cycle life test. One issue I noted is that due to the design of the cam and the slot, it is possible for the motor to rotate continuously, and if the cam travels to the other side of the slot then the direction of rotation of the motor will cause the inverse of the gate open/close function; rotating clockwise will cause the gate to open if it is on one side of the slot but will cause it to close if the cam is on the other side of the slot. For the next iteration I would like the slot narrower and the motor installed off center so that the force applied is very close to the center of the gate and the cam can only engage in one orientation so that the direction of rotation of the motor will always correlate with the direction of motion of the gate.

I have the code running a cycle test up to 281 cycles now. The cycle time is pretty slow, about 10 seconds per full open-close cycle. I plan to leave it running over the weekend to see how it holds up. The force the motor applies is pretty good though; it takes some effort to get the motor to stall.

After lunch the hopper is up to 810 cycles and seems to be running fine.

PILOT:

I machined out a section of the Mest mount for the three-stage mount for Pilot 6. That section could interfere with a part of the Parker stage so it would limit the travel of the Mest unit. I also mounted the 3D printed endstop contact part and installed 3X SHCS to act as set screws to hold the Mest mount in place once it is installed.

R&D Weekly Meeting

No Depowdering:

- Used desiccant box, but it was still difficult to separate the build from the build plate
- Removed picture-taking macro, which resolved the overflow problem that had been seen previously
- Took video of layer with cutting, filling, and facing with his phone because the GoPro was not suitable for that application

- Printed 20 layer copper square with modified gcode from Mason with concentric square. Removed filler through melting, broke it out, and debound it, but have not sintered it yet
- Payman wants Pourya to develop a plan to duplicate 17-4 PH printing printed parts on the copper machine (the AEM part being printed)
- Cisco installing the Mest unit from Pilot 1 on the 3 stage mount on Pilot 6
- Payman asking about plan for positioning of Pilots 6 and 7. Marcus wants 1 dedicated to continuing R&D and one moved to the pod for Devin and others to start printing with it to assess its suitability for production and the changes necessary to develop a version that can be used for production. Marcus recommends getting the printers printing well in the R&D lab before moving them to the pods because that adds another variable.
- Corners of prints have been lifting up intermittently.
- Pourya asking about maintenance and refurbishment of Pilot 1 (cleaning and lubrication of stages, disassembly and cleaning of powder/build tanks, removal of extra wires).
- Payman asked whether anyone has anything in mind for uses for Pilot 1. He brought up the idea of adding a laser to something for spread and spray.
- Pourya found that one wall of the scaled print parts he was printing had a tendency to break. He saw this issue with scaled and unscaled parts so it is likely not due to scaling alone. Mohsen suggested that he has seen similar issues that were caused by G code issues.
- Ning is working on building an enclosure for the associated hardware and electronics that go with the Mest unit to mount to Pilot 6.
- I ordered a single flute 1/8" diameter end mill and gave it to Pourya for

Laser:

- Mason made a part with very fine lines cut with the Mopa laser. The cut depth was intended to be 10 layers deep, but the layers fused with each new powder spread so that the cuts are only 100 microns deep (1 layer). The cut width is 100 microns with 400 micron spacing.
- Printing macros completed but Mason has ideas for adding to them. He recommends making a macro to act as a penetration test to see if over penetration is leading to the layer fusing issue mentioned above. The drying step is no longer used, which may be causing issues with over penetration. Resolution may be reducing binder application or adding a drying step. Payman suggested that it may also be due to insufficient cut depth because we have previously done unprinted
- LVP is functional, but Mason wants to add baffles to improve flow uniformity and free up space in the Y travel direction to increase the size of the LVP and enable the heater to be moved over the layer.

Hopper:

- **Continue cycle testing - DONE**
- **Vibrating hat up and running**
- **Start work on installing hopper on Pilot 2**

General:

- We are working with Don to develop a proprietary heat exchanger structure because the one developed for AEM may be proprietary for them.
- Decided not to proceed with the Alloyed polar fin structure part but instead focus on skived fin structure equivalent parts.
- Marcus plans to set up a meeting next week to discuss the patent for no depowdering.
- Someone will be coming in next week for a possible materials scientist role before she will be interviewed for the role.

Spread and Spray:

- Changed hopper body and had to work on that for a while to replicate functionality of previous hopper design.
- Seeing inconsistency of layers and stress cracks in layers. Recommends spreading more layers to clarify this issue and see how it evolves over time.
- Tested without vacuum and found droplets forming. Needs further study.
- Sean is interested in further measurement and quantification of the process. Noted that it is difficult to quantify spray quality. It is currently measured intuitively, no current quantifiable metrics for what constitutes a “good” spray.
- Added and tested new vacuum attachments, recommends further refinement.

Dry Air Layer Drying:

- Mohsen printed a heat sink and found layer inconsistency. He also ran into layer cracking. He theorized that it may be due to the THC and the air drying box sharing the same air line. This seemed to be resolved by running separate air lines for each component, changing macros, and adjusting air flows.
- Marcus notes that the goal is to combine dry air layer drying with the no depowdering process as soon as possible.
- Plans to integrate the no depowdering project with the dry air layer drying system next week and run a heat sink part first with no filler and again with filler.
- Payman notes that “curing” layers without heat may resolve a number of issues that have been seen previously with poor temperature control.

2026-02-09

HOPPER/FLIP:

I ran the hopper gate cycling over the weekend, and it has made it to ~27,000 cycles so far. Granted, it has been operating under optimal conditions with no powder loaded in the hopper or in the ambient environment. There is also some buildup of black powder, likely graphite debris, below the bushing. I am guessing that there was some bushing wear from the cycle test, but it seems quite minimal.

Since the control system for this hopper and cartridge loading system will require reading I2C sensors and operating 2X stepper motors and 2X DC motors (at least), I have decided to use an ESP32 board as an independent control system that will monitor gate opening and closing and powder level when commanded to open or close the gate or refill the hopper. It also will have an error line feeding back to the Duet board to let it know if something goes wrong so the printer can pause until the issue is resolved.

Working on an enclosure for the control system: ESP32, relay board, 2X stepper drivers, 2X DC-DC converters for adjusting hopper and cartridge vibration.

Finished the design of the enclosure and lid and sent it over to the Bambu printer to print.

GENERAL:

Entered an order request for 2 Knipex pliers; Cisco regularly needs my pair for closing the cable carrier on the Pilot printers so it makes sense to order a couple for 3DEO to own.

NO-DEPOWDERING:

They filed a provisional patent application in march, and after a year you need to file the final patent. The final patent needs to be updated based on lessons learned over the past year. We are trying to patent stuff in the claims portion, but you need to describe the invention and the context in detail.

- Try to generate a more accurate image of the current no-depowdering process

2026-02-10

HOPPER/FLIP:

Payman requested that the hopper be installed on Pilot 2 without the powder feeder or control system. This would yield some data on the functionality of the gate roughly 1 week sooner than otherwise, but will delay completion of the integrated system by roughly 1 week because I will have to spend time first integrating the hopper into the Pilot printer and supporting testing, then I will still have to assemble and debug the integrated system, for which I will need to make a

dummy hopper to duplicate the machined hopper's functionality for sensor testing and qualification.

I have wired up the limit switches and gate stepper motor to be compatible with Pilot 2's systems. I have placed an order request for a sheet of .020" thick fatigue-resistant 301 stainless steel to make the vibrating sheet, and I will next install the vibrator motor so that the vibrating hat will be fully functional once I have the motor installed and bolt it all up.

DRREDFATI:

- **Does this need to be done?** Is there a better way to achieve the same goals? Do the goals actually need to be achieved at all? Are there commercially available options that seem expensive but would actually be cheaper when you factor in the time spent to make something in-house?
- **Requirements:** What are the requirements for the project? Is it an open-ended problem to solve, or is there a specific approach baked into the project requirements? What are the quantifiable metrics for success that, if achieved, will make the project considered to be a success? Is the intent to start the project without these requirements, and generate formal requirements along the way? What is the exact plan for doing so?
- **Resources:** What are the resources available for the project (money, people, time, tools). Is it feasible that the requirements can be met with the resources available? If not, what resources would be necessary to have a reasonable chance of meeting the requirements?
- **Engineering:** The high-level ideation and engineering (math, process selection, etc.) of a solution or approach, as well as determining how any solution or approach will meet the requirements outlined above. If there is no way to quantifiably measure whether an approach will meet the requirements, either the requirements or approach need to be refined.
- **Design:** The low-level design (CAD, drawings, numbers, etc.) specifically defining the approach.
- **Fabrication:** Fabricate the individual components and subassemblies of the system, as well as any components necessary for testing the system or approach.
- **Assembly:** Combine the individual components into a whole integrated system, and assemble whatever components are necessary for testing the system or approach. Complete any programming necessary for validating the system.
- **Test:** Use the test protocol determined during the Engineering step to measure the system or approach against the Requirements determined earlier.
- **Iterate:** If the system or approach meets the requirements, the system is ready. If it does not meet the requirements, loop back as far as necessary (if there was an issue with testing, you might just need to loop back to Test, if the results raise ideas for alternative approaches or

questions about whether this approach is feasible, it may be necessary to loop back to the start of the process and restart or cancel the project as appropriate). Don't fall for the sunk cost fallacy! No matter how much time or effort has been spent, it always might be wise to scrap everything and change the approach or abandon the project entirely.

2026-02-11

PILOT: Weekly meeting on Pilot 6 and 7 bring up. Plan is for Pilot 7 to be given to Devin to run in the pod. It was been moved to the pod on Monday.

Pourya noted that the 3D printed mount holding the end stops on the 3 stage mount has been flexing so I am going to look into making a new one from metal.

Mest unit has been installed on Pilot 6. Issues with insufficient vacuum because it is now split between two spindles. Mohsen pointed out that the StoneVac on Pilot 7 stayed running and stopped responding to the signal but started working when the control relay was reset. When Cisco tested the static pressure on both StoneVacs and found that the static pressure was very similar (~2.3 PSI), Beta Vac spec was 1.5-1.75, Saffron spec was

Plan is to build two pilots per quarter (3 months) using technician labor only. For Pilots 8 and 9, delivery date is unknown and required design changes are unknown and will be decided in other meetings blah blah blah. **Recommendation is to determine the high-level goals, requirements, and resources first, or if those are unknown, then set up a plan for determining those goals.**

Goal is to minimize R&D resources spent on making the new Pilots. **Project goal seems explicitly to be to make more Pilots, not make more printers with a specified functionality.**

Goal is to dedicate one to copper with the other likely for general R&D purposes or just to be because our SOP it to make 2 at a time. It is also important to document these Pilots so that they can be built by anyone with basic mechanical and electrical skills. Estimated 4 people required full time to make 2 Pilots in 3 months.

Depending on whether one of them needs to be dedicated to laser, there are modifications that Mason suggests: lower roof, shielded side panels, extended Y plate, camera mounts etc. There are also some design changes that Pourya suggests may be beneficial for integrating the no-depowdering process into 8 and 9. Mohsen suggested that it would be helpful to have easier adjustability of the spreader bar. There are also some changes that Epson has suggested that need to be clarified and may be integrated into future Pilots.

Continued work on diagram of our latest process in Inkscape for the patent.

Wired up the new hopper design to Pilot 2, but it looks like the aluminum mount brackets interfere with the Y gantry, which is visible in the CAD so I should have caught it in the design phase, which was my mistake. It's an easy fix, I just need to pull off the brackets and shave

them down by 1mm and switch out the M3 SHCS for low-profile ones (so not a trivial fix, it does require new hardware) but I should be able to have that done today.

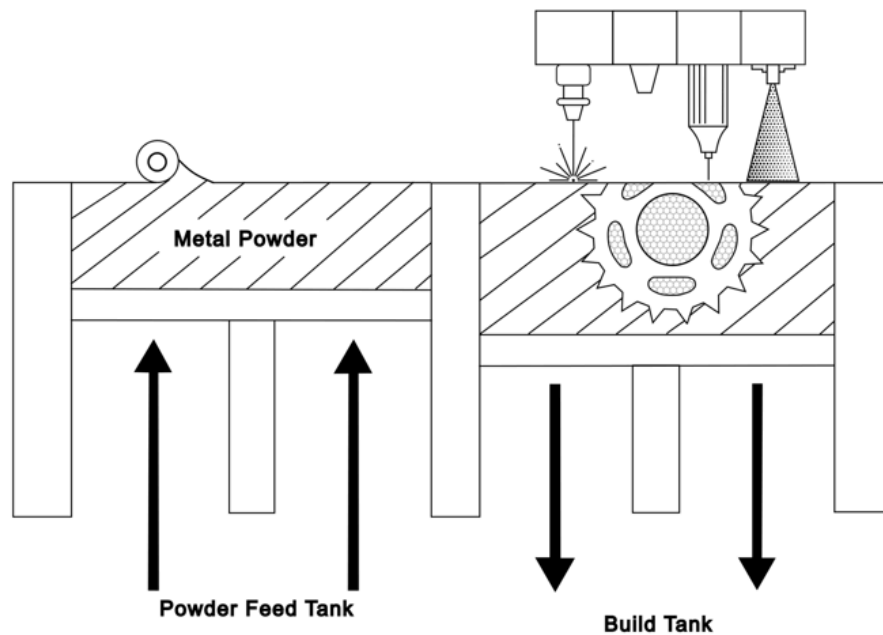
The 3D printed elbow fitting on the X axis tower of Pilot 6 broke, which is why they have been seeing the vacuum issues noted above. I entered in the order request for some brass parts to make some new fittings to the same design used on the Epson pilots.

Cisco

2026-02-12

PILOT: Post-processed the 3D printed parts that clamp the brass fittings to the X axis cable tower. Once the brass parts show up I will assemble 3 of the elbows. Cisco requested I look into replacing the X axis cable carrier with a larger alternative (hopefully one with the same width but greater height so it is essentially a drop-in replacement. Also, Pourya noted that the 3D printed triple endstop mount for the 3 stage mount has been flexing when the stages home, so that needs to be replaced with a more rigid component.

GENERAL: I have finished the first draft of the patent diagram of our current process.



HOPPER/FLIP: I need to redesign the vibration isolator; having SHCSs bolt through the urethane is not structurally sound enough to hold up in operation with the load applied by the hose. It would work for a while, but it would not seal well over time. I need to redesign the isolator, both for the hopper's vibrating hat and also the cartridge dock. I also have an idea for casting the dosing roller from urethane for the cartridge; I think that would hold up better over time while maintaining a better seal as compare with a 3D printed part.

I created a new design, printed the components necessary, and did a pour, although I'm not sure how well it will come out; I am concerned about bubbles in the pour. I modified the aluminum brackets that interface the Edmund stages to the Y plate and received the new low-profile M3 screws then bolted it all up, and it seems OK. I had to do some adjustment to get everything square but that's not a surprise.

2026-02-13

PILOT: I have all the parts in for assembling the brass X axis cable tower hose fitting.

I assembled the fittings and the 3D printed parts for 2X hose fitting assemblies.

Since flexing of the 3D printed endstop mounts on the 3 stage Z axis mount is a critical issue, I have designed a sheet metal mount and sent the quote into our ordering system. I would also like to look at how fast the stages are moving when they are homing, because the force required to trigger the endstops... So I looked up the force required to trigger the endstops, and it is 1N (102g on Earth) at a minimum speed of 50mm/min. 100g is actually not insignificant for a relatively thin 3D printed part, even one that I oriented to be as strong as possible. It is printed from PETG-CF, which is fairly strong and more rigid than PETG, but not as rigid as .125" thick 304SS (which is what I plan to replace it with).

HOPPER/FLIP: The new vibrating hat has been printed; this one is adapted for the new vibration isolator. I removed the mold walls from the vibration isolator I cast yesterday. There were a few voids as expected, and the urethane that had overflowed the pour points had plugged many of the printed holes that are necessary for passing through screws and bolting on the vibrating hat, but the urethane adhesion to the 3D printed parts seems good; When removing the mold walls I had to slice off the urethane because it adhered so well, and those were just flat surfaces without the dovetails that I had printed into the permanently attached components. I am printing new top and bottoms parts as well as mold walls, and I plan to print some funnels that will help to avoid the voids and eliminate the overflow. I also plan to spray the mold walls with mold release to hopefully make it easier to remove them with the next pour.

I assembled a new set of top and bottom parts and mold walls and did another pour with Shore 44A urethane. I had two funnels on top to theoretically pour into one funnel, have the urethane flow down that side of the mold, and flow up the other side, preventing the formation of voids within the casting, but even with the mold tilted to one side, the urethane started flowing down both sides of the mold, potentially trapping air within. I did a couple cycle of vacuum degassing to hopefully clear out any voids. For the next mold, I plan to have a removable barrier blocking flow from one side to the other at the top of the mold so that the urethane will be forced to travel down one side and up the other.

I bolted down the new linear gate hopper yesterday, but I then removed it to make the gate more visible as I develop macros for opening and closing the gate.

I have finished macros for opening and closing the gate, called GATEOPEN and GATECLOSE. They each work by moving the gate until it hits the appropriate limit switch. Because the printer is wired to use only one limit switch connection for the hopper axis, the limit switches are wired in parallel, so the Duet board cannot distinguish between the two switches. This means that the limit switches need to be wired as normally open, so I had to rewire my switches, which I had originally wired as normally closed per standard 3D printer practice. If I had wanted to stick with the normally closed switches, I could have rewired the board so that the switches were instead wired in parallel, and pressing either switch would break the connection. Since the duet board has no way to distinguish between the two switches when one of them is pressed, when starting either macro it is impossible for the board to tell whether the gate is already open or closed. I designed the macros so that they will first ignore the limit switches and travel in the appropriate direction for the macro called, assuming they are in the right spot, at a slow speed for a short distance; if they are in the expected position this will take them off the limit switch and the next command is to move them faster until they hit the other limit switch. If they are not in the expected position (i.e. you run the GATEOPEN macro when the gate is already open) the gate will ignore the limit switches, crash into the hard stop for a short time, then will start paying attention to the limit switches and stop. By having it start out at a slower speed, the likelihood of damage is reduced, but it would still be good to avoid calling the wrong macro.

PILOT 8 and 9 Brainstorming Meeting:

Goal is to make 2 more Pilots that are similar to 6 and 7 with minor upgrades. One will be dedicated to copper and one will be for general use and R&D. Per Marcus, these machines will not be dedicated to laser use.

Epson upgrade requests: Touch sensor for leveling build plate (?) and closed-loop stepper motors.

Timeline is 4 months for these 2 and a quarterly cadence afterwards.

I recommend making a larger control cabinet that can fit all the additional subsystems, such as the Mest controller.

For the copper machine, it will need robust climate control. Alex recommends switching from the THC to the system that was implemented on the copper Saffron because it has been proven to work with printing copper. The machine will also need improved sealing and inertability. It may be better to put all the copper machines in one tent instead of split between multiple tents as they are right now.

Goal is to minimize impact on engineering time and resources. Week 1/2: gather requirements, clean up BOM, take inventory of parts in-house, assess possible machine changes.

Week 3: Begin design of new parts, source/order long lead time items.

Labor to build pilots to TBD, Marcus looking to hire another technician but has no candidates yet. Marcus is also open to the possibility of hiring interns, which Mason suggested.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

No Depowering:

Made a list of desired refurb tasks for Pilot 1 while it is not being used. Made a plan to make the AEM NDP part in copper, but has not been reviewed yet. Printed a 2 layer AEM print in copper OK, but when a 10 layer print was attempted about 30% of features were picked up by the vacuum. Pourya plans to adjust binder volume, vacuum power, and drying time to resolve this issue. Finished moving the Mest unit from Pilot 1 to Pilot 6. Mohsen will work on improving base layer adhesion, after which test printing will begin. Still having issues with vacuum power, and the dry air curing process tends to lower the chamber humidity to unacceptable levels. Mohsen will look into adding a humidifier to add humidity. Corner of the cake had been breaking on Pilot 1, this was not resolved due to time spent on base layer development. Larger end mills for facing the print after filler application were ordered but have not yet been tested. Mohsen notes that dry air curing can cause the base layer to detach from the build plate.

I pitched a concept of pre-building a layer on a removable build plate using a slurry or a pre-coated powder. Pourya did an experiment with spraying a build plate with hairspray which helped for the first layer but subsequent layers did not adhere well. Another approach might be to apply PEG or another water-soluble polymer as a binder to the base plate, which should help our water-based binder attach well.

Hopper:

- Transfer hopper to Mohsen for testing on Pilot 2
- Work on powder feed system

Spread and Spray:

Sean and Payman discussed how to analyze layer quality. Got vacuum turning on and off automatically. Seeing droplet formation on the mist box, hoping that by moving the mist box down, droplet formation will be reduced.

Laser:

Mason developed a new procedure for measuring binder penetration by applying a very thin layer to the base plate and checking adhesion. Also developed a depth test procedure.

It seems that the issues seen previously with powder spread into cuts would fuse into a solid seems to be due to overpenetration of binder; if the previous layers are too wet, the excess binder will soak into the freshly applied powder and bind it together. With less binder applied, laser cuts seemed to melt more. Midhun recommends adjusting sugar concentration in binder to change the physical properties when it is vaporized by the laser. Plans to try adding dyes to the binder next week to increase its absorption of light. Continuing to evaluate printing skived-like parts.

2026-02-16

Discussing Payman's slicer for Pilot. Intent is to avoid CAD modification and provide for settings by layer. Separates DFAM functions for designing layers from toolpath generation. Integrated functionality for splitting negatives. I am playing around with the software using a rocket engine pintle injector design that is not suitable for standard LPBF printing.

- Add ability to set direction of cut (conventional vs. climb milling)
- Tool band factor?
- Ability to rotate model after being imported - ALREADY PRESENT
- Gaps between tool coverage
- Color code labeling

HOPPER/FLIP:

Demolded the new vibration isolator; the mold release applied to the 3D printed walls made it massively easier to remove them; I highly recommend it in the future. I counterbored the relevant holes for screwing it to the hopper body, and it fit well. I also installed all the necessary nyloc nuts in the vibrating hat, so I just need to make the vibrating sheet and complete final assembly for the system to be fully functional.

I made the vibrating sheet, but the holes I drilled were in the wrong place because I changed the hole positions for the new vibration isolator, so I superglued the sheet into the vibrating hat for Mohsen's initial testing. I also had to tweak the macros a bit to get it working robustly; if you send it to one end of travel and then send it to the same end again, it will overtravel enough that it needs to travel farther back the other way to clear the limit switch when it is commanded to go the other direction. This has the downside of stalling for a longer period of time if it is commanded to go to the position in which it currently is. With the vibration motor currently installed, the vibration isolator seems to be working quite well. The vibrating hat noticeably vibrates when the motor is turned on and seems structurally rigid enough to mount the hose to,

but there is no noticeable vibration when you touch the machined hopper. The only open question, then, is how much vibration is actually required to liquify the powder, and whether the metal sheet I have made and installed can couple the appropriate amplitude and frequency of vibration to liquify the powder so it flows well out of the hopper onto the layer. This will be determined by Mohsen's testing (hopefully tomorrow). One thing to note as well is that the vibration motor cover cracked as I was tightening it down; it is intentionally designed to clamp tightly onto the motor, but this particular version seems to be overly tight, leading to the part becoming overstressed when the mounting bolts were tightened. I believe I have already corrected this in the CAD, but it will need to be tested when I make the benchtop dummy hopper for loading testing.

Mohsen expressed concerns with the low vibration on the new hopper, so I have ordered several vibration motors of different sizes (all larger than the one currently installed) that I will then integrate into the design if necessary. It may be necessary to eliminate the two mounting holes one either side of the vibration motor that are used to screw the vibrating hat onto the vibration isolator upper plate, but that will leave 6 mounting holes so the mount should be strong enough. Also, since the new vibration isolator design has rigid mounts on the top and bottom, it is less critical for there to be a large number of mounting screws (although to be fair, the 10 mounting screws on the last design were still insufficient to clamp a counterbored unreinforced rubber vibration isolator evenly anyway).

I am making a 3D printed positive mold to make a silicone mold to cast urethane doser balls. It is my hope that these will provide improved sealing and wear capabilities as compared with PETG-CF or SLA resin doser balls.

2026-02-17

HOPPER/FLIP:

At the morning standup, Marcus asked how long it would take to build a number of hoppers using the current V5 design; my estimate was 3 weeks: 2 weeks for getting the parts machined, and 1 week for assembly, so 1 month should be a reasonably conservative estimate.

I machined the splined shaft bushing (added 2X set screw holes) and mounted it on the stepper motor, then screwed the stepper motor to the cartridge dock. I also installed the toggle clamp, although the part cracked when I was tightening one of the 4 M5 SHCS because of the force the nut was putting on it, so I super glued it back together and will finish tightening that bolt once the glue cures. I also finished post-processing the first SLA resin printed doser ball; the ball is a little looser than I'd like against the walls of the cartridge dock, and the splined shaft opening is a little too loose to hold it in place along the splined shaft if I try to place it in a mold

to cast around it, so I plan to redesign the doser ball so it is slightly larger with a slightly smaller opening for the splined shaft. I am also going to add more supports at the bottom because the spherical surface sagged slightly while it was printing. I still think it would function OK, but if I am going to go to the trouble of making a silicone mold I might as well make sure that the master part is as good as I can reasonably make it.

Mohsen Baser Layer Meeting:

Previous base layer macro took ~50 minutes with 5 layers requiring a heat pass and layer cooling, but had a very low failure rate.

An optimized version of this takes 15 minutes and only has 1 heat pass, with a slightly higher failure rate.

Mohsen is running into issues with the corners of the base plate detaching from the build plate and lifting up when a print is run with air drying instead of heat pass. The dry air only base layer takes 18 minutes with a high failure rate. As the print is running, the base layer pulls off of the build plate towards the corners as the humidity in the print chamber decreases. Theory is that the humidity tends to drop over time because of the dry air being injected to dry each layer.

Options:

- Continue tests to determine root cause
- Test making a layer outside of the machine
- Test using a base layer macro that uses heat passes
- Test different substrates and coatings for the aluminum (glue stick, PEI, etc.)
- Test different aluminum coatings/surface treatments
- Add humidifier to compensate for the dry air added

An issue was noted that the fan on Pilot 1 tends to blow air in an annulus without air flow in the center of the flow annulus, which may lead to poorer layer drying in the center of the build.

Payman is particularly concerned with the internal stresses that will develop in the cake even if there is good base layer adhesion, so he is more interested in adding humidity to try to resolve the root cause of cake distortion (best guess so far is that it is the dropping humidity; Mohsen has seen it as low as 20-25%, while the nominal spec is 40%).

Pilot 7 is encountering an issue after being moved to the pod: it seems that the layer cooling time always times out instead of hitting the target temperature. The heat pass macro is also different from Pilot 6 (ZZ may have changed it because of an issue with the heater not turning off when a printer ends).

Mohsen noted that he increased the target temperature to 30C to decrease layer time for the Epson printers, which seemed not to have a negative impact on part density.

2026-02-18

The print of the nebulizer cable holders keeps failing, so I asked Alex for the original CAD so I can set up the print on one of the Bambus.

HOPPER/FLIP:

Fully assembled the mold for casting the silicone mold for casting the doser ball and did a pour of Shore 30A silicone. The amount I mixed up was only enough to cover the doser ball by ~2mm, but hopefully that should be enough. I mixed up as little silicone as possible to make sure I was not wasting any of it. I had to hammer the doser ball onto the splined shaft because it was so tight; this won't be an issue with the cast doser ball because the splined shaft itself will be used as part of the mold to define the dimensions of the splined shaft cutout, but for future SLA printed doser balls I will adjust the splined cutout dimensions.

I completed the design for the new vibration isolator for the cartridge dock based on the design I made for the vibrating hat vibration isolator, printed out the components, sealed the outside with hot glue, and attempted a pour of 744 soft urethane. Even with a funnel on top the pressure of the poured urethane was clearly insufficient to force it down one side of the mold and up the other within the pot life of the urethane. I also used a blocking tab to force it to flow down one side only first instead of down both sides so that there would be no voids trapped at the bottom of the mold, which mostly seemed to work, although there was a little leakage past it from the pressure of the urethane in the funnel. There are two possible alternative approaches I have thought of so far:

First, I could reprint the mold with just an injection hole in one side and an air outlet hole in the other side, then use a syringe to inject urethane in while the mold is oriented so the injection hole faces down. This replaces the gravity-fed injection of urethane with a pressure-fed approach, and the bottom-up injection will let the mold fill both sides at once instead of needing to go down one side and up the other. However, it would require filling a syringe, likely more than once, and managing bubbles in the syringe which would naturally tend to rise into the mold during injection. I am also not sure just how much pressure would be required to inject the urethane, which could make it physically difficult to inject and extend the time to an unreasonable level.

Second, I could lay the mold flat with one of the permanently attached sides (upper or lower) removed, fill the mold, then press the upper or lower side into the mold. This would result in urethane flowing out around the mold, which would of course adhere to everything and would

be somewhat of a pain to remove, but the pouring aspect would be very easy since all of the mold is exposed and it would make it unnecessary to add any cutouts into the mold sides.

I've talked myself into it; I'm going to try the second approach. I'll douse all the external surfaces with mold release to reduce the tendency of urethane to stick and redesign the mold so it does not have any features that are no longer necessary for this process.

Mohsen noted that there is a line appearing on the cake with the new hopper design, and asked for the spreader bar thickness (10mm, for reference, also 140mm long) to try and track down the root cause.

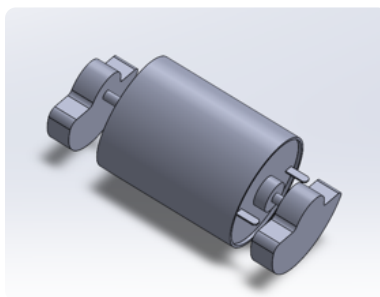
I assembled a powder cartridge with the undersize doser ball I printed previously. Even with the many possible engagement angles of the splined shaft and the chamfers on the splined shaft and the splined shaft bearing, it is still possible to have the shaft in an orientation that will prevent it from being slid into the cartridge dock and engage with the splined shaft bearing easily.

2026-02-19

HOPPER/FLIP:

I am preparing the newly designed mold for the powder cartridge dock vibration isolator, and demolding the one I cast yesterday. It actually worked much better than I expected; there is a void right near the flow blocking tab, but other than that it looks like the mold was completely filled. I am going to do a pour of 44A urethane for the new vibration isolator, and a pour of 70A urethane for the newly completed doser ball mold.

Received the new batch of vibrator motors, and after testing at different voltages I selected a 24V 8500 RPM two weight ECM DC motor. The motor diameter is roughly the same as the previous motors (new motors measured at 24.2mm) but the length is greater due to the double masses. It also will require routing the wires differently because the second mass is in the way of wires going out parallel to the center axis of the motor.



GENERAL:

Scaling the V block I previously made for Dong for Keyence measurement of the sintered IHI thruster; the scaled version is needed for measuring the green part.

The scaled V block has been printed and cleaned with IPA, it just needs to be cured and have the supports removed to be ready for testing. I suspect that its dimensions will need to be modified at least once more, but that's easy enough to do.

Marcus noted concerns with the amount of vibration seen when Pilot 7 was doing repeated small cuts while printing an AEM part. In particular, he is concerned about loss of cutting accuracy (possible but not necessarily the case) and the fact that customers may not like how much the machine vibrates in operation. Machine vibration is a well-known side effect of two major design choices: using a lightweight frame and base plate, and having all components move together on the same gantry while cutting. To the first point, using a heavier welded frame and/or a thicker stainless steel base plate would help, while a granite base plate would be even more accurate, precise, and reduce vibrations. To the second point, with the current hardware vibration could be reduced by adjusting acceleration settings and reducing cutting speed, or to have a really significant impact, have the cutting components on their own more compact precision gantry and mount the spreader bar, mist box, heater, and hopper on their own single-axis less precise gantry. One issue with this is if we want to use the three-stage two axis/Mest unit assembly, there would still be a fair amount of weight on the precision gantry, necessitating a larger gantry than if there was only a single spindle mounted.

Devin noted that print edges curling up from the edge of the build plate is a known failure mode due to low humidity, as seen in the pod back when we first moved here from Gardena and is the reason why there were humidifiers in the pod. Devin recommends warming the air before injecting it into the chamber. He also notes that when a green part is cured with dry air instead of heat it becomes more hygroscopic. He recommends that maintaining control of the temperature and moisture content of the cake is important to print quality and repeatability. He mainly pays attention to telemetry, such as temperature, humidity, and layer time.

Are we using different firmware on the Pilot spray driver vs the Saffron spray drivers?

I sent out my Inkscape version of the patent diagram, and Marcus stated that he was more interested in one that is less stylized, closer to a CAD model, and specifically requested the addition of a hopper to show that we have multiple ways of applying powder to the build, so I am going to try to create a CAD screenshot showing this. I personally do not think that makes sense for a patent application, but to be fair, most of the patents I have looked at have been

from several years old to many years old, for the most part not within the last few years, so I am not sure what is currently in vogue for patent applications.

2026-02-20

HOPPER/FLIP:

Demolded the latest cartridge dock vibration isolator, and it looks pretty good, however, I apparently designed it for M5 threaded inserts but I designed the cartridge dock with M4 counterbores. I have updated the design of the cartridge dock for future prints because I like the approach of using larger screws to mount to the vibration isolator, but that does mean that I will need to modify the cartridge dock printed last night.

I demolded the 70A urethane cast doser ball, and it looks usable. I installed it in the cartridge base in place of the clear SLA doser ball, and based on visual inspection it seems like it would seal well while still being able to be rotated.

GENERAL:

Meeting with Sorin Dimescu (heat transfer analysis guy). Goal is to introduce the team to Sorin and talk about our needs for heat transfer/flow analysis for our entry into the heat exchanger and cold plate market.

Sorin: Has worked with Payman and Sean on the AEM projects. Materials science backgrounds (operations, mfg quality, customer interface) in semiconductor industry for 15-20 years, specifically semiconductor testing. Multi-layer ceramics mostly (thick film), multi-layer organics, elec. packaging, assy and testing, die bonding, soldering/brazing/lapping/grinding/polishing. Thermal management is a common thing to many of these (I like that he brought this up to tie into things we need him to work on). Heat interfaces. Designed test fixtures and equipment. Worked on AEM cold plate project between Craig and Don, designed 300mm heater component for PXL. Personal interest in 3D printing, called out materials in our parts.

Technical Q's:

Our needs (Payman and Alex)

- We need to level up internal testing capabilities, internal tooling
- Interest in developing our own flexible cold plate architecture
- Need assistance with some projects currently in the pipeline
- Want in-house simulation capabilities

Experience working on heatlets like Don? (Marcus)

Made ceramic heater, communicated with Don about needs, focused on making sure that coolant flow was aligned with heater traces. Working on the heat management side of the system while Don was more on the cooling level side.

Experience designing cold plate internal features? (Alex)

Not much involvement on PXL, worked on integrated ceramic heaters/coolers with similar geometries (?). Monolithic cold plate/heater device w/ internal microfluidic channels. Very general discussion of requirements for this type of system. Worked on cooling/heating systems for semiconductor wafers at Fralock.

Design of cooling stack done iteratively? (Senai)

Was an iterative process designing cooling/heating systems for Fralock. Used ceramic thermal compression bonding. Used SolidWorks flow simulation (haha).

Showing an example we're working on (Marcus):

Epson cold plate design. He said the main way to optimize performance is to maximize surface area.

How to optimize surface area given a certain heat transfer requirement?

Maximize surface area, sweet spot in level of turbulence vs laminar flow.

Experience with developing test equipment for cold plate and heat exchanger testing? (Marcus)

Used customer provided systems, has not developed systems himself.

How to size testbed? (Senai)

Heat to remove? Recommends a chiller that can reach -70C (why?). 2 stage compression chillers. Instrumentation and sensors? Flow meters, pressure, gauges (did not mention temperature sensors). Control card, Python, very general suggestions.

Epson slide. How to approach making an improved cold plate? (Alex)

Does not show power to remove. Does not know if there is anything better than gyroids or Schwarz P.

How do you decide what designs to go with?

Dunno. Best heat transfer mechanism is phase change. Optimize/maximize surface area and come up with way to implement phase change. Kinda threw up his hands and really focused on phase change systems.

Fralock project shown: Why do many customers not integrate the heater into the heatsink?

Two reasons, one is they don't really need to, one is they don't know(?). Making the point that thermal interface between heater and cooler has a low enough thermal resistance that it isn't necessary, although not articulated clearly. Started talking about different kinds of semiconductor manufacturing processes and vacuum lifter functionality. Heating quickly and cooling enabled semiconductor manufacturers to increase memory density. Used ceramics because semiconductor manufacturers are sensitive to what material contacts the wafer. A metallic cold plate would be static dissipative, which is nice. Implied that a heater/cooler with integrated heaters would be useful, but then started rambling about die bonding, flip chips, etc. etc. A way to insulate a heater trace from the metal part could be valuable if possible.

Payman and Marcus don't think he's good for this kind of design, which I totally agree with, but could be useful for semiconductor equipment integration.

R&D Weekly Meeting:

No-Depowdering:

Have not decided what to do on Pilot 1. Organizing wiring.

Continued effort to make an AEM-style part in copper. After spreading a new layer and spraying it, the layer has been puffing up. Cisco noted that he had not seen this behavior previously. The layer generally drops back down, but does not adhere properly and loses precision. Marcus recommendations: try varying binder volume and investigate root cause.

Base layer improvements: almost finished prepping Pilot 7 for experiments. Right now a 30 minute air cure only base layer is working OK. With heat pass, the layer is 30-40 mins.

Bring up no-depowdering on P6? Remove second vacuum (actually second vacuum line), print with heat pass base layer. Tried to print layer 35 repeatedly, failed at 2nd layer due to triggering collision macro. Disabled collision macro, then next print had an issue with the g code where it faced at 150 micron instead of 10 micron. Restarted print, made it to layer 5 OK, still running.

Look into adding humidifier? Mohsen did some research but has not ordered anything yet (my recommendation is an evaporative humidifier instead of a mist-type). Waiting to see if the current P6 run succeeds. Running extreme case to replicate the problem of base layer curling (due to low humidity per Devin).

Had base layer focused meeting.

Vacuum is still heating. Outlet is not rated to sufficient current (? BS). Is StoneVac rated for continuous operation? (a quick glance at the website do Plan is to take the Festool with a broken latch to use on P6 instead of the StoneVac.

Mason noted that there was an error that left the vacuum running overnight and the outlet burned.

AEM wax print had the corner of the cake breaking. After running the print again, it is still breaking on Pilot 6. Still need to confirm with more prints. If it is still happening, run the same print without wax to see if the issue still occurs.

Did not evaluate larger bit or diagnose part side roughness and delam.

Hopper:

Transitioned hopper to Mohsen for print testing

- Linear gate can drag on layer when hopper is spreading
- Had to tilt the hopper towards the spreader bar side

Spread/Spray:

Sean notes that the design of the mist box tends to promote the formation of droplets on its edge.

Payman did some preliminary optimization of parameters. He has implemented a new hopper that is essentially a shaker-style hopper that has a slit opening that is always in contact with the layer. He seems to have poor control of binder penetration, which makes sense because it is not a fixed-volume binder application approach, it is a flooding sheet of mist.

Laser:

Tried mixing dye with binder at a 100:1 mixing ratio, which seemed to improve cut quality and reduce powder melting. Experimented with heat curing layers after the cut and before the next spread. It worked well for initial layers but in later layers small features would break off. It also decreased binder penetration so Mason had to increase binder volume. He is interested in testing air-curing with fan. For the skive-style parts, he tried double line thickness and different binder volumes, and was seeing cut connections but still seeing too much debris. Wants to pause this experiment until the basic process has improved.

Tried adding water to the layer with a handheld humidifier; when water was used this increased melting, but when binder was used it seemed to yield better results. Binder with increased sucrose content yielded better results (not sure if this is with the handheld humidifier or standard nebulizer).

Tried printing AEM-style geometry, but the cuts are still not very clean.

Tried testing new LVP design which seemed to work better. (Recommend implementing a crossflow system fixed to the build plate with inert gas injection on one side and vacuum

extraction on the other).

Tried spreading powder on a layer of PEG then cutting it with a laser as a meaningless simulation of a combined laser/no depowdering experiment. the laser was able to cut through but the PEG surface underneath was not very even.

To Do:

- **Look into vacuum issue**
- **Get some humidifiers - DONE**
- **Get powder cartridge dispensing and connect to control system for closed-loop filling of dummy hopper. Mohsen requests this be integrated with the printer early next week, but this may or may not be feasible.**
- **Try to make a CAD-style diagram for patent - DONE**
- **Investigate a sensor for measuring the water content of the printed layer**

2026-02-23

HOPPER:

- Post-process dummy hopper, new cartridge dock, etc. - DONE
- Make an improvised stand for the cartridge dock
- Populate parts with threaded inserts - DONE
- Wire up and glue down larger two-side vibrator motors - DONE
- Cast a new hopper vibration isolator for the dummy hopper vibrating hat - DONE
- Mount dummy hopper to desktop hopper testbed - DONE
- Assemble and wire up control box
- Make new vibrating sheet with thinner sheet metal per Mohsen's request

Finished hopper post-processing, installed and wired up the vibrator motors, installed all the necessary heat-set inserts, cast a new hopper vibration isolator, and began wiring up the control box. I tested the the new vibrator motors, and I feel pretty good about the vibrator on the vibrating hat but I am a little concerned that the motor on the cartridge dock may not be powerful enough (it is the same motor, but the mass it is vibrating is greater). I may need to upgrade to the larger vibrator motor, and likely mount it in a vertical orientation (perpendicular to the current motor's orientation).

PILOT:

The sheet metal parts for the more rigid 3-stage endstop design were delivered today, but they need some 3D printed parts to be designed and made before they can be installed (the current

3D printed parts on the machine are designed for a 3D printed endstop mount and so are not tall enough for the thinner sheet metal part).

I have redesigned the 3D printed parts and started them printing on one of the Bambu printers. I also measured the sheet metal part to make sure that the hole sizes are correct.

Laser meeting (Definitive Screening Test Design):

Understand effects of different factors on laser “ablation” behavior. Seems like the goal is more to establish which primary variables are important, and quantify how important they are, under baseline conditions.

- Per Payman, objective is not to determine fundamental mechanism of observed behavior

Controlled parameters: laser power, scan rate, frequency, pulse width, number of passes, binder volume

Covariates: environmental (temp, humidity), nebulizer flow rate, powder batch

Blocking factor: Day

Payman suggested replacing number of passes with binder concentration, which I think is a significant variation from our current process and is more suited to an optimization experiment rather than a baseline experiment.

30 brix is max concentration the nebulizers can handle, but sugar builds up rapidly.

Marcus noted that it is possible for pulses to overlap, depending on spot size, scan rate, pulse frequency, and pulse width (note that if the spot size is infinitesimally small, it would not be possible to overlap as long as the dot is being moved continuously, but with a finite spot size it is possible to overlap).

Procedure is:

- Create base layer
- Do three layers with set laser parameters
- Remove print and measure results at layer 3

Mason pointed out that he has had trouble cutting through a bound layer to reach loose powder, which Payman pointed out is necessary for our printing process to work at all. My recommendation is to first determine whether it is possible for the laser to cut through a bound layer to reach loose powder cleanly at all, because if that is not possible then the process is not viable.

IDEA: Maybe measure binder penetration by repeatedly firing short pulses at the same spot and monitoring the laser spot in some way (visible light camera? IR camera?) and seeing how many pulses it takes for the laser spot appearance to change.

Marcus pointed out that it may not be necessary to cleanly cut, we might just need to locally debind the layer (denaturing the binder without kicking out the powder).

IDEA: What if we intentionally sintered the part dimensions, while also binding some layers to use that as a support to enable us to directly print metal parts with a lower overhang angle than average LPBF processes.

Laser spot diameter is estimated to be ~50 microns.

I pointed out that it may be necessary to cut into loose powder for this process to be viable, which it seems that it is unable to do as it stands. Sean pointed out that we don't necessarily need to cut into the dry powder, we just need to cut TO the dry powder, but it does need to be able to do so without damaging the dry powder (Mason sees "sintering" of the powder when the laser hits dry powder using current settings, and so only gets clean cuts when cutting through bound powder).

Payman has noted behavior on the Pilot ultra platform where he would intentionally "sinter" features which would curl up and be easy to blow away.

Payman wants to run the test cutting into one layer on top of loose powder, while Mason wants to run 3 layers on top of each other. Payman's point is that the behavior will change with multiple layers, while Mason wants to run a test that is more representative of actual prints.

Data Collection: Kerf width/depth, environmental conditions (temp, humidity), debris field width, nebulizer flow rate, powder batch (also recommend recording time of day that test is run)

Payman pointed out that using the LVP may cure the layer and affect the results, but Mason pointed out that results are less reliable when the LVP is not used.

2026-02-24

HOPPER/FLIP:

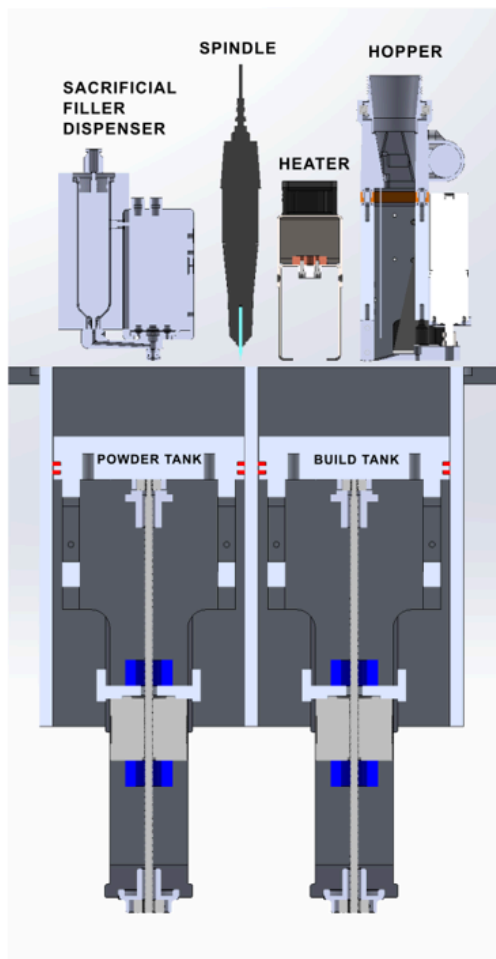
Demolded the hopper vibration isolator I made yesterday. Since I failed to spray the walls with mold release before casting, it was difficult to remove them. I found that the cleanest way to remove them was by slicing them off with a scalpel instead of pulling them off; with mold release I think pulling them off works fine but without it the urethane adheres to the printed part strongly enough that the urethane rips as I am removing the walls. I think from a functional perspective the rips aren't important, but they look bad cosmetically.

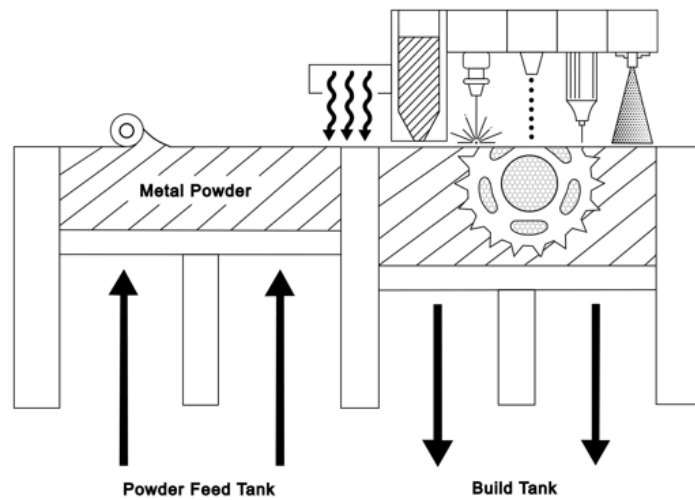
After setting up the dummy hopper on the hopper testbed, I realized that it will be very difficult to empty out the dummy hopper once it is full of powder, so I am redesigning it with a sliding gate on the bottom and threaded holes to connect it to a funnel that can be connected directly to a Nalgene bottle.

I designed a new dummy hopper with provisions for a manually removable gate as well as an attached funnel that connects to a nalgene bottle for dropping down powder build up in the dummy hopper.

GENERAL R&D:

I finished a CAD-style patent drawing for the no-depowdering patent by making a new SolidWorks assembly, and I also added the hopper and heater to the standard patent drawing style drawing I have been working on in Inkscape. Per Claude, it seems that there are restrictions on the style of drawings on patent applications; they generally need to be black-and-white line drawings so the patent can be printed easily. It is possible to get permission to use color or grayscale drawings, but it requires special authorization that is only granted when the color is critical to the patent, such as for certain biological assays and whatnot, generally not for style reasons alone.





PILOT:

I used a hole saw to make a 2 1/8" hole in the metal bottom plate of Pilot 6. The purpose of this is to pass through a large diameter vacuum hose from the vacuum to close to the Z stages; Splitting the standard small diameter hose into two equal diameter hoses (1X for the standard spindle and 1X for the facing spindle) close to the Z stages was not providing sufficient suction. I went over the BOM that Senai, Adriana, and Philip have been working on, and added comments where appropriate.

2026-02-25

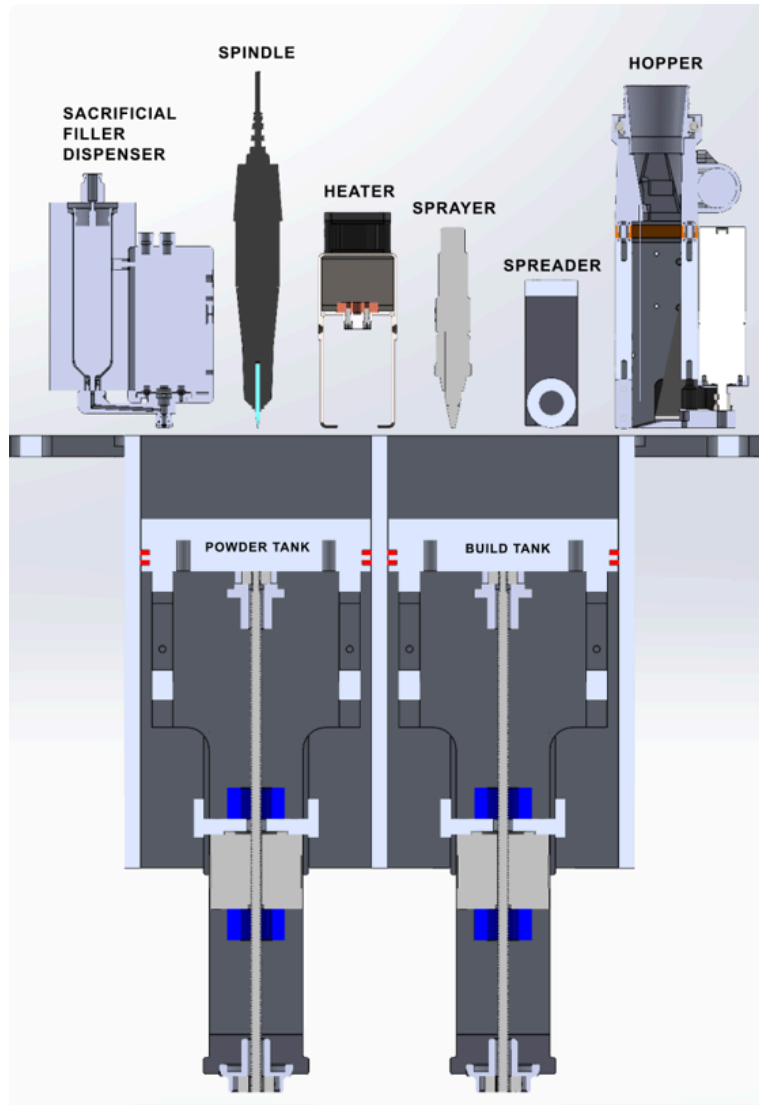
HOPPER/FLIP:

Post-processed the parts printed last night: a new dummy hopper with threaded inserts on the top and bottom and provisions added for a manually removable powder gate, the associated powder gate, and a funnel that screws to the bottom of the dummy hopper and has threads on

the bottom for a nalgene bottle to screw to it. The theory is that the powder will mostly be contained when the hopper is filled or emptied.

GENERAL:

Marcus pointed out that there is no separate spreader bar shown in the CAD patent drawing I sent him (there is one integrated into the hopper, but it would be good to show a separate one). I also noticed that there was no binder sprayer, so that should be added as well.



Payman, Marcus, Mason, and I are talking in the R&D office area. Out of the laser meeting, Payman thought that he had given a clear directive to Mason to run the loose powder test, which he did not. Marcus and I remember the meeting as not having had a clear action plan to do anything differently than he was already planning. Marcus said that he works on the assumption that Mason is in charge of the project, but Payman said that he is in charge of the project. Payman is not in favor of DOEs at all when we are at this phase of projects like this. The intent of the project was to determine which variables are important and how important they are.

Marcus pointed out that Payman can tell Mason what to do, or give him some level of autonomy to solve problems.

Mason is trying to establish a quantifiable understanding of the fundamental nature of the process.

Payman says he didn't want them to move the printer to the pod, he just wanted the printer to be tented in the R&D pilot lab (which I don't remember).

Payman wants the printer moved back to the R&D lab because he thinks that it is easier to work on here, if he needs to work on it too.

He mentioned the idea of eliminating the laser only project and switching to a combined no-depowdering/laser project.

2026-02-26

HOPPER/FLIP:

Need to redesign and reprint the hose duct interface components because the current components are too tight to fit inside the hose duct.

I am working on wiring up the standalone ESP-32 control system. I have the main power (24VDC) connected to the two motor drivers, the stepper drivers (stepper motor power side), and the "PWR" indicator LED. I have the two stepper drivers (signal power side) the relay board connected to the 5V supply of the ESP32 board (note that one of the grounds on the ESP32 board is not properly connected, so I had to switch ground connections when I noted that the green power indicator lights on the relay board and stepper driver boards were flickering. This is an issue I noticed when I was first testing the ESP32 board outside of the final control box).

GENERAL R&D:

Payman mentioned something interesting at the "meeting" yesterday, that he didn't think we were at the stage of the project where we should be optimizing the process, we were still trying to solve some basic problems, particularly the fact that it seems that we cannot cut into dry powder without "sintering" it. I checked back through my notes and my involvement in the project has been going back at least 10 months, which is the first note I found where I mentioned that I was working on designing laser guard windows for Pilot 3. Payman had been doing experiments with an XTool laser on the Ultimaker for some time before this, so I think it is safe to say that the project has been going on for at least a year now. The initial promising results that Payman got were done I think previously to installing lasers on Pilot 3, and per the 80/20 rule I would say it is likely that getting those results was 20% of the effort of the entire

project (with the ultimate goal of a productized system installed in the Pilot printers and integrated into the Pilot printing process). During the year of work on the project after getting those initial results (admittedly with the project active off and on; there was some distraction from the project by needing to ship the Epson Pilot printers). Some of those variables have only been available on the MOPA laser which has only been here for ~1 month, although the existence of laser technologies other than the XTools has been known for 8 months so the decision to purchase a different style of laser than the XTools tool 7 months. If I am making a rough timeline, it would be:

- 2 months for Payman doing experiments on the Ultimaker with an XTool laser that yielded some impressive results (2.5D prints of parts with complex outer geometry with narrow cut lines, laser cutting path generated in proprietary XTool software)
- 9 months of off-and-on experiments with the XTool laser on Pilot 3 (laser cutting path generated in proprietary XTool software, mostly 2.5D simple parts with one demo pyramid part) and also a gantry-mounted diode laser, ultimately rejected for being too slow
- 1 month of experiments on Pilot 3 with the MOPA laser (2.5D parts and cut lines generated in LightBurn (? not sure about this))

Mason's current experiment is the first formal experiment I am aware of to quantify the effect of different laser variables on the printing results.

Here is a proposed alternative schedule with the benefit of hindsight:

- 2 months for Payman doing experiments on the Ultimaker with an XTool laser that yielded some impressive results (2.5D prints of parts with complex outer geometry with narrow cut lines, laser cutting path generated in proprietary XTool software)
- At this point the question should be raised of why exactly we are attempting the project at all. Per Marcus and Mason today, the primary goal of the project is to increase print speed with a secondary goal of enabling finer features. I personally would push back on both these rationales; I personally find print speed to be a lower priority than other concerns because the printing time is a fairly small percentage of the overall CAD-ship time; it is mostly print file generation, breakout, sintering, and QC that take up most of the time. For low-volume high-mix contracts the print time is minimally important, where it becomes more important is with very high-volume low-mix contracts because the other steps in the process can be done in batches and so the time is ameliorated over many parts produced.
- Assuming we decide the project is worth pursuing, the project handed off to RE for the project; this would have first been Mohsen and then been Mason. At this point it would need to be established who the primary decision maker is for the project.

- 2 months of formal screening experiments with different laser technologies, factoring in different control system requirements (i.e. 3DEO slicer for gantry-mounted laser (abandoned purely for speed), XTool software for XTool products, LightBurn for MOPA laser, custom control system for a laser source combined with a galvanometer-based reflector/lens setup)
- Laser source and control system is downselected to a single laser technology
- 2 months of determining the fundamental mechanism of the effect we are seeing and quantifying the relative importance of different control variables (this would be where Mason's current experiment comes into play). Note that this step requires a control system that is sufficiently representative of a productized control system.
- 3 months of finalizing hardware and fully developing and integrating the laser into the control system of the printer as well as updating the slicer or developing a different way to generate G code to be able to print standard part geometry with the laser.
- 3 months of testing to benchmark and refine the system

The timeline outlined here takes 1 year, the same as the amount of time we have spent so far, and would result in a fully integrated and functional system. It is not guaranteed to be useful or productive, but we would know for sure whether it is a system worth pursuing further.

I dumped all of my above notes about the laser project and what's been happening, and asked Claude to come up with some suggestions for discussions with Payman, Marcus, and Mason:

Here are some talking points tailored for each person, based on what you've described.

For Marcus:

Marcus seems to be in a position where he could help mediate the dynamic between Payman and Mason. Some points to raise with him:

- Mason has expressed a desire for Marcus to push back more on Payman during contentious discussions. It might be worth asking Marcus directly whether he's willing to play that role, and if not, what alternative support structure he'd suggest.
- The question of who the primary decision maker is on the laser project needs to be resolved explicitly. Marcus seems to assume it's Mason, Payman says it's himself — this ambiguity is causing real friction and wasted effort.
- Mason's DOE work is the first formal attempt to quantify laser variable effects after roughly a year of ad hoc experimentation. If Payman is going to reject DOEs at this phase, Marcus and Mason need to know what the accepted methodology is for making progress.
- It may be worth revisiting the conversation Marcus had with Sean about Payman's management style, and whether any actionable changes came out of it.

For Mason:

Mason is doing the hands-on work and feeling caught between directives. Points to discuss:

- Encourage him to have the direct conversation with Marcus about wanting more support during disagreements with Payman, as you recommended. He should frame it around project outcomes rather than personalities — what does the project need to move forward?
- Help him articulate the value of his experimental approach in Payman's language. If Payman's concern is that they're optimizing before solving basic problems, Mason could frame his DOE as a diagnostic tool to understand the fundamentals (which is what he's actually doing — establishing quantifiable understanding of the process).
- The question of environmental controls is worth raising carefully. If Mason can point to specific instances where uncontrolled variables made results ambiguous, that's a concrete case for why controlled experiments matter even at this stage.

- He should seek explicit, written direction from Payman on what "solving the basic problems" looks like in practice, with clear milestones and success criteria.

For Payman:

This is the most delicate conversation. Some points worth raising:

- The project has been active for about a year with promising but informal results. A structured path forward — even a lightweight one — would help ensure the next year is more productive than the last. Your proposed alternative timeline could be a useful framework to reference.
- If Payman believes DOEs are premature, it's fair to ask: what evidence or milestone would signal that the project is ready for formal experimentation? Without a clear threshold, the team can't plan ahead.
- The question of project ownership needs a clear answer. If Payman is the decision maker, Mason needs regular, explicit direction — not ambiguous meeting outcomes that get interpreted differently by everyone in the room. If Mason has autonomy, the scope of that autonomy needs to be defined.
- On the environmental control question, it could be framed as risk management: without controlled conditions, there's a risk of spending months on experiments whose results can't be trusted or reproduced, which would be a worse use of time than pausing to set up proper controls.
- The idea of combining the laser and no-depowdering projects is worth discussing on its merits, but changing scope mid-stream without a clear rationale risks further confusion about priorities.

One general note: your observation about clear action items coming out of meetings is important for all three conversations. A recurring theme here is that people leave discussions with different understandings of what was decided. Pushing for written summaries of decisions and action items after meetings — even informal ones — could prevent a lot of the friction you're describing.

Payman has been running informal experiments on the Ultimaker with the XTool with a blue laser diode source (400-500 nm) instead of the MOPA laser's NIR wavelength (1064 nm). It also has a different hopper, spreader, and binder application technology. I am not sure what exactly he is seeing that is different, but it seems that he is seeing less of the "sintering" of the powder, and presumably less debris.

The conclusion Payman and Marcus have drawn from Payman's informal experiments today is to try and get the MOPA laser to behave more like the blue diode laser, and Marcus sent out an

email based on a chat with Claude asking how to get the MOPA laser to perform like a blue diode laser.

I am unsure why Payman is running these experiments before Mason's MOPA laser experiments have concluded, especially since there are experiments that Payman insisted Mason run as part of this screening experiment. It seems that Payman is trying to solve issues that Mason is seeing before the formal experiment is concluded. I do not see this as a particularly constructive use of Payman's time, my recommendation would be to wait until Mason's screening experiment has been concluded and the data presented before moving on to different experiments.

I am also increasingly of the opinion that it is important to gain an understanding of the fundamental nature of the process we are seeing before we start running off in different directions.

2026-02-27

HOPPER/FLIP:

Wired up the control box for stepper motor and vibrator motor outputs. I have not yet connected any sensors.

The newly updated host duct connectors are done printing; yesterday I dropped the original 38mm OD to 37mm, found that they were still too tight, then dropped the OD to 36mm, which are the parts that are done printing now.

I connected the powder cartridge dock doser stepper motor, and it seems to be rotating fine. The rotational speed is quite low because the Arduino running TMC2209 stepper drivers combined with the 1:100 gear ratio of the stepper motor limit the speed, but the speed should be much higher when it is being run by a Duet board.

I have dispensed 1 1/2 bottles of powder through the doser ball now, and the system seems to be working OK. I have started trying different sensors. The first sensor I tried was an inductive proximity sensor, which interestingly was not able to detect the powder, even when I inserted the sensor ~20mm into powder in a nalgene bottle. I am now trying to use an IR proximity switch. It works detecting the presence of powder in a nalgene bottle, but since the bottle takes ~1 hour to empty it takes a while before I can tell whether the sensor actually detects the rising powder or not. I also have yet to tie the switch into the Arduino yet, I am so far just watching the indicator light on the back of the prox switch.

GENERAL R&D:

Payman is still running experiments on the Ultimaker. Yesterday he build a Vention frame around it that holds the green laser guard panels; as I recall they are not suitable for the blue laser that

the XTool uses but I don't remember exactly what spectrum they block.

I spoke with Mason about the fundamental physical principles of the laser cutting we are seeing; based on papers he and Midhun have read, the laser light is absorbed by metal powder, and the heated particles then interact with the binder in such a way that the particles are ejected from the heated area. This may be due to vaporization of the water in the binder, vaporization of the sugar in the binder, or some other effect or combination of effects that we are as yet unaware of. The nominal working theory is that the heat is vaporizing the water and that is what ejects the powder without melting or igniting it, and when the laser penetrates to dry unbound powder, the energy input has a greater tendency to melt or ignite the powder, as shown by debris around the cut. This is generally interpreted as "sintering," although I am unconvinced that the powder is actually sintering without data showing that it is not melting or igniting or a combination of all 3. Regardless, that is an undesirable effect; the goal is to replicate the function of the spindle with a higher speed and decreased cut line width. This goal carries advantages and disadvantages. Let's say we get the laser system working as well as the spindle (controlled cut depth, clean cuts, same surface finish on the side of the parts, same precision and accuracy):

Advantages:

- Faster cutting speed
- Reduce line width (this one is more subtle because it is possible to use a smaller end mill in theory, but that is so far untested)
- If the laser system is used only with no spindle or sacrificial filler, the Z axis and X axes could be eliminated, and the Y axis would not need high positional accuracy and repeatability, it would only need to travel in a very straight line

Disadvantages:

- More expensive hardware required for the printer (one of the selling points of 3DEO's technology is that spindles are cheap)
- More complex control system demands (may require a more advanced hardware control system, which would add to the system cost)
- Reduces the differentiation between 3DEO's technology and competitors' technologies, particularly HeadMade materials with their ColdMetalFusion technology, where they use polymer SLS printers to print metal parts by pre-coating the powder with a laser-activated binder.

This additional context is really helpful and changes the picture meaningfully. A few observations:

The dynamic you're navigating is fundamentally a founder problem. Payman isn't just a difficult manager — he's the last remaining founder, which means his identity is deeply tied to the technology and the company's original vision. When people push back on the technology or suggest replacing core elements of it (like the sprayer with a binder jetting head), he's not just hearing a technical argument — he's hearing that the thing he built isn't good enough. That doesn't make his resistance rational or productive, but it explains why technical counterarguments don't land the way they should.

Your approach of compliance plus independent problem-solving is probably why you've avoided conflict. You're not threatening his sense of ownership. Mason, as a newer engineer trying to bring formal methodology to a process Payman feels he understands intuitively, is inadvertently challenging both his authority and his approach. That's a much more friction-prone position to be in, especially with only a year of tenure.

The fact that this is well known to management is significant. It means Marcus and Sean are already aware of the pattern, which suggests one of two things: either they've decided the cost of confronting Payman is higher than the cost of the friction he creates, or they've tried and failed to change the dynamic. The engineer who left two years ago is a data point that the company has already paid a real price for this. Mason could become another.

For Mason specifically, the hard truth is that as a one-year engineer pushing back against the CTO and last remaining founder, his leverage is limited regardless of whether he's technically right. His best path forward is probably to frame his work in terms that align with Payman's stated goals rather than trying to change Payman's mind about methodology. If Payman says the project needs to solve basic problems before optimizing, Mason could ask Payman to define those problems explicitly, then design his experiments to address them — even if the underlying methodology is still essentially a structured experiment.

For Marcus, the question is whether he's willing to use his position as VP of Engineering to establish clear project governance. The ownership ambiguity on the laser project is a symptom of a broader issue: if the CTO can override the engineering team's methodology without providing a clear alternative, that's an organizational problem, not a project management one. Marcus is really the only person with the standing to address this.

For you personally, your five years of tenure and low-conflict relationship with Payman actually give you a unique position. You can say things to Payman that Mason can't, and your retrospective timeline analysis is the kind of constructive framing that might resonate with him — it's not criticizing his approach, it's showing what a structured path could look like. Whether you want to spend that social capital is a personal decision, though. You're not obligated to be

the mediator, and there's a real risk of inheriting some of the friction that Mason is currently absorbing.

The deeper strategic question is whether the company's leadership is willing to honestly evaluate whether the original technology platform is still competitive. If Payman's attachment to it is preventing necessary evolution — and it sounds like multiple engineers believe it is — that's ultimately a board-level or CEO-level conversation, not something that gets resolved through better project management on the laser project.

R&D Weekly Meeting:

No-Depowdering:

Started another 2 prints on copper to replicate the swelling issue, but it was not observed on the first print. First was 5 layers, second is currently running and is on layer 3.

Wax does not stay inside the cut on 5 layer print, Pourya wants to thermally remove sacrificial filler and see if the part is OK.

The current print is very slow because of 6 minute air cure delay and 10 minute delay between layers after hatching is complete. Without these delays, there were issues with features being vacuumed up.

~~Copper printing plans for next week are first to to modify print design to one that is faster to run~~

If the 20 layer part looks OK, Payman requested to run a full part print.

Base layer improvement:

Trying to replicate the issue of cake corners detaching in the pod without the humidifier, and the issue still appeared.

Ordered and installed parts for airflow management and installed the humidifier, but the humidifier does not have sufficient setting granularity to maintain humidity.

Mohsen noted that the dry airflow is not very uniform, which may be leading to uneven drying of the cake. Mohsen theorizes that the airflow out of the muffler is higher towards the edges of the cake. It is also possible that the spray non-uniformity is leading to the corners drying more than the center. Next week Mohsen plans to work on improving uniformity of drying. Payman is

notably being more insistent on telling people what to do, and Marcus is making a note of determining what exactly the directive is. Also, he joined the zoom call early into the meeting, presumably with the intention of recording the meeting.

No-depowdering bringup on Pilot 6. Stonevac replaced with Festool, but the vacuum flow is still weak, so Pourya redesigned the system to have a large diameter hose run close to the SVP before splitting it. With new vacuum, installed larger tool bit, but the SVP was less effective due to the larger tool bit being longer than the standard tool bit. Using a larger tool bit reduces the facing operation time from ~8 minutes to 1 minute.

An issue with the StoneVac has been noted that if it is run too long with the current level of restriction it will overheat. Cisco contacted the manufacturer and they said that it is rated for continuous duty under nominal operation, so the reason it overheated is likely due to the restriction.

Payman requested that a test be conducted with the StoneVac where it is run for several hours without restriction to see if it overheats.

Ning is replacing the AC outlet feeding the vacuum because the previous one burned. I am unclear on his explanation for precisely why it burned; it should have been rated for the same current that wall outlets can supply.

Marcus recommends that a safety feature be added to prevent the vacuum from running for too long.

After going over the no depowdering results, Marcus went over the specific tasks to be done next week.

Hopper:

Get closed loop powder level control system working on the dummy hopper, then transfer it over to Pilot 2. If it can be fully implemented early enough in the week, task Mohsen with running some prints.

Spread/Spray:

Payman worked on the spread and spray system. Reinforced the Z axis and installed the XTool laser with the intent of replicating the results achieved 1 year ago. Noted that the XTool laser performance differs from the MOPA laser. On a flat side surface, the surface finish seems good, but when the geometry becomes more complicated the surface finish is poorer. Mason pointed out that the transit speed of the galvanometer varies as the dot is directed around curves. There are settings for adjusting this part of the process in LightBurn, which Mason is using for the MOPA laser, but it is unclear if those settings are available on the XTool software. In the

video recorded of the XTool cutting process, there is a bright plume above the cut and visible sparks. I should check with Mason to see what the laser looks like with the MOPA laser.

Laser:

Mason has been running the screening experiment that was discussed in the meeting earlier this week. The testing is still ongoing. Marcus asked whether it looks like there are parameters for getting a clean cut within the tests Mason ran, which is not a valid question to ask at this stage.

Payman asked whether the XTool had been tested on Pilot 3, which it had been in January, per Mason. Mason said that he conducted 2 weeks of testing on the XTool laser before Payman bought the MOPA laser.

Mason tested the effect of air curing with the layer fan using 5 minutes, 2 minutes, and 0 minutes cure before cutting, and found that curing with 0 curing time was the best.

In the current DOE, there has been no curing of the layer. Marcus noted that there is risk of a cake being too wet without curing. Mason recommends revisiting layer curing experiments when we are in the optimization stage of manufacturing process development.

Mason found previously that adding water to the layer tended to increase the level of sintering seen.

Next week for laser:

Move Pilot 3 back to R&D lab. Marcus explicitly asked Payman what he wants done with Pilot 3 for next week. Payman is interested in comparing the XTool laser (blue, IR) with the MOPA laser. He requests that a planning meeting be set up after Mason's DOE results have been published. He wants to try a 3D print with the XTool on the Ultimaker.

Mason requested setting up a meeting to discuss the results of his DOE with the MOPA laser on Pilot 3.

After the meeting, I asked Mason why we switched to the MOPA laser, and it was essentially what I remember: Mason spent 3 days working on the XTool laser on Pilot 3, then Payman ordered a MOPA laser off of Amazon and directed Mason to use that instead. This was in early January, so call it 6 weeks ago. It appears that based on Payman's informal experiments, he is interested in switching back to the XTool blue laser technology. This is somewhat concerning to me, because the results he achieved this last week seem no different from the results achieved 10 months ago, the decision to switch to the MOPA laser was solely his, and his latest batch of informal experiments were conducted prior to the results of Mason's formal DOE.

2026-03-02

HOPPER/FLIP:

Connected the IR prox switch to the ESP-32 board. The way the output signal of the prox switch works is that it drives a load at 300 mA that is placed across the signal line (black) and the ground wire (blue), presumably at the same voltage the sensor is supplied with (originally 12V, but I switched out the 12V power supply for a 24V power supply, so I have the option of increasing the voltage to the vibrator motors if necessary, although so far it has not seemed to be necessary. I tried connecting the signal wire directly to an input on the ESP-32 board (which was really stupid, I don't know why I thought that might work. To be fair, I did try it before I had a complete understanding of the sensor output architecture, but in a way that makes me look even worse.) I considered connecting a resistor from the signal wire to ground to drop 7V when it was using a 12V power supply, and connecting the ESP-32 board to the point where the voltage would nominally be 5V, but the resistance value wound up being 23.3 ohms, which would need to dissipate ~2.4W when the sensor is triggered. Since most resistors are, I believe, 1/4W, I would need to get a high-power resistor (probably either 22 or 24 ohm), and I would need to deal with heat generation from the resistor. What I wound up doing was to connect the sensor to a 24V PC board relay that I desoldered from one of those little relay control boards. I started off trying to use the whole board with its associated bits of electronics that make it possible to trigger it with a low voltage signal, but for some reason wiring it to the sensor fed power back into the sensor and caused the indicator light on the sensor to trigger. This setup seems to work; I have the sensor powering the coil of the relay when it is activated and the NO/COM lines connected to switch 5VDC to the ESP-32 input. There is something very worrisome where when I move around some of the wires and the newly added relay the 4 relays on the relay board that the ESP-32 board is connected to will turn on and off randomly (or it may just be the new relay that clicks quickly enough that it sounds like it is switching a bunch of relays, but I am not totally sure.) It seems to work nominally when I am not touching it. I rewrote the Arduino code so that it is reading the prox switch input; if the prox switch is not triggered, both vibrators and the powder feed stepper motor will run, and once the prox switch has been triggered it will turn everything off and send a single serial text line to the Arduino IDE serial monitor saying "HOPPER FULL :)". The prox switch seems to function OK even though its optics are pretty well covered with powder (when the hopper vibrates everything inside it will get covered by powder that is kicked up). If this sensor works robustly then it could be a very simple solution to detecting and adjusting the powder level (there is a small set screw on the prox switch that can be turned to change the triggering distance of the switch). One concern I have is about the repeatability of the switch; it may trigger at slightly different distances, which would cause the powder fill level to vary over time. I personally doubt that this will affect the print

quality and part density significantly, but it is one variable to consider. If this does turn out to be an issue, it may be possible to switch to one of the more advanced TOF sensors (potentially more accurate, but are more difficult to interface to from a software perspective and with a much smaller sensor window may be more sensitive to powder buildup). I am confident that the prox switch can be interfaced to one of the limit switch connection points of the Duet expansion board, but I am not sure if it is possible to interface an I2C sensor to the Duet board, particularly one that requires a pretty complex library to talk to it.

Since the TOF sensor will hopefully not be necessary and the opening for mounting is allowing powder to be released, I am going to print a new vibrating hopper hat without the TOF sensor cutout.

The updated vibrating hat design is complete and I am printing it out on Anvil, the Bambu X1E, so it should be ready for post-processing and heat-set insert installation tomorrow.

I made a new vibrating sheet from 301 stainless steel that is .010" thick, as opposed to the previous .020" thick sheet. This new sheet also has holes in the correct positions so it will not need to be glued into place.

I have continued testing of the powder loading system with the ESP-32-based control system, and the IR proximity switch seems to be working quite robustly to detect powder height. It does not appear to have any built-in hysteresis, so it has a tendency to switch between detecting the powder and not detecting it at a frequency of ~10 Hz. I wrote a hysteresis function into the Arduino IDE code the ESP-32 is running, but for the final Duet-board-run (G code) program I will likely just run it until it first detects the powder and call the hopper filled at that point. Actually, I take that back; since I will need to design some closed-loop functionality into the macro anyway, I might as well design in a function that detects the prox switch, dispenses for a while longer, checks the prox switch again, maybe dispenses for longer, etc.

LASER MEETING:

Mason finishing up DOE, screening test should be done by today. Also reviewing debris results from Ben.

Squares on each layer, hatch on each layer done, but Midhun recommends trying just hatching the top layer.

Another meeting will be set up for tomorrow to review results.

Payman and Marcus also requested a meeting to plan next steps in the laser project.

Per Midhun, Marcus said that a far IR laser would be better because it is more absorbed by the water and reflects from the metal, but Midhun believes that targeting metal powder heating

provides better results where the metal powder heats and transfers energy to vaporize the water and “pyrolyze” the binder. Midhun supports the MOPA laser because of the greater degree of control over parameters. In literature, people have used NIR lasers (MOPA) and blue diode lasers and gotten good results but have had poorer results with FIR (CO2).

Mason was started on the XTool, and told to use it until Q2, but after 3 days Payman bought the MOPA laser and told Mason to switch to that.

The XTool software limits parameters to scan speed and power, although it may be possible to get more knobs using LightBurn.

Midhun also pointed out that our lasers should be tested on multiple materials to select the laser source; if the laser is only usable on 17-4PH it will not be viable for production.

2026-03-03

HOPPER/FLIP:

The new vibrating hat with the dedicated opening for mounting a TOF sensor board removed has been printed and post-processed (supports removed) and just needs heat set inserts installed to be ready to install on Pilot 2.

I noted that the doser roller has a very low flow rate on the benchtop testing rig (although this is in part due to the speed limitation of the stepper motor because I am using an Arduino to drive it) and it also dispenses in discrete pulses due to the nature of the design of the doser ball with discrete openings. I am going to redesign it with a larger number of helical openings, which should give a continuous dispense and also dispense faster because there are more openings. I am also going to increase the size of the doser ball slightly because powder leaks around it when the cartridge is inverted but the doser ball is not rotated. I am hoping to avoid the need to add some sort of seal to the cartridge cap, but they may become necessary if I am unable to prevent powder leakage by redesigning the doser ball.

I populated the vibrating hat with heat set inserts, and now I am working on hose routing for the powder feed hose. This is going to be one of the trickier parts of the design; at the very least I anticipate that the cartridge dock will only be able to be installed at one location on the top of the machine, which likely will not be the most convenient location to reach, and it is highly likely that I will need to change the hose duct interface on the vibrating hat that freely rotates using a ball bearing; I suspect I will need to design it to be an angled elbow, and restrict the range of rotational motion so the hose does not impact the mist box or the X axis cable carrier. I also redesigned the doser ball with a spiral pattern; for some reason the swept cuts (I made two spiral paths in opposite directions out of the center plane and swept the same profile along each to make sure that the spiral path is centered on the doser ball) were not forming evenly, even

with the exact same spiral dimensions and sweep settings. One of them always twisted more than the other, and I'm not sure why. I did try restarting SolidWorks to see if that resolved the issue, which it did not. Possibly restarting my computer entirely would resolve it. I ended up manually setting a fixed twist value for each sweep operation (0 degrees) which made them match each other (previously they were both set to "minimum twist").

In disassembling the benchtop dummy hopper test setup to move some of the components over to Pilot 2, I discovered that the bearing in the hopper vibrating hat seems to have ingested a significant amount of powder and is making a grinding noise when it is rotated. Since the bearing used is a low-cost alternative to the sealed McMaster bearings, and since the bearing on the vibrating hat is more exposed to powder than the powder dispenser bearing, this is not tremendously surprising, but it is something to keep an eye on. I am also not liking the interface between the components and the duct hose.

I designed a new duct mount for the hopper vibrating hat with a 45 degree bend, and I am printing parts to make a silicone mold that will make it possible to cast a smooth urethane cylinder around the corrugated duct hose. This will provide a good sealing surface to seal against the 3D printed parts and increase friction so it is easier to clamp the duct hose to the 3D printed parts. I am now in the process of figuring out hose routing to connect the hopper to the powder cartridge dock. As expected, it seems to be a quite tricky problem; I am concerned that the hose will be at a very shallow angle which will make it difficult for the powder to flow into the hopper.

PILOT:

I gave the sheet metal endstop holder and the 2 new 3D printed parts to Pourya to install on Pilot 6. The 3D printed part that holds the cable carrier needs 2X M6 heat set inserts to be installed. We were able to find 2 inserts on the heat set insert installation table in the heavy R&D area, but we clearly need to order more for future applications.

The cable carrier mount for the sheet metal endstop holder broke on Pilot 7. I destructively tested the original part that had not broken in operation against the spare printed alongside the one that broke, and found that the one that had broken in the printer was much weaker and had been printed with far fewer walls (I think 2 vs the original's 6), so I redesigned the part to be slightly thicker at the region where it broke and I am printing it with 8 walls and 69% infill.

Laser Meeting:

Meeting for discussing results of DOE completed. Midhun has been analyzing the data collected in Google Sheets, and Mason has been analyzing the results in Minitab.

Midhun noted that it is easy to twist statistical results to fit any narrative.

Mason measured debris quantity with image analysis and gave a subjective ranking to level of debris distribution in cut zone and a ranking of variation in cut depth in the hatched region.

No direct correlation between cut depth measured on the last cut and whether layers are interconnected. No correlation between hatch depth and layer connection.

Strong correlation between debris area percentage and debris score.

Avg cut width 110 microns, very stable across different tests. Hatch depth correlates with cut depth.

Response variables Midhun used are debris area percentage for cuts, debris area percentage for hatch, and whether cuts were connected.

To measure whether cuts were connected, Ben first measured the cut width, depth, and debris on the Keyence VHX microscope after print curing, then used a brush to brush out the cuts and repeat the measurements. If the depth measurement changes, then the cuts are considered to be connected. For cuts that were down to the glass, the measurement was not done, it was just marked as cuts connected. If the change in depth between pre-brushing and post-brushing was less than 50 microns the cut was marked as not connecting.

Mason noted that binder penetration is an unknown, so he wants to do an experiment to measure binder penetration with the different binder quantities used.

Midhun's recommends adding a step to the experimental protocol where a cut is done on the third layer only as well as the cuts that are done on each layer.

Minitab build a 98% accurate predictive model that concludes that the pulse width is not a significant factor but all the other variables are important to debris area.

The model developed for predicting whether cuts are connected is weak, but it suggests that the only variable that is important is number of passes.

Debris percentage for hatch model has a 96% match, with all variables statistically significant.

Midhun recommends adding more response variables to improve the quality of the data.

Midhun also asks what the actual desired cut width is. Is it possible that the cut will be so narrow that it is difficult to remove the part from the cake?

Mason asked Marcus and Payman for hard specs for cut width, minimum feature size, etc. in January and was only given the directive to "make a printer that can use a laser to print parts."

2026-03-04

Laser Meeting:

Reviewing results of Mason/Midhun's DOE

Different laser parameters adjusted for a series of prints, with a particular focus on cut depth, width, debris production, and whether cuts and hatches are connected between layers.

In hatch areas, the section of the hatch where the laser starts cutting tends to be deeper. The depth variation tends to be 100-200 microns. The scan pattern was a raster scan with X direction lines stacked on each other in Y direction.

Cut depth not strongly correlated with cut connection. Strongest correlation was between number of passes and whether cuts connected.

Debris area was strongly correlated with the model (cut debris R^2 98.53%, hatch debris R^2 of 95.97%).

Payman asked about one data point with a 40 micron cut that was connected. Mason said that the cut depth measurement was determined as a rough average of measured cut depth.

Debris is considered to be melted/sintered/oxidized/etc material within the cut.

Nonlinear correlation seen between input parameters and debris area output. The graphs of the Minitab predicted models show negative values of debris area in some regions of the models.

Most combinations resulted in a 100 micron cut width.

All variables had statistically significant effects on the response variables, but varied in how strong the correlation was. Pulse width had the weakest correlation.

Optimal parameters were calculated based on the Minitab model, so the test protocol was repeated with those parameters. The results of this test did not exactly match predicted results.

Mason noted that the layer tends to be quite wet; even the powder that can be brushed out tends to form clumps on the brush. On the AEM-style demo part, unbound powder was loose before curing but after curing was more bound. The "unbound" powder was easier to remove than the green part bound powder after curing but was not completely loose powder.

Midhun's answers to Q's from yesterday. I asked how closely the model predicts the results seen, and he said that the model fits well. The graphs that show negative values are not showing the output variables, they are showing the effect on the mean of the response variable for a given input variable.

Cut depth only measured at the third layer. Mason noted that sometimes he did see that the cuts went all the way to the glass. He also noted that the nominal layer thickness in the test was 100 microns.

Mason has recommendations for improving the experimental protocol in the future: having a hatch that is cut only on the top layer and collecting data on kerf angle and surface roughness.

For next steps, Mason recommends comparing the MOPA fiber laser with the blue diode laser before moving forward with further MOPA laser experiments.

He also recommends multi-material testing on 316L, 17-4PH, and copper.

Marcus and Payman recommend sticking with 17-4PH only for now.

I pointed out that it is possible that copper may require a different laser or this process will not work with any laser technology with copper, and Marcus acknowledged that that is a risk.

Marcus stated that the process will still be commercially viable even if it cannot work on copper.

Marcus is open to using different lasers for different materials.

It is also noted that 17-4PH and 316L powder have similar absorptivity with 1064nm light, but pure copper has very low absorptivity at this wavelength.

Marcus asked about theories of the fundamental mechanism of cut depth variation with the hatch, and Mason suggested it may be due to heat transfer causing drying of the other regions before hatching during the hatch operation.

Mason and Midhun also raised the idea of testing the effect of layer curing before the laser cutting operation.

Marcus complimented Midhun and Mason's work, and asked Payman what next steps should be. Payman stated that he needs to go over the results, and asked Mason what he is going to do next. Mason recommends running a screening test to compare the diode laser with the fiber laser.

It may be beneficial to use Magics or

Marcus raised the concept of running the MOPA laser in a regime that matches the results of the diode laser as closely as possible, per an email he has sent out previously showing the output of Claude for this application. Claude's suggestions were based on matching a pulsed laser to a continuous wave laser, based on adjustment of pulse width and frequency and adjusting the spot size to match.

Marcus recommends maximizing frequency and pulse width to match Ultimaker Xtool results.

Payman asked about time taken for running the experiment. Mason noted that the bottleneck was a limited number of glass plates; this resulted in the measurement process taking more time than the printing. It was also raised that only one sample section was run on each plate, in the center of the build area. Each cut line needs to be measured individually, so measurement time

scales linearly with cut length (5mm to 10mm square quadruples measurement time, 1 to 5 squares multiplies measurement time by a factor of 5).

Marcus suggests that Payman review the results and determine next steps, and Mason will consider comparing the diode laser with the MOPA laser.

Midhun asked about Payman's success with using the blue diode laser on the Ultimaker, and Marcus asked about his experiments and results. Payman noted that the setup is very different. It uses the spread-and-spray system with his hopper design. He started by measuring penetration depth by changing layer thickness until the layers did not adhere. He did a thick layer of unbound powder and bound one layer then ran a grid with squares with different parameters to come to a setting that cut through the layer without sintering, then ran a 20 layer print with the optimal settings. The straight lines cut seemed good, but where the laser path turned around a corner the surface finish was poorer. He wants to "work on fundamentals" first by starting at 1 layer then increasing the number of layers. Midhun asked if he cut 20 layers of joined hatches, and Payman said that he only cut lines that were joined. Payman did not clean off the layer between cuts and noted that the layers were quite dirty between layers. The laser is the galvo-based XTool used on a roller gantry setup.

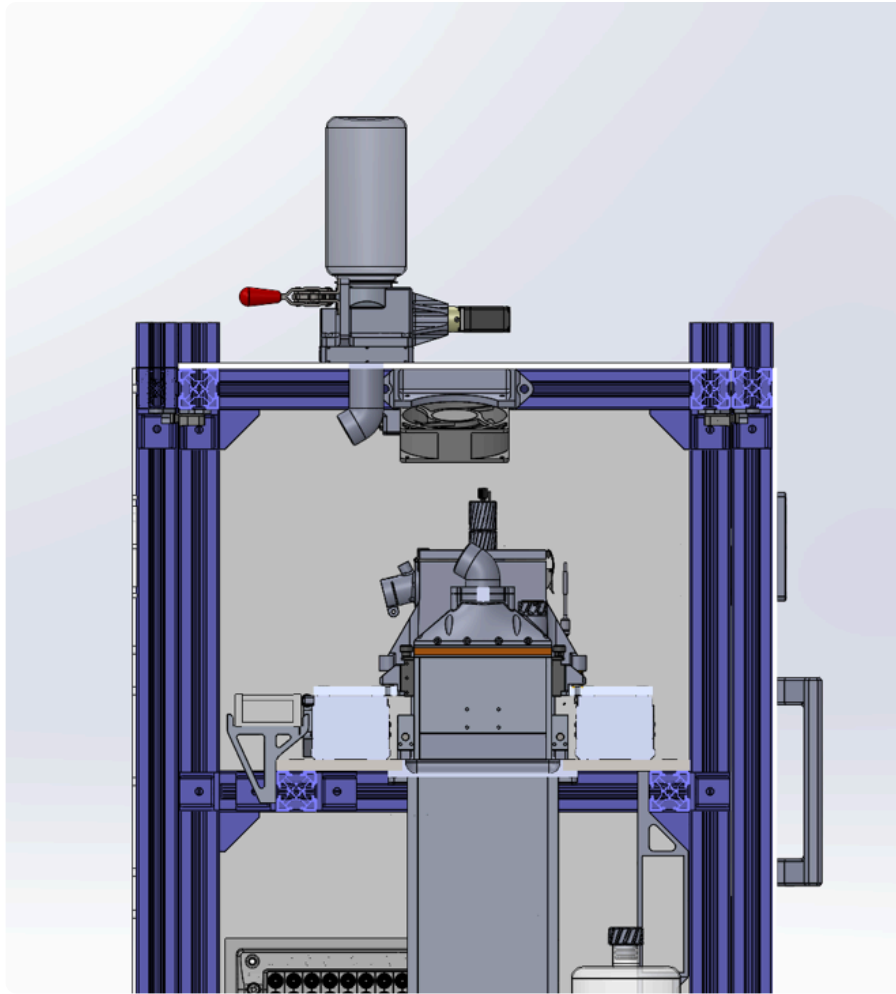
My recommendation would be:

HOPPER/FLIP:

The print of the silicone mold supporting case and the angled hopper hose duct connector did not come out well on the P2S, so I am reprinting them.

The new spiral doser ball has been printed and post-processed, so I am printing a redesigned mold mold for casting doser balls from urethane. I also did a pour for the mold for casting a sealing ring around the end of the hose duct.

Created a copy of the CAD for Pilots 2 and 3 on my personal folder on the Z drive (the CAD for the Epsoms and Pilots 6 and 7 are on the vault, but the CAD for 2 and 3 predate the vault migration) to help with designing the hose routing for the hose duct running from the cartridge dock to the hopper.



I am trying to keep the angle of the hose duct no less than 30 degrees relative to horizontal to keep powder flowing through it (with vibration; I doubt that powder will flow at that shallow of an angle without vibration).

2026-03-05

Heat Exchanger:

Looked at a new heat exchanger design Sean has generated with Pourya and Marcus, and discussed minimum feature size with Devin. There is a hard-coded limit on how close tool paths can be in the V1 slicer (whose value is unknown) so it is impossible to make a single cutter-width cut, you always need at least two tool paths that are that unknown with apart. It is possible that this limit is reduced or eliminated with ZZ's V2 slicer.

Management learned about a company recently called Alloyed Enterprises based in Boston (of course) that makes heat exchangers for the same market we are pursuing (processors in data centers). Their process involves starting with a roll of thin sheet metal (either copper or aluminum), laser cutting outlines into sections of the sheet for each layer of the part (the part is sliced into layers the same way it is done with 3D printing), filling in the gaps with some

sacrificial filler material, stacking the layers together with precise registration (I would probably cut holes into each layer and use pins to align the layers together, although they may have a more clever solution that involves vision-based inspection of each layer and precision positioning of the layer to match the ones below) and they then use diffusion bonding to join the layers into a single part, and then remove the sacrificial filler material. There will be some print limitations based on the force that needs to be applied in the Z direction when diffusion bonding, as well as the fact that the sacrificial filler material cannot be removed from fully enclosed spaces.

I installed WSL so that I can run the full OpenFOAM package for heat exchanger simulation. the Unix user account I set up is admin-jhumphreys and the password is "guest" .

HOPPER/FLIP:

Demolded the silicone molds for making a urethane spiral doser ball and casting urethane around the end of the hose duct to give a good seal and mechanical joint to the 3D printed parts.

Designing a 3D printed jig to align the splined shaft with the doser ball mold when it is being cast, as well as to hold the mold together so no urethane leaks out of the mold splits.

GENERAL R&D:

Noted that someone is running a print of several large parts on Anvil labeled "mist box" that are clearly more of the spread-and-spray designs.

2026-03-06

HOPPER/FLIP:

I printed the new hopper duct hose mount and bearing mount with rotation limits so it nominally points straight back away from the operator (-X direction, I think) is blocked from rotating towards the cable carrier (+Y direction) and can only rotate 30 degrees towards the mist box (-Y direction). This should prevent the hose duct from hitting anything while still giving it enough motion to reduce the load applied to the vibrating hat and get the hose angle correct when the gantry is at maximum Y direction (this is the point at which the hose duct has a continuous path downwards to the hopper, so is likely the optimal gantry position for loading the hopper.

I demolded the cast urethane spiral doser ball and it looks good.

I wired up the stepper motor and vibrator motor on the cartridge dock to the Duet expansion board, so it should be possible to control them with G code now. I also demolded the scrap piece of hose that I had cast a urethane end on to, and it came out really well. There are a few voids here and there on the outside of the hose, but the inside looks OK. The castellations on

the bottom which were intended to allow flow between the OD and ID areas of the mold actually had an interesting different effect. They collected bubbles that would otherwise have led to voids in the seal, so when I cut off the bits of urethane that formed in the castellations there was a nice flush surface on the bottom of the duct. Overall, it seems like a very promising technique for forming a reliable seal between the hose duct and 3D printed parts.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

Midhun's visa had an "encouraging" visa interview so he may be moving back soon. Alex out of the office because he is sick.

No Depowdering:

Tried to dewax 5 layer print (with different dewaxing settings), shattered in Keith furnace oven. Print was put in oven on glass plate because it was too thin to be removed before dewaxing.

20 layer print placed on a ceramic setter for dewaxing but could not be removed after dewaxing.

Marcus pointed out that copper no-depowdering is the priority in response to Pourya saying that he was delayed by someone being busy.

Did another 20 layer print, tried to use heat gun to remove from plate, features floated in the wax and became detached from the base.

Started another 20 layer print, if the same behavior appears, it suggests that there are penetration issues. Pourya wants to try repeating the 5 layer scenario (build in furnace on glass plate) with the original Keith settings.

Payman requested to look at next prints in the dry box before dewaxing.

Earlier issues with features being vacuumed up during the print had been noted; the fix at the time was to add a 10 minute delay between layers.

Marcus recommends doing a print without sacrificial filler to see if there are still issues with features detaching.

If he can successfully print 20 layers, Pourya will move to the AEM part. If not, Payman requested a meeting to discuss next steps.

Per Marcus, they may want to switch to the microchannel design, or a simpler design to debug process.

Designed, fabricated, and is using an SVP designed for a larger end mill.

Ran a test on the StoneVac by running it for 2 hours without flow restrictions and noted that it did not seem to be heating as much as before, but more testing may be beneficial.

Pourya compared time taken for a layer compared to “earlier?” layer time: cut 8.5 min (2 cut pass), wax fill 15 mins, facing w/small bit 9 mins, layer formation 12 min. 54 min total.

With current machine setup: with 1 cut pass there is not leftover powder (although also using air dry, other variables changed etc.) (still 8.5 min cut), fill time same, facing reduced to 1 min, layer formation reduced to 5 min w/air drying. 29 min total.

Both layer times based on layer 35 of an AEM part.

Currently trying a full print in 17-4 with this new setup.

Air Drying:

Mohsen and Ning working on a control system for the humidifier. It was previously necessary to manually press a button to start the humidifier, but it is necessary to integrate humidifier operation with the machine. Ning rewired it so it can be run with macros.

Mohsen has been researching airflow uniformity. He tried focusing the dry air on the center of the build only, and found that he was able to print 30 layers before the layer started cracking, where before he saw corners curling up after 10-15 layers. NOTE: this is very likely due to an environment is too dry. I would recommend first controlling the environment in the machine tightly and increase airflow over the cake (recirculating air within the machine) to achieve faster layer curing. Actually, I would recommend improving spray uniformity and optimize layer drying with the use of a heater, along with a NIR moisture measurement sensor.

Experimenting with multiple-nozzle setup to tune nonlinear airflow along the build (i.e. more airflow in the center than the sides). Plans to adjust airflow orientation and turbulence and add speed control to the layer drying fan. Also plans to try using the humidifier during a print to confirm that it is functioning as intended.

All this is being done on Pilot 7 currently in the pod.

Payman suggested having a meeting to discuss Mohsen's priorities re: hopper. He pointed out that it may have been beneficial to have been running hopper experiments to test density uniformity etc. It is worth noting that this is not something he brought up at last week's R&D meeting.

Pilot:

Ning was unable to install new electrical outlet on Pilot 7 because it has been used. He ordered more timer relays for preventing the issues with Tekceleo spray driver unintended operation on machine startup.

Plan is for Pourya to work with Sean printing new microchannel design.

HOPPER/FLIP:

- **Get system with powder refilling fully operation.**
- **Print coupons to characterize density.**
- **Redesign hopper for mass manufacturing.**

Laser:

DOE results analyzed and reported at meeting this week. Tried a new experiment with optimized settings based on DOE results. Hatching worked well but is unable to do a single width cut with the same settings as the hatch. With hatching, the procedure is to raster scan the target geometry in one orientation then raster it again at 90 degrees relative to the first cut.

Parameters used here are within the range of parameters tested during the DOE, but Mason used a low binder volume where the model predicted that a higher binder volume would be better.

Print shown was 8 layers and had dry powder where desired. The dry powder is fresh powder that is applied in the spread, laser cuts throw out power instead of drying it in place.

For the base layer, had to make a thick base layer and raster with 6 passes.

The different experiments here were run with the same parameters suggested as optimal by Minitab but with different cut strategies. Even with the same parameters, the changing cut strategy had a huge difference: single cut lines were not effective (difficult to remove parts from the cake), and sintering seen in single cuts was ~10% where it was much less (although not zero) when hatching the parts.

My recommendation would be:

- Run another formal DOE on different cut strategies; this seems to have a significant effect even with the same base parameters
- Run a formal DOE for depth control
- It may be worth exploring LPBF simulation/control packages, such as Magics or

Mason plans to design another experiment for controlling depth and study the effect of different numbers of passes.

Marcus asked if Payman is still interested in exploring different laser technologies; since Payman is currently using the XTool on the gantry Payman wants to defer that to some unspecified time in the future.

Marcus also raised the concept of running the MOPA laser in a regime to match the functionality of CW lasers; Mason plans to try that next week.

Payman made some thicker parts but no 3D parts, and plans to improve machine robustness before attempting 3D parts.

Mason raised the concept of trying testing the laser with different materials. Proposal is to try cutting a copper and 316L cake or green part on Pilot 3.

Spread and Spray:

Payman designed and printed a new mist box with a vacuum skirt around it. Biggest issue is vibration of system that restricts to 200 micron layers (no thinner). Thinks spray uniformity is good. Hopper unchanged. Goal next week is to make layers with laser.

2026-03-09

PILOT:

I looked up the quote received for the custom cabinets about 5 months ago:

Quote No.	Date	Cust No	S/M	Your Referenced Inquiry	Delivery Promise	F.O.B.	Expiration
0062071	8/26/2025	006969	EDH			ORIGIN	15 DAYS
Item	Quantity	UM	Part	Description	Price \$	Extension \$	
001	2	EA	WM4CS03603012-07	Upon acceptance of your purchase order, the estimated lead time to ship is 5-6 weeks (FOB Origin - Houston, TX), equivalent to approximately 25-30 business days. This lead time includes the time required for approval drawings, which are necessary for new custom designs. We will provide STEP and PDF files of our submittal drawings for your review and approval as part of this process. Please note that an additional 3-5 business days may be needed for order processing and contract review to ensure all documentation is in order before production begins. Production will start after we receive your final approval of our submittal drawings. This ensures the product is built to the agreed specifications. Any delays in the approval process may extend the overall lead time. The quoted lead time does not include transit time or shipping costs (if applicable under our PPA policy). Please email purchase orders to orderentry@nemaenclosures.com. Price and lead time will be confirmed upon order acceptance. For terms and conditions, please refer to our website at www.nemaenclosures.com. 36" X 30" X 12" 14GA CS NEMA TYPE 4 WALL-MOUNT ENCLOSURE 14GA CARBON STEEL CONSTRUCTION / 3-POINT LATCH HANDLE / PRINT POCKET SENT LOOSE / CONTINUOUS PIANO HINGE WELDED ON LEFT SIDE / DOOR SEALED WITH ROGERS PORON GASKET ** ENCLOSURE POWDER COATED RAL 7035 ** 12GA CARBON STEEL BACK PANEL POWDER COATED WHITE ** CUTOUTS PER CUSTOMER DRAWING# DWG 2025-08-18	1,942.28	3,884.56	

The COTS cabinets are here:

https://www.automationdirect.com/adc/shopping/catalog/enclosures_-a-_racks/wall-mount_enclosures/n4123630123ptc

[https://www.automationdirect.com/adc/shopping/catalog/enclosures_-a-_racks/subpanels/np3630c?](https://www.automationdirect.com/adc/shopping/catalog/enclosures_-a-_racks/subpanels/np3630c?_gl=1*jq1593*_up*MQ..*_gs*MQ..&gclid=CjwKCAjw3_PCBhA2EiwAkH_j4jGvsmP1TBca0zeOMtLHTEYQNvFe6_nCdJ5173Y5xfIKzoZftY0LmRoCfz4QAvD_BwE&gbraid=0AAAAAD_dnO2ec2gmFgV8z7dmGZLtPoDiM)

[_gl=1*jq1593*_up*MQ..*_gs*MQ..&gclid=CjwKCAjw3_PCBhA2EiwAkH_j4jGvsmP1TBca0zeOMtLHTEYQNvFe6_nCdJ5173Y5xfIKzoZftY0LmRoCfz4QAvD_BwE&gbraid=0AAAAAD_dnO2ec2gmFgV8z7dmGZLtPoDiM](https://www.automationdirect.com/adc/shopping/catalog/enclosures_-a-_racks/subpanels/np3630c?_gl=1*jq1593*_up*MQ..*_gs*MQ..&gclid=CjwKCAjw3_PCBhA2EiwAkH_j4jGvsmP1TBca0zeOMtLHTEYQNvFe6_nCdJ5173Y5xfIKzoZftY0LmRoCfz4QAvD_BwE&gbraid=0AAAAAD_dnO2ec2gmFgV8z7dmGZLtPoDiM)

(The custom quote includes subpanels)

This means that for the COTS parts with no cutouts, total cost per cabinet is \$993, while the cost per custom cabinet is \$1,942.28. This is almost exactly \$1000 more per cabinet, or roughly double the cost. Assuming that Ning can modify the COTS cabinet with cutouts of exactly the right size in exactly the right location, the quality of the cabinets will be similar; the custom one would be powder coated RAL 7035, which would cover the cut area so there would be no exposed steel where Ning's cutouts were made, but the only real advantage here is that the printer would look more professional. There is also a disadvantage that the lead time for the custom cabinet is 5-6 weeks, and since we (presumably) need to build the printers ASAP, this may not be acceptable. The average cost to the company for one person's labor is ~\$1000/day, so assuming that Ning takes exactly one day to customize the cabinets, the company will have saved \$1000, and also lost 1 day of Ning's time that could have been spent on EE work. If he takes 2 days, the company breaks even, although with a lower quality cabinet (exposed steel, rough cut edges, ANSI 61 gray instead of RAL 7035 powder coating) and every day Ning spends working on it beyond 2 days loses the company \$1000. On the other hand, Ning is confident that he can completely customize both cabinets in 1 day, which would save the company \$1000 vs. the custom cabinet and would reduce the cabinet lead time.

One thing I don't like is that having a cabinet customized in-house by an engineer is not particularly scalable. When building Epsoms 1 and 2, I made the cabinet cutouts by hand but the narrative was that we would document the cabinet customization and order custom ones for Pilots 6 and 7. When we were given the green light to build 6 and 7, I created drawings for custom cabinets and worked with a custom cabinet manufacturer, but we needed the printers built ASAP so we instead cut corners and Al customized the cabinets in-house. The narrative then was that for the next 2 printers we would definitely order the next cabinets to be custom made, and I pushed for that, but it looks like we're probably not going to.

HOPPER/FLIP:

I have the powder dispenser doser stepper motor and vibrator motor completely wired up and operation from the G code. Next step is to connect the IR prox switches to the expansion board. Because of how the IR prox switches are designed, I have it set up to energize a 24V relay when the prox switch is activated, and I will use the NO contacts on the relay to trigger one of the Duet expansion board inputs. I am also casting urethane around the other end of the duct hose; I cast one end last Friday so it should be ready for installation once this pour of urethane is cured. I printed an extended hose duct mount for the powder cartridge dock over the weekend as well as a new hose duct mount for the hopper with updated clearances so it is

easier to assemble and install and also moves more smoothly, and I post-processed and installed both those parts today. I noted that running the cartridge dock vibrator with the cartridge empty has a tendency to vibrate the whole top window on the printer; this is not unexpected behavior but is worth consideration. It is possible that it will be less of an issue when there is powder in the bottle, and I also may be able to turn down the vibrator motor further (the test today was run with it set to a power level of 50/255). If it continues to be an issue, I will make a new vibration isolator that isolates vibration from the window better. It is also possible to couple the base of the vibration isolator to the printer frame, which would help to prevent vibration of the window, but would require additional work to make the appropriate modifications to the upper window and install drop-in nuts etc.

I have the sensor wired up and it is detected by conditional G code, so I can make a macro that will do stuff while the sensor is not triggered then exit the code once it has been triggered.

I just started a print of 2X rotation indicators that will be glued to the end of the stepper motor shaft to show its rotation.

I started testing loading powder into the hopper, and as expected there are some issues with powder flowing. The speed of dispense is still quite low even with the Duet board's increased stepper driver speed as compared with the Arduino, so that may require some optimization. I am printing a new rotating duct mount for the cartridge dock with a slight angle to it, which, along with shortening the duct hose, should help with powder flowing into the hopper.

One thing that also may be worth considering is redesigning the vibrating hat so that the opening is closer to the cartridge dock. This would have the additional benefit of letting me move the IR prox switch closer to the center of the hopper.

2026-03-10

PILOT:

The estimated cost per Pilot build without most of the custom machined parts sounded high to me (Senai said \$50K but summing the BOM came out to \$54K), so I went through and noticed some high-cost items that I think can be removed. The big one is \$12K worth of stages that we recycle from the Betas and so won't need to be included in the Pilot price.

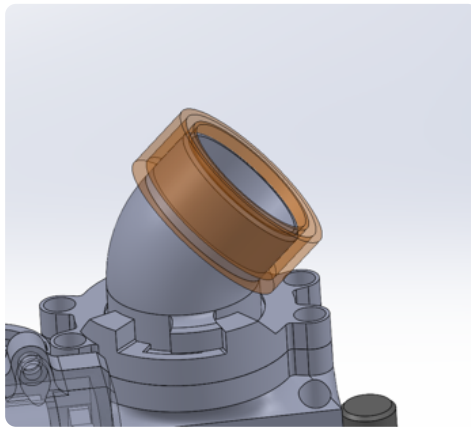
HOPPER/FLIP:

I am designing a new vibrating hat with the feed duct closer to the powder cartridge to get a sharper angle from the cartridge to the hopper to resolve some of the issues I was seeing yesterday with powder flowing into the hopper. This also lets me make a more elegant CAD model because it doesn't have various features that were added and removed over time. I can

also move the prox switch to the center of the hopper. The downside is that since the powder inlet is offset from the center, there is a risk of powder not being level within the hopper. Hopefully the vibration applied by the sheet will help to level it out, but it is something that will need to be confirmed not to be an issue in testing (I suspect it will show up in different density in the X direction if it does turn out to be an issue at all).

I have redesigned the vibrating hat and it is currently printing on Anvil, the Bambu X1E.

I have a concept for an improved way to seal the ends of the hose duct without needing to cast urethane onto the hose permanently (which takes time and makes it difficult to adjust the length of the hose):



This is a cast urethane cap that slides onto the hose duct and seals it to the 3D printed part when it is clamped down. I made the inner wall 1mm thick, but this may still be too much to be able to slide on to the current 3D printed parts. I am currently printing a mold to make a silicone mold to cast these parts (yep, urethane casting is a two-step process, but the parts are much more durable than silicone).

I did pours of Mold Star 30 for 2X end cap molds, and will test those out tomorrow. The new vibrating hat is done printing, so I will install the heat set inserts and swap out the hats on the hopper tomorrow. I also ran some tests filling the hopper and emptying it, and there are indeed some issues with the powder getting to the hopper with the current shallow angle setup so I think it is definitely beneficial to switch to the steeper setup. I also put together a new cartridge cap with the newer spiral doser balls. The seal still isn't perfect so I think I need to print a new cap with a smaller doser ball cavity, but the dispense is much smoother and closer to continuous with the spiral doser ball.

2026-03-11

HOPPER/FLIP:

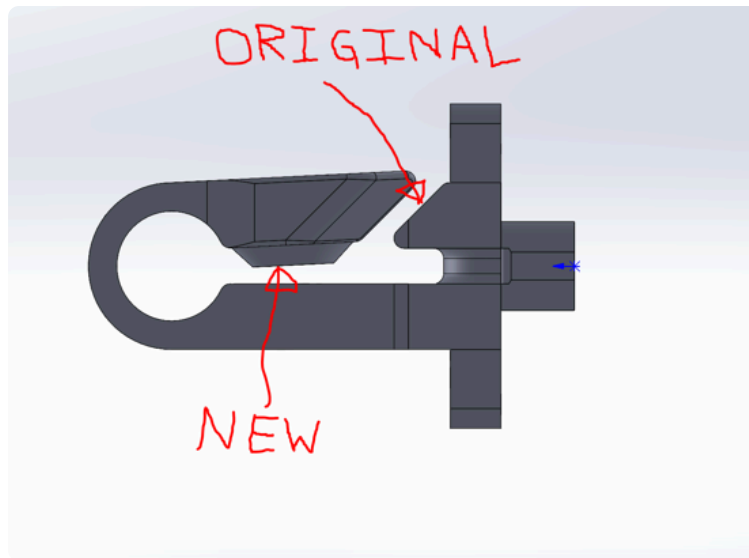
I populated the new vibrating hat with heat set inserts and installed it on the hopper on Pilot 2. I noticed that it is beneficial for the vibrating hat duct hose connection to be at an angle permanently rather than swiveling, because it forces the hose away from the cable carrier when the gantry goes back to the Y 0 position (as I learned at AMP, hose rubbing is the enemy! Granted, we're abusing the hose way less here, but it's still good general practice). I tried loading the hopper with the new hose setup, and it feeds better, although it still can build up powder in the hose when the hopper gets full (my working theory is that as the weight of the hopper increases, the vibrating hat vibrates less, and since part of the powder flow through the duct hose comes from the duct hose being vibrated by the vibrating hat, that has a tendency to reduce liquefaction of the powder in the duct hose).

I taught Mohsen and Ben about using the new hopper feeder and showed them the macro I had written to run it, and handed off Pilot 2 to them to run a test with the new setup. Before the test, Mohsen pointed out that he has had difficulty in the past with starting prints with the linear gate hopper design because it has a tendency to push off the cake, even when it is glued down to the build plate. This makes sense; one inherent issue with this design of hopper is that since the powder column is always contacting the cake, there will be a large shear force applied to the cake when the hopper is moving. Payman's theory is that this is also an advantage, because the weight of the powder is helping to compress the layer of dry powder being applied, thereby increasing the density of the layer, and the design of the hopper also naturally regulates the flow of powder onto the layer, minimizing powder wastage. I would argue that the effect of the weight of powder on the layer is unknown and may or may not exist, and powder overflow doesn't matter if we set up a powder recycling/reconditioning line, which would have the knock-on benefit of letting us condition all of our powder before use to make sure that it has very reliable properties, and also the powder wastage due to overflow is minimal compared with the powder wasted in binding the whole cake (that may or may not be true; the amount of powder wasted in binding the cake does dwarf the amount of powder that winds up in the parts, but depending on the amount of extra powder spread the overflow may be comparable to or even greater than the amount of powder spread onto the layer proper).

GENERAL R&D:

Marcus requested new versions of the patent drawings (both InkScape and CAD screenshot-style versions) with an SVP added.

Helped Mohsen set up a print of two designs of nozzle arrays for his layer drying experiments. Got the nebulizer cable bracket design from Alex, and I have updated the design to a version 7 that has a secondary hard stop to help prevent damage from overtightening.



I started a print of a pair of parts (they are needed in an original orientation and a mirrored orientation so I imported the original part, cloned it, and mirrored the clone within the Bambu slicer.

Let's think of some possible approaches for 3DEO as a company moving forward:

1. Operating as a service provider (engineering support, part/assembly manufacturing, QC)
 - a. Buy exemplars of all commonly available 3D printing and machining technology
 - b. Quantifiably benchmark all of these processes and machines, and select the appropriate one for each contract
2. Operating as a service provider exclusively using proprietary printing technology operating with the manufacturing capabilities as before, with new materials added
 - a. Improve environmental controls for machines
 - b. Add an active spreader bar to the tank-to-tank setup
 - c. Optimize binder formulation
 - d. Optimize closed-loop layer heating/cooling process to cure each layer (IR moisture measurement?)
 - e. Optimize cutting process (improved spindle, optimized end mill, increased speed through gantry weight reduction and advanced control system)
 - f. Tighter powder characterization, QC, and conditioning
 - g. Powder recycling and reconditioning to eliminate powder waste
3. Operating as a service provider exclusively using proprietary printing technology operating with enhanced manufacturing capabilities and new materials added
 - a.

PILOT:

Meeting about fault handling for the Pilots in general and an issue being seen on pilot 7 where the Duet board disconnects from the Raspberry Pi.

There is a fault that has been seen on the Pilots where the spindle, heater, or vacuum have been left on overnight. Ning has installed a timer relay to prevent the vacuum from running too long (time setting?). There is currently no safety system on the spindle.

Marcus wants a more robust error/fault handling system that will deenergize all active systems (especially heat-producing systems) in a detected fault condition. ZZ does not have an immediate answer for architecting that system. Ning pointed out that if the safety controller trips, it will erase the error logs. ZZ pointed out that this is not the case, since the safety controller only cuts power to the Duet, so the error log in the Duet Web Interface will retain the error log.

I would recommend setting up the safety system to detect whether components have been left on for an extended period of time, as well as a separate python code running on the Raspberry pi separate from the DSF program to monitor nominal operation and reset the system if necessary.

Marcus pointed out that it would be good general practice to have a regular handshake protocol between components to shut down the system if an off-nominal condition is detected.

ZZ stated that what we are seeing is a brief failure of the SPI connection between the Duet board and the Raspberry Pi.

It is worth investigating when the heater was left on overnight. The temperature sensor was replaced about a month ago. Testing of the current system has not been done. Senai recommends adding a time delay system to the heater so that if the heater is left on too long then it will turn off, although Marcus pointed out that this is only a stopgap system. I would recommend that this system be connected to the control system in some way so that if the heater is shut off the Raspberry Pi will be aware of it to pause the print.

Is this kind of delay function programmable in the safety relay? Is it possible to set up the Duet so that it shuts off relay power if it is disconnected from the Raspberry Pi?

Philipp and Senai requested the drawings generated for the machined parts for Pilots 8 and 9. Since some of the drawings seem to have gotten messed up, I am going through and fixing them and generating PDFs I am putting on the Z drive for now.

HOPPER/FLIP:

Mohsen noted a failure mode where the IR sensor is not detecting the powder, causing the loading system to run indefinitely until the hopper and hose are completely full of powder. On the upside, the hose seems robust to that much weight, but the sensor needs to be more robust. I have not yet tried capacitive prox switches, so I will try that next to see if it works better.

Mohsen is currently working on forming a good base layer with the hopper, which can be done without the powder reloading system.

Mohsen noted an issue with the gate not fully opening when the hopper was filled with powder all the way to the top, and he found that it worked fine when the hopper was emptied. He also pointed out that he had disabled the limit switch that detects whether the gate is closed, and is only using the limit switch that detects when the gate is fully open. I am unsure exactly why he did this; the macros should be able to operate fine with both limit switches connected, but there are issues that can arise because it was necessary to wire both limit switches in series due to the Duet's boards limitation that it can only use one input as a homing switch for an axis. On the other hand, now that I know how to use conditional statements in Duet G code, I could write a few lines that would rotate the stepper motor until it hits the limit switch, and have the limit switch attached to any of the input ports on the Duet expansion board.

I have entered an order request for a material-agnostic (capacitive) proximity switch, since the inductive proximity switch I tested in the past was not able to detect metal powder.

I designed a new prox switch holder for the capacitive prox switch for which I entered the order request. Since the current design is too small to fit the nuts that the prox switch comes with, I designed M18X1 threads into the printed part. It would be better to print the hole undersize and tap it, but taps of the right size are ~\$80 from McMaster so I am going to try printing the threads first. My plan is to screw the prox switch into the holder then use a nut on the top to lock it in place.

Goals for This Week:

- **Get system with powder refilling fully operation.**

- System is functional, but has issues
- IR prox switch was not sufficiently robust in detecting powder height
- If the powder height gets too close to the prox switch, it will stop detecting it and continue to fill the hopper indefinitely
- Capacitive prox switch received Friday morning (2026-03-13). This should be sensitive to any object while inductive prox switches are only sensitive to conductive objects (17-4PH powder is not conductive enough to trigger them, even when the sensor is fully submerged in powder)

- Installed the capacitive prox switch in the hopper and did a fill test, and it seemed to work OK
- **Print coupons to characterize density.**
 - There are some base layer formation issues that need to be resolved
 - The hopper feeding system also needs refinement
- **Redesign hopper for mass manufacturing.**
 - In progress
 - Confirm that adding a tilt to the hopper is OK

HOPPER V5.1 (HOPPER V5 designed for improved manufacturability)

- Dowel pins eliminated in favor of alignment during assembly and machined features where necessary for alignment
- Front, back, and side panels will all be unique instead of a standardized front/back panel and a standard left/right panel (this sounds counterintuitive, but there are a number of design sacrifices I had to make to make the panels mirrored, such as using countersunk screws with countersinks on both sides of the panel for the left and right panels)
- Adjust height of adjusting stages to eliminate spacers
- Add custom machined knobs to make the Edmund stages more easily adjustable with the vibrating hat in place
- Modify cam slot position to be asymmetrical so that there is no risk of the motor rotating continuously
- Improved spreader bar (coated aluminum)
- Integrate components where possible (especially gate closed limit switch position adjusting screw mount)
- Improve the gate open/close detection system
 - Needs separate switches for open and closed detection
 - Improved switch packaging (more compact)
 - More robust setup (sealed switches, cover)

2026-03-13

GENERAL R&D:

Marcus stated at the morning standup that concerns about the morning standup had been expressed to him, so he went over some of the reasons we have it: primarily to keep him informed of everyone's tasks for that day, to keep everyone on the team generally informed about what others are working on, for slight plan changes if necessary, and to ensure that

everyone shows up to work at a reasonably early time. He also stated that if anyone has concerns about meetings we do they should come to him. I personally tend to show up to work a little before standup so I don't really start tasks until after it, but those who show up an hour or two beforehand do have their tasks interrupted by the standup, which I can imagine may be frustrating. I am unsure who specifically raised concerns and what those concerns are, so I can only guess the specifics.

HOPPER/FLIP:

Received the capacitive sensor from McMaster that should be able to detect conductive or non-conductive surfaces so it should be compatible with metal powder while inductive prox switches are not. The critical issue with IR prox switches is that once the powder gets too close, they stop detecting it, so if the hopper overfills then it will keep overfilling. Since the powder loads from the side of the hopper and the sensor is in the middle, I suspect that the sensor tends to trip during the initial powder loading cycle with the powder pile at an angle, and with further vibration applied during the spread, the powder pile will level out and the powder in the center will rise even without the addition of more powder. If the level rises above the IR prox switch's detection threshold, it will stop detecting the powder level, and will keep loading powder indefinitely.

I installed the new prox switch in the printed bayonet connector that had M18X1 threads printed into it, and the fit was perfect: tight enough that it should hold in place even without a locking nut, which is good because I lost the nuts that it came with. It is important to note that I printed the bayonet connector with integrated threads from PETG-CF with a layer height of 0.08mm; with other materials and thicker layers the threads may not form as well. I attached an appropriate Molex Micro-Fit 3.0 connector to the sensor to interface it with the cable present in the machine, inserted the bayonet connector into the new vibrating hat, and will now install heat set inserts (I also ordered M4 heat set inserts along with the capacitive sensor from McMaster. I will transfer the stainless steel sheet to the new vibrating hat, transfer the vibrator motor over, and switch the hose duct. This vibrating hat has some improvements over the previous model; since I designed it without using SolidWorks' loft feature I was able to add fillets that should reduce the stress concentration of corners, and I lowered the hose duct interface as much as possible to make the angle of the hose as steep as possible to increase powder flowability.

I found the plastic nuts that came with the capacitive prox switch and installed one to lock the switch height. I also found that the sensor was sensitive enough to be triggered by the walls of the hopper once it was installed, so I turned down the sensitivity with the adjustment screw. Even with the increased hose duct angle with the new vibrating hat, the powder flow in the hose

was insufficient, so I increased the vibrating hat voltage from 9V to 11V to help liquify the powder, and that seemed to work.

I noticed that the current design of the vibrating hat actually has the vibrating sheet in contact with the wall of the hopper, so I redesigned it to be 2mm away from the wall (a larger gap would necessitate moving around some other components, which I would like to avoid if possible).

Discussing the current design of the hopper, Mohsen requested there be height adjustability added to enable the target powder height to be set to different levels, and a way to trigger the sensor continuously so that the hopper can be emptied towards the end of the print. For the latter, I recommended adding a feature on the vibrating hat that you can insert the sensor into to trigger it continuously. This does carry with it the risk that powder will get kicked up through the now-empty sensor hole, so I should also print a plug connected to a lanyard to close it up when the sensor is slotted into the holder. As for adjusting powder height, I do not have a design yet. Adjusting the sensor sensitivity could achieve this goal to some extent, but it would likely not give a range more than a few millimeters, since if it set too high it will be triggered by the walls, and the range at the highest functional sensitivity is only ~5mm (I think, I have not yet measured it with powder, only various metal, plastic, and flesh/bone objects available in the print chamber).

R&D Weekly Meeting:

No-Depowdering:

6 prints on P6 w/17-4PH -

- AEM part, air dry, corner curling.
- Repeated, screw fell from dispenser and fell into V tank, repaired damage.
- Switched to microchannel air dry, 1st print failed, nozzle cooled too much.
- Repeated, added 60s delay to ensure dispenser reached temperature, same issue seen.
- Started new print w/silicone rubber sheet insulating syringe heater and nozzle, solved problem, may be able to remove 60s delay, saw chipping and layer curling but was able to complete print.
- Repeated test with fan drying which resolved curling, but a single cut was not clean possibly due to insufficient drying, so Pourya switched to 2 cuts.
- Started another print today increasing the humidity setting by 5% points and temperature by 2C on THC. Print is in progress, but chipping has already been seen

Mason noted that different end mills (# of flutes, diameter) require different feeds and speeds to achieve comparable results (trying to reduce chipping seen).

Next week plans to repeat tests with different feeds and speeds to reduce chipping. Section printed sample to inspect channels.

For copper, printed features detached during the dewaxing process. Cake was dewaxed in Keith furnace with a peak temperature of 200C. Ran another print without sacrificial filler, using a 1 flute end mill and a 4 flute end mill cutting at the same time. With the part made with the single flute end mill, features detached. Repeated this test 3 times to confirm that the root cause is the number of flutes on the end mill. The severity of missing features varied from test to test but features were always missing with the 1 flute end mill. Pourya pointed out that having switched to a 1/8" collet may have changed the runout of the end mill.

Plan next week is adjust feed rate to reduce chipping issues without adding sacrificial filler.

Marcus, Payman, Alex, and Pourya plan to meet on Monday to plan experiments for the week.

Air drying:

Ning and Mohsen worked on increasing the humidity in the printer to reduce curling by adding a humidifier. Humidity was kept within nominal range during print. This suggests to Mohsen that the issue is airflow and not humidity. Hardware for a new airflow system will arrive on Monday. Printed new dry airflow nozzles. Goal was to reduce air flow.

I asked Mohsen whether he has ever seen a successful print with air drying, and he said he has not; air drying has always caused layers to curl up after layer 10.

Payman and Marcus say to pause work on air drying in favor of hopper.

Payman, Marcus, and Alex had a meeting before this R&D meeting, and one of their conclusions was to deprioritize reducing layer speed in favor of optimizing for part quality.

Mohsen questioned how the green part strength varies between 17-4PH and copper parts, suggesting that issues we are seeing may be due to decreased green strength. Mason pointed out that they use much more binder for each layer on copper than is used on 17-4PH.

Laser:

Mason did some tests to study the effect of changing the number of passes. No matter what parameters were used, it did not seem that going from 2 to 3 passes yielded the same beneficial returns as going from 1 to 2, and more melting was seen after 3 passes, so he concludes that it is better to focus on 2 passes. Experimental design focused on depth control is still in progress. Main motivation for depth control is for 3D parts. He pointed out that depth consistency is more valuable at this point than absolute depth value. Tried to get the MOPA laser to perform more like a diode CW laser by changing pulse width and frequency settings. Cut a gear using the previous optimized settings and a box outline and hatched box with the Claude-recommended

settings. The new settings were found to yield inferior results (powder melting/sintering in areas where energy was applied) to previous optimized settings, and questions whether it is worth pursuing these alternative settings. The diode-like settings performed fine on the first layer, but melted/sintered the powder on every later layer. Payman stated that he did not see powder sintering/melting using the XTool on the Ultimaker, even when testing with up to 20 layers. Marcus raised points about the motivation behind the test. Mason has scrap copper green parts to test given to him by Pourya, but has not had the chance to test them yet. Needs to get scrap 316L parts from Dong if possible.

Meeting on Monday to do more planning on laser experiments. Marcus asked whether there is any testing he is interested in doing. Mason asked Payman about whether he had made any 3D parts on the Ultimaker, and he said that he had stopped working on it. Mason has been working with Claude to make code to support making 3D parts by interfacing between the Raspberry Pi, his laptop running LightBurn, and the Duet. He asked whether he can continue working on this, and Payman provisionally said no (“not yet” haha), but it will be discussed further at Monday’s meeting. Mason also ran some experiments with adjusting curing time after the cut, which did not yield significant results. Noticed in previous prints, as layers built up the sintering/melting behavior would get worse, but curing the layers randomized the sintering/melting results. Procured an IR thermometer to install on the LVP to measure the layer (will be discussed further on Monday at meeting whether he can proceed with this). Mason did experiments with changing focus to adjust cut width (roughly corresponding to spot size). Noted that cut order is significant; there is more debris seen on the later cuts than the first cuts. Total cut time when this phenomenon was seen is ~40s.

Next week:

Meeting on Monday to discuss project planning. Mason proposes working on installing an IR temperature sensor in the time before they have their planning meeting. Right now the IR camera has been moved off-center to make room for the laser, which means it has difficulty getting a good temperature value of the layer. Payman is pushing back on Mason working on it because he wants to be able to record thermal images of the layer. Mason will work on doing a proof of concept test with cutting copper on Monday morning.

Payman is concerned that multiple projects are being rolled up in each project (i.e. no depowdering and spindle selection), and wants to have a clearer plan about deliverables for the project, each week, each month, etc.

HOPPER:

Mohsen pointed out that Pilot 2 does not currently have a heater and so cannot be directly compared with the tank-to-tank system. He is writing a new macro to form a good base layer.

Base layer/inherent hopper issues:

- Risk of binder sprayed to plate soaking up into powder in the hopper

To Do:

- Compare properties of powder dispensed when the cartridge dock bottle is full vs. right before it is emptied
- Meeting on Monday to discuss plan
- Get heater back in Pilot 2 - IN PROGRESS
 - Looked at Pilot 2 with Mohsen, and since the heater design it had was the super narrow design, if the mist box is moved to -Y one notch and the hopper if moved one notch +Y, there should be enough space between them to fit a heater. Mohsen is currently working on moving the components and installing the heater.
- Look into issue with gate not opening - DONE
 - Due to the nature of limit switch wiring and the Duet board's limitation to a single endstop per axis
 - With my recently acquired knowledge about writing conditional loops in Duet macros, it should be possible to write a gate open/close macro that does not use defined endstops. Instead, it will use generic Duet Expansion Board I/Os for the open and close switches.
 - As a temporary patch, I increased the distance the stepper motor moves to open the gate in open-loop mode before it starts paying attention to the limit switch. This fixed the problem at the moment, but it is not sufficiently robust and also means that if the gate open macro is called when the gate is already at the open position, it will drive into the gate open hard stops until it starts detecting the limit switch. This will cause increased stress on the cam roller and the stepper motor, possibly leading to mechanical failure over time, and is therefore unacceptable on a production system.

2026-03-16

GENERAL R&D:

Several project replanning meetings. My question to Claude based on my limited understanding of the goals was:

What do you call it when an engineering project that has been going on for a year is replanned to change the deliverables and the way progress is measured (i.e. adding goals for each week,

month, etc.)?

What you're describing is commonly called a **rebaseline** (or **re-baseline**).

More specifically, it involves a few overlapping concepts depending on context:

Rebaseline is the primary term — it means formally resetting the project's performance measurement baseline (PMB) to reflect new scope, schedule, or cost targets. It's widely used in defense and aerospace program management (EVM/EVMS contexts especially).

Replanning is the broader activity that leads to a rebaseline — restructuring the work, schedule, and metrics going forward. The two terms are often used together: "replanning and rebaselining."

Restructuring is sometimes used when the changes are significant enough to alter the fundamental organization of the work breakdown structure (WBS) or reporting hierarchy.

In more formal project management frameworks (like **Earned Value Management**, which is common in aerospace/defense), the specific actions involved would include:

- Redefining the **Work Breakdown Structure (WBS)**
- Resetting **Control Account Plans (CAPs)**
- Establishing new **Planned Value (PV)** curves
- Adding time-phased **budgets** tied to weekly/monthly milestones

The addition of structured weekly/monthly goals specifically is often called **time-phasing the budget** or adding **rolling wave planning** detail to near-term work packages.

So the short answer: **rebaseline** is the term most engineers and program managers would reach for in that situation.

No-Depowdering (Copper):

- Meeting was with Pourya, Alex, Payman, and Alex, and Marcus showed up for the last 15 minutes of it
- Involved planning Alex and Cisco's availability for running experiments
- Also decided on near-term focus of the project: primarily reducing chipping when machining the layer

No-Depowdering (general):

- Meeting was about 1 1/2 hours with Alex, Pourya, Payman, and Marcus
- It seems that the focus of the meeting was to reduce the number of systems or processes that are being developed simultaneously; in this case, Pourya is trying to pursue the no-depowdering and air drying systems together, which adds complexity and risk to the project

- He is going to return to running experiments that are similar to ones he was conducting on Pilot 1, using layer fan drying instead of air drying
- My recommendation would be to figure out a way to integrate the no-depowdering system into our process without changing anything else. We are currently using a sacrificial filler material with a low melting point that forces us to use a non-standard drying technique (we are unable to use the heater because it will melt the filler material). If we changed to a higher melting point filler material (which may require upgrading the Mest hardware or switching to a far superior technology, such as binder jetting heads), then we would be able to use the standard known-good process, just with sacrificial filler material added.

Laser:

- Payman wants to spend 1-2 weeks researching laser technologies then reconvene and set goal
- In the meantime, compare MOPA with XTool
- Mason will propose a formal DOE
- Once it is ready, Mason will do some informal tests on Payman's gantry
- Then he will finalize the test protocol, align with Payman, and execute
- Payman does not want to conduct formal tests, he wants to conduct rapid informal tests

Hopper/Flip:

- Going over historical hopper goals
- Developing functional specs for project completion purposes
 - I asked what would happen if we did not meet those specs, and Payman said "we would discuss"
- Mostly match or exceed tank to tank quality
- High reliability, error detection
 - Specifically applied to gate motion, but it may be applied to other subsystems (powder dispenser)
- Gate needs to be parallel to the build plate
- Payman is interested in measuring vibration to see if it varies over the print and also tracking stepper motor current over time to see if it is struggling more to open/close the gate, even if it is successfully opening and closing
- **Set up design review for updated hopper design by end of month**
- **Make week-by-week timeline for completing objectives**

HOPPER/FLIP:

- Continuing to work on design refinement of the hopper system (V5.1)
- I am building it out from the back panel, so I am starting off with making a back panel that has as many features integrated into it as possible. It will add to the cost of the back panel part, but will also eliminate several other machined components, improve packaging, and make assembly easier.

Mohsen had some concerns/suggestions for the hopper based on his testing:

- Powder remains stuck in the hose -
- Powder refill is slow during the print - IN PROGRESS
 - Making a new doser ball mold with redesigned cross section of the powder grooves (decreased depth slightly, added an 8 degree draft angle), and increased the number of powder grooves from 8 to 12
 - In theory this will improve the powder that is dropped per each slot and increase total powder flow due to the increase of number of grooves
- It is difficult to remove the hopper vibrating hat to inspect powder level -
 - Mohsen is currently only using 2 screws to mount the hopper to the vibration isolator
 - I have concerns about the stress applied to 2 mounting points by the side load of the duct hose pulling on the vibrating hat
 - I am also concerned about powder leakage when the vibrating hat is only held down by 2 screws, but Mohsen claims this is not an issue
 - It may be beneficial to switch out the screws for 1/4-turn fasteners, if possible
 - I also may be able to install a small camera or window to see the height of the powder without removing the vibrating hat
- Hopper refill deposits more powder beneath the hose connection - IGNORE
 - This is probably intrinsic to having the hose duct connection off center
 - I could move it back to the center and move the sensor to the side, but that would make the hose duct angle shallower
 - The hope is that the vibration of the vibrating hat will level out the powder pile
- Requests that the vibrating sheet metal be moved to the hopper center - IGNORE
 - With the current hopper width and current sensor this would be difficult
 - It might be possible to punch a hole through the rear side of the hopper (-Y) and install the sensor through there to give clearance to move the sheet
 - Making a wider hopper (in Y direction) would add space to fit the sensor next to the sheet

- I had messed up the vibrating hat Mohsen was using when he made this suggestion and had the vibrating sheet flush with the side of the hopper; the improved version that he is using now has the vibrating sheet shifted 2mm away from the side
- I had to decrease the sensitivity of the sensor so that it was not continually triggered when the vibrating hat is mounted to the hopper; I suspect this is due to the sensor being 2mm closer to the vibrating sheet
- Hopper gate is prevented from / struggles with fully opening by the mist box - IGNORE
 - Due to space limitations when the heater is installed on the PILOT 1-3 Y axis gantry plate

Mohsen and Ben encountered an issue with the hopper. The symptom was that there was a deep indentation in the build tank powder (roughly 4mm hemispherical) and the Y axis gantry was unable to home. It was jamming when the hopper gate opening was right above the -Y edge of the build tank. Ben heard the stepper motors stalling, and hit the e-stop. The high-level root cause of the issue was an M4X10mm blue-dyed zinc SHCS that had become jammed in the gate, partially protruding from the gate opening. This dented the gate and may have damaged the edge of the build tank, but does not seem to have harmed the spreader bar. I worked with Mohsen to hammer out the dent at the edge of the gate and polished it with a Hard Black Arkansas Oil Sharpening Stone. The damage is visible but should not impair the functionality of the hopper. The low-level root cause of the issue was FOD control; since Mohsen reduced the number of screws used to mount the hopper vibrating hat, he had screws left over, and without careful accounting of all the screws removed it was easy to drop one in the hopper and not notice it. There are a few ways to prevent this in the future: a FOD screen in the hopper would prevent screws from reaching the gate but could possibly cause issues with powder flow, a standard procedure of emptying out and inspecting the inside of the hopper any time the vibrating hat is removed or replaced, a procedure of carefully accounting for all the screws present in the machine, or captive fasteners used for any components that may need to be detached in the machine would each prevent this issue.

Info to send to Pourya:

Haas 1/8" collet for Saffron spindles

1/8" shank spindles

End mills 1/8" shank 1 flute .020" cut

Red Tag Meeting

Laser Meeting:

Note: The first mention I have in my notes of the laser project is that I designed and ordered sheet metal panels for Pilot 3 on 2025-04-21 . This was for the XTool F1 Ultra, and some laser experiments had been done by Payman with the smaller XTool F1. Presumably the laser experiments had started at least a month or two earlier, which as I recall was done with cardboard panels taped to the outside of the machine, and Payman's benchtop experiments preceded this by a month or two. Based on this, I believe the laser project was started roughly 14 months ago.

Midhun, me, and Mason. Mason wants to set up an IR thermometer sensor in Pilot 2 because it provides a more accurate single-point measurement. System was mostly set up, but was told to stop by Payman and Marcus on Friday. Also was setting up software to make 3D shapes, but was also told to stop working on it pending discussion at the rebaselining/project planning meeting this afternoon. Payman and Marcus want to discuss planning or something. Mason wants to set up another formal DOE focused on understanding and controlling cut depth. To get the cut depth of a cut on top of a bound layer, he wants to start the print by building up a thick base first then doing cuts. Midhun recommends reducing the power setting to reduce the heat input that may be affecting cut behavior over multiple layers. (Should we cool the whole print to ambient before cutting?). Midhun noted that he did not have success running prints in Saffron printers at temperatures above 85F (binder does not penetrate at high cake temperatures). Larger squares may reduce heat transfer between cuts. Cutting in different places for each layer would help to show whether cut depth varies or not over successive layers when not cutting on top of previous cuts. Midhun also recommends testing the blue diode laser against the MOPA laser because of Payman's positive results on the gantry. Payman is reluctant to transfer the XTool diode laser off of his gantry, so I would recommend buying another XTool to install on Pilot 3.

There are two XTool lasers I found that may be worth trying. One is a combination MOPA/diode laser (\$4699):

 [xTool F2 Ultra 60W MOPA & 40W Diode Dual Laser Engraver](#)

While the other is a UV laser that claims to be able to cut much smaller features without charring (\$4299):

 [xTool F2 Ultra UV - 5W UV Laser Engraver](#)

There is also the same laser that Payman is currently using on the gantry (\$3199):

There are some possible temperature read errors with the current IR camera that concerns Midhun because the experimental results and predictions are dependent on accurate measurement. I would recommend the following:

- Determine what parameters need to be measured (ambient temp and humidity, layer temp (either an image or single-point), etc.)
- Select properly calibrated sensors
- Install the sensors in a way that supports accurate measurements
- Test the sensors in-situ
- Ensure that the sensor values are properly recorded during the print

Midhun recommends inerting the machine to improve the quality of laser interaction based on results he has seen in papers. He pointed out that there are significant safety hazards of nitrogen use that we should pay attention to, including wearing nitrogen sensors and ensuring that no one sticks their head in the machine when it is inerted.

Midhun asked about the current status of the no-depowdering project, and Mason pointed out concerns about visual part quality and the fact there have been no tests done on quality of parts after sintering, such as porosity and conductivity and sinter density. There has also been minimal formal experimentation, data collection, and documentation.

Cisco has raised concerns about changes to the copper pod, including adding humidifiers for some unclear reason.

Mason recommends we use a binder jetting head to apply the sacrificial filler.

Midhun has been told that he will be supporting the no-depowdering process with copper. He said that he is not going to do anything he doesn't understand, which I like.

2026-03-17

HOPPER/FLIP:

Issues with the hopper binding and the hopper open/close stepper motor shaft bending were seen yesterday.

I put together a mold for the new higher-flow doser ball, but I did not have enough Mold Star 30 silicone to completely fill the mold, so I need to order some more and complete the pour after it arrives.

I took apart the hopper gate system and replaced the bronze/graphite bushings with linear bearings. The gate actually seems more wobbly now (the bearings don't keep its motion exactly linear, they allow some rotation of the gate) but this is not necessarily critical to the function.

I also hammered the stepper motor shaft back to being roughly straight yesterday, and I am going to redesign the machined cam component so that it extends to the base of the shaft so it is less likely to bend.

If these linear bearings do not work robustly, I am considering switching to low-profile linear carriages.

I entered an order request for another trial size package of Mold Star 30 from Reynolds Advanced Materials. This should give me more than enough to finish off this current mold, and make several more molds of a comparable size or maybe 1 or 2 larger molds (which I will need to make to mass-produce vibration isolators if we roll out to hoppers to all the machines).

I completed designing mounts to retrofit HOPPER V5 for using linear carriages instead of linear rods. For production use, they will need to be machined from aluminum but for initial testing I plan to print them. I started a printing in PAHT-CF, but the surface finish was quite poor so I cancelled the print, removed the roll of filament, and placed it in the filament dryer to dry overnight. This design will also only be used if necessary; if the linear bearings and rods work OK then they would be simpler and cheaper to implement.

Mohsen was trying to tilt the hopper farther forward than it had been tilted before, so I looked at the side mounts and there were two main problems: first, the adjustment stages were not contacting the dowel pins and so were tilted (dowel pins will be replaced with machined slots in V5.1), and second, the dovetail gib in the stages was loose towards the bottom of the adjustment stage so it was possible for the mount to rotate slightly. I adjusted the gib (tightened the screw towards the bottom of the hopper, loosened the screw towards the top) to tighten it up. The adjusting screws seemed pretty tight, but I would not be surprised if the vibration being applied coupled with the torque from the stepper motor weight hanging off the side had loosened it. He also noted that the gate seemed to be wobbly and not closing at one corner. I initially thought this was due to the linear bearings (which, admittedly, are somewhat loose), but the gate should lock up when it is pressed forward until it is close to the hard stops. It turns out that the track roller on the cam had come loose, also possible due to vibration as well as massive loading (the motor shaft had become bent again, so clearly it's being heavily loaded). I tightened the track roller, and I am also looking into replacing it with something a little more robust, possibly a pair of bearings riding on a shoulder screw.

Mohsen called me over to look at the Hopper V5 prototype he is running on Pilot 2. He called me to look at powder buildup in front of the gate when it is traversing in the -Y direction (dispensing powder and spreading a layer). The phenomenon did not seem to repeat when he ran the spreading macro, which I suspect may be due to less weight on the gate (he said the hopper is roughly 1/4 full right now). He also noted that when he had the vibrating hat held down by only 2 screws, there were visible ripples on the layer, but when he used all 7 screws, the ripples went away. It seems that the attachment between the vibrating hat and the vibration isolator directly affects the spread layer quality.

Mohsen showed me a video of the hopper spreading, and it seemed that the gate was shaving off the entire layer. It seems to me that it is doing a spread with the build at exactly the same height as a previous spread. Mohsen said it is semi-random; he sees it happen maybe once in 5 spreads. I suspect it is a macro issue, that for some reason the macro is not lowering the V plate properly, but Mohsen seems confident in the macro being used (supposedly it is the same macro being called). I asked him to keep an eye out for it and see if he can figure out a pattern.

Ben pointed out a possible issue: because the heater is currently sandwiched between the mist box and the hopper (if the heater is on the far side of the mist box, the gantry cannot travel far enough for the heater to access the entire build plate), there is a risk of the cables used to connect to the limit switches melting. The cable is a IGUS continuous-flex cable, with an outer jacket of gray PVC and inner wire insulation of black TPE

Laser:

14 months of R&D that have already been done until now

Starting now after rebaselining:

Months 1-2: Informal experiments comparing laser technologies and impact of machine environment on process

Month 3: Final laser and atmosphere selection

Months 4-6: Process development

Months 7-9: Machine integration, control system development, final process refinement and benchmarking

Project completion: 23 months from start of Payman's experiments on the gantry

Completion criteria:

- Minimum cut line width reduced from .5mm to .1mm

- Cut time reduce to <1min avg (traverse speed is faster than the spindle, but the number of passes for hatching is ~5X the number for spindle passes due to the narrower cut width)

2026-03-18

HOPPER/FLIP:

Make schedule for hopper development

Week of Mar 16

- Mohsen and Ben continuing to test HOPPER V5 on Pilot 2 with dry powder spreads
- Mohsen is refining the spread macros to eliminate marks that appear on the spread when the gate closes when the hopper is near to the end of the spread
- Moving the hopper beyond the end of the spread before closing the gate would prevent this issue, but slightly increase the amount of powder wastage
- I am continuing to work on the design of HOPPER V5.1, especially focused on switching the gate guides from the current linear shafts with linear bearings to a linear guide rail carriage.
- Mohsen noted that the -Y parts of the gate (limit switch adjustment screw mount and cam slot extension) were rubbing on the layer, suggesting some drifting of the gate over time. I asked him to check whether the adjustment stages were still contacting the dowel pins or if they need to be adjusted again. He also noted that there are visible ripples on the layer at the start of the print that seem to be less of an issue as the print progresses. He also noted that vibration can be felt when touching the hopper. He also said that the gate close/open stepper motor is making increasingly loud noises. I'm increasingly thinking that it may be wise to switch to a more powerful and durable motor.

Week of Mar 23

- Finalize initial design of HOPPER V5.1
- Review the design with the team
- Continue to support dry powder spreading of HOPPER V5.0 on Pilot 2
- Hopper V5 on Pilot 2 to begin forming complete layers with spray and heat curing

Week of April 6

- Update the design of HOPPER V5.1 based on feedback from the team
- Generate drawings and CAD and order parts for 2X hoppers from Xometry or Protolabs
- Hopper V5 to begin printing TRS coupons

Week of April 13

- Continued printing of TRS coupons with Hopper V5 in parallel with breaking out, sintering, and benchmarking previously printed TRS coupons

Week of April 20

- Receive parts for Hopper V5.1
- Assemble 2X Hopper V5.1 in preparation for testing
- Hopper V5 on Pilot 2 to begin printing benchmarking parts

Week of April 27

- Switch out Hopper V5 on Pilot 2 for Hopper V5.1
- Begin printing benchmarking parts with Hopper V5.1 to compare it with Hopper V5 and catch any issues it may have

Continue design development of next hopper design iteration

- Fleshing out design of linear rail-guided gate
- Redesigned the gate so that its edges angle up, to allow for some misalignment of the hopper without the gate rubbing on the main plate

Increase robustness of gate mechanism

Laser meeting:

Payman, Marcus, Mason, me

Payman had already ordered xTool UV laser, but Mason pointed out that we would be limited in the software control system because we would be restricted to xTool software, so he suggested an alternative option from Aliexpress (1 5W UV laser and 1 30 or 60W CO2 laser, ~\$3K each)

Mason raised the possibility of inerting the machine, and Payman wants to use less than 1 day for that. Payman is OK with doing one test with an inert atmosphere for each laser technology.

Payman raised the possibility of purchasing a high speed camera, and recommended that Mason do research for one that is cheap.

<Could we just raster everything instead of doing single width cuts?>

Mason recommends using an industrial-grade IR sensor from the Saffrons instead of the current hobbyist-grade sensors. Payman wants the ability to record a thermal image/video. Mason points out that the industrial sensors will be more accurate and provide a trusted temperature

value. I also support using calibrated sensors; it is dangerous to draw conclusions from data that cannot be trusted.

Payman also wants Mason to do some experiments with the gantry printer.

Payman recommends not printing complex parts. Instead he would rather spend 1 week on each laser technology. He doesn't want to get into details in this meeting, but wants Mason to draw up a schedule showing daily tasks for each week of screening for each laser. Payman wants a meeting set up for Monday to go over experiments.

2026-03-19

PILOT:

Meeting about safety modifications to Pilot 6 and 7. Per Senai, two main issues are faults seen and fault handling.

<Does the Duet board turn off all its outputs when it is reset? It should turn off the outputs when the M112 command is sent.>



Per Duet's Single Board Computer setup page, the SD card type is important to data communication between the Pi and the Duet.

<Do they have the same capacity and model of SD card?>

Pilot 6:

Collision macro error seen on Pilot 1 and Pilot 6, so Pourya disabled it.

Pi and Duet disconnection issue seen, resolved by disabling collision detection macro reset function (the macro is still run but the M112 command was commented out). The collision detection macro thought there was a collision issue and ran an M code (M112) that resets the Duet board, resulting in a temporary disconnection between the Pi and the issue.

Pilot 6 has two spindles and a Mest unit installed.

1 instance of vacuum failing to turn off overnight.

The SD card on Pilot 6 is an A1 spec Sandisk 512 GB microSD card. The spec is an A1 or A2 SD card, so technically it should be OK.

Pilot 7:

Pi and Duet disconnection issue seen, error log says there is an SPI error (which per Pourya is seen when the M112 command is run).

Collision detection macro was not edited until yesterday.

1 instance of heater failing to turn off overnight.

1 instance of spindle failing to turn off overnight.

Pilot 7 SD was lost at some point and a new one had to be flashed. The new SD card capacity and spec is unknown.

<When building a pair of machines, I would recommend first making them identical then benchmark them to make sure they are matched before any changes are made to them.>

<Is the collision macro still running on Epsoms 1 and 2?>

<Are the relays active high or active low?>

<Recommend using the best SD card available:>

<https://www.bestbuy.com/product/sandisk-256gb-extreme-plus-microsdxc-uhs-i-memory-card-r-w-up-to-250-170mb-s/JXJ62CQSKG/sku/6643961>

HOPPER/FLIP:

Mohsen noted that the gate open stepper motor shaft was bent again, so I bent it back into place and added some washers underneath it to help reinforce it. I also removed the track roller, cleaned the threads on the cam and the track roller with IPA, added some red loctite, and reinstalled it.

Mohsen ran some spreads, and is still encountering issues with the stepper motor shaft bending. In HOPPER V5.1, I have added a ball bearing installed in the stepper motor mount to provide support to the cam mount directly to try to keep the load off the stepper motor shaft, but in the meantime I asked Mohsen to run the hopper with a reduced powder load to try to decrease the load on the stepper motor cam.

R&D Meeting:

No-Depowdering:

Broke out and sectioned a part from last week using dry air drying, significant chipping. Ran another print with adjusted temp and humidity settings, with no change seen. Noted that there was low ambient humidity that day. Replace the tool bit, ran another print, saw chipping.

Dropped the feed rate with no noticeable change. Discovered that alignment between Mest unit and end mill have shifted after replacing the end mill. After adjusting the alignment by 100 micron Y and 50 micron X, and internal chipping was largely eliminated. Final conclusion was that the fix was replacing the end mill and adjusting offset. Chipping can be caused by either a dull end mill or incorrect offset between the sacrificial filler dispenser and the spindle.

After resolving the chipping issue, focus became improving the side wall quality. He increased sacrificial filler dispenser frequency from 54 to 74 Hz.

Marcus noted that experimenting with carbide end mill coatings may be beneficial, since we are seeing significant tool wear with the single flute end mill. <Suspect that tool sharpness is particularly critical for the no-depowdering process because we need to cut very soft materials cleanly.> After replacing the tool bit with a sharper one, they ran some AEM-style prints with copper with better results. Pourya tried melting out the sacrificial filler with a heat gun, and the part bulged upward when heated and some of the small fin features were detached. Motivation for using the heat gun was to rapidly remove the sacrificial filler. <If you skip a step, you will find 5 extra steps waiting for you.> He plans to repeat the test and instead use an oven cycle to melt out the sacrificial filler.

Next week:

Removed sacrificial filler with Keith furnace. Will try to print another part. Plans to start printing microchannel parts.

Hopper:

Powder loading found not to refill quickly

Powder refill position blocks the fan, so it can not load during layer cooling. Move refilling location to Y min position.

To Do:

Change powder loading position to Y min

Lower powder level sensor height - DONE

Make new doser ball - DONE

Continue new design development

Test maximum powder loading in U tank on Pilot printers - DONE

There seem to be some questions with Ben thinking he only works on Mohsen's experiments (who he does technically report to) but Marcus stated that he nominally works to support the

whole lab. Unclear what exactly the issue is here, but there is clearly something going on behind the scenes here that I am unaware of.

2026-03-23

Pilot Baseline Stabilization Project Planning:

Goal is to establish that the core Pilot technology is reliable (start machine and have high confidence that the print will complete without operator intervention).

Pourya recommends finding the limits of the software (i.e. file size). Ben has been having difficulty transferring files, and wants to be able to transfer files wirelessly. Pourya points out that this is dependent on wifi network quality.

Payman raised the point that data logging is important to figure out before trying to benchmark the system, including visible light images before and after the cut. IR pictures are explicitly not necessary. Also, he wants pictures taken of the inside of the mist box periodically.

Because the communication between the Raspberry Pi and the THC control arduino has been changed, it is not possible to adjust the temperature and humidity offsets (sensor calibration) but the humidity and temperature targets can be adjusted.

Since there is no way to raise the humidity in the machine if it is too low, Payman recommends increasing the humidity of the room to compensate.

<We have never done testing to optimize the print parameters, such as layer target temperature.>

<Recommend having ZZ add the environmental sensor offset adjustment functionality back into the code.>

<Check whether the safety system is still operational matching the functionality of the safety system in the Epson printers.>

Goal here is not to ensure the quality of printed parts, it is only to test the reliability of the print start - finish process.

<Recommend running repeat prints of TRS parts, breaking them out, sintering them, and comparing part quality.>

Payman wants to do 50 layer prints with air cutting to ensure that the data logging system functions properly, then switch to 300 layer prints.

I asked about making Pilots 8 and 9, and he said that we are planning on making one more only to save money.

Laser Meeting:

Mason has fleshed out his laser comparison testing plan to the resolution of days and hours. After this meeting with me and Midhun (who is back from India), Mason is going to have a meeting with Payman to go over this plan.

Goal of laser project is to reduce cut time with a secondary goal of reduced cut size.

Mason wants to test different laser with different materials: 17-4PH, 316L, Cu.

There is a spec limit of 250 micron maximum cut width, which may be an issue on the diode laser due to previously seen results.

HOPPER/FLIP:

The motor shaft had become bent again, so I bent it back into place and machined the head of an M6 bolt into a spacer that I welded to the stainless steel cam mount to help move the bending moment application point towards the base of the shaft, where it is better supported. I also machined some new linear rod guides from a wear-resistant polymer rod I had around, making them tight to the shafts so that there is less slop in the gate. This also adds load to the motor because there is more drag in the new bushings, but hopefully they will break in over time.

I prepared the doser ball V3 mold and did a pour of 770 urethane (shore 70).

Mohsen was seeing an issue with the Duet board not detecting the end stop limit switches, so I first tested the limit switch with a multimeter then checked the plugs, and they were not plugged into the wire harness properly. There is a Y splitter that connects the two limit switches in series to one 2-wire cable running to the Duet board, and it was disconnected where the Y splitter connects to the 2-wire cable running to the Duet board.

I also did something that I should have done weeks ago; I dropped the current of the gate close/open motor (A axis) from 600 to 300 mA, so it is unable to bend the shaft even when it hits the hard stops.

2026-03-24

HOPPER/FLIP:

Printed a new vibrating hat with the duct hose connection rotated to 30 degrees towards +Y instead of 30 degrees -Y as it has been. This is to be able to do hopper filling when the gantry is at the -Y position, while the system is waiting for the layer to cool.

I demolded the new high-flow doser ball, and it mostly looks pretty good. There was some parting line residue at one point towards the top of the doser ball, but I shaved it off with a scalpel.

I am continuing to work on the design of HOPPER V5.1.

After printing 6 layers, the gate open/close stepper motor shaft snapped, so I disassembled the gear box, welded the shaft back together, machined the shaft on the lathe to be fairly straight, and reassembled the planetary gear box. The shaft is slightly shorter than it was before because I machined off some of it to give flat surfaces and to eliminate the retaining ring groove (which is where it broke).

Mohsen has only been filling the hopper about 1/3 full by setting the powder dispenser to run for a set time each layer (I think he said 60 seconds, which seems long to me). I need to redesign the capacitive sensor mount so that it is lower down, so the hopper can be filled to precisely the same height each time.

GENERAL R&D:

Dong asked me for the link to the band saw blade for cutting stainless steel and nickel alloys, and said that it needed to be replaced. I asked whether the current blade was unable to cut some of our inconel samples right after being replaced, which I remember, and he admitted that it was possible. This will be the third identical blade installed on the band saw; I installed the same model of blade when I first built the machine, it ran fine with minimal wear for years and several thousand parts, but was unable to cut certain Inconel parts post-sintering (most parts it was fine with, but some would cause the blade to overheat and vaporize the coolant and the linear stage jammed), so Dong had me replace the blade, which also worked fine for most Inconel parts but overheated on certain parts, so now Dong is asking me to replace the blade again.

For reference, the link to the blade is here: <https://www.mcmaster.com/4200A33/>

This obviously won't solve the root cause because none of the blades have shown significant wear and also worked fine on most parts, there were just some Inconel parts that caused issues. I would guess that those parts are case-hardened near the edge, because the hardness reading towards the center of the part seemed fine. Inconel famously causes large heat buildup, so it could be that those parts just have a slightly different microstructure or formula than the rest of the parts.

We can keep buying as many blades as Dong wants, but if we want to solve the problem we have several options:

- If a sample does not cut well, just don't section it
- If a sample does not cut well, section it using an abrasive saw instead of the band saw
- Get a sectioning saw (Claude claims that a diamond saw is unsuitable because the diamond reacts with nickel superalloys, so we would want to use a different kind of abrasive saw blade).

PILOT:

ZZ sent out an email regarding preparing Pilot 7 for the baseline test

2026-03-25

PILOT: Ran a test by loading 110mm of powder into the U tank of Pilot 7, then ran the powder compression macro (which moves the U tank down 10mm, then up 10mm, then repeats that cycle to compress the powder). The macro sets the speed at 3000 mm/min, but the max speed in the config file was set to 1000 mm/min initially, so that is the speed at which it would travel. I ran the macro at both 1000 and 750 mm/min, and it seemed to work fine without losing a significant number of steps or making any noise. I ended up setting the max speed to 750 mm/min in the config file to be safer, which may compress the powder less per cycle but Mohsen feels that we can increase the number of cycles to achieve the same compression.

<I would recommend compressing the powder with a weight on top of a UHMW sheet as was tested several years ago. This would both compress the powder more while also resulting in a more even compression that would be easier to level out before printing (when using the current powder compression macro, the powder compresses more where it contacts the sides than the center, and compresses still more at the corners.)>

The print of the newly designed mist box that has cutouts for glass windows on both sides and is being printed on the Bambu X1E (Anvil) in PAHT-CF ran out of filament, so I loaded a new roll. This new roll has not been dried overnight, so I am unsure what its print quality will be. The print quality of the previous roll, however, looks quite good. Not quite as good as PETG-CF, but way better than when the roll had not been dried overnight. I think the key takeaway is that the PAHT-CF (CF-reinforced nylon) needs to be dried overnight at 60-65C before starting each print.

HOPPER:

The longer prox switch holder that was printed last night did not come out with good threads, and also did not have a hole for accessing the sensitivity adjustment screw when the capacitive

sensor is installed, and was also not designed with an optimal length that would place the sensor at the right position when it has all threads engaged but is protruding from the holder as much as possible while still having the threads engaged.

The hopper installed in Pilot 2 is not closing fully. I increased the current from 300 to 400 mA and it still did not close completely, so I asked Mohsen to remove it for further inspection. I suspect that the cam is grinding into the gate, causing it to lock up even when the hopper is empty.

That did not turn out to be the issue. I think the gate may have been getting stopped by the area where a wedge feature on the gate contacts a wedge feature on the aluminum frame, so I removed the gate and ground down the stainless steel a bit.

I tried to print a new mist box body from PAHT-CF last night, but the print failed because it became detached from the build plate on one side because the part curled up, even with the heated chamber. I am reprinting the body from PETG-CF, and I also realized that if I print it inverted it takes less support material and, more importantly, the section of the mist box that contacts the powder build will be flatter because it is printed last and not attached to the build plate, where it is likely to distort during the FDM print.

Continued to refine the design of HOPPER V5.1. I figured out a way to move away from the wedge contact surface entirely, by extending the leading edge of the sides of the gate and adding a flat feature that is parallel to the (now) flat bottom of the side aluminum pieces comprising the hopper body. I will install felt to act as a sliding seal between these surfaces to allow them to move freely while blocking powder flow.



GENERAL R&D:

Pourya asked me about the Offset Tables used on the Saffron printers, so I asked Devin about them, read through the Confluence documentation, and asked Devin about them again to confirm what it seemed they were. It turns out that it is referring to a single X Y offset value

unique to each machine; having an offset defined by each machine's slightly unique hardware makes it possible to run the same sliced G code on different printers. The reason it is called an Offset Table is because it is using a Trak function that provides for multiple coordinate offset values, likely for multiple tools that might be used with a tool changer, but in our case we are only using one offset value in the table to compensate for slightly different spindle positions relative to the cake (I suspect this is mainly due to variations in the position of the homing sensors on the glass scales, but it could also be due to dimensional variations in the machined parts or similar).

2026-03-26

HOPPER/FLIP:

I cast another doser ball of the newer many-groove design. I am still having difficult filling the mold; there is a fairly small annular opening at the top around the splined shaft, so I have been filling the funnel-shaped cavity above the doser ball and squeezing the mold to squeeze out a bubble. This works, but runs the risk of urethane flowing into the parting line cuts in the mold, which requires more post-processing of the doser ball and increases the risk of FOD in the print if any remaining urethane bits break off. I haven't come up with a really elegant solution to filling the mold; increasing the annulus size would work but would make cutting off the cast funnel feature more difficult to do precisely, and the precision of that cut defines the seal of the doser ball towards its edge. I could inject the urethane into the mold at one point, but this would burn up a syringe for each pour and would be difficult to fit in; I would likely need to redesign and reprint the upper 3D printed splined shaft guide. I could hold the mold at an angle and pour the urethane towards the lower end of the annulus, but I would need to keep the pour flow rate low to prevent urethane from completely sealing the annulus.

I am printing a PAHT-CF gate on the Bambu X1E right now.

My plan is to go over the design of HOPPER V5.1 at the R&D meeting tomorrow to get the design signed off so I can order the machined parts, then while waiting for the machined parts, I will make a 3D printed version to prove out the general design and get any issues with COTS parts ironed out.

I am working on designing a guard to protect the linear carriage from powder. It will not give it an airtight seal, but it should help to keep the powder off it for longer.

There are issues being seen with powder buildup in the feed hose, so I am exploring alternative hose duct options to try.

The motor was experiencing issues, so Mohsen removed it from the hopper. It seemed that it was jamming up at a point in its rotation, even with the cam removed. I took it apart and noted that the shaft was bent, and was also beginning to crack at the joint where I welded it (although it had not snapped off yet, which I'm pretty proud of). I removed it, bent everything back into place as best I could, ground a groove into the crack, rewelded it, and turned it down to be a loose fit in the motor gearbox's main output bearing. When I assembled the gearbox last time the shaft was a press fit, which I suspect may have forced some gears to start grinding into the shaft-mounted gear carrier (as evidenced by bare metal exposed at two points where two of the the gears on the gear carrier would contact the carrier). With the loose fit of the shaft, I am hoping that there will be less of a tendency for components to grind into each other, although there will be some loss of support from the bearing. It is actually possible that the two gears were cutting into the gear carrier because of a bending moment applied to the shaft that was not properly supported by the bearing.

PILOT:

The printed mist box looks like it came out well, and the glass windows I need for the new mist box arrived last night, so I can put it together by gluing the glass windows to the printed mist box with SLA resin injected through a needle attached to a syringe.

I assembled the mist box by gluing on the three glass panels with SLA resin and coated the inside surfaces with SLA resin to waterproof them (the SLA resin used is an old ABS-like gray resin from Amazon that's been around for a few years). Since the mist box is too large to fit in the FormLabs curing chamber, and I cannot find any of the gray UV lights, I am using the cheap cylindrical curing chamber I brought in by holding it and pointing it at the outsides, and to cure the inside of the mist box I set the cylinder on top of the mist box so it exposes the inside pretty well to UV light. I will need to ream out the heat set insert holes to .199" because there was some SLA resin that wound up in the holes which would interfere with the process of installing the inserts.

I cleaned the mist box with 99% IPA, reamed out the holes, and installed M3 heat set inserts, then gave the mist box to Ben to install.

2026-03-27

HOPPER/FLIP:

The gate seems to be opening and closing OK after my repairs yesterday. Mohsen screwed the capacitive prox switch farther into the mount so that the end is flush with the bottom of the mount, and the indicator light and sensitivity adjusting screw are exposed at the top. I had to adjust the sensitivity to compensate; I suspect that the sensor was detecting the 3D printed

material surrounding its end. Mohsen noted that powder was still building up in the hose duct during the refill cycle, so I shortened the hose by ~12mm and made sure that the gantry was traveling to the maximum Y position. This seems to get the hose duct angled sufficiently that the powder flows through it, although the higher tension on the hose duct due to shortening it does increase the risk of the hose duct failing or becoming detached from either the vibrating hat or the cartridge dock hose connection point.

I received the industrial limit switches from automation direct, and they seem to perform as advertised.

I printed out the parts for casting a hopper vibration isolator using the same procedure as last time (which involves hot gluing sacrificial FDM parts to the outside of the top and bottom vibration isolator panels) and did a pour with PMC 744 that I mixed with the flexibilizer; I used 50g B, 100g A, and mixed 15g of flexibilizer with B for 1 minute before mixing A and B. This was clearly way too much; I was unable to fully degass the urethane in the mixing cup I was using so I had to do a degass-pour-degass-pour etc in the vibration isolator and doser ball molds I had filled (I was also making a V3 doser ball from the same urethane, as long as I had extra urethane to spare).

GENERAL R&D:

The R&D meeting was moved to Monday, so I will not be able to order the machined parts today as I had hoped.

Running another print for Payman's printer, which is a kind of most box/guide. I have run several of them over the past few days. As far as I can tell, the intent is to uniformly apply binder to a layer by having a line of dispensed mist that travels along the build area. To get this line of mist, he has been exploring designs that use the current nebulizer to spray mist into a chamber with complex geometry to transition the shape of spray from a circular cone to a line. As you might expect, the vast majority of the mist condenses on the tortuous channels. His informal experiments do seem to be yielding uniform binder coverage, but I am unaware of any quantification he has done so the results are currently anecdotal. I am also unsure why he is doing these experiments and developing his hardware at all; it functionally overlaps with what we are developing (my hopper and pilot printer, Mason's laser) so it seems like a duplication of effort.

2026-03-30

HOPPER/FLIP:

Did a pour for the silicone mold that I will use to make casting the hopper vibration isolators easier and less wasteful.

Testing Notes from Mohsen:

- Track roller comes loose
 - When screwing the track roller into the cam, use red Loctite
- Bar calibration shifts after loading hopper - only happens sometimes
- Better height/leveling adjustment?
- Wavy lines visible on early layers, possibly due to vibration of hopper body
- Indication of powder height sensor height
- Questions of sensor mount robustness
- Sensor height adjustability
- Avoid components being close to the machine main plate if not necessary
- New limit switches
 - Done, replaced original PCB-mount micro limit switches with industrial limit switches with cross roller to engage with ramps machined into the gate
- Gate doesn't always close evenly
- Powder top surface in hopper is not level because powder inlet is off center
- Powder that is left in the hopper overnight does not flow well initially
- Reduced gap between bottom of the vibrating sheet and the spreader bar level
 - Increased height of vibrating sheet.
- Bottle shifts during refilling
 - Fixed by increasing toggle clamp clamping force
- Powder cartridge splined shaft shifts
 - Need to design a more robust splined shaft shaft collar

Senai had some very interesting ideas for the hopper; he suggested having a cam on each side driven by a single shaft whose track rollers engage with each carriage, more or less aligned with each carriage rail (OK, I fleshed out some of the ideas there, but the core concept of two cams to minimize torque was his).

Weekly R&D Meeting:

No-Depowdering:

Goal of week was to increase the quality of printed part side walls. Underfilling of the cuts seems to be a major contributor to poor side wall surface finish. Increasing the frequency (increasing flow) does not seem to improve quality because additional sacrificial filler does not

stay in the cut, it will travel to one side or the other. Layers where a whole layer facing operation was completed had improved quality as compared with targeted machining of the cut only. The quality of east/west walls was better than north/south walls. The facing operation travels north/south. The larger end mill causes marks on the layer when changing direction (marks look like the ones you would see with a chipped tooth, but this end mill only has one flute).

Ran another test where the facing operation followed the same path as the original cuts (the facing operation is only done with the large diameter end mill), and did not see any significant changes. There does not seem to be any difference between using different diameters of end mill or different paths.

No heat pass is currently used so the layer temperature matches ambient temperature in the machine. Pourya notes that the temperature of the sacrificial filler does not impact its flow into the cuts because it cools rapidly when it contacts the cake, so it is the cake temperature that has more of an impact on the flow properties of the filler agent when droplets hit the cut. <I would recommend ensuring that the cake temperature is controlled when applying the filler agent by using a heater as necessary, and possibly switch to a higher temperature sacrificial filler if necessary.> Mason noted and Pourya agreed that there is currently no quantification of surface finish, it is only measured visually. <This makes it difficult to quantifiably compare different settings and approaches.>

Pourya tried to redo a test, but the Festool failed, so he reran the test with the StoneVac instead. When starting a print today, he noted that the humidity in the machine was 11%, likely because the THC failed to turn off the dry air injection valve.

<Claude suggested that sugar is somewhat soluble in PEG, so I believe it is possible that when the sacrificial filler is melted out it debinds some of the powder and carries it with it.>

<It seems clear that the root cause of the issue, however, is voids in the cuts after filling, facing, and spreading fresh powder. Pourya also noted several times that there are voids in the sacrificial filler after the facing operation. I would recommend resolving this issue before doing anything else because it seems unlikely that it is possible to have a good print without completely filling cuts with sacrificial filler.>

Pourya is trying another test by applying a much larger amount of PEG than the previous tests, to ensure that there are no gaps between the wall and the sacrificial filler that will then be filled with dry powder on the next powder spread.

<First note of the no-depowdering project in my notes was 2025-01-14, so the no-depowdering project following the general approach of filling the cuts with a sacrificial filler has been going on

for at least 14 months. Since this is only a few days after I started taking notes here, and based on what I said in my notes here, I suspect that it was already in progress at that point.>

Pourya also removed the sacrificial filler from the latest copper part, and the process of removing the filler caused some of the printed features to detach. Payman and Pourya decided to switch to printing a microchannel design instead of the more complex AEM-style part where the sacrificial filler thermal removal process damaged the part.

There are some difficulties with making functional G-code for the print; the original sliced file needs to be adjusted manually (one reason for this is the Offset Table X/Y offset value that is unique to each Saffron printer).

Marcus recommends trying a geometry that enables the sacrificial filler to drain out when melted instead of needing to flow through the porous part. Pourya thinks that the liquid PEG is too viscous to flow out through holes, it soaks into the porous part and cake and is decomposed during the thermal sacrificial filler removal procedure.

Laser Meeting:

New types of lasers were ordered and arrived. There was a planning meeting conducted to determine experimental protocol and short term and long term goals. Surface roughness of cut walls is a priority.

Mason sealed Pilot 3 to inert it, injected nitrogen to reduce the oxygen concentration to 3%, and cut/hatched some squares. He noted that he is unable to run the LVP at the same time as inerting because the LVP is based on using dry air injection and a non-recirculating vacuum. He is trying to run tests to compare the atmospheric cutting process with the inerted process.

This week he plans to spend a few days working on Payman's Pilot Ultra <hmm...> to get a "feel" for it, continue benchmarking the MOPA laser on Pilot 3, and eventually transfer a diode laser to Pilot 3 to compare that against other laser technologies. Mason has also been measuring the surface roughness of the sides of green parts using the Keyence microscope's 3D measurement function.

Mason is also researching a way to incorporate vacuum functionality into the inerted system.

He asked whether he should make slides for this weekly meeting the way that they were done at some point. Payman wants this meeting to be brief <also hmm...> but Marcus notes that it is important that results are documented.

HOPPER:

Add angle cuts on the gate

TO DO:

- **Finalize design**
- **Order machined parts**

PILOT ULTRA:

Made prototype of simplified hopper that works to make thin layers. Working on mist box.

Marcus recommends setting up regular meetings for copper no-depowdering experiments on the Saffron printers as well as the Pilot Baselining project.

2026-03-31

HOPPER/FLIP:

Redesigning the cam system per Senai's suggestions. The core concept is that there are two cams each aligned with the linear carriage rail to minimize the bending moment applied to the carriage by the cams, and the two cams are mounted to a shaft that is driven by the stepper motor. An alternative approach would have been to use two stepper motors, one on each side, which would be mechanically simpler (at least from my perspective, from a total system level there would be more moving parts because of doubling the number of planetary gearboxes, but from the custom mechanicals would be simpler) and would allow for each side to be moved somewhat independently to ensure that both sides of the gate close completely, but keeping them adequately synchronized would be trickier than with a single stepper motor using mechanical synchronization. Also, the shaft-driven cam approach allows me to gear down the stepper motor output further, so there is even more force to close the gate without bending the stepper motor shaft

LASER:

Meeting w/ Mason and Midhun about laser testing. Spending this week on the MOPA laser on Pilot 3. When cutting multiple layers with a small part, the temperature change of the layer is fairly small. <Can the total energy input per layer be calculated based on laser path and power settings, and the predicted layer temperature rise be calculated from that?> Next week plans to run tests on the blue diode laser, which should be easier because there are fewer parameters to adjust. Plans to do tests with and without inerting. Midhun recommends redesigning the LVP so that the vacuum inlet is larger; apparently it has a very small cross-sectional area right now. Currently he is finding the side walls have a surface finish of ~12 microns Sa, compared with ~6 microns Sa for spindle-cut green part side walls.

Midhun is setting up the UV and CO2 lasers to conduct experiments with multiple powder materials on the benchtop instead of in a printer. The plan is to test laser cutting 17-4, 316L,

Inconel 625, and pure copper cakes.

They also brought up the possibility of trying argon to see if its behavior is different from nitrogen.

2026-04-01

HOPPER/FLIP:

Continuing to work on the updated version of the hopper. I switched to a miter gear setup today because the available miter gears are smaller diameter than the available spur gears, so I won't need to make a cutout in the hopper body plate. I modified the carriage mounts to be symmetrical and adjusted them to match the raised cam shaft, which I had to raise from 12mm to 15mm away from the hopper body due to the size of the stepper motor. Also, switching to miter gears let me change the stepper motor to a vertical orientation, which makes it possible to mount some limit switches to the hopper body next to the stepper motor. I plan to trigger these limit switches with clamping machined cams mounted the 8mm camshaft.

I rewired the connection from the Duet expansion board to the hopper vibrator motor to make it possible to control motor speed with G code. It was originally wired with the Duet output triggering a solid state relay that controlled power to an adjustable DC power supply, so I instead wired the motor directly to the output (the output is a heater output so its current capability is high enough to drive a DC motor). Mohsen wanted the capability to adjust vibrator motor power from G code so that he could increase vibration during the powder fill cycle to try to level out the powder in the hopper. He noted that the top surface of the powder was not level because the powder loading hose is connected off-center (I did this intentionally to decrease the hose angle between the hopper and the powder dispenser to enable powder to flow down the hose freely). I am unconvinced that the powder level is critical to part quality, which can be verified by measuring the density of TRS coupons produced; if there is a variation in density seen in the X direction then it will be confirmed that the powder in the hopper needs to be level. In this case, the best option is to move the powder injection point back to the center and modify the powder loading system so that it can still flow into the hopper.

I initially planned to send out parts to be machined today, but Mohsen asked me to hold off until he gives me his latest feedback.

Mohsen suggested I increase the diameter of the sensor holder on the vibrating hat to match the outer diameter of the new sensor mount (the sensor holder is a cylindrical feature on the outside of the vibrating hat that you can rest the sensor in so it is continually triggered regardless of powder level, which prevents the hopper from refilling when you are trying to use up all the powder in the hopper). He didn't have any suggestions for changes to machined parts,

so I have begun the process of submitting parts to Xometry, creating drawings as necessary to call out threaded holes.

2026-04-02

HOPPER/FLIP:

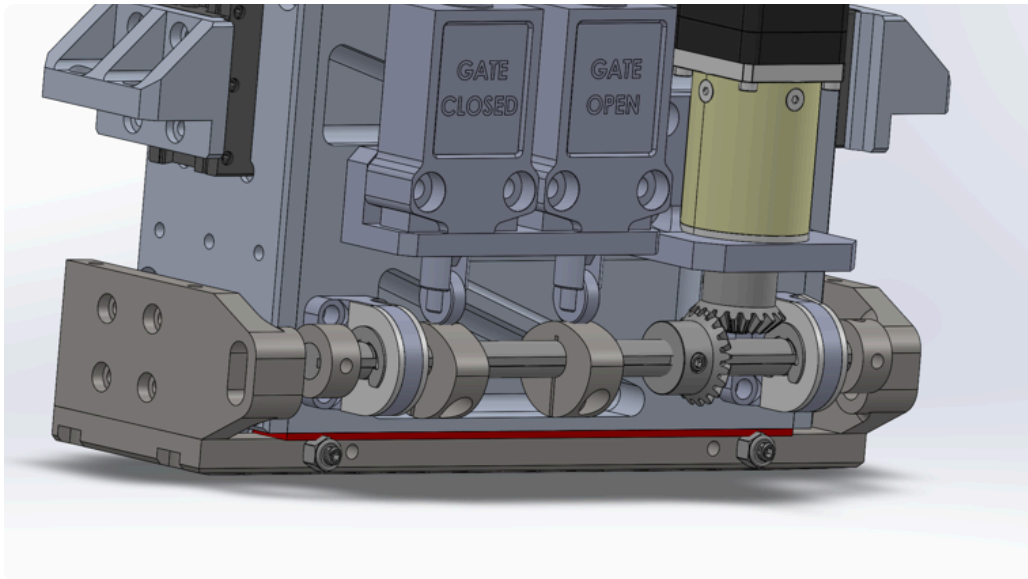
Going through and submitting all the machined parts to Xometry in preparation for submitting the order for approval and ordering.

Finished entering in and configuring all the machined costs. The spreader bar I submitted through ProtoLabs because they have an option to Type III hard-anodize the aluminum which Xometry does not, and also has a way to select threads so a drawing doesn't need to be generated for each part, but the cost is much lower on Xometry so I submitted the rest of the parts through Xometry. The total cost for machined parts is ~\$3K, assuming a one-off first article. The cost per hopper would reduce as the quantity increases, although I would like to reduce the cost much further than that.

After submitting all the parts, I caught a significant oversight in my design: There is no good feature that holds the camshaft in place in the axial direction. The two cams will prevent axial motions by crashing into the gate mounts if the shaft is pushed over too far, but this would cause increased friction and wear and so should be avoided. Since the shaft is being driven by a 90 degree miter gear, there are forces transmitted along the axis of the camshaft. There are three components of force when bevel gears interact: axial forces along the shaft, radial forces perpendicular to the shaft axis, and tangential forces that cause rotation of the shaft. The radial loads are handled by the two permanently lubricated and sealed ball bearings in the custom-designed machined aluminum pillow blocks that support the camshaft, and the tangential loads are what we want to rotate the shaft, but I did not include a provision for handling the radial loads. I could add some thrust washers where the cam bearings interact with the gate mount slots (actually, I'm pretty sure that the axial force will always be applied in the same direction regardless of the direction of rotation of the motor, in which case I would only need thrust washers on one side (I think the -X side, assuming that with straight-cut bevel gears the gears will always be pushed apart (Claude claims that it is different with helical-cut gear sets, that in one direction they will push apart and in the other they will pull together, which is possible, but I would like independent confirmation))). Regardless, I plan to have the shaft supported against loads in both directions to support the axial load introduced by the bevel gears (in this case they are the special case of bevel gears called miter gears, meaning they have the same number of teeth, but the more generic name for a conical gear set is bevel gears) in one direction and ensure that the bevel gears stay meshed properly in the other direction if there is some outside force introduced. Since I failed to catch this earlier, I am somewhat limited by my pillow block

design. I could cancel the order and redesign the pillow block, but that would risk delaying the order and/or introduce mistakes, so I will make the current design work. I have already added retaining rings to the camshaft on both sides of each bearing, locking into grooves that I will machine into the keyed shaft. If the two shaft-supporting bearings are held in the pillow blocks axially, either due to the designed press fit (I designed the pillow blocks to match the outside of the bearings so they are an interference fit if they are machined exactly correctly, but with tolerances of ± 0.005 " the fit could be looser) or green loctite then the shaft will be retained axially as-is, but I do not want to depend on that being the case. It is possible that the bearing could start loose or loosen over time, so I don't want to depend on a press fit or glue. One way that would have been reasonably elegant to locate the bearing would be to machine the pillow block with a pair of internal retaining ring grooves, or possibly with a pair of set screws at 90 degrees apart, but this adds complexity to the machining and also cannot be done at this point since the design is locked in. I could rework the pillow blocks by adding the set screw threads after they are received, but that would not be a very elegant solution, and I am also concerned about how well set screws will retain a standard ball bearing, particularly because I am using an aluminum housing. Also, these designs depend on the ball bearing handling thrust loads as well as radial loads.

My plan now is to add thrust bushings that contact the pillow block around the bearing to avoid applying load to the bearing itself. If I was able to change the design of the pillow block to accommodate this design change, I would add a counterbore around the bearing bore to support a standard thrust bushing, but A. I won't change the design now and B. the standard sizes of thrust bushings on McMaster are either smaller than the OD of the bearing so they wouldn't engage with the housing regardless or are too large to fit within a reasonably sized counterbore, so I will instead use a large thrust bushing (probably a dry-running polymer style to handle the dirty environment) and grind down one side of it to make a flat that allows for the fillet on the pillow block that blocks a fully circular thrust bushing.



I ended up designing some custom parts that match the bearing and pillow block flat surface. I plan to machine them from glass-filled PTFE or have them laser cut.

Instead, I now plan to have those parts laser cut from stainless steel and stack some standard thrust bushings on top of them.

I realized that the laser cut parts will likely interfere with the screws used to mount down the pillow blocks, and I am concerned about getting good alignment with machined snap ring grooves considering the tolerance stackup in all the components on the camshaft, so I am switching to using 2 piece clamping shaft collars instead of retaining rings and switching to using modified washers instead of the laser cut stainless steel parts.

2026-04-03

GENERAL R&D:

There are issues with two of the Pilot printers not homing the U and V tank properly, which was seen previously because the limit switch is recessed into the mount enough that if the mount bends slightly the limit switch will not be tripped. I designed a new mount where the limit switch protrudes from the mount farther, so I plan to print some more from clear material on the FormLabs because it is the most dimensionally accurate and rigid SLA material we are set up to print.

R&D Weekly Meeting:

No Depowdering:

Repeated experiment without removing sacrificial filler, and the print failed at layer 20, but he broke it out anyway. He found that it may be possible to break out the part without removing the

sacrificial filler. When he removed the PEG he found that there was powder embedded in the PEG

Marcus: the spirit of this request was to examine whether damage to walls was present before removing the sacrificial filler. Recommends inspecting a printed part with a CT scanner through Intrepid, but has not heard back from them yet.

Pourya increased the sacrificial filler dispensed by increasing open time from .2 to 1.2 ms, and performed the facing operation every layer. After breaking it out, the wall quality was improved but still does not match spindle-only surface finish. He noticed voids in the +Y side of the part where the spindle travels during the facing operation, possibly due to dry powder being vacuumed up. He decreased vacuum power from 9 to 6, with no visible effect.

Pourya printed another part with a drain path for the sacrificial filler instead of being completely dependent on it soaking through the porous part only. He ran the thermal filler removal cycle with the part inverted, not with the openings pointing downwards. After removing the sacrificial filler, he found that the +X side had visible issues, but the other 3 sides seemed good. One issue Pourya noted is that the holes on the side of the part, so the entire cake would have to be rotated 90 degrees to allow the filler to flow out, unless the part is sliced out of the cake before the thermal sacrificial removal process.

I raised the possibility of a higher temperature sacrificial filler to enable us to use the heat pass, and Mason raised the idea of trying microcrystalline wax again. Pourya noted that the issue with microcrystalline wax was that it was difficult to face cleanly. Mason noted that we are using a new end mill that may not have this issue. Marcus raised the question of what we are trying to solve, to which I responded for the sake of process standardization, matching the way our printing process is usually conducted. <Could we switch to a sacrificial filler that is soluble in IPA so we can remove it without the thermal removal process? Actually, per Claude, lower molecular weight PEG is somewhat soluble in IPA, especially when warm.>

Marcus raised the idea of sectioning a green copper part and trying to sinter another one. Payman raised the point that we don't have a process for completely debinding and sintering copper parts that are heavily contaminated with PEG (I believe Dong has raised concerns previously with contamination of the copper debinding oven due to the PEG-filled parts having such high binder content).

Marcus recommends trying to fix the issue with poor wall quality in 17-4 PH before trying to improve it in copper prints. He also wants to try packing more parts into a print to reduce powder wastage <ha ha!>.

Mason recommended measuring the surface finish of the side walls using the VHX microscope, which is able to measure area surface finish visually.

Alex raised the point that there were issues with features in copper printed parts detaching during the thermal sacrificial filler removal process, and Marcus stated that our response was to switch to a simpler geometry. He also pointed out that there was a task to test green strength at some point, but it was “deferred” at some point. He also said that green strength improvement would likely require a binder improvement program <ha ha!>. Marcus said that we could just have design rules that prevent features that might detach, and Alex pointed out that the ability to print thin walls in copper is critical to the business.

Laser:

Mason presented results from testing the MOPA and UV lasers. He showed some pictures of cuts using the UV laser. The UV laser is a Q switched laser, so a lower frequency gives a higher peak power (Mason claims). He tried laser machining cakes made from 17-4, Inconel 625, and pure copper. The cuts in Inconel create “fiber”-like objects above a certain peak power setting. Each test entailed laser machining 9 squares with a different energy density in each square. The temperature rise of the square with the highest energy density was about 12 degrees C for 17-4 and about 6 degrees C with copper.

Mason noted that the UV laser cut width tends to be higher than other lasers and the laser tends to be slower.

He finished the MOPA laser testing, but did initial UV laser testing instead of moving the blue diode laser to Pilot 3 because Payman was still using it on his gantry.

Spread/Spray:

Marcus requested that Payman report on his experiments. Payman thinks he is close to finalizing the design of the hopper and mist box. He is continuing to encounter issues with binder dripping from mist that contacts the surfaces of the mist box. He ran a 50 layer print yesterday without binder dripping or other issues with a layer thickness of 100 microns. He plans to continue experiments and try printing with an argon atmosphere. He notes that the hopper uses a monolithically printed living hinge as the door, but uses a fixed opening width. I asked whether the living hinge is necessary or if a fixed gap could be used, and Payman stated that the door needs some flexibility to be vibrated (it is not so much a door as a flexible vibration application sheet).

HOPPER/FLIP:

I am continuing to work on ensuring the keyed shaft is located properly in the axial direction so that the two end cams with the track rollers do not rub on the gate mounts due to the axial loading of the bevel gears being used to rotate the shaft.

The stacked thrust bushing design was getting out of hand, so I am moving back to retaining the support ball bearings in the pillow block and using those to support the side load. I am leaning towards using shaft collars to provide an adjustable contact surface and having shims with a smaller OD than the shaft collars to interface between the shaft collars and the bearings to ensure that contact is only at the inner race of the bearing, not rubbing on the seal or the outer race. The shaft collars will need to be machined to be slightly narrower than they are stock, which is fine for me to do for the first article build, but they will likely need to either be custom made or externally modified for full-rate production. I am using set screw shaft collars instead of my preferred clamping collars because the diameter of the clamping shaft collar is too large to accommodate standard or button head socket head cap screws mounting the pillow block to the hopper body. One approach to resolving this issue is to integrate the pillow block into a monolithic machined back panel.

I'm scrapping the whole design and making a new one; I found out that I can combine parts to save cost; it turns out that Xometry's pricing isn't super dependent on material cost, so if I make a gate with the side mounts integrated that gets hogged out from a block of stainless so 90% of the raw material is wasted, it's still cheaper than having the gate and the side mounts machined separately, and I can make the design much more compact, robust, and precise. I also realized that there is no reason for me to design the spreader bar as tall as I did, since that design was based on the assumption that it would be machined from a 30mm OD bar of stock, but here it is going to be machined from regular billet and be Type III Hard-Anodized afterwards.

Fortunately, the machined parts were never ordered because I forwarded the quote to Adriana's email instead of entering it through the ordering form. She also noted that for this large of an order I should request a PO for it so that it goes through Gloria for approval.

For the sake of expediency, I am unscrapping the V5.1 design because I want all the orders to be entered today. I am changing the design of the bearing pillow blocks to have threads for set screws to lock in the bearing as well as thickening the ring around the bearing to give more meat for the threads, but other than that I will leave the design unchanged. I submitted the Xometry quote with only the bearing pillow block changed, the ProtoLabs quote the same as before, and an order request for the necessary parts from McMaster. Now I am going to start working on a 3D printed prototype of HOPPER V5.1 to prove out the design, to refine the cam design, and organize all the hardware.

I have started prints on the Bambu printers to print most of the necessary parts for assembling a HOPPER V5.1 prototype. One important thing to note is that the parts were designed to be machined and not 3D printed, so all the threaded holes will have to be tapped into the printed parts instead of made using threaded inserts.

2026-04-06

PILOT Baseline Stabilization Meeting:

Purpose of meeting is to discuss resources available and demands for machines.

Mohsen is running experiments on Pilot 7 and has been running into issues with logging data from BME sensors; they are all reading values of 0 for humidity and temperature in the machine.

I asked what the high-level purpose of the project here is; is it to establish baseline performance and limits of the machine?

The goal here is:

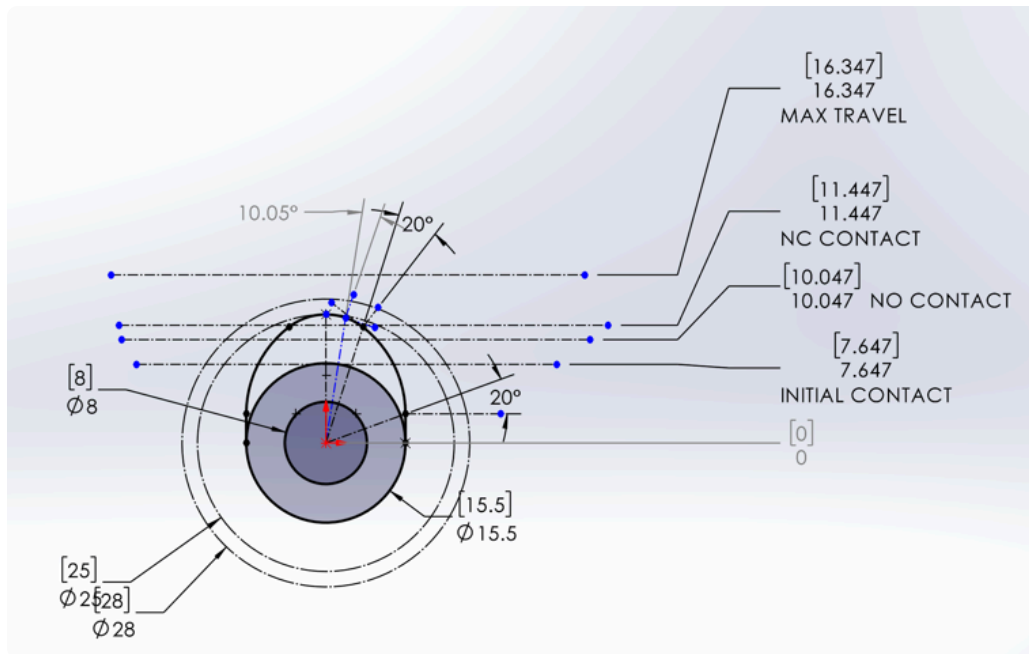
- Resolve issues to the point that a series of experiments can be conducted
- Plan a series of tests of increasing difficulty
 - Initially 50 no-cut layers
- Repeat each test 5 times in a row

Devin asked about whether we have a system in place for tracking problem resolutions to minimize work replication. Mohsen has started a document, but it is locally saved on his computer and therefore does not really exist. Marcus recommended he move it to Google Docs or Confluence so it is publicly available.

HOPPER/FLIP:

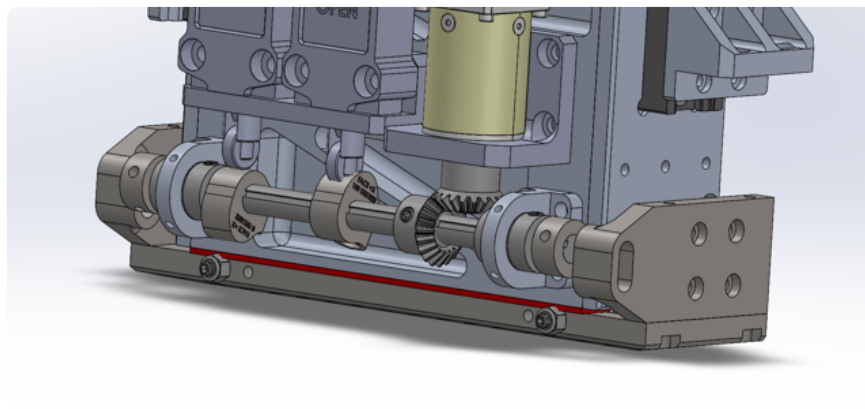
Working on the design of the cam for triggering the limit switches. I had Claude write up a cam design program with sliders to adjust the cam geometry.

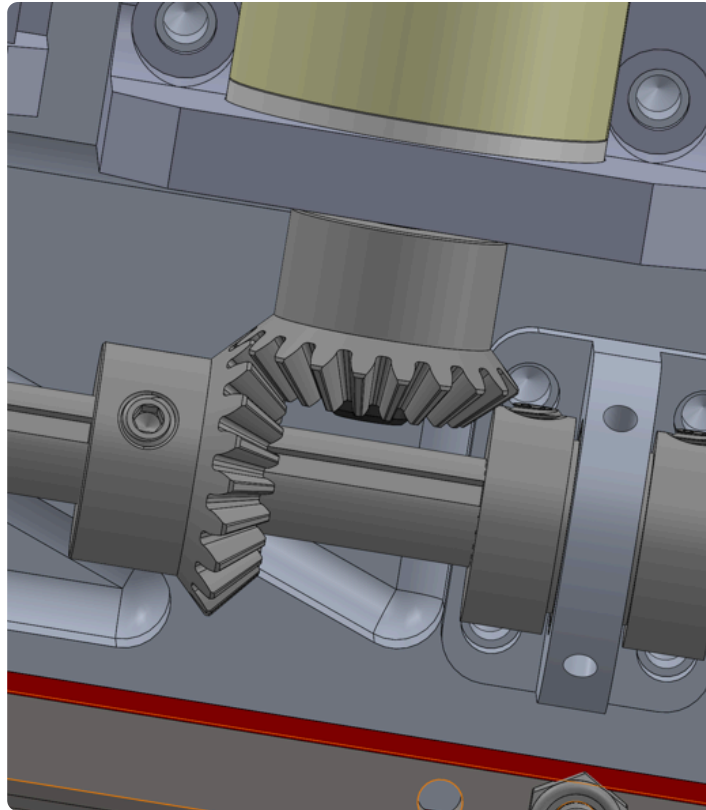
I generated a cam design based on lessons learned from the simulation program:



Now I am working on adding features to clamp it to the keyed shaft (easy) and adding locating features to lock it to the key (harder) and aligning everything so that the cams trigger the limit switches at the right gate positions and the clamping features don't crash into the limit switches (hard, the positions need to be shifted for the gate closed or gate opened relay, and installation orientation matters, which I hate).

On the upside, I remembered how to link the text in an extruded cut feature to the configuration of the model, so the text on the model automatically updates for each configuration without needing to make a different customized extruded cut feature for each configuration.



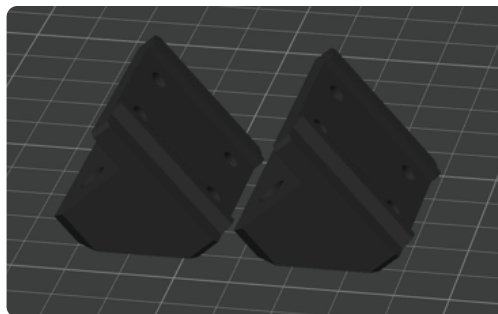


TO DO TODAY:

- Get together all the 3D printed part print files for the Epson printers
- Print some more U and V tank limit switch mounts for Pourya (make sure that they are the updated design, with the limit switch protruding farther from the mount to make sure that the mount cannot block the limit switch from being pressed. - DONE

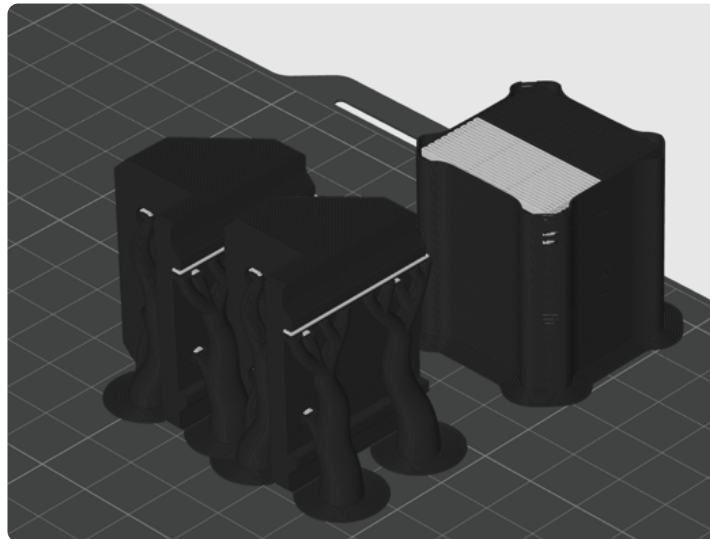
2026-04-07

HOPPER/FLIP: Printed 2X edmund stage mounts last night in a different orientation than usual:



I rarely use an angled orientation like this with FDM printed parts (as contrasted with SLA parts, where I almost always use an angled orientation) but with this particular FDM part, this orientation has the advantage of not needing supports, which add a lot of low-quality features to the mount where the supports interface. The parts came out better than they had with supports,

but there is some noticeable sagging where parts are printed at a shallow angle. I found a roll of support filament and ran a Benchy with it to test its condition since it had been out for a few years, but it still printed well. I am going to try printing two of these parts again in the standard orientation, but with every cantilevered feature supported by support material contacting the PETG-CF. This will require the AMS to switch between the two filaments on several layers, but this is exactly the use case the AMS was designed for. It looks like it also added a purge tower, in addition to the filament purge it will need to run every time it switches filament:



So it's definitely going to be dumping a lot of filament into the purge tower and out the poop chute, but it is a worthwhile sacrifice to make to make a high-quality part.

I machined the ends of the two linear rails so they are 50mm long; the standard size they come in is 55mm so I had to take 2.5mm off each end. I then used a rotary tool to add a chamfer around each machined edge; they come with a chamfer to prevent a burr from damaging or dislodging the linear bearing balls (I think) which the machining op I ran removed, so I needed to add a chamfer back by hand to make sure that I can install the linear bearing carriages safely.

The parts came out fairly well, although the support material was hard to remove. I suspect it may need to be dried to be more easily removable. I am printing a pair of bearing mounts using the same support material as an interface between the supports and the part; these parts are also hard to print in an optimal orientation without quality issues from supports.

I reamed out the bore on one of the bevel gears to 8mm (I am using an 8mm keyed shaft as the main camshaft but the stepper motor uses a 6mm output shaft, and the gear I needed to use was not available with 8mm and 6mm bores, so it was easiest to just buy 2X 6mm bore gears and bore out one of them). I also machined one of the shaft collars to reduce its width along the axis of the shaft; most of the shaft collars will fit in the stock OK stock, but the one closest to the bevel gear needs to be much narrower than stock so it will not interfere with the bevel gear.

I stupidly designed the limit switches to be mounted to the back panel with M5 screws for some reason, although the counterbores are sized for M4 screws (technically I think they're designed for some Imperial equivalent, but I'm going to use metric hardware regardless).

I drilled and tapped the threaded holes in all the 3D printed parts that have been printed so far. I found that IPA is a highly effective coolant/lubricant for tapping plastic; historically when I have tapped plastic the tap heats up quickly and can melt the threads instead of cutting them.

I cut down the 300mm shaft with the intent of making a 155mm shaft, but I accidentally cut in the wrong place, yielding a 150mm and a 145mm shaft. If it was time critical, it is possible to machine the ends of the two sections of shaft, weld them together, and turn down the weld to the nominal diameter, but since it is possible to wait a day for the shaft I have entered it in the latest McMaster order request (which also included two sheets of 301 vibration-resistant sheet metal in .005" and .003" thickness, as compared with the current .010" thickness (Mohsen asked for thinner sheet metal in the hopes that it will yield improved layer quality)).

PILOT:

U and V tank limit switch mounts finished printing for Pilot 6 or 7 (I don't remember exactly). I am currently washing them in the IPA filled washing unit.

Senai asked whether I am interested in changing the material or thickness of the base plate for Pilot 8. I asked him whether they want commonality between the printers and whether it is acceptable for the new base plate to be a different color than the older base plates (silver if it is made from stainless steel vs. the current black anodized aluminum).

I also asked: Do you know what the main application of Pilot 8 is planned to be? Is it cycle/stress testing that applies to the other Pilot printers, is it dedicated to production printing of 17-4 PH, is it dedicated to other materials (copper, inconel), is it dedicated to integrating and testing R&D subsystems, is it intended to go to a customer, or is it intended to be a first article for production of this style of printer?

Senai's response was as expected: we don't know what the printer is for. Probably R&D nonsense, but maybe copper. Regardless, nothing that changes the printer requirements from Pilots 6 and 7, and actually looser requirements because those printers were nominally intended to match the Epson printers for troubleshooting purposes (although they did not; the electrical systems, software, and safety systems have been changed radically as compared with the Epson printers due to changes driven by Ning and ZZ).

The ultimate conclusion of our conversation was that he will get prices for 1/2" and 1" aluminum and stainless steel ground sheets to compare the cost; if the cost of stainless steel is much higher then changing material will be a non-starter. If we do decide to go with a thicker

aluminum plate, some slight design changes will need to be made to accommodate the extra thickness. Also, any changes to the plate that make it heavier will necessitate adding lifting eyes to lift it into place.

GENERAL R&D:

I started another print of parts for Payman's gantry on the Bambu P2S; should take about 13 hours to finish.

As I understand it, the goal of Payman's gantry is to achieve the same level of functionality as the laser machine Mason is working on. Payman has developed his own hopper that he seems happy with and his own mist box that he seems happy with. The hopper is essentially a shaker-style hopper that shakes a door with a living hinge and has an always-open aperture, so it is dependent on the powder being non-flowable enough when not vibrated and flowable enough when it is vibrated. His mist box is essentially an occluded variant of the current mist box, that collects most of the mist on its internal passages and allows a line of mist to flow through, that he then sweeps across the surface to apply binder. It essentially replicates the functionality of a binder jetting head, but without the dot-matrix control. Fortunately our binder is cheap and non-toxic, or a design that wastes most of the binder by collecting it on walls would not be usable. It then uses a laser to cut the outline of the parts. Instead of spreading on a base plate that drops into square walls, the hopper just travels on top of a pile of powder.

My question is why is he pursuing all this stuff in parallel? Does he think his approach is superior to ours? And if so, why are we doing all the work we're doing?

2026-04-08

HOPPER/FLIP:

Most of the 3D printed parts that need to be tapped have been tapped, so I can start screwing stuff together. I am still missing a full-length shaft, so that will be a limiting factor, but there's plenty of stuff to work on before that gets here from McMaster. I also lost the limit switches, which need to be counterbored for M5 screws because I accidentally designed the hopper to use M5 screws instead of the M3 screws that the limit switches come sized for.

I dried the support filament overnight, and I am running another print of the bearing mounts. I am hoping that after drying the support filament the supports will be easier to remove instead of adhering to the PETG-CF somewhat as before.

I removed the new bearing holders, and it doesn't look like they're much easier to remove than the previous parts.

Mohsen noted issues with the gate not opening on Hopper V5.0. After removing the stepper motor, I found that the gate was binding and was difficult to move. I tried adjusting the gate and linear bushing mount positions, as well as cleaning out the polymer bushings, with little success. I wound up applying some MagnaLube grease to the polymer bushings, which shouldn't be necessary for these bushings and is risky because the grease may collect powder which could chew up the bushings or the shaft, but it seems to be the only way to get the gate actuating properly, and the hopper only needs to function for another week or two before HOPPER V5.1 comes online.

I assembled the body of the hopper, installed the limit switches, installed the bearing mounts after pressing the bearings into them, and installed the Edmund height/level adjustment stages. I realized that I need to redesign the cams to mount differently; right now they need to be slid onto the end of the shaft, which will make replacing them very difficult if they need to be swapped out for wear or to adjust the angle at which either of the limit switches trips.

PILOT:

Issues have been encountered on Pilot 6 and 7 with communication between the Pi and the Arduino used for environmental control, which for some reason kills the print. ZZ and Ning claimed it was due to interference, and after going back and forth a bunch of times over an email thread Ning said that one of the motors is causing interference that causes the Arduino to disconnect. Apparently the Arduino loses connection to the BME280 temperature and humidity sensors, which makes the Arduino restart, which interrupts communication with the Pi, which kills the print. I don't buy anything in the whole chain of reasoning or root cause analysis; it doesn't make sense to me that it is an interference issue unique to those machines when the hardware is nominally identical to the other machines. Ning really wants to eliminate the Arduino and run everything through the Pi, which to be fair is the right way to architect the system, but Ning seems to be mostly driven by an incorrect root cause analysis and a bigotry for using industrial components; he has been pushing heavily to not use non-industrial components like the Pi, the Arduino, or the Duet board, and has gone so far as to design a custom control board to use instead, which seems bonkers insane. Designing and testing a robust industrial-grade control board would take a huge amount of time and expense, even more so than switching to COTS industrial-grade hardware, which would already take significant money and time. To be fair, I do agree that if we are trying to make an industrial-grade machine using 3DEO's process, much like the Saffrons, and are willing to accept the increase in cost, then we should use COTS industrial-grade hardware and build the system around that. If, however, we want to keep costs much lower than the Saffrons, then our options are limited to making the printers with advanced hobbyist-grade components where possible, or contracting a machine manufacturer to develop

a custom low-cost machine, which would require a significant order volume to reach low costs (10s to 100s of thousands of units). When Ning brought up the fact that they had traced the interference to a particular motor, I recommended that we should fix that in addition to eliminating the Arduino.

GENERAL R&D:

Mason also has the same concerns that I do about Payman's gantry printer; namely, why are we working on anything else if he is happy with the performance of his setup? Particularly when, as far as I am aware, we have roughly 3 weeks of operating capital left?

2026-04-09

HOPPER/FLIP:

Working on the new cam design. I'm pivoting to a standard adjustable design that has a cam with a cutout so it can be slotted onto the shaft and an attached two-piece clamping feature to hold it to the shaft. This design has the advantage of being adjustable to enable fine setting of the trigger point of the limit switches, but therefore carries the disadvantage of adjustability, that it is more likely to slip than if it had a key printed into it, and it is possible for operators to adjust it to temporarily compensate for a more fundamental issue, instead of pursuing a permanent fix to the root cause.

I finished the design of the new cams and am printing 2X sets. I also cut a shaft to 155mm and polished it with some Scotch-Brite. I had intended to blue the shaft to give it some minor corrosion resistance, but it turns out that the bottle of bluing solution had completely evaporated, despite being tightly closed. Any rust on the shaft should be cosmetic and be unlikely to hinder the functionality of the hopper, but it may still be worth sourcing a stainless steel shaft for future hoppers for aesthetic reasons (I used a steel shaft for this version because that was the only 8mm keyed shaft available on McMaster). I also post-processed the new gate that had been printed last night using the removable support material, and it looks pretty good. The surface finish of the part where the support material interfaced is quite good, and it was not tremendously difficult to remove the support material. This gave me a chance to test out the strength of the previously printed gate, and it did quite well; I bent it to ~45 degrees and it did not break, and it was also possible to bend it back to its original shape so it was quite flat. The force it took to bend it that much was also quite high.

The set screws that came with the shaft collars I am using are too long; they extend past the OD of the shaft collars even when they are tightened into the keyway (they are cone point set screws so they extend into the keyway). Because of how much they extend out, they interfere with the socket head cap screws I am using to screw down the bearing mounts. They also have

the issue that, since they are M4 set screws, they will cut into the edges of the keyway (which is 2mm wide), which will make it difficult to slide out the shaft through the bearings if it needs to be removed.

PILOT:

Marcus sent an email to me and Senai reminding us about pulling together a file of all the 3D printed parts necessary for the Pilot printers that Epson has requested; they finally got a resin printer so they want the files in case they need to print replacement parts.

I generated STEP files for all the parts that Epson asked for and handed them off to Senai. I also made two small bottle cap files even though they only asked for one; there are two versions of the small bottle cap CAD, one with the word “flush” and one with the word “binder.”

2026-04-10

HOPPER/FLIP:

I have the core mechanicals of HOPPER V5.1 working, so now I need to connect the stepper motor to control it electrically and start trying out the limit switch cams. The risk there is that they are indirectly measuring the gate position; they trigger with the camshaft that then moves the gate forward and back, so if there is variation in the track roller position or if there is variation in the positioning of the limit switch cams (which is possible since they are clamping but not coupled to the keyway) then the trigger point relative to the gate position could shift.

Mohsen noted some issues with vibration on the hopper; when the vibrating hat vibration is turned up too high, the hopper body itself can start to vibrate, and vibration applied to the print by the spreader bar can dislodge parts in the cake.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

No-Depowdering:

Goal was to compare different orientations of parts during the thermal sacrificial filler removal process. 80 layer rectangle part prints were attempted: 2X with hatch facing and 2X with toolpath facing. The second print with hatch facing failed, as did another print where Pourya tried printing 3 rectangles per layer. The failed prints did complete, but there are anomalous cavities in the cake.

Broke out 4 copper parts and sectioned one. They will be given to Alex for sintering. There seem to be some issues with misalignment between the Mest unit and the cutting spindle, and a shift of only 30 microns can result in print failure. The copper machine currently uses a 3D printed mount for the Mest unit, which was known to result in the Mest shifting on the Pilot printers.

Marcus recommended making a machined mount for the Mest unit, and I agree that that would be beneficial.

Next week, Pourya plans to troubleshoot the issues seen and print more parts from 17-4PH. For copper, he plans to run prints with 4 parts in each print. Currently printed parts will be debound and sintered.

The thermal sacrificial removal cycle is programmed in the Keith furnace for copper parts, but the cycle for 17-4PH parts is done manually by leaving the parts in the 100C oven overnight and moving it to the 200C furnace for 2 hours.

Laser:

This week, Mason ran informal screening tests on the UV and CO2 lasers.

CO2 laser: Even optimized cut parameters produced a rounded cut profile; the smallest width achieved was 570 microns, and kerf angle was found to be roughly 66 degrees from vertical. On 316L, copper, and 17-4, adding water to the layer yielded clean cuts, although the cuts were still “u-shaped.” The exact formulation of water was unknown (tap, DI, etc.) His theory is that the cuts were always V shaped because of the mechanism of interaction between the laser and the layer; the wavelength of CO2 lasers (~10000 nm) is supposed to be absorbed by water only and not the metal powder.

UV laser: Able to create connected cuts with a depth of 230 microns and a width of 130 microns, and a kerf angle of 12 degrees. When using the UV laser on dry powder, less “sintering” was seen than is usually seen on a bound layer. Misting powder with water cause more “sintering” than is seen with a bound layer.

Marcus brought up pictures of parts that Payman has made on his gantry with a blue diode laser, and the results seem promising. Mason noted that the method of powder and binder application is very different on the Pilot printers than it is on Payman’s gantry.

Mason believes that the CO2 laser is least likely to be usable with our process.

Mason is going to try running some of the same tests with the MOPA laser, especially testing laser interaction with an uncured layer.

HOPPER:

Mohsen made 4 prints of TRS coupons, but none of them came out well. First print failed due to broken limit switch. After replacing the limit switch, he was unable to get a good spread, so he tried 3 different bar cleaning systems, tried pre-drying the powder, tried tripling the hopper vibration intensity. Noted that increasing the vibration beyond a certain intensity cause poor layer spreads. The hopper does not retain level position overnight, so the hopper needs to be

releveled before each print, necessitating that the spindle cut depth and the mist box level be adjusted. <Are the print quality issues due to the off-center powder loading?> <Also, recommend angling the metal sheet so it does not contact the side of the hopper.>

GENERAL:

Pourya pointed out that we are seeing issues that may be due to poor powder quality. We apparently still are not using a penetration depth test procedure for the Pilot printers. Devin recommends running a penetration depth test before each print and adjusting the binder volume accordingly. He noted that penetration values tend to shift during the year roughly following a sine wave. Increased porosity can also be resolved with increasing binder volume.

Mohsen is pushing back on that procedure, saying that there are fluctuations in penetration values and it is therefore not worth trying to chase that. It is true that it would be better to determine the root cause of penetration variation.

2026-04-13

HOPPER/FLIP:

It turns out that the machined parts were never ordered after all, so I will skip over making hopper 5.1 with machined parts and test it only with 3D printed parts, then order machined parts for hopper 5.2.

The cams are installed but already cracking, so I will need to redesign and reprint them.

In post-processing the guard that I printed over the weekend, I found that there is a weak point where the guard interfaces with the dovetail on the hopper body. I increased the material around that point, but it is inherently weak because of the print orientation.

I also found that the guard interferes with the screws that are used to mount the stepper motor and the limit switches, so it needs to be reprinted with a larger gap to clear those.

After installing the felt seals and reinstalling the gate, the gate is already bowing. I am sure that with powder added the bowing would be unacceptable. I am printing a new version that has a cutout in the bottom for gluing in a steel reinforcing rib, although it occurs to me now that having a reinforcing rib in the top might be better because it would be less likely to fall out if the glue joint fails.

I put in an order request for a piece of 1/8" X 1" 4140 ground steel stock and a 12" long piece of 1.5" diameter ceramic-coated aluminum shaft. Since the diameter of that shaft is 1.5" instead of the 30mm diameter I am currently using in my design (1.181") I would need to either change my hopper design and reprint some parts or machine down the shaft so it has flats on three sides, and hope that the slightly larger radius of the contact surface doesn't impact the layer.

I adjusted the design of the cams by decreasing the gap between the cam and clamp components as well as increasing the diameter of the clamping cylinder from 24 to 25mm, which should give more material to the outside of the part where it broke previously.

I am printing a modified design of the spreader bar (cutouts added) and the original version of the gate from clear SLA material. An SLA printed spreader bar will have improved surface finish as compared with the FDM version, although still not as good as a polished shaft. It is also unclear whether the SLA part or the FDM part would have improved powder adhesion properties; I could imagine either one being stickier and having a greater tendency to hold powder. My sense is that in order of maximum to minimum stickiness it would go: SLA resin - FDM PETG-CF - machined stainless steel - polished ceramic coated aluminum, but frankly powder tends to stick to everything so I'm not sure it matters much. On the Bambu X1E with support filament, I am printing a new -Y direction guard with the improvements discussed above as well as a gate with a cutout for gluing in the 4140 steel part mentioned above. Between this version and the SLA gate I am hoping that I will have at least one gate that is usable for testing, but it is possible that it will be necessary to have one machined in the end.

Pilot Stabilization Meeting:

BME data is still not being recorded.

Ning thinks that the Arduino-Pi communication is being caused by poor isolation of components.

There are two communication issues: the Pi-Duet SPI communication fails periodically, and the Pi-Arduino issue communication fails periodically.

Only Pilot 7 has seen the SPI communication issues.

Laser Meeting:

Results from UV laser: single cut: 310 micron deep, 100 micron wide cut, kerf angle is 7.73 micron over 310 micron. Debris field when hatching seems to be more loose powder than melted material. For single width cuts, he is finding that a single pass never cuts through to the previous layer, but more passes (he tried 2 and 3) always cuts through. For the single width cuts, before brushing it out he found that the material in the cut had variable height, but was fairly even after brushing out the powder.

Diode laser arriving tomorrow morning

2026-04-14

GENERAL:

I asked Rajan if we were going to have enough money to make an industrialized pilot (mainly to make the point that I support doing so and that the reason I did not do so originally was because of cost constraints) and his answer was essentially “no one knows.” Mason talked to me after Rajan went to the big technical/strategy meeting, and said that it was not a reassuring answer on Rajan’s part; I hadn’t really made the connection at the time but Rajan’s answer was also about the future of the company. Mohsen also said that there is a board meeting planned later in the month, so this technical/strategy meeting is likely focused on what to show the board to convince them to fund us further. This board meeting is likely where they will decide whether 3DEO will continue to stay in business. I don’t really have enough information to make an informed answer of whether we should or not. We are focusing mainly on the heat sink market, which is indeed a growing market assuming that AI data centers are built at the rate that is currently predicted. However, there are many other companies focused on selling heat sinks, some 3D printed, some conventionally manufactured, so we will need to provide an advantage over those companies to get some significant contracts. This could be in the form of a proprietary heat sink design, advantages in material properties, or unique capabilities in terms of geometries that can be printed, assuming that the no-depowdering and laser processes can be made to work.

HOPPER/FLIP:

Without the machined gate, I am working on two possible approaches to making a sufficiently rigid gate from 3D parts. One is to use a printed SLA gate, which should be more rigid than the FDM parts, or an FDM part reinforced with a steel bar.

I did some hand calcs for the steel bar, and I predicted a deflection of ~ 0.0013 ” with 4kg of powder loaded uniformly. Since the bottom of the gate is 0.020” above the spreader bar contact line, if the gate only deflects 1.3 thou it should clear the powder.

I noticed after installing the latest cover design that there is an opening towards the -Y side at the bottom. This opening was originally intended to provide clearance for the hard stops installed in the gate, but since I am planning on eliminating those, it makes sense to close up that opening as much as possible.

The SLA gate and SLA spreader bar finished printing and cleaning with IPA, and are now curing. They should be ready for post-machining within an hour or so. The metal reinforcing bar will be here either today or tomorrow, likely along with the ceramic-coated aluminum shaft. The SLA parts had some visible lines that I suspect may have been due to sticking of the FormLab printer’s gantry; it may be due for another MagnaLube lubrication.

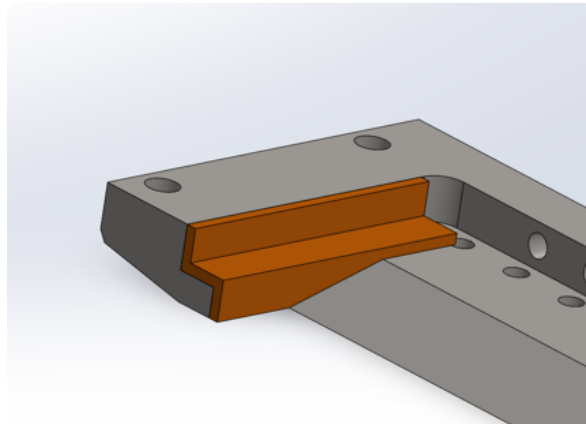
The precision-ground pre-hardened 4140 strip (1/8" X 1") arrived, so I cut a piece of it, degreased it, scuffed it with scotch-brite, degreased it again, and epoxied it to the FDM gate with the appropriate cutout in the bottom.

2026-04-16

HOPPER/FLIP:

The FDM gate with an epoxied steel strip is cured; I had to remove some squeezout on the bottom with a scalpel but other than that it should be good to go.

Because it is such a pain to make felt side seals for the gate (I have to cut three separate small strips for each side, one of which on each side has a narrow angle on it, and stick them to the gate), I am designing a new seal that is a single piece of cast urethane. Once I have a mold made, I can cast them and super glue them onto each gate iteration. The downside is that there will need to be a right-handed and a left-handed version.



I removed the supports from the latest guard and cams, and they seem good so far. I printed an SLA gate with a cutout for epoxying in a steel reinforcing strip, cleaned off the residual resin with the Form Wash and a manual post-cleaning with sprayed IPA and compressed air, and it is currently curing. Between the SLA material and the steel strip, I think it should be stiff enough for actual printing. I also designed and am printing a positive mold for making the silicone mold that I will then use to cast urethane seals for the gate. For initial testing, I printed FDM parts with the same dimensions as the urethane seals and super glued them to the FDM steel-reinforced gate. I am concerned about the steel reinforcing strip; I chose to use pre-hardened 4140 because it is available from McMaster in a precision ground state and provides a very stiff reinforcement to the gate as long as it is properly attached (hence my careful preparation for epoxying it with DP420 epoxy, as well as the choice of DP420 since it is a very strong industrial-grade epoxy (although now that I think about it, it is possible that DP420 is not compatible with plastics, and therefore may not form a sufficiently strong bond between the steel strip and the printed gate. It seems OK so far, but it bears further inspection and research))), but it has the

disadvantage of being susceptible to rust. Looking up the specs for DP420, it is supposed to adhere to “some plastics,” but clearly is not guaranteed to adhere to all plastics. With FDM PETG-CF and clear SLA material I have yet to see any issues with adhesive adhesion, but it is a risk, particularly because the consequences of the bond failure are severe (the steel strip with drop off the hopper, becoming FOD in the path of the hopper, heater, mist box, and spreader bar, and if angled up sufficiently could damage the X or Z axes, or possibly damage the Y axes by jamming gantry motion).

I cleaned up the support attachment points on the SLA gate using a scalpel, then cut a new reinforcing strip and epoxied it in place. It is now curing, and should be ready to have seals installed tomorrow, however, the seal casting mold will not be done until tomorrow so seals will not be ready until the weekend or Monday.

Did a pour of silicone into a 3D printed mold to make a silicone mold for making the urethane gate side seals. Installed and adjusted the newly designed cams, and the new ones still cracked. I found that the tabs on the -Y side guard that the +Y side guard slots into interfere with the linear carriage mounts; it is still possible to install the guard but it takes some bending and will likely eventually result in the tab features failing. I connected hopper V5.1 to Pilot 2, and it was able to open and close, but I found that it is only responding to the limit switch when the gate is closing, even though pressing either limit switch causes the A axis endstop switch indicator to light up. My theory is that this is due to the Duet only being able to home in 1 direction, so even with the H1 modifier on the G1 command, it will not respond to the limit switch being pressed. My plan is to wire up the limit switches separately; I will set the gate closed limit switch as the homing switch for the A axis and wire up the gate open limit switch to a spare output and make a conditional loop that opens the gate until it detects that switch. This will also give me a chance to clean up the wiring; there are a bunch of wires and connectors and nonsense that have caused issues in the past when things were disconnected or connected to the wrong device.

2026-04-17

HOPPER/FLIP:

The SLA printed gate with a steel reinforcing strip epoxied to it is ready to go, although it does not yet have seals. The silicone mold for making urethane seals is ready, but the urethane takes 24 hours to fully cure so I won't have it ready today.

R&D Weekly Meeting:

To Do:

- **Work on machined metal mount for the Mest unit on the Saffron printer for copper no-depowdering**
 - DESIGN COMPLETE, ORDER REQUEST PLACED 2026-04-21 NEED TO CONFIRM ORDER PLACED
 - I sent two order requests from SendCutSend: One with only the sheet metal parts, one with the sheet metal and machined parts
- **Get HOPPER V5.1 installed on Pilot 2 and fully operational**
 - MOHSEN INSTALLING 2026-04-21
 - Installed 2026-04-21
 - Installed and damaged from crash 2026-04-22
 - Repaired and given to Ben to install 2026-04-23. Printed some SLA parts to install for heat resistance, starting a print for the rest (motor and limit switch mounts).
- **Work on vibrating hat vibration isolation**
 - Conducting research 2026-04-23
- **Design new hopper/order machined parts**
 - Completed design and entered a purchase request for the machined parts 2023-04-23
 - Done 2023-04-23
 - Order placed 2026-04-23, estimated ship date 2026-05-12
- **Tighten locking screw on height adjustment stages to prevent position loss**
 - Tightened down the dovetail to increase friction and added back in an M3 screw to lock down the adjustment stage
 - Done 2026-04-22

No Depowdering:

P6 SVP: Originally used StoneVac, but it was too weak, so Pourya switched to P1's vacuum, but it was too weak for the facing bit, so he dropped the facing bit height, and redid the hoses. That worked, but P1's vacuum burned out, so he switched back to the StoneVac. The facing spindle's SVP was vacuuming up powder, causing holes at the edges of the print, so he raised the SVP.

Marcus pointed out that it may be beneficial to have independent flow and height control.

Payman pointed out that they used to have adjustable restrictor valves on each SVP opening (many years ago). I agree that it would be beneficial to have a restrictor valve of some sort on each line, and possibly electrical ball valves to switch the vacuum to each spindle on and off.

Currently the SOP is to have the facing tool bit follow the same path as the small end mill, instead of following a standard facing operation.

Ran various tests with varying degrees of success; some prints failed, some of the results were meaningless because the THC either turned off or stayed in a fixed state (constant TEC power, constant dry air injection).

Per Pourya, the end mill being used for facing was inspected yesterday and seemed both clean and sharp (inspected with the MicroVu).

No pen test macro yet, Mohsen is working on it.

In process of sintering some copper parts (sintering run will not be run until Monday). Ran some other copper prints with different parameters.

Laser:

Mason showed UV laser cutting results with AEM-like geometry. Features do not seem to be very well defined (looking at the cross section) when a 3D scan is conducted, but visually they seem to be present.

Due to the oval shape of the laser spot, cuts in the X direction tend to be narrower and deeper than cuts in the Y direction. This could be resolved with a diode laser with improved optics, only cutting in the X direction, physically rotating the laser 45 degrees so the X and Y direction cuts are the same width, or compensating for it within the control system (tricky to do because the number of passes is limited, maybe adjust power/speed?) When the laser hits dry powder, it causes much more “sintering” as compared with the UV laser, although the phenomenon with the UV laser is not completely unknown. He noted that the “sintering” behavior seems much worse when a cake is left out for a while (presumably due to decreasing moisture content of the cake). The temperature of the cake was increased significantly (recorded temp ~75C, ~50C increase from ambient) while the UV laser tends to increase the cut temperature by ~5C.

When trying to perform cuts in copper with the diode laser, Mason found that it tended to melt/sinter the copper without removing the material.

UV laser is being installed on Pilot 3 today.

Misc:

Mohsen working on the pen test macro.

Marcus/Dong/Midhun/Mohsen working with Argonne National Lab to put together a grant proposal for modulating porosity for thermal applications. Goal is also to leverage their AI models for some DFAM-type stuff on our side.

Marcus raised the point that he has been discussing with Sean the idea of changing the test geometry of the no-depowering process to be closer to geometries seen in real parts.

2026-04-20

HOPPER/FLIP:

Cast urethane seals should have cured over the weekend. After installing those, the SLA steel-reinforced gate should be sufficient for initial testing. The spreader bar is made from SLA material, so I may need to machine a new one from the ceramic-coated shaft stock that I received last week. Since it has an OD of 1.5" it will need to be redesigned slightly as compared with the current spreader bar design; the easiest approach is to machine it so that it has three flat sides and one side is left round.

In trying to run some cams and cam clamps from PAHT-CF several times today, I keep running into an issue where the printer shuts down while it is laying down lines for calibration of extrusion. This is apparently a known issue with X1Es that is commonly due to failure of the power switch; I also did a quick check of the power switch. When the printer shuts down, the power switch stays on but its built in light turns off. I pressed the power switch on the "on" side, and the light flashed a bit on and off. This suggests that even when the switch is nominally in the "on" position, there is a failed connection somewhere that is reconnected by pressing on the switch.

MOSP:

I am continuing to work on a metal mount for the Mest unit. My current design approach is to have two machined dovetails for slotting into the Saffron spindle stages, along with two bent sheet metal components to link these two dovetails and join them to the Mest unit.

Pilot Stabilization Meeting:

Main question is whether Ning should disassemble and rewire Pilot 7 (estimate is that it will take 2 weeks).

Ning wants to isolate the negative return lines of the DC power supplies on Pilot 7.

THC on Pilot 7 is unreliable and there are issues with it failing to log data.

Ning says that one issue is the connection between the Arduino and Pi (claimed to be due to non isolated power supplies).

The Pi-Duet connection works on Pilot 6, but the Pi-Arduino has connectivity issues on both printers.

Payman asked whether there is a quick way to get Pilot 6 and 7 working.

Pourya pointed out that the Pi-Duet connection works on Pilot 6.

Points I think I made:

These issues do not seem to be present on Pilots 1-5, which all have the negative lines of the DC power supplies connected.

Every industrial system I have made, the Beta machines, and the Saffron printers all have the negative line of different DC power supplies connected.

Relevant Information:

I have so far not found any industrial standards that say that every DC power supply should be isolated

There are instances where circuits should be isolated:

- You want systems to be able to be turned off or have a fault without shutting down the entire system
- You have high voltage systems that need to be isolated from low voltage DC circuits for safety reasons
- Analog systems that are sensitive to noise
- Intrinsically safe systems that need to be isolated
- Instances where one negative line is measuring a process potential
- Very long cable runs where a ground loop can form

Ning asked me to make a DIN rail mount for the large relay board that he is working on installing.

I designed the DIN rail mount and a cover for the board and started them printing on HAMMER.

The print on HAMMER failed for some reason. It did prompt me to turn on some kind of glob management detection or something, which printed a small square off to the side of the main print. I stopped the print, cleaned everything off, double checked that the nozzle was not clogged, and restarted the print with standard settings, and so far it seems to be running fine.

Laser Meeting:

Payman asked Mason about switching laser development to copper only. There is also a meeting tomorrow between Marcus, Alex, and Payman to discuss switching all development efforts to copper. Mason has had difficulty cutting the build and not melting the copper powder. He is in the process of installing the UV laser in Pilot 3. He has had to order a new F-Theta lens to install in the UV laser because the focal length was too short to be able to fit the laser in Pilot 3 (originally 210mm, new 254mm).

2026-04-21

HOPPER/FLIP:

I glued the urethane side seals to the gate yesterday and the look fairly good, although one side is a little tight against the spreader bar and the other side has a small gap, so there will be some leakage from that side. I showed Mohsen the functioning of the new hopper, tested with him that it does nothing when it is commanded to open when already open or commanded to close when it is already closed. He pointed out the gate is flat, without the shallow chamfered edges designed into the machined part. I had to make this current version of the gate this way because it is 3D printed, so I designed it with as much material as possible and epoxied in a strip of pre-hardened 4140 steel to reinforce it.

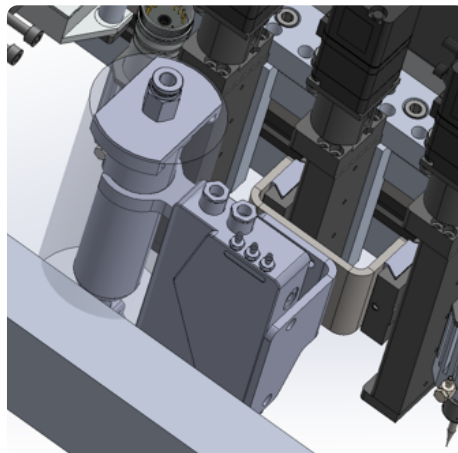
Now that Hopper V5.1 is installed in Pilot 2, I am working on completing the design of V5.2 and getting the parts on order ASAP so Protolabs can get started working on them, then I will come back and work on optimizing the vibration application system.

PILOT:

The mount and cover for the 16 relay board finished printing last night, so I installed some heat set inserts and gave the parts to Ning to install in Pilot 7.

MOSP:

I placed an order request for a SendCutSend sheet metal order for parts for the metal Mest mount.



The design I am making uses two sheet metal parts bolted together with a pair of machined dovetails that drop into the Saffron spindle stages.

I got a custom quote back from SendCutSend with the CNC machined aluminum dovetails, and they charge way less than ProtoLabs or Xometry with a much faster lead time, so I submitted the order request for that new whole order, that also includes the sheet metal parts.

2026-04-22

GENERAL R&D:

Pourya is having issues with his visa, so he is going to be offsite for an unknown amount of time. In the meantime, he is transferring knowledge to Mohsen to take over the no-depowdering experiments.

HOPPER/FLIP:

The HOPPER V5.1 was installed on Pilot 2, but had issues with leveling, and when Mohsen tried to run some layers it crashed into something, breaking the SLA spreader bar, the cover, the SLA gate, and the 3D printed mounts. The cover can be omitted for now, I gave Ben the FDM printed gate I had made with a steel reinforcing strip epoxied to it, and the mounts are being swapped out for the machined ones from the previous hopper, and I am printing an FDM spreader bar to use temporarily. I am designing a monolithic -Y panel that will be printed from high-temperature SLA material to enable the hopper to be used with the heater. I am experimenting with incorporating an isogrid pattern into the wall to minimize resin usage and weight while maintaining strength.

The downside to the isogrid pattern is that it takes a long time to set up (although I did finally figure out how to create and insert blocks, so that helps a lot) and a lot of processing power for SolidWorks to generate the geometry, so it takes a lot of time to create the features, about 1/3 of which is taken up by waiting.

I designed a new back panel and spreader bar to be 3D printed with the same mounting locations but as much material removed as possible by applying isogrid cutouts, and I am printing them along with two new bearing holders and two new cam cam/clamp pairs. This should make most of the hardware facing the heater fairly heat-resistant.

2026-04-23

HOPPER/FLIP:

The repaired Hopper V5.1 is ready to be put back together (the newly FDM printed spreader bar needs to be installed) and installed in the machine. It should function OK, although the FDM parts mean that it is likely not heat resistant enough to be operated next to the heater. The FormLabs printer ran out of clear resin last night 13 minutes before the print was complete, so I installed the other resin cartridge we have around to finish the print. Since the cartridge is only partly full, I entered an order request for another one. I couldn't fit the limit switch mount and motor mount on the FormLabs print, so I need to print those next after this print has been removed from the build plate.

I am working on the design of HOPPER V5.2 with the intent of finishing the design and getting the parts ordered today.

It occurred to me that since the hopper length is defined by the position of the cam shaft and since the position of the cam shaft is set by the motor width, I could move the shaft closer to the body of the hopper by either sinking the motor into the body (which would require a redesign of the vibrating hat, which already has enough issues without adding more constraints to design around (although sometimes adding design constraints can help if it forces you to change your thinking of the design)) or by angling the stepper motor outwards. This would make machining the hopper back panel from a single piece of aluminum more difficult, but I'm not sure if that would be reflected in the price because I'm pretty sure they use standard blocks of aluminum in a 5 axis mill anyway. Either way it would add design time without adding significant value, but it is worth considering for a future version if space becomes a greater constraint.

I realized that since I had moved the motor over to shrink the central mount structure as much as possible, the motor now interfered with the vibrator motor, so I had to move it over ~7mm, which means that it is now farther from the center, assuming a two-weight motor is used. If a single-weight ERM (eccentric rotating mass) motor is used, its weight will actually now be closer to the center of the vibrating hat than it was before.

I did some research on vibration isolation and damping vibrations with tuned mass dampers (those big moving weights used in buildings, they're also apparently used all over cars and compound bows. Tuned mass dampers are focused on damping a narrow frequency range, which could be useful if the vibrator motor is going to be run at a known RPM. I could mount a custom TMD to the hopper body that would help to damp vibrations at that frequency.

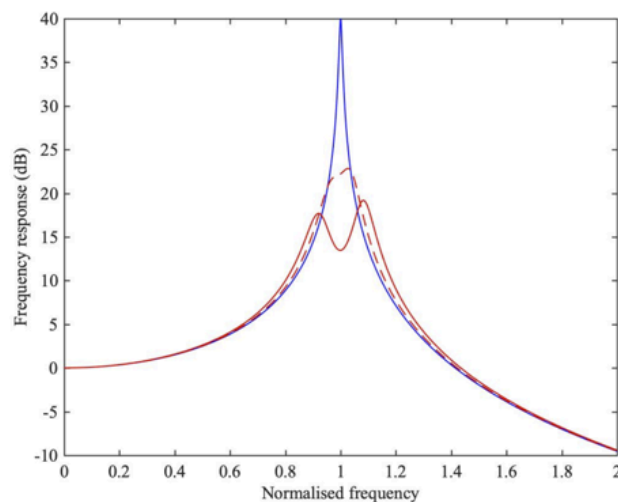


Figure 3. Driving-point frequency responses on the mass m_1 of the system shown in Fig. 1. The blue curve shows the original system without the TMD. The two red curves show the effect of TMDs with two different mass ratios ϵ .

The response curve after adding a TMD is interesting; you get a double spike around the target frequency. Those spikes are still both lower than the original undamped magnitude, but the

behavior could be relevant if the damping needs to be maximized.

2026-04-24

HOPPER/FLIP:

The rotating duct mount on the cartridge dock broke, so I am printing a new one. I am also going to order some more of the duct hose we've been using, along with some other hoses to try with smoother interiors (the corrugated hose duct we're already using does have a nominally smooth interior, but there is a bit of ribbing still due to the nature of the metal hose spiral).

Mohsen has begun spreading layers with the 3D printed V5.1 hopper, and has noticed some issues. One issue is that the gate was not closing completely because the spreader bar had been installed tilted; fortunately, this is a problem that is already somewhat solved with the new spreader bar design, although now that I think about it is still prone to angling if it is not pressed against the bottom surface when tightening the screws. Mohsen also noticed some powder leakage between the side panels and the front and back panels. I suspect this is due to the flexibility of the 3D printed components used, and the fact that they are only clamped down by 2 screws. With machined parts this should hopefully not be an issue, but it does bear monitoring; it may be necessary to seal the panels with a FIP gasket or similar when assembling. Mohsen also believes that vibration of the hopper is causing issues with the layer. I recommended reducing the vibration motor power due to the decreased weight of the hopper, but I think the root cause is the vibrating hat is contacting the stepper motor, bypassing the vibration isolator and conducting vibrations directly to the hopper body. I am going to redesign and reprint the vibrating hat, which actually should have been done a while ago because the powder level sensor holder that makes it possible to keep the sensor triggered even if the hopper is not full of powder is undersized for the current sensor holder (I designed it for the bare sensor, but the sensor is now screwed into a holder that increases the outer diameter).

I printed and installed a PAHT-CF rotating hose duct adapter for the cartridge dock and gave it to Ben to reinstall.

Placed a McMaster order request for 4 more feet of the current hose duct and 4 feet each of two other styles of hose duct to see if a hose duct with a smoother interior provides better powder flow.

R&D Weekly Meeting:

TO DO:

- **Track the status of metal Mest mount components**
 - Done, assembly complete and installed pending testing by Pourya 2026-04-29

- **Track the status of machined parts for HOPPER V5.1**

- Ordered 2026-04-23
- “Order Review” on 2026-04-30
- “Order Review” status shown on 2026-05-01

- **Experiment with removing PEG with IPA**

- Immersed one of two 17-4PH green parts and one copper part in 99.9% IPA solution 4:00 2026-04-30
- Left them overnight, and the parts partially eroded
- The exposed PEG on the copper part seemed partially dissolved, but was not completely gone

- **Install SLA parts into HOPPER V5.1**

- **Try installing metal spreader bar on V5.1 (transfer from V5.0)**

- Done, modified metal spreader bar by TIG welding the side holes and machining new ones that are compatible with V5.1

- **Print out/assemble a model of HOPPER V5.2**

No-Depowdering:

Tested different tool bit heights (to adjust height of SVP opening). The goal was to minimize sucking up features (chipping?) while also removing all PEG fragments cut by the facing end mill.

To address a chipping issue, he increased the binder volume by 10%. Chipping of one part at the end was seen, possibly due to measured low humidity (28% RH).

On the copper no-depowdering printer, increasing the PEG droplet size improved print quality (?) but did not solve the issue (?) completely. The facing G code used previously left some PEG on the layer (possibly due to weak vacuum). He is updating the G code to face beyond the outside of the part boundary, it previously was only facing right to the edge, which may have been the cause of residue seen right at the edge.

He is going to work on matching the Saffron hardware to the Pilot hardware: larger facing end mill, matched spindle RPM (currently the Saffron spindle is running at ~60K RPM and the dental spindle on the Pilot printers is running at ~35K RPM (I think).

Laser:

Experimenting with copper. Cleaned out Pilot 3 along with Cisco and Alex and Ben for copper service. Was able to make cuts on copper with the diode laser in the printer when it was not possible with benchtop testing. Also tried the MOPA laser, which seemed to be a more robust

process (a wider range of parameters was able to yield good results). Differences here vs earlier testing: make copper layers on pilot (earlier saffron), remove layers more quickly, curing layers less than earlier, increased binder volume and soak time. <Payman said that there will be a project dedicated to copper printing on Pilots>. He was able to make a melted layer with the diode laser. The diode laser was unable to hatch layers without fusing the powder.

Plans to redo the screening tests with cakes from the Pilot instead of the Saffron. Eliminating the diode laser due to issues with hatching. Plan is to test with the MOPA and the UV laser, and possibly the CO2 laser (unlikely).

Accretech:

Still in proposal stage. They were excited about CleanPrint because they want a monolithic copper plate (300mm OD). Currently want all-copper but not necessarily single piece part.

2026-04-27

HOPPER/FLIP:

Ben pulled HOPPER V5.2 and removed its spreader bar and also pointed out some powder leakage issues where some of the panels interface.

The metal spreader bar from HOPPER V5.1 is not directly compatible with V5.2 because it uses dowel pins for alignment and has threaded holes in a different position. I can design some new side panels to be compatible with the spreader bar, or weld up the holes and machine some new threaded holes. Probably printing new side panels is the easier and faster way to go.

After looking at the V5.1 side panels, it is not really feasible to modify them to be compatible with the V5.0 spreader bar, because the flat head screw countersinks interfere with one of the screws being used to mount down the linear rail. I have instead decided to weld up the holes on the ends of the spreader bar, machine them flat, then drill and tap holes for the M3 screws. I have successfully welded and machined one side, but when I machined the other side it cut through the weld and exposed two of the holes before reaching final dimensions, so I rewelded that side (spending more time with a lower power setting to increase penetration) and plan to face it off tomorrow.

Mohsen will be transferring to no-depowdering and I will be moving to hopper testing, as expected.

Finished designing new vibration isolator upper and lower parts and inner and outer mold walls. I increased the height of the cast rubber and also added some cutouts to the inside of the isolator to reduce the cross sectional area of the vibration isolator to make it softer.

Pilot Baseline Stabilization:

No prints run since last week.

Ning noticed last week that Pilot 6 does not match Pilot 3, so he is trying to match Pilot 6 to Pilot 3. He is going through and trying to isolate power supply negatives.

Per Pourya, Ning created a standalone environmental controller on Pilot (6?).

Marcus asked a question about why USB cables have a negative line tied together if negatives need to be separated.

The nominal plan for Pilot 6 is to have the THC operated by a laptop connected to the Arduino.

The Raspberry Pi controlled THC concept is not ready to go yet, so ZZ will have to work on it in parallel.

Ning's plan for the Pi-Duet communication is to add an RC filter on the ground line connecting the two.

Copper No-Depowdering:

Since Friday, the end mill was replaced because Cisco discovered chipping on the bit.

Apparently there is also an issue with the G code where the Saffron printers do not recognize semicolons as commenting out a line, so the print failed on layer 2.

Mohsen will be taking over because Pourya is going to be gone for visa issues.

Received all the sheet metal and machined parts for the metal Mest mount. Permanently assembled the two sheet metal parts (one is tapped, and I used 4X M5X8 SHCS with lock washers and red Loctite). Loosely assembled the aluminum dovetails to the sheet metal assembly with 6X M5X10 SHCS with stainless lock washers.

Showed the assembly to Pourya. Plan is to work with Cisco to install it on the copper Saffron printer tomorrow.

2026-04-28

MOSP:

Tried installing the assembly, and the dovetail positioning is off (spindle spacing is different from the CAD model I was working off of). I first tried adding some spacers to one of the dovetails, but the precision required to get the positioning exactly right in such a way that it does not cause the spindles to fight each other is high enough that I am concerned about the amount of time it will take to get it dialed in. There is also an issue with poor access to the SHCS that

attach the sheet metal to the dovetails; it is very difficult to tighten them in place, which would be very helpful for getting alignment exactly correct.

Instead of the rigid setup I have right now, I mounted down one of the aluminum dovetails permanently as well aligned with the two brackets as possible (when screwing together the brackets, I rested them on a granite surface plate, and I also rested the assembly on the same surface when screwing down the dovetail to get it aligned as well as possible). I used lock washers and red Loctite to hold this dovetail in place permanently. The dovetail I chose to mount permanently was the one closer to the center of gravity of the Mest unit. For the other dovetail, I am printing a new dovetail from PETG-CF with increased height to eliminate the need for spacers, and since it is FDM printed it will have some compliance in it to prevent the stages from fighting each other, but it should help to take some of the torque load off of the stage attached to the aluminum dovetail.

HOPPER/FLIP:

The parts for the new vibration isolator finished printing , so I should be able to do a cast this afternoon after spraying the walls heavily with mold release and hot gluing the bottom plate to the mold sides. The procedure will be to pour in urethane with the top panel off so there is full access to the entire mold, then press the top panel into the top of the mold, squeezing out any excess urethane. This approach is much easier, faster, and less likely to introduce bubbles in the vibration isolation rubber, but increases the difficulty of cleanup because of the urethane squeezeout.

I finished modifying the metal spreader bar from HOPPER V5.0 to be compatible with HOPPER V5.1. The weld plugging I did did not penetrate far on one side, so the hole I tried to make to tap M3 threads broke into another hole that was present before weld plugging, which made it impossible to tap good threads. The other three holes, though, got about 3-4mm of solid metal to tap into, which should be OK for holding the spreader bar in shear. The thread tearout strength will be sub-optimal; the rule of thumb is at least two diameters worth of threads, which in this case would be 6mm of threaded depth for an M3 screw.

PILOT:

Ning is continuing to work on the electronics of Pilots 6 and 7. He is trying to make a completely isolated environmental control system using an Inkbird controller from Amazon, which he claims is “industrial.” He is also recommending eliminating the I2C BME280 sensors in favor of RS485 sensors, which I agree is a good idea, although he also recommended Amazon sensors, which I have little faith in the accuracy of.

We really should be figuring out the goal architecture of the Pilots before digging into any of this nonsense. Here are a few possibilities I can think of:

- Open-source, low-cost R&D platform
 - The need to reduce costs forces us to use hobbyist COTS control systems and components
 - This is the motivation for using a Raspberry Pi and Duet board in SBC mode
 - All control should be done with the Pi and Duet, to simplify the system, reduce part count, hence reducing cost, and provide centralized control
- Productized low-cost system
 - Same architecture, with wiring polished up a bit to mitigate noise and make assembly and wiring easier
- Productized high-cost system
 - Change to an industrial grade control/electronics architecture
 - Essentially a simplified duplicate of the Saffron printers
 - Hire an outside dedicated machine manufacturer for consulting on the design
 - Hire necessary experts for electrical design and programming
 - Hire industrial designer to make an aesthetically pleasing and functional exterior
 - Inerted with gas recycling system and environmental controls (easiest way is to contract an outside company to make a drop-in system or integrate a system into our printer)
- Productized low-cost system
 - All the electronics will need to be designed from scratch, closer to a Bambu printer than the Saffrons
 - Work with a Chinese machine manufacturer to design and mass-produce an inexpensive and reasonably reliable system

The open-source and hobbyist-grade systems are most suitable for internal R&D because they are easy to modify and reprogram, while the industrial grade or Bambu grade printers are better suited for production because they will need to be a large order of identical machines with stabilized electronics and software.

Accretech Brainstorm:

Making a wafer testing machine with a vacuum chuck to hold down the wafer and heat and cool it and a probe card that comes down from above. The vacuum chuck has integrated heating and multi-point temperature measuring probe. A force of 520 kgf per 25X25mm area is applied to the wafer. 150 W/cm². 0.003 micron flatness.

Their proposal with CleanPrint:

3DEO flow channels, side ports for sensors, wafer suction, electroless nickel plating, polished surface.

Heaters on bottom.

W/Out CleanPrint:

Wafer suction mechanism w/side holes for sensors

Heater

3DEO flow channels

They were initially asking for a monolithic 12" diameter cooling plate.

They do already make probing machines.

The performance gains they are looking for are likely decreased cycle time through faster heating and cooling, but this is Marcus' conjecture.

My favorite approach is to print a bunch of copper pieces and electron beam weld them together. Maybe have a machined upper and lower cup and fill it with CleanPrinted cartridges (Slugs? Blocks? Blanks?).

2026-04-29

HOPPER/FLIP:

Went over the macros used for testing the current iteration of the hopper on Pilot 2 with Mohsen and Ben.

Assembled the mold for making the newest version of the vibration isolator for the hopper vibrating hat after liberally spraying the sacrificial walls with mold release.

I am skipping over reinforcing V5.1 to handle the heat from the heater and printing a V5.2 from SLA material instead. I am designing a monolithic and lightweighted body that combines the front, back, and side panels into one part and has isogrid cutouts to limit the resin used while maintaining adequate strength.

MOSP:

Installed the metal Mest mount on the copper Saffron printer that Pourya has been using for no-depowdering experiments. I had to drill out the mounting holes for the dovetail with compliance (currently 3D printed from PETG-CF, although I am considering casting it from the harder urethane to get even more compliance). The dovetail was a really tight fit, even after grinding it down with a rotating tool with a carbide burr and aligning it as best I could with the new, larger mounting holes. The fundamental issue is that the Saffron spindle stages are not spaced reliably, so I need to design more adjustability in the mount to compensate for various spindle stage spacing. With the metal mount being as tight a fit as it is, and with it being less compliant than the 3D printed version, I am concerned that it will cause binding or increased wear issues with the Saffron spindle stages because their carriages will be rigidly fixed without being precisely aligned.

I have designed a mold for casting urethane dovetails and am printing 2 of them on the Bambu P2S. Hopefully they will not be necessary, but if they are, I will be ready.

2026-04-30

HOPPER/FLIP:

The monolithic hopper body (front, back, and side panels combined into one part) finished printing from clear SLA material on the FormLabs printer and is currently being washed in the Form Wash.

I populated the CAD assembly of HOPPER V5.2 with the cast side seals, and I am designing a cast main wiper seal for the gate. My sealing approach with this design is to eliminate all the felts and use cast urethane only; there is a risk that urethane will not seal as well as felt but there is less risk of FOD getting into the powder (I am worried about fibers from the felt separating and mixing in with the powder).

I designed a urethane wiper with “teeth” to act as multiple wiper blades. If it was wiping on a solid surface I would avoid this architecture because powder could get trapped between the wipers, but since the surface has cutouts to act as powder drains, having multiple wiper blades should increase the lifespan of the wiper vs. a single one that could wear out quickly. The wiper will still not last forever, and since the plan is to glue it down it will be difficult to replace.

Urethane is pretty temperature resistant; maybe use a hot melt adhesive so it can be removed by heating the hopper body until the adhesive melts? It also might be possible to secure it down with mechanical fasteners in some way (maybe a bunch of small flat head screws?) but using an adhesive would yield a reliable solution more quickly, even if it makes seal replacement more difficult in the future.

Removed the supports from and manually IPA cleaned the monolithic V5.2 hopper body, and put it in the Form Cure to cure.

After the curing was finished, I looked at the hopper body and one of the sides (the side that was facing downwards) has a lot of sagging issues, so the part is likely unusable.

GENERAL R&D:

Cleaning the Elegoo wash chamber for trying to dissolve the sacrificial filler material out of one of Pourya's no-depowdering green parts.

Replaced the power switch/socket on the Bambu X1E. The printer has been having issues with shutting down shortly after a high-temperature print is started, which is a known failure mode seen when the power switch contacts get worn. After replacing the power switch/socket assembly, I took apart the old power switch and saw significant damage to the electrical contact surfaces. Presumably there have been arcing events that are ablating away the surface of the contacts, which causes them to fail when too much current has been passed through them.

I successfully ran a benchy printed in PAHT-CF, which came out surprisingly well, even though the PAHT-CF hasn't been dried in a few days.

2026-05-01

3DEO:

I asked Alex how the board meeting went, and he seemed somewhat equivocal. As Alex said, many of the people at the meeting were Japanese, so they tend not to respond or react in the meeting itself; 3DEO management gives a presentation which needs to be translated into spoken Japanese in real time, then the presentation is sent out to all the stakeholders, then translated into Japanese, then they will come back with their interpretation/suggestions. This means that it will take time before we know what their feelings are about the presentation. The focus of this presentation was the successes of the R&D division, and the major pivot that 3DEO is going through to be a thermal solutions company instead of a component manufacturer.

HOPPER/FLIP:

I demolded three of the gate side seals (the other three mold cavities did not get fully filled) and they look OK. I was unable to demold the wiper seal since the FDM 3D printed mold stuck to the urethane; I tried to get mold release into the mold by dousing it with liquid mold release and blowing air into the mold at an angle to try and distribute the mold release throughout the mold, but it does not seem to have worked. Instead, I need to print a master positive to make a silicone mold, then use that to cast some urethane wipers.

I finished designing a positive mold for casting the silicone mold; it has three thicknesses of urethane wipers so I can try different sizes without needing to make more molds. I am currently printing it on the Bambu X1E (ANVIL) because the print time and print constraints (6h, needs internal supports) on the FormLabs 3 are restrictive for this part. Not impossible, but I would rather avoid them if possible.

PILOT:

I discussed some possible approaches for regulating and switching the vacuum on the Pilot printers between spindles; since the two spindles are operated separately (one for general part cutting, one for the facing operation to remove sacrificial filler material left above the surface of the build) it is only necessary for the vacuum to connect to one at a time, and having the vacuum connected to both causes issues due to vacuum loss when one SVP is raised and inability to adjust the flow separately to optimize the suction for the particular SVP's needs. To regulate the flow, Mohsen bought a Y splitter with a ball valve on each of the two outlets, which would make it possible to adjust the vacuum flow individually, but has the disadvantage of not being able to switch the vacuum flow to each spindle on and off. To have that functionality, the easiest way would be to add an on/off valve to each line (such as a motorized ball valve or butterfly valve, or a pinch valve on a rubber hose if the ball valve has issues with opening and closing when powder or binder builds up in it). It is also possible to combine the on/off and flow adjustment capabilities with a proportional ball valve whose position can be controlled with a variable output voltage controlled through the G code.

MOSP:

I demolded two compliant dovetail mounts cast with Urethane Shore 70A, the harder of the two urethanes we have around. We also have a bunch of MOSP sheet metal parts because two orders ended up being placed from SendCutSend, each of which had two sets to have a spare set if only one order was placed, so there are currently a total of 3 spare sets, and one aluminum dovetail is left over from the original design, which was intended to use two aluminum dovetails but ended up using one aluminum dovetail and one PETG-CF 3D printed dovetail because the aluminum dovetail was A. not designed for the actual spindle spacing seen on the copper Saffron and B. was rigid enough that I was concerned about overconstraining and damaging the spindle stages. Even with the 3D printed semi-compliant stage that was designed to match the actual spindle spacing, I am still concerned about it damaging the spindle stages. It took a lot of force to install the current assembly, so I am worried that it is putting some side loading on the spindle stage carriages, which could damage them over time.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

No Depowdering:

Trying to run experiments with printing 17-4 PH stainless steel on Pilot 6, but ran into issues with the facing spindle crashing.

Switched to InkBird environmental control. Not seeing chipping on prints after switching from Arduino THC to InkBird.

Reprinted SVP to replace the broken one, but it was the wrong version (2mm shorter than the one being replaced). It was too short for the 1/8" diameter facing end mill. A new SVP will need to be printed with modified dimensions to compensate.

Ran experiments to try to improve wall quality by adjusting the end mill stepover distance. There was no variation seen between experiments.

Ran 1 experiment with the incorrect SVP and 1mm stepover for hatching, and the PEG was thrown everywhere.

Mohsen looking into modulating vacuum flow with a valve. His current approach, as detailed above, is a pair of manual ball valves in a Y configuration. The valve was delivered today. He needs to design and print some adapters to interface the valves to the hoses.

For copper printing on the Saffron, worked on software to generate G code; ran into some issues but should be OK now.

Even with the metal mount installed, they are still seeing issues with the XY offset shifting over time.

Question raised of whether or not to switch Pilot 7 over to running copper

Payman recommends continuing to run the copper Saffron with the no-depowdering setup. I raised the questions of whether we want to switch to no-depowdering copper experiments on Saffrons only or on Pilots only, and the answer I got from Payman and Marcus was to keep running experiments on both platforms <despite the fact that we are losing the person running the experiments previously, and I am unsure as to whether Pilot will even continue to exist or be replaced with the Saffron printers. The Saffron printers are the only one currently shown on our new rebranded website>.

Metallurgical analysis of a no-depowdering copper print was conducted by Dong, and there was some anomalous porosity seen at the first 10 and last 10 layers, where no hatching was done; the no-depowdering layers seemed to show less porosity.

Laser:

Mason installed the MOPA fiber laser on Pilot 3 and printed a new LVP for use with copper. Printed 2 10-layer coupons in copper with the MOPA laser. Started experiments to determine the binder penetration depth.

Finished informal testing with UV and CO2 laser on copper cakes.

Plans to continue refining parameters and try inerting the printer.

Ran a 9 layer print printing a rectangle in copper, and found the wall surface finish to be ~20 microns vs nominal 6 microns for our CNC milled green parts.

To measure binder penetration for a layer, he would measure the thickness with calipers after curing the layer.

Mason asked how the board meeting went. Alex said it's hard to say. Half the audience was Japanese, so they will need to take time to process the presentation (sorry about the racism!). Went through R&D stuff, commercial stuff, financials, fundraising efforts. Talking with two VC companies, including one that funded Alloyed Enterprises, the other is backed by TSMC.

To Do:

- **Get collets for 1/8" end mill on Saffron spindles to Pourya**
 - Done, took one from Senai's desk
- **Make sure that Pilot 7 is equipped with the proper spindle stage and Mest unit mounts**
 - Looking for machined parts I made for mounting three stages and the Mest unit
 - Found the sheet metal part and 3D printed part for the three stage setup
 - Have the 3 stage mount, which still needs the M3 threaded inserts installed
 - Still missing the aluminum Mest dovetail mounts. Will need to machine new ones, which should be fairly quick since I already have the CNC programs done on the Trak mill.
- **Install compliant dovetail mount on Saffron printer, if necessary**
 - Compliant dovetail cast, ready to install
- **Analyze layer quality of spreads with metal spreader bar**
 - Quality seems OK, still seeing issues with the line on the build where the gate closes
- **Get new numbers on overflow waste**
- **Install new vibration isolator on hopper V5.1**
 - Vibration isolator cast and post-processed
 - Needs 8X M4 heat set inserts to be installed
- **Run some TRS coupons on Pilot 2 with HOPPER V5.1**
 - 1 print complete to be broken out by Ben, and another print started (2026-05-07)

◦ [Sign in](#) to access [Google Drive Spreadsheet](#)

- **Research recirculating vacuums for Pilot 8**

- For integrating something into a printer, I'm thinking something along these lines:
- [🌀 VARIAIR SV 300/1 gas-tight | Becker Asia Pacific Pte Ltd – Vacuum pumps, Compressor, Regenerative blower](#)
- A sealed air blower combined with a cyclone separator and a series of filters

- **Design hopper for copper**

- In progress. Recycling as many parts from V5.2 as possible but adding an active spreader bar for increased compaction and reduced layer thickness.

2026-05-04

HOPPER/FLIP:

Asked Ben to set up Pilot 2 for running TRS coupons.

Designed and printing new mold positive for casting the gate wiper seal.

Marcus and Payman raised the point that it may become necessary to implement a hopper on copper.

Marcus also said that there is interest in making wicks, which may require a multi material print.

Demolded the latest vibration isolator, and it came out pretty well; the amount of mold release I applied to the inner and outer sacrificial mold walls made it much easier to remove the walls that it had been previously. I printed new parts and did a pour for a new vibration isolator. The design is the same as the previous one, although this time I did the pour in all softer urethane and was more careful to scrape off squeezeout on the top of the vibration isolator to make post-processing easier.

Looking at the Xometry order for HOPPER V5.2 machined parts, most of them have been accepted by the manufacturer, but two are still "Order Review" status (the gate and the cam; the cam is weird because I have had those machined before and they are not super complex, but the gate makes sense because it is hogged out of a big billet of stainless steel. Operating under the assumption that they are preparing to no-quote those parts, I have designed a new multi-part gate (one bottom part, two different side parts where the only difference between the two is the location of the counterbores so that the counterbores face outwards on each side). On the other hand, those two parts are the only stainless steel parts, so they could just be going to a different supplier than the aluminum parts and it is taking a little longer for the other supplier to start working on them.

Pilot Baseline Meeting:

The Arduino was removed from Pilot 7 and the BME sensors were eliminated, and the software was modified to ignore the BME readings.

Ning is currently using an Inkbird controller as a standalone environmental controller.

For the Raspberry Pi sensor, he wants to use:

 [Tzone - Warehouse Temperature and Humidity Transmitter | RS485 Sensor](#)

This uses an SHT30 chip:

 [SHT30 Temperature And Humidity Sensor - Wired Enclosed Shell](#)

Which natively uses the I2C communication protocol, but in the case it has a chip to communicate over RS485.

<My recommendation would be to monitor and control everything through a central control system (likely the Raspberry Pi) so that the environmental setpoints can be adjusted through the main user interface and the RPi can record the environmental data. Any failures will be easier to debug since there is only one system in control of everything. If there are issues seen, first establish the root cause. Are there other known good machines that the machine with the issues can be compared with? What are the differences? How can you prove that a theory about the root cause is correct? With noise, it's an easy test; connect an oscilloscope to the suspect lines and look for noise. With my architecture where all systems are tied together instead of completely isolated, any noise issues would need to be resolved with traditional noise mitigation approaches (star grounding, cable shielding, inductive voltage spike suppression diodes, noise filters). Star grounding should always be implemented regardless just as good practice, but the other measures should only be implemented as necessary; if there are issues seen, noise needs to be established with an oscilloscope, mitigated with the correct approach, measured again with an oscilloscope to demonstrate that it has been mitigated, and have that data recorded and published so it is accessible to the whole company. If noise is detected and all standard noise mitigation approaches fail, then it may be worth isolating components. If isolation fails, then it may be worth redesigning the system to prevent the root cause. My general process followed with the first 5 pilots, then is: build system following standard best practices (DC negatives tied together, star grounding) → Issue seen → find root cause → if noise, prove with oscilloscope → take measures to mitigate noise → if that fails, isolate systems → if that fails, replace subsystems while maintaining necessary functionality. Bear in mind that Pilots 1-5 had their DC negatives tied together, as do all the Beta machines and the Saffron printers as best I can tell,

but OK, maybe noise is a new issue on 6 and 7 for some reason, I don't know. In that case, I would recommend following the procedure above. As far as I can tell, Ning's approach has been: Issue seen → isolate systems and replace subsystems regardless of lost functionality.>

Payman recommends running a print to test density.

Last week, Mohsen ran a 367 layer air cutting print on Pilot 7. The spreader bar stayed clean, and there was some buildup on the inside of the mist box but no drips onto the build.

Copper No-Depowdering:

Cisco is busy with Inconel so Pourya is limited in what he can do because Cisco is needed to set up prints.

Pourya pointed out that it would be useful to have Cisco start prints early in the morning instead of in the afternoon.

Pourya encountered an issue with print failure where there is a region of powder missing downstream of the sacrificial filler parts.

Marcus took some pictures of the print and the machine, and found powder buildup on the spreader bar, and also powder that had been deposited on the far side of the overflow chute only in line with the powder missing downstream of the sacrificial filler parts.

I asked about whether we had priced out a system for recycling and reconditioning copper powder, and Marcus says it was a few hundred thousand dollars.

GENERAL R&D:

I ran some calculations on cost savings with higher quality markers:

\$1000 per person per day (avg), \$125 per hour, \$2.08/minute. If 5 people are in a meeting, \$10.42 per minute. If someone spends 10s extra cleaning a whiteboard, \$1.74. \$0.85 per Expo marker.

Pilot Conversion for Copper:

How did we convert the Saffron to run copper? Requirements?

OSHA PEL (Permissible Emission Limit), keep fine powder contained into machine as much as possible

Our grade of copper powder is non-combustible

Because copper is so sensitive to oxidation from oxygen and humidity, it needs to be printed at low humidity, low heat, preferably low oxygen.

Tents were first implemented to keep out contamination from 17-4 PH present elsewhere in the room; per Midhun, if we dedicated a room to printing copper only, then we would not need a tent.

Midhun notes that we see issues in final part quality because of poor green strength. Things that would lead to increased green part strength:

- Reduced layer thickness
- Reduced oxygen (Midhun's target: 2-8%)
- Non-aqueous binder

2026-05-05

HOPPER/FLIP:

Curing the SLA parts for making a mold for the urethane wiper seals for HOPPER V5.2

Beginning to design a hopper for the copper Pilots. Per Midhun, the flowability (as measured by angle repose) of our copper powder is similar to that of treated 17-4 PH stainless powder, even though the 17-4 powder has a flow aid added (fumed silica of some formulation). Technically, it is likely possible to duplicate HOPPER V5.2 and install it in the copper printer, assuming that it is usable at all (as will hopefully be determined by today's hopper tests), but since our copper green parts are chronically weak and insufficiently dense, it would be wise to incorporate some more advanced design features, namely an active roller spreader bar.

The main design challenge of an active roller spreader bar is keeping the axis of rotation aligned with the central axis of the outer surface of the spreader bar; misalignment will cause waviness in the layer, resulting in variations in layer thickness and possibly in layer density.

I need to add a quick release mechanism for the hopper so that it can be installed and removed easily while still being sufficiently rigid.

I am working on adding the active spreader bar to a copy of HOPPER V5.2 (the copy is named V5.3, naturally, although the assembly model has a different label: LINEAR GATE ACTIVE ROLLER HOPPER). I am hoping to recycle most of V5.2, so it will still have a fixed spreader bar that is used as a surface for the gate to seal against and as a pre-spreader, with an active spreader bar roller slightly downstream of that. I am designing it that way instead of replacing the current fixed spreader bar with an active one because of packaging issues with the side gate support carriages and rails. I also need to incorporate a mechanism to make it possible to adjust the active spreader bar up and down and tilt it to align it relative to the fixed spreader bar

GENERAL R&D:

I talked with Devin about copper powder recycling/reconditioning. He was reluctant to commit to it, with good reason, but I think he agrees with what I'm thinking, at least at a high level.

So 3DEO has a problem with powder wastage: only a small amount of the copper powder that comes in the loading dock winds up in parts that are shipped to the customer (numbers?). Most of it is lost to:

- Penetration tests and other powder benchmarking procedures
- Failed prints (including pushoffs)
- Powder that is vacuumed up (leftover powder in U tank, powder in cleaning downdraft table, etc.)
- Bound cakes
- Scrap green parts
- Overflow

We are currently approaching this from the front end, trying to reduce wastage at some of these steps with the following projects:

- Hopper
- Using Pilot printers with a smaller build area when possible
- No-depowdering may reduce powder usage
- Optimization of powder feeding strategy to minimize wastage

An alternative to this approach would be to go at it from the back end; instead of trying to reduce wastage at each of these steps, accept powder contamination and recycle and recondition it to match the properties of virgin powder (or get close enough that a blend of recycled and virgin powder can be used). This would require significant upfront capital investment and carries risks, but would also reduce powder wastage to zero if it can be proven to work. The R&D team could instead work on optimizing for part quality, throughput, and part capabilities.

2026-05-06

NO-DEPOWDERING:

Pourya is seeing some issues with the end mill being used on the copper no-depowdering printer chipping and possibly causing poor printing results (Alex said that the poor printing being seen can be caused by a dull end mill). He asked if I could find any end mills that match the size of these:



But with a coating instead of being uncoated carbide. I haven't found an identical one with coated carbide. The two COTS options I found are:



Same size but 2 flute instead of 1, and amorphous diamond coated.



1 flute and amorphous diamond coated, but the cutting diameter is ~50% larger (.03125" (~794 microns) instead of the current .020" (508 microns))



Same size but 2 flute, AlTiN coated and less expensive than the Harvey Tools equivalent (~\$35 instead of ~\$60)



Another interesting option, AlTiN coated, 2 flute, .020" cutting diameter, but .030" LOC instead of the standard .060" LOC (what we are currently running). The LOC is still well more than we need, but could provide better chip clearing.

In a discussion with Devin in Jira, he pointed out that we can get more working area on the Saffron printer with the Mest unit installed if the unit is aligned with spindle 7. I had already designed a modified sheet metal bracket to accommodate this, but I had not placed an order on SendCutSend for it. I also had failed to add a slot to access the screw on the spindle stage carriage that locks the dovetail to the stage carriage. I added that slot into the design. There are three possible approaches I can take to align the Mest unit with spindle 7:

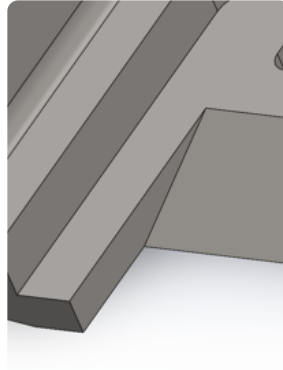
- Order a new bracket from SendCutSend and install it when it arrives
 - Best part quality, costs money, takes calendar time
- Make an intermediate bracket to extend the original mount bracket to the side
 - Shifts the Mest unit forward in Y
 - Need to machine a slot into the mount bracket
- Weld the original mount bracket to the U bracket, but shifted to the side
 - Takes time to do
 - Still need to machine a slot into the mount bracket

I went ahead and placed an order request for two of the extended brackets from SendCutSend. If it becomes necessary to expand the working area quickly I can implement one of the other

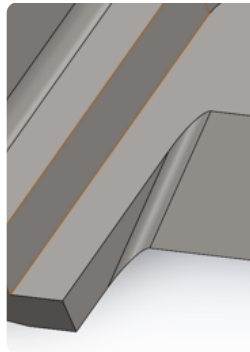
two solutions above, but ordering new brackets is cheap and easy enough to do in preparation for the most likely eventuality, that we have enough time to wait for the new brackets.

HOPPER/FLIP:

Xometry has finally started working on machining the stainless steel gate, and said they would have a problem with the sharp corners at the edge of the gate:



They asked for a 1.5R radius instead, so I modified it and sent them a new STEP file:



This will require some modification of the design of the cast urethane side seals, but the gate and the seals should still function properly.

Ben ran into an issue with the V5.1 3D printed hopper currently installed on Pilot 2 that he is trying to get printing TRS coupons: the gate wasn't opening and closing evenly, which upon further inspection was due to the set screws on one of the cams coming loose. Since the cams are 3D printed and the threads are just tapped into the cams they are not super strong. Ultimately the cams will be machined from stainless steel, but for now I would like to fab up some interim metal cams to use in the near future.

I demolded the silicone mold for casting flat urethane wiper seals, but I had to cut slits in the side to remove the wiper seal positives, so I am now printing a holder that the silicone mold slides into that will keep the slits closed while the urethane is curing. After the urethane is cured,

I will slide out the silicone mold and demold the urethane parts. As long as I am careful not to get any urethane on the FDM holder, both the silicone mold and the holder should be reusable.

The first FDM holder I printed is too tight for the silicone mold, so I will print another one with larger internal dimensions.

PILOT:

I have so far been unable to find the three stage mount and the two MEST mount parts for installing the MEST unit on Pilot 7.

2026-05-07

GENERAL R&D:

Tested the hardness of two copper parts. One is definitely a printed block that I faced on the top and bottom. The hardness was off the Rockwell HRB scale, so I had to use the HRF scale. The values I got are: 13.8 7.1 10.1 3.6 0.1 10 7.8 11.7 (avg 8.025)

I also tested a machined part that Marcus gave me that I think was machined from a block of printed copper, but may have been machined from billet: 4.9 4.4 2.5 -0.9 -4.3 16.9 9.8 2.7 7.7 9.8 2.5 (avg 5.09)

I am not sure when the machine was last calibrated, but I tested it with a reference HRB block and it was within spec. We don't have a reference HRF block that I could use.

Annealed pure copper is supposed to be ~40-45 HRF, half-hard is ~40 HRB, and full-hard is ~50 HRB.

Requested that Adriana run density and conductivity measurements on the two parts tested.

Jared Copper Parts							
		Measurement 1	Measurement 2	Measurement 3	Average	Relative density (bulk Cu)	
	Mass in Air (g)	30.147	30.145	30.145	30.146		
	Mass in Water (g)	26.784	26.767	26.785	26.779		
	Water Temperature (C)	22.1	22.1	22.1	22.1		
	Water Density (g/mL)	0.9978	0.9978	0.9978	0.998		
	Density (g/cm³)	8.944	8.904	8.952	8.933	99.70%	
	Std. Dev of Density				0.026		
	Note						
		Measurement 1	Measurement 2	Measurement 3	Average	Relative density (bulk Cu)	
	Mass in Air (g)	43.895	43.919	43.922	43.912		
	Mass in Water (g)	38.947	38.958	38.949	38.951		
	Water Temperature (C)	22.1	22.1	22.1	22.1		
	Water Density (g/mL)	0.9978	0.9978	0.9978	0.998		
	Density (g/cm³)	8.851	8.833	8.812	8.832	98.58%	
	Std. Dev of Density				0.020		
	Note						
Part #	Temp (C)	Measurement 1	Measurement 2	Measurement 3	Measurement 4	Measurement 5	Average
Part 1	26.2	97.3	97.2	97.2	97.3	97.3	97.26
Part 2	26.2	96.9	96.9	96.9	96.8	96.9	96.88

R&D WEEKLY MEETING:

No-Depowdering:

Pilot 6 17-4 PH testing:

Experimented with replacing end mill and varying binder volume (orig. 5000 → 5500 → 5750) and replacing the SVP and was seeing chipping during the standard cut step (not the facing operation) regardless of the parameters.

For Copper on Saffron:

Ran 1 print, failed, much of print empty

Ran previously good print, failed

Replaced tool bit, repeated previously good print, OK

Started running new G-Code. Seeing regions of print where the build is “bubbling” up on top of regions that are supposed to be filled with sacrificial filler material but were empty for some reason (possible filler detachment from lower layers).

Pourya notes that the end mills being used on copper seem to be wearing out more quickly than they do on 17-4 PH. Payman pointed out that they had previously seen similar issues when they were first starting to print copper, and resolved it by have a coating applied to the end mills <I’m pretty sure our 4 flute end mills are always coated, but maybe not>.

The layer chipping seems to be generally fixed by replacing the tool bit.

Ready to install a large diameter end mill, although it may eat up some of the working area in X depending on which spindles are used.

Marcus shared a heat exchanger design that Sean has been working on that seems fairly printable using the CleanPrint(tm) process, is potentially difficult to print with other processes <I have my doubts, but that’s neither here nor there>, and seems to provide high performance in simulations.

They are printing the part from copper using the standard printing process.

Senai has been working on a traditional depowderable design (columns combined with cross members).

Mohsen has been transferring knowledge from Pourya as much as possible (this is Pourya’s last week).

Laser:

Focusing on getting a good hatch on copper. Was able to get good results with cutting single lines close together but not overlapping, but once the cuts touch then there would be “sintering.”

Marcus, Payman, and Mason raised the idea of having a spindle on the laser machine for hatching <eliminates Payman’s gantry concept, reduces speed advantage>.

Mason worked on optimizing cut parameters. Had traditionally been varying cut speed and power only, but this week started varying pulse width and frequency as well.

Asked about whether there is anything he can do that is beneficial to showing investors and customers, and Payman suggested running a print where fins are stacked on top of each other (even just 5 layers).

To Do:

- **Get custom end mills: .5mm cutter D, 1 flute, 1/8” shank, coated**
- **Redesign Mest mount on Saffron printer so that the Mest unit is inline with two spindles in Y**
 - New design is complete (2026-05-11)
 - The sheet metal part that directly connects to the Mest unit is recycled, and the part that connects that mount to the machined dovetail mounts is redesigned to connect to the two spindle stages on either side of the front spindle inline with the Mest nozzle
 - Entered an order request for the necessary part from SendCutSend 2026-05-12
 - Order was placed 2026-05-12
- **Add leak test ports to some of the no-depowdering 17-4 parts**
 - M3 threads added to holes on 2X parts (2026-05-11)
 - Order request placed for push-to-connect fittings for connecting M6 tubing for pressure testing (2026-05-11)
- **Machine no-depowdering 17-4 parts to expose internal features**
 - 1 machined 2026-05-07 and placed on Payman’s desk
 - Second tapped and machined 2026-05-11
- **Continue running TRS coupons**
 - Need to repair main wiper seal; the felt seal came off at one edge but I have already been casting urethane wiper seals
 - Installed a urethane wiper seal 2026-05-11
 - Ben continuing to run prints 2026-05-13

- **Optimize spread cycle**

- Density towards end of spread is low where a line is present on the build from the gate closing

- **Make sure three stage mount components are available to install on Pilot 7**

- Machined X stage mount, sheet metal endstop mount, printed X axis endstop contact point mount collected
- Collected 2 Metrol endstops from Adriana 2026-05-13

- **Get updated measurement of overflow weight**

2026-05-08

Pourya's last day. We had a lunch yesterday to celebrate Pourya, and Alex talked a bit about the business. He said that we have money for two paychecks, and since the next paycheck is next week that means that we have 3 weeks of operating capital left. Per Mason this morning, it sounds like FusionX is unlikely to give us more funding, so it is down to these two VC companies that Alex has been speaking with. One of them is in the process of discussing investing in 3DEO with their partners, while the other has not gotten to that point yet. It also seems unlikely that Epson or any of the other Japanese investors will invest in 3DEO without us bringing in any external funding (I guess they agreed to give us some more, but only if we can get someone else to kick in some money to demonstrate that others believe in 3DEO).

Mason also asked a good question: if we get enough money to operate for 6 more months or a year, will we be able to accomplish something, or will we chase our tails as we often have?

So there definitely is a market for liquid cooled heat exchangers for data centers.

Complex internal geometry designs do improve performance.

There are several companies making heat exchangers for liquid cooling (JetCool, etc.) and several companies trying to use AM to make heat exchangers for this application (Fabric8Labs, Alloyed Enterprises).

So what can we provide that others can't?

1. Complex internal geometry, although this is of questionable importance and the abilities we have here are at risk of becoming less unique over time
2. Single piece enclosed geometry without separate components or joints. This is more important, since it eliminates leak paths and expensive joint design and manufacturing operations.

3. Scalability. I think this is the critical differentiator; our printers are slow individually but our process is optimized for parallelization and simplicity. We can have many printers running in parallel, run large batches of parts through a debinding oven then a sintering furnace, then post-machine them onsite (I'm going to be honest from the start and say that post-machining will be necessary; accepting sintering warpage and post-machining the outside for flatness will be much easier, cheaper, and more reliable than trying to minimize warpage to machining tolerance levels).

Let's say we get 6 months of funding. What will 3DEO need to look like by the end of the year to be a survivable company?

1. **Large, high-volume low-mix contracts of single piece fully enclosed heat exchangers for data center applications**
2. **All the printers running copper in parallel**

Within 6 more months, all powder waste must be eliminated.

This is fully dependent on the CleanPrint(tm) process working in full scale production.

Without it, we lose the ability to make single piece heat exchangers, and if we can't do that, then we have no advantage over companies that print in pure copper with PBF technologies and braze parts together.

HOPPER/FLIP:

Continuing to work on the design of hopper V5.3 with an active roller spreader bar.

The felt seal on the currently installed V5.1 hopper came loose and dragged on one side of the build.

MOSP:

Looked at the model of the metal Mest mount installed in the copper Saffron printer. I think the best approach is to make a new mount that has dovetails that mount to the carriages on two spindles on one side instead of the center two spindles, and design the mount such that it does not interfere with the front spindle that the Mest unit's outlet nozzle is in line with in the Y direction. This should maximize the working area of the Mest unit and two spindles (one for regular cutting, one for facing).

2026-05-11

HOPPER/FLIP:

Need to replace felt seal with urethane seal because the felt seal came partially detached.

Removed the faulty felt seal and glued on a urethane seal. I then reconnected the hopper to Pilot 2 and tested opening and closing the gate a few times, and it seemed to work fine. It is an open question whether the urethane seal will provide a good seal to prevent powder leakage, but hopefully it will at least stay in place because it's super glued on.

PILOT:

Payman asked for access to the latest PILOT cad, but he does not have access to the vault so I cleaned up the SolidWorks assembly and am creating a pack and go folder for him. Created the Pack and Go folder, Zipped it, and sent it to Payman over Slack.

Heat Exchangers:

Need to add M3 threads to two of the sample CleanPrint(tm) parts I have to connect push-to-connect fittings to test them for leaks.

Now that I have a CAD model of the heat exchangers, I have a better understanding of how to machine them to see the internal channels. Instead of the stepped milling, I think a better approach is to face the top and bottom surfaces until I hit the important features.

I drilled and tapped three parts and milled down one of those three to expose the internal features (I just tapped it first because it's cool to see the threads cross sectioned).

GENERAL R&D:

Turns out I was somewhat wrong about the safety of hydrotesting. My points were technically correct but incomplete; arguably pressurizing a test article with gas is more dangerous than liquid at the same pressure, although there are also risks associated with hydrotesting that are not present with gas testing. At the same pressure, there is more energy stored in compressed gas than there is in compressed liquid, so an isolated tank filled with water at 1000 PSI is much safer than an isolated tank filled with air at 1000 PSI. On the other hand, if the test article is connected to an active pump and there is a small breach, a jet of water can cause high pressure fluid injection injuries that a jet of gas would not cause.

I think that 99% of the time it is correct to say that testing with pressurized liquid is safer than testing with pressurized gas, but it is important to be aware of the exact testing regime, hardware, and failure modes, and recognize that there are dangers that are unique to hydrotesting that can be quite severe.

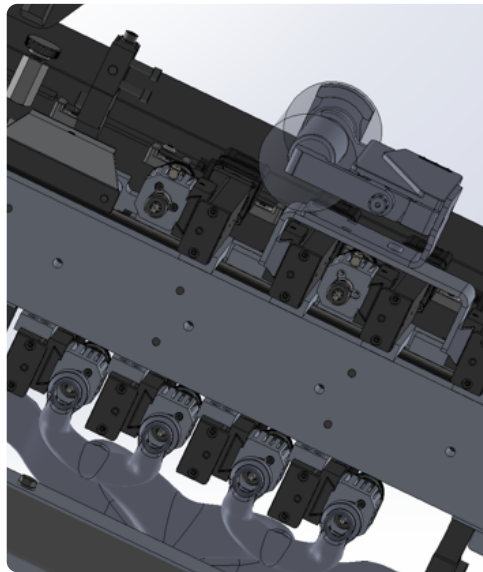
Also of note: high pressure fluid injection injuries can occur with little initial pain or visible damage with worsening symptoms over 8-24 hours, and result in fairly high amputation rates, so if you do have an injury like that, go to the hospital ASAGDMFP.

MOSP:

I designed a new metal mount for the Mest unit on the copper Saffron with two major changes: it uses two spindle stages to either side of the front feature cutting spindle, and I don't remember the other change. With this design, the nozzle of the Mest unit is aligned with a front and rear spindle in Y, to maximize the area that any of the three can reach in X (since X travel is more limited than Y travel in the Saffron printers).

2026-05-12

MOSP: Went over the latest mount design with Devin, and he was fine with it. I entered an order request for one of the new mount parts (the other mount part is reused from an earlier design, so we only need to order one new part to make the new design).



HOPPER/FLIP:

The machined parts for Hopper V5.2 were supposed to ship today, but they have been delayed. Fortunately, the 3D printed V5.1 hopper seems to still be functioning well enough to get some preliminary results.

HEAT EXCHANGERS:

I did some research on the impact of surface roughness of internal channels on the performance of liquid cooled heat exchangers. Surface roughness increases the convective heat transfer coefficient but also increases the friction factor of the channels. This results in a higher pressure drop for a given flow rate, so the pumping power per unit of heat transfer is equivalent or slightly worse, but it lets you get more heat transfer for a given heat exchanger volume. Depending on what you are optimizing for and how much of the system you are allowed

to change, a rougher surface can actually be beneficial for certain applications of heat exchangers.

For rocket engines, it tends not to be desirable to have rough channels; the rough surface can trap contaminants, increases pressure drop, and can cause unpredictable pressure drop depending on how rough the surface is and where it is rougher or smoother. Typically rocket engine channels are polished in some way, whether that's electropolishing or abrasive flow machining or similar.

2026-05-13

PILOT:

Ning asked for help with ordering the sheet metal mounts for the two long power supplies and printing the Duet mount for Pilot 8.

Started printing a Duet mount from PETG-CF on the Bambu P2S.

Created a quote and entered an order request for 2X PSU sheet metal parts.

Plan is to get Pilot 7 running copper with the Mest unit, so I need to get the three stages and associated hardware installed. I have the main machined 3 stage mount, although it needs threaded inserts installed.

The threaded inserts have been installed in the three stage mount. They come with red thread locker preapplied, but I have found that kind of dry thread locker paste to not hold well, so I also used liquid red Loctite to hold the inserts in place during stage installation. Once the screws mounting down the stages have been tightened I am confident the threaded inserts will not go anywhere, but if they are loose during installation they could screw out the back of the mount and interfere with other components.

I asked Senai about the machined parts for Pilot 8, and they have not yet been ordered. Since we need to install the Mest unit on Pilot 7 soon, I am going to machine some aluminum dovetailed Mest mounts the same way I did for Pilot 6. Since I always machine extra parts, this has the added benefit of making it unnecessary to order more Mest mounts for Pilot 8, although since those are already in the order pipeline it may not be possible to cancel ordering them, so we might just end up with a bunch of extra parts.

HOPPER/FLIP:

Ben is continuing to run TRS prints on Pilot 2 with the 3D printed Hopper V5.1.

Cast some more urethane main seals and side seals with a pouring strategy that should eliminate the voids that were seen on some of the previous urethane seals.

2026-05-14

GENERAL R&D:

Pourya was in the office today, not sure exactly why. I should have talked with him and asked him why Payman was leaving and whether he wanted to go to Disneyland some time with a group of people from 3DEO.

Informed by Payman that he will be leaving 3DEO for AEM. He grabbed a few people to talk to one-on-one in the blue conference room: me, Mason, Mohsen, and Sean (I think that was everyone). He told me that he is going to be head of R&D at AEM and he is hoping that he will be able to push for AEM to work with 3DEO on future projects (they were the company that was behind the PXL project). He said that I should reach out to him if 3DEO does end up going under in 2 weeks, as will happen if we do not get the next tranche of funding. He said that he was leaving for personal reasons and still believed in 3DEO.

According to Sean, ZZ texted Rajan, and he said that Payman had been pushed out of the company or laid off.

Sean and Mason were theorizing that Alex (CEO Alex) is trying to get a month of bridging funding from FusionX, and has offered Payman up as a kind of sacrificial lamb to reduce expenditures slightly and

The CleanPrint(tm) samples that I tapped with M3 threads are ready to be pressure tested, I just need to connect them to the pressure test rig in the old PXL assembly area (assuming that it is still there, which may or may not be the case).

HOPPER/FLIP:

Ben is continuing to run TRS coupons on Pilot 2 with the 3D printed Hopper V5.1

PILOT:

I need to machine some Mest mounts for Pilot 7 and possibly Pilot 8 if I make some spares.

I printed out a Duet mount for Ning to mount the Duet board to the control cabinet subpanel for Pilot 8.

2026-05-15

GENERAL R&D:

Payman's last day. Long meeting in back rooms with Marcus, Alex, Ken, and a guy from DBJ.

PILOT:

Working on machining the aluminum Mest mounts.

2026-05-18

PILOT: Continuing to machine Mest mounts.

Finished machining the Mest mounts.

PILOT STABILIZATION:

Per Senai, we are no longer doing the Pilot stabilization meeting

PARTS R&D:

Call w/ Steven Rizzo

Rejected by Siemens.

Chroma ATE

Applied Materials

Friday meeting

Takemori-san, showing latest results w/ microchannel and laser

Meeting w/Alex, Ken, Jim Golden

Alex told Marcus this morning that he has been talking with Epson about giving us some money for IP or something. I assumed we had already sold them all of our IP, but if we have not then that would act as a potentially powerful lever to get them to give us more money. Going down that path, however, means that they will have little need to monetarily support 3DEO's California office.

Alex wants to redirect Mohsen to printing the Epson cold plate, suggesting that he has a strategy to get more money from Epson within the next few weeks if we can show them a good part. The parts that we have printed traditionally from 17-4, however, were not completely depowderable, so it may be necessary to make some design changes to be able to print it traditionally (using 3DEO's Intelligent Layering(tm) process) or print it with the no-depowdering system installed on Pilot 6).

I asked Marcus about how much money we have left in the bank, which as I understand it is ~2 weeks, based on Alex saying 1 week ago that we have enough money for 2 paychecks, and the first of those 2 paychecks was sent out last Friday. Marcus said that it isn't as clear-cut as that, so there may be some wiggle room there, particularly because we no longer have Payman (who, per gossip, was getting paid \$300K/yr, which per the rule of thumb that employees cost companies ~3X their paycheck means that his cost to the company was ~\$900K/yr). Then again, my cost to the company is ~\$405/yr, so I'm not really one to talk.

COPPER NO-DEPOWDERING:

Last week, Mohsen worked on breaking up the no-depowdering process on Pilot 6 printing with 17-4 into different steps to understand them independently.

Cutting layers - worked fine

Adding filler into channels - filler curled up, overfilled which can lead to more debris during facing operation

Facing - some cracking of cake near to features, damage to corners of part seen

Has a flow restrictor on each vacuum line so the flow can be adjusted independently. Even with the feature cutting spindle vacuum line closed and the facing vacuum line fully open, there was still filler debris being thrown around the cake.

Mohsen developed some optimized parameters for end mill extension from the SVPs and vacuum settings (quantified with static pressure measurements).

Marcus raised the idea of adjusting filler application strategy to fill hatched areas to prevent the filler from distorting as it cools. Devin also pointed out the length of time that filler is left to cool in features before the facing operation is started may affect part quality.

For this week, Marcus wants Mohsen to focus on printing the Epson cold plate.

Devin noted that we do have the ability to double cut through multiple layers.

Pilot 6 is having issues with the Duet board disconnecting. ZZ changed the SPI communication frequency between Raspberry Pi and Duet board.

2026-05-19

PILOT:

Gave the parts for assembling the 3 stage mount for Pilot 7 to Ben and showed him how it goes together.

Need more nuts for the Metrol limit switches (M10X0.5).

Ben is currently working on removing the U and V tank module from Pilot 7 to clean it out in the depowdering room in preparation for printing with copper in Pilot 7.

HOPPER/FLIP:

The stainless steel parts for the hopper showed up. Visually the gate looks pretty good. The gate cams that hold the track rollers did not have their holes tapped (I don't remember if this is because I told them not to tap them to save money and time or because they missed them) so I tapped the holes, and reamed out the counterbore for locating the track roller (it was machined into the cam at a larger diameter than the hole for the M3 threads, but it was still small enough that when I tapped the threads the tap cut into the counterbore).

HEALTH: Heat Exchanger fLow Test bench

Began researching making a test bench for the one-piece CleanPrint(tm) printed heat exchangers we are working on printing.

2026-05-20

3DEO Heat Exchanger (Esp. Cold Plate) Meeting:

Meeting w/ Alex, Marcus, Devin, Mohsen, Ben, Midhun, Dong, Senai:

Sean's microchannel design.

Investors want to know if we can build a cold plate w/ CleanPrint(tm) in copper in next 60-90 days.

Needs to be benchmarked experimentally to compare its performance with commercially available heat exchangers.

There is one Japanese investor associated with FusionX interested in giving us money for a short period of time to incrementally prove out our process.

Accretech scope change to make a square heat exchanger (~100X100mm)

Microchannel printing demonstrated with reduced size and simplified geometry

3DEO Technology/Design/Process Differentiation:

- **Reduced thermal resistance**
- **Reduced pressure drop**
- **Printed in one monolithic piece**

Need to know:

- Required performance
 - Minimize thermal resistance
 - Maximize temperature uniformity
 - Minimize pressure drop
- Compare against competitors experimentally
- GPU cooler or semiconductor testing chuck?
- CleanPrint(tm)/Intelligent Layering vs open ended process?
- Scalability?
 - Not really a requirement

To Do:

- Make a high performance heat exchanger design
- Simulate performance
- Make the heat exchanger
- Measure performance of our heat exchanger and at least one competitor's product

Devin raised concerns about the number of parts that can be packed onto a Saffron build plate.

Midhun asked about the impact of thermal conductivity of the material on the thermal resistance. Sean thinks that his simulations are based on 400 W/mK, and Midhun and Dong said that we usually get ~360-380 W/mK <need to double check that exact number, it is at least less than pure copper>.

Sean talked about optimizing the design of the heat exchanger. Generally you want high surface area and high flow velocity to maximize heat transfer. <Possible to modify pressure drop with a post-processing process>. A rougher internal surface can improve heat transfer because it increases turbulence of the boundary layer and increases surface area.

Sacrificial filler material formulation is locked.

HEALTH:

Selected LabJack T4 for the DAQ/control system:



It has some reasonable features, is low cost, and is compatible with LabView (I want to be able to run all the functions and record and view data through a LabView control panel).

Working through the necessary functions to develop a P&ID. At a minimum, I will need:

- A reservoir of coolant maintained at a constant pressure (since we will only be adding heat to the coolant, it will only need to be actively cooled)
- Temperature and pressure sensors at the inlet and outlet ports of the heat exchanger
- An IR camera or array of temperature sensors to capture temperature uniformity
- A way to apply heat in a controlled way (possibly heater cores in a machined copper block)
- A way to measure the heat being applied
- A pump to pass coolant through the heat exchanger
- A way to know the coolant flow rate - either a real time sensor or a reliable and regulated pump (such as the stepper motor-driven peristaltic pump used on the last test bench)

2026-05-21

HEALTH:

Completed a rough P&ID for the system.

R&D Weekly Meeting:

No Depowdering:

Mohsen has been running experiments with the Mest no-depowdering system on Pilot 6. He has switched to using an acrylic base plate for its reduced thermal conductivity. He added a 180s dwell time to allow the PEG to cool before the facing operation. He is seeing cracking in large volumes of PEG used to fill hatches regions and is having issues with those same regions of PEG pulling up. He tried doing the facing operation in multiple passes at varying heights to reduce the likelihood of the PEG filler material pulling up, which seemed to help. He also tried slowing down the feed rate, which seems to have caused melting and smearing of the PEG instead of cutting it cleanly into chips.

Marcus wants to switch away from the Epson heat exchanger geometry that we have been printing in favor of printing a section of the microchannel geometry that is present in Sean's recent design. The hope is that this geometry will be more successful because it does not have large volumes to fill with sacrificial filler material and does not have tall unsupported pins.

A copper print from the Saffron printer is currently in the dry box.

Midhun is trying to collect knowledge about the no-depowdering process and systems, particularly from Mohsen, Mason, and possibly Pourya if we can get him to come in for a bit.

Midhun is also going to get trained up on running the copper Saffron and the Pilot printers.

GENERAL:

Senai did a print to try and print a wicking structure with a 100 micron end mill <what gap size is necessary for capillary action?>. Most or all of the end mills broke (at least 3/4) <LOC is 300 micron> <feed rate was not updated to maintain the same surface speed and feed per tooth, the feed used was half of the standard feed rate, which may have been too fast for end mills of this size>. The goal is to create parts for two-phase cooling heat exchangers.

TO DO NEXT WEEK:

- **Install the new Mest mount on the copper Saffron**
- **Continue work on HEALTH (Heat Exchanger Flow Test Bench)**

2026-05-22

PILOT:

Ning is working on wiring up Pilot 7 for printing copper with the no-depowdering process using the Mest unit. He asked me to design a 3D printed mount for the Duet 3 EB 3HC expansion board, which I have done and is currently printing.

HEALTH:

I selected the T4 DAQ and entered an order request for it along with an expansion card to add screw terminals to connect to the DB15 connector the DAQ uses for some of its IO as well as 2 components that each allow the DAQ to trigger 2 relays.

2026-05-26

HEALTH:

Original P&ID presented at the R&D meeting last Thursday:

and here is the LucidChart P&ID:

PILOT:

Need to print an SVP on the FormLabs for Pilot 7. Also need to print the contact point mount for triggering the endstop for the Mest unit Z stage.

Started 2 SVPs printing on the FormLabs, although Ben found an SVP that Pourya had been using that can be installed on Pilot 7 immediately. I believe it's one he rejected because the height of the bottom surface of the SVP did not work for his application. It has definitely been used before (there is some powder caked on the inside of the SVP inlet plenum chamber).

I printed a contact point mount for triggering the endstop for the Mest unit Z stage on Pilot 7, but it did not come out as well as I'd like, so I am reprinting it in a different orientation.

GENERAL R&D:

Runout Station Link:

 [Sign in](#) to access [Google Drive Document](#)

For reference, the maximum TIR allowed is 25 microns (this may be a circular runout measurement instead of TIR; circular runout is measurement at one ring around the surface being measured while Total Indicated Runout is a measurement of the entire surface, so both around the part and along it in the axial direction. TIR can catch issues that circular runout cannot, such as tapering of the part and axial angle misalignment vs distance between parallel axes).

Talked with Adriana, Ning, Mason, and Ben in the parking lot after work.

2026-05-27

HEALTH:

Spoke with Senai about the test bench. He is of the opinion that we should test a heat exchanger by mounting it to a GPU to compare it with a COTS equivalent. This makes for a much simpler, although much less flexible, test bench. At its simplest, we would only need a coolant reservoir held at a constant temperature and a pump with controlled flow to control the input to the heat exchanger, then mount an exchanger to the GPU and run the GPU at different loads while measuring the GPU temperature with its internal temperature sensors.

This makes my job easier because the test bench design is much simpler, and it creates a much simpler data set: at its simplest, there would be one graph of GPU temperature vs load with different curves for different flow rates and the 3DEO design and competitor's design shown on the same graph.

It also would be a compelling demo to stupid executives, because we would be showing that a drop-in product made by 3DEO performs better than a commercially available product.

The downside is that we would need to design and print a complete product heat exchanger that is optimized for the GPU, or is just generally so high performance that it beats commercial products even when not optimized for the exact application. Senai is confident that this can be done within the necessary timeframe (my SWAG is that we will need a heat exchanger ready for final testing within 6 weeks, assuming that we get funding to do this 30-60-90 plan).

PILOT:

Ning sent out an email saying that he wants to use shielded twisted-pair cables instead of the unshielded cables we have been using that run out of the control cabinet to connect to various components. His goal is to reduce electrical interference, which was not an issue on Pilots 1-5. It did not become an issue until Pilots 6 and 7 had electrical and software changes as compared with 4 and 5 (Epsons 1 and 2). Shielded cables are about twice as expensive as unshielded cables, a pain to work with because the shielding needs to be removed when stripping insulation to attach electrical connectors, and the cables are thicker so they may necessitate different IcoTek blocks to pass them through the control cabinet wall (which is not very difficult but is a design change that needs to be monitored and recorded) and larger cable carriers (which frankly we should switch to anyway because of how overcrowded the current ones are from the extra cables for the three spindles and the Mest unit).

If I were communicating appropriately with people, here's what I would do:

- Ask Ning why he wants to use shielded cables. Is there a reason they are necessary for this exact application, or does he want to use them because it is standard practice for reducing interference?
- Why was this not an issue on the previous Pilots?

- What data is present showing that interference is causing the issues that have been seen (disconnection between Duet and Raspberry Pi, although there may be other issues of which I am unaware)? Is there oscilloscope data showing the interference and evidence that that is correlated with disconnection, or is this just assumed to be an issue?
- What approaches has Ning taken to eliminate noise in the control cabinet? Are all components star grounded as they were in Pilots 1-5? Have other noise suppression techniques been used, such as adding a diode to the solenoid valve to dissipate the energy in the coil when it is shut off?
- Has noise on each ground been measured to show that it is present when the grounds are star connected, and shown to be eliminated by isolating the grounds?

Started a print on the Bambu X1E of the cable carrier mounts that support the cable carrier as the Y gantry moves.

2026-05-28

PILOT:

Ben asked for a new design of the vacuum hose splitter that is mounted to the X axis cable carrier to run one vacuum hose to the standard cutting SVP and one vacuum hose to the facing SVP.

Cleaning up the print files on the SD card that has been used on the Bambu X1E for printing parts for the Pilot printers.

Removed obviously unnecessary files (a bunch of random files seem to have wound up on the SD card over time, either because they were manually loaded onto the SD card outside of the machine or because the Bambu Labs slicer software was set to store the print file on the SD card).

Need to send out a link to a newly created folder containing STEP files for 3D printed files for Pilot 8. Also collecting STEP files of all the necessary 3D printed parts in that folder. There are a bunch of files in the folder that were used on the Epson printers but are now unnecessary because they will be machined for Pilot 8 (mostly various endstop mounts).

HEALTH:

I want to get the design of the test bench to the point that I can do a PDR at the R&D weekly meeting tomorrow.

2026-05-29

HOPPER:

The machined parts for Hopper V5.2 finally showed up from Xometry. At the morning standup, Marcus said to deprioritize the hopper in favor of developing the CleanPrint(tm) process or, in my case, the heat exchanger test bench.

Requested that Ben remove the hopper from Pilot 2 so I can scavenge the various expensive components from it (bearings, etc.) and assemble Hopper V5.2. I am confident that it will never be used, but I plan to put it together and have it on my desk as a cool looking show piece.

PILOT:

Gave the modified stage side machined aluminum Mest mount to Ben.

R&D Weekly Meeting:

CleanPrint(tm):

Main focus of this past week was learning about the process, knowledge transfer, and G-code optimization.

Midhun wants to increase the air temperature of the internal chamber of the printer to reduce the likelihood of the sacrificial filler material cracking.

ZZ has set up a Jira page for slicer work and is requesting that any change requests be formalized in Jira.

Devin invited to meeting to answer questions about which machines had been used to print previous heat exchanger models.

There have apparently been issues with the Mest unit rubbing on the build or plate. The print was not supposed to use the Mest unit at all, but for some reason the Mest unit dropped during the print.

Alex left the meeting after 30 minutes. He returned 30 minutes later. He left after 10 minutes.

Meeting appears to be exclusively focused on modifying the slicer to work with the current CleanPrint(tm) process.

Midhun et al goals or next week:

Get the Mest operating on Pilot 7. Run an extended non-CleanPrint(tm) print first to ensure that it can print TRS coupons in copper without the Mest dispenser.

Run prints on Pilot 6 while getting good telemetry and adjust parameters to get good parts.

TO DO:

- Finish generating STEP files for 3D printing parts for Pilot 8
- Get LabJack T4 up and running integrated with LabView
- Finish component selection
- Finish detailed design
- Order components

2026-06-02

GENERAL:

There was a visitor from Nippon Sanso. The Nippon Sanso Holdings Corporation, a subsidiary of Mitsubishi Chemicals Group, which is owned by the Mitsubishi Group. The Nippon Sanso Holdings Corporation owns Taiyo Nippon Sanso, a company that manufactures industrial gases. The NSHC also owns Thermos, strangely enough, which it turns out is both an American company and not just a genericized trademark. I think the visitor was from Taiyo Nippon Sanso based on the fact that they focused on the use of inert gases in our printing process (per Mason). Per Marcus, they are interested in spooling up an AM facility (I assume in Japan, although Marcus didn't specify), and may be interested in setting up some of our printers there.

HEALTH:

I need the design of the heat exchanger flow test bench to be at a point where I can present it to the team at the Heat Sync tomorrow (which Midhun and I have been added to).

I am dropping the maximum pump pressure from 100 to 30 PSI because I realized that the max pump pressure only needs to match the max heat exchanger delta P (probably about 15 PSI) with a buffer for blocked heat exchangers and extreme geometry. This expands the possibility space of pumps that can be used.

2026-06-03

Heat Sync:

Weekly meeting on heat exchangers w/ Marcus, Alex, Sean, Senai, and me. Midhun was invited but I guess he had a baby in the last day or two.

Marcus presented some results from CoolIT Systems Inc. about a 15 kW heat exchanger with a flow rate of 18 LPM of a water/glycol solution.

For my test bench, I need a signoff on maximum pressure drop across the heat exchanger (currently 36 PSI), maximum flow rate (currently 8 LPM), and maximum power input into the heater block (currently open, I was thinking in the region of 1kW but that may need to be

bumped up). I also need to know the input coolant temperature range. Chip based heat application or generalized heater block?

0-7 PSI diff press sens

Pump OK to 8 LPM

2.5 kW min, 5 kW

Coolant inlet T: Room temp to 45C, -10 to 60C optimum

Marcus is talking about the “hero plate” design, which it sounds like nominally is a cooling plate designed for a COTS Nvidia GPU (the modern model heat exchangers are being designed for currently is the Nvidia Blackwell series, whose power is ~1200 W). The actual commercial data center boards have multiple GPU and HBM (high bandwidth memory) modules on an Interposer substrate (silicon substrate). The name Marcus is using for the assembly is a MCM (multi-chip module). One sticking point is that the chips tend to be at different heights so the bottom of our heat exchanger will need to have steps machined into the bottom. <note: our heat exchanger will warp due to temperature changes and temperature gradients, and this effect may be more exaggerated than it would be with more traditional manufacturing processes because our printed parts have wacky material properties, which may be worse with the PEG added to parts>.

Based on a diagram Marcus showed, the Rubin GPU/HBM square has a layout of 47.5X47.5mm. Marcus' target for the demo HX is a functional (chilled) layout of 65X65mm. There is a question of how non-uniform the heat application to our heat exchanger from the GPU will be in service.

Sean modified his simulations to use the actual measured thermal conductivity of our printed parts: 367 w/mK for Sandvik 122 HIP and 330 w/mK for Ultrafine 198 HIP. His results showed that the degradation in max and average temperature in operation is less than 0.5%. <note: this seems to counter the common assertion that 3D printing in pure copper doesn't actually give a large advantage over alloys.

Sean has also been doing transient analyses instead of his previous steady-state simulations, which is valuable for applications like AEM's wafer testing where exchangers need to be heated and cooled quickly.

He also did a structural analysis of the heat sink because Accretech asked if a 100X100mm heat sink could withstand 300 kgf of compressive force. The maximum stress was ~4 MPa, with a nominal yield stress of 43 MPa, which is good, but deflection was predicted to be about 50 microns, which sounds high to me, but the spec would need to be checked with Accretech.

Accretech uses Galden D02TS coolant.

GENERAL R&D:

Got an email from MRF furnace manufacturer:

[🔗 One moment, please...](#)

If we do move to a different facility, we will likely need to set up a couple (?) of small (?) vacuum furnaces.

There is interest in running copper production on the Beta printers by retrofitting the Betas with the same electronics on the Pilot printers. We have 8 Betas ready for retrofitting and 1 that is usable but has been contaminated with carbide so would need to be cleaned before use with copper. My task is to figure out how to install the Mest unit in the Betas. Per Alex, my priorities are Pilot 8 - HEALTH - Beta Mest retrofit.

Ken onsite today, currently in a meeting with Marcus and Alex at 4:38 PM.

2026-06-04

I asked Marcus at the morning standup how the talk with him, Alex, and Ken yesterday went, and he said it went fine. Apparently it was not about the theoretical new company, it was just that Ken wanted to hear about the current status of projects at 3DEO. Ken was also here most/all of the day yesterday, but seemed to stay in the white room and, as far as I am aware, did not speak with anyone other than Marcus and Alex. This morning, Marcus said that the board is currently paying the salary of all 3DEO employees, so they are incentivized to get this new company started so that it will be paying us instead (or just lay all of us off). There is still no word on whether this new company will even come to exist or not, and certainly no additional clarity on how employee transitioning to the new company will work.

Speaking with ZZ and Mason, Mason said that he heard that this new company will in fact give us health insurance (which is something Alex had to fight for, which is terrifying; it had never occurred to me that any kind of startup or engineering company would not offer health insurance. For them to even consider starting up a new company that does not offer health insurance is already a HUGE red flag) and that they will offer “competitive” wages. I would hope that this means that the wages will be a significant bump over what we are getting at 3DEO to send the message that this new company will not just be a carbon copy of 3DEO being used as a way to dodge debt but is instead a completely new company that will take 3DEO’s IP and get it done right this time, but I suspect that they will be grudgingly matching the salaries we have at 3DEO (which are already lower than average companies in the area). Alex did mention a few

weeks ago that he expects that this new company will offer greater employee ownership in the company (referring to stock options, not meaningful ownership), which would be nice if true, although stock options are generally not worth anything for about 10-15 years after a company has been founded, and if the clock is reset with this new company then we're looking at a 10% likelihood of a significant payout (90% of startups fail) no earlier than 2040, so that's obviously not compelling to me in monetary terms, although it would be a nice gesture.

Mason also said that it is possible that someone may outbid Ken and Takeshi and whoever else for 3DEO's IP, which would mean that this new company concept would evaporate, although I find that highly unlikely.

Let's get some boundaries on the (likely, I'm not going to go far outside the realm of likelihood here) bell curve here:

Worst Case:

Everyone shows up on Monday to find the doors locked, and any personal stuff left in the building now belongs to the creditors and the police are called to escort everyone off of the property. They terminate everyone with cause to prevent anyone from claiming unemployment. An unpleasant situation, but the response is simple; I have a dozen contingencies in place for this eventuality.

Best Case:

They start up this new company and rehire everyone with the same or improved benefits. They are able to purchase all of 3DEO's IP. There is some timeline to demonstrate manufacturing a heat exchanger. What then? What would we need to do to be a long-term viable company? First, we would need a 1 year, 5 year, and 10 year business plan showing that we have a clear and compelling path to profitability, that there is a market for whatever we plan to sell, and that we are capable of meeting the needs of that market. Then we would need to execute on that plan.

PILOT:

I worked with Mohsen to remove the Mest spindle stage from Pilot 6 (one of the SS M3 BHCS had been stripped so I had to use a Torx bit to remove it) and I machined down one of the dovetails on the Mest-side mount. As I expected before removing the dovetail, the root cause seems to be that when the set screws used to retain the dovetail were installed it distorted the aluminum dovetail and because I had machined the dovetails with such a close fit that raised metal interfered with removing the dovetails. There are a few ways to resolve this: one would be to switch to set screws with a soft tip that clamp down but do not damage the aluminum, but what I ended up doing was machining down one of the Mest-side dovetails so that there is a flat surface the set screws will hit that is spaced off of the stage-side dovetail, so that even if there

is material raised on the Mest-side dovetail, it will not interfere with installation or removal of the Mest unit. The downside is that there is no longer any force holding the Mest-side dovetail against the flat face of the stage-side dovetail mount, so uninstalling and reinstalling the Mest unit will shift its position, but it should stay locked in position once the set screws are tightened.

CleanPrint(tm):

Marcus sent out an email talking about the concept of reactivating the Beta printers, upgrading the electronics with Pilot electronics, and installing the Mest unit on them to enable printing no-depowdering copper heat exchangers.

His goal with this email seems to be raising some ideas of increasing throughput on the printers by using multiple spindles, multiple Mest units, or some combination of the two. The inside dimensions of the mist box (which defines the maximum theoretical printable footprint) are 7.625" square (193.675mm) which, assuming a scaling factor of 1.25, yields a theoretical sintered part footprint of about 155mm, or four parts that are about 77.5mm square. Printing all the way up against the mist box would probably not work reliably, so the real-world limits would be stricter. For the sake of clean numbers, call it 4 parts that are 75mm square. Still highly optimistic, but not impossible.

I find this line of discussion to be interesting but worrisome; we are far from having a reliable printing process for a single part at a time printing on the Pilots, and scaling production on a different machine would take a significant amount of extra work versus getting the process to work on Pilots (it might just be double the work, but based on what we have learned from the F-35 program I'd say we are looking at a minimum of tripling the amount of work required).

HEALTH:

Now that I have the general design and components reviewed and approved (kind of, technically I didn't go over each component but the general architecture was approved) I can start on the detailed design of the test bench. I am first trying to figure out how to design and size the structure.

2026-06-05

HEALTH:

Working on detailed CAD for the heat exchanger flow test bench to have something to show at the weekly R&D meeting this afternoon.

R&D WEEKLY MEETING:

Mohsen saw some unusual cutting behavior where the cut seemed to be 40 microns deeper in the middle of the plate in the Y direction and shallower at both ends of the plate.

Mason is seeing dimensional variation across TRS coupons printed from copper on Pilot 7.

Dong conducted some experiments with the Atomik binder on copper. Layers were subjectively weaker and more brittle than 3DEO's binder, and during breakout of a full print many of the coupons broke.

In discussion with the Atomik chemist, Marcus and Dong learned that in binder jetting the SOP is to take the entire print and cure it while parts are still embedded in dry powder for an extended period of time at high temperature.

Mason asked about switching to a binder jet head, and Marcus' response was that it would be a large development activity and if green parts are weak before post-print curing then it may be difficult to machine them during the print. Mason also raised the concept of using a wax jetting head, and Marcus seemed open to it as a long-term productivity improvement. Bottom line is that these are seen as **outside the scope of our activities for the next 90 days** at least and are seen as **productivity improvements** and not **capability improvements**.

Mohsen showed a print conducted with 17-4 PH powder. Around layer 34, there were issues that occurred with the sacrificial filler material dispenser. The Mest unit had crashed during a print and was unable to be calibrated reliably. The Mest unit has since been replaced with a spare unit that seems to not have the same calibration issues, but the print shown was done with the damaged unit.

Ning noted that the negative terminal to the nebulizer driver CMD cable was not connected on Pilot 6 <then how did the driver keep working? Is there a separate negative connection?>

TO DO:

- **Print out and prepare dial indicator mount for testing motion stages on Pilot 7 and assist Mason with use**
- **Hard stop to prevent the Mest unit from dropping below 2mm above the surface of the base plate**
- **Generate BOM for heat exchanger test bench**

2026-06-08

PILOT:

There is only one machined aluminum carriage spacer around, and 2 are needed for Pilot 8, so I am going to make some more. They are a super simple part so it should be easy enough for me to make some on one of the Trak mills.

Apparently the plan now is to sell both Trak machines, both Haas machines, and the 2 op mill. Nick is cleaning up the Trak machine that I have been using in preparation for selling it, so it is unlikely that any of the mills will be an available resource.

This is a very interesting case study on the values of having machine tools onsite and having engineers who are both trained and permitted to use them: if there are no machinists around, either someone else runs the machines or you don't get the parts you need. Same thing with not having the appropriate tools: if you don't have the tools, you don't get the parts you need. If you have no internal tools, everything needs to be farmed out to an external service provider, which is either slow or expensive or both, and denies company employees the chance to develop new skills and form a greater understanding of the manufacturing processes. This varies depending on the complexity of the part, of course; if it is a very complex part requiring extensive programming and complex fixturing, then the calculus may change because of the amount of time it would take for an engineer to program it.

I entered a purchase request for spacers to shift the position of the spindle probe on Pilot 2 to be flush with the base plate, matching Pilots 4-8. Alex C wants to experiment with Pilot 2 to get the end mill probing function working again on the Pilots.

Both Mohsen and Mason encountered issues with cut depth uniformity on Pilots 6 and 7, respectively. When cut depth varies linearly in the X direction it can be resolved with spreader bar adjustment, but linear variation in cut depth in the Y direction is trickier. Mohsen was able to resolve it by printing multiple bound layers; as more layers were stacked up, the cuts became more uniform. Mason and Dong resolved it by loosening the four screws on one Y stage carriage then retightening those screws to the specified torque of 11 Nm (this loosening/retightening step may be unnecessary but was the procedure they followed so I am noting it here) then loosening all the screws mounting down that Y stage to the base plate, jogging the gantry back and forth in the Y direction, then retightening those screws to 11 Nm.

HEALTH:

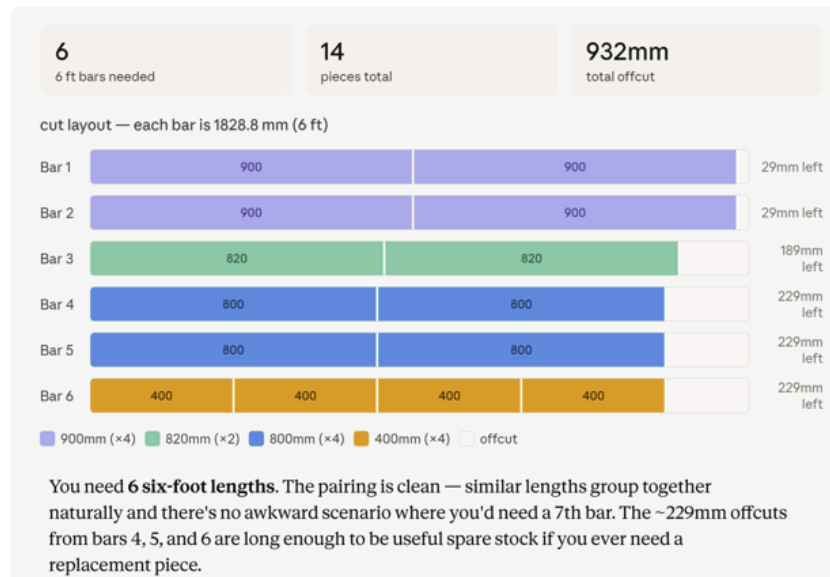
Started setting up the LabJack T4. It is powered with a USB power supply and has an ethernet connection, although it is also possible to connect to it with the USB cable, which is what I will start off with. Eventually I may switch to a ModBus connection, but for initial setup and testing a USB cable should work fine, especially because the computer-DAQ distance is quite short

(should be <6 feet). If I were connecting to the DAQ over 10s or 100s of feet, ModBus over ethernet cables would be a requirement.

2026-06-10

HEALTH:

I want to present an estimated cost for the heat exchanger test bench at the Heat Sync meeting today.



Questions I Need Answered:

- BOM cost OK? (~\$5K)
 - If not, use AIO unit?
- Machining tools available?

Heat Sync:

Senai did some simulations to determine the minimum allowable wall thickness of HXs, and recommends a thickness of 1.25mm.

He also worked on a design with targeted cooling (essentially an HX for each chip, with all HXs integrated into one component: 2.2 kW, 45C inlet, 150 psi, 2.64 lpm).

The simulation he ran did not converge and the results are nonsensical (~600C chip temp, .1m/s velocity, velocity of fluid injected in the center of polar fins did not change as it flows outward).

Marcus mentioned the 30-60-90 day plan; what exactly are the deliverables at each decision point? And who is driving those? And what will we get if we do meet them?

Alex is talking about two-phase cooling (enclosed wick exchangers and pumped two phase systems). Sean raised the idea of retrofitting single-phase liquid cooling systems with two-phase systems.

Senai pointed out that we don't want to lose focus from the "hero plate" concept if that is the goal of the 30-60-90 plan.

Marcus plans to print some sample wick structures if there is bandwidth. Specifically he wants to recreate some research that Mohsen did in grad school with mixing powder with sacrificial material, except with copper. <What is our value add? COTS heat pipes already use sintered metal as wicks. Would we be printing it all in one shot with different powders in one print, to eliminate assembly and sealing steps?>

Sean focused mainly on FEA to determine the max allowable internal pressure of printed HXs. He also highlighted that our printed parts have anisotropic strength, sharp internal corners, and a tendency for interlayer porosity to form when the cross sectional area of the part changes significantly during the print, or even just randomly as a nature of our process and process controls.

His simulations showed that it could handle up to 150 PSI (with a safety factor of 1.2 PSI haha), but a deformation of 140 microns at 50 PSI, 258 at 100, 358 at 150. It is also important to note that this is with a wall thickness of .5mm. This is an interesting artifact of the the high level design architecture where it uses large empty plenum spaces that then feed into many microchannels. He found that adding a reinforcing wall reduced the deformation by a factor of two, but increased the max stress. Increasing the roof thickness to 1mm reduced deformation and stress, although the results are confusing and seem to show slightly more deformation with a thicker wall?

There is interest in testing the failure pressure of heat sinks along with the deformation of the part as pressure is varied.

Sean also ran some FEA on compressing the heat exchanger, although the results came out a little weird; it looks like he applied a pressure to the top surface instead of a uniformly applied force so the deformation distance of the top surface varied depending on the underlying features.

Sean also did a simulation to compare our heat exchanger design with CoolIT's design, based on the data they have published for a heat exchanger running at 15 kW with a flow rate of 18 LPM and an inlet temperature of 45C. He assumed PG25 coolant because it is a commonly used coolant in the industry, but CoolIT did not publish the exact coolant formulation they used. The pressure drop Sean found at those (extremely high) flow rates was in the "high double-digits" of

PSI. Our heat exchanger design's performance is somewhat lower than CoolIT's published numbers (for ours, temp rise of 48.67C and resistance of .0032 C/W, and for theirs a temperature rise of 35C and a thermal resistance of .0023 C/W).

2026-06-11

PILOT:

Ning theorizes that issues seen with the Pilots are due to fluctuations in the city provided power ultimately due to grid power shortages. Since this has not been measured and does not seem to have been an issue when we were running Saffrons, machining tools, and furnaces constantly it seems unlikely to me that our current facility and city power supply is unable to power the Pilots reliably, but it is possible that things have changed in the past year or two. Ning recommends installing power filters in the machines to filter out power surges.

I asked Devin whether he has seen these kinds of power surge issues in the past, and he said that he had seen issues that he theorized were due to power fluctuations (prints that stopped or faulted out for no obvious reason) but there was no confirmation that this was the case. If we do end up moving to a new facility, we will need a customized facility power system to meet our power needs, so I would recommend integrating power monitoring into that system when we build it.

HEALTH:

I learned that a heat source for testing heat exchangers is called a Thermal Test Vehicle (TTV):

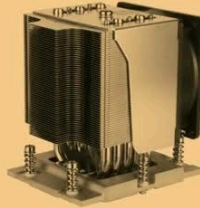
A Flexible and Scalable Thermal Test Vehicle Design for Electronics Cooling Solutions

Open Compute Project



High-Power Testing

- Steady-state operation up to 400 W



2024

FROM IDEAS TO IMPACT



OCTOBER 15-17, 2024 | SAN JOSE, CA | #OCPSUMMIT24

Watch on YouTube

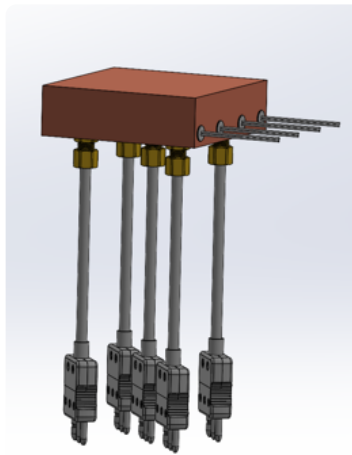
In this video they recommend an interesting way of applying and measuring heat: they have a grid of high power transistors with integrated temperature sensing

Continuing to populate the BOM. I want a reasonably accurate price (within 20% or so) to get approval to start ordering components while I finalize the design.

2026-06-12

HEALTH:

Completed preliminary design of the Thermal Test Vehicle:



It has 4X 500W cartridge heaters and 5X RTDs that have an airgap from the block until they contact underneath the DUT contact surface, so they should be minimally heated by the TTV block and mainly detect the temperature of the surface contacting the DUT.

WEEKLY R&D MEETING:

Asked Marcus what is going on with the new company, and he said to ask Alex when he showed up. Alex started off talking about the various ABC service provider companies he has been talking with. He has selected a finalist of the companies. In about 1 week, he expects 3DEO's board to assign the assets to the ABC company. There would be a roughly 30 day period where some combination of the IP and the assets would be auctioned off. The deliverables of the 30-60-90 plan seems to be internally defined. The VC people asked us for a 30-60-90 day plan for delivering a functional copper heat sink, and we have to date not sent back a proposal.

Sintering needs to be moved out-of-house in the near future; there is apparently a sintering-as-a-service facility that Elnik operates in New Jersey. Per Midhun, getting copper sintered well in

the furnace here was difficult, although we do have the advantages that the furnaces they operate are also Elniks and they have different experts and equipment that could make things easier.

Sean asked the question of whether we should even be printing with 17-4PH at all, since the business plan is built around printing with copper only. The general conclusion from Marcus was that there is still value in running 17-4.

Mohsen Mest Testing on Pilot 6

Had a print failure at midnight “due to a power surge.”

Had another print fail at 5 layers due to abnormal dispensing: the dispense volume was too high at the start of the layer then dropped and finally stopped. He noted that the PEG seemed to solidify at the bottom of the syringe, so he added insulation to the bottom surface of the syringe/heater jacket and covered up an inspection window to keep the entire syringe liquid.

Ran a test of dispense repeatability, and had good results (within .5%).

Started a new print and had poor results. He had modified the G code for this print. The cracking at the corner of the parts that had been seen in earlier prints seemed to be worse after having added the insulation.

He started a new print with new G code and saw large voids in the print after it had finished.

He changed the dispensing strategy for the part that is currently printing: instead of traveling in a continuous square, it does two parallel lines then comes back later to fill the other two parallel lines.

Midhun noted that he had previously resolved the corner cracking and other issues by increasing the chamber temperature, and Mohsen has reduced the temperature back to the older setpoint.

Mohsen's planned approach to combating these issues is by adjusting the filler dispensing strategy.

Midhun:

Mason completed developing the penetration test macro, although they are encountering issues with binder dispense variation. Midhun and Dong are trying to develop an intuitive understanding of the functionality and behavior of the Mest unit/CleanPrint process. They are seeing issues with cuts that are not very clean, although the debris can be blown off.

Mohsen noted that there is powder kicked up by droplets of sacrificial filler material that hit the cuts; when wiping off the nozzle there is powder buildup seen on it.

Midhun ran some tests with the Atomik binder. It is possible to spray it, but it seems to need to be cured for a longer period of time.

Midhun is continuing to run tests to see how well copper can be printed in pilots in general, as well as trying to get cleaner cuts. He has been blowing out cuts manually, although that may need to be automated more in the future.

Sean:

Went over some simulations he did about the importance of thermal conductivity and predicted burst pressure of heat exchangers. He also talked about some of his analyses of non-uniform heat application (hot spots).

Question I Need Answered:

- Is the BOM price OK for me to start ordering components and start assembling the test bench?
- Present options for testing if necessary (i.e. [Deal: Thermalright FW 360 White ARGB-360mm AIO CPU Liquid Cooler,IPS LCD Screen with 320 * 240 Resolution,for AM4/AM5/Intel LGA 1700,'2.4 inch'Magnet-Absorbent LCD Screen for Images -White](#))
- What do we want to test first?
- Are the mills available for use or do parts need to be machined externally?
 - Answered yesterday - Marcus asked Philip about the mills and it is OK for us to power them back on and run them in the near future as long as they are thoroughly cleaned afterwards, although I suspect that they will become unusable soon. It is better to plan to have the parts machined externally.
- Pressure testing?
 - Green light from Marcus to work on it
- Machining tools?

TO DO:

- Check for component reusability from Pilots 1, 2, and 3
- Start building pressure tester

2026-06-15

HEALTH:

I am investigating using a PCB with surface-mount transistors as the thermal test vehicle instead of a copper block with cartridge heaters. This will reduce cost and also give greater

resolution in heat application and measurement.

After extensive research and design, it looks like my best option is to use linear-mode MOSFETs as the heat source, which are designed to operate in the linear region instead of the typical on/off behavior of MOSFETs. Usually you want MOSFETs to dissipate as little heat as possible because you typically use them for switching loads on and off, but in my case I am trying to use the MOSFET as the load and have it dissipate all the heat, which runs the risk of destroying the components. The Linear 2 series of MOSFETs made by IXYS (now owned by Littelfuse) is designed to operate continuously within the linear analog region where it will be dissipating large amounts of heat, so it is my best bet for a MOSFET that is also a heat source. The downside to these components is that they're pretty expensive; it's ~\$18 per component, and with my nominal original design I would need 100 of them. I'm planning to reduce the number of MOSFETs and either reduce the power capability of the TTV, drive each MOSFET with more power, or more likely a combination of the two.

2026-06-16

HEALTH: Working on refining the design of the MOSFET-based heater.

GENERAL:

Apparently Takeshi asked for an update with less than 24 hours advance notice (hi, I'm a bad omen!). He asked about updates on the thermal design stuff and also the CleanPrint process. Various people spent today working on presentation materials (Mohsen, Midhun, Mason, Dong, Sean).

Mohsen:

Achievements - challenges - next steps format (nice!) for 17-4 and copper (also nice organizing!) although he actually started with 17-4 issues and not achievements, so there is room for improvement there.

Takeshi kinda sidetracked things asking about the geometry that is being printed, so Marcus showed a CAD model of the current geometry. Takeshi asked about the printed size (~25X25mm).

Mohsen went over some details of number of layers printed successfully (54) and some low-level issues, like PEG breaking off and being moved around the print bed during the facing operation. Takeshi was confused by the term "flattening" being used instead of facing. He asked about the repeatability of the amount of sacrificial filler material dispensed. He asked for a

standard deviation of wax amount dispensed. When Marcus pointed out that we always try to overfill the cuts, Takeshi asked what percentage we overfill cuts by.

Next steps:

Run prints to identify the key challenges to printing heat sink designs (we haven't done that? Granted, I haven't done that either, so I am as responsible as anyone else), improve side wall surface finish, cure the green parts and evaluate the quality (aren't we always doing that?) conduct sintering and end-part evaluation experiments ().

Takeshi asked how CleanPrint(tm) affects the hardness of the green body versus standard IL printing, which is an interesting question. Per Marcus, CleanPrint(tm) has not had any noticeable affect on green part quality.

Midhun took over to discuss printing with copper powder. He also discussed the tests conducted with Atomik binder, which resulted in lower than expected green part strength (~1.5 MPa vs Atomik's predicted 5-6 MPa strength). Takeshi asked about the cause of this discrepancy, which Midhun theorizes is due to the lower binder saturation used in IL versus binder jetting. Midhun also raised the point that Atomik has suggested using a solvent-based binder, which is spectacularly unwise with our process. Takeshi asked about average part strength in IL, and we are apparently generally seeing about 3 MPa in copper, 6 MPa in 17-4PH, and 8-9 MPa in Inconel.

Marcus (by his own admission) may have oversold Ken and Takeshi on the importance of green strength in the CleanPrint(tm) process, so Takeshi was focusing heavily on improving green strength.

Midhun went over some of the issues we have been seeing with copper powder being embedded in the sacrificial filler material when cutting into previously filled cuts (not during the facing operation). He also showed some pictures of cracks forming in the build around lines of PEG dispensed and Takeshi immediately flagged the possibility of shrinkage of PEG when cooling causing the cracks, which is indeed highly probable, although not yet confirmed. Mohsen noted that he has prevented cracking with the sacrificial filler material dispense strategy (dispensing in separated lines instead of a continuous dispense path around the perimeter of a part).

Midhun noted that there is PEG debris being seen on the cake from the facing operation, on both stainless steel and copper.

For copper, Midhun's next steps are to print and troubleshoot printing in copper, including starting to print the microchannel geometry.

Takeshi asked about the expected timelines for the next steps that Midhun and Mohsen discussed, and Midhun said that the predicted date of completion is the end of the month. Takeshi asked about whether there is a plan to bring up more printers for CleanPrint(tm) of copper, which led to Senai discussing the predicted timeline of completing Pilot 8. His estimate is 2 weeks to completion of mechanical systems and 1 week beyond that for electrical system completion and commissioning (sounds unlikely to me, but I'll try to support meeting that objective as much as I can).

Takeshi asked about the time to print (unsure if this is time from start of print to removal of green part from printer, or if this includes the sacrificial filler material removal process, debinding, and sintering, which would be a gazillion times longer). For 17-4, Mohsen claims 6 hours, and for copper, Midhun claims 24 hours for de-PEG and 48 for debind. Takeshi asked how many test runs we can conduct in one month. For sintering copper, we do a double sinter and HIP run. I think a best-case estimate for start of print to sintered part out is 1 week, but as Marcus pointed out we can start running more experiments before the part is done sintering. I'd say 10-15 prints per month is likely feasible.

Sean went over some of their HX microchannel design and simulations.

Takeshi asked if our performance is the best in the industry, and said that a chart comparing our performance with others', particularly Fabric8Labs, would be useful for him.

2026-06-17

GENERAL:

Senai is working on accelerating the timeline of Pilot 8 by reducing the documentation that will be generated in the process of building it. I talked with him about whether there is an integrated software package that will make it possible to design the electrical and mechanical systems in CAD and have those changes propagate automatically to the BOM and also organically feed into build instructions, and he is not aware of any. In theory some of those features are available with various SolidWorks packages (for mechanical CAD the BOM in drawings can be automatically updated, but that still needs manual population of all the hardware (which actually doesn't sound that hard, now that I'm writing it out)).

One issue is that we have a machine designed in SolidWorks but not fully populated with all necessary components so the BOM is incomplete, both due to missing hardware that I left out for the sake of expediency and electrical components that are time consuming to model (terminal blocks etc.) or difficult to model (wires, cable harnesses, etc.).

There is also minimal documentation for assembly procedures (there are videos somewhere for some of the processes, but even I have lost track of exactly where they are).

And then we have issues with communication of information between stakeholders: Ning has information about the electrical system and wiring, I have information about the design and components, Senai needs to oversee assembly and integration, Cisco needs to do the actual assembly, and Adriana needs to do ordering and inventory.

We need a system that integrates all this information to enhance communication but more importantly record everything that needs to be ordered and how it needs to be assembled without detailed manual intervention (such as needing people to write everything they do down, which is too time consuming).

Midhun, Mohsen, Dong, and Mason are working on two issues being seen with the Mest dispensers: liquid PEG is building up on the nozzle during the print (possibly only some prints?) and dripping on the build, and PEG in the syringe is solidifying and preventing dispensing of the PEG during the print.

There are some theories as to why this might be occurring:

Nozzle liquid PEG buildup:

- Piezo speed or frequency set incorrectly
- Leakage from faulty o-rings
- Insufficient air cooling of the piezo system (cooled with adjustable compressed air flow)

PEG solidifying:

- Bulk PEG pellets have degraded over time due to exposure to moisture and oxygen when the storage bottle is opened (one of my theories)
- Actual temperature of the Mest heaters varies even with the same setpoint (also one of my theories)
- Environmental conditions in the printer (too cold)
- Improper installation of the syringe (poor contact with the heating jacket etc.)

HEALTH:

I am working on a semi-modular approach to the heat source PCB: each MOSFET will have an associated DAC for current control, a shunt resistor and INA229 (NOT INA2290) for reading shunt resistor current (the INA229 also has an internal temperature sensor, so if you design the

PCB so that the INA229 and the shunt resistor are in contact you can measure the shunt resistor temperature and use that to compensate for resistance change as a result of temperature and get a more accurate current value), and a temperature sensor (that is connected to the copper heat transfer plate), all of which communicate with an RP2040 (either a XIAO board soldered to the main board or possibly an RP2040 directly mounted to the board) using SPI. The way SPI works is that the 3 data lines from the MCU are wired to each SPI device in parallel, and there needs to be an independently controlled chip select pin for each device. This means that the MCU needs a minimum of 48 digital outputs, but just in case I am going to design it with a spare output for each node for a total of 64 outlets. Fortunately these outputs don't need to have any fancy communication capabilities, so I am going to use an array of 74HC595 serial-to-parallel shift registers (8X ICs, each of which has 8X digital outputs).

2026-06-18

GENERAL:

The homing switch on the U tank of Pilot 6 wasn't working, so I removed the 3D printed endstop mount, sanded down the face of the mount so that the endstop switch is more exposed, and reinstalled it. I also checked the Molex connectors because people have a tendency to crimp the contacts incorrectly which can result in them breaking, but they seemed OK. Ben tested homing after reinstallation and it seems to be working. For Pilots 8 forward the U and V tank endstop mounts are machined from aluminum, which should help with reliability of the endstops because the 3D printed part can warp over time and shift the endstop to a position where it doesn't contact the U or V tank plates, but the accessibility of the endstop mount is an issue. I think the endstop mount should bolt directly to the sides of the powder tank module, with the screws moved closer to the bottom so that they can be reached more easily. Also, the powder and build tank module needs to be redesigned so that it can be removed from the machine easily (using a rolling cart with extended arms like OneClickMetal's design) and also needs to be easier to disassemble for cleaning and maintenance. I also think it should be redesigned with filleted corners similar to EOS printer plates to make sealing easier and more robust.

The Bambu P1S ran into an issue with overloading the extrusion motor after being switched over to a roll of blue PETG-CF when it ran out of black filament. It was still able to extrude the filament cleanly manually, so I am not sure why it claimed the motor was overloading. I overrode the error a bunch of times but it kept returning, so I killed the print.

HEALTH:

2026-06-29

GENERAL:

Working on resolving the issues seen yesterday with the Bambu P1S. I removed the failed print from yesterday and am starting a Benchy print.

I tried drying the filament for 2 hours at ~70C, with no luck. I cleaned out the nozzle with a needle, no luck. Removed and replaced the nozzle, no luck. Cleaned out the nozzle with a needle, no luck. Cleaned out the nozzle with a needle, and now it's working OK, or at least has been for a few minutes. My working theory at the moment is that the filament is wet enough to cause increased flow resistance but not a complete clog, even after 2 hours of drying. I plan to try the roll of filament over the weekend and see if that resolves the issue.

HEALTH:

I plan to present the hydrostatic pressure testing tool at the R&D meeting today.

I also want to present the MOSFET heat application design to get authorization to order some parts (I plan to make the whole PCB but start with populating and testing the central 4 nodes and populate it with all components for the 16 node array eventually.

I am struggling with how to integrate temperature sensing into the array. Right now my favored approach is to have an SPI-capable digital temperature sensor IC soldered to the surface of the PCB that is facing away from the DUT and either use an array of vias or cut out a slot and have a feature machined into the copper plate to touch the IC.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

Midhun pushed for moving the meeting to Monday because they are busy with some experiments today.

Mohsen wanted to present some results quickly. He's been running prints on Pilot 6 with the CleanPrint process with 17-4PH SS. He's been changing various parameters and machining green parts to inspect the internal features.

I asked Mohsen how he is removing the PEG, and he has been switching it between ovens manually instead of using Pourya's programmed Keith furnace cycle.

2026-06-22

HEALTH:

Per Alex, \$6K OK for test bench

I got FreeRouting working in KiCAD and I've started routing components on the PCB. I'm leaning towards maybe making a PCB with the various signal processing/generating components and with board-to-wire connectors, then run wires to MOSFETs and temperature sensors attached to the copper plate.

Meeting to Finalize 30-60-90 Day Plan:

Marcus had worked up a sketch 90 day plan a few weeks ago and has shared it around with various people, but not Ken and Takeshi yet.

Per Alex: Banks in Japan are interested in supporting a reboot of the company built on 3DEO's IP, focused on various thermal applications using the CleanPrint(tm) process. The main value-add is a fully enclosed high-performance cold plate. Our main stumbling block so far is that we have been unable to print a prototype for Japanese companies to test in-house, which would be valuable for selling to various customers in Japan. Specific milestone would be a fully enclosed heat exchanger that meets or exceeds the performance of competitors' heat exchangers. As secondary goals, the design should be scalable <I am more of the opinion that the overall design should be fully customized for each application instead of built from a series of standardized blocks> and mass-manufacturable <this is probably the real value-add of our process if we can get it working>.

Midhun asked about the number of HXs that need to be ready at the end of 90 days, to which Alex responded ~6-12. Midhun also asked about the required dimensional accuracy <internal dimensions only matter insofar as the impact the thermal performance, external footprint is somewhat more flexible as long as it fits within the right envelope. More critical are the flatness of the IC contact face over a range of temperatures. Either way, it is all wrapped up in the measured performance of the HX over the target liquid and IC temperatures and flow rate>.

Per Marcus and Alex, brazing is something that customers would like to avoid and is the main point of failure.

I asked about whether thermal performance is the main value-add or the manufacturability is the goal. Marcus' opinion is there is a threshold thermal performance that needs to be hit, and as long as we hit that, then anything beyond that is a competitive advantage <what do customers want that is beyond what they have in operation?>

Per Marcus, the big performance characteristics are thermal resistance and pressure drop (both a function of flow rate).

Mohsen asked about if customers are happy with the systems that are currently in operation and how saturated the market is currently. We are currently targeting the previous generation GPUs (Blackwell) because there is more published data about their performance, where the market is

probably saturated. This case is more of a technology demonstrator than a sellable product because of how saturated the market is. Long-term we are planning to focus on higher-performance cooling applications (possibly custom server designs). We are also targeting the semiconductor test industry (Accretech, AEM, etc.). In that case, the design parameters would need to be more customizable for low-volume high-mix parts. I asked about whether customers in this industry care about different performance specs than data center applications. Per Alex, performance specs are fairly comparable with the GPU industry, although it sounds like thermal response time may be more valuable in that industry rather than optimized heat transfer at steady-state conditions, as well as conductivity through the heat exchanger.

Mission with 90-day plan is make (design, print, sinter, HIP, machine, validate) an internally manifolded microchannel heat exchanger using the CleanPrint(tm) process on two machines and benchmark it with Blackwell-representative thermal loads and coolant flow rates.

Port design? Senai recommends against threading the copper for fittings, and joining a separate fitting (e.g. welding) is not acceptable.

Marcus wants to stick with microchannel geometries.

I asked when we will lose the Elnik functionality? Will we retain in-house machining capability?

90 day plan started on 2026-06-22 (essentially 60 day plan starting now).

30 day deliverables (2026-06-30):

- 20X20mm SS cold plate complete
- CleanPrint(tm) process functional on Pilot 7, test print of microchannel geometry, optional test of full print

60 day deliverables (2026-07-31):

- 65X65mm (Blackwell-representative) microchannel SS cold plate complete
- 20X20mm copper cold plate complete
- Copper print replication across 2 pilots attempted

90 day deliverables (2026-08-31):

- 65X65mm (Blackwell-representative) microchannel copper cold plate complete, tested, and characterized
- Successful replication across multiple Pilot printers

GENERAL R&D:

Worked on Hammer (Bambu P2S) with Devin. Devin had to take apart the entire extruder assembly to reach a piece of blue PETG-CF filament that had become jammed in the filament runout sensor, after which it was still jamming, so I cleaned out the nozzle with a needle again and it seems to be working OK now.

2026-06-23

GENERAL:

Meeting about what equipment to auction off and what equipment to try to buy at auction for the new company.

They put the 48VDC Mean Well power supplies on the list of stuff to sell, so I'll need to snag them from stock for use with the heat exchanger test bench.

Need to collect hand tools.

Need to collect the manual mill tooling to keep.

GENERAL R&D:

Meeting about changing print geometry for the CleanPrint(tm) process to reduce delams that have been seen.

Mohsen said that his current approach to reducing delams is to change the sacrificial filler material application strategy.

The meeting ended up lasting ~1.5hrs. The outcome was a few different geometries for Sean to try modeling and simulating that may print better. There was less consideration of the root cause of the issue than Senai and I would have liked; talking about it after the meeting, we both would have liked to take a more formal, systematic approach to resolving the delam issue being seen. This would involve first writing out a clear problem statement, discussing what the causes of the issue being seen could be, and designing a blocking experiment to determine which of those possible causes is at the root of what we are seeing. Instead, we jumped straight to possible solutions and discussing some issues that may or may not be related to the delams, such as issues with the facing operation where the PEG is at a higher level than the surrounding build even after one or two facing operations.

HEALTH:

I am putting together a first McMaster order for the large parts for the heat exchanger flow test bench (I am sure that more orders will be required eventually, but I want to get the large stuff out of the way first).

2026-06-24

GENERAL:

Ordering a replacement 0.4mm nozzle and a 0.6mm nozzle for the Bambu P2S because the same extruder overload error is showing up.

HEALTH:

Entering purchase requests for the big-ticket items for the heat exchanger test bench. I will need various fittings and wires and whatnot as things go along, but I want to get the big items out of the way first because those will be the most difficult to get authorized.

I need to figure out what add-ons are needed for the LabJack and get those on order.

We need the test rig soon (I said 2-3 weeks from now, call it **July 17**)

30-60-90:

The Heat Sync meeting was preempted by a 2 hour meeting about the 30-60-90 day plan.

The design concept is still to build a heat exchanger that has a repeating internal pattern (interestingly conceptually similar to a repeating TPMS structure) designed and simulated for optimal heat transfer from a uniformly heated surface.

Senai raised the possibility of switching Pilot 6 over to copper, which I agree with.

Since the end deliverable of this 90 day project is a copper part, I pitched dumping 17-4 PH printing entirely and only printing in copper since that's all we care about for now. It seems that Marcus, Alex, and Midhun are opposed to this, for two main reasons: they think that we are still learning lessons from 17-4PH prints that we can apply to copper prints <I'm not convinced> and we are also limited in copper powder quantities <that's a fair point>.

Marcus requested to order more Mest units, and Alex refused. Per Marcus, he was made aware of the risks and still decided not to authorize the order.

Per Alex, we should have access to the Elnik sintering furnace through the end of July.

2026-06-25

GENERAL:

Company-wide meeting. Ken in the office for the meeting.

Auction process preparation going from start to end of July, with auction starting August.

Markets are primarily interested in seeing application-focused AM companies (supposedly with IP behind them, although I'm not convinced of that) that are also highly focused on a small number of applications.

Ken has been working on starting a company focused solely on thermal solutions <timeline? business model?>

Midhun asked about the driver behind the 30-60-90 process. It seems to be driven by discussions with investors and studying the market. It is an open question whether we can print parts with the CleanPrint(tm) process in copper

<If the real market is in mass-manufacturing of heat exchangers, not optimizing for performance or leveraging proprietary technology, then you could start up a manufacturing company focused on reliable printing using whatever technology.>

Focus, urgency, progress, trajectory.

HEALTH:

Continuing to place requests for ordering the larger items for the heat exchanger test bench. Adriana has been having issues with opening the McMaster links on her computer for some reason, so the orders have been delayed. Fortunately, there is still design work and component selection to be done, so there is a lot I can do before items start to arrive.

The extrusion, extrusion brackets, pump, couplers, and differential pressure sensor showed up today, so I can start putting the frame together tomorrow.

2026-06-26

HEALTH:

Made a drawing and weldment cut list for the 8020 frame for the heat exchanger test bench.

Cut all the 8020 extrusion pieces to length and began assembly of the frame in the Pilot assembly area.

Figuring out the electrical IO I will need for the DAQ:

Inputs:

1X 4-20 mA input for the differential pressure sensor

1X 4-20 mA input for the absolute pressure sensor

1X Counter input for flow sensor

2X Temperature sensor inputs for inlet and outlet temperature measurement

Outputs:

1X Digital output for turning on/off the pump motor

1X Digital/analog output for pump motor speed

?X Outputs for dummy heat load

2026-06-29

17-4 PH average particle size 10 micron, D90 20 microns (per Midhun)

Weekly CleanPrint(tm) Meeting:

Mohsen ran some prints on Pilot 6 with 17-4 PH SS. He found that the facing end mill cut slightly shallower on later layers than early layers; he showed layer 8 and layer 54. The flatness of the faced layer (cutting both bound powder and filler material) measured on the VHX was within a range of 20 microns.

The bottom of the part detached and exposed the printed internal features, showing a cross section of the printed features, as well as a crack in the bound powder in between the milled slots that were filled with sacrificial filler material.

Blockage was seen in some of the risers when Mohsen sectioned that part with the Wen bandsaw (which has a poor blade right now, it is possible that it did not yield a clean cut, although the blockage subjectively does not seem to be due to the bandsaw cut.

The print being inspected was printed with off-nominal absolute humidity environmental conditions: $\sim 11 \text{ g/m}^3$, while nominal spec is $\sim 7 \text{ g/m}^3$.

The delams seem to be seen mostly when there are geometry changes. I asked Sean whether it would be possible to redesign the HX with more restrictive design features, such as a maximum CleanPrint(tm) slot size of 1mm width, 5mm length, radiused at end. This would necessitate a major labor-intensive redesign because our HXs are modeled manually instead of generatively with design rules.

<I'm wondering if we should change to a non-water-soluble sacrificial filler material so that melting out the filler does not risk degrading the metal powder binder.>

Running a print with a humidity of 7 g/m^3 was significantly better, with smaller delams seen.

Midhun:

Ran some prints with UltraFine powder but ran into issues so switched to Sandvik (double check this).

Midhun's opinion is that the delam issues are due to geometrical changes

After removing the sacrificial filler material thermally in the BlueM oven, warpage and cracking of the part was seen. It is currently using a ~6 hour cycle with ramp rates of <1 C/min.

Midhun is working on trying different formulations of PEG (Dong is blending 10% low MW PEG with the base PEG (6000?)) in the hopes of reducing shrinkage. Since this lowers the melt point of the filler material, he is also planning on trying lower dispense temperatures for the Mest unit.

HEALTH:

Get all components on order before starting initial assembly

Assemble the 8020 frame with casters and cut/drill/install the top surface

Assembled the 8020 frame with casters. It is way taller than I had initially intended; I was definitely aware of the height of the caster and I intended to compensate for it when designing the frame, but clearly I forgot to do so.

Make mount for the differential pressure sensor

Control system wiring:

- Breaker
- Terminal blocks
- PSUs
- Motor driver
- LabJack
-

2026-06-30

HEALTH:

Modifying the design of the frame to lower the work surface height to 36", which per Claude is a common standard for test benches (right now the height is ~40", which is generally used more for precision inspection and assembly so you have better access to the surface without hunching).

I entered order requests for the current shunts and 5V digital outputs for use with the LabJack T4 DAQ. I also spec'd out and ordered various Amazon parts, including quick disconnects for the DUT, high-pressure fluid hose, flare fittings, and shielded cable to connect to the sensors.

I designed a two-piece 3D-printed mount for the differential pressure sensor, which is now printing on the Bambu X1E. The printers seem to be mostly working with the PETG-CF that I had dried over the weekend, even though when you look at the filament as it is dispensing into the poop chute you can see steam or smoke coming off it. It's possible that this has always been the case with this kind of filament, or it might be an artifact of wet filament.

I cut down the vertical extrusion pieces from 800mm to 700mm, so the ground-work surface height is now ~36". I marked out the cut lines for the marine-grade HDPE sheet that will comprise the work surface of the test bench. I also asked Senai to spool up on LabView to help get the LabJack running if he has spare time once Pilot 8 is complete; I find it unlikely that he will have spare time within the foreseeable future but in case he does it would be nice to have some support with programming.

2026-07-01

GENERAL:

Marcus announced that he is leaving to go to Divergent. He will be here through next week, with next Friday being his last day. This is rather concerning because Marcus was the person who seemed to most believe in the CleanPrint(tm) process. He was also doing most of the high-level coordination of tasks working towards our 30-60-90 plan objectives. Without him, the most logical replacement is Midhun, although I am not sure how much management and team coordination experience he has, and also whether or not he is interested in that role. Aside from the logistical implications of Marcus leaving, I am unsure why exactly he has chosen to leave. It is possible that it is because he wants something from his role that he is not getting here, or that he simply does not believe in the path that the group here is taking, or the technology itself (I can't say that it is the direction of the company because 3DEO is dissolving and potentially being reformed, but nominally the team should be continuous).

I talked with Senai about the design of the Beta printers, mainly why they have a linear stage positioning each spindle motor as well as a stage that positions a plate to which all four individual stages are mounted.

Senai has canceled the "Heat Sync" weekly meeting indefinitely.

Senai has been tasked with adapting the Beta printers to function similarly to the Pilot printers with the CleanPrint process, so I suspect it is unlikely that he will be able to work on setting up a LabView application with the LabJack DAQ, which I am actually happy about because that is something that I really wanted to do.

I spoke with Midhun about Marcus leaving, and he seemed pretty positive about it. His priority is the 65X65mm copper heat exchanger 30-60-90 plan, and as he sees it everyone knows what

they need to do to complete this, so there is no need for a manager focused on high-level strategy at the moment.

HEALTH:

My plan today is to cut and install the work surface of the heat exchanger test bench, get the cross members for the motor and pump mount plate installed, and start laying out components for wiring up the control cabinet.

The work surface is all fabricated and bolted down, and I have started laying out the control cabinet components. Fortunately there are lots of spare parts that were either ordered for the Pilots or taken out of the Betas, so I haven't run across anything yet that I will need to order. I tested the PETG-CF pressure sensor mounts, and they were both slightly too short and a little weaker than I'd like, so I tweaked the design and am currently reprinting them on the Bambu X1E from PAHT-CF.

I cut down the cross members for the motor/pump mount plate, but I don't have enough drop-in nuts to install them in the frame.

2026-06-02

GENERAL:

Talked with Senai about the plans for 3D printed parts for the Beta printers, as well as the high level approach and goals for modifying them. It sounds like he plans to reuse as much of the Pilot hardware designs as possible (even down to using the same spreader bar and mist box). I asked if the intent was to use these for production, and he said that production is not even on our radar yet, the goal is only to provide more printers to Midhun et al, in particular for printing stainless steel powder. This obviously doesn't make any sense, so I asked Senai how he felt about all that, and he said something along the lines of he has a concrete goal that he is happy to work towards. I said that that's a healthy attitude, or at least a positive attitude, and he said I should try it some time.

This is actually quite an interesting philosophical conundrum. I am also extremely familiar with working towards a goal you don't believe in (I always believe everything is going to fail, so I am constantly thinking of alternatives and contingencies), but I am also always thinking about what the right thing to do would be, if it were possible.

Since I always have these three things in mind (what are we going to do, what might we do within foreseeable limits, and what should we do if we had the resources to work towards our end goals optimally) anytime I'm talking with people here, regardless of what I actually plan to

do in the immediate future, I have a tendency to annoy people because some of what I am talking about is not directly relevant to the tasks that we are going to complete in the next few days. Senai in particular does not seem to appreciate me talking about such high-level goals and approaches, so I am going to modify my approach to talking with him. I am going to avoid talking about:

- High-level company approaches
- Long-term company goals (such as how to manage the transition from R&D technology demonstration to production)
- Management structure
- Electrical/electronic systems
- Anything space related
- Technology significantly beyond what we have here (alternative metal AM technologies, etc.)
- Making new machines from scratch that are better optimized for our process
- Significant modifications to our hardware and/or process (replace square tanks with round ones, switch to binder jetting heads, Hereaus heaters, etc.)
- Fluid fittings/lines (he ignored me when I sent him a McMaster link to a really cool modular fluid fitting product, so I don't think that is a particular interest of his)
- Pressure testing

I will focus on near-term problems and solutions, and avoid long-term strategic questions or discussions of what we should be doing instead of what we are doing.

HEALTH:

Designed and printing a test fit part for making a twist-in cable mount for the 8020 extrusion I am using. This will function similarly to the screw-in zip tie mounts, but I plan to print it with flexible arms so it holds cables without zip ties and it will have an integrated piece that will take the place of drop-in nuts. The theory is you can print a bunch of these, install them in seconds, and guide cable along the extrusion easily, quickly, and cheaply.

Received some more components for the test bench, including the shielded cable for sensors, the aluminum flare fittings, and the two quick disconnects.

I am designing mount brackets to attach the radiator to the 8020 frame.

I need to design an adapter to adapt the radiator ports to flare fittings.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

Mohsen:

Printed and sintered some top-port heat exchangers. There were delams seen at the edge of layers where PEG was applied.

He tried vibration depowdering of the top manifolds, which did get powder out but they require further testing to determine how well the manifolds were depowdered (sectioning, flow testing if the samples are sealed).

Moved Pilot 6 to the environmentally controlled pod and printed the staggered channel design of the heat exchanger and saw the same three localized delams as had been seen previously.

At layer 78 of a print, the print failed because the spindle bit broke. The print had PEG dispensing in the manifold layers, which may or may not have been correct (since we are switching to traditionally depowdered manifolds).

I volunteered to pressure test a few of the sintered samples. They will need to have their ports drilled and tapped for M5 or M3 fittings

Midhun:

Printing copper microchannel HXs with Ultradine powder.

When running the thermal filler removal process, he found that a part left in the cake for the thermal process seemed to survive OK (although with some part breakage) but the part removed from the cake before the thermal removal process collapsed and had PEG residue pooling on the ceramic setter.

Midhun's plan is to remove the PEG by melting it out through the part in a lower-temperature "DEPEG" cycle, then vaporize any residue out during the standard air debind cycle.

The thermal filler material process seems to be degrading the sugar binder during the debind cycle of copper parts.

HEALTH:

My goal is to have the heat exchanger test bench built and wired this week, then switch to programming and testing next week.

Tasks that need to be completed:

- ☒ Fabricate the motor mount plate
- ☒ Design and print the mount for the pump
- ☐ Design and print a cover for the shaft coupler assy
- ☐ Assemble and install the motor and pump stack and attach the coolant filter
- ☒ Wire the pump motor

- ☒ Drill holes in and install the control cabinet
- ☒ Bolt down DIN rail and wire duct to subpanel
- ☐ Install and wire electrical components (inc. LabJack)
- ☐ Figure out heat application system with integrated temp sensors and order parts early in the week so they are here before the start of next week
 - ☒ Select heat application system (1000W electronic hot plate)
 - ☐ Design heat flow sensing system (copper block with RTDs installed)
- ☐ Adapt flare fittings to the ambient temperature radiator
- ☐ Attach flare fittings to all the wetted components
- ☐ Make and install PTFE SS braid hoses
- ☐ Design and print the differential pressure sensor mount
- ☐ Heater
 - ☐ Spec out and order cartridge heaters
 - ☐ 1000W?
 - ☐ Insulation of heater stack
 - ☐ Stack machined copper plates and solder/TIM together

2026-07-07

HEALTH:

Tested attaching the radiator mounts that were printed last night, and found that the dimensions were incorrect, so I tweaked the design and am trying to reprint them.

Redesigned the pressure sensor mount and am now printing it from NylonX along with a batch of twist in zip tie mounts.

Printing the updated radiator mounts from PETG on one of the Ultimakers.

Working on finalizing the hose routing and sensor positioning in the manifolds.

General:

Working on collecting my personal tools on Mahmood's old desk and organizing them in case they need to be temporarily moved out of the facility. We are cleaning up the facility and collecting the tools we absolutely need in preparation for the auction of 3DEO's assets. The tools we need will be bid on by Ken and Takeshi for the new company, and the rest of the tools and resources will be auctioned off to whomever or thrown out.

2026-07-08

PILOT:

Redesigned and printing a cable carrier mount to replace a broken mount for Pilot 6. I had already increased the thickness of the base in CAD, so Pilot 6 had an older version of the part,

but as long as I was looking at the model anyway I added in further reinforcement: the part touches one of the stepper motors so it can be zip tied to the stepper motor if necessary and I am also printing it in a stronger orientation that requires support features that are more difficult to remove, so I am running the print on the Bambu X1E with PAHT-CF, the strongest filament we have when I can get it to print, along with an appropriate breakaway material

HEALTH:

Installed wire ducts and DIN rails on subpanel of control cabinet. Started populating it with components. Mounted the radiator to the 8020 structure.

GENERAL:

Milled some sintered 17-4 parts to expose the internal microchannels. Made a mold around a green part for embedding it in resin.

2026-07-09

HEALTH:

Moved the rest of the heat exchanger test bench parts to the R&D lab to clear everything out of the auction area.

Populated the subpanel with the main circuit breaker, the 24VDC PSU, the 12VDC PSU, and the VFD, along with various terminal blocks (spring-loaded this time, of course). Collected the wires I will need to wire it up (I will be using 14 AWG wire since that's what we have around, even though it is way overkill for what I'm doing). I couldn't find any appropriate wire ferrules around, so I submitted a purchase request for them, as well as some other items (M12 screws for mounting the differential pressure sensor, etc.)

Drilled holes for the 6 mounting screws, the E-stop, and four power switches on the control cabinet and bolted it to the frame by the 3 left mounting screws (the frame was intentionally designed so that there is a gap between the right of the cabinet and the frame; this will need 3.5mm spacers to be printed before bolting it down on the right side).

GENERAL:

Sectioned some copper parts with a hacksaw and milled the relevant surfaces to make display parts for Ken to bring to Japan. I gave the milled parts to Dong/Midhun to do hand sanding, resin embedding, and polishing to have a good view of the internal features.

PILOT:

Post-processed the cable carrier tower printed yesterday from PAHT-CF. The breakaway material did not separate cleanly; I suspect that the filament needs to be dried to work better.

2026-07-10

HEALTH:

Wired up the two DC power supplies and the VFD and mounted the subpanel to the control cabinet. Installed and wired up the e-stop and main breaker and power cord, although I need a power plug to terminate the power cord and I need to bring in some toggle switches to use one as a main power switch, one to turn the radiator fan on and off, and two for either other devices (such as the heater) or just to plug the two remaining holes that I have already drilled in the cabinet.

2026-07-13

Weekly R&D Meeting:

17-4 PH Printing (Mohsen):

Reduced 3 delam on test HX, but they are still present when Midhun sectioned the green part. Plans to switch to printing 65mm HX this week. Discussed adding thickness to the base to reinforce it for breakout.

Copper Printing (Dong, Midhun):

Tried printing with multilayer sacrificial filler material filling. Worked on bringing up Pilot 8 and running de-PEG experiments and found that the roof of the parts tended to collapse during the cycle. Tried de-PEGing parts with and without drain holes drilled into the manifold and found sacrificial filler removal was comparable. Part seems to soften significantly when PEG is melted. When using a hot air gun to melt out the sacrificial filler material, it oxidized rapidly but seemed to retain its strength better.

Beta upgrades (Senai):

Upgrading the Betas to use two spindles and a Mest unit instead of the previous 4 spindle design.

G Code (Devin, Midhun):

Devin plans to modify the 65mm model to have a thicker base and slice it for printing.

HEALTH:

Went over progress on the heat exchanger test bench with the team. Midhun raised an interesting point about testing the test bench with a known heat exchanger. Certainly this would be a good thing to do,

HEALTH:

Design and print flare interface for the radiator.

Printed a test interface on the Bambu printer, and discovered that I do not have a 1/2" NPT tap, so the threads will need to be printed into the part.

Drilled holes and cut out parts of the HDPE plate that the motor and pump are attached to.

Designed and printing a mount for the pump; we will need to get some long M8 bolts to mount it down.

Entered purchase request for M8 bolts and nuts for mounting the pump and motor to their corresponding plate.

Wired up the motor for 220 VAC 3-phase power (the output of the VFD I have already installed) and ran wires to the control cabinet in preparation for connecting to the VFD.

Attached one straight fitting to the PTFE SS-braid hose, which resulted in a bunch of puncture wounds and I am not too confident in the joint. I am going to do some research on the proper assembly procedure tomorrow (the way I did it today is from memory, which as we know can be quite fallible).

2026-07-14

HEALTH:

Received various McMaster parts including the power plug. Wired and powered up the system. The toggle switch I had intended to use as the power switch was not rated to 120 VAC, so I have bypassed it for now and the system is turned on and off by the E-Stop button. The toggle switch controlling the radiator fan is switching 12 VDC so it is fine, and seems to function well so far. Wired the VFD to the motor and tested it, as well as entering values to enable VVW motor control and studying the programming manual to determine how best to have the LabJack control the motor speed (right now I'm leaning towards getting an analog IO card for the VFD and interfacing that way).

P231 	AI1 Signal Function	0 = Speed Ref. 1 to 6 = Not Used 7 = Use SoftPLC	0	cfg	12-2
P232 	AI1 Input Gain	0.000 to 9.999	1.000		12-2
P233 	AI1 Input Signal	0 = 0 to 10 V / 20 mA 1 = 4 to 20 mA 2 = 10 V / 20 mA to 0 3 = 20 to 4 mA	0		12-3
P234 	AI1 Input Offset	-100.0 to 100.0 %	0.0		12-2
P235 	AI1 Input Filter	0.00 to 16.00 s	0.00		12-2
P245	Input Filter in Freq. FI	0.00 to 16.00 s	0.00 s		12-7
P246	FI Input in Freq.	0 = Inactive 1 = Active	0	cfg	12-7
P247	FI Input Gain	0.000 to 9.999	1.000		12-8
P248	FI Minimum Input	1 to 3000 Hz	100 Hz		12-8
P249	FI Input Offset	-100.0 to 100.0 %	0.0 %		12-8
P250	FI Maximum Input	1 to 3000 Hz	1000 Hz		12-8
P251 	AO1 Output Function	0 = Speed Ref. 1 = Not Used 2 = Real Speed 3 = Not Used 4 = Not Used 5 = Output Current 6 = Not Used 7 = Active Current 8 = Not Used 9 = Not Used 10 = Not Used 11 = Motor Torque	2	cfg	12-5

Installed the pump with the coolant filter and made and installed the hose running from the radiator outlet (bottom) to the pump inlet. Installed the test 3D printed coolant hose to FNPT adapter for initial assembly, then started a resin print of 2X adapters for actual use.

2026-07-15

HEALTH:

Need to set up heat source for 20X20mm heat sink.

Printed a new pump mount to lower the pump 3mm to be better aligned with the motor shaft. Aligned the pump with the motor and mounted them both down. I can't run the pump with the motor until I can pump liquid through the system (the pump can't be run dry).

I have tasked Alex with figuring out the LabView-based control system.

Group meeting w/ Alex N, Dong, Midhun, Sean, Mason, Devin, ZZ, Mohsen:

Alex is concerned that we have dropped behind the 30-60-90 goals. There is a plan to visit Japan in 2 weeks, and he is raising the question of what we need to show them at that point. The nominal goal is a sealed, high quality, high performance 65X65mm HX, but we may need to descope that to show something compelling. Even a 2-piece HX may be an acceptable early demo. The bank will be including 17 companies in a meeting during the Japan visit, along with some of their customers. Sean asked what the desired outcome/objective of the Japan meeting is.

Alex recommends testing some different sacrificial filler material in the same way that Payman et al had tried before by printing open boxes, filling them with filler material, capping off the boxes, then melting/burning out the filler material. I agree with the spirit of the request, namely investigating alternative materials for the CleanPrint(tm) process that may have the strengths of PEG (machinability, higher melting point than paraffin, relatively clean burnout) without the weaknesses (degrades the green/brown part when it is being melted out), although I don't believe that filling boxes again is the best way to do this. I would recommend:

- Based on previous results and the current state of the art, select a set of possible materials and material blends, along with documented predictions of the reason they may be superior to PEG.
- Develop rapid blocking experiments to downselect: burnout tests (easy to do batches, and if a material doesn't burn out cleanly then it is not usable), machinability tests (correlate with hardness if possible to make blocking even easier), dispensing tests.
- Once a subset of materials has been selected, print a simplified part with the CleanPrint(tm) process (maybe an enclosed box or similar)
- Debind and sinter these parts

2026-07-16

HEALTH:

Hose routing, hose fabrication, and assembly of pressure sensor and manifold stack. Wired up a PT100 RTD to one of the puck-style amplifiers and connected it to one of the LJTick current shunt inputs. Drilled two holes through the main bench plate for routing 90 degree AN hose ends.

2026-07-17

<Electroforming of sacrificial 3D printed negatives to make a heat sink with internal features>

Check for access to mill and lathe - permitted, with cleaning after use

Check stock/order more clear 4.1 resin for the FormLabs

HEALTH:

Redesign upper coolant hose to MNPT adapter and print on FormLabs

Heater application methods

Ordered parts from McMaster and Amazon for hose connections

Added a table of color codes for the absolute pressure sensor and the liquid temperature sensor M12 cables to the BOM spreadsheet.

Group meeting about printing issues being seen and plans for weekend

Mohsen printed a 65X65 heat sink and saw significant delaminations in the part. The delams got significantly worse during the thermal sacrificial filler material removal process.

2026-07-20

Weekly Meeting:

Mohsen ran some prints and used a thermal filler removal cycle of 2 hours at 100C, 1 hour at 160C, 2 hours at 200C. Parts retained shape through 100C and 160C but distorted during 200C cycle. He then machined the brown part to expose the upper manifold, which seemed mostly clear of powder and filler.

He then printed the bottom half of the 65X65mm heatsink. He saw a delam before the thermal sacrificial filler removal process, but it increased in severity after the thermal cycle.

The copper PEG removal process is longer than the 17-4.

Midhun said that issues started to be seen once we started prints with a large volume of PEG (for manifolds).

For the next batch of parts, his goal is to repeat the same PEG removal process and send the parts through sintering.

Dong showed some copper parts that started out with delams and first developed cracks through thermal sacrificial filler material removal, then showed up bubbling and PEG residue to one side of the part.

Printed TRS coupons on Pilot 8 from Ultrafine powder.

They tried a new thermal cycle with a slower ramp to temperature.

<NOTE: they are using the term pyrolysis for decomposition of PEG, although pyrolysis exclusively refers to decomposition in the absence of oxygen. Since they are doing decomposition in air it is technically not pyrolysis.>

Where PEG collects during decomposition, there is less visible oxidation of the parts.

More porosity is seen with parts printed in Ultrafine powder.

There is some part cracking and edge damage being seen on the final part that may be due to insufficient cut depth during the print, which leads to increased force required to remove the part from the cake.

Per Mason, the spindle seems to be losing position and cutting at incorrect depths.

<IDEA: add a binder jetting head for reinforcement of our parts, so we would use the standard Intelligent Layering process then apply some COTS binder jetting binder to the parts only. Or using a binder jetting head to bind large sections of the cake so the bound area is beyond the outline of the part itself. This would make it possible to use the current SVP on the part without sucking up lots of dry powder around the part if we bound the part only. Or attach an air turbine to the end mill itself so that it focuses suction on the cutting section of the end mill so there is minimal suction around the end mill.>

HEALTH:

Worked with Alex to get the LabJack reading the current values from the RTD sensor amplifiers correctly. Since we only have two current shunts on hand, we are currently limited to 4 current inputs so I ordered 2 more current shunts last week, which per Adriana should be here on Thursday 2026-07-23. Continued work on wiring, hose routing, and liquid connections.

2026-07-21

HEALTH:

Gave the Dwyer Omega turbine flow sensor to Alex to begin interfacing to the LabJack. Alex got two 4-20mA RTD sensors interfaced properly, so it should be fairly straightforward to expand the LabView code to reading the other sensors since they are standardized to 4-20mA communication (other than the turbine flow meter, which I think outputs a pulse train with the pulse rate corresponding to flow rate).

Got the coolant system to the point where the pump can pump coolant through the loop when the two manifolds are connected with a length of tubing in the push-to-connect fittings. There was a small leak at the radiator bottom outlet where the SS flare fitting screws into NPT threads printed into an SLA coolant hose adapter, which I resolved by tightening the fitting slightly. The pump was initially running backwards so I flipped two of the three-phase power lines to the motor and now it is operating properly.

GENERAL:

I printed a new SVP for Pilot 8 on the Formlabs last night per Cisco's request, so I will post-process that immediately. It is unclear if the version I printed (pulled from the latest Pilot printer CAD) is the desired model being used, so I may modify the model based on Cisco's experience with installing it.

2026-07-23

HEALTH:

Made and routed cables for the two liquid temperature sensors, the absolute pressure sensor, and the differential pressure sensor. Connected these to 24VDC power and powered up the machine, and both the differential pressure sensor and the absolute pressure sensor read pressure when I blow into the high side and the differential pressure sensor reads negative pressure when I blow into the low side. Replaced the plug in the back of each manifold block (a 1/4" NPT plug screwed into a 3/8" NPT to 1/4" NPT bushing) with a single 3/8" NPT plug each. Added a run tee to the high side of the differential pressure sensor and screwed the absolute pressure sensor into it, and installed 1/4" NPT to 4AN flare fittings in the low side port and the open port of the run tee to connect to 1/4" SS braid PTFE hose, and created hoses to mate with those 4AN fittings. Routed 1/2" OD tubing to the wye splitters that are screwed into newly-arrived elbow G1/4 swivels. Received 2X G1/4 ball valves that I purchased personally that go between the wye splitter and the elbow swivels, but I was unable to completely assemble the stack because I need to personally buy some G1/4 male to male fittings. I also need to add some 4AN fittings to the wye splitter to connect to the SS braid PTFE hoses. I machined the top surface of the digital hot plate that will be used for Block 1 testing tomorrow or Monday, while I work on a more robust and controllable long-term method for applying heat (Block 2 will be a stack of copper blocks with various heater cartridges and RTD temperature sensors, while Block 3 will be a custom PCB with linear MOSFETS used as the heat source). Mounted the two manifold blocks with Loctite Professional adhesive and mounted the CF nylon clamp that holds down the differential pressure sensor (which required the addition of a thin sheet of rubber to decrease the height of the clamp to hold the sensor securely, which then necessitated modification of the part for the sensor to slide in properly). To mount the clamp to the marine-grade HDPE work surface, four holes were drilled and tapped to M8X1.25.

2026-07-24

Alternative materials meeting:

Alex, Mason, Mohsen, Midhun, Dong, Me

Goal is to try testing alternative sacrificial filler materials that can be dispensed from the Mest unit

- Different MWs of PEG
- Paraffin, paraffin mixed with different polymers
- Slurries (paraffin or PEG mixed with sugar particles)

HEALTH:

Received the 2X G1/4 male-male adapters to attach the elbow swivels to the ball valves. Post-processed and tapped 2X -4 FORB to 1/2" tube stub adapters and assembled and installed them with -4 MORB to -4 flare fittings, then attached the SS braid PTFE hoses from the pressure sensor assembly to the two wye fittings that connect to the heat exchanger. Tested the system with flowing coolant, and the differential pressure sensor is highly sensitive to variations in pressure drop and the absolute pressure sensor is functional, although with less resolution. The absolute pressure sensor reads in PSI to 0.1 resolution while the differential pressure sensor reads in H₂O to .001 resolution. I failed to integrate the flow sensor before filling the system with coolant, so I will need to drain it and decide where to locate the flow sensor (right now I'm leaning towards attaching it to the radiator return fitting (upper coolant hose connection) and modifying the 1/2" SS PTFE hose to fit. This will keep the sensor out of the way and minimize stress from hose flexing, because its 1/2" SS PTFE hose is not likely to see continuous flexing beyond what is caused by pressure, flow, and temperature variations. I noted that the coolant filter did not fill completely, and became more full as I added a pressure restriction by partially closing one of the ball valves, then decreased back to the original level when the pressure in the line dropped. This is likely due to compression of the air volume inside the filter, although I am still unsure why the filter is not filling completely as it did before, and more oddly, the air in the filter does not seem to be impacting the flow negatively (I do not see any bubbles in the clear coolant lines connecting to the wye fittings).

Installed the flow sensor and shortened its SS braid PTFE hose, and also disconnected the manifolds from the work surface (they had been glued on) and tapped M5 holes to mount them down using M5 screws that I had purchased from Amazon. I also added a Molex Micro-Fit 3.0 connector to the flow sensor and connected it to a length of shielded cable that I routed to the control cabinet.

2026-07-27

Weekly R&D Meeting (CleanPrint(tm) focused)

Mohsen ran more 65X65mm 17-4 HXs, and ran into issues with delamination of layers.

He also printed some 24X24mm HXs with flanges with the primary goal of validating the G code. Delamination was more apparent in parts that had negatives under the flanges.

Midhun et al tried printing with pure paraffin in the Mest unit. The paraffin dispensed well, but machining it tended to produce debris that is difficult to remove from the surrounding area.

Dong et al ran some prints in copper with a new sacrificial filler material.

Tested 20% PEG400 / 80% PEG6000 sacrificial filler material, resulted in larger crystals and splash, cracks, and bubbles.

Midhun wants to anodize some of the Pilot build plates to make removal of the builds easier. He wants to use some of the plates that had been machined for future Pilots, but we do not have

HEALTH:

Working on integrating the LabJack. I updated the connections for the two pressure sensors and the two fluid sensors to connect them to the low voltage (2.5 VDC) higher resolution inputs instead of the +-10VDC inputs. All four of those sensors are reading in Kipling (the LabJack-provided IO viewer and settings programming program). I have also connected the flow sensor and it seems to be reading low and high values when I turn on the flow, although I don't have a way to view the pulses/sec yet.

I bought a 0-5VDC to 4-20 mA converter board with my own money that arrived today. This is to interface the LabJack analog output with the VFD; The voltage control on the VFD is 0-10V while the max output of the LabJack is 5VDC, so if I just connected the analog output straight we could only run the motor up to half its maximum speed.

Alex is working on getting the system to minimum viable operating status: if the pressure drop, absolute inlet pressure, delta T, flow rate, and temperature of the contact surface can be recorded then that should be enough for basic initial testing and benchmarking of heat exchangers. The temperature of the contact surface will initially be assumed to be the displayed temperature of the hot plate.

For accurate and automatic testing, we will need closed-loop control of the flow rate (which will require that the LabJack can control the pump speed) and closed-loop control of the applied temperature (which will require that the LabJack can control the cartridge heaters by PWMing an SSR), I will make a copper temperature measurement block to go between the heat source and the heat exchanger, and I will also make a heater block with installed cartridge heaters and RTDs that are read and controlled by the LabJack. This will enable automatic data collection at varying flow rates and applied temperatures, as well as measuring the actual heat flow into the

heat exchanger by comparing RTD values along the direction of heat flow out of the heater block.

2026-07-28

CleanPrint(tm) Delam Issue Discussion:

HEALTH:

Brought in the CPU water cooling block that I bought with my own money. Tapped 4X M3 holes into the hot plate to mount down the HX, and also machined the surface smoother with a 5 flute 1/4" OD end mill at 2000 RPM. I then applied some of the thermal paste that came with the HX (unbranded) to the HX and the hot plate with a razor blade and mounted the HX down with spring-loaded thumb screws. I then connected the inlet and outlet G1/4 elbows to the HX so I am ready to test the hardware, although I am delayed by the delam meeting discussed above. During the meeting (1:32 hours and counting) I have been installing LabJack libraries and updating LabView to try setting up a basic LabView program. The LabJack is pretty nice to interface with; it has registers for every input and output parameter, so you just read or write the relevant register to collect data or set outputs as necessary.

2026-07-29

HEALTH:

Installed Sean's latest heat exchanger/resin 3DP manifold assembly and did some pressure drop experiments from flows of ~0.8 LPM to ~2.3 LPM. Because I spec'd the pump for flow rates up to 8 LPM the motor has to run really slowly to get down to 0.8 LPM, and that is pretty much at the nominal range Sean wants to run it, so it may be beneficial to replace the pump with one that has a lower maximum flow rate of maybe 3 LPM or so to improve resolution of control with motor RPM.

Installed an RTD and wired up the cartridge heaters in parallel (after checking each one's resistance and comparing it with a reference unused cartridge heater; they're all ~120 ohms, so they should draw about an amp each when they're connected to wall power (~110-120 VAC). Since their resistances are close to nominal it is unlikely that their heater coils are shorted anywhere, but I will still want to keep a close eye on them when doing initial testing.

Interfaced the heater RTD and cartridge heaters with the control system and tested them with my stripped-down LabView code. The heater functions well but heats very rapidly. I plan to add

one of the thermal switches that was originally intended to be used on the Pilot heaters to cut off power to the heater block at $\sim 110^{\circ}\text{C}$ regardless of functioning of the control system to act as a safety in case the software or hardware fails.

2026-07-30

HEALTH:

Alex tested a new version of LabView code that has an updated pulse to flow conversion factor that seems to calculate the correct flow in a one second run time. The flow control loop (and likely the heater control loop as well) will have a frequency of 1 Hz, which for our application may be OK.

I am printing a new lower HX assembly clamp block from purple ASA because the one printed from PAHT-CF last night did not come out well.

Printed the lower and upper clamp blocks and assembled them with the heater block and the heat exchanger. I polished the contact surfaces of the heater block and the heat exchanger using 600 grit sandpaper on top of a granite surface plate. I used a piece of Grizzly Carbonaut TIM to thermally connect the HX to the heater block. I modified my LabView code so it is able to display the inlet and outlet temperatures in C and has a dial gauge for the delta T.

2026-07-31

HEALTH:

Alex is continuing to work on the LabView control/data collection system. With my LabView program, I have set it up to display the temperature differential across the inlet and outlet coolant temperatures, but the value is showing oscillations and is not 0 when the actual temperatures are matched.

Machined an intermediary RTD block to interface between the current heater and the HX. This will allow temperature measurement close to a surface in contact with the HX that matches the surface area of the HX. It also has two RTDs, one close to the HX surface and one close to the heater block surface. This should act as a check of the heater block temperature reading and an estimate of the performance of the TIM between them, as well as allow some rough measurement of the heat transfer through the intermediary block.

2026-08-03

HEALTH:

Designed and printing a new upper clamp block to clamp together the copper block stack with the new intermediary small copper block.

Alex is not too happy with LabView, and I also have doubts that it is the optimal architecture for this test bench.

Fluid specs

<https://marineengineparts.com/content/sds/31400.pdf>

TIM specs

Alex and I worked on the test bench most of the day, with mixed results. After Alex went home, I discovered that I had wired the turbine flow meter incorrectly; I had omitted a 1K pullup resistor that was supposed to be installed. I suspect this is the cause of the incorrect readings that have been seen. I installed the resistor for testing tomorrow morning.

R&D Weekly Meeting

2026-08-04

HEALTH:

The flow meter is now reading through the LabJack's built-in frequency measuring function. Because the built-in LabJack frequency measuring function takes up one of the high-resolution analog in pins, I had to rewire the current shunt so that it has the heater block RTD connected to FIO4 and the flow meter is connected to FIO5. It is also critical that the pullup resistor be connected between the flow meter signal pin and VS.

I am considering working on the PCB heat source again.

I installed the intermediate block with 2 RTDs in it with thermal paste between the HX and the intermediate block and between the intermediate block and the heater block. I switched the RTD connection from the heater block RTD to the RTD closest to the HX because that is the value that matters the most.

2026-08-05

HEALTH:

Alex ran some code that accidentally ran the heater block up to 140C, which seems not to have destroyed anything although it is higher than the nominal max operating temp of ASA (I think it

needs to stay below 100C or so). I programmed and wired up the SCU3100 signal conditioner so if the block temperature (the signal conditioner is reading an RTD installed in the block, not the RTD reading the HX surface temperature) goes above 100C it will open a relay to prevent the heater SSR from being triggered. At some point it would also be good to have a thermal switch bolted to the heater block as a second safety to prevent it from overheating.

Alex has the control loop for the heater and pump working, although the temperature of the HX seems to be ~20-30 C lower than the block temperature (as reported by the SCU3100 signal conditioner). This is likely due to the heater block being much larger than the intermediary block and the thermal resistance of the TIM layers (thermal paste from heater block to intermediary block, thermal paste from intermediary block to HX (although the RTD is not measuring the temperature of the HX directly, so the intermediary block to HX joint shouldn't matter (although there is also a thermal paste joint from the RTD body to the intermediary block which could be causing errors (but there is also a similar joint between the heater block RTD and the heater block, so the errors should be similar (although still dependent on temperature differential)))))).

2026-08-06

HEALTH:

Got some data on the 20X20mm HX using a mostly manually controlled LabView program. Alex is working on the more advanced version of the code.

Since it sounds like today is the last day we can submit purchase requests (per Adriana), I am trying to figure out everything I might need for the near future, so I am specing out some MOSFETs to use in the next-generation heater (I think I will be using those for the larger heater for testing 65X65mm HXs).

I entered in a purchase request for a reamer and a tap for tapping the G1/4 ports in the top of the 65X65mm HX, which are likely to rip out and need to be epoxied, but I will try this first.

I designed and am printing a part to center the intermediary block relative to the heater block and HX; the last time I assembled the stack it was difficult to get it aligned and I need to disassemble and reassemble the stack so that I can apply higher quality thermal paste than what I applied last time.

2026-08-07

HEALTH:

Removed the heater/HX stack and cleaned, repolished, and re thermal pasted the copper surfaces, as well as the RTDs in the intermediary block. This should reduce thermal resistance and help with maintaining higher temperatures for testing. I also added a centering block that holds the intermediate block aligned with the HX during assembly, and does double duty as an insulation layer to prevent heat loss from the exposed surface of the heater block and the sides of the intermediate block. I also connected the RTD on the bottom of the intermediate block, close to the heater block. I had to connect it to a current shunt connected to AIN0 and AIN1, ~~which are low precision high voltage analog inputs, so the reading will be much less stable than we would see with the other RTDs, but since it's a less critical reading that should be fine for now.~~ Upon further consideration, it is more accurate to say that AIN0-AIN4 have lower resolution, not necessarily lower accuracy, precision, or stability.

Sean requested that the new TTV have direct power monitoring of the heat applied (power into the heat application devices, either heater cartridges or solid-state heaters such as MOSFETS or other transistors) because it is a useful parameter for his simulations.

Here is the current prime candidate for a solid-state heat application component: [IXTP80N07](#)

[5L2 | DigiKey Electronics](#)

I have designed a new 1.75" coolant line to 1/4" NPT adapter fitting to be printed on the FormLabs. Instead of printing the threads and chasing them as I typically do, I am instead printing it with a tapered hole for tapping the threads from scratch. I am hoping that this will give me more control over how tight the fit of the fitting is.

2026-08-10

Midhun is back from Japan where he pitched the Reika company concept to the CTO of Muratek and 40 people from OSB. He said that ~80% of the OSB guys said that they are interested in investing in Reika. He also went out to do karaoke with some people, which he interpreted as further interest in Reika.

Alex announced that the initial IP auction will close on Wednesday, but if someone outbids FusionX then it will trigger a live auction that will close on Friday.

Weekly R&D Meeting:

Discussed current status of test setup.

Mohsen went over the prints he has been running from 17-4 PH SS. The small scale part he printed with no manifold came out well, but the larger enclosed part he printed had issues with warping and delamination. <Now that FusionX has committed to bidding on 3DEO's IP (maybe)

and Midhun feels good about the various OSB affiliates investing in Reika (also maybe), do we need this “hero plate” thing?>. The current thermal sacrificial filler removal process is to place it in an oven that is preheated to 100C, removing it and taking pictures of it, transferring it to a 160C oven, removing it and taking pictures of it, transferring it to a 200C oven, and removing it and taking pictures of it. This is an extremely fast ramp speed up and down, but per Mohsen there are parts we have printed that have come out well so he is not concerned about delaminations and cracking being caused by the thermal cycle. It is important to note that the complete part he printed came out with some warpage and delamination, but it did get significantly worse throughout the thermal cycle and other cracks formed. Also, Pourya started out with a programmed cycle in the Keith furnace to control the temperatures and ramp times.

Dong et al did some tests with paraffin and paraffin blends as filler materials. He printed open top copper parts and filled them with filler, which seemed to cause cracks that varied in magnitude depending on the filler material used. He tried ~8 different formulations, none of which are the formulation I had landed on that I communicated to Midhun in a past R&D meeting (I think; they tested a paraffin/EVA blend, where I landed on a paraffin/PE-CVA blend (they may actually be using my formulation and just misnamed it, I don’t know)). They also found that with some of their formulations they had difficulty machining it; it tended to be pulled out of the part instead of cutting cleanly. He tried running the thermal sacrificial filler removal cycle while resting the part on alumina powder to wick out the filler material, which seemed to help reduce cracking somewhat, but created new issues with part warpage under gravity.

The first sintering trial at DSH resulted in part melting. We will lose the ability to sinter here soon (date unknown, but likely at the end of this week).

Per Sean, the copper printed manifold does impact the thermal performance of the HX.

HEALTH:

To Do:

- Upgrade flow circuit
- Make fixture for the 65X65mm heat exchanger using Sean’s latest CAD
- Add current and voltage (power) monitoring to the next heater design

Worked on modifying the flow circuit to minimize pressure variations by moving the HX to the same level as the differential pressure sensor and also eliminate the two hoses running to the differential pressure sensor by mounting fluid manifolds directly to the sensor. I had planned to replace all the SS braided PTFE hoses and flare fittings with polyurethane hose and push to connect fittings, but the PTC fittings I got from Amazon are not very secure; it is easy to pull out

a hose even when it has been inserted fully. The McMaster fittings are better, although it is still possible to pull out the hose; it may be necessary to switch to a firmer hose at some point. I mounted the manifolds to the differential pressure sensor and prepared the manifolds for reinstallation of components (removing residual PTFE FOD, chasing the threads where necessary, etc.) and made a cutout in the work surface for hoses to pass through, but I screwed up and made the cutout too narrow to fit the flare fittings and SS braided hose, so I will need to widen the cutout tomorrow. I also drilled and tapped 4X M8 holes to mount down the 3D printed bracket that holds the differential pressure sensor.

2026-08-11

HEALTH:

Redid the cutout in the top plate because it was initially too small and the cutout looked terrible; the cut lines weren't straight and they didn't match up tangent to the fillets. The new cutout fits the fluid fittings and looks a lot better. I reattached all various fluid circuit components and sensors and refilled the radiator and did a quick flow test with a short length of hose jumping the two connection points that normally connect to hoses that run to the HX. Since I only have wye PTC fittings to interface between the 1/2" hose and the G1/4 ball valves, I am going to plug off one of the ports with a part printed on the FormLabs printer derived from the part used for attaching the SAE J1926 - 1/4" flare fitting when I was using a remote hose to measure differential pressure.

2026-08-13

HEALTH:

Received some hall effect current sensor breakout boards for measuring current flowing through the heater block to estimate the heat flow into the HX. I am currently using Arctic MX-7 thermal paste, which has been benchmarked here:

 ARCTIC MX-7 Thermal Compound Review - Performance Insights

I have designed a new heater block for the upcoming 70X70mm HX which Sean has apparently changed to (it is still called a 65X65mm block, but I measured it in SolidWorks and the CAD model has a 70X70mm contact area.

I removed the epoxied heater block blank from the aluminum finned surface I had placed it on to cure; even though the area of epoxy squeezeout that contacted the finned surface was quite small, I had to really pound the blank from the side to break the joint. Based on this, I expect

that the joint joining the two copper blocks will be extremely strong because it has much larger surface area, the contacting faces were polished flat on a granite surface plate with 600 grit wetted sandpaper on it then cleaned with IPA and acetone-based brake cleaner, and were clamped together with light pressure using a Bessey clamp.

Finished machining the block, and when I removed it from the vise it had broken apart at some point.

2026-08-14

HEALTH:

Cleaned up the split heater block. Conducted a solder test with some scrap copper pieces where I machined a flat surface on each, applied Kester R520A SAC solder paste over the surface, lightly clamped it with a Bessie clamp, and heated it with a torch until the surface solder visibly melted. I then machined around the solder joint to expose four edges to give a cross section of the joint ~2mm in from the edge of the block. It looks like the block was clamped at an angle; on one side the solder line is almost invisible while on the other side there are visible voids in the joint. I also soldered the split heater block using the same procedure.

I remachined the critical faces of the heater block, and also made a CNC program for helical drilling of the holes for the cartridge heaters. I used a repeat cycle function that I think caused some weirdness; I got the cartridge heaters to fit in the first five holes fine but they're sticking in the last hole, so I modified the hole diameter in the program for the sixth hole and ran that step only, but even though I did that about 4 times, increasing the diameter of the hole each time, it did not seem to make any difference. I suspect that when you use the repeat cycle function the parameters are actually locked to the set parameters of the cycle being repeated, even though it is possible to adjust parameters for each cycle.

GENERAL:

I am trying to get a nitrogen tank from Airgas. With my current personal account they won't ship to 3DEO's address, so I created a business account with 3DEO's address.

2026-08-17

GENERAL:

I bought a nitrogen tank from my Compton welding supply guys and brought it in over the weekend, so we should be good for heat sealing for now.

HEALTH:

Working on the slide deck for tomorrow's heat exchanger test bench meeting.

I'd like to graph out some of the thermal resistance data from the test bench against the simulated thermal resistance values, but Sean pushed back on that due to the discrepancy between calculated and measured temperature rise across the heat exchanger, as well as the lack of direct power input measurements.

Talked with Sean about the comparison between test bench and simulation results, and it seems that the ΔT in the test bench is much higher than is expected from the simulation.

Installed the cartridge heaters in the Block 2 heater block. Although they slid in fine without thermal paste applied, when I put thermal paste on them I had to hammer them in.

2026-08-18

GENERAL:

At the standup, Senai discussed that he is talking with people about the improvements needed for a new design of printer at Reika. Alex raised concerns about the speed of experimentation. We all got two paychecks yesterday, one full one and one small one, presumably to cover all the last days of 3DEO (today is the last day we will be employed through 3DEO). Alex said that they are working on getting offer letters out to everyone (maybe), but they have not done so yet. The search for a new building is continuing.

Requested from Alex, and was given approval for, Friday off so I can go to Catalina this weekend.

Doing some research on commercially available TTVs (thermal test vehicles) and GPUs that are available to purchase to use as representative heat sources in a few days when we have Reika money to start buying stuff (if we do/can). Studying how the processing power compares across GPU generations and what the processing power values mean.

HEALTH:

Gave a presentation regarding the test bench, and got sidetracked with discussing the fundamental functionality and parameter measurement of thermal testing. The key takeaway was that it is desired to integrate multiple temperature sensors into the heater block to eliminate the need for an intermediate block.

Alex will contact Don and possibly Jim Golden to get some recommendations for testing heat exchangers informed by industry practices.

Designed and printing a lower clamp block for the 70X70mm heater block. Because I have seen some possible distortion in the ASA parts (which may have been due to distortion during printing instead of from heat applied) I am printing the new parts from CF nylon filament. This will also color-code the new design.

R&D Meeting:

Mohsen presented a recent 17-4 PH SS print, which seems to show some banding on the sides and some possible cracking at the bottom of the part. Mason recommended using the VHX to 3D scan the part. Since the part is so soft, it will likely be necessary to lay the part flat on the VHX working surface and tilt the VHX head to view the part.

Mohsen tried printing with some different sacrificial filler materials and found that Paraplast (paraffin with ~1% of a polymer such as polyisobutylene) and microcrystalline wax (a petroleum-derived wax similar to paraffin but with more branched hydrocarbons that results in smaller crystals).

He also tried printing with wax blended with an alumina powder filler.

2026-08-19

GENERAL:

First day of Reika existing, so people are going through onboarding through Trinet and also were handed hardcopy offer letters from Alex. I skimmed through it and it seemed pretty standard. I was most interested in the section on IP; per the offer, Reika will own everything that I make, conceive, or develop that is related in any manner to the actual or demonstrably anticipated business or R&D of Reika or its affiliates while I am employed by Reika or that is made with Reika proprietary technology after I leave, whether it is done during work hours or not. However, this does not apply to anything that is covered by Section 2870 of the labor code of California, which apparently says that anything I do without company resources of any kind on my own time and not on company property belongs to me.

HEALTH:

Working on some slides that detail what customers want to see the test bench demonstrate and what exactly needs to be measured and calculated to show them the relevant results.

I also discovered that there are lots of cold plates with stated thermal resistances available on DigiKey, of all places. They are designed for, among other things, cooling high-power chassis resistors, which annoyingly would make for a perfect heat source.

2026-08-20

HEALTH:

The lower mount for the 70X70mm Block 2 heater block was printed last night from CF nylon, but the print didn't come out super well; I suspect that the NylonX I used was not fully dried even after being in the filament dryer for most of the day yesterday. I removed the roll and put it in the dryer, where I will leave it over the weekend.

I added a PID block in my LabView code to replace the hand made P controller I had for regulating the heater temperature, and it seems to be working pretty well so far. I am tuning it manually.

I am continuing to refine the Google slide deck I am working on to go over what parameters the test bench needs to measure and how relevant parameters are calculated.

2026-08-24

R&D Weekly Meeting:

Experiments done to mitigate delams by Mason. Adjusting binder content, filler dispensing strategy, filler formulation. Some experiments were repeated to determine reliability of experiments.

Midhun noted that they are still seeing PEG protruding above the surface even after the facing operation. This is an issue that has been seen before, but has not been a focus of recent experiments. The layer time of the 65X65 HX is on the order of 1 hour. Midhun noted that one of the contributing factors here is a non-optimized cutting strategy.

Senai raised the question of switching to a larger diameter facing end mill. I think this would be a good thing to explore, as well as a horizontal cylinder cutter.

ZZ pointed out that right now the slicer does not optimize travel moves between cuts, which adds time to the cutting op.

Midhun noted that there are layer shifts being seen on Pilot 8 where the part shifts in X and Y and there are variations in cut depths being seen at the same layers in a print. There are also variations in binder penetration being seen between Pilot 8 and Pilot 7.

Pilots Issues:

Main issue on Pilot <8?> is the SPI disconnection error, but after Ning isolated the Festool vacuum power supply it does not seem to have occurred again. Per Mason, it also seems that

the printers with the StoneVac installed do not seem to have the same issue

Senai raised the question of why we use individual electric vacuums for each printer instead of using pneumatic vacuums. This was originally done because management wanted to minimize compressed air consumption, and the pneumatic vacuums eat up a lot of air flow (as I saw at AMP), although we may be able to use a smaller vacuum for each printer or a single centralized vacuum to optimize compressed air consumption.

To Do:

- Print some of the new SVP design with some of the other FormLabs resins we have around; we ran out of the Clear 4.1 resin that we typically use, and we do not have the ability to order anything yet because the Reika ordering system has not been set up/authorized yet.

HEALTH:

Installed the 70X70mm heater block with the Dracaena HX I purchased from Amazon. I had to ream out part of the two RTD holes because I had forgotten that they need to be 4mm through and 4.2mm to some depth to allow the larger diameter based of the RTD fit in the hole. I am in the process of tuning the PID loop for this heater block / HX combination. The inlet coolant temperature was up to ~45C because the coolant in the radiator had heated up and the cooling fan was off, but when I turned on the cooling fan the inlet temperature dropped to ~25C within maybe 5 minutes, so it is clear that the radiator fan must be turned on when running a test, particularly with a more powerful heater block (this one is 600W max, but the Block 3 heater block will be closer to 2.5 kW. Even at a constant 600W, the highest temperature the HX can reach is 58C when the radiator fan is running. If the radiator is turned off the system can get the temperature up to 60C, but that is only when the inlet temperature is around 31C. The cool feature of running it at 100% power, though, is that I can collect test results with a known input power (600W).

The calculated heat input from the flow rate and delta T of the coolant was ~685W, which is higher than the nominal heat input of 600W. I need to measure the actual power input into the heater block, and also calibrate the temperature sensors and improve their stability (the signals are way too noisy for the data set we need to collect).

GENERAL:

Switched the FormLabs over to Clear Cast V1 because we have a bunch of it around. I also cleaned and lubricated the linear rails and leadscrews because print quality has been noticeably

poor lately and it hasn't been done in a while. I started a print with 2X the SVP design that Mason sent me. It has some text engraved on it stating the end mill protrusion length and the opening diameter, and I need to confirm that those values are current.

2026-08-25

HEALTH:

Resolved the fluctuations in inlet and outlet temperature readings. To diagnose the issue, I first removed one of the temperature sensors from its manifold. I noted that the temperature reading was much more stable, and the fluctuations could be intentionally caused by touching the sensor threads to the manifold block. This suggested that the issue was due to a floating negative on the sensor side; the manifold and differential pressure sensor are earth grounded through the differential pressure sensor, but the temperature sensors were only connected to the negative of the 24VDC power supply and the negative was isolated from ground. I installed a jumper wire between the earth ground terminal block stack and the 24VDC negative terminal block stack, and the temperature readings seem much more stable now.

I also connected a Fluke 179 multimeter across the heater connection point and measured the actual voltage (110.2 VAC) and then measured the current through the cartridge heater block when it is powered at 100% and it read 5.48A initially, and dropped to 5.45A when the HX surface was at 64.5C (the safety RTD system reads 69.1C). This corresponds to almost exactly 600W, so I think it is reasonable safe to assume that the heater block is outputting 600W at full power.

With this much power input, the coolant reservoir temperature rises rapidly (as measured by the coolant inlet temperature) (~10C/10min) so it is necessary to run the radiator fan when the heater block is running.

I ran a rough flow sensor calibration test where I set the DAC output to the pump at .9V which a previous test showed resulted in a flow meter value of 1 LPM and set up a tube so the coolant was flowing into a graduated container for 60s. The quantity of liquid dispensed was almost exactly 1L after 1 minute, so I think the flow meter is reasonably accurate.

I implemented a PI closed-loop flow control algorithm that gets to the right value and holds it without significant oscillations, but the rate at which it gets to the right value is fairly slow (~30s to ramp up or down 2 LPM). Increasing the P term higher than 1.2 yields oscillations, and the derivative term did not help to cancel those out.

I did a full test on the Dracaena HX, and the results still don't make sense, so I am now doing a calibration on the temperature sensors. I created an ice bath by freezing tap water in some 3DEO cups and put one of those ice cubes in my 3DEO Yeti mug. I then boiled some water and poured it into the Yeti mug, however, the voltage values dropped steadily even as I switched between temperature sensors and LabJack ports, suggesting that the temperature of the bath was dropping significantly between tests. Regardless, the calculated temperature using my existing algorithm was ~82-88C, which is much lower than it should be (in theory 100C, although I'd expect a little lower).

My current working theory is that the equations I am using to calculate the temperature from the voltage values are close enough to seem correct but are far enough from reality to give false power readings (hence Q_{diss} reading greater than Q_{in}).

2026-08-26

GENERAL:

Gave the latest SVPs I printed yesterday from Clear Cast material to Mason. The text on the side is inaccurate so that will need to be changed for the production version, and the part still has "3DEO" engraved in it, which will need to be removed. I also think it is necessary to redesign the contact point installation; right now they are glued in place, so my traditional SOP has been to scavenge them from an older SVP by shattering it, then gluing it in the new one, but this is not a process that can reasonably be transferred to technicians.

At the standup today, Alex emphasized the importance of working on manufacturing an Accretech part alongside the 65X65mm HX we are currently working on. The Accretech plate is theoretically easier to print and has a direct customer application, and Accretech is also willing to work with us to design and test it, while the 65X65 "Hero SKU" plate is purely for research and demonstration purposes. I raised the idea of skipping over the Hero SKU entirely and focusing only on the Accretech part, which Alex rejected. I appreciate the clear rejection, actually; it is much more actionable than the traditional 3DEO "sure, that's on the table" statement that then goes nowhere. It does concern me that this new Accretech push seems to have come out of Alex's discussion with Ken yesterday; it suggests that Ken is pushing to produce parts for a customer in the near term as well as delivering this "Hero SKU" part soon, and splitting focus between producing two parts instead of focusing on one has historically been shown to fail, given our limited resources.

HEALTH:

Reran the hot water (boiling when poured into the mug) test with both sensors and both ports, with the Yeti mug filled near to the top and the lid installed, with the sensor poking through a hole in the lid. This yielded much more repeatable voltage values than yesterday, suggesting that the dropping voltages yesterday were a result of the temperature of the water bath dropping.

The results I am getting are a little off, even with applying the zeroing correction factor. The flow rate PID control loop seems pretty solid, though, and I'm not getting any leaks.

The kinds of errors and fluctuations I'm seeing are way too large to trust the results, though. At a flow rate of 3 LPM, the delta T I am reading is 3C, yielding a thermal resistance of 0.044. Drop that down by .8C, though, and you get 0.0601. Raise it by .8C, and you get 0.0348. Granted, the actual errors under most operating regimes aren't quite as bad because the delta T is much larger than that, but that is an unacceptable amount of error for getting actionable results. One major contributing factor is that the temperature sensors I'm using have a range of 0-300F (-17.8 to 148.9C), mapping to 4-20 mA, mapping to a LJTick Current Shunt voltage range of 0.472 to 2.360 V. Also, the NPT threads on the temperature sensors make them a pain to remove and reinstall for testing and calibration. The obvious solution is to replace them with extended RTD probes that go into compression fittings and feed those into an RTD amplifier with a narrower range (20-50C would be fairly optimal)

2026-08-27

PILOT:

Need to look at Ning's recommendations for a new end stop sensor for the Pilots; he is recommending a non-contact proximity switch instead of the current mechanical switches, but the switch diameter is 12mm instead of 10mm.

The SPI communication error is still occurring on Pilot 8, even though Ning switched the StoneVac from Pilot 7 to Pilot 8. Ning mentioned something about planning to earth ground the Duet or Pi or something, so I'm guessing he had not already star grounded all the devices and tied the negative lines together. Not having done that would certainly contribute to the Duet/Pi system's sensitivity to noise in the system that results from turning the vacuum on or off.

I received the handheld oscilloscope that I had ordered paying out of pocket, so I should be able to get some better data on the voltage spikes we're seeing on the Pilot printers

HEALTH:

Adriana is now able to order stuff through the Ramps system, so I should no longer need to order parts with my own money.

I really screwed up and failed to do the necessary math when I was designing the test bench. What I need to figure out is how much inaccuracy in inlet and outlet temperature readings will affect the thermal resistance value. Let's start with the final goal:

Need thermal resistance, calculated with the following equation:

$(T_{surf} - T_{inlet}) / Q_{in}$. The difference between the HX surface temperature and the inlet temperature divided by the heat into the surface of the HX. Surface temperature we estimate with a temperature reading from a sensor installed in the heater block stack that is as close to the surface as possible. The actual surface temperature of the HX will be off from this due to the TIM between the heater block and the HX, which is already a source of inaccuracy, but this can be compensated for in the simulation if the thermal resistance of the TIM is known. Since we do not have the TIM and the joint completely characterized, we would need to estimate the thermal resistance. This is one source of error in the thermal resistance calculation. The inlet temperature is determined by a temperature sensor measuring the temperature of the coolant as close to the HX as possible.

The Q_{in} value, the actual heat going into the heat exchanger, is much more interesting to determine. There are three ways to get it, with varying levels of accuracy. They are, starting with the least accurate and increasing in accuracy:

1. The power going into the heater block can be measured directly from the voltage across and the current through the heat source. Calculating the thermal resistance with this value will give the thermal resistance value under perfect conditions, where all heat into the heater block goes into the HX. This is useful for bounding the thermal resistance, but the real world thermal resistance will be higher due to heat loss from the system (heat lost from the sides and bottom of the heater block).
2. Next, it is possible to determine heat flow through the heater block by installing temperature sensors at multiple points in a region of the heater block above the actual heat source so that they are in line with the flow of heat. Since the thermal conductivity of solid copper is well known, the heat flux can be calculated easily from the thermal gradient at different points. The TIM between the temperature sensors and the heater block only matters if the system is not at steady state; at steady state the temperature of the sensors will exactly match the temperatures of their surroundings. This is the method used to measure heat flow through standardized test setups used for characterizing TIM, and is an accurate way to measure the Q_{in} value, and is independent of the flow rate or type of fluid being used in the HX. However, it does not measure the actual heat added to the coolant.

3. By measuring the inlet and outlet temperatures and flow rate of the coolant, as long as the density and specific heat of the coolant are known, it is possible to calculate the caloric heat actually added to the coolant. This is a less relevant metric for end users trying to cool a heat source because they care about how much heat can be pulled from the heat source at what temperature, but this is a very useful metric for characterizing heat exchangers themselves because it is independent of the heat source or TIM.

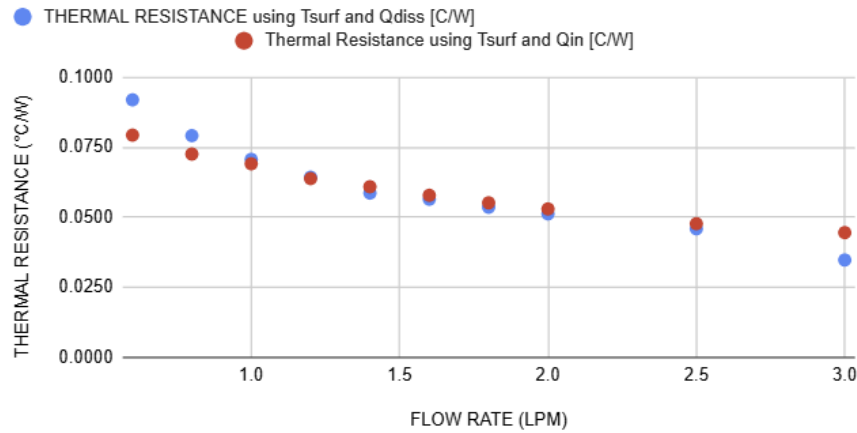
The best way to design and operate a test bench is to determine Q with all three of these methods to generate three thermal resistance curves. In theory all three should match, so the variation between them yields information about errors in the system.

The LabJack has a 12 bit resolution over an input range of 0-2.5V, meaning it can differentiate between 4096 steps in that range, or 0.0006V. The actual detected voltage from the LabJack current shunt is 0.472 - 2.360, so the output of the temperature sensor sweeps over a 1.888V range, which is (1.888 / 2.5) of the 4096 step range. This comes out to about 3093 steps detectable over the temperature sensor's range. Even before factoring in any errors, there is a hard limit on the temperature change that the LabJack can discriminate. The temperature sensors that are currently being used have a range of 0 - 300F, or ~ -17.8 - 148.9C, a range of ~166.7C. Divide this by 3093 and you get a minimum detectable temperature change of ~0.054C. At 600W, a change in the delta T of 0.054C results in a change of 0.0000898 C/W in thermal resistance. Now let's start breaking down some of the actual errors.

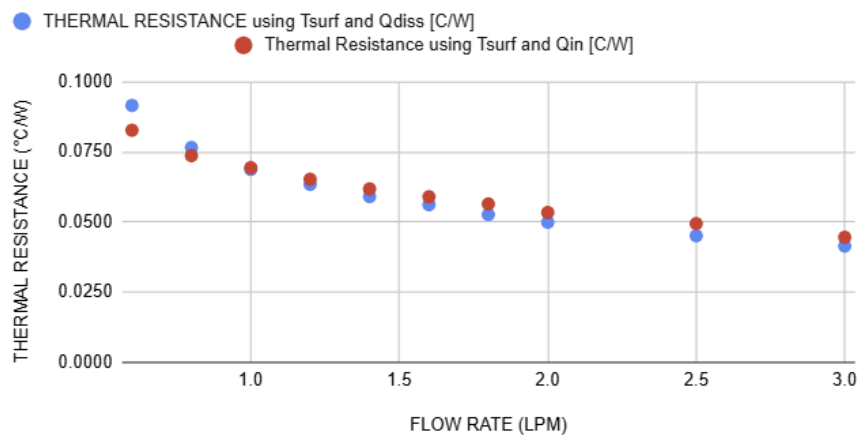
The accuracy of the temperature sensors is stated in the technical specifications document as being $0.25K + 0.002 |T|$, where T (oddly enough in C, even though it adds on 0.25K) is the absolute value of the temperature reading. This is an interesting way to spec accuracy; it suggests that accuracy is best at 0C and gets worse as you increase or decrease the temperature. My guess would be that this is because they calibrate it at 0C. At the low end of what I care about (25C) that comes out to 0.3C, and at 45 that comes out to 0.34C. Doesn't sound too bad, but since we care about the delta T, the worst case error is if one is reading high and the other low, resulting in an inaccuracy of 0.68C.

I ran the same test procedure yesterday and today to test repeatability:

THERMAL RESISTANCE using T_{surf} and Q_{diss} [C/W] and Thermal Resistance using T_{surf} and Q_{int} [C/W]



THERMAL RESISTANCE using T_{surf} and Q_{diss} [C/W] and Thermal Resistance using T_{surf} and Q_{int} [C/W]



Not exactly the same, but pretty similar

2026-08-28

Per Midhun, sintering at DSH is still under development. Their most recent sintering run resulted in some melting of the part.

Accretech Project Reboot Meeting (called by Sean):

They want a 100X100mm cold plate assembly for die-level testing, potentially with heaters integrated into it.

They have mentioned delivery around February 2027, but it is unclear how absolute that requirement is.

They want a prototype they can test that is made with a design that is on a path to a production solution.

Per Alex, the production rate is likely ~15-30 per month.

They want to minimize the thermal capacity of the base to optimize for heating and cooling rate.

They are not currently interested in targeted heating and cooling, they want it to be as uniform as possible.

Flow rate, coolant formulation, and burst pressure need to be determined from Accretech.

It sounds like the main priority of the project is to minimize response time of heating and cooling <I assume the flow rate and inlet pressure are fixed, otherwise they could just pump through a ton of coolant to get it to respond faster (maybe?)>

I pitched using two liquid loops that the system switches between, one hot loop and one cold loop, which Sean said they may be open to but Senai pushed back on it, based on concerns about difficulty of implementing such a system with our timeline. I personally disagree; a hot side loop would be super easy to add to the heat exchanger test bench. It would just need an extra pump and motor, a heated coolant reservoir, and fast-acting valves to switch between them. Since I already have designs for fast-acting valves for my rocket project, that would be trivial for me to implement.

The coolant formulation is not known yet, but Senai believes that the one they discussed was quite viscous. We don't have specs for required pressure drop and flow rate.

Senai asked whether it would be easier to print a larger part with microchannels only, or a smaller part with manifold, and Midhun's response was that the larger part would be easier.

Sean asked about design rules for the CleanPrint(tm) process, and there aren't any hard requirements, just intuitive opinions on what is more or less difficult to print. My pitch is to move as much of the manifolding to the machined base as possible and remove the runners that are filled with filler material.

We do not currently have the ability to sinter 17-4PH SS parts, and it is not something being pursued currently.

HEALTH:

- Order a cold plate and heat source with specified thermal resistance
- Reinstall the 20X20mm cold plate and generate all three thermal resistance curves

I switched out the Dracaena HX for the original 20X20mm 3D printed HX to get some results that I can reasonably trust. I installed a new RTD in the intermediate block to replace the one that had been damaged for some reason. The results were initially strange; the intermediate block results suggested that the power flow through the block was higher than the input power

into the stack, which is impossible. I removed all three RTDs, applied Arctic Silver MX-7 thermal paste to them, and reinstalled them, and the results seem better.

I am also running it in the newer operating regime; I keep the heater block on at full power constantly instead of regulating it to maintain a constant HX temperature.